THE BEGINNING AFTER THE END

by TurtleMe

RETRIBUTION

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THE BEGINNING AFTER THE END

BOOK 10: RETRIBUTION

TURTLEME

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PROLOGUE

ALICE LEYWIN

Time slowed and the very air around me turned viscous as the asura's spear so effortlessly passed through Ellie's body.

The asura's heavy hand released me, and the screams that had gone mute behind the ringing in my ears exploded as I watched Ellie's body crumple to the ground.

I choked back sobs. "It's okay, baby, it's okay. I'm right here. I've got you, and I'm going to take away the pain, sweetheart, Ellie. I'm going to take care of you."

My hands pressed into the wound in Ellie's side, ineffective in staunching the flow of blood that came out in spurts with each beat of her weakening heart. Mana rushed out of my core and through my channels, jumping from my hands to the deep wound as visible light, but I choked on the incantation in my panic, the magic flashing in and out.

But Ellie was smiling. She was *smiling*, her eyes closed, her face tinted a light purple. She wasn't breathing…

My baby girl was dying.

The asura's killing intent was suffocating. It swelled just above me, and I knew what was going to happen. A sob shook my entire body, and the healing spell faltered again.

I pictured Reynolds's face, imagined him giving me that nonchalant smile and running his hands through my hair and along the back of my neck. His features shifted like wet clay, becoming Arthur's. But even in my mind, in

my memories, Arthur was covered in blood, his face half hidden and stained black and crimson as he dragged himself back to me from some distant deadly threat…

My eyes refocused on Ellie. She looked so much like him, now, lying on the ground covered in her own life's blood…

I closed my eyes to the sight and waited for the spear to fall, for the asura to send Ellie and me to her brother and father…

"Regis, help my sister."

My head snapped up. The purple light, I realized belatedly, was issuing from a shimmering portal that had come to life inside the portal frame. The words came from a figure silhouetted by the amethyst glow. I made out only his sharp features, bright hair, and golden eyes before he was moving.

Something else came toward me…toward Ellie. *Help my sister.* What did those words mean?

What could they *possibly* mean?

A wisp of shadow and energy flew into Ellie's body, but nothing happened, nothing changed.

I nearly slapped myself. My hands pressed hard against Ellie's side, and I began chanting again. There were other words—and fighting—but I pressed it out of my awareness, focusing entirely on the healing magic. The incantation spilled out of me, as did mana, filling the hole that pierced entirely through my baby girl.

But there was something else, too.

An emitter's magic touched something intangible just beyond the reach of my awareness that no one had ever been able to explain to me before. Mana alone couldn't heal wounds like Ellie's, but my spells drew it in, encouraged it, showed it what I wanted.

Like a guiding hand, the wisp of energy pulled my magic along, feeding it with this external power, strengthening it. I felt…strong, powerful in a way I could hardly remember anymore. Muscles and bones began to fuse, veins and nerves knit back together, then—

The room spun wildly beneath my feet, sudden pain and confusion wiping all thought from my mind.

I blinked hard against a sickening ringing in my ears and suppressed the bile creeping up the back of my throat. My skull ached. I looked around, trying to get my bearings; I was lying on my back at the foot of the benchlike stairs, beneath the edge of the dais. I could just see Ellie's arm dangling off the side of it.

The asura and the man with golden eyes clashed, their movements so fast I couldn't follow.

I tried to move, to stand, but my head swam dizzily and I nearly retched. Someone took me by the elbow, tried to pull me to my feet. The world seemed to tilt, and there was an ear-splitting crack from above. I fell into myself, curling into a ball as the shadow of the stone ceiling descended on me.

Dust swallowed me, but a jagged, burning purple light cut through it. Uncurling, I looked up.

A huge mana beast towered over me, a large chunk of stone propped up on its back. Its wolfish body was wreathed with dark purple fire, and its glowing eyes met mine with obvious intent and intelligence.

Someone cursed from my side, a deeper voice gave a pained grunt from the steps at my back. I wanted to help them, but…

Scrambling on my hands and knees, I dragged myself free of the collapsed rubble and up the side of the dais. Ellie had been sent sprawling by whatever blast had knocked me off my feet, and she lay twisted awkwardly, her wound stretched open and furiously pumping out blood.

Nearly right in front of me, I watched the asura and the stranger struggle before vanishing into the portal. *Stranger?* some distant corner of my mind wondered. Those words echoed in my mind yet again…

Help my sister.

"Ellie!" I rolled her over and pressed my bloodstained hands to her wound. Saving her was all that mattered.

The chant poured out of me, and mana followed it. Distantly, I heard the cries of pain and terror, the shifting of rubble, the shouts for help. Virion's crushed-gravel voice ground over the rest, calling my name, but I couldn't. I just couldn't leave Ellie. Not until—

Her eyes snapped open, blinking away the dust and blood. “Arthur?”

My throat constricted. I choked on my own words, swallowed heavily, and tried again. “Hold still, Ellie. You’re still hurt. You’re—”

She tried to push herself up onto her elbows, despite the half-healed wound still piercing much of her body. I gently but firmly pushed her back down. Her hand grabbed mine, but instead of struggling against me, she only squeezed. “Mom. It was…that was Arthur.”

I shook my head, tears beginning to build up behind my eyes. “No, honey, no. Your brother is…he’s…” A cold blankness swept over my mind as I trailed off. I didn’t know what I’d seen, what I’d heard, but I couldn’t dare to hope. Not now, not yet. I couldn’t think about it. “I still have a lot of healing to do, sweetheart. Just…just lie back, okay? Just let your mother work.”

My heart nearly broke as my little girl gave me a look I could only describe as pitying, but she did as I said, and I closed my eyes and began chanting again, letting the entire world fall away, nothing in my mind except for her and the spell.

Time became nothing, rushing past like an engorged spring river while simultaneously frozen like a painting of the same. I knew others needed me too, but I ignored my guilt for saving my daughter, just as I ignored those who needed saving. The healing was slower, harder, without the guiding presence, but that was all right. Together, we had already healed the worst of her wound. And for what remained…

I was strong enough on my own.

Ellie’s hand gripped mine, gently pushing it away from her. “Mom, it’s okay. I’m healed.” Her voice was soft and consoling.

I started, realizing she was right and that I had been too intensely focused and not even sensing the wound, simply pouring healing magic into her. The spell faded, the magic dying out as I stopped channeling.

My attention finally turned to the rest of the people in the cavern. Many were still struggling with fallen rubble, searching for survivors. I could see more than a few unmoving bodies. Panic surged through me as I searched for the Twin Horns.

I found Angela Rose first, on the benches behind me, using gusts of

desperate wind to hurl broken stone away from where I'd nearly been crushed, and I remembered the hand on my arm, just before the cave in.

Helen lay against the wall not far from the entrance, her eyes closed, her dark hair matted with blood. But there was a subtle rising and falling of her chest, so I knew she was alive.

Before I could find Jasmine or Durden, the light of the nearby portal flickered, revealing a faint aura radiating out from the mana beast, who had been standing just before it, unmoving for some time.

My eyes widened as a silhouette once again appeared within the portal frame. The portal itself wavered and dissolved, momentarily becoming a pink mist wreathing the figure, then vanishing. The mana beast did the same an instant later, seeming to become incorporeal, then nothing but a ball of light, receding into the man's back.

Golden eyes settled on Ellie and me. I searched them carefully, trying to prove to myself that the hope I felt was nothing more than a grieving mother's foolishness.

His eyes were the wrong color, not Reynolds's sapphire blue, and they were cold…but curious, too, and looking at us with a certain…familiarity.

And this man didn't share my auburn locks. Instead, wheat-blond hair framed a face as hard and sharp as a blade. The jawline, the curve of the cheeks, the line of the nose…no, the man was more mature, older…it *couldn't* be him. I knew it couldn't, as I knew the hope inside me would turn to poison if I let it linger, gave it light and life, only to be proved wrong.

Then Ellie spoke. "B-brother? Is that really you?"

The man seemed to relax, and the otherworldly glow of power that had ringed him like a halo faded, allowing me to see him properly for what I felt like was the first time. "Hey, El. It's been a while."

I grasped at Ellie's arm as she jumped up and ran to the figure, throwing her arms around him.

Help my sister. That's what he'd said when he arrived, before the thing went to Ellie. And there was something else. Words half heard but suppressed until the moment I could properly deal with them. *Arthur Leywin? I'm glad you're here.* But it *wasn't* possible.

This stranger *couldn't* be my…

I flinched as Ellie suddenly slammed her fist into the man's arm. "I thought you were dead!"

Those golden eyes met mine over Ellie's back as our rescuer pulled her into a tight embrace. He smiled, and it was like a bolt of lightning ran through me. That smile…I never thought I'd see it again. It was Reynolds's smile, and it both lit and softened the man's face, letting the truth shine from him so bright and warm that the icy barrier I'd been building around myself melted away.

"Hi, Mom. I'm back."

Arthur…it really was him. My son.

I wanted to rush to him, to wrap him up in my arms like I could when he was just a little boy, hold him and squeeze him and make us both feel safe. But my knees were weak, and already I could feel the tears coming, stealing my breath away.

There was so much I wanted to tell him.

So much had been left unsaid, words that I thought I would never get the chance to say to him. How sorry I was, and how thankful. For him, and for everything he had brought into our lives. For how much he had sacrificed.

I wanted to tell him how much he meant to me. How glad I was to have him…as my son.

I wanted to. And I would, eventually. But in that moment, it was all just too much.

My hands flew to my face as my legs gave out, and I began to weep.

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A SAVIOR'S BURDEN

ARTHUR LEYWIN

A cascade of cracked stones and rubble tumbled from the cave roof just over Ellie and me. With her in my arms, I turned and took a small step, letting the stones rain harmlessly on the dais behind me.

Ellie winced. "Oh, ouch."

Her eyes were red-rimmed from crying, her jaw tight with pain. I prodded at the hole in her clothes just below her ribs. The skin beneath was clean, only the barest hint of a scar. My mother had done a good job healing her.

I sensed inward for Regis, who was hovering near my core, drawing hungrily from my aether. I couldn't sense anything different between us, even after our separation by the portal. Although the range we could travel apart had increased greatly, that was the first time we had been cut off from each other like that since he first appeared out of the acclorite in my hand.

Glad to have you back, Regis.

My companion hummed his muted acknowledgement. Holding open the broken portal from this side had been a drain on him, and so I left him to rest and to continue drawing aether from my core.

"We've been saved!" a young elven woman shouted suddenly, pulling me sharply out of my reunion with my family.

Another voice called out, "Our savior!"

Ellie flinched away from the shout as she slipped past me and hurried to

our mother's side, easing down beside her. Mom looked different. Not as different as me, maybe, but thinner, older…and something more difficult to pin down. There was a hardness to her, even as she shook and trembled on the floor.

There was so much to say between us. Even if we had hours or days, I wasn't sure if that would be enough time. But we didn't.

"Thank you!"

"Is it really you, Lance Godspell?"

"Please," the first woman said, now reaching out both her arms to me. "Speak to us!"

I had seen faces like this, wide-eyed with awe and supplication, directed at me as King Grey but never as Arthur. It was a conflicting sight. I didn't want to be worshiped like some deity, an instant replacement for the asuras who kept trying to kill these people despite having for so long been looked up to as gods.

"I'm not your savior," I said, gently removing my arm from the woman's grasp. My gaze shifted to where Rinia's body lay in Virion's arms, and when I spoke again, I could hear the sadness in my own words. "The leaders who brought you here…they are."

A tense, still silence followed my statement, at least among those who were more focused on me than the work still needing done around them.

"I'm not here to become the focus of your false hope, a replacement for that source of wonder the asuras gave you. Take strength from yourselves; don't force others to hold you up." I paused, looking away from the crowd. "The path is only going to grow more difficult from here."

I turned back to my mother and Ellie, hoping for even just a moment to be together, but it wasn't to be.

Madam Astera limped up to the edge of the dais, leaning against it just beside my mother. Despite having dueled with her and fought beside her when she lost her leg, I still saw her first as the hard-drinking cook I had met back when the war just started.

But the look on her face now wasn't that of a cook. "Alice, I'm sorry to break this up, but there are too many wounded. We need you."

My mother wiped at her tears, smearing blood across her face, which made her look like some wild, fierce warrior. She glanced up at me, and I knew that whatever we both needed to say could wait. I was here to keep her safe, and now she knew that I was alive.

For the moment, that was enough.

She turned and slid off the dais, moving first to Angela Rose and Durden, who I realized had been hunkered on one of the broad stone benches that encircled the Relictombs portal. Angela Rose seemed to be favoring her leg, but Durden was lying still, his eyes open but unfocused, a steady trail of blood flowing from his ear.

Regis, could you help my mom again, even if it's just the most dire ones. She won't have the strength to heal all these people alone.

'All I did was draw aether into the spell, which was reacting with the natural vivum in the…' Regis trailed off. *'Yeah, all right. But I better be getting some kind of raise, here.'*

I watched as Regis drifted out of me, leapt across to where my mother had climbed up next to Durden—earning a surprised yell from both Angela and Madam Astera—and dematerialized, drifting into Durden's body.

A blend of wariness and curiosity flitted through Ellie's eyes as she watched him go. When she looked away, her focus settled on the portal frame, which once again stood empty. "Wait, where's Sylvie?" she asked in the tone of voice that suggested she already suspected the answer.

I activated my dimension rune and called up the egg. The gloom leached the iridescent shine from it, and it looked like little more than a smooth rock. "She's in here."

"Wait, what does that mean?" Ellie asked, leaning down to peer at the stone in my hand. "Is she okay? Why is she—"

I stopped her with a smile, though I knew it didn't reach my eyes. "Later, okay?"

Her mouth opened, more questions ready to tumble out, but she caught herself. Nodding firmly, she hopped to her feet with a poorly concealed wince. Her eyes jumped around from person to person, group to group, and mine followed.

I didn’t recognize everyone. It seemed like most were elves—survivors who had fled Elenoir during the Alacryan invasion, I assumed. Those who weren’t there when Aldir arrived.

Helen Shard, leader of the Twin Horns, was unconscious but alive.

Boo dragged himself up to his paws as I watched, shaking his head. The large bearlike mana beast stiffened, staring around, but when he caught sight of Ellie, he relaxed. His dark beady eyes moved to me, and I could have sworn he squinted. I nodded, glad to see my sister’s bond was alive. The bear hesitated for a moment, then nodded in return.

Virion was closest, his cheek resting on the top of Rinia’s head, his arms wrapped around her to hold her prone form upright against his chest. He stared at the ground at my feet, almost as if he was avoiding looking at me. As much as I wanted to offer him comfort, though, there were too many people who needed my help.

Scrambling to dig away a pile of small stones near the back of the room, an uncharacteristic look of desperation on his face, was Gideon. His entire body was covered in a thick layer of gray dust, but he himself didn’t seem injured. Which meant…

Ducking through the empty stone rectangle that was the portal frame, I leapt off the dais and climbed up a rockslide until I was next to him. Gideon looked at me with wide bloodshot eyes beneath half-grown brows. Despite his obvious terror, he still paused long enough to give me a thorough inspection.

He wheezed, coughing up a lungful of dusty air. “Em…ily,” he choked out between more coughs.

I scanned the hill of stones and dirt, cursing my lack of ability to sense mana. “Stand back,” I said, pushing aether out of my core and beginning to shape it.

Though the aether within the in-between realm where I’d fought Taci had reacted to my will instantly and in ways I didn’t fully understand, such as the formation of the platforms that had consistently appeared just where and when I’d needed them, now that I was back in the real world, I felt the same struggle I always had.

But I had experienced what was possible.

Picturing the shape in my mind, I shuffled to the side and released an aetheric blast over the surface of the rockslide, carefully molding the blast to only scrape away the top couple inches of stone. When it worked, I did it again, then a third time, revealing the scratched surface of a stone bench.

A gust of wind blasted upward, coiling and spinning so that the remaining dirt and gravel was suspended in a funnel of air over three huddled figures.

Jasmine lay atop Emily Watsken, my old friend from Xyrus Academy and Gideon's apprentice, and a girl I only knew from my visions within the seeing relic. All three looked choked with dust and half suffocated, their faces blotchy red and caked in sweat-moistened dust. Jasmine must have shielded the two young women when the ceiling collapsed on them.

With a jerk of her arm, Jasmine sent the revolving debris clattering to the ground in a rough circle around us. She leaned back against one bench and rested her head against the cool stone. I was surprised when her red eyes opened a slit and stared at me. I'd nearly forgotten.

Gideon pulled Emily to her feet and began brushing her off with rough pats. Her green hair was a tangled mess, and her glasses had been knocked askew. One lens was cracked, and she had a bloody gash across the bridge of her nose, which was probably broken. Other than that, she didn't seem dangerously injured.

I grabbed the third figure, an elf girl perhaps slightly younger than my sister, and helped her to sit up. She scooted away from me to lean against Jasmine, who winced. Only then did I see the deep gash in Jasmine's side, a clean cut that sheared through the black leather of her armor and the flesh beneath.

She followed my gaze, staring at the wound as if only just noticing it was there. The elf girl did the same, whimpering quietly. "J-Jasmine?"

My old mentor and friend ruffled the girl's hair in a very un-Jasmine-like way. "I'll be fine." Her scarlet gaze moved back to me. "So, while we were all here fighting for our lives, you were busy getting your hair dyed, huh?"

I let out a startled laugh. It resounded awkwardly through the cave, clashing against the noises of pain and remorse that surrounded me. "I'm glad you recognized me."

Jasmine shrugged. "You could have come back with green skin and three

heads, and I'd still know you. I'm…glad you're not dead, Arthur."

"And I'm glad you figured out how to use your tongue while I was away," I said, nudging her foot with mine.

Emily reached out and touched my arm as if trying to make sure I was real. "Art? Is it really…" She paused, and I realized there was a greenish tint to her face that matched her hair. "Um, just a…" Turning, she rushed away, bent over, and was sick.

"Stay here, I'll go get my mother," I said, watching Emily with a look of concern etched on my face.

"I'm fine," Jasmine repeated insistently. Then she glanced at Emily's back. "She may have hit her head though."

"All right, just wait here," I said, scanning the room for my mother.

She had moved from Durden to a small, huddled group of elves. An elderly woman was lying on the ground between them. I could see Regis within her, moving throughout her body and drawing aether to himself. The aether seemed to ignore her wounds, and my mother was shaking her head.

I closed my eyes and took a deep breath to steady myself. Even with magic, it was impossible to save everyone.

When I opened my eyes, Mom was looking in my direction. I waved my hand and pointed at Emily and Jasmine. She nodded and held up one finger, then turned back to the elves.

With Jasmine and Emily out of immediate danger, I began to hurry along the upper ring of benches, searching the room below for anyone who looked as if they needed help. As I did, many pairs of eyes followed me, filled with hope and fear, the awe I inspired in them written clearly on their filthy faces.

I passed a young elf about my age. He was sitting on the ground between two corpses, his head in his hands. Both bodies were carved nearly in two —one of Taci's ranged attacks that I hadn't been able to stop.

But when he looked up at me, I didn't see my failure reflected back in his eyes. He scrambled forward onto his knees, bowing.

"Th-thank you," he stammered. "Justice for the f-fallen." When he looked

up again, his eyes were hard and full of fire. “May all the asura burn like the trees of Elenoir.” I couldn’t help the thought that both his words and his voice seemed too old for him, like the war had aged him beyond his years.

Nodding, I moved on, keeping up a quick circuit of the cavern, my mind and spirit both heavy.

Near the arched door, which led out into a hallway covered in carvings, several corpses lay butchered. Guards, by the look of them. I found no familiar faces among them until—

“Albold,” I muttered, going to one knee beside the young elven guard whom I had first met in the flying castle. His skin was pale and cold to the touch, his eyes staring sightlessly up at the unstable ceiling.

Where his chest used to be, there was now only a bloody hole.

I closed his eyes, bowing my head over him, but only for a moment. There were more living than dead, and I needed to make sure they stayed that way.

There will be time for mourning later, I told myself.

Not far from the entrance, an older woman with a bloodstained face reached out and grabbed my hand, tugging insistently. When she tried to speak, I realized her jaw was broken. She was sitting off to the side by herself and no one seemed to have noticed her. As I bent down to lift her in my arms, there was a sharp grinding noise and a puff of dust as the ceiling shifted above us.

I grabbed her and used God Step, letting the aetheric paths guide me across the room, where I appeared next to my mother. Wordlessly, I set the woman down and then God Stepped back across the cave just as the ceiling collapsed.

Aether rushed to my hand, then outward in a blast of energy that destroyed the collapsing stone.

My gaze tracked over the benches and rubble even as vibrant purple arcs of lightning still ran over my limbs, but everyone else had been quick enough to pull away from the rockslide.

“A *true* deity,” someone said in a quiet, almost reverent voice.

“Lance Godspell!” someone cheered, and several others followed suit.

But a different voice cut across these, raised in frustration and anger, drawing my attention to the dais in the middle of the cave.

Framed in front of the empty portal, Madam Astera stood awkwardly, the foot of her prosthetic leg shattered, leaving it a few inches shorter than the other. Her finger was pointed down at Virion, her voice raised like she was scolding a child.

Feeling as though I was being pulled in twenty different directions at once, I hopped down the steps and over onto the dais. Astera turned at the sound of my approach, her brows raised. “Is it true then? Is that you, Lance Arthur Leywin?”

I gave her a hard look. “It is. Now what’s going on?”

The older woman’s brows turned down in anger, and her jaw tightened. After a moment, however, she took a long breath and let the tension fall away. “You talk some sense into him, then. We need a plan, Arthur, and we need to get moving.”

Astera limped down the steps, shaking her head, but I was focused on Virion.

He didn’t look at me until I settled down next to him. The woman in his arms was Rinia, I knew that, but she looked so *old*, like she’d been living ten days for every one that passed.

“She was using her powers too much,” Virion confirmed, as if plucking the thought from my mind. “Saw Taci coming but couldn’t figure out how to escape it.” He closed his eyes and shook his head bitterly. “I failed her, Arthur. I wasn’t there when she needed me.”

I felt a pang as Virion’s regret and self-doubt matched my own. Reaching out, I took a firm hold of his forearm. “She did what she had to do, Virion. Rinia knew better than any of us the price of using her power, and she did it anyway.” I gently pushed aside a lock of gray-white hair that had fallen over her face. “My mother and sister are alive because of Rinia. Again…”

Rinia Darcassan had always been an enigmatic character in my life, quick to dole out mysterious, vaguely-worded advice but withholding any real details of the future. And yet, when things were most dire, she seemed to appear out of nowhere like a ghost from the shadows to deliver salvation.

An echo of her words from so long ago came back to me then, almost like I was hearing them for the first time.

She'd told me to have an anchor, to set myself a goal, and I thought I had: power, enough to keep those I loved safe, but…

I looked down at her, then around at the destroyed cave.

It had never been enough.

Which, I suppose, was why she gave me another piece of advice later on: "Do not fall back to your old ways. As you well know, the deeper you go into that pit, the harder it will be to climb back out."

And I did have a long way to climb to be the person I wanted to be. The calluses I'd built up around myself to survive in Alacrya wouldn't fade in a day, but they would eventually, if I let them.

"As soon as my mother has healed who she can, we should get moving," I said, watching Virion carefully. I had no way of knowing everything he had been through since my disappearance, but he seemed much too close to his breaking point. "Perhaps we can set up a kind of cairn or—"

"No," Virion said, his eyes flashing. "I can't—I won't leave her down here."

I nodded in understanding, but shot pointed looks at several other corpses, clearly visible among the wreckage. "Of course, Virion. We'll return for the bodies later, then. So they can all receive proper burials."

"I…" Virion's voice gave out, and he shrugged. "Very well then. I…I do not understand this…how you are here…but I *am* glad you're alive, Arthur. These people need a strong leader."

I rested a hand on his shoulder, looking at him gravely. "They already have one."

As if waiting for some cue, Astera reappeared with Helen, Gideon, and a middle-aged elven woman I didn't know.

The inventor held out a hand to me. I took it firmly, glancing to where Emily sat huddled with Jasmine, Ellie, and the young elf girl. Boo was keeping so close to my sister he was practically sitting on her.

"Concussed, but your mother has already seen to it," Gideon said, his

voice raw. “Got here just in the nick of time, as usual. Like to make an entrance, don’t you, Arthur?”

Despite his scathing tone, I knew this was Gideon’s way of saying thank you while deflecting any real emotion.

“We’ll have plenty of time to play catch up and figure out where Lance Arthur has been hiding all these months *after* we get the hell out of here,” Astera cut in. “We’re all that remains of the council, at least here. The Glayders, Earthborns, and the Ivsaar boy should be scattered all over the tunnels, waiting for word that it’s safe to come out.”

“But where do we go from here?” the elven woman asked. She had a kind face beneath a tangled web of auburn hair that had just started to gray. “We can’t exactly return to the sanctuary, compromised as it is.” Bright leaf-green eyes focused on me. “What is your guidance, Lance?”

“Please, Arthur’s just arrived back,” Helen said quickly, a defensive edge to her tone. “He likely had no idea what he was walking into. You can’t expect him to simply take up leadership of all these people, Saria.”

The elf woman bowed her head deferentially. “Of course, Ms. Shard. I simply thought, due to his obvious strength, perhaps…”

“Virion, do you have anything to put in?” Gideon asked into the silence that followed Saria’s words.

Everyone looked down at the commander, who was still sitting on the ground with Rinia pulled against him. His gaze trailed from one set of feet to the next, never going higher. Just when it seemed he wouldn’t respond at all, Virion said, “I need time. Do not look to me for leadership, not now. I can’t give it to you.”

Saria kneeled, reaching out her hand, then hesitated and withdrew it. “Virion. You have been a hero to all elves for my entire life. And I understand the pain you face now, I do. My own mother lies dead not fifty feet from here. But we *must not* give in to our sorrows, lest we risk losing all the rest, too.”

I held out my hand to Virion. “She’s right, Gramps. We need you.”

Virion looked between us, heavy tears shining in his eyes, and took my hand. Saria eased Rinia’s corpse to the ground while I pulled Virion to his feet. We all watched in silence as Saria undid the sash around her waist

and laid it respectfully across Rinia's face.

Claws scratched against stone as Regis loped over to us, making the rest of the council members flinch back.

"We've done everything we can for the wounded," he said tiredly, then drifted into my body.

The others stared at me in confusion but were too tired and overwhelmed to press for details.

"Okay, let's get moving then," I said, already feeling the weight of their combined expectation.

Though exhausted and wary of more traveling, no one was eager to linger in the cave, which continued to tremble and rain down dust and gravel at random intervals. I caught many nervous glances being thrown at the portal frame as well, as if they feared Taci might spring back out of it at any moment.

The deceased were laid out as respectfully as we could manage in the moment, but then we moved on.

The tunnel leading away from the descension chamber was entirely covered in carvings unlike anything I'd seen around the Relictombs in Alacrya. I could only hope there would be an opportunity to return in the future, as I had promised Virion, so that I could study them more closely.

We didn't go far before Ellie grabbed my arm and pulled me to a stop. "There is a…thing up ahead. A trap."

Moving forward alone, I found the passage inundated with aether. I could feel the edge of its effect, warning me away from this place, urging us forward at speed. I reached for that aether, feeling its purpose and the shape of the spell cast by the djinn so long ago, and as if the hallway were filled with cobwebs, I waved it aside.

There was a violet shimmer in the air as the aether particles sank back into the walls, clearing the passage.

A gasp ran through the group. I ignored it, waving a hand forward. "Let's

keep moving."

This tunnel was deep under the sanctuary, and we marched for more than an hour without seeing any signs of life.

Ellie, who had been walking with me at the front and giving me directions, suddenly held up a hand, forcing a stop. "There is a mana signature ahead, just there."

As she said it, half a face peeked out of a narrow tunnel branching off the wider path we were taking. Raven-black hair framed a pale porcelain face, out of which stared one large chocolate-colored eye.

Kathyln's thin lips parted as she stepped out into the open, seeming to forget her wariness. She scanned the group quickly, but her gaze settled on me, and she frowned deeply. She looked at Ellie, then me again, and finally rubbed her eyes. "Who…A-Art? Is that…?"

"No time," Astera grumbled from atop Boo. "Where is the rest of your group?"

Kathyln had taken several quick steps toward me but stopped and straightened suddenly at the reminder of the reason she had been hiding. "We took shelter in a cave about twenty minutes farther down this tunnel. After feeling the asura's intent vanish, I came out to wait. I haven't seen anyone else."

Our group rested while Kathyln hurried off to retrieve another group of survivors. When they returned, I was pleased to see how many there were. A moment was taken for reunions, then we began marching forward again.

It was Boo who warned us next, sniffing deeply and bullying past me to get in front of Ellie, earning a startled yelp from Astera.

"What is it, Boo?" Ellie asked, pressing her hand into his thick brown fur. "Oh, there's someone coming. They smell like blood."

I stepped out in front of the group and waited, aether swirling between my fingers in case I needed to form a weapon.

Slow, unsteady footsteps resounded down the tunnel just before a silhouette coalesced out of the darkness. For an instant, I thought it must be some kind of monster, then I realized the truth.

A tall, broad-shouldered man was approaching, and in his arms he held

another, thinner figure. Mahogany-colored hair rose up from the man's head, spiky like a lion's mane. Intense brown eyes searched desperately for something behind me.

"Curtis!" Kathyln yelled, breaking from the group and sprinting past me, only to pull up short.

"Oh, oh no…"

I moved forward cautiously, focusing on the unmoving form in Curtis Glayder's arms. The blond braided hair was matted with blood, the face nearly unrecognizable. Still, I knew the curve of his brows and shape of his ears.

Curtis sagged, and I darted forward to scoop up Feyrith's body before it tumbled to the ground.

The tunnels went cold and silent as I stared down at the body of my once friend and rival.

I didn't expect so many goodbyes, so soon after my return, I thought, letting a cold sense of detachment keep the sorrow at bay.

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JUST OUT OF REACH

ELEANOR LEYWIN

My heart gave a painful squeeze as I saw my brother holding Feyrith's body. Pressure built uncomfortably behind my eyes, but I didn't have any tears left.

Albold, Feyrith, Rinia…and how many others, people whose names I don't even know?

The shock of so many conflicting emotions scraped at me, making me feel raw, brittle. From certainty of my own death to wordless amazement and joy at my brother's return…to the slow dawning realization of how much had been taken from us in the last several hours.

As if sensing my discomfort, Mom wrapped an arm around me and pulled me close.

We stayed back and watched as Durden hurried forward to conjure an earthen bier for Feyrith's body. I felt a pang of guilt thinking of all the bodies we'd left down in that weird chamber but reminded myself that the living were more important right now.

The dead had time to wait.

Then, we were moving again. Arthur and the Glayders walked ahead, and I found my gaze constantly settling on my brother's back, watching his soft, strong steps and the effortless way he seemed to command the others without even trying. It was like his mere presence settled our minds and spirits…or maybe it just settled mine.

I caught Mom watching him too, her face slipping between little frowns

and half-hidden smiles.

Just a couple minutes farther down the tunnel, Curtis and Kathyln broke away, heading to get all the people who had been traveling in Curtis's group. He confirmed that all the refugees who had been hidden with Feyrith—at least fifty people—were dead. After that, we found the rest of the surviving groups one by one.

Hornfels and Skarn Earthborn had each led separate groups but in similar directions, and had sealed the tunnels behind them, only letting the conjured barriers fall away when they sensed our group approach and Curtis confirmed through the walls that the asura was dead.

By the time we reached the main cavern, we were a long winding river of tired, frightened, surprised-to-be-alive people. The tunnel mouth had collapsed, but the Earthborns easily moved it aside, revealing a pile of corpses: the guards who had been at the rear.

Arthur went through first, along with a group of our strongest mages, instructing everyone else to stay in the tunnels.

It was so comforting to have him there, to watch him step right back into the role of protector as if he'd never left, but I couldn't help but also be a little sad. Seeing how the others looked at him, how even the members of the council seemed to walk just a step behind him at all times, it felt like he was there but still somehow just out of reach.

Like he was keeping us all at arm's length…or maybe it was the other way around. By immediately treating him like he was some storybook savior, everyone was pushing him away, putting him in front of us like a shield instead of welcoming him back with open arms.

I shook my head to snap myself out of it. We would have time to do all the lovey-family stuff when we were safe.

From the mouth of the tunnel, I could see Arthur and the others fan out, carefully scanning the wreckage of the sanctuary, which had been our home for so long. The place was in ruins. Huge gashes had been carved in the ceiling and walls, giant boulders had fallen down on the village, crushing entire houses, and everything was blasted with ice and lightning.

There was movement to our left, and a figure stepped up onto a higher shelf of rock to look down at everyone else.

I slipped free of my mother's grip and took a few quick steps out into the cavern, stepping over familiar bodies in order to see what was happening.

"Lance Bairon!" Curtis shouted, his voice echoing eerily in the otherwise deathly quiet. "You—you're okay!"

Despite standing straight and tall, it looked for all the world like the Lance had been chewed up by some giant mana beast and spit back out. "I was lucky that the—" He cut off suddenly, staring down at the group of mages. "Who…?"

"Bairon," my brother said. Anyone who didn't know him might not have sensed it, but I could hear the undercurrent of tension in his voice. "I'm glad to know I'm not the last of the Lances—"

"Arthur!" Bairon burst out, sputtering.

The wounded Lance half slid, half jumped down a section of crumbled wall that made a ramp up onto the higher ledge, rushed toward my brother—whose eyes went wide with surprise—and grabbed him by the shoulders. The usually stoic Lance had tears in his eyes, and he stared at Arthur in disbelief, then he leaned forward, resting his forehead against Arthur's in a sign of respect and care.

Two more figures appeared on top of the ledge, and I felt my jaw fall slack.

Lances Varay and Mica looked a lot different from the last time I'd seen them—in the castle, before Elder Rinia had rescued us from the Alacryans.

Lance Varay followed Bairon down. Her long, snow-white hair had been cut short, and instead of her uniform, she wore battered and ruined silver armor. As Bairon finally released my brother and took a step aside, Varay stepped into his place, her arms slipping around my brother's waist in a soft embrace. One of her arms was an icy deep blue and shined like glass.

I was surprised by how small she seemed next to Arthur. How…normal.

Still standing on the ledge above, Mica snorted. "You're late."

The dwarven Lance was badly injured. An ugly wound marred the left side of her face, and a black gem glinted in the socket where her eye should have been. She was leaning on a huge stone hammer, watching Arthur and Varay with a look I couldn't read.

I realized with a spike of alarm that I could barely sense the Lances' mana signatures. Even though it must have been hours since their battle with Taci ended, they still seemed near the edge of backlash.

Varay pulled back from Arthur, inspecting him closely. "It's good to have you back, and apparently in the final moments before disaster. You must have been what the old elven seer saw coming?"

Arthur cleared his throat, looking uncomfortable. "That seems to be the case, yes, though I had no idea what I would be walking into." He paused and looked around. "Where is Aya—"

"Brother!" I said, the word slipping out unintentionally.

Everyone turned to look at me, brows raised in surprise or lowered in clear irritation like I should know better than to interrupt when the adults were speaking.

Boo stepped around me, his eyes narrowing in the direction I had felt it.

"There are mana signatures coming," I said past the lump in my throat, pointing toward where dim beams of light were piercing the cavern ceiling. Sand was raining down through the light, and as we all watched, it seemed to pick up, becoming a steady stream. "A whole lot of them."

I realized then that people had been slowly trickling out of the tunnel mouth behind me, because they all began to panic and surge back toward the tunnel entrance, pushing at the people just trying to come out. I was suddenly caught in the middle of it, being jostled from all sides.

Boo gave a warning growl as he stepped in to shield me from the rushing bodies.

"Everyone, back to the tunnel!" Bairon barked, his voice heavy with authority despite his injured state.

And yet he and the other Lances hesitated. Varay said something, questioning, her expression strained. Arthur's reply was short and met with clear frustration from the others. Someone bumped hard against my elbow, and I stumbled, reaching out to Boo for support. By the time I looked back, the Lances were marching in our direction, though not without throwing resigned glances back at my brother.

Arthur's form grew smaller, the only one still moving away as he walked

toward the oncoming mana signatures. Alone.

“You can’t just let him go by himself!” I said as Kathyln hurried past me.

The once-princess gave me a wry, apologetic smile as she slipped her arm into mine. Wordlessly, she began pulling me gently, but firmly, back toward the others.

Boo gave me a sniff and nudged me hard with his nose, growling.

“Boo thinks we should fight too,” I muttered, a sense of foreboding filling me with nervous energy that made my fingers tingle and yearn for a bow to hold, since mine had, yet again, been destroyed.

“Boo is brave,” Curtis said from Kathyln’s other side, smiling sadly. “Grawder has been eager for battle as well, but to be honest, I think he’s enjoying his current duty.”

I looked into the dark mouth of the tunnel, but it was packed with people, and Grawder was too far back for me to see. I knew, though, that Curtis had set the giant world lion to guard the many children that were with us, including my friend Camellia, who was no doubt chafing at being treated like a little kid.

When I turned back to the cavern, Arthur had crossed over a pile of rubble that had fallen across the once-beautiful little stream that ran through the cavern. His steps were light, almost relaxed, as he approached where the sand pooled over the smooth stone floor.

The movement of the flowing sand shifted, taking on an undulating pattern of waves, then condensing into several smoothly flowing pillars. Up above, I could just make out a bunch of shadows descending down through the pillars like they were elevators, followed immediately by several more. At the bottom, fifty feet from where Arthur stood, Alacryan soldiers began pouring out of the sand.

The ground beneath my feet trembled, and walls of semitransparent ice began growing up from the floor in a rough curve around the entrance. Only Arthur was outside the barrier, facing a literal army of Alacryans all by himself.

Helen Shard appeared at that moment, shuffling through the crowd to stand next to Mom. She waved for me to join them, reaching out for me to take her hand. Next to me, the wall was growing quickly; it was already

beginning to curve overhead and in moments would entirely contain the tunnel opening and everyone inside.

Half the faces were turned inward, calming and encouraging, while the rest stared out through the ice, trying to see what was going on. The air was thick with tension and a smothering sort of silence. The other Lances stared most intently of all, some complex combination of hope, frustration, and fear written on each of their faces.

Once again, everyone was standing back, looking to my brother as a savior, no one standing at his side.

Has he been alone all this time? I wondered, trying and failing to imagine what might have been on the other side of that portal.

It wasn't fair that all these people were just going to push their burdens off on Arthur. It didn't matter how strong he was; he shouldn't have to do everything by himself. He needed to know that there were still people by his side.

Without deciding to, I was moving. Helen's eyes widened as I plucked the bow right out of her hand, then shot toward the still-growing walls. My mother's voice cut over the general din, but I didn't look back as I leapt up the stone wall of the cavern, caught my toes into a shallow indentation, and then pushed upward, reaching for the top of the curving ice.

My chest hit hard, and I nearly slipped and tumbled backward as I struggled to hold onto the moving edge of the ice barrier. Swinging inward, I kicked off the ice and pulled myself up over the lip so suddenly that I was on the outside of the curve and sliding downward. A moment later, I landed in a roll, curling protectively around the bow and then letting momentum carry me back up to my feet, already running.

I could still hear my mother's yells for a few seconds, then the ice barrier must have closed over everyone and sealed them in because the sound cut out.

Staying close to the cavern wall, I jumped down the rocky slope that led to where the now-dry stream used to run into a series of cracks in the wall and floor that were too small for a person to get through. I leapt the algae-slick stones at the bottom of the stream and scrambled up onto a higher shelf of rock on the other side, then from there to another, before finally hiding myself in a fold in the cavern wall that perfectly hid me from the

Alacryans.

Arthur's eyes flicked to me. I was over a hundred feet away, but I could see into his bright gold eyes as if he was standing right next to me. He made a face like he was concentrating on something, the same face he always made when he would talk to Sylvie in his head, and the shadow-and-fire wolf leapt out of him and ran in my direction.

I felt a moment of uncertainty, and Boo appeared next to me with a *pop*.

The shadow wolf jumped up to me with a single leap. "Stay back, stay quiet," he said gruffly before turning and settling protectively in front of me.

Boo eyed the wolf—Regis, I reminded myself—and moved next to him, matching his defensive posture competitively.

So much for staying hidden, I thought. But at least Arthur knew I was out here with him. He knew he wasn't alone.

Arthur still hadn't attacked, only let more and more of the Alacryans come down through the earthen elevators. As each battle group appeared, they rushed into formation before conjuring swirling barriers of air, translucent panels of mana, and flickering walls of flame.

I didn't understand why he wasn't doing anything. Why let them prepare? He wasn't afraid, anyone could tell that just by looking at him. Arthur was calm almost to the point of seeming casual, his golden eyes tracking across the enemy force intently, but without any sign of concern.

Finally, an Alacryan soldier stepped forward. He was a thin man in silky black battlerobes that were tied tightly to his body by a series of belts. Dozens of daggers were sheathed to the belts on his arms and across his torso. A bright white scar cut across the almond skin of his hard-lined face, and his dark eyes were watching Arthur carefully.

At the man's back, at least fifty battle groups were arranged in rows, all of them focused entirely on Arthur, ready to launch spells at the man's command.

"Give me your name," the Alacryan leader shouted, his voice slightly nasal and rough. When Arthur didn't immediately reply, he went on. "We are hunting Dicathian rebels. There was very recently a large-scale disturbance of mana in this location, and we have reason to believe that a

sizable group of rebels is hidden here. Are you their leader? Tell your people to surrender peacefully, and we may avoid any unnecessary bloodshed."

"Avoiding unnecessary bloodshed is what I would like as well," Arthur said nonchalantly. Then, firmer, he added, "So turn around and leave."

The Alacryan's face reddened. He flicked his wrist, and the knives all over his body flickered out of their sheaths, hovering around him, the gleaming steel blades all pointed at my brother. At the same time, his soldiers all stepped forward, igniting spells and conjuring magical weapons and armor.

"By the decree of retainer Lyra Dreide, in her position of interim regent of Dicathen, all native-born Dicathians who raise arms against any faithful servant of the Vritra or who willfully disobey any order by an Alacrya soldier or official operating in the High Sovereign's name, may be struck down to ensure the peace," the man said, rattling the words off as if he'd said them many times before.

"If you resist, you and all those who have been foolish enough to follow you will be put to the—"

My knees gave out, and I sank down to the ground, unable to escape the sudden weight pressing down on me. I felt lost and trapped at the same time, as if I was being swallowed up by an ocean of thick black tar. Boo spun, whining, his own huge bulk shaking with a fear I could feel in my bones.

Through the gap between the two mana beasts, I could just see the Alacryan leader sputtering out a series of wheezing, choking breaths. It was Arthur's intent, I realized. Even from where I was, all the way at the edge of the cavern, it stole the breath from my lungs.

Among the rows of soldiers, many fell to their knees as I had, their held spells fizzling out in their hands. My senses sharpened as I instinctively slid into the first phase of Boo's beast will, and suddenly, I could hear their whispered prayers to the Vritra and the heady stink of their fear.

With my sharper senses and instincts provided by the beast will, I could tell just how controlled and precise Arthur was being. This was only a warning, a stifled show of power.

"Casters!" the leader gasped out. "Release spells!"

I sucked in a terrified breath as dozens of spells shot toward Arthur. Regis stiffened but did not move away as we both watched Arthur raise a hand.

A shower of bright purple light exploded forward like ten thousand lightning bolts all tied together at their tails. The hail of spellfire converging on Arthur vanished into the radiant blast as it kept fanning out from him. The leader's eyes widened, and he scrambled back, several shields appearing in front of him, but it wasn't enough. He, too, vanished in the blast, shields and all.

The amethyst wave rolled over the front line of the enemy forces, then crackled out, leaving only a bright pink afterimage that I couldn't blink away.

Arthur was unhurt. None of the spells had even reached him. The Alacryan leader was entirely gone, and the closest battle groups had been reduced to smoking lumps.

The rest were so motionless I would have thought time itself had stopped, except that Arthur took a single steady step forward and leveled them with an imperious glare. "Leave now. It's not too late."

Like the breaking of a spell, the Alacryans burst into sudden panicked movement, stumbling over themselves and each other as they began to flee.

The columns of sand shuddered and reversed course, falling back up to the desert it had come from. The Alacryans were sprinting back into the sand, their shadows just visible as the magic lifted them up and out of the cavern.

I squeezed my eyes shut, hard, still struggling to catch my breath as the weight of Arthur's intent chased the Alacryans away. I couldn't believe what I'd just seen.

At least fifty men—trained Alacryan soldiers and mages—had just fallen before Arthur in the blink of an eye, and my brother hadn't even been scratched. I'd seen him fight before, raining down spellfire on the mana beast hordes that attacked the Wall, but this was different…a casual kind of massacre. Arthur had waved his hand and snuffed the life out of the enemy, as simple as that. It was…scary.

As the last of the Alacryans hurried to escape, I slipped down from my

hiding spot and made my way toward Arthur, who only watched as they fled. His strange golden eyes left the enemy and turned to me, a slight frown wrinkling his older, sharper features. The weight of his gaze made my back bend and my knees tremble as I found myself suddenly nervous to be alone with him.

Boo nuzzled my side, and that glowing golden energy that gave me courage pushed away the moment of hesitation.

Arthur smiled. “You’ve reached the Acquire stage. I wasn’t even sure if your bond with Boo worked like that, considering.”

“Oh, um…yeah,” I said awkwardly, caught off guard. My eyes jumped to what was left of the Alacryan corpses, and Arthur’s followed. “Why did you let them go?”

Arthur frowned toward the sand, which had returned to falling in rainy sheets, the magic affecting it broken. He put his hand on my head and mussed my hair lightly, his expression suddenly strained, like his sour frown was hiding a deeper, stronger sense of hurt. “Those people aren't our enemies. They're just following orders, trying to survive, same as us. I'd like to give them a chance.”

The sound of ice cracking filled the cavern, and I glanced toward where the rest of the Dicathians were starting to spread out away from the tunnel entrance.

“Do you really think we can win like that?” I asked, wondering again what Arthur must have been through while he was gone. “It’s not like they’ve treated us like people. If we’re afraid to—”

Arthur wrapped his arm around my shoulder, cutting me off. “I’m not afraid to fight, El.” He gave me a wry smile. “Neither are you, obviously. But we should be afraid to become as bad as the thing we’re fighting against.”

Arthur left me to ponder his words, turning toward Lance Varay, who was the first to arrive, flying as she was, but Mom was right behind her, looking thunderous. She looked from me to Arthur as she approached, though, and slowed down, taking a deep breath.

I hurried to her, wrapping my arms around her waist, not saying anything.

She smoothed down my hair, taking my lead in remaining quiet. Most of

the crowd stayed well back, and I could see the same hesitancy and intimidation I had felt only a minute ago written plainly across their faces.

“We can’t stay here now,” Varay said, eyeing the aftermath of the battle with a calculating expression. “General Arthur, did you have some plan for what to do next?”

Arthur glanced at Lance Mica, approaching on foot next to Bairon. “Yeah, I have an idea.”

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MOVING ON

ARTHUR LEYWIN

There was too much to do after the Alacryan attack. With the djinn sanctuary exposed, it was no longer safe. Somehow, we had to move several hundred people across the Darvish desert, keeping them safe both from the elements and the Alacryans.

As people continued to pour out of the tunnels, the leadership gathered across the stream near where I'd fought the Alacryan forces. Varay flew up through the holes in the ceiling to scout while the rest of us discussed what the next step would be.

"Xyrus would make more sense," Madam Astera was saying. She was leaning back in a conjured chair of soft earth, massaging the stump of her leg, the broken prosthetic abandoned on the ground nearby. "We can disperse the nonfighters throughout the villages around Sapin's southern border. If we can make it to Blackbend City, General Arthur can easily get us to a teleportation chamber."

The old soldier wore a cold smirk as she added, "Then we just unleash him on the forces guarding the city. It would be ours in a night."

There were a few murmured agreements at this idea, but Hornfels Earthborn was quick to step in. "The Sapin border is twice as far as Darv's capital city, and there aren't any tunnel systems that far north. Plus, we'd be abandoning the civilians if the Alacryans pursued them after we've left."

"But surely they wouldn't waste their time, would they?" the elven council member, Saria, asked softly. "The Alacryans will almost certainly pursue

the stronger force."

Madam Astera gestured to Saria in agreement but was looking at the dwarves. "Exactly. Plus, we can *trust* the people of Xyrus—"

"And what the bloody hell is that supposed to mean?" Skarn Earthborn, Hornfels's brother, growled.

Hornfels pressed his hand against Skarn's chest, holding him back. "The meaning is clear enough, but you're mistaken, Madam Astera. The dwarves—"

A thin, almost childish voice silenced all others as a pulse of heavy, frustrated intent pressed down on everyone present. "The dwarves have suffered from some very poor leadership and have been exposed to constant propaganda since before the war even began." Mica paused, her gemstone eye glinting as she stared around. "But the people of Darv are not cruel or evil, and Mica…*I* know they have started to see through the Vritras's lies."

Madam Astera nodded deferentially. "As you say, Lance. Still, we should hear from everyone." She eyed Bairon and Helen, who had largely stayed silent. Virion had insisted he needed to look for something and excused himself before the meeting started. "Do the rest of you have anything to say for yourselves?"

"The people of Xyrus may prove less trustworthy than you hope," Bairon said, an edge of poorly suppressed bitterness in his tone. "If Generals Arthur and Mica believe the dwarves will work with us, then I stand with the Lances."

Helen shrugged. "It'll be a fight wherever we go. Arthur gives us the best chance of victory, so the Twin Horns will be staying close to him."

She looked at me with a blend of fierce pride and respect that reminded me of my father, and a warm tightness moved up from my chest and into my throat.

'Look at you, getting all mushy. Being surrounded by your enemies for so long has made you—'

You must be bored, I pointed out to my incorporeal companion. *Go help my mom if you're just going to be narrating my emotions.*

‘Meh. She’s better company than you anyway,’ Regis thought with a mental snort before jumping out of me and loping off toward the town. There was a chorus of gasps and a choked yelp from Saria at his sudden appearance, but then it fell quiet again as the group watched him bound over the dammed stream.

Everyone reluctantly turned their gazes back to the meeting when Madam Astera began to struggle to her feet, doing her best to hide a scowl. Hornfels took her arm to steady her as he conjured a simple stone prosthetic around her leg. I was glad to see that, despite any disagreements they might have about our course of action, they still treated each other with respect.

“We should leave immediately,” I said, looking pointedly at the sunlight still streaming in from the cracks in the ceiling. “I caught them off guard just now, but we don’t want to give the Alacryans time to regroup and attack again.”

“I advise you to give these people some time,” Astera replied, countering my suggestion with her own. “Both to rest and to gather what little remains of their belongings. And we need to prepare defensive positions, map out our path, conjure transportation for those who can’t walk.”

I matched her steel gaze for a moment, then nodded.

“So that’s it?” Skarn Earthborn said, focusing on me. “Just, ‘Let’s all run off to Vildorial, meeting end’? Nothing about how you just sent a hundred Alacryan soldiers pissing themselves back into the desert?” Skarn threw his hands in the air and glared at Mica. “What in the red blazes are the rest of us supposed to be doing then, eh? If this boy can crush armies and asuras alike, what is the purpose even of Lances, cousin? I just—” Skarn stopped suddenly, spitting on the stones before marching away.

Hornfels gave the group an apologetic shrug, then followed his brother.

“He does have a point,” Bairon said, frowning at me. There was a complex emotion in his expression, something existential that was leaking up from the deepest roots of his sense of self-worth. “How are any of us supposed to help you, Arthur?”

Mica looked down and away, not meeting my eye. The others did the opposite, peering hungrily at me, eager for my protection and the hope my presence gave them.

“This war isn’t over,” I said simply. “Alacryan soldiers—even retainers and Scythes—they aren’t the threat Dicathen has to be ready for.” My lips turned up in a wry, mirthless smile. “Taci was just the beginning, Bairon. The gods themselves are our enemies now. And…whatever you all think, I can’t fight them alone.”

Bairon’s jaw clenched, and a tremor ran along the muscle of his neck. Through gritted teeth, he said, “Then we must find some way to grow stronger.”

“Yeah.” Reaching into my dimension rune, I withdrew Taci’s long spear and threw it to Bairon. “This will be a start.”

He snatched it out of the air, then seemed to realize what he was holding and nearly dropped it.

“I don’t want the weapon that killed Aya,” he said after a moment, spinning the handle toward me and holding it out for me to take back.

“Don’t be a thickhead,” Mica grumbled, though she looked at the scarlet spear with unsuppressed loathing. “That is a powerful weapon, and there is no better way to pay your respects to Aya than using it to kill a few more asura.”

She reached out and flicked the head of the spear, making a clean, silvery ringing. Then she was moving off after her cousins, her despair and rage a nearly physical thing burning like a mantle of fire around her.

Bairon’s fist clenched around the haft. By simply holding the weapon, the Lance already seemed stronger, more present. “Thank you, Arthur.”

I nodded, and Bairon spun on his heel and marched away, effectively ending whatever was left of our meeting. Saria gave me a small bow, then took Astera’s arm as the pair began making their slow way back into town.

“You all right, kid?”

I looked up to realize Helen was watching me. “Kid?” I asked, my lips quirking up in amusement.

She mirrored my expression. “I’ve seen your mom wipe poop off of you. You’ll always be a kid in my book.”

I rubbed the back of my neck, chuckling. “Well, I guess that’s fair.”

The two of us began moving back toward the sanctuary, which was swarming with activity as people did their best to reclaim what items they could from the ruins. Although Ellie had wanted to stay with me, I'd asked her to keep an eye on Mom, who was worn down after so much healing. But there wasn't time to rest yet.

"I'm fine, you know," I said as we crossed over the rubble-dammed stream. "Just…feeling impatient, I guess. But I am glad to be back. To be…" I trailed off, not sure how much I could tell her.

"Home?" Helen filled in for me. There was a lilting curiosity in her tone, an unasked question buried in that single word.

I nodded, and we walked in silence as the noise and motion of hurried preparations grew around us.

A man's ankle turned on a loose stone, and he stumbled under the weight of his pack as he marched by. I caught him and helped him straighten.

A crying child sat on a collapsed wall, squeezing a battered and torn stuffed mana beast as her tired, red-faced mother struggled to wrap their belongings in an old blanket.

An older woman scrabbled frantically in the ruins of a house only to collapse back on her rear with a crumpled piece of parchment in her hands. She held the paper gingerly to her chest and wept.

"They've lost everything. Again," Helen said softly. Then she cleared her throat and squinted down at the ground, looking embarrassed.

I wished there was more I could do, but for all my power, I couldn't use Aroa's Requiem to mend their broken hearts or God Step to take them away from their grief and fear. Their lives would never be the same, and although the holes left behind would heal over in time, there would always be the ache of loss, scars reminding them of everything that had been taken from them.

"I'm sorry," Helen said, reaching out and grabbing my wrist. "Come on. We should take a moment to mourn properly. With settled spirits, we can straighten our backs and help these people carry their burdens."

She led me to the far edge of the cavern. My breath caught as I looked down on a large crystalline tomb. Even in the dim light, it shined with blues and greens. Floating in its center was a familiar body. Aya's hands

were crossed over a wound in her stomach, not quite hiding it. Her eyes were closed, her expression one of peaceful rest.

Several smaller tombs—simple slabs of cold gray rock—had been raised around Aya's. To her right was a marbled tomb overrun with vines and bright, out-of-place flowers. The words *Feyrith Ivsaar III* were carved into the top of the stone. In smaller lettering below, it said, *The most important truths are sought within the cracks of one's own self.*

I ran my fingers along the grooves of the lettering, uncertain as to their meaning. Helen was walking in between the other slabs, touching each one briefly. When she saw me look in her direction, she smiled sadly. "Feyrith and Albold, they…well, your sister can probably explain it better than I."

"You did good out there, old friend," I said to the cold stone, echoing my own words from what felt like yet another lifetime ago.

Moving on to Aya's tomb, I rested my hand atop it, looking down at the elven Lance's serene face. I didn't need to be able to sense mana to see how the other Lances had worked together to craft Aya's resting place. Bright lights like frozen sparks gleamed within the crystal, and her body rested on a nest of fractal, frostlike patterns.

Closing my eyes, I nudged aether into the tomb. It rushed along the sharp edges and frozen contours, into the subtle striations within, grabbing onto the frozen sparks and filling in the fractals.

Helen's breath caught, and I opened my eyes. A light sheen of purple infused the blues and greens, seeming to move constantly inside the crystal, swirling and gusting like slow-motion wind.

"This tomb will be an enduring testament to all you've accomplished," I spoke softly. "Because that's something even death can't take from you, Aya."

Boo grunted irritably as he shook sand out of his coat, jostling Ellie atop his back. She scratched his neck fondly. "It'll be okay, big guy. Not too much farther now."

A gentle breeze had blown consistently into our faces for the last few

hours, and like Boo, everyone had sand clinging to them, which actually worked like a form of camouflage, helping to blend our long train into the surroundings.

Hundreds of people wound along in the rifts between shallow dunes. It was black and moonless in this part of the desert, with the only light coming from the bright stars overhead. We carried no lanterns or lighting artifacts, which would have been visible for miles across the empty central deserts of Darv.

Regis and I walked alongside Ellie, Boo, and my mother, near the head of the train.

Varay guarded the line's rear, while Bairon and the Earthborn brothers guided us at the front, and Mica flew ahead to scout the route. If Hornfels and Skarn's estimate was accurate, we were getting close to the outermost tunnels that would lead us to Vildorial.

"And so then there I am, getting *processed* out the thing's backside," Regis was saying. Ellie laughed, and Mom's eyebrows rose uncertainly. "But I got the better of the thing in the end. Well, Arthur helped, I suppose."

"Another!" Ellie wheezed through her giggling. "I want to hear everything."

"You know, Princess here has quite the temper. It almost got us in trouble a few times, like when—"

Mom stumbled as the sand slipped away beneath her feet, and she barely managed to catch herself.

"I'm okay," she said before anyone could ask. "Just lost my—hey!"

As my mother had spoken, Regis slipped up beside her and scooped her off her feet and onto his back. The sight of my surprised and frightened mom frozen like a statue atop Regis would have been comical if I wasn't so surprised as well.

"Um, Arthur?" Mom's wide eyes turned in my direction.

"He's just…trying to be helpful," I said, reaching for the link between us. Uncharacteristically, Regis stayed silent, his bright eyes staring seriously ahead.

Sitting stiffly, Mom wrapped her fingers into his fur, careful of the flames

leaping and gusting around his mane.

Ellie hid her mouth behind her hands, but I could still hear her half-suppressed giggles as she shot me a what-is-happening-right-now look from Mom's other side.

We walked on in silence for a few minutes until the call of "Alice?" came from somewhere behind. Some half-healed wound had become infected, and so, his chin up regally, Regis carted my mother off down to the line to help.

The sun was just beginning to brighten the eastern horizon, and Ellie was little more than a shadow atop her bond. Still, I could tell from her hunched shoulders and downturned head that something was bothering her.

Over the last few hours, Regis had kept his stories mostly lighthearted, and in exchange, Ellie had told us what she'd learned about Boo and the training she'd done in my absence, but mostly she'd listened, eager to hear everything about my time away, especially in the Relictombs. She'd been a quiet and patient listener, asking a few questions but otherwise just letting Regis talk—something he could do at length and without encouragement.

"Brother?" Ellie asked after a few minutes of silence between us.

I looked at her expectantly.

She hesitated, then seemed to steel herself. "Why didn't you come home sooner?"

My gaze settled on Durden's broad back, which was slung with several heavy bags. The big conjurer was walking not far ahead of us, while the rest of the Twin Horns were spread throughout the train, constantly on the lookout for any approaching danger.

Although it hadn't even been a day since my return to Dicathen, I had felt my inability to sense mana more distinctly. I was entirely reliant on the other mages to forewarn us of an approaching enemy. And, unlike the other Lances, I couldn't even fly to scout. It was a limitation I had maneuvered around in Alacrya, but now, with many more lives than my own at stake…

Finally, I spoke up. "I *did* want to come back sooner…as soon as I realized

where I was, but…I knew if I came back too soon, if I didn't take my time, grow strong again….then the same thing would happen all over again. There would be no one to save me this time, and then I wouldn't be able to protect you."

Ellie's body sagged in defeat, and I quickly added, "But I did keep an eye on you."

She rose again just as fast as she had deflated. "What do you mean?"

I withdrew the djinn seeing relic and showed her, turning it so the pink light of the horizon caught on its many facets. "It uses aether. Lets me see a person, even from a long way away. It only ever worked for you and Mom, though."

"That's…kind of creepy," Ellie said, her face scrunching into a wrinkly frown.

I chuckled and stowed the relic. "That's what Regis said you'd say." I paused. "I *am* sorry, though, El. For being gone so long."

She looked past me, her gaze unfocused, then said, "I know. And…I think I can forgive you for that, but…"

I raised a brow, unable to keep a frown from my face. "But what?"

"Coming home without even bringing me a present? *That's* unforgivable." She crossed her arms huffily, like she had when she was a little girl, and stuck her tongue out at me.

Bending down, I scooped up a handful of sand and chucked it at her. She squealed and leaned to the other side of Boo, trying to use him as a shield, but not quick enough. Just like Boo had done, she shook herself to knock the sand from her hair and glared at me.

"You know, I forgot how *annoying* you can be."

I gave her my widest grin. "Isn't that what big brothers are for?"

She rolled her eyes, her mouth opening to respond, but she froze for an instant, focusing on the sky, and the lighthearted moment came to an end.

I followed her gaze to Mica, who was drifting down toward us. "Are we nearly there?"

Mica waved her hand and a stone platform coalesced out of the sand. “We’re flying ahead to scout the entrance.” She inclined her head to the platform.

I gave Ellie an apologetic smile, brushed sand off Boo’s face, then stepped on the platform.

Mica turned and sped forward, and the platform followed. We quickly outpaced the train but didn’t go too far ahead. Hornfels, Skarn, and Bairon were waiting. They had taken shelter behind a formation of sharp beige rocks that grew up from a hilltop. In a valley below them, a dark rift broke the rolling waves of tawny sand: one of the entrances down into the spiderweb of tunnels that made up the dwarven kingdom.

“What’s the plan?” I asked as soon as my feet were on the ground.

Hornfels pointed to the shadows. “Behind that door will be miles of tunnels to hide the civilians in, and a more or less straight shot to Vildorial. These smaller gates aren’t guarded, only patrolled at random, so with a bit of luck we’ll have time to get everyone inside without being bothered.”

“Then, you lot hit the city,” Skarn said, sounding even grumpier than usual.

“The Lances, he means,” Bairon confirmed. “The rest of the mages will stay and ensure the people are safe.”

Sending just the four Lances into Vildorial allowed us to keep a solid fighting force in the outer tunnels to deal with any random patrols, although the Twin Horns and other mages present in our band of refugees wouldn’t be enough to defeat a sizable Alacryan assault force.

“And you’re sure it won’t be guarded?” I asked.

“Not this far out, it won’t be,” Hornfels assured me. “There aren’t enough dwarves in Darv to guard every crack and crevice.”

“The priority right now is getting these people out of the open,” Mica chimed in. “The strike against Vildorial will need to be hard and fast.”

Skarn was scowling deeply as he tugged at his long beard. “If the dwarves fight with the Alacryans, it’ll be a damned bloodbath.”

Mica smacked her cousin’s arm. “We won’t let that happen.”

Skarn rubbed his arm and spit in the sand. “Aye. Well then. We better get moving.”

The brothers turned back toward the train as Mica, Bairon, and I made our way down the hill toward the entrance. Just inside the shadows of the small ravine, a heavy stone door was inset in the wall.

When I’d snuck into Darv during the war to search for proof that the dwarves had betrayed Dicathen, I had been able to bypass the strange magical locks with Realmheart, but with Mica at my side, there was no need.

She reached into what looked like a patch of stone, and I knew she was releasing bursts of mana in a specific pattern. Moments later, the door began to grind open.

It took a moment for my eyes to adjust, which is when I saw five men sitting around a table in a small carved-out room off the side of the tunnel. They hesitated for a few seconds, then leapt to their feet, sending their chairs clattering.

Mica made a quick downward movement with her hand, and all five men and the table collapsed, crushed to the ground. One of them managed to send out a bolt of sickly green energy toward us, but it only burst against the stone wall of the tunnel, pulled off course by Mica’s gravity field.

“Alacryans,” I pointed out, noting that none of the guards were dwarves.

Mica clenched her jaw, and there was a wet crunch.

“I thought there weren’t supposed to be guards?” I asked, moving forward to inspect the remains.

“Do you feel that?” Bairon asked, looking at Mica.

She glanced around, the line of her gaze tracking something invisible through the stone. Then her eyes widened. “It’s an alarm. Shit.”

She held up a hand, her wrist and fingers working in the air as if she were manipulating some complicated pieces of machinery. When this apparently wasn’t working, she clenched her fist, and I heard stone shattering inside the tunnel walls.

“Subtle,” Bairon said, moving quickly into the tunnel. “Assuming that signal reached the city, we don’t have time to wait for all the people to file

in. We have to go now.”

“Varay?” I asked, looking back out the door into the desert.

“She’ll catch up,” Mica snapped, already flying away at top speed.

Bairon made to follow, then hesitated. “Can you…?”

“Go!” I urged him, God Stepping well ahead of both of them.

Tendrils of purple electricity arced off me to ripple over the smooth walls of the passage, and I began to sprint, pushing aether into my muscles to keep up with the two flying Lances, whose speed was limited in the tight quarters anyway.

The journey of miles took us twenty minutes, and we didn’t even slow down when we approached the massive stone gates that closed the tunnel off to the city of Vildorial.

A hook-nosed Alacryan mage was leaning against the edge of a small square opening. He only had time to widen his eyes as Mica hit the gates. Instead of exploding inward, however, the stone rippled out from the point of impact, turning into sand that splashed down to the tunnel floor. Several Alacryans had been standing along a rampart that ran along the back of the gates, and their screams were cut off abruptly as they were swallowed by the sand.

We rushed through the now-empty twenty-foot opening into the huge cavern of Vildorial. A wide road of reddish paving stones curved down to the right and up to the left, connecting different levels of the cavern.

Several dozen dwarves were arranged along this road, rushing into positions, shouts of alarm accompanying the sounds of defensive spells being cast.

Up and down the path, cavelike homes were carved into the outside walls, and a few doors opened as the residents stepped out to see what the commotion was.

A cheer rose up from nearby.

A dwarven woman, her fist raised in the air, was shouting, “Down with Alacrya! Down with the Vritra!” A nearby man hissed for her to be quiet, but she only gave him the back of her hand across his stunned face and resumed cheering. A few others joined in.

The dwarves' spells and weapons alike dropped, heavy steel clanging off the stones, and the crackle of fading magic filled the air. A look of utter shock was carved into each dwarven face, surges of horror and guilt fracturing their features like tremors. Tears began to spill from wide wet eyes, and, one by one, the dwarven soldiers fell to their knees before their Lance.

The rest of us stayed silent as Mica observed her people. She grimaced, her own eyes shining with the long hurt of watching her people betray Dicathen again and again. But, as she wiped a tear with the back of her arm, her expression softened into a sad smile.

She flew up into the air, making herself more visible while also being able to look down on the terrified soldiers. "First the Greysunders and then Rahdeas…they poisoned our minds with rose-colored lies, promising us equal footing with the humans and elves—no, *superiority* to them. But the whole time they were doing everything in their power to ensure that *they* were raised up but that their people—*you*—remained in squalor. You have been lied to! Betrayed. The Alacryans only use you, like tools, like livestock.

"Since before this war even began, our leaders have plotted against us, convinced us to fight against each other and our own well-being. Mica…I mean, *I* understand. And…I forgive you."

There was a moment of stillness and silence as all the dwarves present to hear this message struggled to absorb it. This stillness was broken a moment later when a line of Alacryan mages appeared from above, marching around a granite tower and down the curving road toward us, shields hovering in front of them.

Mica conjured her huge stone hammer, and Bairon floated up off the ground, lightning crackling around him. Varay flew in behind us, taking in everything with a single glance before landing next to Mica. The two exchanged a nod, and an icy aura leaked out to freeze the ground around Varay.

A magically projected voice boomed through the city. "Warning, dwarves. Return to your homes! Vildorial is under attack. Return to your homes!"

Before the voice had even stopped echoing, a crimson lance of energy fired from the approaching soldiers. But it wasn't aimed at us.

I God Stepped into the path of the spell and released a burst of aether that devoured the ray before it could strike its target: the woman who had cheered at our arrival. After a moment of delay, she gasped and stumbled back against the wall of her home.

Still clad in purple lightning, I moved out into the center of the road and away from people's homes, eyeing the approaching force. There were around thirty battle groups, all hardened men and women, but I still saw more than a few fearful looks tremble across their faces. It was hard to say, but I thought some might even have been at the sanctuary during the attack there.

Spells began to fly.

“Arthur!” Varay shouted, but I held my hand up to the other Lances.

Pushing as much aether as I could manage into the barrier clinging to my skin, I let the spells hit me. Stones broke against it, fire fanned out and faded, wind dispersed. A few of the strongest spells broke through, cutting or burning me, but aether rushed through my body, coalescing around the wounds, and I healed faster than I was being hurt.

After a minute or more of constant barrage, the spellfire slowed, then stopped entirely.

The ground around me had been blasted black. The far edge of the road gave an ominous crack, and several large chunks of paving tumbled down toward the lower level of the city.

Light steam and dark smoke mingled around me, drifting up from the broken stones, obscuring me in mist.

I stepped forward.

A heavy, threatening silence hung like a storm cloud over the city. For several heartbeats, no one moved. Then, one by one, the Alacryans began to shift, looking at one another or back the way they’d come with pale faces. Shields flickered as the soldiers conjuring them struggled to focus, and the straight, organized lines of men wavered and broke apart, their strict training failing them.

I waited until the tension was nearly ready to burst apart. “Anyone who wants to live, go now. For the rest”—I activated God Step, appearing in the center of the Alacryan force and unleashing my aetheric intent—“I can

offer only a quick death.”

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WINDS OF CHANGE

CAERA DENOIR

The sun was setting behind roiling storm clouds over Central Dominion, the sky's mood mirroring my own. It had been a tense and dull few days since the Victoriad's incomprehensible finale.

Highblood Denoir had, expectedly, gone on full alert after the Victoriad. They had immediately withdrawn me from my post at Central Academy and arranged for the entire extended blood to return to our primary estate for an all-hands-on-deck meeting. For days, the estate had been swarming with lower-ranking cousins and vassal lords, but Corbett and Lenora were keeping me isolated even from our own blood.

It seemed like they didn't want anyone else to ascertain the full depth of my connection to Grey until they had laid the appropriate political groundwork.

This suited me just fine. I had been unable to speak with Scythe Seris since the Victoriad, and I hadn't heard from Grey—not that I expected to—which only led to more and more questions, none of which I had answers for.

I found myself frustrated in a way I hadn't experienced since I was a freshly awakened teenage girl, forced to hide a power that I simultaneously wished I didn't have but also wanted to explore and understand. Until I could go to Scythe Seris, however, I saw no better alternative than simply lying low and playing along with my adoptive parents' wishes.

A boy suddenly appeared in the yards below my window, sprinting with all his might. Not far behind him, a slightly older boy was giving chase, a

sling spinning in one hand. With a jerk, he let a projectile fly, but the younger boy dove forward, rolling under it. When he popped back to his feet, he took just enough time to stick his tongue out at his pursuer, then vanished out the other side of the frame, the older boy close on his heels.

I smiled. It was a faint thing, heavy against my cheeks, but it felt good to know that there was someone out there unburdened by everything that was happening. Even if it was only my young cousins, who were both about as intelligent as the average toadstool.

A thunderclap shook the glass of my windowpane only a moment before heavy raindrops began to patter against it. The boys began to shout as they were no doubt soaked by the sudden deluge.

Closer at hand, barely audible beneath the noise of the storm, fabric rustled.

Grabbing a silver hairpin from my desk, I spun to my feet and brandished it like a weapon, then sighed and lowered my hand.

My adoptive brother, Lauden, was leaning against the doorframe of my bedroom. His muscular figure filled the doorway in a vaguely threatening manner, although the look on his face was more amused than hostile.

He swept his carefully trimmed olive hair to the side, his smile widening. “Your senses are growing dull, little sister. If I were an assassin—”

“Then this pin would be in your eye, and your blood would be on fire,” I said coolly, turning my chin up slightly. “And I would be saved from listening to any of your didactic dithering. What do you—or rather, what do Corbett and Lenora—want?”

Lauden held up his hands as a sign of peace. “No need to punish the messenger, Caera. Your tongue is sharper and burns worse than that of a sun-scythe toad. Father would like you to be ready, that is all. We’ll be meeting within the hour.”

I set the pin down and leaned against the desk. “Within the hour. Message received.”

Lauden’s brows rose, but he said nothing else as he turned on his heel and marched out of my rooms.

“Perhaps it is a good thing my brother is an ignorant oaf,” I muttered under

my breath as I followed him to the suite door and locked it.

There was a guilty squirming in the region of my stomach; what I was feeling had nothing to do with Lauden, and he had actually—perhaps for the first time in my life—made a genuine effort to be pleasant since the Victoriad. Of course, he also teased me several times about my "boyfriend" Grey, who, as it had turned out, was somewhere above Scythe-level in strength, so it may have been fear spurring his sudden good manners.

Moving to my dressing table, I took a seat on the cushioned stool and gazed at myself in the mirror, my mind lingering on Grey.

"Where is he now?" I asked the mirror, but there was no answer except my own expectant face staring back at me.

The Victoriad had changed everything for Grey and me—maybe even for all of Alacrya. That was yet to be seen, which was in large part the purpose of the meeting I was supposed to be getting ready for. The events of the Victoriad had shown light through a crack in Agrona's perceived infallibility. His own right hand had been challenged and killed, and when Agrona arrived to show off the power of his new pet mage, they had both been outmaneuvered, failing to capture Grey in what could only be seen as a stunning defeat.

But not every Alacryan would understand what had happened. And even if they did, most could be made to forget amidst the threat of war with the other asuras or would simply continue to toe the line for fear of the Vritra.

Cowards, I thought, watching my lip tense into a frown.

Taken by a sudden reckless impulse, I unclasped the medallion that I always wore around my neck and set it down hard on the dressing table. In the mirror, my horns simply appeared, no longer hidden by the medallion's illusory powers. I pulled my lips back from my teeth and snarled at the mirror.

Now that would be quite the look for this evening's meeting, I mused before letting the expression fade. The face left behind was cold, almost forlorn. Lonely.

I was *so tired* of hiding who I was. Of being isolated from the people around me. Grey had been something to me that I'd never had before: a peer, a confidant. A *friend*.

I pictured again his regretful gaze in the moments before he vanished. *He didn't want to leave me behind*, I assured myself, but…

How well did I really know him?

Sighing, I took up the amulet and reclasped it behind my neck. In the mirror, the horns disappeared in a blink. Reaching tentatively up, I ran my hand along the invisible horns, feeling the curves, grooves, and points. Just because I couldn't see them, that didn't mean they were really gone.

With practiced efficiency, I prepared for the meeting. Lenora wished for my face to be painted, and Corbett had already picked out a gown for me. They expected me to appear graceful and elegant, but nonthreatening. Many a highblood had devoured itself tail first in less dire circumstances than what the Denoirs now faced.

And as an outsider—an adoptive Vritra-blood—my entire life had been a double-edged blade for the Denoirs. As much as I was a point of pride and potential empowerment, any misstep either with or from me could just as easily lead to their ruin. Thus the tight leash I had been kept on my entire life, which only grew tighter by the day.

I had just finished pinning up my hair when there was a light knock on my door.

Standing, I twisted the gold gown around me, watching the light glint off blue gems that matched my hair, which I had folded into a slightly messy twist and fixed with a gold-and-ruby pin that doubled as a blade if necessary. I didn't expect to be attacked in my own home, but…one could never be too careful.

Slipping into a stately walk, I crossed the room and opened the door. Nessa was waiting outside with Arian.

Nessa clicked her tongue, her eyes narrowing critically at my hair. Her fingers twitched as she said, "Lady Caera, Highlord and Lady Denoir request your presence in the parlor."

"By all means," I said, and she turned and began marching down the hall. I fell into step behind her and heard Arian's soft footfalls behind me.

We crossed paths with only a few other Denoirs on the way to the parlor. Each of them stopped whatever they were doing to give me a shallow bow,

but I could feel their eyes burning into my back once I'd gone past. There was curiosity there, but also fear, frustration, and even outright hostility.

They may not know what my relationship with the mysterious Grey had been, but they knew it was a beacon drawing unwanted attention to Highblood Denoir. While other bloods—high, named, or otherwise—were excitedly gossiping about recent events, the Denoirs were on high alert, uncertain if they—*we*—would survive.

Although I was certain the Denoirs would place the blame on me, in reality it was Corbett and Lenora's insistence on involving the highblood in Scythe Seris's business that had led to this point. Inviting Grey for dinner, meeting with him in public, asking endless questions about him around Cargidan and Central Academy…they had *tried* to draw connections between themselves and Grey. And they had succeeded, which put the entire blood at risk.

Not that I could fault them for that. Whatever their reasoning, they'd given Grey a chance, even protection during the trial. It almost made me dread what was to come. I hadn't been able to read Corbett's mood at all over the last few days.

Instead of entering the parlor through the main doors, Nessa took us down a servants' stairs and in through a shadowed alcove. Corbett, Lenora, and Lauden were already there, as was Corbett's brother, Arden. Taegen and a woman I didn't know—one of Arden's guards, I assumed—were flanking the parlor doors.

Lenora's hand went to Corbett's arm when she noticed our entrance, interrupting whatever he'd been saying. The pair of them looked me over with the same critical air Nessa had, although with a hundred times more judgment, but Arden didn't give them time to say anything.

Seeing the line of their gaze, he turned around, grinned, and then held out his hands in a gesture of welcome. "Caera, dove!" he said, his voice deeper and slightly more raspy than his brother's.

"Uncle," I replied, giving him a courtly curtsy.

I knew well enough to be on my best behavior, including using the preferred titles for my adoptive parents and their many relatives and vassals, but I'd always called Arden *uncle*. In part because he had insisted on it throughout my childhood—and I hadn't seen him often enough as I

grew into adulthood to break the habit—but also because I knew it irritated Corbett that I didn't fight back against the familial title the way I did with *mother* and *father*.

"What kind of trouble have you gotten us into now, ay, little bird?" he chuckled, moving over to give me a stiff one-armed hug.

Despite being Corbett's younger brother, Arden looked ten years older. He was shorter and heavier, with a pronounced belly and olive hair that was receding away from his temples. But he used these softer features to his advantage, hiding a blade-sharp mind behind his outwardly unimposing features. That, and a potent regalia.

"That remains to be seen," Corbett said, drawing the words out so they lingered in the air.

My adoptive father wore white and navy, as usual, but his suit had an aggressive military-style cut, and he wore a single shining pauldron that extended into a narrow gorget that wrapped around his neck. His thin blade hung from his belt as well, making him look like he was prepared to lead a charge into battle.

Lenora, on the other hand, wore a soft, flowing navy gown, billowing out and lending matronly curves to her thin frame.

Sugar and spice, I thought. It was a presentation they had perfected over their long marriage. One intimidating, one welcoming. In reality, they were more hammer and anvil.

I'd never seen them engage in these political mind games with their own blood, however. My pulse quickened. It made me nervous.

"Bring the rest in," Corbett said next.

Instead of sending one of the servants, Lenora went herself.

Corbett waved for me to join him and Lauden. Arden stood slightly to the side. No other words were exchanged, and I felt like the three men were carefully not looking at me.

Within seconds, Lenora returned, followed by Arden's wife, Melitta, who entered with their children, Colm and Arno, the two little boys who had been playing so roughly beneath my window. Arno, the younger of the two, still had the grass stains on his clothes.

The three bowed deeply to the Highlord and Lady Denoir, and I caught Arden giving his sons a wink as they marched by.

Lord Justus Denoir followed. Corbett's uncle was in his sixties. His hair had gone gray, and there were two gray streaks in his goatee, but he stood straight and strong, carrying himself like the lifelong nobility he was. Corbett and Justus had always had a difficult relationship, as Justus had intended to become highlord when Corbett's father, Corvus, died, but the deceased highlord had outmaneuvered his brother and set Corbett in his place.

Still, infighting and backstabbing was an inevitable path to see your own highblood crumble, and so the two willful men had kept a forced sort of peace between them for the last fifteen years.

Following Justus was Lady Gemma Denoir, Lenora's oldest sister. She walked stiffly like she was carrying a sword in her backside, taking her time entering the room. Her white hair was carefully coiffed and shining with black gemstones that matched her glittering black gown. The effect made her crystalline blue eyes shine like diamonds.

Though Lady Gemma smiled, there was a simpering, frustrating tone to every movement she made, and her bow was shallower than was proper. When her eyes caught mine, her smile slipped away entirely, her nose wrinkling in disgust, and she simply walked past.

And so it went, for a while. The Denoirs traipsed in by ones and twos, starting with the highest ranking members of the blood and working down to the lowliest vassals. There were others who were also technically considered members of the highblood but who lacked any station within it, and so had not been invited to this meeting.

Finally, when the last of the highblood had been seated and plied with drinks by Lauden, Corbett gestured for me and my adoptive brother to take seats as well. The parlor was just large enough to accommodate such a crowd but small and private enough to give the meeting a conspiratorial air.

When Corbett's chief attendant closed the doors, leaving only members of the highblood and a handful of trusted guards, such as Taegen and Arian, inside the room, the impression deepened.

"As you are all certainly aware," Corbett began without preamble, "the

events of the recent Victoriad are without precedent in the known history of Alacrya."

Lady Gemma snorted, drawing a raised brow from Lenora.

Despite being the older sister, Gemma was an adoptive member of the blood, taken in after her own husband died, and she carried no position or authority beyond what her relationship with Lenora granted her. There was nearly always an edge of bitterness and one-upmanship between the pair when they were together.

"True enough, Highlord," one of the older cousins—Dereth or Drothel or something, I'd forgotten—said amicably, but his bushy brows were pinched in a nervous frown, "but what does that have to do with the Denoirs? Are you confirming that there is truth to the rumors that our highblood is somehow entangled with this Ascender Grey fellow?"

Corbett glanced to where I was lounging back in a thick-cushioned chair, my face hidden behind a glass of bright red wine that I wasn't drinking. That subtle tic was the only sign of his agitation, however, and when he spoke again, his words came out clear and calm. "Before we speak to Highblood Denoir's relationship with the man called Grey, first we must share information only very recently acquired." He gestured to his brother.

Arden stood, clasping his hands behind his back so that his pouchy belly stuck out even farther. "Yes, indeed. Thank you, Brother." He cleared his throat. "Just yesterday, a large detachment of Alacryan soldiers—thousands of mages in all—returned from Dicathen."

Arden was carefully watching the rest of the blood, likely trying to ascertain who else might know whatever he was about to tell us. From the eager way Gemma stared at him, the wine glass in her hand suddenly going still, it was clear that she, at least, certainly did.

"All from the homeland of our dwarven allies," Arden continued. "Darv, for those of you who don't follow these things. And with a number of Dicathian dwarves in tow."

This caused a stir. I shifted forward in my chair slightly and set down my drink, keeping my back straight and my expression poised.

So far, Dicathians had only been brought to Alacrya for public displays of punishment, like those at the Victoriad. There was little other reason for prisoners to be teleported from the other continent, and no allies had been

offered quarter in our land before. Or if they had, it had been kept very quiet.

“The returned force accounts for nearly seventy percent of the soldiers stationed in a city named Vildorial, the capital,” Arden continued. “And they returned not under order, but because they were defeated.”

A chorus of disbelieving chatter interrupted Arden, some expressing bewilderment, others even calling Arden’s story into question. He scowled, and the highlord called for quiet.

“Were any members of our highblood present?” Justus asked, his deep baritone ringing like a gong over the lingering remnants of chatter that struggled to die out. “If so, they should have been brought before the entire highblood to explain their cowardice.”

“No,” Arden confirmed, nodding to the older man. He took a moment to compose himself, then continued. “The small force we fielded are staged in a city called Etistin. But…” Arden paused, his gaze now flicking to me in a way that made the small hairs on my neck stand on end. “But I was able to secure several firsthand accounts of what happened there.”

Arden began to pace, cleverly using it as an opportunity to meet the eyes of several different people, somehow making it feel like he was speaking to each of them individually. “The strike on Vildorial came out of nowhere. There hasn’t been any real resistance in Dicathen in months, and the largest cities have already begun transitioning, building newer, larger forges and foundries for the Imbuers.

“And so Vildorial’s peacekeepers had little warning before a small group of Dicathen’s elite warriors—the Lances, I believe they are called—smashed down the gates.”

“Oh, I read all about the Lances!” little Arno piped up, his small voice cutting right through the electrified tension building in the room. There were a couple of surprised chuckles at this, but his mother pulled him close, quieting him.

“I’m afraid I’m not following,” one of the more distant cousins asked, giving Arden an embarrassed smile. “While this is stunning news, what does it have to do with us?”

“The attack on Vildorial was led by a man with golden eyes,” Arden said slowly. “Who, it appears, could walk through lightning and conjure purple

flames from his hands."

The bottom dropped out of my stomach. Whatever the rest of the blood's reaction, I didn't hear it over the sudden pressure in my ears.

It was a simple description, but there was only one man on either continent who fit it.

"Grey," I mouthed noiselessly.

Like a single stone that falls and begins an avalanche, this piece of information tumbled into place amidst everything else I knew about Grey. The strange questions in the Relictombs, his lack of basic knowledge despite being so powerful, his unusual magic, his lack of blood connections, Scythe Seris's interest in him, the fact that he'd fought in the war but never talked about it…the pieces of information all came crashing down around me.

But it didn't make sense. Grey couldn't be a Dicathian…could he? Scythe Seris knew him, apparently trusted him, and that alone was enough for me to do the same. *But should it be?* I asked myself, suddenly wary.

"You've destroyed us." Justus's voice thundered over the tumult, bringing the scene around me back into focus. He was staring at Corbett, his finger pointing accusingly. "You've always been too greedy and power hungry, Corbett, clinging to Scythe Seris Vritra like a bloodworm ever since *she* was forced on our highblood," he ground out, his accusing finger momentarily turning in my direction.

The parlor fell quiet.

Though some may have agreed with him, no one had the spine to join in his accusations, and in fact, those sitting closest to him scooted away, as if worried he might spontaneously combust.

"And if Ascender Grey returns, Uncle?" Corbett asked, breaking the uncomfortable silence. "Would you prefer we were on bad footing with a man capable of felling two Scythes?"

"But what actually ties us to this man?" the same cousin from before asked into the silence, again feigning embarrassment.

Lenora had wrapped her arm around Corbett's waist, and together, they looked defiantly out at their blood.

“We were made aware of Scythe Seris Vritra’s intense interest in Ascender Grey some time ago,” she said pleasantly, her tone as simple and nonconfrontational as if she were discussing the weather, “and so we made inroads to establishing a relationship with the man. He kept himself rather apart from the normal social circles of Cargidan, but through a happy accident had already made the acquaintance of our daughter, Caera.”

I stiffened slightly as all eyes jumped to me, then just as quickly away. Only the red-faced Justus let his gaze linger, his brows lowering angrily as I gazed back at him, refusing to be intimidated.

“Couldn’t it be that this *accidental acquaintance* was really Grey worming his way into Highblood Denoir’s good graces?” Justus asked, standing and copying Arden by pacing around and looking not at Corbett but the rest of our blood. “Taking advantage of us in order to place himself at the Victoriad, in a position to weaken the leaders of the war in Dicathen and embarrass the High Sovereign?” Only then did Justus look at Corbett, a disappointed sneer marring his face. “An act that, by aiding him, you have made us all accomplice to?”

“I can assure you that isn’t the case,” I said before Corbett could respond. When all eyes yet again turned to me, I paused to take a slow sip from my glass, gathering my thoughts. “It is fundamentally impossible for our meeting to have been by design, considering we were in the Relictombs at the time, and I was the one who initiated that contact, not Grey.”

Justus opened his mouth to counter me, but I spoke over him, keeping my tone calm but firm. “And before you embarrass yourself by making accusations about either my or *Scythe Seris Vritra’s* intentions regarding Grey, know that my parents’ assumption was entirely correct. She saw his power—the same power you all saw for yourselves at the Victoriad—and grew interested; that is all.”

I felt Corbett’s gaze on me but didn’t look away from Justus. Although his features were rigid and angry, I could see the fear in the jittery back-and-forth movements of his eyes.

The room devolved into several layers of loud conversation, each voice fighting to be heard over every other.

“I mean, he *did* defeat a Scythe, it makes sense—”

“—should throw ourselves at the High Sovereign’s mercy—”

“—be a counterattack? Perhaps we could save face by joining—”

“—pure fire, and to escape the Victoriad apparently unscathed—”

“—does this mean for Highblood Denoir, Highlord?”

Corbett focused on Melitta, Arden’s wife. “A good question, Melitta, thank you.” Slowly, the room around him quieted again. “We would not be meeting like this if the situation did not present *some* danger to our highblood, but Lenora and I believe there is opportunity here as well. For—”

“Of course you do,” Justus muttered, loud enough for all to hear.

A muscle near Corbett’s eye twitched, but he kept going. “For the moment, outwardly we will take no action, only biding our time and watching,” Corbett said, focusing on Justus. “If there is an official inquiry into Highblood Denoir, rest assured that we have only extended what welcome and courtesy was due to a potent ascender and member of Caera’s team.”

“Foolishness,” Lady Gemma said, leaning farther back in her chair and swirling her wine glass. Her predatory gaze lingered on Arden. “What about the counterattack already being prepared? Do we plan to participate? To make up for your failure of judgment?”

Corbett and Lenora exchanged a glance. “We’ve determined it is best to maintain our current strategy in Dicathen,” Corbett answered.

Justus scoffed. “This only makes us look more guilty.”

“No inquisitor, not even the Scythes themselves, will find a hint of wrongdoing in Highblood Denoir’s actions,” Lenora insisted. “But change is on the wind, Denoirs.” Lenora gazed around the room, masterfully letting her expression vacillate between a small frown and conspiratorial smile. “And, as we all know, sometimes the wind blows hard from the mountains. We’ll need sure footing to weather it.”

I blinked, unsure I had understood Lenora’s words properly. It *almost* sounded as if she were endorsing Grey and Scythe Seris if there were some kind of power struggle between them and the High Sovereign…

The rest of the blood was quiet and thoughtful. Little Arno caught my eye as I surreptitiously scanned the room, gave me a big smile, and waved.

Justus stood, his shoulders back, chest out, chin held high. His steady eyes cut into Corbett and Lenora like daggers. “I’m afraid this line of thinking is untenable with the continued well-being of this highblood. Highlord Corbett Denoir…I am forced to officially request you step down from your position. Beg mercy of the Scythes—Scythe Seris Vritra herself, if you must. Assure them that your mistakes are your own, and that leadership of Highblood Denoir will rest in steadier hands. I will—”

The words hissed into silence as Justus jerked his sword free of its sheath. Taegen was by Lenora’s side in an instant, Arian rushing to stand over me, the bare steel of his thin blade glinting in the soft light as he looked frantically in every direction at once.

“There won’t be any need for that at the moment,” a calm voice said, drawing all eyes to the shadows of the servants’ entrance.

A gray-skinned man in dark leather armor stepped out of the shadows. He was quite handsome, with an undeniable strength despite how he suppressed his mana.

I stood as everyone else—everyone except Justus—went to a knee, bowing deeply before Cylrit, retainer to Scythe Seris and the dominion of Sehz-Clar. His scarlet eyes met mine, and I felt a bolt like lightning pass between us. He could only be there for me. Finally, Scythe Seris was rescuing me from these long, dreary days of tedium and tension.

“Do as the highlord and lady command,” Cylrit said to Justus, who had somehow managed to go pale and flushed at the same time. “Highblood Denoir should take no action at this time. Lady Caera is to come with me.”

“W-what do you mean?” Lenora stammered, her mask of absolute control and confidence cracking. “Caera is—”

“Let them take her,” Justus said, very carefully sheathing his sword and taking a knee. “Please, Lord Cylrit, with your approval, I would—”

Cylrit smiled, a subtle, dangerous thing, and Justus’s mouth snapped shut.

“Lord Denoir,” the retainer said slowly, enunciating each syllable carefully. “Do as you are commanded. Or things may go poorly for you.”

The last of the color left Justus’s face, and a muscle in his jaw pulsed.

Like that, Cylrit seemed to dismiss them all entirely. To me, he gave a

softer smile and held out his arm. “Please, Lady Caera. Scythe Seris is expecting us.”

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PURITY

ARTHUR LEYWIN

‘Ugh, spending five hours listening to these dwarves play the blame game is making me miss passing through a mana beast’s colon,’ Regis grumbled.

These meetings may not be exciting, but they are important. Just…try to enjoy the view or something, I thought tiredly.

The Hall of Lords within Vildorial’s palace, Lodenhold, was an astonishing sight. The hall itself was built inside an enormous geode that stretched at least seventy feet wide and was perhaps a hundred feet from floor to ceiling. It was difficult to tell how much exactly because the floor was hidden by a swirling pool of silvery mist.

The long hand-carved table where the dwarven nobility met rested atop a thin sliver of crystal that floated unsupported in the air in the geode’s center. To reach it, we had crossed a series of hovering stones that made a kind of walkway.

The geode itself shone with a kaleidoscope of colors: aquamarine bleeding into rusty orange cut through with purple striations, sparkling with yellow and white. When the light shifted, the colors seemed to jump and run together. Instead of lighting artifacts, ever-burning candles floated at intervals throughout the space, ensuring constantly flickering light that made it look like waves of color were washing across the geode’s million little surfaces.

I had examined it at length, mostly when the gathered dwarves began pointing fingers or arguing about who had failed in what duty, which clans

deserved a seat at the table, and who had proven the worst failure to dwarvenkind.

“With all respect to Lance Mica,” Lord Silvershale said for probably the seventh time, “the Earthborns stayed nice and chummy with the Alacryans in Vildorial throughout the occupation. Never had to leave *their* homes, none of *their* kin died defending—”

“A blatant lie,” Carnelian Earthborn responded, rolling his beetle-black eyes. “And not even a clever one, considering that my own daughter *led* the damned war.”

I looked from Silvershale to Earthborn. The former was older, with shoulder-length hair that had largely gone gray and a beard braided into three prongs. Carnelian, on the other hand, looked relatively young. His mahogany red hair didn’t match Mica’s at all, but there was a roundness to his cheeks and a bright, shining youth in his eyes that gave him that same childlike appearance as his daughter.

“Where has the Earthborn clan been, then, these last many months?” Lord Silvershale looked around the table, not at Carnelian but the rest of the dwarven nobility. “Certainly not in the tunnels fighting against the Alacryans and *turncoats,*” he finished, crossing his arms and flashing the others a victorious grin.

Okay, you’re right, I admitted to Regis. *The important part appears to be over.*

Before the two could take the argument further—or worse, draw in any of the other lords—I stood. The crystal below my feet rang against the petrified wood of my chair, drawing all eyes to me. Everyone in attendance—as many dwarven nobles as we could round up on short notice, the surviving members of Virion’s council, and the other Lances—hurried to stand as well.

“I’m afraid I need time to prepare before moving on to the other long-range teleportation gates,” I said.

Mica let out a relieved sigh, then seemed to catch herself, stood straight, and smoothed her expression into something slightly more noble. “All the Lances, in fact, have other duties to attend to. Father,” she finished with a slight inclination of her head.

“Indeed,” Carnelian said, beaming at his daughter. “We’ve kept our guests

far too long. Let this meeting of the Lords Assemblage be adjourned, to reconvene tomorrow, midday." He rapped his knuckles on the tabletop like a judge swinging his gavel.

From across the table, Helen caught my eye, widening hers just slightly, her lips pressed tightly together. I knew exactly how she felt.

It was hard to feel sorry for the dwarves, difficult to avoid comparing their pain and loss to that of the elves. But there was no denying they had suffered. Since the war began, they'd been quietly slaughtering each other in the tunnels beneath the desert. The two factions saw each other as fools and blood traitors, each side betraying what was in the dwarves' best interest.

This animosity wouldn't fade in a day, and I felt certain we hadn't seen the last of the bloodshed between the dwarven factions. Still, we had done what we could in such a short amount of time.

Most of the dwarves had been thrilled to see the Alacryans pushed out of Vildorial. Almost as many had been furious when the Alacryans had been allowed to teleport back to Alacrya, however. Even among the Lords Assemblage, many complained that we hadn't executed all the Alacryan soldiers for their crimes. I couldn't exactly blame them.

Even more controversial was the decision to allow those dwarves who were most dedicated to the Alacryans to leave with them. Despite the dwarven nobility's concerns that we'd just given Agrona more soldiers, I hardly thought they'd be treated as equals in Alacrya. But by the time they realized their own folly, it would be far too late.

For *those* men and women, however, I felt no sympathy at all.

An attendant opened the doors that led back into the palace proper, which, after the grandeur of the Hall of Lords, felt almost plain by comparison. Gideon was leaning against the wall just outside, while four heavily armed and armored dwarves glowered at him unwelcomingly.

The inventor pushed himself away from the wall at the sound of the doors opening and gave me a wide boyish grin. "Finally! These dwarves think as slow as the stone they live in…" Gideon trailed off, then cleared his throat as the guards' faces darkened. I kept walking, and he fell into step beside me. "Anyway, I've been waiting for you, boy. I've got a few things to show you, inventions I worked on while in the Alacryans' *care*. There are

a few things that I really think—”

I held up a hand, forestalling the deluge of information about to spill from Gideon. “I want to see it, I do, but not right now, Gideon.” The old inventor’s face fell. Twisting the ring of polished black stone off my middle finger, I held it out to him. The moment of disappointment melted away as he plucked it out of my hands. “I need you to focus on this.”

He held it up to his eye and turned it over several times. “But this is just a dimension ring. What…” He trailed off, his wide bloodshot eyes jumping from the ring to me as an excited grin spread across his face. “Oh, *please* tell me you’ve brought presents from the other continent.” He bobbed on the balls of his feet, nearly skipping. “Some of their technology, perhaps?”

“Very specific technology,” I confirmed. “Figure out how it works, if we can replicate it. Whatever else you’ve been working on, this takes priority.”

We made our way out of the palace together, Gideon peppering me with questions that I answered to the best of my ability. He hurried off from the front gates, rushing toward the Earthborn Institute to unpack the dimension ring and begin his studies, assuring me he wouldn’t eat or sleep until he had answers.

From the front gates of Lodenhold, which was on the highest level of Vildorial, I could see the entire cavern laid out below me.

The city was bustling with activity: soldiers preparing defenses against Agrona’s inevitable counterattack, food and materials being carted in from the expansive tunnel system that surrounded the city, and temporary homes being found for the hundreds of refugees we’d brought with us, all of which mingled with the day-to-day activities of the city’s residents.

The city center, a huge plaza that dominated the bottom level, had become ground zero for receiving the hundreds of mostly elven refugees we’d brought with us. Even from the palace, I could see that the plaza was filled with large tables, crates, and tents for handing out fresh food and giving the most tired and feeble refugees a place to rest while they waited for more comfortable lodgings.

Plenty of dwarves were lined up to receive food as well, although I couldn’t help but notice how little they mingled with the elves. Pushing aether into my eyes, I looked more closely at the individuals. No one

bothered to hide the bitter sideways glances between the two races, and there was a palpable tension hanging over the plaza.

Unfortunate, but not unexpected, I thought. *The elves see the dwarves as turncoats, while these struggling, starving dwarves see the elves as competition for too few resources.*

'They better figure it out,' Regis chimed in. *'They'll all be in Agrona's crosshairs together. Or Kezess's. Pick your megalomaniac.'*

I took a deep breath, held it for several seconds, then slowly let it back out. *I know*.

'I still think the Relictombs would have been better,' Regis thought with the mental equivalent of shrugging his shoulders. *'Less complicated.'*

It was true that the Relictombs would have been an impenetrable shelter from the asuras, considering they couldn't even enter it.

But then I would be no better than the asuras, I thought with an edge of rebuke. *The Relictombs would be as much a cage as an asylum, and I'd become their master.*

'Better a master who protects them than one ready to sacrifice them for his own ends,' Regis thought mulishly.

I imagine that's what Kezess and Agrona both thought before they became the tyrants they are today, I refuted.

'The real problem is that you won't make up your damned mind,' he shot back, agitated. *'Arguing with yourself—and by extension,* me*—every moment of every day about what's the* best *way to do something. It's war. There are going to be consequences, and you have to be ready to accept that no matter what you do.'*

I know.

'Do you?' Regis pressed. *'Like this whole portal-to-Alacrya thing. You want to destroy it but don't want to give it up as a tool, but just turning it off is still dangerous, and you're afraid of what will happen if you're wrong. It's exhausting being in here.'* His huge shadow wolf form leaped out onto the road beside me. He shook out his mane, causing the flames to flare.

"I'm going to go exploring," he grumbled, loping away down the road and

ignoring the chorus of surprised and frightened shouts from the dwarves he passed.

I sighed as I watched him go, but my mind was settling into a discordant blankness, my thoughts fluttering like tattered cobwebs in the dark, disrupted by Regis's frustration that was still leaking into me.

I closed my eyes hard, then opened them and focused on the crowd again, looking for Mom and Ellie. After a minute, I found them at one of the long tables. Mom was ladling soup into bowls while Ellie handed out chunks of bread and full waterskins.

I wanted to go to them. *Almost* as much as I wanted to be alone. I couldn't bear the thought of all those people, their eyes turned expectantly in my direction, pleading and begging…

I didn't blame them. Not at all. I understood. I'd lived it all before, after all, as King Grey. But now wasn't the time.

Instead of descending the looping path down to the lowest level, I turned and moved around the edge of Lodenhold and through a garden filled with glowing mushrooms. Around the far edge, where the cut stone merged back into the rough, natural cavern cliff, there was an arched tunnel carved into the wall. Steam and the heavy sulfuric smell of a natural hot spring wafted out.

The short tunnel opened up onto a ledge above a series of round pools. The water had a subtle blue luminescence, almost like it was absorbing and reflecting the light of the many glowing fungi and hanging vines that grew over the walls and ceiling. No one else was present. During our short tour of the Lodenhold, Carnelian Earthborn had explained that the Alacryans had forbidden dwarves to use these pools.

I suspected the nobles would move back in soon enough, but for the moment, it was the perfect place to rest and think.

Letting myself move slowly, almost meandering, I walked along the edge of the pools until I found a spot I liked, next to a small private pool where a patch of long-stemmed mushrooms grew. They waved on their stalks like the antenna of some subterranean mana beast.

Slipping off my boots, I eased my feet into the water and took a seat on the soft mossy ground.

The keystone had become my primary tool for meditation, and so I withdrew it from the dimension rune. I turned the heavy matte-black cube over in my hands a few times, considering it.

So far, I had discovered that the blackness within the keystone realm reacted to mana use, but not in a way I could see or manipulate. It was nothing more than inky-black ripples in the dark. Thanks to Caera, I had learned that the black ripples were mana itself and theorized that having a mana core allowed one to see the mana particles around them when they entered the keystone. My lack of a mana core seemed to be the primary obstacle preventing me from moving forward.

As I'd done dozens of times now, I imbued aether into the keystone. My consciousness rushed into it, passing through the purple walls into darkness. And I stayed there, surrounded by blankness, the lightly sulfuric smell of the hot water only barely pressing through to my conscious mind.

I didn't bother activating any of my aetheric abilities, didn't hunt through the nothing for signs of magic or mana. I didn't even think, at least for a little while. It was like being asleep, except I didn't have to struggle as I would to sleep naturally.

Then, after some indeterminate amount of time, something changed. I wasn't quite sure what at first. It was a subtle sensation, like a prickling at the back of my neck when someone was watching me.

But this feeling was coming from within the keystone realm.

Near the edges of what I would consider my vision, something shifted in the darkness. It wasn't the black-on-black slithering I had felt before. More like…stars, barely seen through light nighttime clouds. They were barely perceptible gray motes that pulsed, turning this way and that, almost like they were hunting for something.

I opened my eyes.

Across the room, Ellie crept out of the entryway, her hand on the wall, her nose wrinkled up against the thick air, tension tightening every muscle. She squinted into the strange, fungi-borne light, saw me, and relaxed.

"Wow."

Her whisper carried in the silence of the hot springs.

El. Had my sister been the source of the gray motes inside the keystone realm? But if so, how? Why? What had she been doing? Instead of firing off these questions like arrows, however, I gave her a warm, if tired, smile. “How did you find me?”

She wrinkled her nose again. “Okay, it’s going to sound weird, but I smelled you.”

“Smelled me?” I chuckled, one eyebrow raising. “I’m pretty sure I don’t stink that bad, do I?” I sniffed at my tunic just to make sure.

“It’s part of my beast will,” she said, tucking a lock of hair behind her ear. She hesitated at the stairs that led from the ledge down to the moss-covered stone that ringed the pools. “Is it okay if…”

“Of course,” I said immediately. As much as I wanted to be alone to explore the keystone—to discover more about the gray particles I’d seen—after all this time, I also just wanted to spend time with my sister. “Come sit with me. The water feels amazing.”

Ellie beamed at me as she practically skipped in between the pools to join me, kicked off her turnshoes, and plopped down with her feet in the water.

“Where’s Boo?”

She laughed, kicking her feet in the water and splashing us both. “He was terrifying the dwarf children in the food lines, so I sent him to hunt in the tunnels.” She frowned suddenly. “I hope he’ll be okay. What if someone thinks he’s a wild mana beast or something? I should have thought of that sooner.”

“I can send Regis to keep him company,” I told her, pinging my companion mentally to do just that. I had felt the boredom trickling back from him, so I knew he would eagerly agree. Both of them were technically born of Epheotus, and I had sensed Regis’s curiosity about Boo several times since returning.

Ellie smiled in thanks, but the smile flickered at the edges. “Hey…why didn’t you come down to see us? You’re…it’s not because of Mom, is it?”

“No, it’s not…” I stopped, forced to gather my thoughts. “It was mostly the crowd, but maybe a little because of Mom. Don’t get me wrong. I have nothing but love for her. It’s just…”

“Complicated?”

I kicked my foot and watched the ripples move outward, slowly fading as they went. “I don’t know what’s best for her, El. Time with me, time apart to digest everything that’s happened, starting the conversation, waiting for her to take the lead…”

Ellie shrugged. “It’ll take time. But you need to know that Mom really, really wants to fix things between you two.” She grinned. “And not just because you’re some crazy super-powered hero now.”

I laughed, pushing her sideways. She slid down the mossy slope and got soaked up to her knees, then splashed water at me.

When the laughter subsided, she noticed the keystone in my hand for the first time. “What’s that?”

“A djinn—ancient mage keystone. It’s like…an instruction manual for aether arts. But I’ve been working on this one for a while, and I can’t seem to make sense of it. Every time I think I’m making progress, I just end up at another dead end. Except…” I hesitated, weighing my curiosity about the gray motes versus my concern in involving my sister.

She ran a finger along one edge, peering closely at its surface. “How does it work?”

There was no way to separate these parts of my life, I decided with a sigh. Not anymore. “Do you want to help?” She nodded excitedly, so I quickly explained the training process I’d used with Enola and Caera. “It’d be just like when we used to practice forming different shapes with your mana back at the castle.”

Ellie’s face scrunched with concentration as she held up a hand. An identical cube formed on her palm, but this one was made of her own bright, pure mana. “Like this?”

I nodded. “Now, my mind is going to go into the keystone. It's hard to concentrate on my other senses, so I may not be able to hear you, but just keep going until I come back, okay?”

“Got it,” she said seriously, letting the cube dissipate as she prepared to conjure a different shape.

I nervously slid back into the keystone realm, quelling any hopes or

expectations. For a moment, all was still, quiet, and empty. Then the mana began to move, and my heart stopped.

Burning amidst the otherwise formless black was an uneven orb of blurry gray motes. After a few seconds, the orb began to change, adding in more mana particles as it became more complex. Like watching a ball of clay molded into shape, the shadowy mana particles became a rough but recognizable bear. I could *see* Ellie continuing to work at it, thinning the body, widening the legs, adjusting the bear's heavy brows. When the bear began to walk, I lost focus.

My eyes snapped open, and I stared at the water in front of Ellie, where an identical little bear of pure mana was slowly maneuvering across the surface of the water. She was so intently focused on her creation that she hadn't noticed me return.

Most mages adapted an affinity toward a specific element quite early on, but Ellie's mana had never manifested in that way. Like an augmenter, Ellie used the pure mana from her core to cast but used a bow to focus that mana and project it away from herself, giving her a longer range than an augmenter could normally manage.

Most augmenters eventually revealed an affinity for a specific element, with their augmentations taking on aspects of that element due to the abundance of elemental mana in their core. But Ellie's had stayed pure. She was the only nonelemental caster I knew. The mana used for her spells was entirely pure.

Closing my eyes again, I returned to the keystone realm. There was the bear, out of focus but clearly visible, pacing around in the darkness. Then the bear melted away, and a simple silhouette took its place. At first the silhouette was featureless, but Ellie slowly added more detail, giving it long hair, a little face, and distinct horns.

A girl…Sylvie.

I felt my throat constrict as her face came clear. Molded from the blurry mana, she looked uncomfortably similar to my last moments with her, like I was watching her dissolve all over again…

Sensing my focus slipping away, I pushed those old painful memories to the back of my mind, focusing entirely on the shape.

What am I supposed to be seeing, sensing?

The purpose of the keystone was to guide me toward insight over some principle of aether. The first keystone had led me to Aroa's Requiem, but the path to that understanding had been bizarre, almost nonsensical.

But that was the point, I thought. It was the journey that provided wisdom, not the keystone itself. *Less of an instruction manual, more a map.*

Sylvie's figure began to change again. It bloated out, mana particles rushing to it as the figure expanded, forming wings, a tail, and a long neck. Sylvie's draconic form.

While the end goal was a mystery, it seemed clear that the path involved watching the mana particles as they moved or reacted to the casting of a spell.

Although I couldn't be sure, I doubted that the djinn could see individual mana particles the way Realmheart had allowed me to. This keystone gave them that ability, which must have allowed them to then gain some additional insight.

But what could that be? And why can I sense Ellie's pure mana, but not elementally aligned mana?

The djinn's focus had been on learning about aether, not mana, so whatever the keystone's purpose, the insight it provided had to be related to aether. Caera had been able to see the mana with it, but simply seeing had not granted her any greater understanding, and I doubted it even could, since she had no affinity for aether.

Growing frustrated, I released my hold on the keystone realm and let my consciousness drift back into my body.

Ellie was trying to make the dragon's wings move but was having trouble with the complex motion. Her face was pinched in a frown of concentration.

I stayed still and silent, embracing the quiet peacefulness of my surroundings.

As a quadra-elemental mage with the ability to use Realmheart, at one time I had a better understanding of mana than just about any other mage in Dicathen. I didn't *need* to see it now to understand it. Although it wasn't physically in front of me, I could still picture the jagged energy of red fire

mana, the liquid grace of blue water mana, the sharp, cutting gusts of green air mana, and the heavy rolling of yellow earth mana.

The djinn may have needed the keystone to see and understand how mana particles moved and reacted to spells being cast, but I didn't.

Earth, air, water, fire…

My gaze jumped from the cavern walls to the steamy air to the warm pools. Mana was drawn to the physical elements it represented. This room was full of all four elements. Without a spell being cast, however, the atmospheric mana was dormant. I needed to agitate it.

"Ellie," I said, louder and more forcefully than I'd intended.

My sister jerked out of her highly concentrated state, and the dragon vanished. "Oh, darn."

"Never mind, I need you to try something else," I said in a rush. "Create shapes that interact with the elements in the room. Disrupt the water, stone, air…shoot it, whatever. Get creative."

Without waiting for a response, I dove back into the keystone.

After a moment, there was a flash, a beam like an arrow flying in the dark. Distantly, I heard the cracking of stone. In the keystone, I watched a ripple spread out from where the arrow had vanished, inky black but not formless.

Earth, I thought, watching the way the mana bumped up against itself like stones rolling down a hill.

"Again," I said.

This time, I watched the spot even more closely. The arrow appeared, flashed, then vanished.

Ellie shot arrow after arrow, and each impact set the atmospheric mana into brief motion. Then she made spinning blades to push the air, and finally spheres like cannonballs to hurl into the peaceful water.

But, although the tremors and waves and ripples made logical sense, it changed nothing about how I saw them. I tried picturing the disruptions within the keystone realm as the brightly colored particles they really were, anticipating how they would react to Ellie's spells.

I *understood* the mana, could see it even without seeing it. But…maybe that was part of the problem. I wasn't learning anything. There was no new insight here.

What am I missing?

I thought back to my childhood, how I had taught myself to be a quadra-elemental mage. And Xyrus Academy, learning to focus on my weakest attributes. Then Epheotus, and how I'd needed to entirely change how I looked at mana manipulation, inventing new techniques to adapt to the challenges I faced. And then I learned about aether.

Lady Myre had told me that aether was creation. It was like a cup, mana like water. Aether shaped mana. It controlled the forms mana could take. But I had already learned that the dragons' understanding of aether was limited. This simplistic comparison was flawed…but that didn't mean it couldn't be useful.

I attempted to channel aether through my body. It didn't work; my mind and body were too separate, too metaphysically distant. I tried again, attempting to reach for my physical form without losing my connection with the keystone realm. It was like trying to make my arms longer or force a bone to bend.

I needed to sense two things at once, hold two separate ideas in my mind at the same time. And slowly, very slowly, I began to feel the hard edges of the keystone in my hands, hear the trickling of the spring water flowing from one pool to the next, and feel my breath moving in and out of my lungs.

"El?" I asked, testing.

"Yeah, should I—oh! Are you…?"

"Still in here," I said, my mouth forming sluggishly around the words. "Going to try something…"

And then I *pushed*. I didn't try to form the aether, just expelled it from my core and body, sending a pulse of formless, harmless aetheric particles out into the atmosphere. I struggled to keep my senses open from both directions, feeling the aether moving through the room while also watching the invisible mana particles move inside the aether realm.

I lost track of both. Resisting the urge to leave the keystone realm in pure

frustration, I tried again, then again. I wasn't sure how long I kept trying, with Ellie continuing to disturb the atmospheric mana in whatever ways she could think up.

Slowly, two opposing pictures formed in my mind.

One was the shape of the aether. The way it moved based on a fusion of its will and my own, but regardless of the physical space around me. Then there was the mana tied to individual elements, dormant until agitated by Ellie's magic.

I understood how the aether moved, and I understood how the mana moved. No new insight to cultivate there. But where they interacted with each other…

The aether simultaneously contained and gave shape to the mana, and yet the mana continued to move exactly as expected of its nature.

Like a cognitive illusion, I realized. *A picture that is two things at once, with the negative space of one image creating the other.*

My perspective shifted. Suddenly I wasn't just sensing the aether, but the shape of the mana in between it. The keystone realm realigned itself to my new perspective, and, between one breath and the next, everything changed.

Where before I had seen only an endless field of black nothing, now the rough shape of the grotto was visible, painted in the colors of mana. Next to me, my sister glowed with it, all the elements being drawn in through her channels to be purified in her core.

The colors ran together, the scene disappearing into a spinning vortex of mana, with me at its center. Unlike the previous keystone, I didn't feel the scouring sensation in my mind. Instead, I felt warmth spreading across my physical body, while at the same time a window opened in my head, letting golden light bathe my innermost thoughts.

My eyes fluttered open.

Ellie was staring at me, no longer casting her spells. I sensed for the godrunes. They were there, dormant, waiting for aether to touch them, give them life and purpose. And there was a new one, still warm against my skin.

I pushed aether into it.

“Whoa,” Ellie breathed. “You’ve got glowing purple tattoos under your eyes. That’s so cool.”

As before, my mind was filled with knowledge. This new godrune had a name, a purpose, a history, but it felt incomplete. Unlike before, it was not my understanding that was incomplete, but the djinn’s. I instinctively understood that they had not taken this aether art to its full potential. I could do more with it.

And so I abandoned the name it had come with. As my vision shifted and the atmospheric mana suffusing the cave appeared all around me, I decided what *I* would call this godrune.

Realmheart.

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SURFACED ENMITY

ALDIR THYESTES

Lord Indrath's great hall was as full and loud as I remember it ever being. Representatives of all the great clans were present, but Lord Thyestes had brought an unusually large entourage, rivaling even the Indraths in number. The other clans mingled between the dragons and pantheons, but not freely. One only had to open their eyes to see how the political turmoil shaped the room.

The Eccleiah clan of the leviathan race had also brought a large delegation, and the leviathans carefully moved between Indrath and Thyestes, making sure to give both clans time and attention.

That was in contrast with the Mapellia clan, chief among the hamadryad race. Their alliance with the dragons was as old as the foundations of Mount Geolus, and they honored it unflinchingly, lingering among the dragons while giving the pantheons only perfunctory greetings.

The titans, on the other hand, had long been friends of the pantheons. Though they showed no outward signs of enmity toward the dragons, the members of the Grandus clan gravitated to my own. Conversation between my clan and theirs was open and accessible, whereas the few titans who spoke to dragons did so in a more formal manner.

There were few sylphs in attendance, as the carefree people did not enjoy subjecting themselves to such tensions. Lady Aerind had come herself, however, and the few of her clan to accompany her mingled carelessly between the other clans.

Even fewer were the phoenixes. Their antipathy toward the dragons was

deep-rooted and slow to burn, and the Avignis clan largely kept their people out of both politics and courtly turmoil. After their predecessors, the Asclepius clan, were removed from the Great Eight, it had been difficult for the Avignis clan to rebuild trust between the phoenixes and other races of Epheotus. Lord Avignis and his daughters kept to themselves amidst the frustration and anger of the pantheon warriors smoldering in the air.

As I scanned the great hall, my brother caught my eye. It was rare for Kordri to attend court, but as Taci's trainer, Lord Thyestes would have demanded his presence. The death of an asura—any asura, much less a pantheon warrior—at the hands of a lesser was unheard of. Our clan demanded answers.

"Ah, General Aldir."

Turning from my brother, I realized that Lord Eccleiah had appeared at my side. The leviathan was an elder of his long-lived race, nearly as old as Lord Indrath. Unlike the lord of dragons, Lord Eccleiah wore his age proudly. His pale skin was thoroughly wrinkled, and the ridges that ran along his temples had lightened from the deep-ocean blue of youth to a light, nearly transparent hue. A milky-white film covered his once sea-green eyes. Even of those with several working eyes, only few could see the world as clearly as he seemed to, however.

"An unpleasant setting for a pleasant meeting," he continued. "It's been at least a hundred years, I'm sure. Far too long. Please, allow me to extend my great sorrow for your clan's loss."

He held out a hand to me, palm down. Taking it gently in my own, I bowed and pressed my forehead to the cold skin on the back of his hand. "Thank you, my lord."

He smiled, deepening the wrinkles around his eyes and mouth. "Should Lord Indrath ever allow you even a moment's rest from your duties, you must visit our clan, Aldir. Zelyna still harbors feelings for you, I believe. She's settled down a bit now, you know. Not quite the firebrand she used to be."

I said nothing, and Lord Eccleiah's cheek trembled as he tried to suppress his amusement. "Well, can't be seen playing favorites between the clans. I suppose I'll have to find some dragon to talk with until Lord Indrath makes his appearance." He gave me a quick wink, turned, and melted

away into the crowd.

After my odd conversation with Lord Eccleiah, I kept to myself, exchanging simple greetings with a few dignitaries, but otherwise doing my best to avoid being pressed into conversation and staying to the rear of the crowd. There was a gnawing sort of guilt growing in me, and it sharpened each time I heard Taci's name. Although I had no way of knowing the truth, it was possible my actions had contributed to his death.

While I had hoped he would fail to wipe out Virion Eralith and his refugees, I had never imagined Taci would die in the effort. He was a pantheon. A youth, perhaps, but with decades of advanced training within the aether orb. Had he returned from his mission, he would have been welcomed back as an adult.

The white flames of Lord Indrath's throne flared, interrupting my thoughts. The myriad voices filling the great hall went silent in an instant.

Lord Kezess Indrath appeared before his throne, stepping through the flames. His perpetually youthful face was carefully impassive, lightly welcoming, and entirely controlled. When his purple eyes swept across the still, silent crowd, however, there was a predatory intensity to his gaze.

Indrath didn't speak until the silence had reached the point of discomfort. "Lords and Ladies. Greatest among your great clans. It is too rare that we meet in this way. You stand in the heart of my home, and I welcome you."

As one, the attending asuras all bowed. "Hail and welcome to his grace, Lord Indrath."

The ceremonial greeting carried a rough edge, drawn begrudgingly from the lips of my clansfolk. Though I was certain Lord Indrath noticed and kept a careful mental tally of all who replied without the expected vigor, his demeanor didn't change.

Once the last asura had stood, Indrath eased himself onto his throne, the white fire dancing harmlessly around him. "I have brought you all here because one of our own has been lost. We all understand how easy it is for lies and misinformation to spread among our people, which is why it is essential you know the truth of this unfortunate death."

Lord Thyestes stepped forward but did not immediately speak. Instead, he waited for Lord Indrath to address him.

Lord Indrath looked him in the eye but continued speaking. “As war with the Vritra clan creeps closer, pruning our relationships in Dicathen is ever more important. It was also an opportunity for me to see for myself how the young pantheon, Taci of Thyestes clan, handled himself on the battlefield.”

Lord Thyestes took a firm step forward, putting himself directly in line with the throne.

“The rumor has already spread that Taci was defeated in battle by the lessers,” Indrath continued gravely. “At best, this is a ridiculous falsehood born of fear. At worst, a cruel lie meant to disrupt relations between the clans.”

“And who would wish such a thing?” Lord Thyestes snapped, speaking out of turn. My clansfolk burst out with a low rumbling of support for our lord, and those present who were not already watching him carefully turned to stare.

Indrath’s face stayed cool and impassive as his attention settled back on Lord Thyestes. “Ademir. Go on then, speak. You clearly cannot contain your thoughts any longer.”

“Nor should I have to, your grace,” Lord Thyestes shot back.

The lord of the Thyestes clan, Ademir, was tall and lean, like most pantheons. His four front eyes stared fearlessly at Indrath. His long black hair was shaved along the sides, revealing two additional eyes, one on each side. These bright purple eyes tracked with a jittery quickness across the faces of the other asuras, no doubt scanning the room for support.

Lord Thyestes was in a difficult position. Our clan demanded answers and satisfaction, but if he pushed Indrath too far, the Thyestes clan could fall just as quickly as the Asclepius clan had. But pantheons were not easily cowed, and Ademir would find it difficult to back down from Kezess’s threats in front of his peers, a fact Kezess understood full well and would not hesitate to take advantage of. We were a warrior race, and we responded to threats with strength.

“Taci was a talented and promising young pantheon,” Ademir said, his words directed to the half of the great hall where the Thyestes pantheons had gathered. “I was unsurprised when Lord Indrath expressed interest in testing the boy. Taci had trained extensively within the aether orb with

Kordri, had studied alongside young dragons in this very castle, and was whispered to be a suitable heir to learn the forbidden World Eater technique, currently safeguarded by General Aldir."

A few eyes turned in my direction—most notably Lord Indrath's—but most of the hall remained fixated on Lord Thyestes.

"But this will never come to pass, because his future has been taken from him, and for what? Why have we been deprived of a son, a friend, a pantheon with thousands of years of grace, strength, and life remaining?" Ademir's eyes turned back on Kezess, who hadn't moved, not even the flicker of an eyelash. "Tell us, Your Grace. Explain this escalation. First you fail to destroy the outcast, Agrona Vritra, then you break our treaty with him by using the Thyestes clan's forbidden mana art, and now you lose a pantheon warrior to the lessers."

As Ademir spoke, his tone became harsher and sharper, and the force of his mana swelled until it distorted the air around him. "You must forgive us if some of your subjects have begun to question your judgment."

Raised voices crashed through the great hall like waves against a rocky shore, rising and falling, tumbling over one another as asura turned against asura.

"How *dare* you—"

"—not a justification for—"

"—removed from the Great Eight immediately—"

"—damned good question!"

A shadow fell over the hall, and the outpouring of Indrath's power stole the oxygen from the air, quenching the arguments like candle flames. Each asura in attendance was considered among the strongest of their clans, and yet we all flinched away from our lord, knees going weak, breath shuddering out of our lungs.

Lord Kezess Indrath didn't move. He didn't scowl or even frown. His eyes became a slightly darker shade of purple, perhaps, but that was the only outward sign of his displeasure.

"You forget yourselves," he said after a long moment. "We are asura. We do not squabble and yell like lessers."

Lord Thyestes' hands curled into tight fists, his own King's Force radiating around him, pushing back at Indrath's aura. But he kept his silence.

"It is unfortunate that you overrepresented Taci's abilities to me," Indrath continued. "Had you been more open, I could have sent another." Ademir's scowl deepened, but Indrath kept speaking. "For it wasn't a lack of martial prowess or control over mana that condemned Taci, but a lack of wisdom. He was not defeated by the lessers but tricked into destroying himself. There are no lessers in either Alacrya or Dicathen that pose a threat to us. *That* is the message you must take home to your clans."

"What a load of—"

"Enough," Indrath said, smothering Ademir's curse. "My decrees are not subject to discussion, even among the great clans." Indrath's gaze traveled through the room, and he finally withdrew his King's Force. "You are dismissed, for the moment. We will reconvene when tempers have calmed so that I am not forced to do something…*dramatic*."

The sudden dismissal after so short a meeting caught the room off guard, but I didn't wait for Indrath to repeat himself. Moving quickly, but not so quickly as to draw attention to myself, I was at the doors by the time the guards heaved them open. Both snapped into quick salutes as I moved past.

I took the first side hallway, then turned again, and then again, losing myself in the sprawling interior of the castle. Tempers among my clan were sure to be running hot, and I had no desire to be drawn into the indignant debates that were certain to follow such a heated conference.

I hadn't gone far, though, before I became aware of the steps shadowing my own. At the next corner, I took a careful look behind me, but whoever it was kept out of sight. *One of the guards?* I wondered. *Or perhaps Kordri, or some other member of my clan sent by Lord Thyestes to track me down.*

Despite my desire to stay away from the well-trafficked areas of the castle, I took the most direct route to the front gates, which stood wide open. A cool breeze blew in, carrying little eddies of cloudy fluff that dissolved almost immediately. The sun winked off the translucent, many-colored bridge that spanned the gap between the two peaks of Geolus.

I hesitated before stepping foot on that bridge.

“Where are you going, General Aldir?”

I resisted the urge to sigh deeply and turned to face the man who had been following me. “Windsom. I didn’t see you at the council.”

“I hardly stand out among so many asuran leaders,” he said, giving me a humorless smile. “You left very quickly.”

“I’ve decided to return home,” I said immediately, making up my mind that I would do so in the moment. “I will be away from the castle for some time.”

Windsom's brows rose. “And have you informed Lord Indrath of this leave of absence from your duties?”

I didn’t reply. We both knew full well I hadn’t.

“I have become aware of two small but interesting facts, Aldir, which is why I sought you out.” He gave me that smile again, and I felt an incomprehensible tremor run up my spine. Windsom was a dragon, but he’d spent his long life minding the lessers. He was no threat to me.

So why do I feel so threatened?

“When I returned for Taci, I discovered that the lessers’ sanctuary was empty, but a tomb had been left behind. A tomb for one of the Lances, who you were meant to have killed.”

I felt for the threads of mana that connected me to my weapon, Silverlight. “That is because I let them go,” I said slowly, watching for any hint of aggression from the dragon.

He inclined his head slightly. “I know. I appreciate your honesty, though I should expect nothing less.”

“And what is the second interesting fact?” I asked, unsure what game Windsom was playing.

“There was a certain amount of…carnage left at the lessers’ sanctuary,” he said, his nose wrinkling. “A large number of Alacryans were brutalized. Based on what I saw there, I am certain that Arthur Leywin has returned to Dicathen, and that it was he who killed Taci. Additionally, I believe Arthur to be the same person as this mysterious Grey who killed Scythe Cadell

Vritra at Agrona's Victoriad."

"You believe quite a lot," I said, crossing my arms and looking out over the edge of the mountaintop. There was nothing but an endless sea of clouds below.

Windsom took a step toward me. "Aldir, come with me to Lord Indrath. Throw yourself on his mercy, tell him what you've done." He paused as if weighing his words carefully. "Offer to go to Dicathen and complete your task. *Prove* that you can still be a leader among the asura."

"When did being a leader among the asura come to mean destroying lessers…people who once relied on us, called us their allies," I said, trying to sound musing, but my words came out hard even to my own ears.

Windsom waved a hand dismissively. "The lessers of Dicathen only exist because of Lord Indrath. We both know very well what he'll do if it becomes necessary to wipe them out and start over again. What is a handful of lesser lives when held up against the well-being of all Epheotus?"

Windsom's words slammed shut a gate in my mind. It blocked the way forward…or rather, the way back. This immediate and unthinking acceptance that Kezess could determine which lives had value and which did not, and that we were expected simply to be the tools of his will, was too much. I couldn't accept it.

"Anyone capable of labeling one group of lives as unimportant can just as easily make the same determination of another. How long until the dragons determine the phoenixes' lives do not matter, or the titans' or pantheons'." Windsom opened his mouth to respond, already wearing a condescending, dismissive smirk, but I quieted him with a pulse of my King's Force. "The asura have lost their way. We have been led astray by the corruption and selfishness of Kezess Indrath."

Windsom darkened. I saw the edges of his true form flicker around him, the alchemy of fury, fear, and frustration boiling into something only barely controlled. "You know what this will mean," he said through clenched teeth. "Do not expect that Lord Indrath will tolerate such seditious speech just because of your long service to him, Aldir."

"I hardly expect loyal service means anything at all to him," I answered, spinning on my heel and marching across the bridge.

The colors flared wherever my feet touched, and I wondered what Kezess was sensing. It hardly mattered. He would not make a scene here, now, not with Lord Thyestes and so many of my kin in the castle. No, he would wait until a more convenient time.

As I expected, nothing happened as I crossed the long bridge. I had hardly stepped off it when a figure stepped out from the shadows of the tree arch. I stopped, again reaching for Silverlight, but I did not summon her.

“A bit edgy, are we?”

I felt the tension ease from me. “Wren Kain. It’s been a while.”

The frail man looked as disheveled and emaciated as ever, hardly living up to the name of titan. His dingy hair hung down over his face, which was covered with uneven stubble. But I knew there was a steel-hard core to his outwardly feeble appearance.

“Lover’s quarrel?” he asked, looking past me to the castle gates. Windsom was no longer standing there.

I grunted, unamused. “Epheotus is changing.”

Wren chuckled and scratched his chin. “Is it, Aldir? Or is it you who has changed?”

I bent down and took up a handful of soil. It was dark and moist, full of potential. Full of life. I’d never noticed before. I hadn’t looked.

Maybe I *had* changed. But…I didn’t understand what that meant. If I wasn’t General Aldir, keeper of the World Eater technique, then who was I?

Wren wiggled his fingers, and the soil came alive in my hand. It shifted and ran together, forming a small wolf with dusty clouds around its neck and tail. “Did you know *that’s* the form Arthur’s acclorite manifested? Fascinating, huh? Heard from the boy lately?”

“Don’t bury your meaning with me, Wren,” I said tiredly. “What are you doing here?”

He tutted, rolling his eyes and crossing his arms as if I’d offended him. “Just because Lord Grandus didn’t see fit to invite me to the party doesn’t mean I wasn’t curious about what’s happening inside.”

The animated wolf in my hand melted back into soil, which I let trickle between my fingers. “Windsom believes Arthur killed Taci,” I confided, curious what Wren might think of that. “But Lord Indrath wants the great clans to assure everyone it was a fluke, a trick.”

Wren whistled, a low sound thick with disbelief. “What are you going to do?”

I straightened, careful of each word and movement. Wren had never been sycophantic in his service to Kezess, but this was a dangerous moment for both of us. “I believe my service to Lord Indrath has ended.”

Wren’s nose twitched. “You’ll go to Dicathen, then? To Arthur? Try to teach the lessers the way of the pantheon warrior?” He gave me a wry smirk. “So that maybe, in a hundred years, they’ll be slightly less incapable?”

I shook my head. “Nothing is certain at the moment.”

Wren tapped the side of his nose, giving me a knowing look. “You know, Aldir, I’d love to get a closer look at that weapon of Arthur’s…”

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LONG-WORN SHACKLES

ARTHUR LEYWIN

The violet markings of Realmheart burned hot against my skin as I focused on the godrune. Now that I could once again see and sense mana, I felt connected to the physical space around me in a way I hadn't since waking in the Relictombs.

The smell of sweat and ozone, the sight of mana particles rolling and tumbling out of Mica's core, the sound of Bairon's heavy breathing, and even the weight of my own body pushing down on the ground beneath me all wove into one intertwined tapestry of sensation.

I focused on the mana along Mica's arms as it rushed into the huge hammer she swung with both hands. The hammer thickened and hardened, swelling to become even more unnaturally large. The sound of thunder crashed and rolled through the cavern, and the hammer shattered, exploding into a million knifelike shards.

Mica rolled under a lightning spear as the stone shards all shivered to a stop in midair, turned, and hurtled back at her target. Crackling static jolted through the air, and the stones became magnetized, snapping to each other and veering off course. The few that managed to reach Bairon burst against his mana barrier.

Next to me, behind a layer of transparent ice that protected us from any stray spells, Varay shifted. Her eyes were half closed as she focused more on sensing the two sparring Lances' cores and the strength of their mana manipulation than the physical aspects of their fight. "Their cores both feel strong. Nearly replenished."

I bit my tongue. *It is true that they've nearly returned to their full strength, but…*

'Their full strength barely dented a toddler asura,' Regis cut in, looking up from where he lay in the corner, uninterested in the sparring.

The air in the room grew heavy as the gravity swelled. Going stiff, Bairon strained against the massive weight of his own body, which threatened to pull him to the ground. Sand was swirling up all around him and hardening into boulders that immediately flew in his direction.

Another thunderclap shook the training cave, lightning-attribute mana shivering and sparking in my Realmheart-enhanced vision.

The stones quivered but didn't break, their forms momentarily seeming somehow indefinite, and then they hit him. Instead of solid rock meant to crush and bludgeon, the stones exploded across Bairon like mud—or maybe quicksand—caking him from head to toe. Mica's core again thrummed with the release of mana, and the sand became stone, hardening around his body.

Bairon's eyes dilated, and the hair on his head stood on end.

A cloak of lightning coiled around him, and the crack of thunder shivered through the stone, causing it to burst apart before it could fully harden.

Lightning spread out like a web across the floor around his feet, creating many individual bolts that snapped up from the ground to destroy the pieces of stone that Mica tried to control, including the hammer forming again in her hand.

The currents of electricity—visible as streams of bright yellow mana—raced up Mica's arm, causing her fist to spasm and tighten around the hammer. Her eye went wide as her muscles were swiftly paralyzed by the overload of electrical energy. But even when she suddenly reversed gravity and sent Bairon plummeting up toward the ceiling, it wasn't enough to break his spell.

With Thunderclap Impulse active, Bairon was able to react with near-instant precision. He spun in the air, stabilized himself so that he was hovering upside down, and activated the lightning web burning across the floor.

Each individual tendril of electrical energy formed a small bolt and struck

out in a seemingly random direction, ricocheting off the walls and ceiling to create a chaotic maelstrom of lightning bolts filling the cave.

The mana felt so close, like I could almost touch it. The muscle memory was still there, and it twitched as I watched the fight, like a one-armed soldier trying to lift his missing arm to ward off a blow.

With a sigh, I glanced at Varay's conjured arm of ice. A thin but constant stream of deviant ice-attribute mana was trickling from her core into the arm, holding its form. If she could use mana to duplicate the effect of having a physical arm, was there a way that I, too, could replicate what I'd lost?

A haze of fine sand had risen to fill the cave, absorbing the electricity and nullifying Bairon's spell. A new hammer was growing in Mica's second hand, this one formed of dull iron. The lightning mana paralyzing her muscles was drawn out of her and into the metallic hammer. Bairon's hair fell flat, signaling the end of the Thunderclap Impulse spell, just as Mica hurled the lightning-infused chunk of iron at Bairon. At the same time, gravity flipped again, and this time he was slammed backward into the closest wall.

I focused on how the atmospheric aether reacted—or didn't react—to the mana. It seemed to ignore the mana completely, while at the same time always fitting into the space not occupied by mana. It was neither avoiding nor shaping the mana, not really. It was more accurate to think of the two forces as shaping each other, like a mountain stream following its banks after having formed the banks through erosion.

However, like the water and cup metaphor, this idea failed to properly explain the relationship between the two forces.

Pinned against the wall, Bairon couldn't react in time to avoid Mica's electrified metal hammer. It crashed into him, and he was lost in a cloud of dust and debris.

The visible mana particles faded away as my concentration on Realmheart gave out.

"Bairon?" Varay said, stepping out from behind the protective layer of transparent ice.

A dry cough came from the dust, then Bairon's silhouette appeared, hunched slightly. He straightened and cracked his neck as he strode back

out into the open. Behind him, the dust faded, revealing a hole in the cavern wall several feet deep. “Well fought, Lance Mica. I’m feeling nearly recovered. You seem to be as well.”

Mica flexed the arm that still held her oversized hammer. “Mica does feel much better, yes.”

The Lances had been strained to the point of backlash during their fight with Taci, with wounds that would leave a mark for the rest of their lives. Although the scabs around Mica’s eye had already fallen away to reveal shining scars beneath, the eye itself would never heal.

Varay’s arm of magical ice and the onyx stone resting heavily in Mica’s eye socket would stay with them as stark reminders of their near deaths, but for me, they were something else entirely.

The other four Lances together hadn’t been able to defeat Taci. Aya had sacrificed her life just to slow him down. And Taci was only a boy by asuran standards. How could I expect them to stand against the likes of Aldir or Kordri, much less Kezess and Agrona?

The truth was that we were preparing for a war against deities, but we’d already lost a war against men, and our most powerful mages not only hadn’t grown in strength, but *couldn’t.*

‘There is still Fate,’ Regis reminded me. *‘Maybe they wouldn’t have to fight if we went back to the Relictombs.’*

Or, by the time we came back, there might not be a world left to save, I thought, feeling a dark melancholy creeping to overtake my mood.

I turned back to the Lances and forced a smile onto my face. “So Bairon, how did Mica manage to beat you with only one eye?”

A scowl flashed across Bairon’s face, but it quickly transformed into a wry grin as he took in my expression. “Well, you know how grumpy she gets when you don’t let her win.”

Mica stamped her foot and crossed her arms, making her look more childlike than ever. “You *let* me win, did you? Maybe if you were more versatile, Bai, you wouldn’t have ended up buried ten feet into the wall.”

I chuckled and felt the sourness leaving me. Even one side of Varay’s lips quirked up in something that almost looked like a smile.

“I’m curious, though, what were you doing with the lightning tendrils while you were under the effects of Thunderclap Impulse?” I asked. “I couldn’t keep up with the micromovements while your reactions were so fast.”

Bairon’s head turned to the side slightly as he regarded me in surprise. “You noticed? But how? I—” He cut himself off with a disbelieving laugh. “Never mind, nothing you do surprises me anymore. As for your question, I can extend my senses out through the lightning-attribute mana when casting Thunderclap Impulse.”

“So you’ve even improved on my spell. Impressive.”

Mica snorted. “If you’re going to be a one-trick pony, it better be a good trick.”

“Perhaps your head has grown too big for your small body,” Bairon said, flexing his hands and making electricity jump between his fingers. “I think a rematch is necessary.”

“Actually,” Varay cut in, raising her brows at me, “I was hoping Arthur might agree to a bout with me. It’s been a very long time since we sparred. I know I speak for all three of us when I say that we’d like to get a closer look at your capabilities.”

I thought about this, then shook my head. Although I knew I needed to help the Lances grow stronger *somehow*, I didn’t think that sparring was the way. “Actually, I was just about to excuse myself. I’ve been waiting on Gideon for something, and I’d like to check on his progress.”

“Understood,” she replied. “I suppose I should check in with Lords Earthborn and Silvershale on the defensive alterations they are making to the city.” I could sense the mostly concealed hesitation in Varay’s voice. When I gave her a wry smile, she sighed. “Their bickering is tiresome.”

Chuckling, I said, “Well, good luck with that.” I gave the three Lances a small wave in farewell, then started down the long tunnel back to Vildorial, where I circumnavigated the city to arrive at the Earthborn Institute. Regis padded along silently behind me.

The gate into the school was guarded, but the dwarves there only watched warily as we passed by. The school’s carved-stone halls hummed with the constant rumble of machinery, folding in any noise Gideon’s lab may have made, and eventually, I had to ask for directions from a passing faculty

member to track him down.

This led me deep into the bowels of the school where the hallways were plain and unadorned, looking more like a prison than an educational institution. Heavy stone doors lined both sides of the hall at regular intervals on my right, while those on the left were much more spread out. I found what I was looking for halfway down the hall.

The door was propped partially open, a fact that probably had something to do with the dry heat and burning stench that was wafting out into the hall, Gideon's harsh voice coming along with it.

"Bah. Let's start from the beginning. Emily, have you been writing all this down?"

"Writing what down, Professor? We haven't covered anything new in hours," she said, her tone teasingly insubordinate.

"Don't call me that, girl, and just…write down everything I say."

"Yes sir," she answered, the rolling of her eyes practically audible from the hallway.

I slipped through the door and leaned against the frame but didn't announce my presence. Regis poked his head in beside me. *'It smells like burnt ass in here.'*

Gideon and Emily were standing next to a metal table draped with a ragged, scorched leather cover. Several lighting artifacts hung over the table, casting bright light down on several items that had been carefully laid out atop it.

"We know—"

"*Think*," Emily interrupted.

"—that the obsidian staff is the primary device used in what we have been told is the *bestowal ceremony*, a ritual using these artifacts to grant Alacryan mages *runes*—"

"Spellforms," Emily said.

"—but simply channeling mana into the staff does not cause an immediate reaction."

Resting lengthwise across the table was an obsidian staff, just like the one I'd seen used in Maerin Town during the bestowment. The gem at its head glittered green, yellow, red, and blue. Not visible to the naked eye, but clear as day to me, was the concentration of aetheric particles contained within the crystal.

Curious, I activated Realmheart.

Warmth flooded through my back, along my arms, and under my eyes as the godrune lit up. The world around me shifted as the mana became visible. Earth mana clung to the stone walls, floor, and ceiling. Eddies of wind-attribute mana were tossed around on the subtle currents that moved away from where fire mana blazed in a couple of low-burning forges built into one wall.

Emily tensed, and I could see the goosebumps forming on her arms from across the room. Slowly, she turned toward the door. "Arthur, what…?"

Gideon turned a second later. He stared at me, his head cocked slightly to one side. "You going to a party, kid?"

I smirked at the joke, but my focus was on the staff: densely packed mana particles gave it its glow, and even without being activated, it seemed to be drawing more mana toward itself in a slow trickle.

Mana clung to the other items on the table as well, but being able to sense this didn't tell me anything new, so I stopped channeling aether into the godrune. The mana particles faded away until they were once again invisible, and my ability to sense them cut out.

I blinked a couple of times as my eyes adjusted to the change in my vision. "So, it sounds like the research hasn't been very productive?"

Gideon and Emily exchanged a look, and Gideon scratched his half-regrown eyebrows. "Hard to put a puzzle together when you don't know what the hell it's supposed to look like," he grumbled, waving a hand at the artifacts. "Maybe if you would have graced us with your presence a bit sooner…"

"Well I'm here now," I said as I crossed the room to the table. "And I brought a research assistant." I gestured to Regis, who reared up to put his front paws on the table. "Understanding this technology is essential if we hope to match the Alacryans, much less stand against asuras."

“So you implied,” Gideon said wryly, his consternated gaze on the shadow wolf staring thoughtfully down at the artifacts. “I *think*”—he shot Emily a sharp look—“the runes woven into the ceremonial robes have something to do with activating the staff. Like a key. But there is a sequence to the runes that isn’t immediately obvious, and I don’t want to just blindly try things. Someone could get hurt, or worse, we might destroy the robes by accident.”

Emily’s brows rose as she considered her mentor. “Your priorities seem to be out of alignment,” she muttered.

“I don’t know, I think I agree with Professor No Brows,” Regis said offhandedly, eliciting a giggle from Emily. “The robes are definitely necessary.”

“Thanks, I think,” Gideon grumbled.

“Do your memories from Uto contain anything useful about the bestowal?” I asked.

Regis’s lupine brows knitted together as he struggled to parse the mix of thoughts and memories that had originally combined to give him consciousness. “Uto’d seen a hundred bestowals, usually higher-ranked officers or highbloods. But only the officials who actually perform the ceremony, and I suppose the Instillers and Vritra who designed the things, are taught the specifics.”

“And nothing in the book helped?” I asked Gideon.

Next to the ceremonial black robes rested a thick, well-worn tome. Gideon reached out and opened it to a random page. “It’s a catalog of the many marks, emblems, et cetera that have been handed down by this staff in particular. Fascinating, but no help in *using* the thing.”

“I guess it was too much to hope it came with an instruction manual,” I said.

Regis’s snout wrinkled. “I think you’re trying to be funny, but that would sort of defeat the purpose of having a super-secret ritual.”

“Oh, good, he insults you too,” Gideon said, giving Regis an amused look. “I was worried it was all just you pantomiming through your summons, and I was wondering what I’d done wrong.”

“I’m not being insulting,” Regis replied defensively. “I just call it like it is.”

Focus, I thought to Regis, then turned my attention back to the artifacts.

The plain black dimension ring given to me by Alaric was also on the table. A necklace of small beads had been arranged in a coiling pile between the ring and the book. The beads were a dull yellowish white, and I immediately thought they looked like bone.

“They are,” Regis said seriously, the flames of his mane writhing in agitation. “The carved bones of djinn whose remains were stolen from the Relictombs.”

I carefully scooped up the artifact and let the beads tumble through my fingers. Faint grooves were barely visible, distorting the surface of the smooth bone. I squinted and pushed aether into my eyes. Although most of it flowed in the direction I indicated, some of the aether slipped away, drawn toward the necklace.

I thought I understood.

“This technology must have been co-opted from the djinn—ancient mages—and requires some small ability to channel aether,” I said, rolling a bead around between my fingers.

“I don’t follow,” Emily said, looking from me to Gideon.

I set the necklace carefully back on the table.

Regis leaned down and sniffed at the old bone. “Most of Alacrya’s technological advancements have come from the Vritra’s research into this endless, monster-filled dungeon called the Relictombs. Half tomb, half creepy carnival, but full repository of ancient knowledge, you know? But the djinn mostly worked their magic with aether, which the Alacryans can’t use. These dead-djinn beads attract aether.”

“Which must simulate the capacity for direct manipulation,” Gideon suggested. He grabbed the robes and shook them out, then began tracing the runes embroidered into the interior lining with the tip of his finger. “I’m not entirely fluent, and the runes are complex, but I believe the robe serves a similar purpose, only for mana.”

I tugged down a corner of the fabric to get a better look. “You’re right. I

bet these robes allow for channeling all four types of elemental mana. Not in a quadra-elemental spellcaster sort of way, but enough—in conjunction with the necklace—to activate a device that requires earth, air, fire, water, and aether to properly use."

Gideon tapped his fingers on the table. "It seems unnecessarily convoluted."

"But maybe that's purposeful," Emily suggested, her face brightening. "I mean, think about it. If magical strength were as simple as waving around an artifact"—she pointed to the staff—"then whoever controls this bestowment controls *everything*."

"And lesson one of megalomaniac studies is that they don't like to share power," Regis replied.

I picked up Regis's train of thought. "The bestowals allow Agrona to create mages and enhance the purity of their cores with little effort, but the same technology would allow, for example, one of his Sovereigns to do the same in order to challenge him."

Gideon let out a thoughtful hum and leaned over the table, staring down at the staff. "By controlling who understands how the pieces fit together and limiting access to the secondary artifacts, you maintain control of the process."

"Although…" Emily bit her lip hesitantly. "If the artifacts can simply be stolen…"

"Oh, there are definitely secondary means of protection," Regis said, hopping down from the table. "Carefully manufactured ignorance is only one part of it. The threat of a horrifying death alone is enough for most. But I'd bet my horns there is some kind of ward or trap woven into all this technology for anyone who *does* try to steal it and use it against Agrona."

We were all silent for a moment as we considered this thought.

Then the silence shattered as an explosion shook the walls and brought down trails of dust from the ceiling.

Regis's fiery mane bristled as we both turned toward the door. Orange-gray smoke was filling the hall outside.

Gideon chuckled. "Don't worry, that's just the new experiments I've been

trying to show you."

Without waiting for me to acknowledge his words, Gideon headed out into the hall and toward the source of the blast. Emily shrugged and gestured for us to follow. Regis and I exchanged a look, hesitant to leave the robe and the necklace given the implications we just unlocked, but followed Emily after she locked the lab door behind us.

Not far down the hall, thick red-orange smoke was pouring out of a set of heavy stone doors. Just inside, two dwarven mages were using what looked like scorched cloaks to wave the worst of the smoke away.

They blanched when they noticed Gideon leaning against the doorframe. "Eh, sorry, sir, a spark from one of the weapons ended up in a beaker of niter spirits."

Gideon was wearing a wide grin, and he took a deep breath of the noxious smoke that was starting to clear. "You can't make an omelet without causing a few explosions!"

Regis gave a throaty chuckle. "You know, I'm starting to like this guy."

Emily sagged tiredly. "Great. It's like there are two of them…"

The old inventor waved us into the room, then practically jogged through the lab to a second set of large doors. "The prototypes aren't completely stable, as you can no doubt see, but I really think you'll like what we've been doing."

He yanked the doors open, revealing a much larger chamber. It looked like a war zone. The bare stone walls were scorched black in a hundred places. Along one wall, a scarred metal table held a handful of strange-looking devices.

"Ta-da!" Gideon held out his arms, beaming at the arsenal.

I stepped up to the table and looked down at a series of long, tubular devices that looked vaguely like a cross between an ancient musket and a modern rocket launcher from my old world. Only these were also inscribed with mana-channeling runes. "Are these what I think they are?"

"If you think they are weapons capable of converting energy from dwarven fire salts into destructive blasts capable of incinerating even yellow-core mages, then yes, absolutely," Gideon said, rubbing his hands

together and grinning like some storybook evil genius.

“Theoretically,” Emily mumbled, eyeing the weapons with clear distaste.

“I call them rune cannons,” Gideon added, oblivious to Emily’s hostility.

“I want one,” Regis said immediately, his tongue lolling from his mouth. “No, make that two. Quick, Arthur, strap them to my back.”

“They’re not perfected yet, but when they are—”

“By ‘not perfected’ he means they’re unstable and still require the presence of mages capable of channeling both fire and wind,” Emily pointed out. “They’re difficult to use and incredibly dangerous—”

“Well that’s entirely the point, isn’t it?” Gideon snapped, glaring at his assistant. “And those bestowal robes actually gave me an idea how we could use mana crystals and focusing runes to fix the mage problem. The idea is that, with the right training, anyone could use them.”

Although I wanted to—planned to—win this war, I understood much better than Gideon the wide-ranging implications of his invention, as well as the barriers to its use. My hesitation must have shown on my face, because Gideon’s excitement faded away. “What is it?”

I’d decided a long time ago not to be the filter through which Dicathian technology was either held back or escalated, but I couldn’t hold my tongue. “I was just thinking of the *Dicatheous*.”

Emily crossed her arms and shot Gideon a vindicated look. “See?”

He pouted and kicked the floor with his toe. “Like I didn’t consider that myself? With the appropriate safeguards—”

“What about training?” I asked, cutting him off. “Manufacturing? Distribution? You’re talking about entirely changing the way Dicathen approaches warfare.”

Gideon leaned against the table and began to tap his fingers on its surface. “Yes, yes, but to balance the power dynamic between Dicathen and Alacrya, as well as mages and non-mages, a large-scale change is both necessary and warranted, isn’t it?”

“It does seem a little hypocritical to worry about putting weapons into the hands of non-mages in a world where single beings are capable of wiping

out entire countries," Regis added.

"Exactly," Gideon said, rapping hard on the tabletop.

I regarded the rune cannons, considering both Regis's and Gideon's words. Perhaps there was a way to utilize Gideon's discoveries without handing untrained soldiers weapons that might literally blow up in their—our—faces.

"Tell me more," I said. "Especially about the fire salts."

The eccentric inventor launched into a rapid-fire explanation of his many discoveries and many, many experiments that led him to this invention, and as he talked, an idea grew in my mind.

Gideon was right, though. We did need a way to make our non-mage soldiers more effective.

As I opened my mouth to explain the idea, another explosion shook the underground tunnels—this one larger and farther away. I shot Gideon a questioning look.

He turned from me to Emily and then back. His face had gone pale. "That wasn't me."

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DEFENDING VILDORIAL

VARAY AURAE

The shifting earth of the battle map rotated around under the careful control of three dwarven mages working in concert. The three-dimensional blueprint showed the tunnels and egress points in and around Vildorial in detail, the image of it held in the dwarven tacticians' minds. In the short time since our arrival and ouster of the Alacryan forces, most of the tunnels had already been diverted or capped off, isolating the Darvish capital from the larger underground network that connected it with other dwarven cities.

"Just a handful of tunnels remain open to the north of the city, here." Carnelian Earthborn, Mica's father, pointed to a section of small tunnels that laced into several much larger thoroughfares. "But they'll be closed off in the next of couple hours. All mining and farming operations outside of the city have been halted, and all civilians have been brought into the city."

"Fast work," I said appreciatively. "And the city gates?" I asked, turning to Daglun Silvershale, who had been given charge of the work within the great cavern itself.

"The city's sealed up tighter than a rockworm's sphincter," he confirmed, nodding grimly. "And Lodenhold has been opened up to provide shelter for a few thousand, at least."

I bit my tongue. This had been a part of the plan I hadn't agreed with, but the dwarvish lords had insisted that the highest-ranking dwarves—themselves, in other words—and their families be evacuated to Lodenhold.

Carnelian himself had wheedled a promise out of Mica that she would stand guard over the estate.

Despite this frustrating waste of resources, I had been forced to acknowledge that the Lances were not in charge of the dwarves and had no right, other than that provided by our power and prowess, to give orders or make proclamations. We had already agreed that the Lances would not force control away from the lords in some kind of authoritarian military coup.

There had been enough infighting already, and we needed to focus on the Alacryans. The dwarven people had a lot of soul-searching to do when this war was over. Again and again, their leaders had failed them. If the people wanted the Lances' help to rectify that after the war, I would be more than happy to acquiesce, but we had to survive the oncoming storm before we could begin to clean up the mess that was our own house.

However, I didn't try to hide my contempt for their plan as I met Lord Silvershale's eye. "And fortifications to the other city structures, as I requested?"

He cleared his throat. "Ongoing, Lance."

Carnelian stepped in with a grim smile. "A squad of mages from the Earthmovers Guild can be reassigned from the tunnels into the city to strengthen fortifications."

Silvershale tugged at the braids of his beard, and he looked like he wanted to argue, but eventually seemed to think better of it, deflating slightly. "Aye, we could use the assistance."

If the Alacryans attacked the city, they would have to blast their way in. This placed the many dwarves whose homes were built into the walls of the cavern directly in harm's way, and stones dislodged from the cave's ceiling would have the velocity of catapult stones by the time they reached the lower levels, easily demolishing unfortified structures. Simply instructing people to shelter in place wasn't enough. Not nearly.

"There is no telling how long we'll have to prepare," I reminded the two lords. "We've bitten the Alacryans' hand, but somewhere, that hand is curling into a fist to strike back."

As if conjured into reality by the weight of my words, an ominous rumbling shook the foundations of the Earthborn Institute, sending tremors

up through the soles of my boots.

Carnelian rushed to the door of the chamber and looked out into the hall. Panicked voices echoed through the school. The three-dimensional map crumbled back into dust as the mages turned to their lords for direction.

“Defensive positions,” I said immediately. “Get a squad of mages to those northern tunnels to finish closing them off.”

“They’ll be right in the line of fire if the Alacryans come from the north,” Carnelian said, his tone hesitant and lightly questioning, as if asking for confirmation.

“And our defenses are breached before the battle even begins if those tunnels are not sealed,” I replied, fully understanding the risks. This was hardly the first time I had sent soldiers to what could very well be their deaths. “And send up the alarm. People need to take shelter wherever they can.”

Waiting only long enough to see the two lords’ sharp nods of understanding, I wheeled around and flew out of the room, along a series of square tunnels, and out through the front gates of the Earthborn Institute.

Mica flew up from some lower level, the black gem in her eye socket giving her a menacing look as she glared through the stone walls in the direction of the rumbling. “Someone is opening the blocked tunnels…or trying to. They must have set off one of the stone-sheath traps.”

The dwarves were, unsurprisingly, quite adept at hiding all manner of devious traps within the tunnels of their home. Even if the Alacryans had dwarves among their forces, they would find it difficult to brute-force their way through the many obstacles the people of Vildorial had erected around the city.

The approach of a powerful aura made Mica and me turn in unison, but it was only Arthur appearing from the Earthborn Institute’s gates. As he strode purposefully toward us, I couldn’t help but stare at him, my eyes traveling slowly across his features as I tried, again, to match this man to the sixteen-year-old boy he had once been.

His wheat-blond hair was set waving by the speed of his own movement, hanging down around a face that could have been chiseled from stone, any youthful softness erased by the trials of this war. The most startling,

though, were his eyes. Those golden orbs burned like the sun, his gaze carrying a physical warmth, a raw and indefinable power, whenever it fell on me. His sudden presence conjured goosebumps along the backs of my arms and neck, uncomfortably reminding me of how I'd felt in the presence of General Aldir.

Small. Insubstantial. Without purpose.

"What's the situation?" Arthur asked, stopping next to me.

I gave myself a mental shake before answering. "Movement in the tunnels. No word from the scouts yet, but some of our traps have been set off. The Alacryans are coming."

"Then let's get ready for them," Arthur answered, his tone unwavering.

After the hurried rush of preparation, Vildorial fell into a tense, quivering stillness. I had ensured the defensive forces were moving into position as directed, then fallen back to a remote curve of the highway that ringed the city so that I could see the entire cavern at once. Watching. Waiting. But there was no sign of the Alacryans. Not yet.

An approaching mana signature drew my gaze upward, and I watched as Mica flew across the open expanse to land next to me.

"The lords and their families, as well as a few select…important residents, have been seen safely to the palace," Mica said, her cheeks red with clear embarrassment. "Mica…I mean, I'll be, um, guarding the palace. Is there anything you need before I…?"

I shook my head, trying not to target my irritation at her. "The dwarven forces have been posted around the city at the most likely points of entry should the Alacryans breach the cavern. Bairon and I will rotate between these forces."

"Has the scouting party returned?"

Again, I shook my head. We'd sent a dozen elite mages, all highly capable of earth-attribute manipulation, out into the eastern tunnels to investigate the source of the original disturbance, but they'd been missing for hours.

Almost as if he had heard our wondering, the air thrummed, and Bairon appeared, flying at speed. A cloud of dust burst from the ground at the force of his landing. “A handful of mages just returned from the northern tunnels,” he was saying before the dust had cleared. “Less than a quarter of the mages sent to close them.”

“What happened?” Mica said, her agitation setting the stones beneath my feet vibrating.

“They claim they were attacked by shadows.” Bairon’s voice was low and cut through with an edge of superstition. “And then the corpses of their own dead.”

This proclamation was met with a moment of silence.

Then, “Are you fucking kidding me?”

“What kind of magic could do such a thing?” I asked, ignoring Mica’s foul language.

“None that I’ve ever encountered before,” Bairon said ominously.

I clenched my ice-fist and let soothing mana flow through me, cooling my nerves. “Did they succeed in closing off the tunnels before the attack?”

Bairon floated up into the air, a gust of wind rippling across him as electricity arced over his armor. “They did, though not as thoroughly as should have been done. It may not hold, especially if the enemy is already there.”

“Bairon, see that the wards are in place over the last two entrances. Mica, to your duties.”

The other Lances both gave me grim solutes, then they were off, leaving me alone. Dwarves scurried like ants below, hurrying to whatever safe haven they’d arranged for themselves. Most of the elven refugees had been taken to the Earthborn Institute, while our strongest mages—the Glayders, Twin Horns, and surviving guards—had joined in the defense throughout the cavern.

I wondered idly where Virion was holed up. He had been absent from most of the preparatory meetings, and I hadn’t seen him at all in the last day. Though my blood oath had been sworn to the Glayders, Virion had been our commander during the peak of the war, and I had great respect for the

man. Watching him fade away caused a slow-moving, glacial ache that I wasn't prepared to navigate at the moment.

A flash of purple light cut through my thoughts, and I took a quick step back before realizing that it was Arthur. "I will never get used to that," I muttered, chagrined.

Arthur's stoic features were carved down into a slight frown. "Have you seen my mother or sister?" he asked without preamble. "They aren't with the refugees at the Earthborn Institute." Then, looking slightly embarrassed as he rubbed the back of his neck, he added, "I just wanted to make sure they were someplace safe before—"

"You don't have to explain yourself to me," I said, saving him from explaining further. "And yes, to set your mind at ease, I did see your sister and the bear leading your mother to the highest level earlier, toward the palace. And"—a tiny smirk forced its way across my lips despite myself—"I *may* have overheard Eleanor berating Alice about how the palace would be the safest place for her, considering Lance Mica will be guarding it."

The hardness of Arthur's features relaxed, and he let out a sigh of relief. "Oh. Good. I was…worried she might run off into battle again."

I cleared my throat, then turned my attention back to the movement below. "I hate this waiting."

Arthur flashed me a smirk that very much reminded me of the boy he'd once been. "Is the unflappable General Varay, perhaps, slightly flapped?"

I laughed, caught off guard by his teasing. "I shouldn't be. After all, we have the mighty Lance Godspell present to protect us."

Arthur's smile faltered, twitching into something more wry and, I thought, even slightly bitter. "A title I'm not sure I ever earned, Lance Zero."

I hadn't expected such self-deprecation and had to take a moment to consider a response. It was easy to forget that Arthur was still just a boy, really, no older than perhaps nineteen or twenty. Although he had tremendous power—more than I could safely wrap my head around—he had been subjected to horrible trials and great pain both before and during this war.

But then, perhaps that is what makes a Lance, I thought before

immediately cutting myself off and returning my mind to the conversation at hand.

"If not that one, then maybe another? I've heard some of the sanctuary survivors calling you Godkiller…"

Arthur snorted in disbelief. "I wouldn't exactly—"

A piercing static hum vibrated through the air, making my ears ring uncomfortably. "What in the—"

"People of Vildorial," a magically magnified voice announced, resounding from every surface at once, folding in and over and through itself like a wave striking and then receding from the face of a cliff.

"Lyra Dreide," I hissed, searching the cavern for her mana signature.

"*Please listen carefully to what I have to say*," the voice pleaded gravely. *"You have committed a most unfortunate error in fighting back against the Alacryan soldiers in your midst. By aligning yourself with the rebels known as Lances, you have angered High Sovereign Agrona."*

She let these words bowl over each other, echoing round and round within the great cavern. *"But the Lord of the Vritra is not without mercy. He knows that many of you feel as if you have no choice. He does not blame you for your confusion, your lack of courage. You will be offered a second chance at a life in his new Dicathen, so long as you simply don't fight back."*

Arthur cursed. "More likely, he'll kill everyone in this city to make sure the rest stay in line, if we let him."

"We won't," I assured him. "We've already defeated the retainer once. She can't hope to stand against you in combat."

"Please, people of Vildorial. As your regent, I do not wish to see you slaughtered…but I will ensure all who stand against High Sovereign Agrona are appropriately punished."

Her words stuck grotesquely to the insides of my ear. "Awful creature," I muttered, shaking my head as if I could dislodge the voice.

"Generals!" a hoarse voice puffed. I turned to see a stocky dwarf sprinting furiously in our direction. "The—the…" He coughed, choking on his own tongue as he struggled to form the words without enough breath in his

lungs.

Arthur vanished and reappeared at the man's side, clad in dancing purple lightning. "What is it?"

"The…portal!" he gasped out, coming to a stop with his hands on his knees. "A group of dwarves…took it—reactivated it."

I met Arthur's eye, my mind spinning. "If they're drawing our attention to the outskirts…"

"Then their strongest force is likely coming through the portal," Arthur finished for me. I watched as his unyielding gaze swept across the cavern, lingering on the palace where his family was. Then something clicked into place in his expression. "I'll hold off whatever forces come through the portal, destroy it if I have to. Can you and the others—"

"Of course," I answered firmly, drawing myself up to my full height. "I'm done losing battles, Arthur."

His jaw tightened, and then he was gone, leaving nothing behind but the purple-white afterimage of a bolt of lightning.

"Sh-should we gather reinforcements to guard the tunnel mouth in case any of the attackers escape Lance Godspell?" the man asked, stumbling over his words.

"No," I said, my eyes still on the place where Arthur had vanished. "We need the resources elsewhere. If this enemy can get past General Arthur, then we are lost in any case."

The dwarf, shaken and slightly pale, saluted. "Yes, General." Then he was off again, huffing back down the wide spiral of the highway.

I was looking from sealed entrance to sealed entrance, sensing for any mana signatures, trying to guess which direction they would come from, when my vision flickered strangely, and I had to hold out a hand to steady myself. Screams of complete and utter terror trembled up to me from the lower levels, thousands of voices so piercing they cut through rock and earth to fill up the cavern.

I watched, horrified and paralyzed, as a black scythe of energy slashed through several buildings, collapsing them on the civilians huddled inside. The screams only grew louder.

“No,” I breathed out in disbelief. How had the Alacryans gotten inside the city?

Stepping forward, I plummeted off the edge of the highway and toward the commotion below. The light changed again, like a shadow crossing over me from above, and I wobbled midflight. Pressure stabbed at my temples, white-hot pain bleeding in behind my eyes, making the world go dark…

At the last instant, I pulled up, but I still struck the ground with enough force to shatter the paving stones. Nearby, the frame of a partially collapsed house shifted and fell in on itself.

Down here, the screams were louder still.

Where is everyone? The dwarven forces? Bairon? Who is making all that noise?

I spun around, searching frantically for any signs of life. But it was just the voices. Screaming, screaming…and there were words in the howls of pain.

I sucked in a choked breath that caught in my throat.

“You! Your fault!” the screams said. “You could have protected us! Saved us!”

“Why?” other voices pleaded through their piteous dying moans. “Why didn’t you make sure we would be safe?”

“You saved the lords and left us to die! You should have done more!”

My pulse quickened, and a sense of dread seemed to steal the air from my lungs.

A cold, bitter voice sounded in my head, cutting through all the other noise. *You can hide your fear and self-doubt from the rest of the world, but not from yourself. Put on your ice-queen mask and take shelter behind your own inadequate power, but when the frost melts, the real you will always be just under the surface.*

I closed my eyes hard, squeezing until I saw snowflakes glittering in bright rainbow light. Deep breath in, long, steady breath out. A half-seen shadow writhed just at the edges of my vision.

You can never escape what you truly are. Frightened, lonely, and weak. Even the strength that made you a Lance isn’t your own. You couldn’t save

Alea or King and Queen Glayder or Aya. You lost the war, and soon everyone you know will be dead. Just lie down and die, coward.

My eyes snapped open. I'd heard these words before. Whispered them to myself in the dead of night in our dark, hopeless cave in the Beast Glades after we'd been defeated and sent into hiding. When I'd watched King and Queen Glayder continually succumb to their own weakness and selfishness, I'd heard these words in my plush rooms in their castle. And I'd heard them when the Scythe, Cadell, had sneered down on me, his red eyes burning with disdain, just before he'd swatted me like a fly.

I focused on shielding my core at the same time as I gathered mana into my hand. The shadows shifted at the edge of my vision. An ice-spike flew.

The world twisted sickeningly, then snapped back into place. The shadows vanished, and the reality of my situation came surging in.

I was on my knees in a crater at the center of the city's lowest floor. Several buildings around me had collapsed, and dozens of people were huddled in corners and behind whatever meager protection they could find. Bulging, terrified eyes stared not at me, but a woman standing at the edge of the crater staring down.

She lifted a hand to her neck and wiped away a thin trickle of blood where my spell had wounded her, then licked the blood from her thumb. "Given Cadell's stories about how pathetic you Lances were in the war, I'm surprised you were able to break through even part of my illusions."

Dark purple hair flowed down over her shoulders and framed the pale gray skin of her face. Her eyes were colorless in the gloomy cavern light, two black coals set in her expressionless face. White and gray robes, fit tight to her wispy frame, were hung with silver cord, and from these cords dangled gray-yellow lumps that could only be dozens of vertebrae.

Her expressionless mask didn't change as she followed my gaze to the chunks of bone. "Macabre, I know. But each represents a life, a story. Some even carry the faint aura of the previous owner's mana. Yours will go here," she said, tapping a cord that ran from beneath her ribs and across her body to her opposite hip.

"You're trying to wear me down by playing on my worst fears, but something like this…" I paused, my mouth suddenly dry. "I see and hear worse whenever I close my eyes, Scythe."

She nodded as I stood to my full height. “I am here because you Lances have scurried around in the dark and avoided this fight for too long.”

“Rich of you to accuse us of cowardice,” I said, fighting to keep my voice even. “Where have you been during this war? Safe at home, hiding behind the Vritra clan’s skirts.”

The Scythe did not bat an eyelash, only looked off to our right.

There was a crash of stone and the head of a huge hammer exploded through the wall of a half-fallen building. I tensed, ready to attack alongside Mica, but then I saw her.

The dwarven Lance scrambled through the hole she’d made, her good eye huge and shining like the moon reflected in the surface of a lake. Her pale face was smeared with dirt and blood, and she was swinging the hammer around her in short, sharp jerking motions. Several civilians scrambled away, crying in fright.

“No, Olfred, stop! M-Mica is sorry! Please…”

Her plea choked off, and she flipped the hammer around and smashed it into the floor. The stone gave out, and she tumbled into the chasm she’d made with a scream of absolute terror.

“Mica!” I lunged up the side of the crater, prepared to hurl myself into the chasm after her, but the light flickered sickeningly, and when it came back she was gone, along with the hole she’d tumbled through.

A harsh growl emitted unbidden from the back of my throat, and I sent blades of ice hurtling at the Scythe. They passed harmlessly around and through her to shatter against hard rock. “Where is she? What are you doing to her?” I demanded, conjuring a new arsenal but not wasting my energy in attacking again.

I needed to figure out what this Scythe’s power was and how to defend against it.

“The dwarf has a staggeringly complex labyrinth of inner demons to navigate,” she said, wiggling her fingers. When she did so, I could just hear the echo of Mica’s voice, like it was seeping up through the solid floor, but I couldn’t make out the words. “You, on the other hand, are quite simple, really. Boring. Cliché.”

I felt the white-hot pain behind my eyes again. Reaching inward, I found the cold comfort of my power waiting for me. Ice began to form along my skin, racing from my sternum up over my shoulders and down my legs, finally enveloping my head. The touch of it soothed the burning and dimmed the Scythe's power and voice.

"Get out of my head, witch."

Throwing out both hands, I sent the array of spikes and blades hurtling at her. A black shadow slashed the air, and the projectiles exploded. The Scythe took a step back, her form rippling as she did so, splitting into three images. For one hideous moment, the figures seemed to be several people at once, and then they solidified. In the middle, Lord Glayder looked down at me disapprovingly. He seemed taller and stronger, but his look of cold disapproval was as bitter and sharp as it ever had been. To one side, Alea Triscan was glaring at me out of ruined, empty eye-sockets, her legless body hanging in the air like some horrible mannequin. To Glayder's other side…Aya. My longtime friend and companion had a gaping hole where her core should have been.

"You were supposed to be the strongest of us," the three said in unison, their voices bleeding together into a tinny, unrecognizable cacophony. "But you failed us all." Alea's one remaining arm rose.

Twenty feet to my left, there was a rush of wind. Four dwarves, huddled behind an overturned trolley, were lifted screaming into the air. Their wild eyes turned to me for a single devastating moment, then they burst into red mist as slashes of black wind erased them from existence.

I ground my teeth in impotent fury, then threw out my hands to wrap the remaining survivors in thick barriers of ice.

"You can't protect them," the blended voices said again. "How many were there, just like us? How many have you failed, how many have you sent to their deaths?"

Something burst up from the ground between my feet and grabbed hold of my ankle. I looked down in horror as more and more hands clawed free of the earth, reaching for me. I tried to fly upward, but the grip held, keeping me tethered. Then the heads were free, and I saw a dozen dwarves, recently dead, their flesh pale and torn, their eyes sightless and wounds bloodless.

Squirming horror threatened to rip my last meal from my guts, but I couldn't turn away.

"You ordered us into the tunnels knowing we'd die," one dwarf moaned around a gray lifeless tongue.

"Join us," another grunted, baring her teeth and brandishing a mud-caked ax. "It's only fair, Lance."

The ax swung, but I lacked the wherewithal to even try to block it. When it hit the ice around me, the shaft snapped and the head went tumbling away, leaving a shallow chip in my armor.

Unlike the images of King Glayder, Alea, and Aya, the ax wasn't an illusion. She was animating the corpses of our dead and using them against us…

"I'm sorry," I muttered, then let out a deep breath.

Frosty mist roiled over and through the walking corpses, freezing solid where it touched their skin and cocooning them in shells of ice. I yanked my ankle free of the murderous corpse still gripping it. The dead hand shattered.

"Your tricks are stale," I ground out, doing my best to ignore the illusions as I searched for some sign of the real Scythe. "The others were more straightforward. They knew how to stand and fight!" I forced a sarcastic smirk onto my face. "Have the rest of you gotten cold feet since one of your own was butchered?"

I lifted an arm just in time to deflect a line of dark wind, then watched as the black line went through the ice cladding my body and my arm beneath it, which clattered to the broken stone tiles and shattered.

Shadows coalesced in front of me, forming the pale, purple-haired Scythe. The back of her clawed hand caved in the ice around my chest and sent me hurtling backward. I felt myself glance off one of the ice barriers protecting a group of huddled dwarves, then lost all sense of up and down as my body bounced along the ground like a skipped stone.

In the distance, I could hear the melded laughter of Aya, Alea, and King Glayder fading away.

She seemed to float as she approached, her dark eyes hellish voids that

threatened to consume me. “This is over. My sister will have finished your Thunderlord already, and the dwarf will soon succumb to my power.” The barest hint of a smile turned up the corners of her lips for the first time. “And if you think your guardian angel with the golden eyes will sweep in to save you, I’m afraid you are so very, very wrong.”

I pulled myself up out of the dust and brushed off my clothes, then stared straight into her dead eyes. “No reason to keep spitting pointless barbs at one another then, is there?”

The ground beneath the Scythe exploded upward as the head of a dragon formed entirely of deep-blue ice ripped through the stone tiles. The huge jaws snapped shut around the Scythe, lifting her up into the air as the construct clawed its way from beneath the earth. Inside its belly, stunned and nearly unconscious, was Mica.

Black lines of stabbing wind pierced the dragon’s skull, but I reformed the ice before it could shatter.

The dragon kicked off the ground and began flying up into the air, while at the same time the pocket of air containing Mica slid lower through its body, eventually expelling her fifty feet up.

I held my breath, trying to keep the dragon’s form whole while also watching Mica plummet ten feet, twenty, thirty. When it was clear she couldn’t stop herself, I conjured a sloped ramp just beneath her body. She slid uncontrolled to its base and rolled to the ground at my feet.

Above, ice shattered as the head of the dragon burst outward.

The Scythe, wrapped in a black cloak of her deviant wind mana, spun like a top. Dark lines slashed through the dragon in a dozen places, and I released my hold over its form, letting the ice dissipate harmlessly instead of crashing down on any nearby civilians.

Mica moaned.

Above, the cloak of shadows was expanding out around the Scythe, while at the same time curling inward like huge black claws, all pointed down at me.

Reaching for my core, I prepared to defend against the attack if I could.

But before it fell, a red line slashed through the air, straight at the Scythe.

Her power coalesced into a shield, but the red line punched straight through. She twisted at the last second, avoiding the scarlet missile, but I could see the ripple running through her mana from the smoldering hole it had left.

The burning red line turned in the air and flew back past the Scythe and over my head. I spun around.

Reaching out a hand, Bairon caught the spear. A red gleam stained his blond hair as the spear flared with its own internal light. When the light faded, though, I realized it wasn't only that staining him red.

Bairon was covered in blood from the tips of his well-trimmed hair to the heels of his boots. From the wounds I could see, it seemed to be his own.

He strode forward, favoring his left side. His leg dragged and his arm hung limp, but there was a blazing fire in his eyes that told me he was far from accepting defeat.

"A Scythe," he said, his deep baritone strained with the pain of his many wounds.

I only nodded, looking back up at the purple-haired woman. She was struggling against the growing agitation in her magic as the shadows bucked around her like a wind-tossed sea.

"No, another," Bairon said, leaning into the spear to take the weight off his left side. "I fought a horned woman with white hair. There are…two."

Coughing, Mica pushed herself up to her knees. Blood dripped like a tear from her ruined eye socket. Her core felt drained; she had used up an inordinate amount of mana fighting against herself.

"Stop looking at me like that," she grumbled, wiping the blood away. "I'm alive. And very pissed off."

"Lodenhold?"

Mica waved me away. "The Alacryan forces have…moved to block escape routes, but they are holding back from the city. The lords are only in danger if we…lose down here."

Wobbling slightly, a second woman appeared in the sky, flying toward the first. Two thick black horns sprouted from her brilliant white hair and curved outward. Her hand was pressed against a cut in her side, deep

enough to expose ribs. Drops of blood shimmered like falling rubies beneath her.

“You fought her alone?” I asked Bairon, unable to suppress the wonder in my tone.

Bairon snorted. “The spear. A lucky blow. Cut off her mana, but just temporarily.”

I remembered well enough the feeling of the scarlet blade disrupting my mana as we fought a losing battle against the asura. “That’s how we hold them off,” I said, extending a hand to Mica.

A harsh aura fell like an iron curtain down atop us as Mica pulled herself to her feet, and I heard the barriers of ice I was still focusing on shatter. The people beneath them screamed.

“Tricks and gimmicks won’t save you!” the second Scythe screamed, her blood-red eyes bulging in her head. The purple-haired Scythe had regained control of her mana after Bairon’s strike, and she was steadier than her counterpart, the only sign of any emotion a slight flaring of her nostrils.

Two Scythes…

This was a battle we’d lost before, in Etistin.

Bairon stepped up beside me, the asuran spear held in a white-knuckled grip as he leveled it at our enemy. Mica moved to my other side, unable to keep the apprehensive frown from her face. I understood, as I was struggling to ignore the cold claws of doubt and uncertainty that clutched at my insides.

And then I remembered Arthur, the way he had looked at the palace, gauging his family's safety before entrusting us to protect the city, and then what I had told him. “I’m done losing battles.”

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LIGHT AND SHADOW

ARTHUR LEYWIN

Living with this constant fear of being unable to protect my loved ones…I had nearly forgotten what that felt like. In Alacrya, my battles had been entirely distant, separate, from my friends and family. It was only ever my own life on the line, or at worst the lives of strangers and people who I had, for most of my unintentional stay there, seen as enemies.

Now, as I God Stepped from Varay's side, I couldn't stop considering the potential death toll of a full-scale assault on Vildorial. The people here were tired and afraid, the Lances only recently recuperated from very nearly dying, and our most powerful warriors, mages like Curtis and Kathyln and the Twin Horns, could not stand against even retainers, much less Scythes.

Another God Step took me from the edge of the city down two levels to where a series of arched gates opened into a long, straight tunnel wide enough for thirty dwarves to march abreast.

A miasma of brutal, animalistic killing intent was radiating from the portal room ahead, purposefully projected to loudly announce their presence. I ignited Realmheart, and five distinct mana signatures became clear, each burning with the sickly intensity I'd come to understand as the corrupted deviant mana used by the Vritra.

Hesitating, I looked over my shoulder up to the highest level, where my sister and mother were sheltered with a thousand dwarven nobles. Lodenhold was much too close.

'This definitely seems kind of sus to me,' Regis thought, sharing in the

same nervousness that quickened my heartbeat.

I stepped beneath one of the arches leading toward the portal room, resting my hand on the cold stone pillar. *Of course. It's a trap, after all.* Even if I defeated whatever enemy was giving off such an awful killing intent in front of me, there were still the enemies behind me to consider. I didn't know if the Lances could hold the line. If it took me too long…

The pillar crunched in my fist, which came away full of pinkish dust and stone shards. *But what other choice do we have?*

Hurling the mess to the ground, I took a step forward. And then another. And with each cautious step, I pushed down another question and source of anxiety. The truest way to protect those I cared about was to make any fight as swift and decisive as possible and to do that, I couldn't be shackled by my own uncertainty.

At the end of the tunnel, there was a matched set of arched openings carved of some light red stone. They opened into a huge empty cave that surrounded the thirty-foot-high, fifty-foot-wide portal frame, which provided enough space to stage a small army if necessary. Columns of gray and red rock held up a series of balconies that encircled the cave thirty feet up.

The room was lit by the natural glow of the still active portal.

My eyes moved quickly from the portal's opaque screen of undulating energy to the four dwarven corpses bleeding out in front of it, their bodies impaled by black metal spikes, and then to the five figures spread out throughout the chamber.

Within me, Regis trembled with a mixture of anticipation and nervous energy. I felt Uto's memories bubbling up unbidden in Regis's mind and bleeding over into my own. I saw the sons and daughters of the basilisks who followed Agrona from Epheotus, the interplay of asuran and human magic fine-tuned over a hundred generations. I knew what these beings were. Windsom had told me about them, long ago.

'The Wraiths,' Regis thought, giving a name to Agrona's hidden half-blood soldiers.

"You must be my welcoming committee," I said curtly, taking in each figure.

The foremost was a tall, broad-shouldered man. Flowing locks of earth-brown hair tumbled around thick corkscrew horns that stuck up several inches from the top of his head. He wore red chainmail under black half-plate armor that glowed with protective runes.

His dismissive eyes met mine. “We are here to eliminate a threat, not engage in witless banter.”

“Oh, come on, Richmal, we hardly ever get to have any fun,” one of the others said, whipping thick blond braids around his head and staring at me with hungry eyes. “If it is true that this one killed Cadell, we should have some fun with him before releasing him to the oblivion of death.” Like Richmal, this second man also had blood-red eyes and onyx horns. His curled out and down from the sides of his head, nearly touching again under his chin.

While they spoke, Regis’s Uto memories continued to ripple across the mental connection we shared. I saw a distorted, half-remembered thought of the man called Richmal standing over the gaunt, ashen corpse of a woman with brilliant white-blonde hair, through which two lightly curved black horns protruded—a dragon, I was certain of it.

Her golden eyes stared lifelessly up at Richmal as the Wraith bent down and wrenched one of her horns free of her head. The noise of it breaking sent a psychic tremor through me that made my stomach turn violently.

With an acute sense of urgency, I reached for the thread of aether that always connected the djinn’s relic armor to me. The black scales feathered into existence across my body. There was a comforting weight and coolness to it as the armor wrapped itself around me, and I felt the swelling of aether as the limited amount in the atmosphere pulled closer.

“Ah, I think he wants to be one of us!” a rich, feminine voice drawled. “Look at his little horns!” The speaker was a marble-skinned woman in heavy black plate armor. Only her face and head were exposed, showing off her short bright-blue hair, which was styled into spikes around her ridged horns. Runic lightning bolts were tattooed across her scarlet eyes. *Ulrike*, I knew, her name manifesting from Regis’s uncontained stream of consciousness.

“Cadell must have been sauced on elder nectar to let this skinny lesser best him.”

The rasping voice crawled like bugs out of the shadows and into my ears, making the hair on the back of my neck stand on end. I traced it back to a Wraith whose robes were dark with burn marks, the hood of which was pulled half up over his bald head. Two daggerlike horns thrust forward from his forehead. *Blaise*. The bright red of his eyes was interrupted by dark splotches that seemed to float over their surface, matching darker, ash-gray patches that marred his cold, marble skin.

Next to him, the fifth Alacryan was half hidden in living shadows. I caught flashes of jet-black hair curled up around the horns atop her head and dark, oxblood eyes surrounded by gray-black skin. *Valeska*.

"Enough," Richmal ordered, the deep well of his baritone burying the other voices. "You demean yourselves." A coiled lash of dark green stinking liquid shivered into existence in his fist, and he met my eye. "We will waste no more breath on you, lesser."

In the same moment, I activated God Step. The room shifted in an amethyst flash, and I appeared just beside and behind Richmal. "Suit yourself," I said, conjuring an aetheric sword and sweeping it backward.

The room exploded into chaos.

Black iron spikes shot from the ground to deflect my blade, and a gust of black wind seemed to enfold Richmal. I felt the aether blade strike home, then the wind carried my target away. A breath later, he reappeared across the room from me, his armor torn and blood seeping from a wound in his side.

This enemy was fast, and they worked together with flawless efficiency. I couldn't afford to hold anything back against them.

Regis, the blade.

Mana condensed within the dust and shadows hovering in the air, and a ring of black iron spikes thrust out of nothing to stab at my face and core. Using Realmheart to sense the formation of the attack, I sidestepped, pivoted, and ducked around the spikes, slashing through those I couldn't dodge.

A specter shaped from black flame reached for me, soulfire claws scraping over my armor. My sword spun around, flicking out toward the specter's throat. Just before it made contact, Regis reached the sword, and the thin amethyst blade burst into dark violet fire.

Destruction devoured the specter, leaving behind nothing, not even a residue of mana.

All five opponents were moving, casting. Shields of black wind and soulfire moved with them, turning the room into an inferno.

Twin torrents of black fire and sluggish, bubbling ooze sprayed at me from different directions. I leapt upward, grabbing the railing of the balcony and flipping myself onto it. The metal twisted when I Burst Stepped away again, ripping apart under the force of my movement, and then hissing and melting as a cloud of soulfire chased behind me.

The room became a dark blur as I moved near-instantly toward my next target, the blue-haired Wraith, Ulrike. I had only an instant to be surprised as her red eyes followed me, her shield shifting up to block my strike just as her spear lowered into a position to catch my momentum and use it against me.

The Destruction blade crashed against her towering shield, which was wrapped in a thick shell of blue-black lightning. Her conjured spear hit my armor like a battering ram, just above my core.

A concussive burst of pure energy shook the chamber as we were both thrown away by the force of our simultaneous blows. I tumbled, landed on my feet, and had only an instant to take in the sight of violet flames engulfing her shield before acidic tentacles wrapped around my legs. I slashed through them, and Destruction ripped the spell apart.

The soulfire cloud caught up to me, inundating me within an opaque black mist of seething fire that tried to force itself into my nose and mouth. I burst outward with an untargeted nova of aether, nullifying the flames.

The ground heaved beneath me as a partially formed golem made of hundreds of interlocked spikes ripped through the granite tiles and reached for me. I slid one foot back across the broken tiles as spiked claws closed on nothing but dust, then flicked out with the Destruction blade once, twice, three times.

Violet flames raced across the golem, which crumbled and burned.

Greenish mana condensed beneath me, and I dodged back just as the floor began to ooze thick poisonous sludge. A cyclone of black wind forced me to dodge again while deflecting a three-pronged bolt of lightning with the

Destruction blade and releasing an aetheric blast to ward off the clouds of soulfire.

There were too many of them, and they left me few openings between their combined spell attacks to go on the offensive. As I pivoted to stay out of the gusting cyclone, I considered my own capabilities. I needed to maximize my mobility and rebalance the scales.

Sensing Regis following along with my thoughts, I prepared my maneuver, condensing aether into my fist until the bones began to ache.

God Step flared, and I was standing across the room, just inside the arched entryways.

The aether blade vanished, as did my connection to Regis and the Destruction godrune.

Extending my arm, I released the blast.

Ulrike and the braided Wraith, Ifiok, disappeared in a cone of roiling purple aether. It engulfed the long-range teleportation portal beyond them as well, and the portal frame shattered with a sound like a thunderclap. The hard stone came down in a fluttering wave of glowing confetti as it dissolved. The opaque liquid energy of the portal itself swirled with the turbulence of its failure, then hissed and faded away.

At least they wouldn't be bringing in any reinforcements that way.

Ulrike lowered her shield, which was pockmarked and burn-scarred from Destruction. Scarlet runes burned brightly across its dim metallic surface. Ifiok stepped out from behind her, his braids smoking and one horn cracked. The flesh on the side of his face was torn and bleeding.

Now, I sent.

In the breath that followed, Regis exploded into being between the two, fully manifesting his Destruction form in a rush of aether. Caught by surprise, the two Wraiths were battered aside by his bulk, and his huge square jaws full of razor-blade teeth crunched down on the wounded Ifiok's shoulder and arm. Destruction flicked between his fangs, its jagged edges cutting and snapping as they leapt across Ifiok's pale flesh.

Simultaneously conjuring a blade and sending aether into every muscle, tendon, and joint, I Burst Stepped, blade thrusting forward at the side of

Ulrike's head.

And sank into an ocean of pain and filth.

The air had turned into a jellylike acid sludge that sucked me in and absorbed the momentum of my Burst Step. It hissed and popped where my aether struggled to keep it back, but the caustic substance was attacking every inch of me. My eyes burned and the relic armor trembled as the acid ate away at its structure.

Although I couldn't see through the sludge, with Realmheart active I could sense the locations of the five enemies, and even their decay-type mana arts couldn't stop me from finding the aetheric pathways. Focusing through the pain, I imbued aether into the godrune and ignited God Step, reappearing just behind Blaise.

With uncanny quickness, the bald Wraith diverted the stream of his soulfire away from Regis, who three of the others had pushed back against one curved wall, and into a shield between us. At the same time, I formed a sword and slashed across his side. Aether shivered against soulfire. My blade jolted with the force of the two opposing powers, then sank through his shield and slashed across his throat.

Blaise tried to shout but only gurgled up blood. His cloudy red eyes squinted into an agonized snarl, then black wind wrapped him up and yanked him away from me.

Claws of the same decay-type wind mana raked at me and grabbed for my wrists. I released the blade and pushed aether into my hands, reinforcing my protective barrier until it shone as visible gauntlets of amethyst light around my clawed gloves, so much aether built up that the fine bones in my hands began to ache.

The wind scrabbled to get a hold but was unable to grasp the aether.

Sensing multiple other spells targeted toward me, I made a sharp cutting motion with one gauntleted hand, releasing the pent-up aether in a wide, curving arc to eat away the barrage of pursuing spellfire.

A pained, enraged howl punctuated the sound of fire burning the air, black spikes erupting from the ground, and lightning crashing.

Across the chamber, Destruction erupted from Regis. A hot wind like the leading edge of a charging inferno flash-dried the sweat beading my brow,

and all the active spells in the vicinity were burned away like dry leaves.

“Valeska!” Ulrike shouted, her drawling voice pierced through with a spike of uncontained fear.

In an instant, I took in the chamber.

Regis was on the far side of the room, pierced through in several places by blue-black barbs of solid lightning. The stone around him had been carved away by Destruction for twenty feet in every direction, and the balconies above him had collapsed. His jaw hung open, thick ropes of saliva dangling from between his teeth, and his bright eyes were entirely focused on his prey.

On the floor just beyond the ruins, Valeska was dragging herself away with one arm while conjuring a thick shield of wind between her and Regis. Parts of her black hair and the ends of her horns had been burned away, and her face was covered in ugly blisters. One leg was missing at the knee.

Ulrike was floating twenty feet off the ground, a bombardment of blue-black bolts spraying from her fingertips down on Regis. Some burned away in Destruction before they reached him, but not all, and he was making no effort to defend himself.

Ifiok was on a balcony behind me. One fleshless skeletal arm hung useless at his side, and the flesh of his neck was broken open and oozing. His remaining hand was waving as he conjured dozens of black spikes from the ground to hurl through the room in every direction, carefully cutting just around his allies as they targeted both Regis and me.

Blaise had relocated to just outside the series of arched frames that opened into the chamber. He was surrounded by an oval field of flickering soulfire, fingertips pressed to his throat. Purple-tinged soulfire flames danced inside the wound as the flesh knit back together, while clouds of conjured flame continued to burn in the air between us as he struggled to envelop me within his power.

Richmal was controlling several long tentacles of dark green acidic liquid that had boiled up from between the granite tiles. The wound in his side had healed, and even his armor seemed to have mended itself. One of his tentacles wrapped around Valeska’s waist and helped pull her away while two others began harrying Regis, going for his neck and legs.

Meanwhile, three more tentacles came lashing at me, cutting whiplike through the air and spraying acidic slime in every direction.

Using God Step, I maneuvered out of the middle of the maelstrom of spells to the balcony, then away again immediately as Blaise's cloud of fire seared through the air toward me.

Regis's jaws were snapping furiously at the caustic tentacles when I reappeared standing over Valeska. An aetheric blade formed in my hands, pointing down, and I thrust at her core. She let out a piercing cry that cut off suddenly as she was jerked away by the tentacle around her torso. My blade carved a smoking hole in her side and the granite beneath her.

A huge iron spike manifested from my own shadow and thrust upward. Bracing my blade against my forearm, I caught the momentum of the spike and let it propel me up into the air and away from the grasping tentacles. Spinning, I deflected a burst of lightning that had ricocheted off Regis, then landed just in front of him. The aether blade swept through the vines harrying him, and then those chasing me, but more spells were already bearing down on us.

'Move,' Regis's deep, half-mad voice sounded in my head. Destruction was swelling within him, building up like magma within the caldera of a volcano, and he was about to rupture.

Jumping up, I planted one foot against the edge of an expanding spike and Burst Stepped after Valeska, my aether blade searing through the granite tiles of the floor in a straight line toward her and Richmal.

Behind me, a nova of Destruction washed across the room, erasing everything it touched. But my focus was on finding Valeska. She seemed to operate as the group's Shield, hiding them, protecting them, and even repositioning them when necessary. Without her, the rest would be exposed.

Richmal tried to repeat his trick of catching me mid-Burst Step, but I was ready for it. The aether blade swung up at the same time as the chamber blurred past me to the side, and I sliced through his spell and slammed into him shoulder first.

He was hurled off his feet to crash against the chamber's outer wall, and all his spells flickered out for just a moment.

Valeska had pushed herself up to one knee after Richmal had saved her.

Despite her grievous wounds, she was still casting, surrounding herself with a buffeting force while cutting at me with wicked scythes of condensed air. I pivoted and dodged those I couldn't block with an aether-wrapped fist, then, when I was nearly on her, invoked God Step.

Jumping, wild arcs of purple lightning ran along my forearm as I punched down at the side of her head from my new position. There was a crunch of bone as my fist connected, and then everything went dark.

Black wings had wrapped around my face, flapping and reeling, jerking me this way and that. With my hand still wrapped with aether, I raked my fingers through the spell, shredding it. But by the time I could see again, Valeska had already been whisked away.

Resummoning my blade, I leapt toward the downed Richmal, swinging at the back of his undefended neck. A blue-black blur flew at me from the side, hammering into me and pushing me off course. My sword cut up and sank through both rune-covered armor and flesh.

"Blaise, send Valeska back," Richmal's resonant baritone rumbled as he pulled himself to his feet. His expression was strained, and his tangled hair was matted to his head and stained brownish red.

Ulrike slid to a stop ten feet from me, pinning me between her and Richmal. Blood was gushing from her leg, which appeared to be nearly severed at the knee. She supported herself on her towering shield, which rested between us, and leveled a conjured spear at my face, snarling, her lax self-assuredness gone.

A bestial howl shook the cavern, and Regis leapt in from the side, his massive paws slamming Ulrike to the ground.

Dozens of sickly green darts flew from Richmal's hands, peppering Regis's side. Dark green mana seeped into him, circulating through his bloodstream in a matter of seconds.

Liquid fire ran through my channels as I siphoned aether from my core, down my arm, and into the palm of my hand, where it built up until the pressure forced it to explode outward, bathing the cavern in violet light and engulfing Richmal.

There was a flash, and a wedge of blue-black static disrupted the air around Regis. He roared, breathing out a gout of Destruction, but the static buzzed around and away from the flames before coalescing like a

guillotine above him. At the same time, Ulrike was jerked out from beneath him by the lightning bolt in her hand.

The static moved through Regis's body like a saw, cleanly dividing flesh, bone, and even aether. My companion howled as his huge, slope-backed torso came in two, the rear half stumbling on its shorter, thicker legs, the front struggling to balance as he lunged awkwardly after his prey.

Regis's barely-contained rage and need to unleash Destruction crashed into me through our connection, warring against his survival instinct and a desperate edge of existential uncertainty.

A razor-sharp knife of panic slashed at my guts, and I could only watch the horrifying spectacle as I struggled to process Regis's inner conflict alongside my own suppressed emotions. I missed the mana coalescing from the shadows above me just before a spear-thin spike thrust out from the nearest column and drove at my face.

I spun at the last moment, taking the blow to the side of my armored head where the horns sprouted out. The spike shattered, and a foot-long shard twisted in the air and drove into my cheek. I felt it scrape bone as it deflected downward to push out the base of my skull.

The force of the impact knocked me back into a supporting column, where I leaned for a moment, dazed, one hand scrabbling against the jagged butt of the spike where it poked out of my face.

The ground shattered beneath my feet, dropping me to one knee in a pool of burning sludge. Dozens of black iron spikes interlocked over the pool to create a sharp-edged dome, pinning me into the poison that I could already feel sapping my strength as it attacked my nervous system. The spikes tightened, forcing me down farther into the ooze. My lungs seized, and I felt my heart stutter.

The iron dome lit up with blue-black light, and hundreds of bolts of electricity began to crash back and forth. My body locked up. My mind went numb from the shock as the ooze continued to eat away at my armor. When I reached for God Step, I couldn't sense it. I couldn't feel anything at all past the pain of mana attacking every nerve in my entire body.

"Now, while he's pinned! Valeska, report to the High Sovereign, inform him—"

My ears popped and stars burst behind my closed eyes, and my muscles

began to spasm as I pushed back at the spikes, but to little effect. I lost all sense of Richmal's words, only knew that the Wraiths were shouting at one another. Although I couldn't understand what they said, the desperation in their voices was clear.

Blue-black particles of deviant lightning mana flashed and popped as they impacted the amethyst motes that made up my aetheric barrier. Dark green mana sizzled and burrowed into the aether before evaporating. Gray-brown deviant earth mana cracked and broke against the purple barrier.

Through a gap in the spikes, I saw Regis, or what was left of him. My companion had been reduced to little more than a wisp of aether trapped within a cage of Ulrike's mana. I could feel him, but just barely, burning, his consciousness receding with each passing moment as more and more of his aetheric essence was exhausted just to keep his feeble form.

I reached for him, tried to pull him to me with the force of my will alone, but he wasn't reacting, couldn't escape the spell burning him away to nothing.

Time seemed to slow, almost like when I'd been able to use Static Void, before. Suddenly, I could feel the weight of all that mana clashing with my aether, see the way the particles bent and rippled and jumped as one, the shapes of the individual spells, how they were formed, their purpose, the metaphysical stitching that held them together.

The mana wove together in a shape formed by the will of the caster, while the aether both contained the mana and determined its natural behavior, but also moved to accommodate the mana's passing, the two forces fitting together like light and shadow. I couldn't believe I hadn't seen it before.

My hand quivered as I reached into the turmoil. All along it, the interplay of metaphorical light and darkness—mana and aether—shifted and moved, always together, simultaneously in coordination and opposition. And in between them, a kind of curtain separating light and shadow.

My fingers twitched. The curtain shifted. Aether wrapped around mana and moved it aside.

The interlocking spikes pinning me down released, floating out in the air around me. They trembled, uncertain, Ifiok's will pushing them to one purpose, but the flow of aether repelling them, redefining what mana was allowed to do.

A web of electricity jumped from spike to spike, crackling threateningly, tendrils reaching out toward me, deflecting, and being reabsorbed into the whole, unable to strike farther than what the aether allowed.

The pool of acid parted, separating, pulling away from me.

As I slowly stood, my legs shook with the effort of enforcing my will on the aether, and through the aether, the mana. My enemies surrounded me, but gone was the physical force of their confidence and their brash expressions.

Instead, I saw wide red eyes amid gray faces turned pale with fear.

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APATHY AND ECSTASY

THE SCENE around me seemed frozen in time.

Richmal's face was slack, his focus on the magic coming undone as he watched with awe. At his side, Ulrike blazed with internal light, more and more mana pouring out of her, the web of electricity growing brighter in coordination with her efforts. Her crimson eyes avoided me as she focused on her spell, the muscles of her jaw working as she ground her teeth.

Behind them, Ifiok sagged, sweat pouring down his face, the ruins of his arm hanging limply at his side, his channeled mana trickling away to nothing.

Blaise and Valeska had retreated down the tunnel toward Vildorial, and Blaise was fumbling with a tempus warp. The familiar anvil-shaped device hummed as it collected and condensed mana.

I was still reeling from my discovery of the interplay between aether and mana. Even though I still didn't fully understand yet what Realmheart was capable of, I had no time to question what I was doing. It took a tremendous effort just to lift one foot and place it in front of the other. There were still five Wraiths to deal with, and I could feel Regis's life force weaken by the moment.

The orbiting field of spikes and blue-black lightning shifted as I moved, rotating away as I passed, my aether containing and redirecting the mana making up the various spells. The force of my will was matched against that of the three opposing mages. I had to maintain a more forceful hold over the aether than they could enforce on their mana, but there was also something else, some resistance from the aether I didn't yet understand.

Moving the short distance to Regis sapped even my asuran physique of its inhuman stamina and strength, and by the time I reached the cage of lightning, my legs were trembling. I released the pool of acidic sludge, which splashed back together and then sank between the cracks in the granite tiles and vanished.

Richmal gasped and sucked in a deep, desperate breath, as if he'd been holding it the entire time. "Valeska! Go, now!" he barked, his voice raw.

Releasing aether from my core, I manipulated it around Ulrike's spell, looking once again for the metaphorical curtain separating the two powers. It was just like in the keystone, when I'd practiced with Ellie. I had to let my mind refocus, shift my perspective. Three Steps had once told me something very similar as well, and even Kordri's lessons had required that I experience the motion and interplay of our bodies differently.

Perhaps that's what all knowledge boiled down to: new experiences that shifted one's perspective slightly, revealing more of a world that was already there but which we couldn't see.

My breath caught, and my mind stuttered, and I wrenched myself back into the moment. Dozens of poisonous slime darts were hissing through the air at me.

My hand raised, too slowly, my mental fortitude drained and exhausted. The darts parted, their path shifting as they swarmed around me to either side, and I let out a breath simultaneously full of wonder and fatigue. I could feel where each particle of mana and aether interacted, how the aether took hold of the mana and redirected it to create a momentary sympathetic binding of the two forces.

But I was also shouldering the combined force of all that mana, trying to hold each of the individual spells separately in my mind, and as the darts curved to avoid me, I was forced to release my hold over the spikes and lightning web the other Wraiths had used to pin me down.

The field of black spikes fired away wildly, nearly impaling Ifiok and crashing against Ulrike's shield. The lightning, which she had continued to pour mana into until it burned to look at, condensed into a single bolt and struck the ground, exploding in a blinding flash.

The chamber quaked.

Turning my attention swiftly to the small cage of lightning, I looked for

the place where the two forces moved to allow each other's presence and tugged, peeling control of the small cell away from Ulrike. It snapped and seared the air as I pulled it away from Regis. The wisp bobbed drunkenly as it drifted up around my ankles. Reaching out, I closed my fist around it. It sank into my flesh and drifted toward my core.

Regis offered no response to my sudden presence, but I could sense his consciousness, distant and unaware but alive. I could only hope he would recover if we survived this battle.

Mana flared from the hallway as the tempus warp began to activate.

The bright mana was clear, as was the rim of atmospheric aether that moved to encircle it. Valeska trembled as she leaned toward the mana, her hand stretched out, her fingertips brushing the surface of the portal as it manifested.

I reached out, my gloved hand curling into a claw as I attempted to seize the portal. The aether jumped at my command, contracting around the portal and compressing the mana. The tempus warp's magic seized, leaving the half-formed portal wavering tenuously in the air.

"I can't get through," Valeska screamed as she scratched at the portal's surface.

"Take him down!" Richmal's deep voice cracked as he roared, and spells rained down on me from every direction.

Iron and fire broke against my armor and aetheric cladding. Lightning and acid glanced aside, bursting or burning into the ground, shattering the stone with the fury and hellfire of my enemies.

But with most of my focus on forcefully distorting the tempus warp portal, it was all I could do to deflect even half their attacks. Acid and lightning burns scarred my face and metal spikes ripped through both armor and flesh. My face and skull burned where the metal spike had punched through it earlier.

Too much aether was being focused through Realmheart to defend against the Wraiths' spells and the portal.

But I knew I couldn't let the Wraiths retreat. Not even one.

In Agrona's hands, information was a weapon. I couldn't give him that. I

couldn’t let them escape to report on my abilities.

They all had to die.

Ulrike was repositioning to stand between me and the half-formed portal. Her leg, sheathed in a cast of pure mana that sparked and jumped at every subtle movement, dragged limply behind her. Richmal’s arm was pressed down over a huge open wound in his side where armor, flesh, bone, and organs alike had been removed to reveal sharp bits of rib poking through a fleshy red mess, a wound caused by Regis’s last desperate burst of Destruction.

Destruction.

I hesitated even as spell after spell pummeled me, deflecting what I could, absorbing the rest, the pain at once all-encompassing and nothing at all as I focused past it to the thing waiting dormant in Regis’s meager essence.

I hadn’t attempted to use the godrune on my own since the mirror zone, but even then Regis had been conscious, flying to my hand to help me concentrate all of my aether in one specific direction. I knew all too well the risks of using it now without Regis to help me focus and control it. With the abundance of aether in my dual-layer core, I could burn through all of Vildorial.

The spells were becoming more random and madcap, their movements jerky and difficult to follow, and I realized Ulrike was imbuing her lightning-attribute mana into the others’ spells. The resulting fusion of magic was faster, wilder, and much more difficult to counter.

As lightning-infused bolts of burning brine struck me like cannon fire, and my pain-wracked mind fought to maintain concentration, I understood that there was no other choice. I couldn’t defend against the bombardment and keep control over the portal *and* fight the rest of them.

Eventually my focus would slip, the portal would open, and one or more of the Wraiths would escape.

Even then, I would *still* have to defeat the others. But what would keep them fighting? If they withdrew to the city, made me fight in the great cavern…

I imagined the power of these Vritra half-bloods unleashed on the defenseless people of Vildorial. If that happened, nothing else would

matter.

I clenched my fists. The godrune contained within Regis's essence came alive with hunger and power, and the violet flames burst to life in my hands, giving off a bright, jagged, deadly aura.

A spasm of pain came from my back where the Realmheart rune burned with golden light, and my vision and sense of mana jolted. I found myself caught off guard by the difficulty of maintaining both godrunes, but I couldn't release Realmheart. Not yet.

Somewhere in the back of my mind, I considered that the hungry, eager power of Destruction was all I needed.

I lifted my hand.

Destruction lurched forward, wild, uncontrolled flames expanding and devouring as they shed their rageful light across the chamber.

Ifiok's iron spikes thrust forward to meet it. Purple flames raced across black metal, unmaking his magic as it leapt from spike to spike, chasing them back to their source. Unshackled from Regis's more compatible insight, Destruction rushed wildly, like a stampede of stallions on fire, and Ifiok began to scream. It raced up his arm and across his chest, converting his flesh and blood and mana to purple light and then to nothing at all.

I spun with a poorly suppressed sense of giddiness, spreading the wave of Destruction haphazardly in every direction.

Richmal dragged himself and Ulrike out of Destruction's path with his watery tentacles while sending out a flood of green sludge to douse my fire, but Destruction only ate that as well.

"Agrona thinks these *lessurans* are going to kill asuras for him?" I asked the flames, my voice undercut by the force of Destruction vibrating within it. "Pathetic."

I grabbed a spear of black iron out of the air and watched as Destruction pulled the spell apart and unmade it.

Noxious fumes were pouring out of Richmal's skin, staining the air with a greenish murk and filling what little remained of the chamber with the smell of death and rot in a feeble attempt to cut me off from the portal.

Above me, the same static guillotine that had destroyed Regis's physical

body was forming again.

I slammed my will into it, and the mana trembled, caught between my force and Ulrike's. Wherever the purple runes of Realmheart appeared on my skin, I began to burn and sweat, but I only pushed harder, Destruction consuming my pain and fear until Ulrike's spell *broke*.

A bone-crushing shockwave of pure force, created by the static distortion's failure, hurled both the Wraiths backward into the wall. I leaned into the force of the explosion, and Destruction jumped to wreath my body in a jagged aura, the violet flames curling between the scales of my relic armor, eating it from the inside.

Instinctively and without consideration, I dismissed the armor, and it dematerialized. I didn't need it anyway. Destruction was better armor than any old djinn relic.

Ulrike hunkered behind her shield as Destruction caught up with her, but it accomplished nothing. Destruction ate away the runes, then the shield, then Ulrike herself as her armor, flesh, and then bones vanishing layer by layer.

Richmal stumbled back, but he didn't try to run. Foolishly, he threw himself in front of the exits, and a wall of steaming, stinking liquid rose up to block the way.

"Valeska, Blaise, *go*!" he shouted, and I was surprised to hear something akin to genuine *care* in his voice.

"Weak," I snarled, the word burning like a chant, the force of it sending a tremor through my enemy.

Through the semitransparent wall, I could see Blaise and Valeska both fighting with the tempus warp, pouring magic into it in an attempt to wrest control of the portal's mana away from me.

The misshapen glowing oval shook, and striations of distortion ran across its surface, but I held it entirely, the apathy of Destruction shielding me from the growing pain of focusing on both godrunes.

Valeska turned and met my eye. Now, there was something akin to real terror in them. These creatures had been trained to wage a shadow war against deities. But they were children playing at being gods. They understood nothing. They *were* nothing.

Still holding her gaze, I sent Destruction to roll across Richmal. Mana poured out of him in the form of a thick greasy steam, momentarily holding the purple flames back as they consumed his power instead.

With Realmheart, I looked for the curtain separating the light and shadow and ripped it aside. His spell was snuffed out like a candle flame, and then his flesh lit up like much the same, and then he was gone.

Somewhere deep within me, something *cracked*.

My vision and sense of mana blinked out, and I had to squeeze my eyes closed against sudden vertigo and nausea. When I opened them again, the glowing oval of a portal appeared over the tempus warp device. Blaise was shouting and shoving Valeska toward it, but she was still staring at the place Richmal had been only seconds before.

I stumbled. Looking down, I realized that violent flames were burning along the backs of my hands and forearms, and my skin was unraveling beneath the fire. I was losing control.

"Go!" Blaise screeched, shoving Valeska hard.

Her arms flailed, and her hand, arm, and then face vanished through the portal.

A groan escaped my lips as I forced aether back into the Realmheart godrune. It sputtered to life with a wave of sickening agony. I wrenched hard on the aether around the portal, crushing it.

The portal shivered, rippling violently. The mana particles compressed, and the force binding them shattered. The portal died out with a grotesque squelching noise, and what remained of Valeska on this side of the portal collapsed wetly to the ground.

I trembled as Realmheart cut out again, severing my connection to the mana for the second time. I spit out a mouthful of blood and bile.

Blaise howled. An enormous serpent of soulfire filled the tunnel, racing toward me. Violet fire subsumed the black, and then flowed into Blaise's eyes and nose and mouth before burning him away from the inside out.

Grinning and burning, I laughed. A single long, mirthful, insane laugh as the last of the Wraiths, Agrona's supposed asura killers, fell before me, the entire essence of their beings wiped away by my power, not even the stain

of their corrupted mana remaining.

The laugh cut out, and I sank down to one knee.

The fingers of my left hand were beginning to disintegrate. There was so much aether in my core now for Destruction to feed on. It was a beautiful sight. I could just picture it burning and burning and burning and—

In the distance, I vaguely sensed the flaring of powerful mana signatures and a storm of magic raging throughout the cavern of Vildorial.

I could burn the city. All of Darv, if I wanted to. Dicathen and Alacrya and Epheotus…

I felt my face crack into a wide, vicious, victorious grin just as the flesh of my arms began to crack and bleed under the force of Destruction.

I thought of Valeska's face and arm tumbling through a portal somewhere in Alacrya. "That will be a very different message than she intended to give Agrona, I imagine," I said aloud, my voice crackling with fire.

With some amusement, I realized my left arm had burned away up to the elbow. Destruction was in the stones now, devouring the chamber and tunnel, searching out more fuel, more, more, reaching for the city where there was so much substance, so much *life*…

'Art…'

Regis's voice, distant, hollow.

'Art!'

More insistent, a note of panic bleeding through the apathy and glory of Destruction.

It was a voice that would grow silent soon enough. All would be Destruction in the end. Everyone, everything.

I thrust my ruined arm outward. Destruction boiled forth to consume the walls and ceiling and floor beneath my feet.

An image pierced my mind like a crossbow bolt. I could feel Regis holding it there, projecting into my consciousness with the last of his strength. Ellie and Mom. They were holding each other, shivering in fear where they huddled with a mass of nameless, faceless dwarves as the ground beneath

them trembled and buckled as it was being eaten away by bright amethyst flames…

Everyone. Everything.

Above me, the ceiling collapsed, and elsewhere I dimly heard the crashing of stones as part of the cavern fell in on itself, but everything within sight was only violet fire.

Everything. *Everyone*.

No, that's wrong, I thought, the effort of holding even a simple thought like walking across broken glass. *Mom. Ellie. Everything I've done…*

But this is victory, a voice uncomfortably like my own replied. *This is finality. This is the end of our enemies.*

And of everything else.

Gritting my teeth, I leaned forward and frantically smashed my head into the rough stone of the crater I was sinking into, trying to jar loose Destruction's hold over me.

When that failed, I attempted to slam shut the gates that controlled the flow of aether out of my core and into the Destruction godrune, but I couldn't.

I pushed at Regis, intent on forcing him out of my body, removing my connection to the rune, but the feeble wisp form wavered, and I stopped, afraid that separating him from my aether would destroy him.

My left arm was gone up to my shoulder. Destruction burned in its place. Soon, it would replace me entirely, leaving only the void.

The void…

I thought of the mirror room again, the void beyond it, how I had exhausted all my aether by sending Destruction into the empty nothing to save Caera. Except I wasn't in the Relictombs. I didn't have the luxury of burning away all my aether into nothing. Here, there was always something to burn, something to consume.

A sharp spike of adrenaline partially cleared my mind as an idea manifested. I didn't take time to consider what I was doing or what it would mean if it worked. I couldn't let the guilt stay my hand, not if it

meant saving my family.

Moving as quickly as my failing form could, I clawed my way free of the crater, then stumbled out into the tunnel toward Vildorial.

Sitting against one Destruction-scoured wall was the tempus warp.

I collapsed in front of the anvil-shaped device. It was half in ruins.

Closing my eyes, I focused on the godrune for Aroa's Requiem. It was distant, and even when aether flowed into it, no rush of power announced the rune's activation. Destruction clouded everything else, and my body was failing, but I pushed harder. That power couldn't be erased, even if my body failed.

Warmth bloomed across my back, and I began to shiver uncontrollably.

Destruction was jumping from me to the stone walls and floor, eager for more matter to consume. Flickering motes of purple energy began to trickle away from me and into the tempus warp device. I focused on keeping Destruction away, sending it everywhere but the tempus warp, but I only half succeeded.

Destruction and Aroa's Requiem pushed back and forth, the artifact dissolving in places while being rebuilt in others.

Dragging in a deep breath, I pulled Destruction into myself.

The aetheric motes danced along the pockmarked metallic surface of the tempus warp, and the artifact reconstituted before my eyes, the holes and gouges filling back in, the runes reappearing.

My breath turned ragged as the fire reached my chest and lungs. I could feel Destruction wrapping around my core, pulling more and more and more aether from it. The feeble form of Regis hunkered in close, huddling incoherently within the core's shell.

Aroa's Requiem finished its work, and I gratefully released my focus on the edict. The motes faded into nothing. Above the tempus warp, the portal relit, a gray-blue-purple-white oval through which I could just see the ghost of whatever was on the other side.

Aroa's Requiem had returned the device to the same state it was in just before Destruction reached it.

Something hot and wet welled up from my eyes and ran down my face as I crawled on claws of Destruction and burned legs into the portal.

The world wrenched nauseatingly around me. Empty space ripped past. I hurtled through a blurred nothingscape. With no other matter to turn on, Destruction feasted on my aether and my body.

Then I was…somewhere else.

A rush of cold air. Hard ground beneath my knees. The vague impression of sharp, fanglike peaks in the distance.

There were people all around me, dozens and dozens of them, surprised faces jerking away, swirls of color as shields were cast from a dozen different sources, incoherent shouting—questions, commands, pleas—and staring up at me from the ground was part of Valeska's face, disembodied and sitting in a pool of blood.

Sharp-edged tongues of violet flame tumbled out of me, and I felt only relief as the Destruction found something else to feast on.

"Th-that's him! Grey!" several voices shouted, and the people—mages, soldiers, *Alacryan* soldiers—surged backward.

"Retreat! Retreat!"

A few spells flew at me, but Destruction pulled them out of the air and devoured them.

"Move aside!" a vaguely familiar voice snarled.

The feverish confusion I felt cooled, and my mind seemed to shift back into focus. I was in an enclosed courtyard surrounded by heavy gray buildings. In the distance, the faded blue outlines of the Basilisk Fang mountains clawed at the sky. I was in some kind of military base, probably around the eastern edge of Vechor based on the position of the mountains and the brutal military styling of the encampment.

The soldiers and mages in the courtyard were all wearing the red and black uniforms and armor of Alacryans. A man in clean azure-lined robes had pushed through the line and was staring at me with a vindictive grin.

"What are you all so afraid of?" he crowed, his bright jade eyes gleaming from a cleanly shaven face framed by carefully styled brown hair. "Look at him. There's barely anything left—"

Violet fire began to spill away from me in waves, tumbling across the black stone of the courtyard floor and toward the lines of Alacryan soldiers.

A soldier grabbed him by the shoulder and tried to pull him back behind the line of shields. “Professor Graeme, sir, it isn’t—”

Janusz Graeme’s victorious sneer shattered as realization dawned across his face.

Destruction caught up with him as he turned and tried to drag himself over the soldier, knocking the young man down. They both went up like so many dry pine needles, and then were gone.

I laughed. A mindless bark of pure delight, empty of empathy or care. The sound of it sobered me instantly.

More shields flashed into existence as dozens of voices crashed together in a concentration of fear and confusion. I pushed and pushed and pushed, all my focus turning back into myself as I tried to force out every particle of aether in my core, projecting the wild, uncontained Destruction as I did.

Tears or blood, I couldn’t tell which, welled up behind my eyes as I watched line after line of Alacryan soldiers vanish within with violet fire. Then the blaze moved into the buildings enclosing the courtyard, and everything and everyone within them, and still there was more.

Destruction spread beyond my line of sight, but I could feel it gleefully leap from structure to structure, leaving no tile or brick or timber behind, destroying utterly and without consideration.

But I’d regained myself, and I no longer felt the apathy and ecstasy of the ruination I was causing. I felt hollow, like the flames had burned away something intrinsic to my being, like I was shedding a piece of my humanity with each passing moment as the violet inferno spread and massacred all within the base.

I pictured Ellie and Mom again and steeled myself. There was no choice, not this time. Not when it was between my loved ones and the people who sought to murder them.

But I still couldn’t help but see the ring of force speeding through the forests of Elenoir and leaving nothing but devastation in its wake.

My core gave a last, final, painful squeeze, and the flames guttered out with sudden finality. My reservoir of aether was exhausted. There was nothing left. And with no aether to fuel it, the Destruction godrune dimmed and went quiet.

I turned in a slow circle, staring around at what I had wrought.

The base was a large complex at the center of an entire town. A circle of ashen nothing spread for half a mile in every direction. The devastation ended suddenly with simple, functional stone buildings, many of which were partially collapsed or destroyed. A three-story complex sagged and crashed to the ground as I watched, sending up a tall plume of dust.

In the distance, I could hear the ghosts of screams, dozens of them, perhaps hundreds.

Just behind me, the hovering oval of the portal remained intact, the tempus warp on the other end continuing to project.

Turning away from the desolation, I felt something hard turn underneath my boot and almost stumbled. Sheltered by my own body, Valeska's single remaining horn had escaped the worst of Destruction. Tiredly, I bent down to retrieve it, then stepped through the portal.

The sickening rush of long-range teleportation, and then I was stumbling back into Dicathen. I kicked the tempus warp aside, breaking its connection with the conjured portal, which shivered, cracked, and blinked out of existence.

My body and mind gave out, and I slumped to my knees, then onto my side. The true pain of my wounds gripped me, and without any aether in my core, I couldn't heal.

Deep inside me, the wisp that was Regis shook itself awake, nudging me wordlessly, the only comfort my companion had the strength to give.

I returned the simple gesture, then sank into unconsciousness.

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DEFENDING VILDORIAL II

BAIRON WYKES

I could practically feel the frayed ends of Varay's nerves firing next to me. At her other side, Mica's mana signature was a weak hum. And yet, both Lances stood firm in the face of a terrible enemy. A swell of pride fortified my own commitment.

I was glad to stand next to these warriors in defense of my home. Each of us had faced down certain death at the hands of an asura. Looking away from my companions, I leveled a ready stare at the two Scythes hovering above, refusing to let any fear of them creep into my heart.

Cruel laughter echoed through the cavern, resounding from stone to stone as it built like the pressure before a thunderstorm.

"Done losing? You've already lost!" the white-haired scarecrow of a Scythe I had wounded shouted down at us, her previously playful voice now full of menace and cruelty. "Don't you feel it?"

On the far edge of the cavern, a horrible pressure was drumming out of the walls in sharp bursts, several sources of mana and paralyzing killing intent all slamming into one another with the force of maces against a bare skull.

Even from so far away, the sensation made my fingers grow weak around the haft of the red spear.

"But please, don't stop fighting," the Scythe continued, her snarl easing as she adopted her darkly playful mannerisms again. Black-purple flames were burning through the wound I'd given her, wiping it away as if it had never existed. "It would be oh so disappointing to finally get a chance to

fight in the war only for the mighty Lances to give up so soon."

Speaking for only Mica and me to hear, Varay said, "Mica, cast defensively, keep them occupied, distracted. Bairon, focus on landing blows with that ungodly spear. We have a chance if we can cut off the flow of their mana, even briefly."

"Yes, that's the spirit," the Scythe said, suddenly giddy. "Scheme away. I can't wait to shove that cursed spear up your—"

"Enough, Melzri," the purple-haired Scythe cut in, her voice oozing like sludge through the air. "Let us finish this before the Wraiths arrive."

The Scythe I'd fought, Melzri, sobered. "Of course, Viessa. Good impressions and all that."

Even to my enhanced senses, Melzri was little more than a shadowy blur as she suddenly flew into our midst. I had just enough time to pull my spear up into a defensive position before her strike landed. The blow sent me skating backward, my feet digging long gouges into the courtyard.

She wielded a long, curved sword in each hand. One swirled with black wind, the other with dark fire. Both blades snapped out simultaneously, one at Varay's ribs, the other at Mica's throat. The strikes deflected off stone and ice, and the other Lances let themselves be pushed away by the force, then flew up into the air.

A dark cyclone was spinning into being above us as Viessa worked some horrid spell, but my focus was on Melzri.

She didn't pursue the others but spun again and catapulted herself at me.

Ice reached up from the earth to wrap around her limbs, and the dust sank unnaturally to the earth as the gravity between us became several times heavier. The Scythe jerked midlunge, and I sidestepped and pulled up my spear. Her blades clanged against the shaft, and I countered with a series of lightning-quick thrusts that she batted aside.

Above me, everything became howling darkness, and I lost sight of Varay and Mica.

Melzri was a vortex of burning, cutting steel, leaping, spinning, and striking with impossible force and speed, the twin blades seeming to come from every direction and angle simultaneously as I struggled simply to

keep my spear between us.

She'd been playing with me before, I realized with a sickening certainty. Just waiting for the other Scythe to finish off Varay and Mica. Otherwise, I never would have landed the blow that forced her to temporarily retreat.

Cutting off these spiraling, unhelpful thoughts, I focused on the Scythe and her weapons, letting myself sink into the hyperfocused state required to effectively utilize Thunderclap Impulse.

Mana infused every synapse in my body. It sparked in my mind, enhancing both my thoughts and reactions by several times over.

Her swords were both cutting toward me, one at my right knee, the other at my left elbow. Instead of flailing wildly in an effort to block both blows at once, I leaned into them, the perception of my lightning-enhanced senses allowing me to thrust my body forward between the two blows. My pauldron rammed into the Scythe's face.

It was like running headlong into an iron hyrax.

Lightning rushed through me, condensed into a single point on my arm, and then exploded outward with enough force to send Melzri hurtling backward. Her swords closed around me like shears.

I dove into a forward roll, so close to her weapons that I felt the fire lick at the back of my neck.

As I came to my feet, Melzri was bearing down on me, already recovered, her body rotating and her blades turning around her like those of a thresher.

The ground cracked beneath me as I launched myself backward with another condensed burst of lightning. Cocking back, I threw the asuran spear with all my might.

Melzri twisted in her flight, flowing like wind around the spear. My sped-up senses barely saw as she let go of her own weapon and tried to grab mine out of the air.

Her body jerked violently. The grace and precision of her movement were suddenly a chaos of limbs as the spear yanked her sideways and sent her spinning to crash and tumble across the ground. She vanished with the crunch of breaking stone into one of the fallen buildings.

The red spear turned in a wide arc and flew to my hand, but I was already moving in to close the distance between me and the Scythe.

With a curse, she hurled away a large section of wall that had collapsed onto her, giving me the perfect opening. I aimed for her core, driving the spear down with both hands.

Her counter was little more than a blur, even with Thunderclap Impulse active. The wind-wreathed blade jumped up to parry my thrust, and the spear's head sank deep into the stone beside her. At nearly the same time, something burned across my back, and then her flaming sword was in her hand again as well. As I hissed in pain and reached for the line of fire across my back, she lashed out with a kick to my chest.

The cavern bent and wobbled as my perspective struggled to correct to my sudden backward motion. I was vaguely aware of crashing into and through something very hard, and then I was lying on my back.

Above me was the writhing, roaring black storm cloud. Within the cloud, I could vaguely sense the other two Lances struggling against the second Scythe. They were relying on me, on the asuran weapon Arthur had gifted me, and I needed to stand up, to help them, to *fight*.

But the fire seeped into my blood.

I knew it immediately. No matter how much time passed, I would never forget that wretched encounter with Cadell in the flying castle or how it had felt to lie there, helpless as a newborn, while his magic ate away my life from the inside.

I imagined actual flames alive in my blood, each frantic *thump-thump* of my heart spreading the blaze.

Melzri appeared above me, her movements businesslike. One arm was hanging lower than the other, but as I watched, she rotated it until the arm popped back into place. She gave me a curious look, her eyes burrowing through my skin and into my blood and bones.

"What does it feel like?" Her words were soft, almost reverent. "Tell me, and I'll speed your demise."

I laughed with derision, then my body spasmed and my back arched with agony, every muscle going taut. "It feels…just like I remember," I gasped out through clenched teeth. The spasm settled, and I took several deep,

painful breaths. “It took me months to regain my strength after the other one filled me with fire.”

Her gaze sharpened, and she leaned toward me, the wind-shrouded blade pressing against my breastplate. Her eyes were wide, and a muscle in her cheek trembled as she suppressed a manic grin. “Go on…”

I met her eyes the color of curdled blood. Outwardly, I was calm. Peaceful. I had accepted my death—again. But inside, the real battle was raging.

“My body didn’t feel like my own, not for a long time,” I continued, inwardly focused on controlling my release of mana. “This alien force had been within it, and even after it was gone, it had left a residue that I couldn’t wash off my soul.”

The edge of her sword slid across my breastplate, sinking into it with the low whine of metal on metal. “You’ve got a surprisingly beautiful way with words, Lance. Finish, and I will relieve you of this pain.” She bit her bottom lip as she waited, filled with anticipation.

“I thought I’d never heal, not really. My time as a Lance was done. I was cursed to linger as a burned-out husk of my former self.” Her eyes closed as her blade slowly parted the leather backing of my armor and then the flesh beneath. “But I had so long to think about it, Scythe. I planned, and I hoped.”

“What did you hope for, Thunderlord?”

Slow, steady downward pressure. The feel of steel scraping across bone, and then…

“That, one day, some foolish Alacryan would be stupid enough to try it on me again,” I growled.

Her eyes flashed open, reflecting the white lightning burning from my many small wounds as I completed casting the spell I had designed for this very moment.

Thunderlord’s Wrath, I chanted in my head, nearly gasping with relief.

For all her speed, Melzri couldn’t react quickly enough.

Instead of retreating, she leaned into her blade, and I felt it scrape against the edge of my sternum as it bit deep. The lightning filling my body—my blood—raced up the steel and into her. I could feel every particle of mana

as it attacked her nerves, crashing along her arms and into her torso.

She was thrown off her feet, then crashed through a statue of some ancient dwarven lord. He fell to the ground in pieces, his cracked face staring up at me forlornly.

I floated off the ground after her, wreathed in reaching tendrils of lightning.

“I just couldn’t get rid of that feeling of fire in my blood,” I said as Melzri thrust herself up from the ground and into the air. The twin blades jumped back into her hands. One arm was blackened up to the elbow. “So I learned how to turn my blood to *lightning*!”

I punctuated this last word by focusing on the deep wound in my chest. A blinding ray of lightning exploded out of me. Melzri brought up both of her swords to deflect the blast, and a shield of wind and fire encircled her. The lightning condensed and built where the two spells impacted, growing and growing until the pressure ripped the mana apart.

The explosion sent us both hurtling backward, tumbling through the air like newborn birds fallen from the nest.

Inside me, white-hot light struggled against the devouring darkness. Every vein and artery screamed with the strain of it, but I was winning. The spell she’d used was specific, designed to eat away at my life’s blood. Without anything to burn, the soulfire was fading.

Taking hold of my tumbling flight, I righted myself and readied the spear, letting mana flow around it, infusing it in a shell of electrical energy.

The black cloud above me rippled, and a small dwarven body plummeted out of it, crashing into the ground nearby. I gave Mica one quick glance to ensure she was breathing, then cocked back my arm to throw. But Melzri was gone.

With a sound like the cracking of thin ice, the cloud above snapped. Darkness was replaced with fluttering white as it became a snowstorm, and I could see the entire landscape of the battle raging above.

Varay and Viessa were both stationary, each facing the other as they hovered a hundred feet overhead, their battle one entirely of will and magic.

The snow of the conjured storm was falling inward toward Viessa. Within it, the shapes of armed and armored men formed out of the gusting flakes, cutting and slashing all around her. Black scythes of wind countered, defending and destroying the conjured warriors as quickly as Varay could form them.

Several mages had gathered along the winding roads that curved around the cavern, and as one, they began casting spells at Viessa.

Helen Shard was firing arrows of burning light from one edge of the cavern with her band of adventurers at her back, each throwing spells of their own.

From another ledge, the Earthborn brothers were sending earthen spikes like stalactites at the Scythe. Beside them, Curtis and Kathyln Glayder were both casting defensive spells in the form of shields of ice and glowing golden panels of flame. The cavern shook with the roars of Curtis's world lion.

Adjusting my target, I threw the asuran spear.

It painted a bright red afterimage across the cavern, flying true toward Viessa's heart.

I sensed the flare of mana and took a jagged lightning-infused step away. The tendrils of electricity surging around me reached for the twin swords closing in on my neck.

It wasn't enough.

Black wind and fire cut through white lightning. Steel glinted hungrily.

Melzri had manifested out of the shadow right beside me. Her face was a mask of concentration.

Then the light was warping, the air hardening and turning to dark crystal around me, and in an instant, I was trapped, my entire body encased within a shell of black diamond.

The twin blades rang off the protective spell, lodged into the diamond, and stuck fast.

Through the opaque crystal, I could just see Melzri's silhouette spin around as a smaller shadow wielding an oversized hammer flew at her from the side. I felt each blow of the hammer shiver up through the ground

beneath me as the two exchanged strike after strike. I could also sense the strain on Mica's core as she pushed herself to her limits.

Whatever magic Viessa had used on her had left her weak. She was almost to the point of backlash.

The crystalline structure trapping me in place shattered.

Mica was on the ground, Melzri pinning her. The Scythe's hands were wrapped in bands of black fire, and each blow burned away a layer of Mica's flesh, leaving her face cracked and bleeding.

I channeled all the power of Thunderlord's Wrath and lunged, wrapping my arms around the Scythe. The lightning coiled around us both, pinning her to me as I yanked her away from Mica's prone form. Desperation fueled my strength, and I held on despite Melzri's power swelling in my arms, threatening to shatter me.

Her body burst into flames. Soulfire battered against the energy cladding my body and restraining her.

I began to tremble.

I couldn't hold the Scythe for long.

Then my mana winked out like a doused candle flame.

I was stumbling backward, Melzri still in my arms. Her soulfire was gone.

Together, we fell.

As I lay on my back, waiting for the pain to hit me, I saw what was happening above.

Varay was sagging, near the end of her strength. Viessa was winning the battle of wills, pushing back against Varay's conjured army, the lines of sharp black wind cutting closer and closer to where Varay hovered.

An arrow slipped through Viessa's defenses and sank into her thigh.

Then the pain hit.

I sucked in a choked gasp. A bloody hole had been ripped through my side just below my ribs. With no mana flowing through my channels to begin healing the wound, I felt the full force of it. Draped across my arm, Melzri stiffened, and her hand pressed against her ribs just below her chest, where

an identical wound had been ripped in her armor and flesh.

Without mana, I could no longer sense the spear, which had been returning at full speed while I'd grappled with Melzri. Knowing I couldn't deliver a blow, I'd done the only thing I could: held her and let my weapon come to us.

Melzri's twin swords lay several feet away, where they'd dropped from the Black Diamond Vault spell when it failed. I struggled to roll onto my side, one arm reaching out, but every nerve in my body flared with pain.

Sensing my movement, Melzri twisted to look at me. As if moving in slow motion, her fist clenched, and she drove it into the open wound in my side. We both yelled in agony.

Above, something was happening. I blinked several times, thinking perhaps it was my own delirium, but when I looked again, it was still happening.

Shadows were coalescing around Viessa and forming copies of her. One became two, then four, then eight, until the sky was full of visions of her. Everywhere I looked, spells were passing through the illusory copies.

Melzri was moving again. She rolled and kicked one leg over me, straddling my stomach. Her hands reached for my throat. I grabbed her wrists and tried to twist them one way or the other to shove her off me, but I lacked the strength. Both our arms shook with effort.

Over her shoulder, the Viessa copies were wavering in and out of focus, popping one by one, the air around them shivering with a kind of black static. Then it was just Varay and Viessa again.

Suddenly more spells were finding their marks. A squadron of dwarven guards had appeared, abandoning whatever position they were supposed to be guarding, and were flinging spells, filling the sky with projectiles. Viessa seemed shocked as an arrow pierced her arm, then wavered and nearly fell as a boulder twice her size slammed into her from the side. Her mouth was moving, but no sound came out.

"That's it!" Varay shouted, her voice projecting triumphantly throughout the cavern. "We're wearing her down. Focus fire! Everything you've got!"

Melzri relaxed suddenly and our arms snapped out to the side. Her head surged down and drove into my nose with a meaty *thunk*. My vision went

blurry, and then her fingers were around my throat.

“You’ve really surprised me.” Her words were ground out between gritted teeth. I pulled at her wrists, but my arms were weak and overtired. “It seems like you Lances learned a trick or three since fighting Cadell. This has almost…been…fun…” Her hands tightened as she spoke, and I could feel the heat in them, the vibration of her mana stirring back to life.

In the same moment, my own core thrummed as the spear’s mana-suppression effect began to wear off.

Something moved nearby. A small motion, but I saw the glint of a jet-black gemstone eye.

Just as Melzri’s hands lit up with soulfire, condensed bolts of lightning poured through my own hands and up her arms. I manipulated the currents to target and disable her muscles, aiming to paralyze her. Her body seized, her legs spasming and digging into my wound.

Her fingers clenched around my throat.

Her soulfire ate into my flesh.

Then a hammer larger than me slammed into the side of her head, knocking her to the ground. Before Melzri could recover, another blow landed, then another, driving the Scythe into the stones like a nail.

Mana flooded my body, lending strength to my muscles and dulling the pain of my wounds. I stood slowly.

Above, Viessa fell back, surrounding herself with shadowy shields, no longer able to counter the barrage of attacks.

The spear was nearby, half buried into the stone floor. I gave it a mental tug, and it wrenched free and flew to my hand.

Mica’s weapon stopped falling. Panting, she stumbled back from the crater she’d hammered into the courtyard tiles. I raised the spear, preparing to finish Melzri.

But the crater was empty.

A giggle escaped Mica’s bruised and bloody lips. “Mashed her to dust, heh.” Then she started to collapse.

I caught her and eased her to the ground. The conjured hammer dissolved, her will unable to hold the weapon's shape any longer.

"At least Varay seems to be winning," she said, her dilated eyes staring up at the fight above.

I knew Melzri was still here, illusioned into invisibility, but I couldn't help but follow Mica's gaze. She was right. Viessa's defenses were trembling now, the shields quaking and cracking as the Scythe reformed them over and over again.

Arrows, stones, bullets of wind, spears of ice, gouts of fire, and dozens of other spells all concentrated on the Scythe, but my attention was drawn to Varay.

She was flinging curved blades of ice at Viessa, one after another, each sinking into a shadowy shield before breaking and dissipating. She had a fierce, determined look as she simultaneously directed the attacks and flung spells of her own.

But I couldn't shake the sense that something was wrong.

Looking more closely, I watched the way her spells moved, and felt the sensation of all that mana crashing through the air.

My pulse spiked.

Varay had no mana signature.

"An illusion," I gasped, meeting Mica's confused gaze.

"Wuh?" Mica's eyes lost focus, then closed. "Oh, that feels bad. I'm just gonna…lie here and die, I think."

I looked from Mica to Varay—the real Varay, wrapped in the guise of Viessa, being crushed under a wave of spellfire—and then back. With Melzri still prowling around, leaving Mica alone could mean her death, but Varay was losing strength, being torn down by her own friends and soldiers…

"Curse you all for giving me *feelings*," I snapped, scooping Mica's unconscious body off the ground and throwing her over my shoulder, then lifting up into the air. I kept the spear ready in case Melzri attempted another sneak attack, but none came.

As I flew, I attempted to rearrange my expression, putting aside my anger and letting very real fear come forward. I thought of Virion, who had gone into hiding since reaching Vildorial, and my family, and the tremendous amount of mana still surging violently in the direction of the portal where Arthur was, and the distant tombstone encasing Aya's corpse.

And…I gave myself permission to feel it. To…break. Even for a moment.

Tears built up in my eyes and a knot of discomfort in the back of my throat. I flew slowly, taking a roundabout route to avoid coming between Varay and all the spells flying at her. Through the wall of shields, her Viessa form gave me a plaintive, hopeful look, and I could see just how close to failing she was.

I ignored her. I had no choice.

Instead, I approached the Varay I could see, the illusory skin wrapped around Viessa like a shield.

She looked at me warily, her eyes tracking across my face, lingering on the tears wetting my cheeks, and she relaxed. "She's almost done. Hold back, if you must. I'll finish this."

"V-Varay," I said, my voice catching. "It's Mica. She's dying."

Varay-Viessa glanced down at Mica. "Ah. Most…unfortunate." She squinted, looking closer. "She's breath—"

I thrust with the asuran spear.

Her lips curled back from her teeth in an animalistic snarl, and she spun away from the blow, her attacks already turning away from the real Varay toward me.

The spear, aimed for her core, cut wide, barely catching the fabric of her robes.

She caught the haft with one hand and slashed across my torso with her other, drawing a black line across my armor. Blood sprayed from the gash, spattering the false Varay's pale face.

I wrenched back on the spear and released a bolt of lightning along the handle.

Sparks jumped between Viessa's fingers, and her hand twitched.

The haft slid through her grip, and the blade carved a thin line across her palm.

She hissed, and her eyes flew wide open. She clawed the air in wild panic.

The illusions vanished. Across the cavern from us, Varay was huddled behind shields of ice, bleeding from dozens of wounds, her mana signature trembling weakly.

“Stop! Cease fire!” Helen Shard shouted, but her voice was drowned out by the noise of combat. Spellfire kept pounding Varay’s position.

Viessa was falling, her mouth open in a silent scream. Defenseless.

But Varay needed me.

Despite the blood running hot and fast from the wound across my torso, I flew up into the path of the spells and released a bright flash from the end of the spear. All the mages focused on Varay threw up their hands or turned away, and the bombardment was broken, even if only for an instant.

“Use your damned eyes!” I yelled, falling back into a protective position in front of Varay.

Far below, Viessa’s body was still plummeting. I held my breath.

A white-haired figure flew from between two first-level structures and scooped the Scythe out of the air, and I let out my breath in a curse.

“This fight isn’t over!” I shouted to the confused mages, focusing on Curtis Glayder, who I knew better than the rest of them. I pointed to where the two Scythes were streaking across the cavern below. “We need to—”

I was interrupted by the shattering of stone as a portion of the cavern wall collapsed.

Alacryan soldiers protected by transparent barriers of mana began rushing through.

“To the breach!” Varay ordered, swinging around and gathering her mana.

Melzri and Viessa floated to a stop over the army pouring into the city. “You haven’t won!” Melzri screamed, her face pale and pained. “You’re just losing slowly, Lances!”

As if to drive this point home, both Scythes flared with purple-tinged black

flames, and their wounds were wiped away. Dark eddies of wind were already beginning to reform around Viessa as her mana returned. Beneath them, dozens of battle groups quickly fell into formation.

Mica stirred but did not wake. Varay looked as if she might plummet out of the air at any moment. Our allies were pale and shaken as confusion gave way to horror at their attacks against Varay.

Distantly, I realized the signs of battle from the direction of the portal had ceased. I could not bring myself to hope for Arthur's victory, however.

There was motion all around as Varay still fought to organize what troops we had. Some were shouting for reinforcements. A few dwarven soldiers turned tail and ran.

I floated forward through the chaos and met Melzri's curdled-blood gaze. "Today, I saw fear in the eyes of a Scythe. That is enough."

She shook her head, bright hair swaying around dark horns, and smiled. "At least you will die brave, Lance."

"Alacryans." Viessa's voice cut through all other noise like a razor. "Advance—"

A purple flash lit up the highest level of the cavern. The entire world seemed to grind to a halt, all sound and motion ceasing.

At the high road's edge near the palace, Arthur Leywin stood armored in gold-rimmed black scales with onyx horns curling down from the sides of his head like a Vritra. He blazed with purple light, his blond hair lifting up from his head as if charged with static, bright runes burning purple beneath his eyes.

He stepped forward, closer to the edge, and each footfall was the beating of a war drum. The sound of it swelled in my chest, setting my heart racing and blood pumping with adrenaline.

The enemy, on the other hand, shrank. The Alacryan mages pulled back, huddling close behind their shields, frightened eyes turning to the Scythes.

The Scythes seemed to dim. The cutting wind around Viessa slowed. The mana around Melzri's weapons flickered and died.

The entire city held its breath.

Slowly, Arthur raised one hand. In it, he held a broad black horn that curled like a mountain ram's. He tossed it over the edge, and it seemed to fall unnaturally slowly, turning over again and again.

"Agrona has exhausted my patience," he said, his voice rolling like thunder through the cavern. The Scythes flinched backward, and a tremor ran through the Alacryan forces. "You have ten seconds." A breath. "Nine."

The Alacryans broke. Men shouted as they stamped and shoved, bowling over one another in an effort to retreat back through the raw hole in the cavern wall.

"Eight."

Melzri and Viessa floated up slightly. Viessa was impassive, but Melzri struggled and failed to maintain her composure. Together, they bowed slightly, then turned and flew out of the cavern, over the heads of their retreating soldiers.

"Seven. Six. Five."

No, I thought, sudden realization waking me from my stupor. "Why…are you letting them live? We need to *kill* them," I wheezed, but Arthur couldn't hear me.

It took longer than the promised ten seconds, but the rest of the Alacryans were allowed to flee in peace. No Dicathian moved a muscle to stop them. Most were not even watching their exodus but were staring up at the glowing figure of Arthur Leywin instead.

Then they were gone. Just like that—the battle won.

I let out a weary sigh and began floating up toward Arthur. I didn't know what to say or how to say it, only that I needed to acknowledge him.

Before I reached him, his golden eyes rolled up toward the cavern roof, then back into his head.

He stumbled back a step, then collapsed to the ground.

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SOVEREIGN'S QUARREL

CAERA DENOIR

Scythe Seris's soft steps were entirely silent against the stone stairs in front of me while retainer Cylrit's were barely a whisper behind, making my own echoing footfalls sound cacophonous in the long, winding stairwell beneath her Sehz-Clar estate.

Dark gray stone pressed in around us, making the narrow stairs feel even more cramped and claustrophobic. It was as though I could feel the weight of the cliffside compound looming above us, tons upon tons of rock, soil, and sandstone all supported at the top of these impossibly long and narrow stairs…

"Your silence surprises me," Scythe Seris said over her shoulder. "I'm sure you have questions." Her composed presence seemed at odds with the rushed, furtive nature of my visit to Sehz-Clar, which only enhanced the sense of anticipation and worry building in me.

"Too many," I replied quietly.

Despite having had nothing *but* questions wheeling like a deranged flock of halcyons through my head since the Victoriad, all of them were knotted together, and I found it difficult to untangle one from the next to ask them.

What do I need *to know?* I asked myself. *Which of my questions are more than mere curiosity?*

"Is Grey really from the other continent?" I asked finally.

"He is," Scythe Seris answered nonchalantly.

I bit my lip as I considered this fact. It was the answer I had expected after everything my blood had discovered, but it only served to further confuse my many other questions.

“Did you know the entire time?”

“I did,” she said simply.

“Doesn’t that put you—all of us—in danger?” This wasn’t really the question I meant to ask, but it slipped out nonetheless, my tone one of disbelief with no small amount of trepidation.

“It does,” came the deadpan reply.

I barely managed to bite back a scoff. “Are you going to answer any of my questions with more than two words?”

“We’ll see,” she said, an edge of humor creeping into her voice.

Behind me, Cylrit stifled a laugh, and I shot him a thinly veiled look of annoyance over my shoulder. Despite this exchange providing absolutely no new insight, it was clear that, despite her goading, Seris had no intention of divulging any real information yet.

I could only assume I was present in Sehz-Clar for a reason, and so I chose to be quiet and patient until she revealed her purpose.

There were no more interruptions as we wound down into the depths. Eventually, the stairway ended in a large square of iron inset in the wall at its base. It looked like a door, but there were no handles or hinges, only a dully glowing mana crystal on the wall. Scythe Seris wasted no time, raising one hand to the teal crystal and pushing mana into it before Cylrit and I had even stepped off the bottommost stair.

The wall hummed, then gave a clunk that was more physical impact than noise, and finally the door began to lift up from the ground and recede into a gap above it with a mechanical whir.

I stepped up beside my mentor and stared into the room beyond.

A series of floor-to-ceiling glass tubes filled a massive industrial space. The tubes each glowed electric blue, their light reflecting off the white walls, floor, and ceiling of the room to give the entire chamber a surreal air.

Scythe Seris walked into the room and approached the closest tube. As I followed, I saw that, in a grated trough around the tube's base, it was heated by piles of glowing orange rocks that gave off a sulfurous stink and enough heat to keep me well back. Translucent bubbles rose through whatever liquid was inside.

Glass tubes as thin as my pinky finger left the artifact in a dozen different places, some connecting to identical adjacent artifacts, others running up into the ceiling or the walls, a few tracing along one wall toward a panel of devices midway into the room: gauges, projection panels, and mana crystals, the purpose of which were a mystery to me.

One thing was quite clear, however.

"So much mana…" The bright blue liquid radiated mana more intensely than the orange rocks radiated heat. "Is it some kind of…storage device? Like…liquid mana crystals?"

"Yes, that is exactly right," she said with no little pride. "Only, these batteries are infinitely more expandable and can be manufactured en masse with the appropriate resources."

I closed my eyes and let my senses wander, basking in the glow of the compacted mana swimming within the devices. "It's amazing."

"It's…important," Scythe Seris started, a note of hesitancy in her voice.

My eyes snapped open, and I stared at her in concern. She met my eye for a moment, then shot Cylrit a glance and made a small gesture with her hand. He bowed, turned on his heel, and marched out of the room.

A moment later, the door clunked again and slowly slid back into place.

Scythe Seris clasped her hands behind her back and began slowly maneuvering around the outer edge of the room. I followed, watching her carefully, the creeping nervousness I'd been feeling since arriving in Aedelgard City returning with a startling suddenness.

"Do you know what the Wraiths are, Caera?"

"Half-blood Vritra warriors secretly guarding Alacrya from the other asura clans," I answered immediately. "I've always assumed they were just a scary story for children."

Scythe Seris gave me a rare smile. "They are quite real, I'm afraid.

Agrona's secret army, the children of Vritra clan basilisks and Alacryans with fully manifested blood. Their reputation as boogeymen is intentional on Agrona's part. Not to scare Alacryans, no, he has no need of that to keep order on this continent, but to build a wall of uncertainty between him and the other asura."

At first, I didn't understand how these Wraiths could possibly strike fear into the hearts of full-blooded asura like the Sovereigns or Agrona himself. Even a Scythe like Seris was no match for a Sovereign—she'd told me so herself—so how strong could these Wraiths be?

And then I registered her words. "A wall of uncertainty? You're suggesting that they really *are* scarecrows, then? Boogeymen, as you put it. A force meant to scare off the other asura, not necessarily fight them."

"They even take their name from ancient asuran legend," Scythe Seris mused, her eyes drifting to the bubbles rolling up through the electric-blue mana containment tubes. "A little on the nose of Agrona, if you ask me, but effective. Don't mistake this for a lack of strength, however. The Wraiths *are* trained asura killers. A strong squad is capable of taking down even an accomplished asuran warrior."

I felt goosebumps raise across the back of my neck.

Scythe Seris stopped in front of the panel of devices and glass tubes. "And Agrona has sent one such squad to Dicathen—to hunt down and capture Grey if possible, or kill him if not." My heart sank, and I looked at my mentor in dread, but before I could respond, she added, "But they failed. And then, because he's nothing if not showy, he appeared via portal in the heart of Vechor and obliterated an entire military base, killing a few hundred battle groups and several battalions of unads."

I leaned into the wall and rested my head against it, coming to the realization just how thoroughly I had overestimated my own understanding of the world I lived in. It had seemed a near impossibility when Grey had defeated not one but two Scythes before immediately escaping the High Sovereign himself. But to slay five Wraiths…

"If Agrona is trying to capture Grey, then he must want answers of some kind. About aether." This thought was instantly confirmed by the dire look on Scythe Seris's face.

"But Agrona will not let his greed for knowledge interrupt his other

plans," she said, flicking one of the small tubes, setting the glass to ringing and the little bubbles wobbling. "He is growing tired of the conflict in Dicathen and is ready to abandon his initial plans to subdue and utilize the continent's population."

"So he'll wipe them all out," I said, staring down at my feet. "And Grey with them."

There was one thing I couldn't puzzle out for myself. It was a question I was afraid to ask, but so much else hinged on knowing my mentor's purpose. "Why risk certain and horrible death by hiding Grey's identity, working with him? You are directly opposing the High Sovereign himself. Isn't this…treason? Betraying Alacrya?"

Scythe Seris let out a bitter laugh that startled me. "We are saving Alacrya, child. Which is why you're really here."

I gave her a questioning look, and she reached out and took my hand.

"It is my turn to pose a question to you, Caera. Knowing now who Grey is, can you still support him? If he stood here now and asked for it, would you offer him your allegiance?"

I hesitated. The truth was, I wasn't yet sure. My feelings toward him were already complicated, and knowing he had lied about who he was for the entire time I knew him didn't help that. But…I wasn't exactly sure what it really changed, either.

"My allegiance is with you, Scythe Seris," I said after a long pause.

Some difficult to parse emotion flashed across her face—gratitude, pride, surprise, I wasn't entirely sure—and she squeezed my hand. "Then listen carefully. If we hope to help Grey and Dicathen, we must keep Agrona's attention in Alacrya. Very shortly, Sovereign Orlaeth of Sehz-Clar will arrive to inspect this machine I have built. But it is not what I've promised him."

I felt the color drain from my face as my heart fluttered against my ribs.

"The mana input system for the device is a trap," Scythe Seris said, a dark light flashing in her eyes. "It will draw his mana out of him, weakening him enough that I can deal with him. Be wary of your thoughts, however. Orlaeth is powerfully empathic, and he will sense it if you do not control your emotions."

My stomach sank. “You expect me to shroud my emotions from a Sovereign?” I asked, the high pitch of my voice giving away my fear.

Scythe Seris released me and took a step back. “I have not brought you here without reason, Caera. You and Cylrit, your emotions will provide much-needed noise to keep Orlaeth from focusing entirely on me.”

I glanced back at the door. “Your retainer doesn’t know this part of the plan, does he?”

“Clever,” she said with an approving nod. “He is purposefully being kept blind to my true intentions so that his emotions will contradict your own.”

“And…” I hesitated, not wanting to question her judgment, but unable to move past my fear.

“If you fail?” Scythe Seris asked, picking up the thread of my thought. “There is a second layer to the plan. Orlaeth is a genius. My trap is well hidden, but if he senses your anxiety and fear or sees through the ruse, he may not take my bait.” I thought I sensed a hint of trepidation in the way Scythe Seris’s voice constricted, which only heightened my own. “But all I need him to do is use his mana, even if not on the machine directly. That will be enough.”

“Scythe Seris, I—”

“Please, Caera. My name is Seris. After today, no one will call me Scythe.”

She held my gaze, the weight of her presence both a balm and a burden.

I jumped as heavy pounding came from the metal door, and she rose one brow questioningly.

“It is time. Come.”

Just like that, she whisked past me and led us from the chamber, only briefly stopping to open and then reseal the door. Cylrit was waiting at the base of the stairs, and together we began the long climb back up to her estate.

Under different circumstances, I would have been thrilled to explore Seris’s estate. I had only been once before and remembered it as a sprawling mansion that dwarfed even Highblood Denoir’s home. Now, I had no mind for the details, following her mechanically as I struggled to

order both my thoughts and emotions, a task made only more difficult by a quickly approaching aura that seemed to shadow the entire city of Aedelgard.

Our quick march took us from the stairs through a series of hallways and arched openings, past a sprawling atrium, and into a large, almost empty space that opened onto twin balconies overlooking the cliffs that ringed the Vritra's Maw Sea.

Dozens upon dozens of rugs in every shape, size, and color imaginable had been strategically laid out over top of the sandstone flooring, and a plush chair, almost a throne, sat central against the back wall, directly opposite the narrow gap between the two balconies.

Next to the throne was another series of devices and artifacts similar to those in the mana storage facility below, though instead of gauges there were a series of mana crystals of different shapes and sizes and several tightly wound coils of a silvery blue metal I didn't recognize.

I turned my attention away from the panel, trying to neither think about nor feel anything regarding its existence. It had nothing to do with me, and I knew nothing about it.

And I certainly don't know that my lifelong mentor is attempting to use this device to overpower a Sovereign, I thought, unable to entirely squash the racing of my pulse.

There was blessedly little time for my worries to build, however, as the growing pressure soon reached its crescendo.

Only once before had I felt such a complete and overpowering presence, and that was Agrona himself in the moments after Grey's disappearance from the Victoriad.

Cylrit took me firmly by one arm, and I realized I had been standing frozen in the middle of the room. He maneuvered me to the side of the throne, away from the strange artifacts, and I could think of nothing other than to let him.

Seris moved with unconcerned elegance out onto the balcony and waited for the source of that killing intent to arrive.

When the man landed on the balcony opposite her, however, he did not crash down like a meteor, but barely touched the balcony before striding

into the room, his irritation so palpable I felt it like a whip across my back.

I had never seen Sovereign Orlaeth in the flesh. I had only ever seen portraits of him during my studies of the Sovereigns that every Alacryan child was tasked to do.

It didn't prepare me for the sight of him.

The man—if such a simple term was appropriate for one of the asura—was tall, but not inhumanly so, and incredibly reedy. But it was hard to register anything at all past his heads, for he had two of them.

Despite my fear, which seemed to be bubbling up from somewhere deep inside me in a constantly upheaving well of uncertainty and self-doubt, I couldn't help but be fascinated by the sight of him.

The two heads were each covered in a mop of dark hair, and each had two horns on the outside of the head. The lower horns pointed outward to the sides, while the upper pair pointed straight up before curving slightly. On the inside of his left head, mostly hidden beneath his unkempt hair, were the stubs of two more horns, and I couldn't help but wonder if he'd somehow used them to create his other head.

The two faces looked nearly identical, though the heads themselves were offset, further suggesting that the rightmost head had been attached after the fact. Their expressions, however, could not have been more different. The right head took in the three of us with cool, calculating efficiency. Its red eyes—which were slightly darker than the other's—lingered on me, and all the feelings that had been roiling in me since the Victoriad surged to the surface with such force that I nearly vomited in my mouth.

And suddenly, something made sense. The power and sense of my doubt and anxiety…it wasn't entirely me. The feeling I'd felt since heading down the stairs into Seris's laboratory was an effect of the Sovereign. He was, quite literally, drawing my emotions out of me.

So he can more easily read them. I swallowed heavily and tried to set my head and heart straight. Seris was relying on me. I wouldn't fail her.

The left head didn't so much as glance at any of us, its furious scowl turned to the panel of artifacts on the other side of the throne.

"Sovereign Orlaeth," Scythe Seris said respectfully, "thank you for—"

“You said the systems were ready for my examination, Seris,” the leftmost head snapped. Then, as if speaking to the right head, it added, “The situation in Vechor is tenuous. First the Victoriad, now this assault. Kiros looks weak. He will lash out, could attack Sehz-Clar again if the High Sovereign abandons the other continent. And with the treaty with Epheotus broken, it is only a matter of time before they launch a counteroffensive. If this lesser reincarnate can strike in the middle of our dominions, then Indrath certainly can. They may even decide to target *us* instead of the High Sovereign, to weaken him before all-out war.”

“The High Sovereign has outmaneuvered Indrath at every turn,” the right head answered. “With our gift, we will prove our loyalty and usefulness. He will side with us against Vechor, if necessary, and ensure we are protected from the other clans.”

“Assuming the lessuran has succeeded in her task,” the left snapped again. Both heads turned toward Seris, one pinched and glaring, the other lifting its brows curiously.

Scythe Seris bowed deeply. “Forgive the delay, Sovereign. It turned out the component we needed was hidden beneath the desert in Dicathen—a peculiar mineral that gathers and condenses fire-attribute mana. With it—”

“Begin the demonstration,” Orlaeth’s left head barked, and I couldn’t help the low moan that escaped my lips at his spike of intent.

Seris’s jaw tightened for a heartbeat. She recovered almost instantly and took several steps toward me. “Caera, perhaps you would be more comfortable in the atrium…”

She doubts me, I realized, and it felt as though a fist were crushing my heart. *We’ve barely begun, her plan isn’t even in motion yet, and already I am failing her.*

“No,” Orlaeth’s right head said firmly. “She should stay.”

Although he spoke to Seris, his gaze had settled on me again, and I could feel his power forcing my emotions to the surface. I turned my thoughts away from the Sovereign, from Seris, from the machine, the trap, the plan, all of it.

Feigning indifference at his gaze, I looked inward for something else to focus on. So, I let my mind settle where it had so often turned since the Victoriad.

I thought of Grey. I was almost surprised by the overwhelming strength of emotions that responded to this thought, foremost among them the cutting edge of betrayal. He had *lied*, again and again. About *everything*.

In the background, I remained dimly aware of Seris and the Sovereign's movement.

"Of course, Sovereign," Seris had said before marching purposefully to the series of devices and artifacts I had noticed upon first entering the room. "This will mark the first full-scale test of the system, although all prior small-scale tests have been successful—"

"Seris," Orlaeth's left head snapped, "I understand the protocol, which I developed, and the shielding array in question, which I ordered *you* to create."

"Her unnecessary verbosity is for the benefit of the lessers," the right head noted. "Her retainer is confused and concerned with the lack of information she has given him, and the unmanifested Vritra-blood is struggling to constrain her emotions by focusing on"—his nose wrinkled in distaste—"a man."

I turned away from his inhumanly piercing gaze. Next to me, Cylrit was stoic and unmoving as a statue. *As if he were glared at by a Sovereign every day.* Despite how my heart hammered at the inside of my chest, I attempted to emulate the retainer.

Grey, I thought, refocusing on my best attempt at a distraction. Logically, it wasn't fair to be angry with him over his lies. Of course he'd lied, he couldn't tell me the truth of his identity. He hadn't even been the one to seek out a partnership with me; I'd pursued him, even magically tracked him down after our chance meeting in the Relictombs. And hadn't I also lied about my identity? If anyone were to understand lying for the sake of protection, it would be me. How long might I have kept up my Haedrig persona if the Relictombs itself hadn't intervened?

I hadn't fully understood what I was getting myself into by partnering with him, but I knew he tried to keep me at a distance, tried to keep me from getting too close. I'd accepted him despite not knowing the details of his life. The fact that he was born on another continent didn't change anything.

Seris's magic flared as she sent pulses of mana into several different

crystals. Lights played through the crystals and glass tubes like the glimmer of many-colored stars, reflecting off the white walls and filling the room with color. A deep hum began to resonate upward as the mechanism driving the shield generator came to life far below us, and the edge of a transparent ripple began to rise from the cliff's edge.

I held my breath, momentarily forgetting everything else.

"Mana fluctuation seems in line with expectations," Orlaeth's left head muttered. "Output is flagging, though. Shield density is at less than half of what I'd calculated."

It was beautiful in its *raw power*. Like a soap bubble, the expanding edge of the shield refracted the sun's light and swirled with all the colors of the visible spectrum, giving the impression that it was harnessing the energy of the sun itself.

And then…the low hum became a harsh grinding, and the shield's surface melted away in a sudden liquid vibration, large uneven patches dissipating before the entire structure finally collapsed with a defeated *pop*.

My held breath hissed out.

Sovereign Orlaeth's left head burst out with a judgmental huff, and he crossed his arms. "There is a problem with the output. The battery array is supplying significantly less mana than it should be. A failure of the activation matrix to properly align all mana batteries."

The right head was quiet, its expression thoughtful. The dark red eyes were unfocused, and it didn't respond to the other's musings.

"Forgive me, Sovereign," Seris was saying, her voice carrying a pleading edge I'd never heard from her before. "You must be right, of course. Perhaps some miscalculation in the alignment of the—"

"Quiet," the right head ordered, not the waspish barbs of the left head, but a thrumming command that forced Seris's jaws to snap audibly shut.

Stars burst behind my eyes as the Sovereign's intent pressed at my temples.

Inundated in a wash of my own emotions, I decided in that moment to forgive Grey. My reasons for fighting at his side had never been patriotic, and I'd never seen sense in the Dicathian war. I was no fawning tool for

the Vritra. Grey was the source of the power I was looking for. He'd conquered aether in a way even the dragons couldn't. Heightened or not, I couldn't allow my emotions—that simplistic sense of hurt feelings—to distract me from what really mattered.

If it took a Dicathian to protect Alacrya from the Vritra, then so be it. There was even a kind of sense to it, really. Alacryans had been bred like pets for the Vritra clan, simultaneously wogarts and weapons. *Who among us would truly ever be capable of fighting back? Of breaking Agrona's hold over the continent?*

Seris, I realized. She was risking everything to do exactly that. And *she* supported Grey.

I stifled a gasp at the train of my thoughts, and I risked a glance over at the two great powers of this dominion. Orlaeth was running his index finger along various parts of the device, his leftmost face pinched into a thoughtful frown. His lips were moving rapidly as he muttered silently to himself. One hand tugged absently at the lowest of his mismatched antlers.

But his right was staring at me.

Suddenly all thought of Grey fell away, and all I could think of was the Sovereign's fingertips tracing along the activation matrix. When would Seris spring the trap? Was it truly capable of disabling even an asura? What if it failed? I felt an intense insistence that, in that moment, I wasn't ready to die…

"Stop," the right head said, and for a moment, I thought Orlaeth was speaking to me.

The left stopped, his fingers pulling back from the activation matrix.

"This is a trap," the right said.

No, I thought desperately, panic stealing the breath from my lungs. *I've given it away; I've failed; I've—*

My eyes widened in horror as tears blurred my vision before streaming down my cheeks. Frozen stiff, I could do nothing except mutter in dismay, "I'm…s-so sorry, S-Seris. So s-sorry…"

Frustration intermingled with the unbridled terror overtaking me, the understanding that the Sovereign was forcing this outpouring of emotion

on me clear in the logical part of my mind, and yet I was entirely unable to protect myself against it.

Bitterness welled up as I considered how Seris had at least prepared for my failure by having a fallback plan in place.

Orlaeth stood and took a step back from the activation matrix. “Yes, of course. In my haste I nearly missed it. See this? The mana acquisition coils have been tampered with, and these crystals here. Once they begin drawing off my mana, it would create a high-pressure loop in conjunction with empty mana batteries to forcefully draw out all my mana and store it.”

“Leaving us helpless to defend ourselves,” the right head confirmed, its tone growing dark.

Turning unhurriedly, Orlaeth raised a hand, and I felt myself relax at the fact that at least the second part of the plan would still happen, whatever it was.

“Relief? Wait…” the right head said, and the hand froze. Slowly, the left head turned around to look askance at the right. “There is something else.”

Both sets of eyes swept the space, tracing across every surface, every curve and line. Then Orlaeth kicked aside a rug, revealing a network of silver-blue metal running between the tiles beneath. “As I thought. Look. The mana acquisition system has been spread throughout the entire room. If we use mana here, it will start the process.”

The left head’s expression softened, growing curious, but the right head was glowering fiercely, his face so dangerous and menacing that I couldn’t bear to look at it. “You always have aimed far too high for your station, Seris. It is a shame that your cleverness couldn’t keep up with your ambition.”

Suddenly the Sovereign turned, ripped the heavy chair from its place against the wall, and dashed it against the activation matrix. Glass shattered, metal bent and sheared, and mana crystals burst and sent sparks flashing through the room.

I flinched away belatedly, instinctively releasing mana to clad my skin as I prepared to defend myself, but Orlaeth took no notice at all, and I knew why.

I'm an insect to him, no more dangerous than a mana fly…

"It's a façade," the left head told the right as Orlaeth's fingers wriggled through the air like he was following the trails of mana moving through the room. "All the mechanisms required for the trap to spring are still in place below us."

The right head sneered. "You've been practicing your ability to shroud your emotions, Seris. Clearly, you've put great effort into this trap. As much as I'd enjoy breaking your bones with my bare hands, it seems likely you've accounted for that, too." The sneer became a cruel smile. "It would be more appropriate that your servants do it for me, considering."

While everything had been happening, Seris had slowly backed away and was now standing near the middle of the rug-covered floor. Despite Orlaeth's cold fury crushing the oxygen from the room, she was outwardly calm. "It appears you've seen through each of my machinations, Sovereign. I should have known I couldn't surpass your intellect. I won't apologize for trying, though. You asura are a pox upon this world, and you deserve everything that is coming for you."

"Spoken with the true bravado of a lesser." Orlaeth's right head looked over his shoulder to Cylrit and me. When he spoke, it was again with a tone of such command that it felt like a physical force. "Lessers. Bring me her horns."

I stood and reached for my blade. I couldn't help it. Suddenly, all the conflicting emotions Orlaeth had forced to surface were submerged beneath a glass-smooth shell of subservience.

Cylrit was faster. He flashed past, his rune-etched blade hissing as it cut the air.

Orlaeth growled as he reached up and caught the blade. Confusion ground my movements to a halt, and I could only stare.

He had attacked the Sovereign. But that was wrong. The Sovereign had commanded…Seris's horns…to do anything else was *wrong*.

Orlaeth's wrist twisted, ripping the blade from Cylrit's hand. In the same motion, he swung the blade like a club, striking Cylrit across the chest and sending him tumbling end over end across the room, then crashing through the wall and out of sight.

The right head stared into my eyes. “Bring. Me. Her. Horns.”

My entire body trembled as I tried to separate who I was and what I wanted from the puppet Orlaeth sought to make of me. One leg stepped forward of its own accord, while one hand released its grip on the blade.

“You won’t break her.” Seris’s voice sounded distant. “She’s one of the strongest people I’ve ever met. Even you Vritra can’t turn her into something she isn’t.”

These words echoed around in my mind as my body half dragged itself toward her.

At any other moment in my life, I would have gushed over with mushy silliness to hear such glowing words from my mentor, but now, I felt only the bitter reality that either she would be forced to kill me in defense of her own life, or she would let me strike her down, because, despite her words, I did not feel strong enough to resist the Sovereign’s command.

Even you Vritra can’t turn her into something she isn’t.

My lurching forward progress slowed further. What did those words mean? Was she trying to tell me something? Some hint at how to break the spell, how to resist?

Seris had given me an option to live my own life. When the entire Alacryan apparatus was designed to create, foster, and make use of people exactly like me, Seris opened the door for me to choose my own path. Without her, my entire existence would have been spent doing exactly what Agrona or some other Vritra commanded.

I refused to be anyone’s tool.

My body ground to a halt, trapped between the conflicting signals it was receiving, unable to move forward, unable to resist.

“So it would seem, Seris. Interesting.”

Orlaeth’s right head watched me, his gaunt features softening as his curiosity won out. The left head seemed to take over. Its guise of irritated, put-upon genius scientist faded away as he held up Cylrit’s weapon, and I saw the truth of the asura’s power, for they were not one thing, not definable by a single trait, but were grace and strength and authority and divinity entwined, never sacrificing one aspect for another, embodying

each simultaneously.

If I weren't paralyzed by my own resistance to the Sovereign's powers, I might have laughed. Death made us lessers philosophical, apparently.

"Then I suppose I'll have to deal with you myself," Orlaeth's left head said tiredly as he closed in on Seris and thrust Cylrit's sword.

Several things happened all at once, and it took far too long for my sluggish perception to catch up with the scene.

The blade ran effortlessly through Seris's collarbone, sticking out of her back and staining the rugs beneath her with a splash of hot blood.

Using one foot, Seris kicked aside one corner of a plum-colored rug, revealing a dull silver-blue plate inset in the floor beneath it. A short spike sprang up from the plate, and Seris stomped down hard onto the spike so that it plunged into and through her foot, its bloody point sticking up into the air.

With a driven commitment, Seris grabbed Orlaeth's wrist in both hands and pulled the sword deeper into her. Blood spurted between her lips, staining them crimson as they curved upward into the barest hint of a smile.

A sphere of inky gray-black mana wrapped around their joined hands. I could feel in my core how her nullification magic struggled against the overwhelming surge of mana boiling out from the Sovereign.

"Stop!" the right head shouted to the left, but too late.

The effect was instantaneous.

The force of command driving me forward released, and I fell sprawling onto the floor, my head suddenly spinning. Mana began to pour from the Sovereign in rivers and floods, passing through Seris and into a network of channels that ran down into the floor beneath us.

There was a surge as Orlaeth attempted to withdraw his mana, but the tugging force only strengthened.

"Get your lessuran hands off me," the Sovereign hissed from both heads, struggling backward, but the blade resisted him, some pulling force of its own keeping it firmly lodged in Seris's body, and the black sphere seemed to be binding his hand to the blade.

Seris was grinning with blood beneath her teeth. “Spoken with the true bravado of an asura.”

The back of Orlaeth’s hand crashed across Seris’s cheek, and for an instant I thought her strength would fail as her magic flickered and her body trembled. The hand rose for a second blow, but before it could fall, Cylrit was there. The retainer struggled to pin down Orlaeth’s arm with the full weight of his body, his eyes flickering between Seris and me, determined but searching for answers.

I tried to push myself up, but my head swam dangerously. All I could do was watch as more and more mana was drawn from the Sovereign. And as it was, he seemed to weaken, unable to shake off Cylrit or break his connection with Seris. The struggle dragged on and on, and I thought for sure one side or the other would fail, but now I saw it.

Seris didn’t need to *defeat* the asura, simply outlast him until…

The machinery underneath the compound hummed back to life, and out beyond the balcony, the shields started rising over the cliffside once again.

“Look, Sovereign, your shields are working,” Seris said, causing blood to leak from the corner of her mouth.

“The High Sovereign…will have your…core…for this,” the left head groaned weakly. With his next breath, the last of his mana left his body.

Seris dragged herself off Cylrit’s blade and stumbled back, her foot leaving the spike with a wet squelching sound, a hand pressed to her chest as blood poured between her fingers.

Cylrit twisted the Sovereign’s arms, forcing him to drop the sword, and then slammed him face-first into the ground.

Seris sagged without Orlaeth and the blade holding her up, and I realized how insubstantial her mana signature was, wavering like a candle flame in a stiff breeze. But she didn’t fall.

Her eyes sought out mine. “Where does your allegiance lie, Caera? And… what are you willing to do to prove it?”

“It has to be now!” Cylrit growled, shaking with effort as the asura struggled in his grip.

I looked dumbly at the scarlet blade, dull against the bright blue rug

beneath it.

Pushing mana into my extremities to give myself strength, I pointedly didn't think about the way my hand felt gripping the handle of my sword or how many steps it took to close the distance to the asura or the weight of the blade as I lifted it over my head.

"Take…the left head," Seris said as she let out a shuddering breath.

Instinct pushed soulfire into my blade to strengthen the blow, and then it was a black-wreathed red streak. I didn't think about the way the blade jerked entering the asura's flesh or the dead sound of the head landing on a royal-purple rug.

The second head let out a gargled screech, and its eyes rolled back into its head. The body spasmed, gushing blood from the gaping wound, and Cylrit released it.

Orlaeth slumped, unmoving but still alive, ambient mana already being drawn like breath into his body.

I stuck the point of my blade into the floor and leaned against it, breathing heavily. There was a faint buzzing in my ears as the sudden surge of adrenaline wore off and my emotions slowly settled. The effects of the Sovereign's presence were fading, leaving me oddly calm, considering.

Cylrit, already on his knees, rolled over to lie on his back beside the asura and let his eyes drift closed.

"What now?" I asked hollowly.

Seris wiped the blood from her lips. "Now…we prepare for war."

393

BENEATH TAEGRIN CAELUM

NICO SEVER

My feet pounded along the bare floor of the long hallway. It was so, so long…had it been this long before? The pale lights blinking on and off, on and off…

I could hear them, the idiots in the crowd, cheering as if my entire world wasn't about to end, as if he wasn't going to kill her. When had my friend become so blinded by his desire to rule?

In the distance, I could just see the miniscule arch of a paler light at the end of this tunnel that seemed to stretch from the beginning of my life straight to its end.

Something moved to my right, and I flinched away from it, then slowed, my rushed steps becoming an awkward sideways shuffle as I tried to both stay still to watch and continue to move forward. Through a sort of window in the hallway wall, an image was playing.

A group of adventurers were gathered in a small clearing in the woods. *The Beast Glades*, I remembered. Introductions were being made to a young boy in a white mask that covered his face, but not the telltale auburn hair draped around it. "Elijah Knight. A-class, dark orange conjurer. Single specialization in earth."

The voice shivered through me like an electrical shock. It was *my* voice, except…it also wasn't. This was *my* memory, but not. Elijah Knight had been my false name growing up in Dicathen, when my real self was subdued, hidden—no, *taken* from me.

I'd thought most of these older memories were buried. I'd purged them. Elijah's purpose had been to grow close with Arthur, but he was weak, a tool that had served its purpose and been tossed aside. That wasn't me. *He* wasn't me. These weren't my memories.

I could hear Grey and Cecilia fighting in the distance. The sounds of their blades hammered against one another, each resounding clang a near-death blow in my electrified nerve-wracked mind.

I began to run again.

More memories of Elijah Knight's brief life flashed by to either side: the Dire Tombs, Xyrus Academy, his growing bond with Arthur, the kindness from the Leywins and Helsteas, Tessia Eralith…

Enough with these things, I ordered. *I don't care. I don't want these memories.*

"What a mess," one of the lights said, flickering nervously.

I slowed again, staring at it. Since when did lights speak?

"This? I thought it cleaned up well enough. A few more hours and he won't even know he was cut open," a man said, his voice coming from a television screen tucked away in the corner between the shallow ceiling and unadorned wall of the endless hallway.

"Didn't you hear? Vechor was attacked. A staging area for the war in Dicathen completely wiped off the map," the light answered with a pulse of brightness.

"You know I've been down here for days. I haven't heard anything. What time is it, even?" The man on the television looked around, a comically weary expression on his face. "We've been the only ones down here for hours. I'm tired as a wogart boar after breeding season."

"Sovereigns. You're gross sometimes, you know that?"

Below the screen, a window into another memory showed young Arthur stepping into the room we'd shared at Xyrus Academy. "Arthur!" Elijah yelled, grabbing Arthur firmly.

"There, there. Yes, I'm still alive. You can't get rid of me that easily," came the sarcastic response.

“I know,” Elijah said with a wet sniffle. “You’re like a cockroach.”

I had been so thrilled to have my best friend back. Bile rose up in my throat. *The* best friend *who murdered my one true love…*

“No,” I ground out through clenched teeth, tears welling up from the corners of my eyes. “I don’t care about any of this. Where is Cecil? Show me Cecilia!”

I felt the light grow brighter, almost like it was leaning toward me. “Did he say something?” it asked.

“Shit, let’s finish cleaning him up and get him back to his room,” the man in the television said. “Agrona won’t be happy if he wakes up on the table, and I sure don’t want to be the one to explain what happened.”

Wakes up? I thought, repeating the words to myself. Why would…

A dream, I realized with a jolt. Only a stupid dream.

Wake up!

My eyes snapped open. The damp-darkened stone of a low ceiling filled my vision. Two blindingly bright lighting artifacts on moveable stands were illuminating my bare, blood-covered torso. There was a cross-shaped incision over my sternum, the edges raw as the flesh slowly knit itself back together, the entire wound shining with a chemical-smelling ointment.

A woman in red robes approached, focused on wetting a square of cloth from a bowl on a table next to me. She met my eye and froze. Her mouth opened, but no sound came out.

I tried to move and realized my wrists were shackled to the table. Kicking out experimentally, I confirmed my legs were as well. I tensed. The thick leather creaked as I strained against it. A feeling of panic boiled up inside me as my strength flagged, then the bindings finally snapped, and there was a loud *ping* as a rivet ricocheted off the wall.

The woman let out a startled gasp, and the other voice cursed as something metallic clattered to the ground.

“S-Scythe N-Nico,” the woman sputtered, taking a step back and bowing.

With my free hand, I unstrapped my other wrist and sat up.

I was resting on a cold metal table at the center of a sterile, largely empty room. The air pressed close around me, heavy with moisture. The woman slowly lowered her rag back into its bowl, which sat on a small bench next to a tray of tools, some still slick with blood. A larger table was pressed against one wall, and several implements I didn't immediately recognize were arrayed across it, along with an open notebook.

Metal scraped on the ground, and I turned to see a man in the same white robes. He was slowly putting several metal pins back onto a tray that he must have dropped when I woke.

"What did you say?" I asked, but when the man looked confused, I realized it had been some time since anyone had spoken. "What don't you want to explain?"

I wasn't sure what was happening or where I was. The last thing I remembered, I'd been in Vechor, and—

Grey!

My hand went to the cross cut into my sternum. I reached for my mana, a half-remembered nightmare of my core being destroyed lapping at the edges of my mind.

My core felt strange. Distant, both mine and not mine. *Just like the Elijah memories.* I ground my teeth against the thought.

A blood iron spike manifested from the shadows beneath the table and sank into the man's chest. His eyes bulged madly as he clawed at the spike, but his movements quickly became lethargic, and within seconds his limp body sagged, his blood running along the smooth black metal in little rivers before dripping to the damp floor.

Icy claws raked at my insides, my core a heavy ball of pain in my sternum, and it was all I could do to hold on to the magic.

"W-what happened to me…" I turned back to the woman, holding myself on one trembling elbow. "What were you doing to me?"

She had shrunk back a step but was paralyzed by my gaze. "The High S-Sovereign, he…he…"

Both her hands came up, and a weak shield of light blue transparent mana hummed into existence between us. She turned to run and slammed into a

second spike. From my angle, the sharp point speared out of her lower back, and a crimson ring began to stain her white robes.

Cold sweat broke out across my brow at the effort of casting and the pain it caused me. My arms shook as I broke the ankle restraints, and I had to support myself on the side table as I maneuvered around to the woman's front.

The spike had gone in just above her hip and was pinning her in place, but it was thin, a weak, trembling thing, just like me.

Despite the pain and fatigue, I took hold of her chin and forced her to face me. "What were you doing to me?"

"W-wanted to understand…examining your…core," she gasped. "She…healed it. But it's…imperfect…"

I pressed my fingers into the incision marks again. These two had opened me up and poked around inside my body. They hadn't asked, hadn't even planned on telling me. I felt no anger at this, which in itself seemed remarkable. I was always angry now. My temper burned like a forge fire right beneath my skin, and any gust of adversity made it flare bright and hot.

Except…

I looked at the woman. *Really* looked at her. She had unremarkable dull-brown eyes and mousy hair that matched them almost exactly. Worry lines were etched into her face, and she had patches of chewed skin on her lips, which I could picture her biting with nervous curiosity as she peered at my insides like I was a bullfrog pinned to the table.

"What happened at the Victoriad? Did we capture Grey? Kill him?"

I read the answer in the woman's face. Her eyes dilated, leaking frightened tears that mixed with the snot dribbling from her nose. Her lips parted then squeezed shut, the muscles in her jaw working silently.

And I felt…

Nothing.

Soulfire jumped to life over the metal of the spike, then raced along the trail of her blood and into her body. Her brown eyes rolled back in her head, and she screamed, but only for a moment. The soulfire was in her

lungs an instant later, and she was dead. Not because I was angry, but simply because she didn't matter.

I dismissed the two blood iron spikes I had summoned, letting the bodies fall unceremoniously to the floor, then slumped back against the wall and slid down it into a sitting position. There, I could only wait for the pain and weakness to recede.

My attention turned back to the room.

There were two exits. Through an open door, I could see a small room with a desk and shelves full of scrolls and journals. After a few minutes of rest, I pushed myself up on the wall and moved to investigate the contents, but there was nothing there of interest. It did, however, lead me back to the open book on the table in the examination room.

The notes were in runic shorthand. I flipped through several pages until I got the jist of it, then spent a few more minutes perusing the contents.

It only confirmed what I'd already guessed.

Cecilia had saved me. She had used her powers as the Legacy—her absolute control over mana—to heal my core after Grey destroyed it. But it wasn't as strong as it had been before. With time, perhaps I could regain what I'd lost. Agrona would allow me another rune or two, I was certain. That would force my core to clarify further.

"And if it doesn't…" I said aloud, but stopped, surprised that the numbness I felt was captured so clearly in my voice. I was certain the weakness of my core and my magic would infuriate me later, but right now, in the moment, in this place, within the aftereffects of whatever these researchers had done to me, I only felt calm.

No, not even calm. I felt…nothing. Except, perhaps, a mild sense of curiosity.

The second door was closed and barred. I pulled the bar from its housing and let it drop heavily to the floor, then opened the door.

I found myself in a wide high-ceilinged corridor. I could sense the weight of the earth-attribute mana pressing in around me; wherever I was, it must have been deep underground.

To my right, the corridor opened into a large space that looked and felt like

a cross between a scientific laboratory and a dungeon. I'd been in too many similar facilities in Taegrin Caelum, being poked and prodded and tested.

Bitter bile burned the back of my throat, and I spit on the floor.

The lab wasn't currently occupied, and I sensed nothing interesting in that direction, so I turned left instead. Several sources of mana radiated weakly farther down the hall, and I was in no hurry to return to the fortress above. The surgical wounds on my bare chest itched, and my core ached.

I wasn't ready to face any of that yet, not Agrona's disappointment or Cecilia's worrying. Down here in the cool dungeons, I felt at home in the loneliness. It was difficult to admit even to myself, but I was enjoying the apathetic catatonia that had replaced the ever-present rage always burning in my chest.

And so I followed the hallway, curious about what secrets might be buried beneath Taegrin Caelum.

The stone of the floor and walls were occasionally marred with gouges like claw marks, and old blood discolored it in streaks and smears. Labs, offices, and surgical rooms opened off both sides, some closed and locked, others open, but all empty and uninteresting.

Then I reached the first cell.

A vibrating barrier of repelling force separated the cell from the hallway. Inside the ten-by-ten square, three naked dwarven corpses hung upside down by hooks in their legs. Their bodies gaped open grotesquely, the flesh of their bellies affixed with pins and clamps to their sides, revealing that the yawning cavity of their torso had been hollowed out, all organs removed.

I scanned the details of their faces, searching my submerged Elijah memories for some connection to these corpses.

The two men, I couldn't find memory of, but there was something familiar in the plump lines of the third figure's face. Now, hanging like a slab of butchered meat, her jaw unhinged and her bloated tongue filling her mouth, she looked monstrous and unreal, but the memory of her I had was different. In it, she was firm but not unkind. A hard-working woman who had helped train me when I was young, some servant of Rahdeas's.

Even though she was a tough teacher, she had never beaten me or experimented on me, unlike so many in Taegrin Caelum. I should have remembered her name.

But I didn't.

I turned away from the corpses and the uncomfortable squirming they caused in my guts, not yet ready to give up the impassivity that had wrapped itself around me like a heavy wool blanket.

Each cell in the hallways contained a similar scene: corpses of men, women, human, elves, Alacryans, mana beasts, and even a scaled and horned man who I thought must be a half-transformed basilisk. The walls of the cells were lined with tables containing piles of notes and trays with stacked and numbered bones and offal, patches of flesh, and any number of tools for the purpose of harvesting these objects.

This was where the Vritra's true power came from; they accepted no barrier to their pursuit of knowledge. Nothing was too cruel, too inhumane for them, as long as it advanced their understanding of the world.

That hallway ended at the intersection with a perpendicular corridor, again full of cells. I sensed nothing of interest to my right, and so followed the vague mana signatures to the left.

I was brought up short at the very first cell I came to.

Inside, through the barrier of transparent mana that sealed the room, a young woman was chained to the wall. From the fiery orange color of her eyes, the way her red hair fell in flat sheets like feathers, and the smokey, gray-purple dusk of her skin, I knew she must be an asura of the phoenix race.

"Not young then," I said to myself, my voice sounding loud in the silent corridors of the dungeon.

The phoenix shifted, and her blazing eyes seemed to engulf me. "Not compared to you, child of another world…" Her voice was like warm coals. Once it had blazed, I felt certain, but it was cooling as the asura herself dimmed.

"You know me?" I asked, genuinely surprised.

She shook her head, the only real motion allowed by the tightness of the

thick black chains binding her. “No, but I smell rebirth in your very cells. You are a reincarnate.”

My brows rose, and I moved a step closer to the mana barrier. “What would you know about reincarnation?”

She cocked her head slightly as she peered at me, suddenly reminding me very much of the birdlike image often used to represent phoenixes. “My kind knows much about rebirth. Do you wish to understand more fully what you are? I will exchange knowledge for freedom, reincarnate. Release me, help me escape this place, and I will take you to the wisest members of my clan, those who have themselves traveled the paths of death and returned.”

A flicker of my old anger burned beneath my skin, and I took a step away from the cell. My curiosity had wilted. “I’m not interested in bargaining with you, asura, and I certainly won’t work against Agrona to help you. If you don’t want my conversation, you can go back to the silence that is slowly swallowing you.”

Her head fell to her chest as she let out a defeated sigh, then slowly rose again so she could look into my eyes. “Go then. Chase your tail in pursuit of the mad basilisk’s approval, foolish yipping little animal. When you end up where I am, perhaps you will understand.”

The ever-present rage coiled around my insides like a hades serpent, but I pushed it back down and pulled the heavy blanket of apathy close around me. Instead of further agitating myself by arguing with the phoenix, I turned my back on her and walked away.

The next few cells passed by without my focusing on them beyond acknowledging that they contained more prisoners. No one as interesting as the phoenix asura, but then, I was regretting having stopped to speak to her. Her attempts to barter for her freedom had instantly upset the fragile balance of my emotions, and I could *feel* the blessed blankness being eaten up by my anger. Acknowledging this only sped up the process.

Foolish yipping little animal, I heard in my head, repeated over and over. The thought of simply turning back and killing her where she was, chained to the wall and defenseless, crossed my mind. Would they call me “Asura Killer” if I did, I wondered, the thought only serving to further rile my temper.

Because no, of course they wouldn't. Cadell had killed an old half-dead dragon, and that made him "Killer of Dragons" for fifteen years, but if I did the same? No, Agrona would only punish me for my actions. Even if I ran to him now and told him his asuran prisoner was attempting to escape, he would only scold me for being down here or tell me how that didn't matter because it didn't involve his precious Legacy.

I jerked to a halt and sobered instantly.

"I won't let you make me hate her, too," I said into the silence, looking up to the ceiling as if I could see through the tons upon tons of stone that separated us at that moment.

Everything I had done for Agrona in this life had been to secure Cecilia's reincarnation. *Everything*. Nothing mattered except that we had a chance at a life together beyond this world. Agrona would see to it that—

Chase your tail, she'd said. *You'll understand.*

My feet began to move of their own accord, following the corridor as my thoughts skirmished in my skull.

Something was different inside me. My hand drifted up to my sternum, and my fingers pressed into the still-healing flesh, but it wasn't my core I was feeling. It was like…a door had opened, letting a hot breeze blow through the dark corners of my mind. Just like with the Elijah memories—memories buried and suppressed for years now—I was feeling and remembering things differently than I had before the Victoriad.

Whatever Cecilia had done, it had altered more than just my core.

It had broken Agrona's spells on my mind.

A dull displaced sickness gripped my guts. *How much of what's in my head is me, and how much is Agrona?*

I understood his power, knew he'd used it on me many times, but that had always felt like a *good* thing. I'd never taken to alcohol, but I'd seen people who gave themselves entirely over to it, sinking into a bottle in order to soothe the pain of the past and forget. Agrona's power was something like that.

But now, looking back with a clear head…

Cecilia…

I'd done *that* to Cecilia. I'd let Agrona tamper with her mind—helped him, offered suggestions, made demands…

The dull sickness surged into nausea, and I sagged against the wall between two cells.

I had wanted her to *trust* me so badly that I'd begged Agrona to implant that trust in her mind, to change even the memories of our past life together. All I had ever wanted was to be with her, to keep her safe, and give her a life free of the pain and torture that she'd endured because of her ki pool—because some fools thought she was something called "the Legacy." But I hadn't trusted her. I'd *never* just *trusted* in her to be able to take care of herself, to know what was best for *herself*.

She needed to know. I had to tell her.

The closest mana shield buzzed horribly as the cell's occupant pressed against it, and I jumped back, my heart racing.

I had to squint and do a double take to make sure I was seeing things correctly.

"Please, tell Agrona I'm sorry. Scythe Nico, tell him, tell him I'll make it up to him, I promise!"

"Sovereign…Kiros?" I asked, dumbfounded.

The large asura was dressed in tattered rags, and his hair hung in dirty, shaggy locks around his horns, the points of which were crackling with energy where they touched the mana barrier containing him.

"You'll tell him, yes?" His red eyes flashed, the pupil's narrowing into slits, and golden scales rippled across his skin. "Tell him!"

It was all too much. The weight of memories—a conflicted tumult of Earth Nico, Elijah, and my life in Alacrya—of guilt, and of the asura's fury and terror, threatened to rip me to pieces, and so I turned and ran. I sprinted back along the corridor blindly, running like I was a child in the streets again, being pursued by some angry shopkeep or city guard because I'd filched a book or a handful of berries…

The cells flashed by at my sides. The corridor felt like it was unfolding around me, peeling apart and leaving me exposed, the sanctuary of its cool darkness suddenly a trap I couldn't escape.

I slid to a stop, breathing hard.

I'd reached the end of the hallway.

The world seemed to settle back into place around me. The fear and anxiety and frustration and self-loathing were all still there, clinging to me like a million little spiders, but each breath pushed more of the panic out of my body, and the urge to flee morphed into a bone-deep fatigue. Had it not been for what I was seeing, I might have laid down and closed my eyes right on the floor.

But I couldn't take my eyes off the contents of the cell before me.

I must have run past the intersection of the previous corridors and gone down the right path without realizing. At its end was a huge cell, at least seventy feet square.

The coiled form of a fully grown dragon filled the space. Her white scales glistened in the soft light suffusing the cell, and the way her huge head rested on her front arms made it look like she was sleeping.

But…I could sense no mana or intent from her. And there was no steady rising and falling of her body, no expanding and contracting of breaths taken, even shallow ones. She was entirely, perfectly still.

In my still-resurfacing Elijah memories, I found a familiar description to this asura. Arthur had told me all about the wounded dragon who had saved his life and given him the egg that hatched into Sylvie. Stepping to one side and sinking into a crouch, I could just see the ancient wound that marred the dragon's chest. Around it, scales had been removed, but I couldn't see well enough to guess what else Agrona's researchers might have done to the body.

"Grandma Sylvia." The name slipped from my lips without intention, but once I'd heard it, I was certain it was correct.

Pulled by a morbid curiosity, I stepped up to the mana barrier and rested my hand against it. It resisted. I pushed harder, imbuing my hand with soulfire despite the pain, and the barrier rippled and pulled away from the flames. I stepped through, and it resealed around the hole I'd made.

A dizzy wobble shook my entire body, and I lurched forward and caught myself on the dragon corpse's cold nose.

There was some kind of powerful magic in the room. I squinted my eyes hard against the vertigo, waiting for it to pass, and when it eventually did, I walked a slow circle around the massive form.

Around the barrier inside the cell, and in the seams between wall, floor, and ceiling, fine runes were etched into the stone. A complex structure of spells was interwoven to maintain the barrier, among other things, but the runes were so complicated I couldn't follow everything they did. Part of the spell, though, maintained a kind of stasis within the room, preventing its contents from decaying over time.

Several tables had been left against the back wall, although they were mostly bare. A large tome of bound parchment was open to the first page, which read *Observation on the Dragon Sylvia Indrath's Remains*.

A tag of fabric marked a spot about a third of the way into the tome. When I pulled the tag, the heavy parchment fell open to a second title page. This one read *Observations on Dragon Physiology, Cores, and Manipulation of Aether*.

Next to the book, resting on a metal frame, was a round object the size of both my fists together.

The white sphere had a slightly rough, organic texture to its surface, and was slightly transparent, revealing a faint purple tinge to the inside.

It was a core. A *dragon's* core. Sylvia Indrath's core.

But it felt empty and lifeless, as if any hint of mana that once might have been contained within it had been scoured away. The dragon's will, I knew, had been given to Arthur just before her death. So what was this, then? Could it really be nothing more than an empty dead organ, like a heart with all the blood squeezed from it?

Reaching out, I let my fingers brush across the core's surface, and a brilliant electric shock ran up my arm.

My vision shifted, revealing swarming particles of energy moving in and around the core like bright purple fireflies.

I snatched my hand back, and the particles vanished.

Gingerly, I reached out and pressed one fingertip against the core.

But…nothing happened. The vision did not reoccur. No purple particles,

no rippling vision. Carefully, I picked the core up and turned it over in my hand. It was very light, almost weightless, but the surface was hard and inflexible. I didn't put any pressure on it, though, afraid it might be brittle. I couldn't really explain to myself why, but I didn't want to break it.

Neither, I thought, did I want to leave it here in this cold place, forgotten and abandoned.

Although I had no idea what I would do with the core, I made the reckless decision to take it for myself. With a pulse of mana, I activated my dimension ring and hid the core within it.

This minor act of rebellion made me feel unexpectedly light, helping to buffer the overwhelming flood of emotions I'd felt only minutes ago.

With a conspiratorial smile at the dragon's remains, I burned my way free of the cell, feeling less strain this time, and began searching for the way out of the dungeon and back up into Taegrin Caelum.

I needed to find Cecilia.

We needed to talk.

394

WHAT MAKES HOME

ARTHUR LEYWIN

I was floating in a familiar hazy amethyst sea of emptiness.

The nothing-space stretched away into infinity in every direction. The absence of anything real and tangible was simultaneously a source of comfort and anxiety. Floating within it, I felt like a child huddled within my blankets, afraid of a monster under my bed I was *almost* certain wasn't real—but not certain enough to let the fear fade.

Not that I'd ever had a childhood like that, but here, in the aether realm, it was easier to imagine all the different lives I *might* have had.

For the first time since I'd been just a small child on Earth, I imagined a life in which I'd known my real parents, ones who had raised me with love. What might I have been, then, if I hadn't grown up as an orphan with that desperate need for attachment and love, that heart-wrenching desire to prove my worth so that *someone* would care for me?

I saw a life in which I'd never met Nico or Cecilia or Headmaster Wilbeck or Lady Vera. I would have learned a trade, ran a successful business, started a family of my own, and eventually died having been happy in my one peaceful, unimportant life.

"No," a soft voice said, a physical thing that was more energy than noise.

I rotated around in the void. In the distance, a star burned bright white against the dark purple.

"Even if you lived a thousand lives, not one of them would be 'unimportant.'"

My chest constricted, and I willed myself closer to the source of that shining light. It radiated a silvery warmth that made me feel confident and afraid and protective and loved all at once, and these feelings only grew more potent and complex as I zoomed closer.

The star grew and solidified, becoming a silhouette, which in turn manifested the refined details of a young girl with hair and eyes identical in color to mine.

I stopped just before her, greedily drinking in the sight of her, whole and unblemished. Reaching out tentatively, I poked the tip of one horn, and she stifled a delighted laugh.

“Sylvie…”

My bond smiled, and the sight of it filled me with tingling warmth.

There was so much I wanted to tell her: how sorry and grateful I was, how much I regretted everything that had happened, how much I missed her…

But I could feel our minds connecting, and I could sense in her the understanding of everything I was thinking.

“It's still nice to hear those things said out loud sometimes, though,” she said, her head tilting slightly to the side as she examined me. “Don’t forget that.”

“I’m dreaming, aren’t I?”

“Yes.”

“Still, it’s…good to see you, Sylv.” I rubbed the back of my neck, a movement my old companion watched with clear amusement. “I’m sorry it’s taking me so long to bring you back.”

“Don’t worry about me. I’ve got all the time in the world.” Her smile sharpened into a smirk, like she’d just said something she found very humorous.

“I *will* rescue you, Sylv.”

“I know. For now, though…” She reached out and poked me in the chest with one finger. As she did, a dull murmur of distant voices began to intrude on the dream. “It’s time to wake up, Arthur.”

My eyes blinked open. I was lying on a hard bed in a small chamber and staring up at the low, gray stone ceiling.

“Ouch! Damned, this thing is sharp,” the grumbling voice of Gideon exclaimed.

I turned my head slightly, revealing the old inventor with his back to me. Leaning against the far wall, Emily was watching him with the unique blend of amusement, fondness, and exasperation reserved for the old inventor. She noticed the small movement and met my eye, her expression dissolving into a look of pure relief.

“Aren’t you supposed to be some kind of genius?” I asked, getting a laugh out of Emily.

Gideon spun around and gave me an affronted look, the effect of which was somewhat dampened by the fact that he was sucking on his index finger like a wounded child. Removing the spit-shined digit, he glared at the dot of blood that immediately welled up, then at me instead.

“About time you’re awake. It’s been a day and a half, boy. Aren’t you supposed to be some kind of unkillable uber hero.” He scoffed. “Our last conversation was very rudely interrupted by a bunch of Alacryans dead set on murdering us all, if you remember.”

I pushed myself up onto my elbows and maneuvered so I could sit up with my back against the wall.

The first thing I noticed was Valeska’s horn resting on a stand next to the bed.

The second thing was that *everything* hurt.

Looking down at my body, I realized I was covered with bandages from head to toe. The stump of my arm had regrown to the wrist, but my hand hadn’t fully formed yet. Worried, I checked my core, but it didn’t seem damaged, just low on aether. Being unconscious for such an extended period had no doubt hampered my ability to collect and purify aether effectively. Considering that, I had actually healed a lot quicker than I should have.

Something else was strange, too—an empty feeling like something was missing.

“Regis?” I asked, worry quickening my heart rate.

He had barely been holding on when I’d woken up on the ground in the tunnel to the portal chamber, and I’d had no time to check on him beyond acknowledging that he wasn’t dead yet. I’d barely had the wherewithal to conjure my armor and build up enough aetheric reserve for a single God Step, but that alone had pushed me past the breaking point. If the Scythes hadn’t fallen for my bluff…

A small ball of purple flames and angst leaped up onto the bed, glaring at me tiredly. “What? I was napping. And having this really nice dream about __”

I reached down and tousled Regis’s puppy-form head with my good hand. “I thought you were done for.”

Regis huffed as he plopped down and rested his chin on his overly large paws. “I could say the same for you. Really went full nova back there. You were so dry on aether I haven’t been able to incorporealize myself into your core because I was soaking up too much, and I was worried you’d shrivel up like some mana-starved muck larva.”

“Well, thanks for not letting me die,” I said, amused.

“Same though,” Regis replied before closing his eyes and immediately falling asleep again.

“You two are *so* cute,” Emily said, melting into a doe-eyed puddle as she stared at Regis. “I have to say, I like him a lot better this way.” She eyed Gideon carefully. “Arthur, do you think there is some way we can—”

“I am *not* your pet, girl!” Gideon snapped, crossing his arms and generally looking very huffy. “And anyway, all these tedious feelings are starting to give me a rash. Arthur, we need to finish our conversation so I can get back to work.”

I looked at him for a long moment as I searched my memory for some hint of our last discussion, but nothing immediately came to mind. “I’m sorry, it’s been a busy couple of days…”

“The fire salts!” he exclaimed, waving his hands. “The cannons, the… the…all of it!”

The moments before the Wraiths’ attack solidified in my mind, and the

idea I'd had rushed back in, almost fully formed. "Right. Your weapons. Actually, I did have a thought."

Gideon's eyes lit up, and he flapped a hand at Emily. "Girl, write this down."

Her eyebrows rose indignantly, but she pulled a scroll, pen, and ink out of a shoulder bag and made busy getting ready, shooting annoyed glares at Gideon's back every few seconds.

"So, here's the thing," I began, knowing I was about to crush the old inventor. "No cannons."

His face fell, vacillating between confusion and disappointment. "No… cannons?"

I shook my head and gave him an apologetic smile. "But we do need to fortify our non-mage soldier's fighting capabilities, and the technology that you've been working on is the foundation for how we're going to do that."

Although hesitant at first, as I explained my proposal in full, Gideon's frustration transformed into studious curiosity, and then blossomed into outright excitement. Meanwhile, Emily scribbled frantically to capture everything we were discussing, only occasionally throwing in a suggestion of her own.

"This…well, it can definitely work!" Gideon said as he stared down at the long scroll full of our notes. "Not as flashy or impressive as the cannon idea, but"—he gave an exaggerated shrug—"it is a little more practical, I suppose."

"But the priority remains on discovering how to operate the bestowal artifacts—"

"Yes, yes, yes," Gideon said, not looking at me as he turned away and started moving languidly toward the door, his nose still in the scroll. Consequently, he was also not looking at the open door and ran face first into the still form of Bairon, who had stopped in the doorframe.

"Oof! Bah, you make a better lightning rod than a door, Lance," Gideon grumbled, conjuring a sour look from Bairon. The broad-shouldered Lance didn't move, and Gideon was forced to shimmy through the narrow opening to leave. Emily curtseyed awkwardly in front of Bairon, who

shifted, allowing her to hurry after Gideon.

Bairon watched the pair go, then looked at me with one brow raised. “It is good to see you’re awake, Arthur. We were…worried.”

I eased my legs off the bed and sat up straight. “Worried? About me?” I held out my stump of an arm, which was already healing more quickly now that I’d regained consciousness. “Just a couple minor flesh wounds.”

Bairon’s mouth twitched, but his brows turned down as if he couldn’t decide whether to smile or frown. “I won’t pretend to understand what has happened to you, Arthur, and I doubt even you yet know the full capability of your powers. What I do know is that Dicathen is fortunate that you returned when you did, and that, after everything, you’re still willing to fight for this continent.”

I looked at my feet, unsure what to say. My relationship with Bairon had always been hostile, and I wasn’t yet sure how to process this sudden change in the dynamic between us.

“I…want you to know something, Arthur.” I looked up to see Bairon ringing his hands, his gaze askance. “Maybe this won’t carry much meaning for you, but I forgive you…for my brother. For Lucas.” Finally, he met my eye. “And I’m sorry for attacking you, for”—he looked away again, some of the color draining from his face—“threatening your family.”

“Bairon, it’s—”

He raised a hand to forestall my response. “My pride blinded me to the evils of my family. My rage wasn’t even about Lucas, but your insult to our house. I was a fool, Arthur. And I’m sorry.”

I waited a moment to make sure he was finished speaking, then said, “I accept both. And I stopped blaming you for that a long time ago. The way you reacted, it wasn’t any different than what I did to Lucas. I thought it was justified in the moment—that I’d been right—but really, how I dealt with things, it made enemies, and that wasn’t smart, strategically.”

Bairon watched me with a distant, detached wariness, and there was a cold formality in his expression that reminded me of the old Bairon. Then, with a shake of his head, it was gone. “Even Lances, it appears, make mistakes. But…that is not why I’m here.”

He stood aside from the doorway, revealing a figure that had been hidden in the hallway behind him. All thought of fire salts and weapons and even the bestowment artifacts fled my mind.

Virion entered the room hesitantly, resting one old, tired hand on Bairon's arm for just a moment. Then Bairon backed out of the room, closing the door behind him.

Virion pulled a wooden chair away from the wall and sat stiffly. His gaze roamed around the room for several very long seconds before settling on me. He cleared his throat.

"Virion, how are you feel—"

"Listen, Arthur, I needed to—"

We had both started speaking at the same time, then both immediately stopped. Virion leaned forward, his fists clenched together, and stared at the floor in silence, his body tense, a simmering animosity evident in each still movement.

I realized just how on edge I was, too. Taking a deep breath, I forced myself to relax. Beside me, Regis rolled over and continued sleeping. At least, I thought he was sleeping until one eye peeked open a slit, caught me watching, and quickly shut again.

"It's good to see you, Gramps. How…are you?" My tone was hesitant, almost awkward. There had been no time to address it since my return to Dicathen, but it was clear that Virion was keeping his distance from me, and I wasn't sure why.

Virion stared down at his hands for a long moment, then said, "I'm sorry, Arthur."

I opened my mouth to immediately interrupt, caught myself, and closed it slowly, waiting for Virion to continue.

"I've been avoiding you. Because…" He cleared his throat, and his gaze began to wonder again, almost as if he didn't want to look at me. "When I saw you come back through that portal alone, all I felt was the bitterness of knowing that Tessia wasn't with you. You were returned from the dead, while her body is left to be tugged and pulled across Alacrya like a marionette. And…I didn't want to hate you for that."

I swallowed hard.

I expected him to be disappointed in me for arriving so late, perhaps even blame me for being unable to save Rinia or Aya…or even Feyrith.

I didn't even realize he knew what had happened to Tess. I suddenly *wished* he didn't know what was happening to her. Virion had lost his son, his Lances, his country…it was enough to break anyone. Knowing that Tessia's body was out there being controlled by the enemy, unsure if she still existed within it…he shouldn't have had to shoulder that burden too.

Anger overtook my guilt as I considered Windsom and Kezess manipulating and taking advantage of Virion, making him lie to his own people, stringing him along with bits of information about Tessia, just enough to keep him desperate and unsure.

One more thing they should have to answer for, I thought, balling the blanket up in my clenched fist.

After a long silence where we didn't meet each other's eyes, Virion continued. "I needed to mourn, but didn't know where to begin. Losing Rinia and so many other elves when there are so few of us left…I spent so long holding it all back, after Elenoir—after Tessia—and then to suddenly feel like I'd lost my granddaughter all over again…" Virion's head slumped, and a tear dropped onto his clasped hands.

"I'm sorry I couldn't save her, Virion. I tried, I—"

My words cut off as the image of Tessia's resigned smile intruded on my thoughts. The aether blade pressed against her sternum, mossy green veins spreading over her face, her words… *"Art, please…"*

"She's alive," I said instead. Virion looked up quickly and blinked his shining eyes. "Her body may be under Agrona's control, but *Tessia* is alive, buried beneath the personality of a being known as the Legacy."

Virion shifted, hesitating, then finally asked, "You're sure? Windsom, he thought perhaps…but…"

"I'm certain," I confirmed with a nod that sent a pulse of discomfort through my entire body. "I looked into her eyes, Virion. Tess was still in there."

Virion searched my gaze for a long time, then his face wrinkled up and he

broke, sobs shaking his shoulders as more tears flooded unchecked.

I slid off the bed and went to one knee in front of him, reaching for his hands. There are no words for moments such as this, and so I kept my silence. Virion leaned down and pressed his forehead to my hand, and we stayed like that for a while. His mourning soothed me, and my presence buttressed him as he vented his long-held grief.

After a few minutes, Virion's sobs ceased, and most of the tension left his body. We lingered as we were for another minute or two. It was Virion who spoke first.

"I can't sense the dragon's will within you."

I pressed my fingers into my sternum, over my aether core, which I'd formed from the broken remnants of the mana core that had once contained Sylvia's will. Settling back onto the hard bed, I began to tell Virion about everything that had happened to me: my defeat and near-death battling Cadell and Nico, Sylvie's sacrifice, waking up in the Relictombs, Regis, the aether core, and everything after that.

Virion proved an intent listener, leaning forward with his elbows on his knees, hardly even blinking. As I neared the end of my tale, however, he leaned back, crossed his arms, and gave me a sour frown. "So you're telling me I wasted *four years* of my life training you to be a beast tamer, just for you to go and lose your bond?"

My mouth hung open as I struggled for a reply, but Virion's frown broke, and he gave me a wry smile.

"That's a heck of a story, brat. But…I'm glad you made it back. And…" He paused and cleared his throat. "Thank you, Arthur."

"And thank you, Virion, for making sure my mom and sister were safe," I said in return.

He let out an amused scoff. "That sister of yours, she's just as much a magnet for trouble as you ever were. Chafes at even the idea of safety." My expression must have given away exactly how I felt about Ellie's recklessness because Virion chuckled. "Speaking of, I'm sure you're eager to see your family. They were both here for the first day, but Lance Varay finally made them leave to get some rest."

I gave him a tight-lipped smile. "Yeah."

He stood and stretched, letting out an old man's groan. "Before I go, though, there is one more thing. Bairon!" he said loudly, turning toward the closed door.

The door opened, and Bairon entered again, this time carrying three identical boxes of polished black wood, each one bound in softly glowing silver.

"The artifacts Windsom gave you," I said thoughtfully, eyeing the boxes as though they might explode at any moment. "You kept them. I wondered…" Thinking back to the moments after I'd driven the Alacryans from the Sanctuary, I recalled Virion rushing off and disappearing for some time. "That's what you were doing while the rest of us were meeting."

Virion took the top box off the stack from Bairon and opened the lid, holding it out toward me. Resting inside was an ornate rod. The red wood of the handle had golden rings wrapped around it at intervals, and it was capped with a glowing lavender crystal. Aether seemed drawn to the crystal, bobbing around it like so many curious bees.

I activated Realmheart. There was a sharp tug that sent a jolt of pain up my spine as the godrune lit up, then a rush of warmth from my lower back up into my limbs and eyes.

The mana came into focus. My breath came out in a rush.

The rod-shaped artifact had become a glistening rainbow of radiant mana, the rings, shaft, and crystal alike not only infused with mana, but constantly drawing more from our surroundings, so that the entire surface, as well as the box in which it was stored, positively swam with blues, greens, yellows, and reds.

"I'm not quite sure what to do with them," Virion admitted, holding the box out. "We can't use them. Not now, after everything that's happened. Not after Rinia…"

I carefully took it from him, holding the box in the crook of my injured arm while I lifted out the artifact, turning it so the facets of the crystal caught the light and sparkled through the glow of mana.

"Ellie told me about Rinia's visions," I said, using Realmheart and my own innate ability to see aetheric particles to track the magic's flow through the artifact. "Has Gideon looked them over?"

Virion burst out with an indelicate snort. “Took one look at them and said he agreed with ‘the old bat’ and promised to vote against using them.”

Regis shifted, no longer pretending to be asleep as he ogled the artifact hungrily. *‘If we’re not going to do anything else with it, I could always absorb that aether. You know, deactivate it, for safety or whatever.’*

Curious what would happen, I attempted to draw on the aether swarming the artifact. The artifact was exerting its own force on the aether particles, which flowed down the handle toward my hand only to waver and draw closer to the crystal again. Focusing, I pulled harder. The aether trembled, and the mana seemed to quake and ripple, small plumes of mana escaping the artifact and spraying out into the atmosphere.

If we take the aether, the artifact will break. With this much mana, the explosion might be pretty violent. Besides, I added thoughtfully, *I’m not convinced yet that we can’t make use of these.*

“They resist being placed into a dimension device of any kind,” Virion said, watching me with his brows creased, clearly confused about what I was doing. I realized that to him it must have looked like I was having a staring competition with the rod. “I don’t want to just cart them around, but I’m not sure what else to do with them.”

Twirling the artifact like a baton, I returned it to its case, closed and latched the lid, then imbued aether into my dimension rune.

The box vanished, drawn into the extradimensional storage space controlled by the rune on my forearm.

“But, how…?” Virion glanced at Bairon questioningly, but Bairon only shrugged.

“Here,” I said, reaching for the other two boxes. Bairon gave them up gladly. In a moment, they too were gone, and I could sense them within the extradimensional space, along with the items I’d collected in Alacrya.

I held up my forearm to show Virion the rune. “I have an original, not an old relic that’s been hacked apart ten times over. Must make a difference.”

Virion chuckled again, his brows rising all the way up into his hairline. “One of these days, I suppose I’ll stop being surprised by you, brat.”

“Let’s hope not, Gramps,” I said earnestly, then looked at Regis. “I think

I've lain around long enough. Ready to get out of here?"

He yawned and stretched, sticking his rump up in the air like an actual puppy. "I'm ready to find a real source of aether, because I don't relish the idea of being stuck like this for a week while we drip-feed off the atmosphere down here."

With the Compass, I could return to the Relictombs at will, and mentally agreed that we should go replenish our aether reserves as soon as possible, but first I needed to check on Mom and Ellie.

After adding Valeska's horn to my growing pile of artifacts within the dimension rune, I wished Virion and Bairon farewell, then made my way through the labyrinthine halls of the Earthborn Institute.

Regis stayed inside my body while we walked, hovering near the stump of my hand instead of my core. It eased the pain of the regrowing limb, but the healing was slow—at least, slow for *me.* I'd become so accustomed to losing entire limbs, it made me genuinely worry for my sanity. There was something distinctly inhuman about watching my hand regrowing in real time.

'Are you really *human anymore?'* Regis sent, knowing just what to say to further agitate me, as always.

I don't know, I answered, then cast the thought aside as I approached the door to the rooms where my family was staying.

It opened as I reached it, and Ellie was half through it before she noticed me and jerked to a stop. Her face lit up, then her focus shifted to my hand. "Oh, Art, that looks…"

I took her by the chin and turned her face up toward mine. "I'm fine, El. I've healed from worse."

She gave me a single decisive nod, then pulled back. "I was just coming to check on you, so you saved me a trip. Mom is asleep." She continued talking as she turned and led me into the rooms. "She was awake for about thirty hours straight, and she put herself into backlash trying to heal you." She flinched and looked into my eyes. "Sorry, I didn't mean—"

"It's okay," I said, ruffling her hair like I'd done when she was little. It drove home how tall she was, how much she'd grown. And how much I'd missed.

“Arthur?” a wispy voice said from somewhere deeper in the suite. I heard feet hit the ground, and quick but uneven footsteps. Mom appeared in the hall, her hair disheveled and dark bags under her eyes.

Still, when she saw me, she smiled. “Oh, Art, I was so—”

Mom wobbled, her eyes losing focus. I was at her side in an instant, supporting her and leading her to the closest couch.

“I’m…fine,” she mumbled as I eased her down onto the soft cushions, but it was easy enough to tell she wasn’t.

Activating Realmheart, I looked more closely, seeing the mana particles moving in her body and sensing her core strength.

“Oh, you’re glowing,” she said, her eyes crossing as she tried and failed to focus on me.

She had clearly pushed herself way past the point of exhaustion. Her core was so strained that it was struggling to start processing mana again, leaving her in a fatigued delirium, not to mention the intense full-body ache she would have been feeling with such severe backlash.

I let Realmheart fade away again.

“You’ve got extreme backlash. You need to be more careful. You’re—”

“Lucky?” she said clumsily, cutting me off. “I do feel quite fortunate, you know. Not everyone gets—how many chances are we on now? Four? Five? Anyway, not everyone gets a second, second, second chance to make things right.”

I winced at the mention of the past.

The regrets that I had from telling my parents the truth about me, and the solace that I felt from finally coming clean…the emotions all came back, forming a knot in my throat that I forcefully swallowed down.

Giving Mom a somber smile, I pulled a loose blanket over her lap. “What do you mean? You made things right a long time ago, remember? After Dad died…”

She sobered, shaking her head and squeezing my hand weakly. “I may have said it, but I was never able to *act* on it. I never got to just…be your mom. But I want to be. I *will* be.” Her eyes fluttered closed, and she sank

deeper into the couch. “I suppose that’s kind of what it must be like being you, huh? Like…being reborn. Trying again to make it right.”

I knew it was the delirium talking, but still, hearing her so casually and calmly mention my reincarnation made my insides squirm. “Yeah, maybe. We can only just…keep trying. To learn, and do better.”

Softly, the breathiness of her tone telling me she was drifting back to sleep, she said, “I made you some porridge, Arthur. I know it’ll take time, but…I hope you can slowly let me be your mom again.”

Turning toward the kitchen, I could just see the small round table, and on it, a wooden bowl with a spoon laid neatly beside it.

And suddenly, the armor of callousness and apathy I had donned in order to survive my time in the Relictombs and Alacrya crumbled.

My throat tightened, and my vision blurred.

A part of me resisted getting up and walking toward the table. With Agrona’s swift counterattack, I knew I couldn’t stay here much longer. I knew he would attack again, and I knew it would only be worse.

But I let my heavy legs drag me toward the bowl of porridge, barely noticing as Regis led my sister out of the room.

Slowly, I took up the spoon and took a mouthful of the cold, tasteless mash. As I did, I gave in to the weight of it all.

Tears spilled freely as I took bite after bite. Alone in this little kitchen, far away from anywhere I’d ever called home, I wept silently as I ate the first meal my mother had cooked for me in years.

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PREPARATIONS

THE SCALDING METAL sizzled against bare bone, charring it black as the flesh around it melted. Water hissed as it hit the black iron, sending up a cloud of steam. I cursed and pulled back.

Ellie slapped my hand away from the pan heating on the stove. “Just let me do it already! Who mixes water and hot grease, anyway? Have you ever even cooked before?”

I dipped my fingers into the saucer of water I’d cooled the pan with and flicked several drops into her face as she struggled to flip the slab of meat I’d burned. “This coming from the girl who's been eating nothing but fish, rats, and mushrooms for the last how many months?”

Regis was sitting in the middle of the table, watching with interest, his nose twitching with every waft of meat-scented air. “You know, that looks pretty much irreparable. Just toss it over to me.”

Ellie dropped a handful of cut-up mushrooms in with the meat and grease, humming with irritation. “I can do more with rat and mushrooms than you can with the whole royal pantry, I bet.”

“I’m not sure that’s something to brag about,” I pointed out, laughing.

Ellie’s leg shot out and thumped against my thigh. I grabbed her ankle and yanked her leg out from under her, holding her upside down with her hair pooling on the tiles beneath her.

“Hey, not fair!” she shouted, swinging her arms as she tried futilely to land a punch.

The whisper of soft turnshoes on stone tiles drew my attention to the

kitchen doorway.

“Good morning,” I said, waving with the hand suspending Ellie upside down so that my sister bobbed around like a rag doll. “It’s not much, but Ellie and I tried making some breakfast.”

“*I* tried making breakfast,” she grumped, her arms crossed. “Arthur was mostly just in the—*ow*!” she yelped as I let her tumble to the floor.

“Oh,” Ellie mumbled quietly. “Mom, what’s wrong?” It was then I realized there were quiet tears running down Mom’s cheeks.

“Huh? What do you—oh.” She wiped at her cheeks with the back of her long sleeves. “Why am I crying?” she asked herself with a laugh.

“I guess it’s just…waking up to something like this…it’s been a long time.”

I pulled out a chair for her, and she eased into it with a grateful tear-streaked smile. Her motions were still slightly sluggish, but her gaze was much steadier than it had been just the day before. Regis scooted back so that he was directly in front of her, and she began petting him behind the ears.

Ellie and I pushed and shoved at the stove, but in the end I let her claim victory and grabbed a handful of wooden plates and utensils to set the table. Ellie delivered stacks of slightly burned meat, eggs, mushrooms, steamed greens, red beans, and a coil of some kind of eel—caught from a nearby underground lake—that Ellie insisted was delicious, and together we filled up three plates.

Mom cut off a burned end from the slice of meat we’d given her and fed it to Regis, who took it right off her fork.

“He's going to keep asking for stuff like this if you spoil him, Mom,” I said around a mouthful.

She waved my words away. “Oh, it's fine. Don’t you think with everything he's done to help out around here, he's earned it?”

Regis’s oversized puppy eyes gleamed as he stared up at my mother like she’d just given him an award. “Would you believe this man never feeds me?”

“You get plenty of aether,” I mumbled as Mom held out half a mushroom.

Regis eyed it uncertainly, then said, “Maybe some more of that meat instead?”

Mom’s brows rose. “It’s important you eat a healthy, balanced diet, Regis,” she lightly scolded.

Regis blinked cartoonishly, then leaned forward and gingerly took the mushroom from her hand, chewing it with such clear dejection that Ellie took pity on him and tossed over a chunk of her eel, giggling when he pounced on it and swallowed it with a single bite.

Truly a magnificent sight to see from the very manifestation of Destruction, I thought.

“Anyway, how are you feeling this morning?” I asked Mom as I speared a chunk of my own eel, keeping my tone light but watching her carefully.

“So much better,” she said. Her bloodshot, tired eyes squinted in appreciation. “Thank you, Arthur, but you don’t have to worry about me. You have so much on your mind already.”

Ellie scoffed and opened her mouth, but paused when Mom shot her a look. My sister took a moment to finish chewing and swallowing, then said, “He let us think he was dead for *months*, didn’t he? Let him worry.”

My mother’s soft smile wavered, and I reached across the table to squeeze her hand. “I *do* have a lot on my mind. But you and Ellie are always at the top of that ever-growing pile.”

Mom’s eyes fell to her plate, but I still saw the moisture shining in them. Ellie watched her, a small frown on her mature features. I slid most of my burned meat over to Regis, who chewed loudly, oblivious to everything except the warm food in front of him, although I could feel how he thrilled at sharing a family meal with us through our mental connection.

We ate in silence for a while after that, but it wasn’t the kind of quiet that was awkward or tense. It was comfortable. Easy. Easier than it had been in a very long time, since the attack on Xyrus.

The thought that it felt like another life flashed through my mind, but I knew that wasn’t really true. I had lived another life on Earth, and then, in Alacrya, I had pretended to be someone I wasn’t, reviving a part of me that had died when I’d been reincarnated in Dicathen. I had needed Grey to survive there, and as much as I wanted to just be Arthur, living as Grey

again had reminded me why I'd become him in the first place.

Until this war was over, truly over, I couldn't let Grey go. Not yet.

"…thur?"

"Sorry?" I asked, realizing my mother had said something.

"I was just saying that I really should go check in at the medical center now that I'm feeling a bit better." She looked slightly embarrassed as she nudged her half-full plate toward Regis. "There are only a couple of emitters in the whole city, and they were relying on me to be there. Besides, I'm sure you have your own business to attend to."

Before I could respond, there was a gasp from Ellie. "Oh! That reminds me! I told Saria Triscan that I'd help relocate the elven refugees today. Most of them were temporarily housed on the lower levels, which were pretty badly damaged in the attack. We're going to start moving them to more permanent places to stay," she added by way of explanation as she pushed herself away from the table.

At the same time, there was a faint *pop*, and the sudden presence of a large furry body shoved the table aside, nearing knocking Regis to the floor.

"Boo!" Ellie said, exasperated. "I'm not freaking in danger! And I've said not to poof into the rooms!"

The guardian bear grumbled, and Ellie's eyes narrowed. "Don't blame me. You interrupted your own nap by being so overprotective." The bear let out a humming grunt that shook the plates on the table, which were pressed against his side.

Mom squeezed around Boo, who was taking up a large percentage of the kitchen, but stopped to lean against the doorway arch and look at us all, smiling brightly. "I'll see you both back home for dinner tonight, okay? I'll cook." Her smile faltered slightly, her brows knitting as her expression became apologetic. "Something hot this time."

"Sounds amazing," I said, giving her the warmest smile I could muster.

She returned it, waved, then vanished behind Boo's bulk. I heard the suite door open and shut, then turned to Ellie. "Do you think she's okay?"

Ellie was scratching Boo between the big mana beast's eyes. "I haven't seen her smile like that since Dad died."

Without looking at me, she put her shoulder into Boo's side and shoved. "Come on you big goof, we need to figure out how to squeeze you through the front door." She stopped and threw a tentative look over her shoulder at me. "Do you…want to come with us? The refugees…they've had a hard time. Seeing you might make them feel better."

I gave her an apologetic smile before shaking my head. "I would, El, but I have duties of my own to see to." *Things that need to be taken care of before I can leave*, I almost added.

She rolled her eyes, but her smile was both good-natured and understanding. "Yeah, yeah, I know, there is so much saving the world to do right now, and only one big brother. Well…see you, then."

Ellie slipped around Boo, who turned to inspect me thoughtfully, his face scrunched between his shoulder and the wall, before grunting and turning to follow her. He nearly overturned the table, and then had to squeeze to fit through first the kitchen doorway, then the front door into the Earthborn Institute's sprawling series of interconnected tunnels.

My smile slipped away. I looked longingly around the suite, wishing I could stay for a while. The time with my family had been a much-needed reprieve from my duties, but time was against me, and there was still too much to do.

I'd spent most of the evening studying the empowering artifacts while my family had slept. The interplay between aether and mana around them was unlike anything I'd seen before, but it reminded me of the soul realm within the aether orb, where I'd trained with Kordri for so long. The artifacts didn't contain an extra-dimensional space, but they weren't simply containers for massive quantities of mana, either. It was almost like Kezess had drawn in and contained *potential*, and by using the artifacts, that potential was expended into a living being.

It was a difficult concept to wrap my head around, but I was only at the beginning stages of understanding. I needed to see the artifacts in use, but *without* activating whatever power Rinia had seen destroying the continent.

"So," Regis said, interrupting my thoughts. I could sense his contentment with his belly full of home-cooked food. "Relictombs for a top off, then back to being the Triple Ds?"

“I…” I sputtered, rubbing a hand down my face, then turned to scowl at my companion. “What?”

“Dicathen’s Dynamic Duo. You know, me and you, the Triple Ds.”

Deciding it was best not to engage Regis on this front, I said, “No time for the Relictombs yet. First, we need to make sure we can leave Vildorial without it immediately falling to Agrona’s forces.”

I gave Ellie a minute or two head start, then followed her out the door. Instead of heading toward the exit, I went deeper down into the Earthborn Institute.

As I’d expected, I found Gideon, Emily, and their team of dwarven mages already at work.

The old inventor barely spared me a glance as I walked into the lab, clearly unsurprised to see me. “I only saw you sixteen hours ago, at least four of which I spent sleeping. Nothing has changed in the meantime, Arthur.”

Emily, who was bent over the crystal-topped staff with a pair of wands, waved one at me. It gave a shrill, humming whistle. She jumped, grinned sheepishly, and moved it back into place.

“Gideon, I need you to gather whatever mana-output monitoring equipment you can scrounge up,” I said. “Meet me by the Three Lakes fishing outpost in an hour.”

Gideon slowly set down the notes he was perusing, stuck a finger in his ear and dug around for a bit, then shook his head and gave me a sickly-sweet smile. “Forgive me, Arthur, but I’d swear it seems like you just marched into my laboratory and started giving me orders without context or consideration for projects already underway—projects I have been repeatedly informed are of the *highest priority* by you yourself.”

Looking him dead in the eye, I continued. “Emily, I need you to track down Lances Mica, Varay, and Bairon, and bring them to meet us.”

She tapped the wands together twice, then laid them carefully next to the staff. “Sure, no problem.” As she moved past Gideon, she reached out and closed his mouth for him, which had been hanging open as he continued to stare at me.

He glared at her back as she headed out the door, but his attention quickly

returned to me.

“This is more time sensitive than our other projects,” I said consolingly. “One hour, Gideon.”

“Bah,” he said, grumbling, but he started bustling around the lab grabbing things and throwing them onto an empty table. “An hour it is then. But why are you making me drag these old bones all the way down to Three Lakes?”

“See you there” was all I said in response before turning and leaving the lab myself.

My feet carried me quickly out of the Earthborn Institute, down the winding highway, past the crews rebuilding the many structures destroyed in the Alacryan assault, and out one of the tunnels that connected to the city’s bottommost level.

‘Are you sure this is all going to work?’ Regis asked. He’d been silently stewing on my refusal to even acknowledge his suggested team name for us, but his irritation has finally settled into a kind of resigned agreement to simply disagree.

It has to, I thought, although we both felt my lack of surety in the process itself. *We can’t fight a war from under the desert. We need to get out there and push back against the Alacryan forces inhabiting Dicathen.*

These thoughts brushed up against a wall of hesitancy in my mind. Because as much as I needed to leave, I also needed to stay. Vildorial was now the epicenter of the fight to reclaim Dicathen, and all the people of Sapin and Darv needed us. But everything I had done to keep the people of this city safe would be for naught if Agrona sent another attack while I was gone.

I needed the Lances here to protect the city in my absence, and in order for them to do that, they needed to break through their current restraints.

The tunnels between Vildorial and the Three Lakes area were cool and lightly traveled, meaning I was left in peace to mull through what I hoped to accomplish.

Mostly, I organized my thoughts, trying to remember everything I had heard about both sets of asuran artifacts: those given to Dicathen’s kings to make Lances, and these new ones that, apparently, could make a mage

strong enough to fight back against even the Scythes.

Ellie had told me everything she could about the conversations between Virion and Windsom, and then later Rinia and Virion. And of course, the old elf himself had explained the Lance artifacts to me when he made me a Lance, but there was still much I didn't understand about how the asura had created them.

These and many other thoughts occupied my mind until the air grew heavy with moisture and the smell of the underground lakes filled the tunnels. Brine, algae, and the heady odor of giant mushrooms combined to create an otherworldly scent like I was stepping out of Dicathen into a place older and more wild. The distant rumble of tumbling water could be felt through the floor soon after.

The tunnel was capped by a rough granite wall, but the gate through was open. Just inside it, several buildings huddled together around the edge of the first of the three lakes that gave this place its name. A stone pier ran along the edge, and a couple of square, flat-bottomed boats floated against it. But the outpost was empty today, as I had expected; most of Vildorial's population was being kept in the city in case of another attack.

The cavern was enormous, even larger than the sanctuary. Although not as tall as the spiraling city of Vildorial, it stretched on and on, the first huge lake spilling into a second in a series of wide waterfalls, which in turn drained into the third almost a mile along the cavern.

As I walked between the empty buildings, I took it all in. Although the smell was something that would take some getting used to, there was an awe-inspiring sort of beauty to the place.

Regis jumped free of my body and strolled next to me. "Y'know, this almost reminds me of the Relictombs."

"Maybe the djinn took inspiration from places like this," I mused absently. "Or even created them."

Along one edge of the lake, a forest of giant mushrooms sprouted up from mossy ground, and across from that, the cavern wall was patterned with striations of orange and white. Water drained across these salt deposits constantly, spilling into the lake and giving off the smell of brine I'd noticed before.

Deep in the dark water, bioluminescent creatures could be seen slowly

trolling like dim stars crossing the night sky.

It was, at least for a short time, a pleasant distraction.

But it wasn't long before footsteps announced the arrival of the others, and the spell was broken.

The Lances arrived first, moving with purpose. Mica led them. Her one remaining eye locked onto me the moment she crossed the threshold into the cave, just as hard as the black stone that inhabited the scarred socket of the eye Taci had ruined. Although at ease in the tunnels of her home, there was something missing from Mica; she had lost more than an eye when Aya died.

Varay was just behind her, towering over the dwarf, as stoic and unreadable as always. Her short white hair seemed to glow in the diffused light of the underground world, giving her a mystical air. Her conjured arm of magical ice was fixed and unmoving, but her flesh-and-blood hand fidgeted with a constant nervous energy, subtly undermining her otherwise indomitable presence.

Finally, Bairon entered a few yards behind them. His gaze trailed behind his companions' heels, unseeing, or rather, seeing something other than uneven ground. I wondered where his thoughts were, what invisible scene was playing out before his unfocused eyes that made him frown so deeply.

I stood on the pier, Regis sitting on his haunches beside me, and waited for them to come to us.

Varay spoke first. "I hope you haven't brought us all the way down here just to take us fishing," she said, focusing on one of the boats floating behind me.

I gave a quiet laugh, drawing uncertain looks from the other Lances. "I actually learned to hone my reflexes and adjust my perception by catching fish with my bare hands when I was just a boy in…" I caught myself and let the thought trail off. "Anyway, no, I think you're all well past that point in your training."

"We are here for you to train us, then?" Mica asked, raising a brow and crossing her arms. "The Watsken girl was a little light on the details when she delivered your summons."

"Not a summons," I corrected gently, "an invitation. I think you all

understand what is happening, what is at stake. When Agrona sent his Wraiths after me, he must have thought they were more than enough to capture or kill me, and likewise that two Scythes and a retainer would be able to regain control of Vildorial and mop up the rest of the resistance against him."

"And it would have been," Mica added, scowling. "Despite giving everything we had, all we could do was hold them off for a time. Without Bairon's new weapon, we wouldn't have lasted even as long as we did."

"You think he'll escalate again?" Varay asked, her fingers tapping constantly against her thigh.

"He will." I began to pace back and forth in front of the three Lances, their eyes following me warily. "My defeat of the Wraiths and subsequent attack on Alacryan soil might give him pause, but not for long." I stopped pacing suddenly, forcefully containing my nervous energy. "Although I stopped any of the Wraiths from returning to him with information, the fact that I was even able to kill them has given him a better understanding of my power."

I took a moment to collect my thoughts, then said, "The truth is, you three just aren't strong enough to protect this city without me."

Varay went stiff as an ice statue. Her face didn't betray her emotions, but the others were less capable of masking their surprise and frustration.

Mica ground her teeth and inadvertently made herself so heavy that the smooth, slightly slick stones of the pier cracked beneath her.

Bairon slammed the butt of his spear against the ground and stood tall, looking at me defiantly and reminding me firmly of his old self. "We can be, Arthur. And I assume you know that, otherwise you wouldn't have brought us here."

"I hope you're right, Bairon," I said, softening my tone. "Because, if you aren't, then I don't know how we can reclaim our homeland, defeat Agrona, and prevent any further assaults by Kezess Indrath."

"Then let's not waste any more time," Bairon said, his chin turning up as his pride struggled against my words. "I will fight until my core cracks and my muscles give out if it will offer a chance at breaking past the barriers placed on us as Lances. Just tell us what you want us to do, Arthur."

Not long ago, I would have marveled at the idea that the noble Bairon Wykes was so willing and open to following my lead, but even in my short time back, I could see just how much he had matured. The war had forged him into a true leader in a way neither of us could have expected, especially after he nearly died at Cadell's hands.

"Thank you, Bairon, but this won't be that kind of training," I said.

Before they could ask questions, we all heard the grumbling approach of Gideon as he came through the open gate with Emily tottering along beside him underneath a pile of equipment. He wrinkled up his nose, presumably at the smell, and radiated pure irritation. "What in all the worlds you think we need to be down in this abyss for, I'll never know."

"Now that we're all here, let's get started," I said, gesturing for everyone to follow me.

We circled around the edge of the lake until we were under the broad purple, green, and blue caps of the giant mushrooms. Varay and I—and to a lesser extent, Regis, who insisted on dragging a single leather satchel—helped Emily carry the equipment, then set it out on a series of flat boulders after Emily made a fuss of clearing the dirt and moss off. I directed the three Lances to take seats in the thick moss next to the still water of the lake.

While Gideon and Emily set about the task of readying their equipment, I addressed the Lances. "If we hope to break through the artificial barriers placed on you, we need to better understand them. The blood oaths you made don't inherently limit your ability to grow stronger, that is something Kezess Indrath did when he originally gave Dicathen the Lance artifacts, and I can tell you exactly why, because I've seen Agrona do the same thing to his people.

"They've seen what lessers are capable of. They *know* we can reach far beyond them, given the chance." I told them about the djinn, how they had gained insight into aether and mana beyond even what the dragons could do, and how, when Kezess couldn't force them to share that insight, he had destroyed them.

Mica cursed. Bairon frowned thoughtfully down at his knees. Varay's eyes were glued to me as she hung on every word I said.

"The asura expect—demand—control above all else. The Vritra clan

breeds people like mana beasts, while Indrath just plays god from afar, poking and prodding our societies into the shape he desires, then, like a rageful toddler, knocking all his toys down if he gets upset.

“In giving Dicathen the Lance artifacts, Kezess assured that certain family lineages were kept safe and politically powerful while actively declining in magical strength—the true power of this world. He did this by giving them you. Powerful protectors that were bound by blood oath from betraying them. And yet still, to keep any one person or nation from growing too strong magically, he prevented you from getting powerful enough to be a threat to the asura clans.

“Agrona had a finer line to walk. He needed soldiers who could fight asura, whether that be the other clans still in Epheotus or his own people if they thought to turn against him. But he had to be certain they couldn’t ever grow strong enough to challenge him, and so he became the ultimate arbiter of who gets magic in Alacrya.

“The truth is, the asura don’t want us to make progress because they see it as an existential threat to their own dominion.”

Something made a splash in the middle of the lake, the ripples slowly moving outward and disrupting the mirrorlike surface.

Varay adjusted herself on the mossy ground. “You’ve spent more time with the asura than any of us, Arthur. We trust your judgment on this issue, but it does beg the question: what do we do about it?”

I held my hand out to her. She took it, and I pulled her to her feet. “I didn’t see it before, but the first dragon I ever met hinted at what was coming, and what the answer would be. She left a message embedded in the mana of my core but told me I would only hear it when I had reached beyond white core. It was a temptation she knew I couldn’t resist, a way to push me to a level far beyond what most mages would ever achieve.”

“And did you?” Varay asked, her hand a frigid claw around mine. “Is that how you gained your aetheric powers?”

I shook my head. “My core shattered, releasing the message before its time, and my chance of passing beyond white core is gone. But”—I activated Realmheart, seeing the reflection of the glowing lavender runes on the surface of Varay’s eyes—“yours isn’t, and I believe Kezess himself has given us the key to unshackle your true potential.”

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LIMITLESS

VARAY REMAINED UTTERLY STILL as my hand rested over her sternum. With Realmheart active, I could see the purified mana like translucent snowflakes compacted within her core, perfectly controlled and radiating with purpose. The particles were steadily being distilled and released back into her body through her channels to strengthen her physical form and keep the conjured arm in place.

Along with the ability to see mana, Realmheart replicated the ability a mana core provided to sense mana in others, allowing me to feel the crushing weight and glacial steadiness of Varay's core radiating out from her.

I closed my eyes, focusing on this second sense.

"Release a small burst of mana," I said quietly, then followed along as purified water mana—now sparkling motes of its deviant ice form within Varay's core—raced out through her mana veins and into the atmosphere. "Now, draw on the ambient mana and focus on purifying it inside your core. Specifically, think about clarifying your core itself."

Varay took a steady breath in. I opened my eyes to watch the particles of atmospheric mana—almost all water and earth—be pulled into her body and then her core, just like how her lungs drew in the air. Within the snow-white core, the mana was quickly purified and made ready for her use.

I asked her to repeat this process a couple of times, then moved on to Bairon. He studied me carefully as I pressed my hand to his sternum. I was surprised by the smoky tinge to his otherwise bright white core.

"Does your core or your mana feel any different now than before Cadell

attacked you with soulfire?" I asked, watching closely as he released mana, took a stiff breath, and then drew it back in.

He repeated the exercise again before answering. "I'm not sure how to answer that question. I had to work tirelessly to rebuild my strength after that battle, and I nearly gave up and accepted my fate."

"Physically though…when you channel mana now, do you feel anything different in your core?"

He closed his eyes as he repeated the cycle two more times. "I'm not confident that I've regained all my strength," he said eventually. "But I also don't remember if the magic felt any different before."

Nodding silently, I moved on to Mica. As my hand pressed against her sternum, her lips curved up into a cool smirk. "I told you once before, I'm too old for you."

Regis was watching from the rocks where Gideon and Emily had laid out their equipment. He chuckled appreciatively. "And much too pretty, too."

She cast a surprised look over her shoulder, then turned a raised brow in my direction. "Is that tiny creature trying to flirt with me?"

"Actually, he's an asuran weapon of mass destruction, and he flirts with everyone," I said matter-of-factly. "Now focus. Release your mana, hold it, then draw ambient mana back in."

I couldn't sense whatever mechanism Kezess had used to put a ceiling on the Lances' potential, but I hadn't expected it to be that easy. Moreso, I needed to establish some baseline in the feel of each Lance' particular core and mana manipulation.

All three were incredibly efficient at both releasing and reabsorbing mana. Whatever hampered them, it seemed specifically designed so it wouldn't interrupt the process of actually using magic.

"All right, we're all set up over here," Emily said, interrupting these thoughts.

I nodded, and Emily and Gideon began outfitting the three Lances with various apparatus that would allow them to read mana output and reaction times much more accurately than I could on my own.

While they were doing that, I withdrew three items from my dimension

rune. I handed the first to Mica, who turned it over curiously in her hand, and then its twin to Varay. Bairon received the horn I'd taken from the ruined remains of the Wraith, Valeska, holding it carefully in front of him like it was a wasp nest.

"These horns contain a huge amount of mana," I explained. "You'll be drawing from them like I did with the retainer Uto's horns a long time ago. They are incredibly potent, but," I said quickly, as both Bairon and Mica opened their mouths to speak, "I need to warn you, there are additional effects as well. You'll capture some of the previous owner's memories. It can be…uncomfortable."

The Lances' intrigue quickly soured into uncertainty. "But what benefit do you hope that we'll gain from such a source of mana?" Varay questioned, setting the horn in her lap and looking up at me. "If your hope is to simply overpower the barrier with a sudden influx of mana, I'm afraid it's been tried before. Elixirs have no effect on us."

"Nothing as easy as that," I admitted, glancing at Emily, who gave me a thumbs up as she finished activating the last of the monitoring equipment. Behind her, Gideon was staring at the readout, his half-grown eyebrows furrowed in concentration. "I can't promise our time and effort will bear fruit. But none of us can afford to just accept our current limitations."

Mica stared at the ground, her gaze distant and her expression stony. Next to her, there was a charge in Bairon's eyes, an intensity that filled the air with a buzzing static that raised the hairs on my arms.

But it was Varay who surprised me.

She stood up in one swift, graceful motion, her furrowed gaze locked on the mossy stone at my feet. "Arthur, I know I speak for all the Lances when I say we are grateful for your time and effort." A pause, just a heartbeat, then, "But are you certain your efforts here are worth your time? *You* are the key to victory against Alacrya and Epheotus. If your time would be better spent training yourself—"

"No," I said firmly as her intense eyes bore into me. "Dicathen doesn't need a savior or a…" I struggled for the word, then blurted out, "another deity to replace the asura. It needs soldiers and generals. People. *Heroes*. Dicathen needs the Lances."

The ever-immovable Lance Varay faltered, just for a moment, her gaze

searching to determine whether to believe my words. “Of course. You’re right.” Giving me a stiff bow, she sank back onto the soft bed of moss, holding the horn in both hands across her lap. “What do you want us to do?”

Kneeling next to the lake, I ran my fingers through the icy cold water. “The first step is to figure out what exactly is preventing you from purifying your cores further. I want each of you to meditate while drawing on the mana contained in these horns. Normally, taking in such a large amount of mana so quickly would force a core to rapidly clarify. As we monitor your cores during this sped-up process, we’ll be able to watch for any signs of the binding affecting you.”

“You hope,” Gideon grumbled, drawing an irritated look from Emily.

“I do,” I said simply, holding my hands out to my sides. “Now, are you ready to begin?”

“Of course,” Varay said.

“Let’s do this,” Mica added with a firm nod.

Bairon said nothing, but closed his eyes and focused on the horn in his hands.

“All set over here,” Emily said eagerly.

Regis hopped off the boulder and trotted up to Mica, who looked down at him in surprise, then up to me questioningly. The puppy gave a resigned sigh and said, “Don’t get too excited about this, but…” and then vanished into her body.

Mica gasped and nearly jumped to her feet, but I stopped her with an outstretched hand. “The mana in these horns could drive you mad. Regis and I are going to help keep you stable until you’ve gotten control of it, okay?”

“Maybe a little warning next time?” she snapped. “I feel violated.”

I focused on Realmheart, channeling as much of my sensory perception through the godrune as possible. “Go ahead, Mica. Begin.”

The effect was immediate.

Umbral mana, tinged by the black shadow that clung to all things Vritra

related, began seeping from the horn and into Mica's body.

She cringed at the sensation and very nearly tossed her horn away. Her wide and frightened eyes stared ahead unseeing.

"It's just a vision," I assured her, keeping my voice low and soothing. Her fingers were white around the jet-black horn. "Stay in yourself. Remember our purpose. Focus through it. Don't pull too hard. Just let the mana flow."

I kept up a steady stream of consoling, guiding words as I began pushing out with aether, intermingling it within the mana. It was drawn into her body alongside the mana, pulled by Regis's presence. Not all of the Vritra-born mana wanted to be drawn to her core and instead seeped out of her mana veins and into her body, but through careful manipulation of the aether, I was able to round up these stray particles and herd them in the correct direction.

Meanwhile, Mica's eyelids were pressed shut so hard the skin around them turned bright white, while her cheeks flushed plumb purple, and she began to sweat heavily. By the way she gnashed her teeth and fidgeted restlessly, I knew whatever visions she was seeing must have been pretty bad.

"I…I've got it," Mica said a few minutes later, letting out the breath she'd been holding. "That was…totally, incredibly, *extremely* awful."

I bent down and closed her hands tight around the horn. "Keep drawing on it, but not too fast."

Next, Regis and I moved onto Bairon. He adapted more quickly to the flow of the decay-corrupted mana and surfaced from the visions after only a minute or two. Varay had it harder, her visions so severe that I had to hold the horn in her hands for her as she whimpered and twitched. Eventually, though, she too had made it through, with Regis drawing my aether toward himself while I guided the gray particles of mana and prevented them from permeating her body.

The Lances settled into a rhythm of slowly withdrawing and purifying mana from the horns, which almost looked as if they were burning as the dark mana boiled out to wreath the Lances' bodies in a smokey nimbus.

Finally, with no danger of the mana poisoning their bodies or minds, I was able to really *watch* the process. Once in their cores, the mana was being processed, the impurities removed and culled by the core itself, leaving nothing but pure mana behind. But whatever process prevented the cores

from clarifying further wasn't immediately apparent.

"What are you seeing?" I asked Gideon as I watched the mana move in constant eddies within their cores.

Gideon's grumpy façade had melted away as his mind bent to the task. I knew it would; he couldn't resist such a complex problem. "There is a higher-than-normal amount of resistance as they draw in and begin processing the mana—except for Lance Bairon, whose channels and core seem to be functioning at expected efficiency given the Lances' strength. I suspect it is due to the nature of the mana in question, however, not some symptom of the limiters placed upon them by the Lance artifacts."

"It's too bad we don't have those artifacts still," Emily added thoughtfully, one finger tapping against her cheek as she stared down at their equipment. "It would make this easier if we could peel those apart and figure out how they worked."

"That would be ideal, but"—I imbued aether into the dimension rune, withdrawing two of the empowering rods—"we do have these."

In one hand, I held the dwarven artifact, which was crafted from a handle of pure gold and studded along the length with obsidian rings. A large ruby-red gem glowed faintly at one end. The second rod—the artifact designed only for use by humans—was topped with a blue gem, and its handle was forged of silver.

"But we can't use those," Emily said nervously.

"Screw those evil things," Gideon snapped vehemently at the same time.

Of the Lances, only Bairon seemed able to focus on both the horn and our conversation, but he stayed silent, his visage that of a nervous soldier trusting his leader's judgment.

What Virion had said about Gideon's reaction to the artifacts came back to me. "What did you discover in your examination of these?"

"Godly tools are not crafted for mortal hands," Gideon said as if reciting something from memory. "Anyone with half a brain only has to look at those things for two seconds to see that they're a veritable baklava of different spells all layered one over another, none of them decipherable even to a genius like myself. Maybe there is some good wrapped up in it all, but the asura haven't exactly proven their intentions *good*, so it would

be utter foolishness to assume that there isn't more."

The truth was, I agreed entirely with Gideon's assessment. In my own overnight examination of the rods, I had discovered much—more, apparently, than Gideon—including cataloging the first few layers of spells and how they would unfold when the rods were activated. It was a risk, but I knew for certain that Kezess had to have built in a key to undo the Lances' imposed limit if the artifacts were to make them any stronger.

"You're right, Gideon. Which is why we're not going to use them," I said. "At least, not the way Kezess Indrath intended."

"You've discovered something then?" Gideon's half-grown brows drew up into the middle of his wrinkled forehead and he leaned over his boulder toward me. "Go on."

I explained what I had deciphered in my admittedly short time spent studying the artifacts. Gideon nodded along, and before long, Emily was grinning beside him. "That's a good thought," they said simultaneously, drawing a barking laugh from Regis.

"You two spend too much time together," he cackled.

"Don't you primarily live *inside* Arthur?" Emily shot back, still smirking. "Like…a parasite or something?"

"Point, Watsken," Regis said, his little snout bobbing up and down appreciatively.

"Let's not waste any more time," I said, returning the dwarven artifact back to my dimension rune and maneuvering around in front of Varay. "Mica, Bairon, reduce your draw on the horn to as little as possible without severing your connection. I don't think you're at risk of draining the horns prematurely, but better safe than sorry."

They wordlessly did as I asked, and there was a slight reduction in the amount of smoky mana pouring into them.

Varay's icy gaze followed me intensely. The fingers of her natural hand twitched against the horn. She drew in a deep breath and steadied herself.

To Realmheart, it looked as if the uneven flow of mana through her body smoothed into a steady flow, its movement in her core becoming a consistent rotating motion as the new mana was continually integrated into

that which was already purified.

With aether acting as an extension of my senses, I reached into her core, felt the walls, where mana should have continued to scour away what minute imperfections it still had. But the mana moved just inside the core's walls, never touching or penetrating it beyond where the body's channels and veins ran into the organ.

Varay was quickly reaching the limit of how much mana she could absorb. Soon it would become difficult for her to continue drawing it in. For all the mana she could still absorb, an equal amount of purified mana would leak out of her core. This would waste the mana while also being far too slow of a process to help us see what was happening.

Despite how much mana she had already absorbed, I still couldn't sense any mechanism behind the phenomena I was witnessing. I ground my teeth, feeling frustrated for the first time. I had thought for sure that the influx of mana would be the key to discovering what Kezess had done to them.

"What…should I do?" Varay asked after another long moment, her voice strained between clenched teeth.

The gears of my mind were spinning hastily.

Emily and Gideon hadn't yet seen anything useful in all their readings. I had the rod, but I couldn't trust the artifact's internal programming to function if I was inhibiting certain effects. Before I could use them, I needed to understand exactly how the limiting spell worked. Even making an educated guess could be horribly dangerous to the Lances. If I couldn't appropriately direct the spells once I released them, this would all be a total waste.

Varay needed to move more mana.

Think, Arthur. Kezess had designed the Lance artifacts to create a limiter, but more than that, this limiter was carefully hidden, undetectable even when the mage was manipulating large amounts of mana. Certainly, that meant he had concerns, even back when the artifacts were created, that the artificial barrier could be circumvented somehow. But what did he do? How could he hide a spell like that? And, more importantly, how could I *find* it?

One problem at a time, I told myself, trying to corral the rushing torrent of

my mind.

More immediately a problem, I needed Varay to be able to keep moving mana. *If only she could use mana rotation*.

My mind ground to a halt. Mana rotation…

Sylvia had insisted humans were too rigid in their thinking to learn the ability, but much of what the dragons had told me had turned out to be wrong, or at the very least, incomplete. Now it seemed entirely possible that the dragons themselves were too rigid and simplistic in the way they saw humans, elves, and dwarves to see our potential.

Steeling myself, I said, "I know this is going to sound impossible, but Varay, I need you to expend a pretty significant amount of mana without breaking your connection with the horn."

Her brows furrowed into a frustrated scowl. "You're…right. That's impossible."

"It's not," I assured her. "I learned how when I was only four."

She scoffed, and the flow of mana wobbled. Her expression hardened, and I could practically *feel* her will clamping down like a vice as she regained control. "Way to…kick me while I'm down."

Rubbing the back of my neck, I gave her an apologetic smile. "I was *going* to say that the dragon who taught me said only someone with a pliable body and core could learn it. Like a kid. But…I think she *must* have been wrong."

Reading my thoughts, Regis became incorporeal and jumped into Varay's body.

"I'm going to help guide the mana with aether, like before, to stabilize the connection. I need you to keep part of your focus on the horn, but the other part, I need you to cast a spell. Something you can do without thinking." To help the connection, I leaned toward her and took her hands in mine, keeping them clenched tightly around Cadell's horn.

"Try flying," Bairon said, most of his attention on us as he continued to draw only a trickle of mana from the horn in his lap.

"That's perfect," I said, giving him a grateful nod before turning all my attention back to Varay and the stream of mana and aether that connected

us and the horn.

Varay bit her lip, a flash of uncertainty crossing her face, then again wrenched control back. Nothing happened for a minute, then two. Then five.

“I’m sorry,” Varay finally admitted, a hint of shame in her voice, “I don’t understand.”

Refusing to let myself become frustrated, I kept going back over Sylvia’s lessons in my head.

But…I can’t teach Varay the way Sylvia taught me, I realized with a sudden rush of adrenaline.

I had to do it my own way, how *only* I could.

“It’s okay,” I shook my head. “Follow along carefully. I can show you.”

Like shaping clay with a trowel, I began to reform the mana in Varay’s core with my aether. This couldn’t be done with mana, as a mage couldn’t influence the mana *inside* another mage’s body. At first, I was just pulling it out, creating little more effect than if we’d let it be forced out naturally, but that was only the start. Bairon’s suggestion, I thought, was perfect.

Flying was second nature to the Lances as white core mages, something they did without thought, manipulating the ambient mana around them to lift them off the ground. For even a silver core mage, such a feat would have drained their mana reserves in minutes, but a white core mage could fly for hours. It was something Varay and I both understood intimately, and one of the few abilities that worked exactly the same for all Lances.

Another minute passed as I practiced the mana-through-aether manipulation while simultaneously keeping a steady stream of aether flowing to herd the horn’s mana to its final destination in her core, where Regis hovered to draw the aether more accurately.

And then, with a suddenness that caught me off guard, Varay drifted up off the bed of moss.

“This feels so strange,” she muttered, wobbling slightly.

“Hone in on that feeling,” I said as I stood up to stay on a level with her, my hands still wrapped around hers. “Just hold it in your mind for a minute. Get comfortable with the sensation of both manipulating the mana

and drawing it in at the same time."

Varay nodded as she frowned. Her expression soon turned into unyielding determination, as though her pride wouldn't accept anything but success.

Then, coming out victorious, her expression softened. Her breathing evened and her body stilled as though she was meditating.

We stayed like that for another minute, then slowly, very slowly, I began withdrawing my own influence, leaving her to keep the mana flowing on her own. With each step, her flight would become unstable as she rocked about in the air, then she'd clamp down and exert control over it, and I'd ease off a little more.

Just as I was about to release the last piece of my influence, Varay reached out and clutched my hand. I couldn't suppress a surprised smile despite the biting cold of the ice. Holding on tight, I stopped channeling aether through her core and the spell.

Still cross-legged, Varay hovered a few feet off the ground as gray mana poured over and into her from Cadell's horn.

It was a wonder, really, but the breakthrough was so far from what we were trying to accomplish, it was hard to see it as such. For our purpose, it was hardly a stepping stone.

"Emily, tell me you see something here."

"I'm sorry, the readings don't show anything—"

Gideon's voice interrupted hers. "Open your eyes, girl. Look, here."

"Are you sure? I really don't—"

"Right here—"

"Guys!" I snapped, my nerves taught as a pulled bowstring.

"Oh! I think I see it," Emily said, her voice an excited squeak.

I was following the absorption and release of Varay's mana through Realmheart, but couldn't see or sense anything new. "So what is it then?"

She was leaning down toward the series of indecipherable readouts arrayed before her, squinting through her glasses as Gideon pointed at something. "Sort of like…crevices or wounds in the core itself, places where the core

is inactive."

Regis, do you sense anything like that?

'Everything is all shiny and white in here. No wounds to be seen.'

Aetheric particles swarmed in and around Varay's core. With them, I poked and prodded everywhere I could reach, but I couldn't sense these crevices Emily was describing.

"I need you to output more mana," I told Varay. A sudden thought lit up like a lighting artifact in my mind. "Your arm. Varay, you're already maintaining a constant stream of mana just to sustain your arm. Focus on that. Push more mana to it, out of it. It doesn't matter *what* the mana is doing, just so long as you are channeling it and maintaining space to keep drawing in more."

Frost began creeping along the frozen exterior of Varay's conjured arm. Just a hint at first, then more as crystals of ice formed over the smooth surface, freezing my skin and sending a web of light blue ice crawling up my own arm. The air around us grew bitter cold, finally resulting in a gently falling snow all around us.

"Perfect, keep that up."

As more and more mana began to leave her core, it reached a kind of equilibrium.

Emily gasped. "There!"

Just as she said it, I found them. Amidst the perfectly balanced input and output of mana through the core, there were six points where a faint disturbance in the otherwise smooth flow could be sensed. Simply absorbing mana hadn't highlighted the spots due to the way the incoming mana swirled and eddied as it pushed and compacted against the already existing mana.

In any other circumstance, the wounds—*no, scars,* I thought—were entirely undetectable. Kezess must have thought his spell was perfectly hidden. A spark of retaliatory pleasure brought a smirk to my lips.

"Well done, Emily. That has to be it."

But what are these points, and how are they preventing the mana from continuing to clarify the Lances' cores?

Each breakthrough was only the smallest step on the path to understanding.

“I need to let go. As much as you can, don’t let this mana spread in your body. But I think we’re almost there.” Varay gave me a single jerky nod in acknowledgement, and I released both her hand and my constant output of aether.

Brushing the frost off my skin, I picked up the silver-handled rod. “Emily, leave the readouts to Gideon. I think I’ll need your help for this.”

Reluctantly, she left her equipment behind and circled around the Lances to stand beside me. I set the incandescent sapphire crystal against Varay’s sternum. “Okay, imbue mana into the rod.”

I felt her eyes burning into the side of my face, but kept my gaze on the crystal and staff, watching every infinitesimal movement of the mana and aether. After a few seconds, she gripped the staff between two of the silver rings, just below my own hand, and pushed out with mana.

The crystal blazed with blue light, refracting off the snowflakes in the air and bathing the lakeside in sparkling sapphire light. Immediately, mana and aether jumped to life, the particles condensing into spells and rushing along the length of the staff.

Reaching out, I pulled at the aether surrounding and imbuing the staff. The coalescing spells jerked to a halt, jagged and misshapen, and the staff began to tremble in my hand.

A cold sweat broke out across my brow, and I redoubled my effort to hold the magic in place. The rod itself was designed to release several spells in sequence, but I couldn’t allow that. Whatever Kezess intended for these implements, they would only harm us in the long run. Instead, I needed to release only the spell that would undo the damage to Varay’s core.

With the screech of metal shearing, a crack ran the length of the rod. The force of holding back so much mana was ripping the artifact apart from the inside.

Regis!

My companion flew free of Varay’s body, his form appearing only for an instant as a burning wisp, then he vanished *into* the rod.

His pain wracked my body as the surging force around the artifact began tearing at his incorporeal form. *'Argh! It's like…trying to piss in a… hurricane…'*

The gem's light began to flash intermittently from the buildup of energy. The heat turned the snowflakes to rain.

My heart thrummed like the wings of a butterfly, and sweat was pouring into my unblinking eyes. There was too much energy—more than there should have been. It was like the rod was reacting to being tampered with. *A safeguard*, I realized with a sick twist in my guts. *A trap in case anyone messed around with the artifacts. Damn it!*

My entire body began to shake. "You all need to…run," I said, the words vibrating oddly as they left my mouth.

Varay was oblivious to my warning, but Mica and Bairon were halfway to their feet in an instant. Bairon reached for Varay as Mica turned, apparently intending to grab Emily and Gideon.

"Don't move, you idiots," Gideon snapped. He'd coiled some kind of wire around his shoulder and was slowly, carefully approaching me, Varay, and the artifact.

With a kind of clip, he attached one end of the wire to the artifact. The other trailed like a long copper worm back to the equipment laid out behind the Lances. The pressure instantly lessened, and I sensed mana being drawn quickly back along the wires and into a series of mana crystals.

"You've got about twenty seconds before those crystals overload and we all die horribly," Gideon said nonchalantly.

With the pressure lessened and Regis there to help draw and focus my aether, I wrapped the rod's magic in my own power and clamped down as hard as my will allowed. The mana stabilized, but it wasn't going to last for long.

'What exactly are we doing here?' Regis asked with the mental equivalent of letting out a deep, momentarily relieved breath.

The third spell contained in the rod was a vivum-based healing spell. I'm sure that's the spell to heal their cores, but everything is all jumbled up.

Worse than being jumbled up, many of the spells looked *broken*. The ramping pressure and subsequent drain on the artifact's mana had left the spells incomplete.

'Here!' Regis thought urgently, drawing my attention to a specific swarm of mana and aether within the relic.

Crushed and distorted, a thread of vivum-type aether wound around an amorphous wave of silvery mana like that used by my mother in her healing spells.

Using my own purified aether, I began to weave together a barrier around the spell, effectively cutting it off from the rest of the mana like a seamstress cutting away the stitching to remove a single piece of fabric from a garment.

"Running out of time," Gideon said as he examined the bank of mana crystals.

Next to me, Emily whimpered. Her knuckles were white around the silver shaft. Suddenly her knees buckled, and she began to fall.

I wrapped one arm around her, pulling her against my side.

With the spell separated from the rest, I released it, then watched as it flowed out through the crystal and into Varay's core. The mana and aether buzzed around the core, but nothing happened.

"Gideon?" I shouted.

He bent over the readouts. "No change."

My breath caught. All that leaked mana, all the compression and delay, shearing apart the spells…

We must have broken something. The spell wasn't complete, wasn't functional.

"Damn it," I ground out through clenched teeth. A fuzzy static was building up around the edge of my peripheral vision from the strain.

Taking the smallest piece of my consciousness, I broke away a sliver of aether and empowered the Aroa's Requiem godrune. Golden light burned against the conjured rain pattering softly around us. My vision became little more than a clear tunnel at the center of a static void. I tried to blink it

away to no avail.

Aetheric particles danced down my arm and across the surface of the rod. The cracks closed as the particles broke away and condensed there, undoing the damage to the artifact itself. The largest share of my focus remained on the broken spell, and I willed the golden motes past the artifact and into Varay's core.

Fix the spell, I urged. I understood the intent behind the spell, if not the specifics. That had to be enough. But Aroa's Requiem only bumbled about within the core. The particles didn't gravitate toward the broken spell. In an act of pure desperation, I turned them toward the core itself, hoping to scrub away the scars and reverse the damage Kezess had done.

Still, nothing happened. My insight into the godrune wasn't complete. I couldn't heal a person, and apparently I couldn't remake a broken spell either.

I found myself considering those moments back in the Relictombs when I rushed to acquire insight via the keystone. So much of what had happened since could have been fixed if only I'd had a more complete insight into Aroa's Requiem. But whatever force handed down these godrunes seemed to be playing cruel jokes on me.

'Art, the spells in the rod,' Regis said, drawing my attention back to where the spell had first been formed within the artifact.

With the sharp sound of the silver shearing over and over again, the artifact kept healing and breaking, then healing again. Within it, the spells were doing the same.

Each time the aetheric particles from Aroa's Requiem fixed the artifact, the spells within reappeared, whole and undamaged.

That's it!

Reading my thoughts, Regis rushed out of the artifact and took physical form, his jaws closing around the crystal at the end. Just as the rod healed, I cut away the healing spell with aether, and Regis pulled at the Vivum enveloping the silvery mana. It tugged loose before Gideon's device could displace any of the mana, and Regis swallowed it.

The spell drifted into him, searching for a core. He pounced at Varay, becoming incorporeal just as his paws touched her, and then shot into her

core. The spell, pulled into her through him, was released. It immediately broke into six equal parts, but they were directionless.

Releasing Aroa's Requiem so I could send a tendril of aether into Varay's core, I maneuvered each drifting star of silver mana to one of the scars.

White radiance spilled across the surface of Varay's core, then raced along her channels and veins until it came out her pores, bathing her in a soft white light.

"Now, Emily, now!" I said in a broken croak.

Emily's mana receded, and she yanked her hand away from the artifact, her body slumping against me from pure exhaustion.

The magic surging within the rod went still, the particles tumbling free of their constricted shapes, the spells fizzling out without effect.

Varay's eyes rolled back in her head and she tumbled out of the air, falling prone on the ground beside Bairon. He jerked as if to catch her, remembered the horn in his hand, and froze.

As quickly and softly as I could, I eased the tremulant Emily onto the ground before hurrying to Varay. Her breathing was shallow and her connection to the horn had been severed, but she was alive. I pulled her upright. "Varay? Varay. Come on, Lance."

Suddenly her arms wrapped around me, and she was pulling me into a tight hug, her breath coming in shallow gasps. I froze, caught off guard.

"It worked," she gasped. "I can *feel* it, Arthur."

I searched her core, and a broad grin spread across my face as I realized she was right. The mana filled her entire core, pressing out against the hardened shell. As I watched, she reached for the atmospheric mana around us and drew it in.

It scoured against the white walls of the organ, no longer held at bay by whatever scars the Lance artifacts had left on her.

We'd done it.

Indrath's spell was undone.

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A PATH DIVERGED

ALDIR THYESTES

The air of the Cerulean Savanna, home of the Thyestes clan, was warm and dry, but a slight breeze always blew over the grasslands, making the tall blue-green blades dance like ocean waves. We called this the Warrior's Wind, a magical phenomenon conjured millennia past to ensure that the pantheons training out in the hot savanna would always have a breeze to cool them.

I could see the savanna for many miles in each direction from my perch, over the top of the blue-tiled roofs of Battle's End. Our sprawling village grew in shades of red and blue from the very center of the Cerulean Savanna and was the place all pantheons thought of as home, even those from other clans who had never lived here. It was the heartland of all our race.

"The way your eyes drink in the sight of the savanna, one might be forgiven for thinking you expect never to see it again, old friend."

"Sharing such tidings brings me no solace, Lord Thyestes," I said, dragging my gaze away from the horizon to focus on the many-eyed pantheon lord, "but I fear it may be so."

Ademir's four front-facing eyes all focused on me, while the eyes at each side of his head moved rapidly, tracking even the smallest motion around us. "Are you ready to tell me why you've left Indrath Castle, then?"

I steadied my breath and adjusted my posture, which was slipping. *A sign of my inner turmoil*, I thought.

Ademir and I were both high above the ground, carefully balanced atop towering poles no larger around than my pinky. A spiral of such poles filled the central courtyard of Battle's End. The shortest and thickest were to the outside of the spiral, and they grew thinner and taller until reaching the central rod, which was delicate as a needle.

We were several poles from the center, across from one another. Ademir had taken a slightly higher, thinner pole than I, and while I could have gone higher, it would have been an act of disrespect to speak down to my lord.

As was tradition, the higher-ranking pantheon also chose the training pose. Ademir had opted for the relatively simple blade-dancer's pose. Matching him, I balanced on one toe with my left leg stuck out at a downward angle behind me, my toes pointing to the ground. My hands were held stiffly across my body, one palm down at the level of my core, the second palm up before my stomach.

"My service to Kezess has ended," I said at length. This proclamation was followed by another long pause as I considered my words. "I am not a sword to be swung without consideration."

Ademir broke form just long enough to flick a venomous hunter fly from the air, then slid effortlessly back into the blade-dancer's pose. "Few asura now alive can remember the time before Kezess Indrath forged the Great Eight and brought the clans together. Epheotus was a place of endless war and death, a wild and untamed world full of walking catastrophes like the living mountain, Geolus. It is said that the Cerulean Savanna itself was flattened by pantheons wielding the World Eater technique in battle against the dragons and hamadryads.

"And Kezess has long taken credit for ending that age, forbidding the use of the World Eater technique because of its history. Its use nearly destroyed our clan, our race, and all of Epheotus. It breaks not only the world, but the caster as well, and so the pantheons of that age realized it would be better to live in subservience than die among the shattered remains of our world."

A sudden truth revealed itself to me, and the knowledge left a bitter-cold sickness in my guts. "Lord Indrath refused to allow our clan to forget the technique. He demanded that at least one Thyestes pantheon always carry knowledge of the World Eater technique so that he could use it if

necessary.”

Ademir did not respond. He didn’t need to.

I thought back to my training, the crushing weight of my pride as I worked for decades to assimilate my teacher’s knowledge of the technique. The eager young pantheon that I had been thought himself a righteous guardian, a protector of sacred forbidden knowledge and of his clan, his people, of all Epheotus.

And yet my pride had made me easy to manipulate.

Just like young Taci.

Because Kezess needed us to be *willing* to use the World Eater technique if he so commanded.

“I am afraid I must leave Epheotus,” I said, the words sounding as tired as I suddenly felt.

“I know,” Ademir replied. His head turned slightly, and one bright purple eye stopped its rapid movement as it focused on something. I followed the line of his gaze. Wren was hurrying toward the base of the balance posts, waving a hand to get my attention.

Ademir released the blade-dancer and settled into a rest pose. “I won’t insult you by acting as though I have wisdom to share with you, Aldir. You are a paragon of our kind.”

“Thank you, Lord Thyestes.” Then, seeing how agitated Wren was, I added, “Excuse me,” before leaning off my perch and falling. I caught my momentum at the last moment and touched down softly on the hard-packed ground. “Wren, what is it?”

Wren was stone jawed and spoke stiffly as he said, “My golems have seen a force of dragons on the move through the savanna, led by your old buddy Windsom. Something about their pale scowling faces and the way their knees shake with each step tells me their mission isn’t a peaceful one, but that they also don’t seem too terribly excited about what they’ve got to do. Do you think, just maybe, that has something to do with you?”

“Dragons? Marching on Battle’s End?” Ademir growled as he landed beside us, the threat in his words unmistakable. “Now of all times? If he thinks I’ll let this outrage stand—”

“Peace, old friend,” I said, touching my closed eyes and then resting my hand over his heart. “I ask for your vow, Ademir. Do not involve the clan, whatever comes of this incursion. They are not here for the Thyestes.”

“They may come for one, but they’ll find us all, Aldir,” he said firmly, starting to turn away from me. “No member of the Thyestes clan will—”

“Then you must banish me.”

Ademir was so caught off guard by the interruption that it took him several seconds to comprehend my actual words. He scoffed but didn’t move or speak.

“Lord Thyestes, I have given every moment of my very long life—sacrificed everything outside of my duties—to protect my clan and people.” Moving my hand up to the back of his neck, I gently pulled him forward until our foreheads touched. “Now, I am prepared to go willingly into exile to do the same. But you must let me.”

His hand rested on my forearm for a moment, then he pulled away. Craggy lines of pain marred his usually calm features. Several seconds passed, and I sensed him gathering his strength.

“Go then. You…are banished, Aldir, from this place and this clan.”

As he said the words, a scorching fire ripped through the flesh of my neck. The Brand of the Banished. A physical symbol of my lack of a place within Battle’s End or the Cerulean Savanna. The pain was like nothing I had ever felt before, and yet I did not allow myself to express it beyond the gritting of my teeth.

“No pantheon in Epheotus will aid you.” His voice grew rough and emotional as he said the last. “But know that you still may find aid and succor elsewhere, should you need it. Seek respite in the lessers’ world, go to the place known as the Beast Glades on their continent of Dicathen. The ancient dungeons there still contain many secrets, and perhaps even assistance for any wayward sons and daughters of Battle’s End.”

The road of my life had been both long and strenuous, but before, I had always known it finished here, at Battle’s End. Now, that future was gone. Despite having asked for it, it left me feeling momentarily disoriented and adrift, cut off from my own future and fate.

At the very least, it frees me of the burden of ever teaching the World Eater

technique to another, I realized as an afterthought.

Then Wren shifted, his clever eyes reading me as plainly as if I were one of the story tapestries in Indrath Castle, and I settled into my new direction. For a being as old as I was, *new* was a difficult concept to wrap my head around.

But I wasn't rudderless. I knew where I was going next, even if I didn't understand what might come of that journey.

And so, with a final bow to Ademir, who could not meet my eye as I was no longer of the Thyestes, I turned on my heel and marched from the square and into the wide, packed-earth streets of Battle's End. Eyes followed me while pretending not to as I passed the homes, training yards, and merchant stalls, all of which were now shut to me. No one wished me farewell or good luck or bade me good health and strength on my travels, as was tradition.

It hurt more than I had imagined it could. My lack of respect for Kezess and his decisions fomented into *hate* in that moment. When I used the World Eater technique, I sacrificed my honor and pride. That had been bad enough. But now he had taken my home and heritage as well, and for that, I would never forgive the lord of dragons.

It was with this bitter fury-fueled fire blazing within me that I stepped beyond the boundaries of Battle's End, but it was the fear that kept me from looking back, fear that the loss would sweep my legs from beneath me if I did.

The savanna grasses grew shoulder high to either side of the well-trodden path, their aquamarines, cyans, turquoises, and teals endlessly whipping back and forth in the Warrior's Wind. The grasslands no longer felt like a softly rolling ocean, but ten million spears marching at my side toward my oldest and dearest friend among the dragons. It was something, to think that the savanna still stood with me.

It was not long before I found them. I took some small vindictive pleasure from seeing a dozen dragon soldiers stop suddenly, as if their legs would not carry them any closer to me. Windsom, who was leading them, lifted his chin and dragged his most imperious mask across his face, waiting for me to approach.

"Aldir of the Thyestes clan, I have been sent to—"

“Of the Thyestes no longer,” I said formally, cutting across his haughty speech. “I have been banished.”

Windsom’s eyes narrowed. “A convenient shield for your clansmen, but it also simplifies things for Lord Indrath.”

“You are here to arrest me and take me back to receive Kezess’s judgment,” I said, taking a step closer, the magic connecting me to my weapon, Silverlight, tingling across my fingertips.

The soldiers’ hands tightened around their weapons.

Windsom’s expression remained impassive. “Only if you make us. Lord Indrath demands your presence immediately, and we are here to compel your acquiescence.” His brows arched, and he straightened yet further, his mana swelling in a poor imitation of true King’s Force. “With violence if necessary, although Lord Indrath and I both believe you will come peaceably.”

I scanned the faces of the soldiers. I knew them all. Brawny Tassos I had saved from a phoenix flame-rider during the skirmishes after Prince Mordain disappeared. The twins Alkis and Irini had been trained by Kordri since they were just children. I was surprised to see Kastor, who was one of Lady Myre’s private guards. But then, I was quite *unsurprised* to see the glowering Spiros, who I’d demoted for his callous and bitter attitude toward the other clans, and who had hated me ever since.

It was just the same with all the others. I knew them. I’d trained them, fought with them, commanded them.

That was why he’d chosen these dragons. Not because of their strength—although they were each powerful in their own right—but because they had served and fought alongside me.

And now those years of service counted for naught. Like Windsom, they were entirely loyal to Kezess, and they wore their loyalty like a blindfold, ensuring they saw nothing but what he wished them to see.

Right now, he sowed fear among them, I could see it in their eyes. These dragons were ready to fight me but afraid to do so. As they should be.

The wrath reared up like a hades serpent within me again. I thought I was done with death. After Elenoir, I had neither the heart nor stomach to end more lives, or so I’d told myself. Now, looking at these onetime friends

and allies, each of them ready to lay down their lives to protect Kezess's lies, I made a decision.

If they did not value their lives, then neither would I.

"I won't return, not by choice, not by force."

Windsom could not entirely suppress his surprise. His eyes widened and his right foot slid back half a step. The aura emanating from him wavered. "You have changed, old friend. I see nothing of the once great General Aldir left in you." Turning to Spiros, he nodded. "Alive if possible, but Lord Indrath would rather have his corpse than nothing."

"But, Lord Windsom, you assured us that—"

Irini's question was cut short as Spiros thrust his short spear forward and shouted, "Take him down!" Then the soldiers were moving, breaking into formations of four, with Spiros, Tassos, and two others closing first.

Silverlight shimmered into my hand in the shape of a curved kopis, and I stepped into Spiros's charge. The curved blade caught his spear, which I pulled up to block a downward cut from Tassos's overlarge two-handed sword. A longspear thrust at my back snagged the fabric of my tunic as I pivoted, and a burning whip cracked before wrapping around my forearm.

Twisting, I hurled Spiros and Tassos backward while ripping the whip-wielding dragon off his feet.

The longspear thrust again, but Silverlight snapped out and caught the haft just below the forged tip, shearing it in two.

Time began to slow.

One of the soldiers teamed with Alkis and Irini was glowing with golden runes that ran along her tan flesh. Another was standing between her and me, two short leaf-shaped blades raised defensively. Alkis and Irini were to either side of the pair, their weapons up, but their focus was on each other as they shared some silent communication.

Opposite them, having circled around me, the last four dragons were transforming. Their physical forms swelled outward, bumping into one another, scales racing over their bodies as the humanoid features melted away to become reptilian and monstrous.

I saw only a splash of colors: white and gold, blue-black, emerald green,

and the burning orange of distant fire before turning back to the more immediate threat.

The severed spear tip was still somersaulting through the air. I took hold of it, spun, and let it fly at the rune-covered dragon's left eye. The defending twin blades came up and knocked the projectile aside, but not before the dragon's eyes flinched shut.

My mana signature melted away as I channeled Mirage Walk. Before her aevum spell could fully take form, I pushed mana into every cell of my body and stepped out from between my attackers, past the dragon bearing two blades, and just beside the rune-covered soldier. Her eyes opened just as Silverlight pierced her core.

The slowly building weight of the time-stop spell snapped like a frayed rope.

Spinning, I hurled the dying dragon into her protector, sending them both crashing to the ground.

Silverlight jumped out of my hand and slashed through the burning whip, the end of which fell to the dirt and writhed like a dying viper. At the same time, a shadow fell over the battlefield.

The now fully transformed dragons wheeled in the sky above. The largest, her scales glowing white and gold, opened her jaws and breathed out a cone of blue fire tinged purple with aether.

Silverlight shot back to my hand, and I slashed the air while calling upon the force-type mana arts of my kind. The flames were slashed into two separate halves, and the soldiers all around me were forced to dodge as the attack burned away the ground to either side of me. The white-gold dragon twisted rapidly in the air, folding in her wings and diving to avoid my strike.

Pirouetting, I carved a wide arc around me, projecting out a scything force. The savanna rang with a sound like forge hammers falling on hot steel as the force crashed against the soldiers' aether-infused weapons.

All except for the man with the twin leaf-shaped blades.

Half risen, his furious gaze still on his dying companion, he brought his blades up far too late, and my attack struck him full across the chest, rending his armor and opening his flesh. I sensed his mana flicker and die

before his body had even hit the ground. A moment later, the rune-covered woman faded as well.

This. *This* was yet another cruelty I would lay at Kezess's feet. These deaths were as much his work as mine.

"General Aldir, please, stop this madness!" Irini shouted from beside the road. She had thrown herself into the savanna grass to avoid the dragon's fire and was bleeding from cuts all down her arms and legs as the Warrior's Wind whipped the grass about. "We only meant to—*hurk*—"

A blade of cyan grass thrust up underneath her chin, piercing her skull. Her misty pink eyes blinked rapidly as she stared at me with dawning terror, then the grass all around her was cutting and slashing, ripping her to pieces.

The savanna was burning, I realized. The dragonfire had set it ablaze. It was under attack, so it was fighting back. Defending itself and the pantheons.

"Irini!" her brother shouted, his voice cracking. He sprinted for her, no threat to me, and I turned my focus away.

Two of the transformed dragons dove from opposite directions, one unleashing a ball of blue fire from its mouth, the other a beam of white lightning. Hidden within the maelstrom of spellwork, I felt Spiros's shortspear whistling through the air, and from another direction, the whip cracked and cut toward my legs.

With Mirage Walk already active, I was able to instantly step from place to place, easily avoiding the attacks. Or rather, I should have been able to do so, but when I tried, I felt myself slam into some invisible barrier. My shoulder ripped free of its socket from the force of the impact, and I went stumbling back.

The spear hit me just below the breastbone. With a purple shimmer, the aether infused within it punctured my mana. The pain of it traveling through my body and lodging against the ribs near my spine was nothing compared to the brand still burning on my neck.

Dropping to one knee, I took the butt of the spear in one hand while lifting Silverlight over my head with the other.

A transparent sphere of cool light wrapped around me just as the dragon's

breath weapons converged.

Fire and lightning crushed in on the barrier, and Silverlight trembled in my fist as she drank desperately from my mana. Violent ripples ran through the shield.

It shattered.

I burst upward, running along the beam of lightning. With a screech, the blue-black dragon breathing it out snapped closed its jaws and banked sharply away.

An instant later, Silverlight cut the air, projecting a wide arc of cutting force. Blood burst from the dragon's underbelly, and it listed to the side before careening into the savanna, where the grass came alive, turning the blues and greens to dark crimson.

Curved claws like scimitars closed around me, pinning my arms to my side. The massive bulk of an emerald-green dragon blotted out the sky above me, and both dragon and I began to tremble.

"Go, Kastor!" the white and gold dragon shouted, and I understood.

The trembling became a vibration, and the black scales took on an amethyst sheen.

Kastor was teleporting us back to the base of Mount Geolus.

I released Silverlight and groped for the end of one of the large claws. When I found one, I twisted my wrist, resulting in a splintering sound as the claw shattered in my grip. Kastor flinched, and his remaining claws closed hard around me. Dull pain overrode all sensation in my left arm, and Silverlight slipped from my grasp and fell from between the dragon's talons.

As the sword tumbled free, she whirled around and flew up just above me, then slashed at Kastor's emerald-scaled ankle, cutting cleaning through scales, muscle, and bone.

Still partially contained within the severed claw's grip, I began falling.

Spiros hurtled to meet me. He had partially transformed so that lustrous black scales covered his flesh and wide wings sprouted from his back. His eyes burned scorching violet, and fire was flickering between elongated fangs.

I kicked free of Kastor's severed claw, rotated, and swam around Spiros's wild thrust. Silverlight was back in my hand, and she drew a raw, red, gory line from Spiros's shoulder to hip.

In the same motion, I carried through with a short, sharp cut, the force of which sheared through everything between me and the ground, including the whip-wielding Urien of Clan Somath, who burst apart in a shower of blood.

With a fierce tug, I pulled my arm back into its socket just before striking the ground. I hit hard, using the force to kick up a cloud of dust to obscure me, even for a moment, while I tracked the remaining dragons' mana signatures.

On the ground, Tassos and the longspear-wielding dragon, Orrin, both of the Indrath clan, stood shoulder to shoulder to my left. To my right, in the distance, Windsom had fallen well back from the combat. Alkis, Irini's twin, had vanished. Taken by the savanna, I was sure.

In the sky, I could hear Kastor cursing his pain while the other two transformed dragons continued to circle the battleground.

"Let this end," I boomed, not speaking to any of the dragons in particular. "There is no need for the rest of you to die as well."

"Traitor!" Tassos shouted, the word rolling like thunder across the savanna.

Through the cold fury of my rage, I felt my heart thump painfully. This, coming from a warrior whose life I had once saved, who had sworn to return the favor someday as he grinned through the pain of his flesh regrowing over burned limbs…

Could none of them see what I could see?

But no, of course they couldn't. Even I hadn't seen it, not until Kezess had forced me to use the World Eater technique. Until then, Kezess's control over my worldview had been absolute, a veil so subtle and ethereal that it could not be seen or touched.

It would have been better if I could show them. Perhaps another could break Kezess's spell someday. But because I could not, it would be too late for these dragons.

Sensing around me, I felt the walls this time before I utilized Mirage Walk. Distortions in space itself, invisible to every sense except my thoroughly honed pantheon's instinct. One of the dragons was utilizing aether to block the near-instant bursts of speed allowed by Mirage Walk, the Thyestes clan's secret technique.

But of course, when all clans answered to Kezess, there were no secrets from the dragons.

Silverlight shifted forms, becoming an ornate silver longspear, and I thrust at the invisible barrier. Though the dragons' ability to influence aether had made them the strongest of all the races, they did not *control* it. Creating something solid, such as an invisible barrier, was a subtle use of their influence that even the strongest of aether wielders would struggle to maintain against the application of pure force.

The barrier shattered. High above, the white-gold dragon howled in surprise and pain.

Tassos was already moving, his two-hander radiating a black-purple glow that seemed to draw the light from the very air. To my right, Kastor turned into a dive, shooting toward us like a dark star.

Tassos was strong, one of the most physically powerful dragons I had ever commanded. His ability to encourage aether into his weapon made him a truly deadly combatant. But I had trained and fought beside him, and I knew his abilities better perhaps than he himself.

All of his strength was behind the swing, aimed directly at my neck with force enough to shatter any defense. I delayed my forward lunge, channeled Mirage Walk, and took a single step.

Like a sovereign cobra striking, Tassos repositioned his blade, pulling it in tight and drawing it across his body in an impressively quick maneuver. If I had stepped toward him, his blade would have been perfectly positioned to deliver a killing blow.

But I hadn't. My step had been just to the right, barely a half step but enough to take me out of the range of his original sweeping cut. That short step occurred with such speed and momentum, however, that when I released Silverlight, it flew as if it had been fired from a godbow.

Kastor's mouth opened to unleash a blast of lightning, and Silverlight sped into his throat. The dragon went stiff as an old fossil and collapsed to the

ground, dark green wings splintering and neck twisting unnaturally as the diffused savanna light glittered off the wreckage of emerald scales.

Tassos hissed in anger and frustration, his blade blazing. Beside him, Orrin Indrath raised clenched fists, and mana began to swell between them.

Sickly sweet smoke was wafting across the path from the smoldering savanna.

A dragon roared in the sky.

The earth shook.

A ring of ground around me collapsed, falling into an infinite void below. Screaming wind came boiling up from the void like one of the ancient elemental beasts that once roamed Epheotus, turning the narrow pillar of earth on which I stood into a prison cell.

Within the raging hurricane ripping upward from the rend in the world, the roughly shaped, nearly invisible planes of spatium aether could just be seen, like glass in water.

Through the wind and aether, I could see the sweat shining on Orrin's brow and how his fists shook with effort.

The void prison spell was no mean feat. Opening a hole to the void was dangerous at the best of times, but channeling its power was dangerous for all but the most talented mana manipulators. Orrin Indrath had always chafed at his position of guard and soldier. He sought above all greater magical strength, to stand out among his clan, the greatest of all the clans.

A dragon had to reach high to stand out atop Mount Geolus. This one, it seemed, reached too far.

Holding out my hand, I summoned Silverlight from the depths of Kastor's corpse. Twirling the spear, I drove it down into the circle of packed dirt beneath my feet, projecting a wave of force deep, deep into the ground.

The pillar, carved by Orrin's spell, splintered and broke to pieces before tumbling down into the void. I flew upward, hovering, fighting the growing pull as the void thrummed hungrily, devouring all that touched it. The wind went up and up and up, and it grew more and more difficult to keep flying. But the situation was escalating outside the spell's circumference far more quickly.

The roar of the wind was too loud for me to hear anything being said, but the way the two transformed dragons wheeled about in panic and how Orrin's entire body shook suggested very clearly that he was struggling, and failing, to control the spell.

Painfully slowly, the void began to drag me back down. My attack had disrupted the shape of the spell, making it unstable. Eventually, Orrin's hold over it would collapse, but that wouldn't help me if I'd already been unmade in the oblivion below. And so I reared back with Silverlight. She became a slim, beautifully crafted rapier and left a silvery arc in the air where she cut.

Below me, the void roiled, the black-purple nothingness bucking and shifting as it devoured the force of my attack. I slashed and thrust and cut, each blow reaching far beyond Silverlight's gleaming point, pouring more and more force and mana into the void.

The walls of wind were growing steadily more unstable. Orrin's form became indistinct, his edges blurred.

The spell broke.

The magic ripped Orrin's physical form apart down to a cellular level, nothing left but a cloud of his purified mana, and even that quickly faded into the atmosphere.

I was left hovering over a deep circular pit that ended in a rough patch of broken rock some hundred feet below.

Tassos stared, mouth agape, at the place where his cousin had ceased to be. Silverlight thrust forward, and his neck opened with a spray of arterial blood. Both hands flew to his throat, but they couldn't stop the red running through his fingers. His sword fell to the ground, the aetheric glow infusing it blinking and going out. He followed it a moment later.

The flying dragons pulled back, one beautiful gold and white, the other the orange and red and yellow of a sunrise, both radiating a powerful aura of fear as they circled tightly in the sky above Windsom. "What do we do?" the white-gold dragon shouted down.

"I think we have seen enough," Windsom said, feigning sadness. "It is clear the once mighty and loyal Aldir Thyestes has been lost to madness. We will return with a greater force."

I flew toward Windsom, rising slowly so I could comfortably look down at him. “We never should have continued to follow Kezess after the djinn, old friend.”

Windsom's nose wrinkled. *“Lord Indrath.”*

“We should have seen what he was then. We have a chance to do so now. Make things right.”

Windsom was shaking his head and scowling. “You simply proved too weak to carry out the duty assigned to you.”

I hadn’t expected Windsom to show remorse or change his allegiance, but I still felt the stabbing pain of regret and loss knowing that we were now truly enemies.

No more words were exchanged. Windsom conjured a portal and stepped through it. The two surviving dragons turned and flew away at speed. I let them go.

Movement to my right caught me off guard, but it was only Wren in his floating earthen throne.

“This is what Kezess wanted,” I said with a sigh, speaking as much to myself as Wren. “For blood to be shed, so that he could paint me as a monster and erode any support I might have remaining in Epheotus.”

“Quite fitting for that high-functioning sociopath to use the very soldiers you helped train as fodder to paint you as a monster.”

“Hmm.”

“You know, I think it might be time to get the hell out of here,” he went on, watching the dragons recede into the horizon. “Property values in the Cerulean Savanna are sure to go down considering the infestation of dragons here. And void holes. And killer grass.” He eyed me skeptically. “Did you know about that, by the way? A little warning would have been nice. What if I stepped on the wrong blade of grass and all the others got pissy and turned me into titan confetti?”

“This is hardly the time for japes,” I answered, too cold inside to find any amusement in his words.

He shifted in his seat, leaned back, and rested one leg over the other. “I beg to differ. There is no better time for *gallows* humor.”

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DESCENSION

ARTHUR LEYWIN

Leaning against the base of a squat apple tree and chewing on the last of its ripe fruit, I stared out at the fields south of Blackbend City.

Once these flat plains and low, rolling hills would have gleamed gold with endless fields of wheat, but large swaths of farmland had been crushed flat by the tent city now ringing Blackbend's southern edge and the ten thousand or more troops stationed there. The gray-and-red clad soldiers moved with stiff short steps, and I saw many heads bent in conversation and furtive glances being cast about. More than once, ranking officers stopped to shout at a group of gossipers as messengers rushed about with a frantic air.

After a brief jaunt to the Relictombs to ensure both Regis and I were at full power, we'd followed the wide swath of churned sand that marked the Alacryan army's passage through the desert and into the foothills separating Sapin and Darv. The tempus warp I'd recovered from the Wraiths would have made it a simple matter to teleport the distance, but I needed to ensure that the Alacryan force didn't split or divert to a different destination.

Despite their multiday lead, the soldiers who had retreated from Vildorial had only recently arrived. From my distant vantage point, with my senses heightened with aether so I could more clearly follow the bustling of the many soldiers, I tracked the comings and goings of the war camp for a while, content to just watch as the Alacryans stewed in their own uncertainty.

It had already been a couple of hours while Regis and I waited under the apple tree. Unfortunately, there had been no sign of the retainer and regent, Lyra Dreide, or of the two Scythes. They would have made a convenient prop for the spectacle.

It felt good to be in the field again, an enemy in front of me. My return to Dicathen had been defined by furtive rushing through underground tunnels and living in fear for my family and all the Dicathians under my protection. I was tired of skulking about and hiding. This was a war. It was past time to fight it.

But I could only do so now because of the Lances. The damage to their cores, forced on them in the same ritual that bound them to their respective kings and queens and catapulted them to white core, had been healed. Varay, Bairon, and Mica were, at the very moment, back in Vildorial, meditating over the remains of the mana in the Vritra horns I'd acquired in order to grow stronger for the first time in a very long time.

When the Lances next faced the Scythes, I was confident the results would be very different.

A horn sounded in the war camp, and soldiers began to gather.

Ready?

Regis drifted free of my body and condensed into the form of a full-grown shadow wolf. "Oh, this is going to be fun."

Together, we began moving quickly from the hilltop where the lone tree grew, down into a slight valley that opened up into the trampled fields, and directly toward the sprawling encampment. Once in plain sight of the guards watching to the south, we slowed to a steady march. It didn't take long for them to spot us.

Another horn blew, then another. These were wilder and, I thought with some amusement, somehow afraid. Several men jumped on quick-moving lizard mana beasts called skitters and rushed to cut me off.

Still a hundred feet away, one of them gave a shout, and the sand-yellow lizards all skidded to a stop, holding well back.

Their leader, a man in his early twenties with a thin blond beard and dark, steady gaze, took in my appearance and went pale. The other soldiers all turned in his direction, and I could tell that they all recognized me from the

rumors even if they had never seen me directly. The skitters, sensing their riders' discomfort or perhaps made nervous by Regis's presence, shied and tried to pull back.

"St-state your identity," the leader said, his voice cracking slightly. He cleared his throat and sat taller. Without waiting for me to respond, he immediately asked, "Are you the traitor to Alacrya known as Grey? If so, know that the regent Lyra of Highblood Dreide has given orders that you are to be killed on sight."

I looked him right in the eye and said, "What are you waiting for then?"

He raised his chin, one hand on the bridle of his skitter, the other on the handle of his sword. "What do you want here?"

"That's easy," I said, pointing past him to the tent city. "That, gone. *You*, gone. Now."

The boy's jaw tightened beneath his blond beard. To his credit, he did not immediately flee, although I could tell he was thinking about it. "You are only one man. There are several thousand soldiers at my back. Surely you don't—"

I reached for the relic armor. The sight of it unfolding over my skin made the soldier yank hard on the reins, and his skitter danced sideways and nearly threw him. "If you've seen me before, then you know I always offer the opportunity to lay down your arms and leave with your lives. The Vritra clan is my enemy, not the people of Alacrya. Disband this encampment and prepare to leave Sapin immediately."

He kept up eye contact for a long moment while his skitter jerked from side to side, now actively attempting to pull away. Finally, he let it, and the mana beast whirled around and shot off toward the war camp. The rest were quick to follow.

"Tired of sounding like a broken record yet?" Regis asked, letting his tongue loll from one side of his mouth.

"It gets harder to offer clemency each time they refuse it," I admitted, crossing my arms as I watched the skitter riders hurry away. "But it's the right thing to do, Regis. If I could snap my fingers and send all these Alacryans back to their own continent without any violence, I would. But…" My voice grew firm as I felt my will harden. "Anyone who would make themselves a pawn of the Vritra—whether they're born in Alacrya or

Dicathen—has chosen their own fate."

The scouts had reached the camp, and a muddle of chaotic activity followed. Shouts and arguments rang across the hills. I watched as the higher-ranking officers clashed with growing animosity and the camp's organization quickly dissolved under a lack of leadership. I thought the Alacryans might collapse into violence, but then a booming voice drowned out all others.

A gargantuan woman in heavy black plate armor hurled a man to the ground and pointed at me with a burning greatsword, and the Alacryans began falling into line. While a few groups of soldiers broke ranks and fled north, most hurried into well-ordered rows of battle groups at the woman's direction. Shields flared, empowered weapons and armor blazed to life with mana, and a rainbow of spells were activated.

I couldn't help but be disappointed as I looked across the field at the thousands of Alacryan mages.

"This really would be so much easier if they had sense enough to run for their lives," I muttered.

"Much less fun though," Regis japed, chuckling darkly. "Maybe it would help if they got a good look at me in all my glory?"

I nodded my approval. "Do it."

With a wide lupine grin, Regis activated the Destruction godrune. His body blazed with purple flames, his physical form expanding and transforming, growing huge and bestial, all hard, sharp angles and jagged fire and long black spikes. His head widened and flattened as obsidian fangs grew out of his mouth. Wings sprouted from behind his arched shoulder blades, and then I leapt onto his back.

Regis lifted up off the ground and gave a roar that shook Blackbend. He breathed out flames of pure Destruction as he wheeled through the air high above the enemy.

A tremor of terror shook the awestruck Alacryans. A Shield ceased conjuring and turned to flee, but the woman who had taken charge of the army appeared before him in a flash of white-hot fire, her sword already swinging. He didn't even have the chance to conjure another protective shield before he fell into two burning halves.

“Any other who shames their blood by turning tail condemns their blood as well! By the Vritra, I’ll make sure your mothers and daughters bleed for your cowardice!”

At the woman’s threat, spells began to fly, filling the sky with blues, reds, blacks, and greens. Cutting rays and bursting missiles erupted around us like fireworks. Regis’s Destruction-infused breath burned away several of the strongest spells. Others, I batted aside with aether. More missed or reflected harmlessly off the relic armor or the thick layer of aether cladding Regis’s bulk. What little damage we took healed almost instantly.

“Cockroaches,” Regis rumbled in his much deeper voice. “They’ll be less than ash when I’m done with them.”

“Wait,” I said, counting on one last gambit to break the line without a full-scale slaughter.

I didn’t have to look for the aetheric pathways between me and the Alacryan leader. As I imbued the godrune with aether, it guided me, and I vanished from Regis’s back and appeared in front of the leader, just inside the effective range of her overlarge sword.

She grunted in surprise and brought the blade up defensively, both the flames and the purple lightning wrapping around my limbs reflecting in her dark eyes.

Faster than she could react, my hand snapped out and caught the blade. Realmheart flared to life, making visible the mana in her weapon. I severed the flow, snuffing out the mana, then pushed aether into the steel. Although of fine make, the metal couldn’t handle the pressure and exploded, peppering us both with shrapnel. Although harmless to me, a piece slashed across her cheek, and she snarled as she stumbled back from the explosion.

God Step took me behind her. My gauntleted fist drove into her spine where her armor opened to reveal several runic tattoos. The bones shattered, and her lifeless body flew into the backs of a nearby battle group, knocking them to the ground.

The exchange had been so fast that most of the Alacryan soldiers hadn’t noticed and were still slinging spells at Regis. Only those closest to hand had witnessed their leader's demise, and most of them could only stare in dawning horror. The smart ones, however, broke ranks and fled. And as

soon as a few had done so, dozens more followed.

'Well, that was dramatic,' Regis thought from above. *'The center of their line is caving in on itself. Most of them are running like hell.'*

Lay down a line of fire just beyond the front line, I thought back. *Avoid the fleeing soldiers where you can, but don't hesitate to burn anyone who keeps fighting.*

The jagged fire jumped and twisted in a way that expressed gleeful excitement. *'You got it, boss.'*

Tipping into a dive, Regis ducked and weaved between the bombardment of spells before leveling out just in front of the foremost shields, which made up a kind of wall of wavering flames, whirling water, crackling lightning, and transparent panels of mana. Destruction blazed from his monstrous maw like dragon's fire, spilling over the field and splashing against the shields, devouring the mana.

I stood at the center of the chaos, a stone unmoved by the retreating sea. No one attacked me—most would not even look at me, as if avoiding me would somehow make me less real. They stumbled over each other, pushing and shoving as they ran around me, away from the violet flames and toward the city.

The encampment itself became an obstacle, but the surge of bodies trampled it under heavy boots, collapsing tents, overturning tables, and kicking campfire ash everywhere as they charged heedlessly past.

I began moving toward the city gates, slowly walking amidst the chaos and insanity. The front lines had crushed back into the rear ranks, and where those who attempted to flee were blocked by those who fought on, all out brawls erupted. But no one came within fifteen feet of me, even if avoiding me meant diving through the high flames of a cooking fire or batting down their own allies.

The resounding vibration of large bells suddenly rang all throughout the city of Blackbend, the backdrop to our battle. Many of the fleeing soldiers were rushing toward the city's open gates, although, as the army shed more soldiers, many were forced to flee east or west along the lines of the city wall or risk clogging the gates and being stuck outside.

'Something's up inside the city. Spellfire all over the place. People are fighting back.'

Through the narrow openings on the second level of the gatehouse, I could see men scuffling and fighting. Then, an instant later, a mossy-haired elf hurled an Alacryan guard from the gatehouse to be dashed on the stones below. In the next moment, the grinding and clanking of thick chains rumbled across the battlefield, and the gates began to pull shut, right in the face of the retreating army.

I appeared before the gates wreathed in aetheric lightning and conjured a gleaming violet blade.

I was surrounded by charging Alacryans. Some few had already breached the city before the Dicathian warriors managed to winch the gates closed, but many more were still approaching.

A woman barreling toward me shouted out in dismay and wildly swung her frozen mace, but my aetheric blade bisected her weapon effortlessly. I caught her momentum on my shoulder and sent her flipping over me, and for a moment tendrils of bright violet lightning connected us.

Suddenly, the Alacryan soldiers closest to me were stumbling and collapsing to the ground. I took a step toward the retreating force, and more fell to their hands and knees, bodies trembling. One more step, and my intent reached its peak, crushing everyone within a hundred feet of me into the churned soil.

Cries of dread and the sounds of grown men retching and weeping lingered for a long, timeless moment, and then the battlefield went utterly silent, leaving them clawing at their throats or chests as the weight of the aura stole the air from their lungs.

Those still outside the worst of my intent pulled up short, then quickly dissolved into pushing and shoving. Behind them, Regis let out a monstrous roar that shook the ground, and a wall of amethyst fire engulfed a dozen battle groups that were still fighting back.

“Listen to me,” I announced, easing the pressure I was exuding to refocus their attention. “This city is no longer under Alacryan dominion, and soon, the rest of Dicathen will be freed. You can go home so long as you do not harm any Dicathian. All Alacryans who refuse to leave or who harm any Dicathian will be executed immediately.”

In the distance, there were no more gouts of Destruction or answering spellfire from the ground. The Alacryan force at Blackbend had been

routed.

“W-where will we go, then?” a thin Caster shouted.

An answer was shouted from the top of the wall behind me in a familiar, cutting voice. “Might I recommend the end of a blade?”

I turned to see a reed-thin man with a sharply angular face. His black hair was flecked with gray now, and shorter than the last time I’d seen him, but the rimless glasses perched atop his nose were the same, as were the clever, observant eyes. He had aged, developing worry lines down the side of his face and across his brow.

When the man saw me looking, he nodded firmly. “General Arthur. The Alacryan highbloods managing the city have been quite upset for the last few days, terrified that you would show up and hoping fervently that you wouldn’t.”

“Kaspian,” I said, caught off guard by his sudden appearance. Kaspian Bladeheart had once managed the Adventurers Guild Hall in Xyrus, and was the uncle of my old friend, Claire Bladeheart. “You’ve gotten old.”

He scoffed and shook his head. “And you hardly look anything like the boy who I once tested to be an adventurer. But I suppose now isn’t the time to catch up, is it?” He gestured behind him. “The Adventurers Guild has managed to retake the city, General Arthur.” His gaze turned to the Alacryan army, sweeping across the hundreds of soldiers knocked prone around me to pin the thousands more hovering uncertainly between the city and the distant flames of Destruction. “Now, I strongly suggest you have your beast finish the rest before whatever you’ve done to them wears off.”

The world seemed to hold its breath. Then, “No, Kaspian. That isn’t my intention.”

A muscle in his jaw twitched, and his voice strained as he said, “I don’t know where you’ve been or what has happened to you, Arthur, but perhaps you haven’t seen the brutality and cruel vindictiveness of these Alacryans. I feel no shame in saying that every one of them should be put to the sword.”

I ignored him, instead watching Regis return, his enormous bulk casting a dark shadow over the Alacryans. He took a moment to hover in front of the gatehouse, staring Kaspian and the other Dicathian adventurers down

before landing heavily next to me. The jagged flames of his mane trembled, and then he was shrinking in on himself, losing his more bestial features, until he was a shadow wolf again. He bared his fangs and growled menacingly before becoming incorporeal and drifting into my body.

How many chose death for Agrona?

'A couple thousand at least. There was still a small force holding back, defensive positions only, no more chucking spells, but if I stayed in that form much longer, I'd have been stuck as a pup again, and I don't think either of us want that right now.'

Well, if my plan works, they'll be dealt with by their own.

With Regis no longer swooping over the battlefield like a giant mutant bat, some soldiers were breaking away from the crowd and following the others who had already fled around the city. I let them go. I knew they were a risk—there were dozens of small farming communities to the north where trained soldiers and mages could cause havoc—but I had to deal with the larger threat first.

Releasing my intent, I scanned the Alacryans. It was unfortunate that the ranking Alacryans in the city had already fled. With Bairon and Virion's assistance, I had brainstormed a general plan for how to handle enemy soldiers who were smart enough to lay down their weapons. It wasn't without its problems, however.

"You," I said after a moment, pointing at a man who was gingerly lifting himself off the ground and brushing the dirt from his uniform.

He froze and stared at me. His hair and beard were carefully trimmed, and he wore what looked like a very expensive blade at his side, despite not carrying himself like a warrior.

"You're a Sentry," I observed. "And at least a named blood, by the look of it."

His brows pinched together, and he opened his mouth, hesitated, bit the inside of his lip, then finally said, "I am Balder of *Highblood* Vassere, sir."

"Vassere? Oh, perfect," I said, giving the man a placid smile that only made his frown deepen. "Balder, you are now responsible for the lives of every Alacryan stationed at Blackbend—even those currently running

north like their lives depend on it."

Color drained from his face, and he looked around in panic. "But I… um…" He cleared his throat. "I'm not the commander of this force—"

"The men and women around us are no longer a *force*," I said firmly, letting my gaze burrow into him. "They are stranded citizens of a far-off continent, and if they ever hope to get home, they'll need someone to keep them organized and out of trouble. That's going to be you, Balder. Assuming you *want* to see home again. You do, don't you? Central Dominion"—Balder startled at my mention of his home dominion, then went white as a ghost as I continued—"Drekker and all the rest."

"But…how do…"

"Just listen," I said, softening my tone somewhat.

I could feel Kaspian's concerned gaze on my back as I explained loudly to Balder of Highblood Vassere what I expected of these Alacryans if ever they hoped to see their homes again. With the long-ranged teleportation gates in Darv deactivated—and reactivating them, even for a short time, was a substantial threat—there was no easy way to relocate so many people. Until I was sure the continent was firmly back in Dicathian hands, they needed to be moved somewhere they wouldn't be a danger.

It had actually been Virion's idea to use the ruins of Elenoir. Even with tens of thousands of Alacryans gathered there, they wouldn't have enough resources to mount any kind of counterattack through the mountains or the Wall. Just staying alive by hunting the outer edges of the Beast Glades would take all their time and resources for such a large population.

Getting them there from the cities in the east of Sapin was relatively straightforward as well, and the Wall was apparently still under Dicathian control, so I wouldn't even have to retake it to allow the plan to move forward.

"Start organizing your people," I said after Balder had assured me he understood. "I want to know exactly how many lives make up your company. And if you've managed to hold onto any skitters, send riders north. Find as many of those who fled as you can." I let an edge of threat creep into my voice as I added, "I will hold you responsible for any crimes they commit."

Balder swallowed heavily. "I u-understand."

Leaving the Alacryans behind, I God Stepped to the top of the wall, appearing right next to Kaspian. He flinched, and his hand went to the hilt of his thin rapier, the same blade he had tested me with when I was only a boy in this world. A handful of adventurers surrounded him, and half of them brandished weapons while the other half jumped back in surprise.

I ignored all the others. “What happened in the city, Kaspian? I was expecting to have to root out the entrenched Alacryan leadership after dismantling that army.”

He straightened his light gray tunic, which had bloodstains on the sleeves and chest, and waved for his men to lower their weapons. “The truth is, we’ve been waiting for an opportunity to strike back ever since the Lances raided the Blackbend Guild Hall. As the war camp organized to face you, the city’s so-called leadership was flying into a panic. As soon as we drew our weapons, they fled, abandoning the city.”

Turning, I rested my hands on top of a crenelation and took in the confused and milling crowd of Alacryans. Balder was shouting as he tried to sort out the highest-ranking soldiers and other highbloods, but the army was in shock and largely unresponsive.

So much rested on this Sentry’s ability to create calm from chaos. I didn’t have time to linger in Blackbend, but I couldn’t just leave a disorganized and frightened army at the city’s gates, either.

But to further complicate matters, I didn’t entirely trust the Adventurers Guild. It wasn’t an army, exactly, but many of Dicathen’s most adept warriors and most powerful mages were adventurers. Many branches of the guild had opted out of participating in the war, then quickly entered talks to work alongside the Alacryans when they won.

Kaspian Bladeheart seemed like a genuine and honorable person. Claire certainly had been, although, as Jasmine Flamesworth showed, sometimes the fruit ended up a long way from the tree. But without even a council to determine the direction of Dicathen or Sapin as a whole, this presented a unique opportunity for the Adventurers Guild to seize power and authority.

What I really needed was someone in Blackbend who I could trust implicitly but was also a respected member of the Adventurers Guild.

The answer was obvious the moment I had the thought.

“Kaspian, are you the ranking member of the guild here in Blackbend?”

He had been watching me carefully through the glasses perched on the end of his nose, and he wriggled them back into position with a frown before answering. “No. The guild hall manager here is a close friend of mine, but many of the ranking committee members are also based out of the Blackbend Guild Hall now. Xyrus became…troublesome to navigate, especially after the Lances’ attack on the academy.”

“Xyrus is next on my list,” I said, turning to meet his sharp-eyed gaze. I held him there, pinned, impressing upon him the reality of my station with nothing but a look. “But before I can deal with the forces there, I need to know something. Can I trust you, Kaspian?”

His thin brows shot up in surprise. “Is this some move to seize power over the continent?”

I shook my head firmly, encouraged by our parallel thinking. “Only to reclaim it from the Alacryans. As for what happens when they’re gone, I promise that I have no desire to be a king again.”

“Again?” he asked, clearly confused.

“Never mind,” I said with a laugh. “I just meant, I want to save our continent. Not rule it. Virion and Tessia Eralith are both alive, as are Curtis and Kathyln Glayder. And”—I couldn’t help the wry smile that crept over my face—“there are about a hundred dwarven lords who all think *they* should rule Darv.”

Kaspian shot a thoughtful glance at his men, sucked his teeth, then said, “I’ve only ever heard good things about you, Arthur, and my niece spoke very highly of you. I believe I can trust you, so, yes, you can trust me.”

“Good,” I said, reaching out a hand. He took it firmly. “Because I’m handing this city over to the Twin Horns, and I need you to facilitate a smooth transfer of power.”

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THE LEAST OF THE SCYTHES

NICO SEVER

The sterile glow of my workbench lighting artifacts illuminated an array of parts that were spread out over the dark wood. Silver runes ran around the edge and across the surface of the Imbuing table in circles of varying sizes.

I picked up two nearly identical objects: hexagonal fittings with a series of grooves and notches etched into the inside. Both were alloys of silver rather than pure silver—I speculated these might perform better for housing active mana crystals, but I would have to experiment to see which alloy held up better and resulted in a cleaner transfer of mana.

There were a thousand variables to consider while undertaking an Imbuing project as complicated as this, and I couldn't afford anything less than perfection.

My eye caught on a blemish on the edge of one of the interior grooves in the fittings. With a frustrated breath, I tossed it back on the charwood workbench surface.

Yet another delay. That blemish is going to prevent the mana crystal from seating properly. And I'll have to order a replacement from a different silversmith, too.

My right eye twitched, and another memory of Earth invaded my focus.

In it, I was perhaps eight or nine, sitting by myself behind the orphanage. With a small pocketknife in hand, I was whittling a stick I'd found in the street. Nothing special, just carving a bunch of circles around it so that it kind of looked like a pretend magic wand.

I'd carved just over half of the stick when the knife slipped, slicing deep into my thumb. It hurt, but I was more afraid of being caught with the knife. Headmaster Wilbeck would have taken it away and scolded me, then I'd have had to see that stupid I'm-suffering-with-you look on Grey's face for a week. It was a small but important lesson.

Be more careful. Pay attention but don't draw attention. Hide when you're hurting.

A life was made of thousands of little moments like this…the fear and the pain clear over everything else, teaching a person not to touch a hot surface or put their thumb on the wrong side of the blade. It was a large part of the material that forged a personality.

Without those memories, what did a person become?

Faced with questions I couldn't answer, I reached for the apathy I had felt after waking up in the laboratory far below…after Grey destroyed my core and left me to die.

After Cecilia did the impossible and healed me again.

One fist hammered on the workbench, making the prepared parts jump.

The dragon core I'd stolen rolled out of a circle of runes and toward the edge of the workbench. The rage I'd felt was washed away by a sudden pang of alarm, and I practically lunged across the table to grab the core, cradling it in both my hands.

Holding the cold hard shell, it was easier to push away the angry voice within me and focus on the apathy instead. I would need that control. As much as these invasive memories of my past life—on both Earth and Dicathen as the fool, Elijah—were troublesome, I also felt fiercely protective over them.

They were mine. And now that I had them back, I wouldn't give them up again.

Which meant I would have a secret from Agrona. There was something thrilling about that prospect. He was not a man who could easily be fooled, however. I would need to feign a lack of control while actually holding an iron grip over myself and my emotions. I couldn't give him any reason to tamper with my mind.

This line of thought caused a sharp twinge of guilt that I couldn't ignore.

Cecilia…

Despite my eagerness to speak with her after the resurgence of my old memories, I'd only crossed paths with her briefly, and I hadn't found it in myself to start the discussion I knew we needed to have. At that very moment, any number of falsified memories were clouding her mind, memories that I had helped develop. More than that, though, I had no way of knowing how many little moments of her previous life she might be missing.

How much of what made you the person I love most in all the world is still intact? I wondered, biting the inside of my cheek until I tasted the metallic tang of blood.

I closed my eyes hard, scrunching up my face and tightening my muscles, then released the tension. If I tumbled down into the deep, cold darkness of these thoughts now, I'd never complete my current task.

Carefully, I eased the core back onto the workbench and examined the array of parts and equipment I had managed to get hold of quietly. It would have been much simpler if I hadn't also felt the need to keep my activities shrouded from Agrona—or whatever much of it was possible.

The problem was that I couldn't make everything myself. Sure, there were facilities inside Taegrin Caelum to do so, but everything I did there would be watched. And if I ordered all the materials from the same Imbuers and smiths, I risked giving away too much of my design. And so I'd quietly gathered everything piecemeal.

This was better for keeping things quiet, but not so much for efficiency. In addition to the scuffed fitting, I'd already received three mana crystals with imperfections, a piece of charwood three inches too short, and an order of refined quicksilver that was contaminated with cinnabar.

But the resurgence of my old memories had reminded me exactly where my strengths lie. For far too long now, I'd relied on the inherent raw power that came from being reincarnated into a Vritra-blooded body. The ability to master even one of the Vritra's decay-type mana arts made me stronger than most other mages in this world, and I had leaned on that almost exclusively throughout my training in Taegrin Caelum. Even the runes marring the flesh along my spine seemed paltry afterthoughts by

comparison.

But with more of my old memories returning in bursts, I realized I had something else, too, something no other Alacryan had.

On Earth, I'd been a technical wizard, mastering advanced scientific principles at a young age to achieve feats like suppressing Cecilia's ki and allowing her to function in something akin to a normal life. After her death…I spiraled, throwing myself into my research, learning everything about engineering, physics, and ki-related studies that I could.

A surprising amount of this knowledge was directly transferable to working magic, especially Imbuing and artificing. Energy had to be sourced and efficiently transferred, instructions were presented, power output to provide a specific result.

Efficiency, I repeated to myself. *That is the real problem. If what I'm doing is going to work, it has to allow entirely efficient manipulation of the mana, with no delay or loss.*

In Dicathen, I'd been trained to manipulate atmospheric mana, not just my runes and the spell formations they provided. I'd gone to one of the best magic schools on the continent and studied under talented professors, learning mana theory and a type of manipulation that wasn't studied in Alacrya.

Mages learned to understand the shape of a spell, to mold the mana with their mind and their intention through chants and other devices like wands. It was harder, and it took longer, but it was much more versatile. The mage could adjust the focus of their intent or the words of a chant to change a spell's output, or even invent an entirely new spell.

Runes, on the other hand, could be mastered but never changed. They were fixed, as was the benefit they provided to both the mage's core and body. And without new runes being slowly doled out by Agrona's servants, no Alacryan mage could make true progress, even among the Scythes.

But there was no reason I had to rely on Agrona to gain power. Not with all the knowledge and skill I had at my disposal.

I saw everything more clearly now that my core had been ruined and rebuilt.

Cecilia had worked a miracle I still didn't understand in returning the gift

of magic to me, but it wasn't without a cost.

My core was weak.

And that meant everyone would see *me* as weak.

But the world was changing. Everything was shifting around us, becoming more dangerous by the day. Cecilia had been so busy since I'd recovered, and I knew there was only one reason that would be.

Agrona was preparing her for war.

If she thought I was too weak, she would leave me behind. There would be sadness in her eyes when she did so, and she would truly believe it was for my own protection, but it would destroy us. She'd never look at me the same way again, and Agrona would slowly cut me out of the picture. Soon, she would be nothing but a weapon for him, and worst of all, she wouldn't even know that she'd wanted to be anything else.

I had to stay by her side. I had to protect her.

And I would do anything to make sure I was strong enough to do so.

With a firm grip on my purpose, I lifted a long, twisted black branch of charwood—one I'd risked raiding from Agrona's private stores after the first sample had been inadequate. Charwood came from Agrona's home in Epheotus. It was as hard as steel and perfect for working runic magic, but also very rare and expensive. The six-foot-long staff came to a dull point at one end but was splintered on the wider end where it had been broken free of its tree.

I took up a tool that looked somewhat like a shallow spoon crossed with a scalpel and pressed it against the charwood. Mana jumped from my hand to the tool's handle, and runes hidden beneath leather wrapping converted the mana to heat. In moments, the blackened metal scoop was glowing orange.

I pressed hard on the raw charwood, and the tool bit into it, giving off a thin wisp of smoke that smelled of vanilla. Fueling my muscles with mana, I drove the tool into the wood, but still managed to scrape away only a thin shaving. Gritting my teeth, I repeated the process, then again, each time coming away with a paper-thin wafer.

After twenty minutes, I had scoured a shallow divot into the staff. After an

hour, I had an uneven pit. In two, I was able to carve out a precise facet.

Next, I took up one of the metallic fittings, double-checking to ensure it was perfect. I pressed it into the facet, then took up a small hammer and drove it into the opening. The hammer's ringing drowned out all the other subtle noises of the castle, such as servants moving back and forth in the hallway outside and muffled bursts of magic from one of the training rooms below.

After setting down the hammer, I inspected the results: the silvery fitting had settled perfectly into the carved facet, and suddenly the plain stick appeared to be something more than it had been. No longer a piece of nature, but something crafted and given purpose.

Taking up another item from the workbench, I slipped a hexagonal jewel into the fitting. The bright red stone looked bloody and dark against the black wood and silver metal. But I didn't permanently set the stone. Instead, I shook it loose and placed it back on the workbench, turned the staff over, and picked up the carving tool again.

"That looks like a fascinating project."

I flinched so hard that I scraped the scorching tool across my knuckles. It burned hot enough to pierce my mana barrier and flay the flesh underneath. I cursed and threw the stupid thing back on the table.

"Oh, sorry!" Cecilia hurried to my side, leaned down, and took my hand in her own.

I wondered nervously how long she'd been standing there, then realized she must have come in while I was hammering.

She bit her lip as she inspected the wound, and when she looked into my eyes, her own were shining. "Are you all right?"

"Fine," I said, my voice hard, then added, "I'm fine," in a softer tone.

Mana trickled out of her fingertips and across the wound, cooling the flesh and easing the burning sting. My own mana was already circulating through my body to enhance my rate of healing.

"I'm glad you're here, actually," I added after an awkward pause where we both just stared at the cut. "I need to talk to you about something."

She flashed me a chagrined sort of smile and subtly rolled her eyes toward

the door. “It’ll have to wait, I’m afraid. Agrona has called for us. For all the Scythes, and me.”

Her tone carried the same uncertainty I felt at this news. It was rare for all the Scythes to be gathered at once.

“Do you—”

“No, but he’s…riled,” she said slowly. “I’ve never seen him like this before.”

I wanted to tell her that she hadn’t been with him that long, didn’t know him well at all, hadn’t seen him at his worst, but I kept my thoughts to myself. Whatever this news was, it didn’t bode well that Agrona had allowed himself to appear outwardly upset.

Before following Cecilia from my chambers, I took a moment to look over the workbench. I used a rag to wipe my blood from the carving tool, fiddled with a few items to line them up better in their respective runic circles, then, realizing it would be exceedingly foolish to leave it here while I was gone, I surreptitiously grabbed the core and slipped it into an inside pocket of my jacket.

“What are you working on, anyway?” Cecilia asked as we stepped out into the hall.

I turned around and set the mana lock. “Oh, nothing really, it’s…”

She smirked at me, and I trailed off. “I can tell it’s something you’re excited about. You don’t need to say, of course, but I’m glad you’ve found something to occupy your time.”

Sticking my hands in my pockets, I rubbed the core with my thumb through the fabric of the lining, but I didn’t elaborate.

Cecilia turned right instead of left down the hallway, catching me off guard.

“Aren’t we going to Agrona’s private wing?” I asked, hurrying after her.

“No. He’s called us all to the Obsidian Vault.”

I didn’t have anything to say to that. I wasn’t even sure what I felt. The Obsidian Vault was where the highest echelons of Agrona’s subjects received their bestowals: Wraiths, Scythes, retainers, and occasionally

even highblood warriors or ascenders who captured Agrona's attention.

There was only one reason he would call us to the Obsidian Vault.

There was going to be a bestowal. *Maybe it's not bad news after all.*

"Nico, I wanted to say…" Cecilia's voice drew me out of my thoughts, and I turned to look at her.

I'd come to terms with her change of appearance, just as I'd accepted my own. Seeing the fine elven features—the pointed ears, almond-shaped eyes, and silvery gunmetal hair that she kept threatening to dye—now, though, wrapped up with all of Elijah's memories of Tessia Eralith, caused more conflict than I was used to.

"…sorry that I haven't been around much these last few days. I *have* wanted to speak to you—I'm sure coming to terms with what happened at the Victoriad has been difficult—but there is a lot going on in both Dicathen and Alacrya, and Agrona has kept me unusually busy, so…"

That only confirmed what I'd already guessed. Agrona was getting ready to unleash Cecilia, send her into real battle.

My mind turned swiftly to the staff, lying barely started back in my room, and I suddenly chafed at this waste of time. Whatever Agrona had to say, it couldn't be as important as my ensuring I had the strength to defend Cecil.

A hand alighted delicately on my shoulder, and I realized that I had, yet again, become distracted.

"Nico, are you sure you're okay?" Cecilia asked, her concern written in the frown lines creasing her otherwise flawless face.

"Like you said, it's been…difficult. I'm sorry for getting distracted. I just have a…lot on my mind."

She smiled the kindliest and most understanding smile I could imagine, and her fingers brushed my cheek. "Don't apologize to me. We're the only two people who can really understand what the other's been through." Emotion swelled up inside me, filling my chest with a warm sweetness, and then she added, "Well, except Agrona of course," and the feeling withered and faded away.

I followed Cecilia down a series of narrow, winding stairs and into a roughly hewn tunnel. At its end, we entered a chamber carved out of

smooth, rippling black stone that glinted with a purple sheen, almost as if it were giving off its own internal light.

Agrona was already there.

He stood before a pair of doors carved with the image of a transformed basilisk with its long, serpentine body coiled into a V shape and its leathery wings tucked in against its sides. Runes tumbled from his claws down upon a series of upturned faces. *Agrona giving magic to the people*. I'd always found the carving serene, the sight of it somehow bolstering and peaceful simultaneously.

The real Agrona, standing before it with his arms crossed and his face the very mask of displeasure, was its exact opposite.

Melzri and Viessa were already there. I was stunned to see the two powerful women with their eyes averted, folded in on themselves like two thief-lamp eels drawing their hoods over themselves to appear as small and unthreatening as possible. It was not a look I had ever seen attempted by either Scythe before.

Behind each Scythe stood a retainer.

I was more than familiar with Mawar, "the Black Rose of Etril". Garbed in pure black wispy robes, she nearly vanished into the gloom of the antechamber, except of course for her short white hair, which was so bright it seemed to glow. Although only slightly older than me—or at least this body—she had been Viessa's retainer for nearly four years, and we had trained together extensively.

The poison-witch Bivrae, on the other hand, I had largely avoided. She was a horrifying creature to look at, like someone had stuck together a handful of broken sticks with swamp sludge and then hung some ratty old rags over for clothes. Her brothers had been tepid mages at best, with Bilal hardly capable of holding off Tessia Eralith long enough for me to arrive, and of course dying in the process.

Mawar had the good sense to keep her eyes on Melzri's back, but Bivrae stared at Cecilia and me as we entered the antechamber and didn't avert her gaze until, several very long seconds later, heavy footfalls announced another arrival.

Dragoth had to bend over to walk through the connecting tunnel without scraping his horns, but when he entered the antechamber he stood tall and

stretched casually. With a careless grin at Agrona, he stepped around me and Cecilia to stand right in front of us, his back so broad it blocked both of us from Agrona's sight.

Dragoth was followed by a mage I knew by name and reputation, but not by sight: Echeron, his new retainer. The man was tall and statuesque. Short onyx horns protruded like spikes from his carefully groomed golden hair. Silvery gray eyes met mine, and the retainer's chiseled features twitched into a scowl before smoothing out again. He stood beside and just behind Dragoth.

Silence filled the antechamber, growing more uncomfortable the longer it lingered.

Beside me, I could sense Cecilia's frustration emanating from her like an aura as her turquoise eyes burned holes in Dragoth's back.

Any sense of the intimidation I knew she used to feel in the Scythes' presence was gone, but I wasn't sure what was driving her current emotions. There was a sickly oozing in my stomach as I connected the brooding fearfulness of Melzri and Viessa with Cecilia's simmering anger.

The Scythes had failed Agrona at something.

Which I found myself not giving a shit about, but seeing just how loyal and attached Cecilia had become to Agrona was a slowly dawning horror I didn't know how to process. It was almost like looking in a mirror that showed a much younger version of myself, back when I would have hurled myself into Mount Nishan at Agrona's command.

A bone-deep cold suddenly began to seep through the room, conjuring frost crystals across the walls and floor, and even the fabric of my jacket.

Then Agrona began to speak.

"First, you fail me at the Victoriad, allowing the boy, Arthur Leywin, to escape, then you somehow manage to lose Sehz-Clar to a traitor."

My mind got stuck on these words like a wagon wheel in a rut.

Sehz-Clar, lost? What? It was then I processed the absence of Seris and her retainer.

"Finally, two of my Scythes retreat before a wounded and likely near-dead opponent, leaving Dicathen under the authority of a single retainer, one we

have now lost touch with."

Agrona's furious scarlet eyes swept through the room, burning like hellfire wherever they landed.

"Forgive us, High Sovereign, we feared that—"

The breath rushed from Melzri's lungs as Agrona turned the full force of his ire on her, and whatever pleas she intended to utter died on her lips.

"You are weak." He paused, letting this proclamation sink in. "The enemy has grown beyond you. And yet, as thoroughly as you have disappointed me, I won't place the blame for that entirely at your feet." He uncrossed his arms and moved to stand in front of Melzri, caressing her horn. "I gave you what power you needed for the role I intended you to play. Now, it seems your roles will have to change. Our enemy has evolved, and so shall you."

Melzri instantly went down on one knee. "Please, High Sovereign. Allow me to be the first to step within the Obsidian Vault."

No emotion marred Agrona's smooth features as he looked down at the back of her head. After a short pause, he said simply, "No."

Then he turned and crossed the antechamber to stand before Dragoth. As he did, the proportions of the room and everyone in it seemed to change so that the Scythe and the High Sovereign were of equal height.

I blinked several times, struggling to push away the strange sensation.

When I had cleared my head, Agrona was speaking again. "Of my four remaining Scythes, only one was brave enough to face Arthur Leywin in battle. The rest of you stood on the sidelines at the Victoriad, letting the best and worst of your number fall."

All of Dragoth's prodigious muscle mass went tense, then the lumbering goon shuffled aside, offering me a clear view of Agrona.

Agrona was looking directly at me. "Today, the least of the Scythes will be the first to enter the Obsidian Vault."

I stiffened, caught by surprise. The taunts and jibes were nothing new, but in this case, it seemed Agrona was offering me a backhanded compliment instead of a straightforward insult. A soft hand came to rest between my shoulder blades, and I turned to look at Cecilia, who was smiling

encouragingly.

I stepped forward.

The carved vault doors opened as two black-robed mages pushed from the inside. Agrona gestured toward the opening as the mages put their backs against the wall and waited.

I hesitated. Not that I could refuse even if I had wanted to, which I didn't, but I couldn't help but wonder why Agrona was really sending me first. Was it just a tactic to light a fire under the other Scythes, or maybe he wanted to see what effect a bestowal would have on me after my core was destroyed and subsequently repaired…

Games within games, I reminded myself.

Moving slowly but with purpose, I entered the Obsidian Vault and passed between the two mages, who closed the doors behind me.

The Obsidian Vault was a strange twilight place. The walls, the ceiling, even the descending stairs, were all shaped from black obsidian and shined with purple reflections.

The smooth stairs went downward for a long time. Behind me, the soft steps of the mages followed, their whisper like a shadow of my own louder steps. After what seemed like several minutes, the stairs ended in an arched opening.

The room beyond the arch was not large, but the way the light twinkled off the million folds and facets of the ceiling made it look like the night sky opened above me, shining with a purple aurora.

Like the Aurora Constellate in Dicathen, I thought absently, the first memory of that distant phenomena to resurface in my healing mind.

The center of the chamber was dominated by an altar, a slab of charwood-topped obsidian large enough for a man to lie down on. It radiated power.

That's weird, I thought. I'd never sensed that power before, even though I'd been to the vaults multiple times throughout my life.

Something had changed.

My thoughts turned immediately to the contents of my pocket, the thing I couldn't bring myself to leave unguarded in my chambers. I recalled, too,

the purple lights I'd seen when I'd touched it down in the dungeons, how I'd seen them through the core as if it had been a kind of lens. Although I'd tried to recreate the phenomenon several times, I'd failed.

Almost of its own accord, my hand slipped into my pocket and took hold of the core.

Nothing happened.

The bestowment ceremony suddenly seemed trivial and unimportant. I wanted to investigate this sensation further, but the two mages—officiants of the ceremony—who had followed me down the stairs were on either side of me, reaching for my jacket, then the hem of my shirt, trying to pull the clothing off me.

Anxiety and fear rippled through me at the thought of them finding Sylvia's core. I wanted to push the men away, but knew it was futile. Whatever was happening here, I had to follow the protocols demanded by the ceremony. These officiants would allow no alteration, and I dreaded to think what Agrona might do if I harmed them in any way. These were no mere researchers hidden away in the dungeons, these officiants were the key to Agrona's hold over Alacrya, and he would personally flay the skin from any man or woman who crossed them, even me.

Mechanically, I followed their demands. A man I hadn't seen—distracted as I'd been by the altar itself—moved out of the shadows and into position on the opposite side of the altar. Carved into the obsidian around me was a ring of wide runes, and I knew a similar feature adorned the floor around the third officiant.

The other two guided me to the center of the runic circle, and I kneeled. My hands rested on the charwood surface of the altar, placed carefully over top of two complex sigils, each made of many small, interconnected runes.

Across from me, the officiant lifted his staff. It clacked against the floor three times, loud in the stillness. The other two moved around behind me, each one taking up a staff that had leaned against the sides of the arched entryway.

There was no chant. No guiding words. Nothing but the quiet power of the altar, the subtle weight of the mountain, and the soft but sure movement of the three hooded mages.

Cold crystal pressed into either side of my spine from behind.

In response, warmth and a vibrating, nerve-tingling power rushed into my hands and up my arms from the altar, tracing across my shoulders and setting the hair on the back of my neck standing on end. Finally, it cascaded down my spine to meet the two points of cold.

For an instant, I was afraid. I'd never felt anything like this during a bestowal before.

What in all the hells is happening?

The vibration built and built, developing from a tingle to an ache into outright agony. I was certain something was wrong, wanted to scream at the officiants, but my jaw was locked, my muscles so tight they were unresponsive.

Somewhere very far away, or so it sounded to my pain-addled brain, a reedy voice uttered a prayer to the Vritra.

I began to shake and sweat. I was trembling from head to toe. Then, like a fist releasing, the pain subsided.

The room wobbled, and I would have collapsed except for the strong hands of two officiants. They pulled me upright and clumsily worked my shirt back over my head, then tugged my arms into my jacket.

Suspended between them, I was dragged clumsily up the stairs, one step at a time. Behind me, I heard the flipping of parchment and the muted mumbling of the third officiant.

My core began to ache fiercely.

One held me while the other struggled to force open the huge stone doors by himself. When one side finally ground out of its frame and swung heavily outward, tears sprang to my eyes at the brightness, and I could only blink them back as they trailed warm and wet along my cheeks.

I was hauled out of the stairs into the antechamber. Blearily, I stared around at a semicircle of surprised faces. When my unsteady gaze landed on Cecilia, it caught there and stayed. The radiance of her beautiful hair and her turquoise battlerobes stood out against the rest like the moon in a starless sky. Concern was etched into her features, but she was holding back.

“What’s wrong with him?” Melzri’s voice. The hint of worry.

“Has the bestowment ceremony failed?” A deep baritone. Agrona. Drawling, almost bored. Unsurprised. Like he expected me to fail…

Suddenly I was being turned around, and my shirt pulled up so that the cold air bit at my hot flesh.

Words. More words, but harder and harder to understand.

I struggled to turn my head, looking over my shoulder. Cecilia’s hand was over her mouth, her brows knitted in concern. A series of emotions on blurry faces—curiosity, confusion, irritation—then Agrona’s features coalesced as he leaned forward to get a better look, his expression inscrutable.

A regalia, the officiant was saying, but…something new?

Something not registered in the old tomes.

Then the weariness and uncertainty and the deep, deep ache from my core proved too much, and the darkness reached up for me. Gladly, I embraced it.

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CHOICES ALREADY MADE

ARTHUR LEYWIN

Spells burst in the air in showers of blue, green, and gold, trailing sparks and popping to an accompaniment of cheers from the ground below. The breeze carried the sound of hundreds of jubilant voices and the smells of roasting meat and sweet pies. A little girl, no more than five or six, sprinted past us, her face red and her grin growing wider with each step. Right behind her, a one-eyed man—a fresh scar, from the war no doubt—laughed as he gave chase.

A smile tugged at my lips as the Dicathian adventurer scooped the girl off her feet, eliciting a delighted squeal from the child. He plunked her on his shoulders, where she continued to giggle and laugh, tipping farther and farther back to watch the magical fireworks that were exploding in a near-constant display high above the city.

"I haven't seen people this happy since before the first attack on Xyrus," Helen Shard said from where she leaned against the side of the marble gazebo that housed Blackbend's only teleportation gate.

Angela Rose was sitting in a patch of grass, Regis sprawled in her lap with his head resting on her chest. "It's sort of like a veil has been lifted, isn't it?" she said, absently scratching Regis beneath his chin.

"Beautiful *and* wise," Regis said, giving Angela a quick lick on her cheek. "Why haven't we been acquainted before? It seems like a crime."

She rewarded him with a honeyed laugh. "I don't know about this beast of yours, Arthur. Are you *sure* this isn't you pantomiming through your summons?" She raised a brow coyly at me.

“If it was, I wouldn’t be nearly as crass,” I said, shooting my companion a glare.

Jasmine had spent the night listening from the street with her back turned to us, her perceptive gaze tracking the many people moving through the streets around us. Absentmindedly rolling a dagger between her fingers, she turned around. “This isn’t exactly a favor you’ve done for us, you know.”

I shrugged. “I know. But I trust the Twin Horns to maintain control over the city without also trying to forge some kind of city-state controlled by the Adventurers Guild. Besides, it won’t be for long, if things go well, and you won’t even be here.”

This caused a stir among the group, everyone’s attention quickly turning to me. Durden, who had barely said a word since arriving in Blackbend, suddenly spoke up. “What do you mean?”

“I was hoping,” I began, looking from Jasmine to Helen, “that Jasmine would come with me to Xyrus.”

Jasmine’s expression gave no indication of surprise but instead shifted into something thoughtful. Still, she said nothing.

Helen, on the other hand, frowned deeply as she pushed away from the pillar she was leaning against. “For what purpose? I can’t imagine having all the Twin Horns, or even all the forces in Vildorial, for that matter, would have made a difference to the outcome here in Blackbend. Forgive me for saying it, Arthur, but the sort of battles you’re likely to have…are you sure you want *anyone* that you care about by your side?”

Of course, Helen was right. I didn't, not really. If I could have had it my way, I’d have stuck everyone I cared about in a hole somewhere deep in the Relictombs to keep them safe. But I also needed someone by my side who could tell me when I was wrong—who could ground me as my own station continued to rise. Perhaps if I had known this before, in my past life, I wouldn’t have engaged in a war that cost millions of lives as retribution for Headmaster Wilbeck's murder.

But I didn’t say any of that. “I’ll keep her safe,” I told Helen. Then, to Jasmine, I added, “If you’re willing, that is.”

Jasmine lifted her chin, and her red eyes caught the reflection of a distant burst of ice shards. “Of course.”

Helen looked between us, her fingers fidgeting at her bowstring, then she let out a sigh and nodded. “Fine, but I swear”—she threw her arm up over my neck and tried to pull me into a headlock—“if I see one hair on her head missing—”

Effortlessly, I swept her off her feet, cradling her in my arms and making her squeal in surprise. “You know hair falls out naturally, right?”

Her hand hammered on my shoulder. “Put me down, you ridiculous boy!”

Laughing, I set her back on her feet, keeping my hands on her shoulders and holding eye contact. “I understand your worry. This is a war, and none of us are truly safe, not even me, but I promise I’ll keep her as safe as possible.”

Helen hmphed, trying and failing to hide a chagrined smile.

‘Well, you have fun. I think I’ll just stay here with Angela Rose and her—’

Not a chance, I shot back. *Come on. It’s time to go.*

While Regis finished being a complete idiot and embarrassing himself in front of Angela Rose, I entered the stonework gazebo and began calibrating the teleportation gate to the flying city of Xyrus. Jasmine followed wordlessly.

When the portal hummed to life inside the frame, I stepped up before it, but turned around to face Helen, Durden, and Angela Rose before passing through.

Regis drifted into my body. Angela Rose gave a cheery wave. Durden scratched at the stump of his arm, his gaze settling somewhere to my right.

“Good luck, *General* Arthur,” Helen said, her knuckles knocking against the carved stone pillar. “We’ll be waiting for word of your success.”

I nodded to Helen and gave a look to Jasmine to say her goodbyes before going through.

The world blurred around me, and I had a brief moment as I was disassociated from time and physical reality to consider the next step.

I had only spent hours in Blackbend, total. Success required a feverish pace on my part, and Xyrus was even more important than Blackbend.

As the most prosperous and defensible city in Sapin, it had become home for many of the highbloods who had been drawn to Dicathen—or at least those who hadn't dedicated their resources to building holds in Elenoir only to see them decimated by Aldir.

It was also home to many of the wealthiest Dicathians, especially turncoat houses like the Wykes.

My fear was that I faced less a battle and more an extended period of digging out the Alacryans from the city like ticks from a wolf's pelt. And the more time I spent in any one place, the more time the next city in line had to prepare. I'd already given Agrona far too much time to react and counter my victory in Vildorial.

The world lurched to a halt as I arrived at one of a row of identical teleportation gates.

A squad of Alacryan soldiers stood at attention nearby. The rest of the street was entirely empty.

Jasmine appeared behind me, her hand already on her blades.

A middle-aged guard with a heavy Truacian accent stepped forward. "Welcome to Xyrus City, General Arthur and"—he looked pointedly at Jasmine. When neither of us answered him, he pursed his lips and finished—"honored guest."

I considered for a moment before responding. The fact that he knew who I was and had clearly been prepared for my arrival yet wasn't attacking me meant that someone in the city wanted to have a conversation.

"I am Idir of Blood Plainsrunner," he continued, and this time I caught the slight tremble in his voice. "My men and I are to escort you to the Courthouse to meet with the heads of Xyrus. If you please."

And if I don't please? I almost asked but refrained. "And who would that be?" I asked instead.

"The ranking members of the five highbloods given stake in this city are Lady Augustine of Highblood Ramseyer, Lord Leith of Highblood Rynhorn, Lord Rhys of Highblood Arkwright, Lord Walter of Highblood Kaenig, and Lord Adaenn of Highblood Umburter." I must have given away some sign of recognition at the names Ramseyer and Arkwright because the soldier added, "Powerful bloods on both continents, as you

know.”

“And what will this meeting entail?” I asked.

Idir gave a humble bow. “I am just a messenger. I know you’ve come from a battle and are wary, but I can assure you, no Alacryan in this city wishes to cross blades with the man who slew Scythe Cadell Vritra.”

I didn’t doubt his words, but they didn’t exactly put me at ease. Just because a soldier didn’t *want* to fight didn’t mean he’d refuse when the order was given.

“Fine,” I said at length. “Lead the way, Idir.”

Although the streets were mostly empty, faces pressed against the windows of the many buildings we passed. Of the very few people that remained in the streets, all appeared to be Dicathian working class folks. A few even called out questioningly but were warned away by our escort. It wasn’t until a man in a sweat-stained, colorless tunic shouted out “Lance Arthur!” that I intervened.

A heavy-set woman in armored robes brandished her staff at the man, but I grabbed it. Everyone froze.

Jasmine, already tense, had her daggers half drawn in a blink, but I gestured for her to stand down. “I won’t have you bullying Dicathians in my presence,” I said, directed at the Alacryan soldiers, then released the woman’s staff.

The man was just past middle-aged with shoulder-length hair that was receding at the temples. It took a moment before I recognized him. “Jameson?” I asked, certain he was one of the men who worked at the Helstea Auction House for Vincent.

He nodded excitedly, wringing the front of his tunic. He kept opening his mouth to speak, but stopped every time under the hostile stares of the Alacryans.

“I suggest you return to the manor, Jameson,” I said firmly but kindly. I also widened my eyes just slightly, a nonverbal communication that I meant more than I said.

He gave me a blank, startled look, but didn’t move.

“Jasmine, maybe you should go with him?” I paused for emphasis, then

added, “To make sure he gets home safe?”

“But Arthur—”

“Please. Ensure that all is well, then come find me,” I said, interrupting her.

Jasmine nodded, clearly understanding. “I’ll be there soon.”

She grabbed Jameson by the arm, subtly dragging him away. The man finally seemed to come to some understanding, and he bowed clumsily as he half backpedaled, half was dragged, before turning and following swiftly behind Jasmine in the direction of the Helsteas’ mansion.

Uneasy at the thought of being separated from Jasmine after I said I’d protect her, I reached for my connection with Regis, but he had already started moving.

As if my shadow itself had come to life, he leapt out from my back, landing heavily, his claws scraping the ground and startling the soldiers. We shared no manifest thoughts as he trotted quickly after them, since we both understood what needed to be done. Jameson gave a yelp of surprise as Regis fell in beside him, but Jasmine was quick to comfort the man.

After watching them walk away, I leveled a cold look in Idir’s direction. He cleared his throat, spun on his heel, and began the march again.

Although I would have preferred to have Jasmine and Regis at my side, I needed the message to get to the Helsteas that I was in the city. According to Jasmine, they had been helping targeted citizens get out of the city ever since the Alacryan occupation began. That meant they had contacts, a network, people who should know that things were about to change.

It wasn’t a long walk from the teleportation gates to the Courthouse. I was somewhat surprised to find the cobbled square in front of the building—an ornate courtyard complete with well-tended gardens, fruit trees, and several statues of famous mages throughout Xyrus’s history—entirely empty. I had expected a show of force, at least. A hundred battle groups would have filled the space nicely and given it an appropriately militaristic air.

“Our soldiers within the city have mostly fallen back,” Idir said stiffly, answering my unasked question. “Lady Augustine didn’t want to give you the wrong impression.”

We moved quickly across the courtyard, but the soldiers stopped at the base of the marble steps. Ahead and above us, the white and gray lines of the huge edifice called the Courthouse seemed to dominate the city skyline.

Five impeccably dressed Alacryans walked in a stately line out from under the towering archway that opened into the Courthouse beyond, each one oozing highblood authority and grooming with each step.

A surprisingly young woman with russet brown skin and tight black curls stood a half step in front of the others. “Ascender Grey. Or…Arthur Leywin, is it?” She batted her thick eyelashes at me innocently. “A pleasure to meet you. My grandfather found you to be such an interesting and complex problem as a professor. I’m interested to better understand why.”

As she spoke, her words crisp and sharply enunciated, the family resemblance became clear. “You are Augustine of Highblood Ramseyer, then? Valen’s sister?”

“Cousin,” she said with the slightest shrug of her thin shoulders. “Though we were raised more as siblings. I am a graduate of Central Academy—a fact that I now consider to be a great shame, since my time there was over before your short tenure as a professor began. Seeing your performance at the Victoriad, I’m sure your class was *most* interesting.”

“You seem to know a little about me, Lady Ramseyer, so I’m sure you also know why I’m here,” I said, pointedly scanning the five highbloods.

She raised a delicate hand. “Please, do you plan to discuss business here on the stoop as if we were shady accolades dealers?” Her thin eyebrows rose, and there was a sparkle in her dark eyes. “Let us retreat to more comfortable accommodations so we might discuss your purpose in Xyrus like civilized people.”

The other four highbloods led the way, while Augustine stood aside and gestured for me to follow. I took a moment to scan the courtyard and what I could see of the Courthouse building. The squadron of guards led by Idir was waiting at the base of the wide steps, but there was nothing else—no one else—to be seen.

As I moved past her, Augustine reached out and slipped her arm through mine. She was a head shorter than me, and her slender arms looked like

frail sticks next to mine, but there was a liquid grace and abiding confidence to her movements that revealed no fear of me.

As we walked arm in arm through the grand halls, I found my thoughts drifting back to Central Academy. I hadn't had much time to consider the chaos I had left in my wake. Those kids, the ones I'd had the most impact on—Valen, Enola, Seth, Mayla…

Did I do more damage than good, by making them trust me only to break that trust and disappear? I wondered.

Who knows what kind of propaganda Agrona and his minions had spread after the Victoriad.

"The kids from my class," I began, then hesitated, unsure exactly what I wanted to ask—or if I even had the right to ask given our situation.

"No blame was placed on them, and they were given ample opportunity and resources to recover from the shock," Augustine confirmed. "My grandfather may be a hard man, but he is dedicated to his academy and its students."

That, at least, was a relief. I knew Alaric would have no such protection, but I trusted the old drunk to be able to look after himself.

Realizing I was letting sentimentality drag my focus down, I began drawing from the same well of impassivity that had helped me survive in Alacrya.

Augustine guided me through several short corridors before we arrived at a large lounge. Like the rest of the Courthouse, the floor was of polished granite, while the carved walls were all brilliant white marble. Arched windows bathed the lounge in light, which only made it even brighter. Dozens of fine chairs and couches were carefully arrayed through the room, broken up with a hundred different kinds of potted greenery. One wall was dominated by a massive marble bar, behind which were shelves upon shelves of bottles.

At the center of the lounge, I noticed that a table had been moved and several seats rearranged to make room for a small round table topped with a Sovereigns Quarrel board. Two high-backed, velvet-cushioned chairs had been set on opposite sides of the table.

The four silent highbloods stood aside, and Augustine led me to the table. I

pulled one chair out and offered it to her. She veiled her surprise well, smiling and inclining her head in thanks as she took a seat. I pushed the chair in slightly, then sat down myself.

“You’re familiar?” she asked, her index finger tracing an ornately carved striker.

“I’ve played,” I answered, examining the board. The pieces were exquisitely carved, each caster, shield, and striker unique. Her pieces were crafted of blood-red stone, while mine were marbled gray and black. “I’m not here for games, though, Augustine. You know that.”

Her smile widened, but she was focused on the game board and didn’t meet my eye. “Blackbend City fell to you in—what?—twenty minutes?” While she stared at the pieces, her fingers caressed the outline of her lips. “Clearly strength of arms is a poor counter to your power, Arthur—can I call you Arthur?” she asked, interrupting herself as she looked at me for confirmation.

I nodded, and she continued. “But Xyrus is a different beast. Hundreds of Alacryans have made the city their home, and there are five soldiers posted here for each civilian. Many Dicathians have already sworn allegiance to the High Sovereign. Do you plan to go street by street, house by house, kicking in doors and dragging away families—children, servants—indiscriminately?”

Picking up a striker, she moved it in a line deep into my end of the field. An aggressive move.

“Usually soldiers surrender after I’ve destroyed their leadership,” I said evenly, maneuvering a caster to counter her striker.

She bit her lip, then moved one of her own casters to support the striker. “Such bravado, Arthur. I thought you wanted to have a discussion. Do you expect me to treat with you when you keep holding a blade to my neck?”

I shrugged, carelessly repositioning a shield. “I didn’t come to negotiate. I came to retake the city. Bloodless is better, but I’m prepared to do what needs to be done, just as in Blackbend.”

“So what then?” Her fingers tapped on the hardwood table. “You want us”—she gestured to the others—“to take our people and go home? Just that simple?”

“Pretty much. And you can take anyone who bent a knee to Agrona with you.”

She leaned away from the game as she carefully scrutinized me. “Before we go any further, I have a confession to make. Please, stay your hand and listen.” Augustine shared a look with one of the others, who gave her a sharp nod. “Every Alacryan soldier at our disposal has already been dispersed throughout the city. Their orders are simple: if any harm comes to me or my compatriots, they will start butchering the people of Xyrus.” She held up her hand again, her features softening. “Don’t mistake me; I am not a monster. I was placed in charge of our blood’s expansion into your continent specifically because I was eager to work *alongside* the people of Dicathen, to learn from them and guide them into Agrona’s service.

“But,” she continued, and for a single instant her composure broke, and I saw real fear flash across her fine features, “just as you said, I will do what needs to be done. Because, on my blood’s honor, I cannot simply *give* you this city.”

I looked down at the game board, offering her no outward reaction to her threats. Instead, I said, “I believe it’s still your turn, Augustine.”

Biting her lip, she slid the striker through the newly formed gap in my line. “I know that you carry no fear for yourself,” Augustine continued, louder and more confident, “but you aren’t callous with the lives of others. Even in Alacrya, surrounded at all times by enemies, you took pains to ensure the students in your care were well tended to, students like Seth of Highblood Milview and Mayla of Blood Fairweather in particular.”

“Surrender yourself and the people of this city will be spared,” one of the other highbloods added, his honeyed baritone positively oozing with pompous arrogance.

Feigning a stifled yawn, I withdrew my forward caster in order to block her striker from my sentry. “I get the feeling you’re not giving the game your full attention.”

Her jaw clenched as she shot the other highbloods an uncertain look. Walter of Highblood Kaenig nodded, and she slid back slightly from the table.

Several things all happened in the same instant: the air all throughout the

room rippled violently, and suddenly the lounge was full of armed and armored knights; several overlapping shields of translucent mana appeared between me and Augustine; and somewhere in the distance, horns began to blow.

I heard the whistle of a polearm swinging, reached up and caught the shaft, then twisted my wrist so the wood shattered. My attacker bore the symbol of House Wykes on his breastplate. I recognized the symbols of several noble houses among the crowd of soldiers: Wykes, Clarell, Ravenpoor, Dreyl, and, most surprisingly of all, *Flamesworth*.

By then, Augustine had kicked aside her chair and retreated into the press of Dicathian soldiers. The other highbloods were busily scuttling from the room like rodents fleeing a burning barn.

I stayed in my seat. No one else attacked immediately, so I went back to perusing the game board.

"These men, these *Dicathian-born* men, are willing to fight to keep you from returning things to the way they were!" Augustine shouted over the sudden noise of a hundred men in armor clanking against one another. "Doesn't that give you any pause? Or are you so single-minded that you would murder even your own people to ensure the world is as *you* think it should be."

There was a wildness in the young woman's dark eyes that reminded me of a cornered shadow panther.

I took a second to look from face to face, seeing in them a stoic certainty that I found surprising. The mere sight of me conjured abject terror in the Alacryan men, but these knights of Xyrus's noble houses seemed so self-certain. Like the little carved men on the board, they simply went where they were told, oblivious to the ramifications of their actions or their own lives.

"You think you've outmaneuvered me," I said, pressing my index finger down on the head of the striker piece that was now sitting behind the line of my shields, dangerously close to my sentry. "You've isolated a weakness and exploited it. Left me with no further actions to take." Picking up my sentry, I moved it next to the opposing striker. "But I don't forfeit, Augustine."

I let my gaze fall heavily on all those nearest to me. "So, strike me down."

Not even a breath interrupted the silence that followed.

Then the command split the quiet, resounding off the marble walls. “Attack!”

A Dreyl knight lunged forward and thrust his sword at my side. A spike of ice flew at me from behind Augustine, cast by a man in Clarell colors. Then another attack came, and another, and soon I was at the center of a barrage of blows, some magical, others by sword or ax or spear.

But they crashed against the relic armor, which unfolded over my flesh in an instant. I stood, absorbing the brunt of the assault without fighting back. Five seconds passed, then ten. At twenty seconds, there was a lull in the assault as the reality of the situation started to dawn over the knights.

In that moment's hesitation, I fell on them like a nightmare fox among raptor squirrels.

Ripping the sword from the Dreyl knight’s hand, I thrust it into another man’s chest, took him by the throat, and hurled him into a Flamesworth knight’s oncoming spear. Activating Realmheart with a flicker of aether, I deflected a roiling ball of molten metal, sending it into the face of a Clarell soldier at the same time as I conjured an aether blade and twirled it around in a wide arc, cutting down several more men.

While the knights had been charging forward, Augustine had been retreating, sliding back through the wall of Dicathians until she was at the lounge door. She didn’t flee farther, didn’t run for her life or attempt to disappear into the streets outside. Instead, she stood and watched. Entranced or petrified, I couldn’t tell.

Directing aether into my fist to form a concentrated blast, I turned toward a group of conjurers bearing the Wykes’ house crest. “Please, General Arthur,” one of them begged, “I served with you at—”

The plea cut out, swallowed by the forge-fire roar of aether blasting the conjurers to pieces.

With the efficiency of a lumberjack splitting the day’s wood, I cut through the remaining soldiers. Dozens upon dozens of them fell into bloody and broken heaps upon the granite floor, their blood pooling until the gray vanished beneath a wet red carpet.

The fight barely lasted a minute before the last of them fell.

I wiped blood from my face and turned toward Augustine. To her benefit, she didn't run. As I started in her direction, she watched me approach like one who had accepted death.

The room was silent again. And now that it was, I could hear the sounds of shouting and spellfire in the distance.

"Order your soldiers to back down," I said, my voice an apathetic void. "No more Dicathians are to be harmed. All Alacryans are to gather and prepare to relocate. If this isn't done now, I'll spare *no one*."

Her dark eyes were unfocused, looking through me into the middle distance where the Dicathian knights' corpses littered the floor.

"Lady Ramseyer," I snapped, and she jumped and stumbled backward, horror dawning across her face.

She began to retreat clumsily backward, her disbelieving gaze locked on me. Behind her, I saw the swishing robes of the other highbloods vanish around a corner.

"Don't test me further."

Nodding frantically, she began running. Then I was alone.

My eyes shut, the lids ponderously heavy. I was tired. *So* tired. It wasn't weakness of body or my core that weighed on me, but a fatigue of the spirit.

I released my connection with the relic armor, and the black scales enveloping me fell away into nothing. Forcing my eyes open, I took in the carnage I'd wrought.

Shining steel was muted with red-brown smears of rapidly oxidizing blood. Severed appendages sat like gruesome islands amid the sea of scarlet. The colorful emblems of Xyrus's noble houses were indistinguishable beneath the stains.

So many of our own had been ready to welcome Agrona even before the war started to turn against us, it shouldn't have surprised me that with Alacrya firmly in control, some people had fully sworn themselves to his service. Fear alone would drive many to that end, and greed many more.

Still. As I stared at the corpses, I knew these deaths were a weight I would have to carry.

I wasn't sure how long I'd stood there in silence, deaf to everything but my own inner turmoil, when the sound of hurried steps drew me back out of my own emotions.

Jasmine marched into the room, stepped in blood, and pulled up short. Her eyes went wide, then focused on me. She must have seen something in my appearance that gave away what I was feeling, because her normally hard exterior softened.

I realized Regis wasn't with her and reached out to him. I could sense him outside, helping to break up the fighting.

"You okay?" Jasmine asked after a moment.

"I…" When my voice came out raw, I bit back my words, hesitant to look weak in front of her. *Fool*, I chided myself, remembering why I'd asked for her to come with me in the first place. "I've worked so hard to keep this war from becoming a slaughter," I continued after a moment, "but these men…"

I trailed off again, sweeping my hand across the room in a futile gesture. "I didn't give them a chance," I finally finished.

Jasmine nudged a body over with her toe so the breastplate was facing up. There were very few identifying features left of the knight, whose face had been carved by an ax, but clear on his breastplate was the symbol of House Flamesworth: a stylized rose, its petals formed from gently curling flames. Her face remained expressionless.

"They had their chances," she said flatly. "Many of them. And they made their choice every time."

She trailed between the bodies, each step leaving behind an empty patch of granite in the blood. "I didn't realize my father had been released from his cell under the Wall."

Trodius Flamesworth had sent his own daughter away for preferring air-attribute mana to fire. He had planned to sequester himself and his noble friends in the Wall to save themselves from the war. And he had betrayed the trust of his own soldiers when he refused to drop the Wall on the army of mutated mana beasts the Alacryans had conjured from the Beast Glades, an act that had directly resulted in the death of my father.

But he wasn't some outlier of villainy inside an otherwise altruistic

institution. No, every leader of every one of these noble houses had done things just as selfish, cruel, and treasonous, of that I was certain.

“Durden still blames himself for your father’s death, you know,” Jasmine said, seemingly out of the blue.

I felt myself sag and leaned back against the bar, pushing a knight’s corpse off the polished surface to make room. “It wasn’t his fault. That battle… even the strongest mages could have fallen prey to those beasts.”

“You’re right, it wasn’t his fault,” Jasmine said firmly, still pacing through the slaughter. “It was Trodius’s. He was careless with the lives of men who trusted him.” She stopped and pointed down at a torso that had been cleaved free of its bottom half. “Lord Dreyl was careless with this man’s life.” She nudged a mage in blood-soaked battlerobes with a toe. “And Lord Ravenpoor with this man’s.” She stopped, her feet on either side of a severed head. “And Trodius sent this woman to her death as well.”

Our eyes met. There was fire behind the red of her irises. “Don’t punish yourself for the deeds of others, Arthur.”

I had to clear my throat before speaking. “This war won’t be over when the last Alacryan leaves these shores. We have too many enemies who were born here and call themselves Dicathians.”

Jasmine nodded, making her way to my side. She reached across the bar and pulled down a bottle, swirling the golden liquid inside. There was something distant and haunted in her face, then she tossed the bottle away. “Even continents have to exorcise their demons, I suppose.”

More footsteps announced the arrival of several people. Jasmine’s hand went to her daggers, but I could feel from my connection with Regis that the fighting was over. Augustine and her cohorts had pulled back their troops, as I’d ordered.

I pressed my palms hard into my eyes until white static played across my vision. Then, with a steadying breath, I moved quickly to the doorway, not wanting to have any more conversations in the lounge-turned-abattoir.

Despite hoping for a few reunions, I was still surprised by the approaching figures, all of whom stopped when they saw me.

Vincent Helstea looked strange in his leather armor and helm. He had aged since I’d last seen him, and added some weight around the middle, and

there was a haggard weariness behind his once playful eyes.

Beside him, his daughter, Lilia, was a grown woman, fierce and beautiful even covered in blood. She was pale, and there were tears clinging to the corners of her eyes as she stared at me in shock.

And behind both of them was Vanesy Glory, unmarred by the battles outside.

While Vincent was looking at me with a kind of delirious bemusement, like he wasn't quite sure if this was all a dream or not, Lilia simmered with a furious intensity, her eyes moving quickly over the lines of my face, except when they would meet my own and catch there.

Behind them, Vanesy Glory had stopped and was standing at attention with one hand behind her back, the other on her blade, its point down, resting on the granite. Her bright eyes were shining, and her lips were pressed together so tightly that they'd turned white.

"Art, my boy, is that really you?" Vincent asked from the doorway.

I tried to flash him a warm smile, but it felt more melancholy resting on my face. "Surprise."

Lilia let out a whimpering breath, her body tensed like a pulled bowstring, and she sprang forward and wrapped her arms around me. "Arthur…I—I can't believe you're alive!"

I accepted the embrace gratefully. She pressed her face into my chest, her body shaking with suppressed sobs. "What about Ellie? Alice? There's been no word for so long…"

"Fine," I said consolingly, my bloody hand softly caressing her hair. "They're both fine, Lilia."

She pulled free and wiped her eyes, grimacing with embarrassment. "So much for being a stoic leader of the rebellion," she said wryly. "But I suppose that is more Commander Glory's thing, anyway."

"Never be ashamed of your emotions, dear," Vincent said, automatically slipping into a fatherly tone. "You cannot control how you feel, and those who love and respect you will not judge you for expressing yourself."

Smiling, I slipped past Vincent and extended a hand to Vanesy. She let go of the rigid stance she'd been holding and took my hand firmly. When I'd

first met Vanesy Glory as a professor at Xyrus Academy, there had been a youthful exuberance to all her actions. Just after the war started, I found her to be steadfast and serious in her role, with much of that lighthearted air subdued, but on the whole, unchanged.

Now, she'd been tempered by years of conflict. Unlike Vincent, the war hadn't aged her physically; the same Vanesy still stood before me, with her brown hair pulled back and tied, as usual. But the easy smile was gone, as was the amused squint that normally wrinkled the corners of her eyes.

"I'm sorry there won't be more time for a proper reunion," I said, "but the situation here rests upon the edge of a blade. I need to get these Alacryans out of Xyrus as soon as possible."

She squeezed my hand, then let me go and took a step back. "Of course, Arthur." She hesitated. "I…everyone thought you were dead." She looked at the ground, her jaw tightening.

"Well, I'm not," I said lightly. "I promise I'll tell you everything, but for now, we need eyes across the city. Can you send out patrols? We need a presence in the streets to make sure the Alacryan soldiers don't have a lapse of judgment."

Vanesy was frowning, and it only deepened as I spoke. "I don't understand. Why are we allowing them to just—"

I couldn't help the deep sigh that came unbidden from my lips. She stopped speaking, and her jaw began working back and forth in agitation.

This is something I need to remember, I thought. *While I was on the other continent learning to see the Alacryans as people, those here in Dicathen witnessed only the most monstrous of their actions. I can't fault my allies for not being eager to simply wave as their oppressors march to freedom.*

"I know many of these Alacryans have committed crimes worth punishing. War is war, and that is hard enough to forgive. I won't pretend to know everything they've done to you and yours since the war's end. But please, right now is not the time to exercise whatever rage is inside you."

I held her gaze for a long moment. Her gloves creaked against the handle of her sword. Then she bent at the waist and gave me a shallow bow. "Of course. General."

401

HIGHBLOODS IN LOW PLACES

CAERA DENOIR

Heavy black clouds had turned day to night, pouring down thick sheets of rain that pummeled the streets of Aensgar on the Redwater. The city was eerily quiet under the blanket of rainfall, broken only by the rattle of carriage wheels over wet cobbles or the rare shout from an unlucky soul caught out in the storm as they rushed furtively toward their destinations.

I'd had nearly a week to come to terms with the events in Sehz-Clar, but the rushed pace of Seris's maneuvering had left little time for contemplative thought. Still, I knew what was at stake. In truth, I almost found myself enjoying the subterfuge, despite the danger of being outside the shields.

Finding the street I was looking for, I pulled the hood of my cloak further down over my face and shrouded my mana signature before cautiously edging around the exterior of a large three-story inn. Dim light filtered through yellowed panes of glass, the low rumble of drunken laughter and conversation spilling into the street from the open door.

I scanned the alleyway behind the inn, but it was empty aside from the usual collection of rubbish that had been tossed out by the too-busy staff.

Slipping along the rear wall of the building, I tucked myself into the narrow alcove the backdoor provided and waited, watching the street. No one breached the mouth of the alley, and the street beyond remained empty except for the splashing rain. Confident that no one was following me, I eased open the door and ducked into the dim interior.

I found myself in a narrow corridor. To one side, the cacophonous din of

the bar vibrated through the thin boards, and a handful of doors opened into storage rooms and the proprietor's private quarters on the other.

Once I had passed these, the susurrus of quiet voices edged into my perception, subtle beneath the louder volume of the barroom. The voices were coming from a room at the end of the hall.

I cautiously approached the last door, and the voices grew slowly louder until I could make out the words over the rest of the general clamor. A thin blade of light was issuing from a space between two planks in the wall, and when I put my eye to the spot, I could see a slice of the room beyond, including several of the speakers.

I could have laughed.

Each of the men visible from my angle was dressed more ostentatiously than the last. It was a wonder they hadn't arrived accompanied by a parade of blood members, servants, and captured mana beasts. One might have been forgiven for thinking that a clandestine meeting such as this would be a good time to dress down, but apparently these highbloods couldn't resist the opportunity to flaunt their wealth, even if only to each other.

Although, to give them some credit, there was a row of plain, rain-soaked cloaks hanging from hooks on the back wall.

"Scythe Seris Vritra's emissary is late," an older man said. His bushy blond goatee had faded nearly to white, but there was steel in his eyes, and he stared around the room. *Lord Uriel of Highblood Frost*, I thought, recognizing him immediately.

A much younger man, dark haired and barrel chested, laughed low and dangerous. "Highlord Frost, this is a Scythe we're discussing." He drummed his fingers across the scarred table that dominated the back room. "Although, I suppose such a title is no longer appropriate. At any rate, her representative will arrive, and when they do, they will consider themselves exactly on time. The real question is why they chose such an unruly, meager sort of place to meet."

Highlord Frost's thick brows rose as he considered the younger man. "I suppose you are correct, Lord Exeter. Although, if Scythe…ah, *Lady* Seris expects to win our goodwill, perhaps she should start by treating us better than her previous compatriots have."

A cool female voice belonging to someone not visible from my current

vantage cut in, saying, “Oh really, Uriel. When have you ever been treated poorly in your life? Born a highblood and heir to the title of highlord, your success and authority were very nearly predestined. You’ve heard the parable of the silver spoon, I assume?”

There were several scandalized scoffs from the men in front of me.

Highlord Frost scowled, a look that would have frozen the blood of most Alacryans. “Some of us have had the good fortune to be born into our position, while others have fought and bled to scrape their way up from the dregs of the unblooded.” His tone was mild, with the barest cutting edge just audible in the undertones. “But we are all highbloods now, Matron Tremblay. And all here for a shared purpose. I suspect if your blood’s interactions with the Scythes and Sovereigns had been positive, you would not have answered Seris’s invitation.”

“Well said, Uriel,” said one of the others, a younger man whose back was to me so all I could see was his tight ponytail.

“Oh, indeed,” Matron Tremblay answered teasingly. “An absolute paragon of facundity.”

I pulled back from the crack in the wall and headed toward the door, deciding to make myself known before things escalated further.

“If you have some grievance against me or my blood, Maylis, air it,” Highlord Frost’s voice rumbled through the shabby wall.

“Pay her no mind, Highlord Frost. These new bloods have no appreciation for those who came before,” Lord Exeter said.

I opened the door to the sight of a tall athletic woman rising to her feet. She had one finger extended toward the men at the other end of the table and her mouth open to hurl what was no doubt to be a well-practiced insult. But her burgundy eyes shifted to me, bright and overlarge in her sun-kissed face, and she stopped.

“Caera?” she asked uncertainly.

I focused on the short horns that grew from her forehead to curve back close atop her lustrous blue-black hair, which she had pulled into a tail. She was Vritra-blooded. But her blood name, Tremblay, wasn’t familiar. Then, belatedly, I realized I’d heard her first name as well.

“Maylis…” I had a flash of a much younger version of the fierce young woman now standing in front of me, a skin-and-bones teenager with blue-black hair down to the back of her knees. “I see your blood has manifested.”

She nodded vigorously, clearly excited and eager to speak, but the men were all on their feet now, and we both seemed to realize this wasn’t the time for a reunion at the same moment. Biting back her smile, she sat back down.

On the other side of the room, a couple of the men offered me perfunctory bows, but most were staring warily.

Only Lord Exeter approached, moving quickly and offering his hand. I went to shake it, but he turned my hand and pulled it toward him. I could only watch, surprised, bemused, and mildly annoyed, as he pressed his lips to the back of my glove.

Maylis snorted.

“By the Sovereigns’ grace, Lady Caera of Highblood Denoir, what are you doing here?” he asked, moon-eyed and ogling.

“Isn’t it obvious?” a wheezing voice said, drawing my eye to a puffy balding highblood in purple and silver battlerobes. “This is some kind of setup! The Denoirs have already spoken out vocally against the situation in Sehz-Clar—”

A bark of laughter from Highlord Frost cut off the wheezing man. “Which, I imagine, Highlord Seabrook, is why this girl is here, instead of the heir, Lauden, or Highlord Denoir himself. Playing both sides I would imagine.”

I leveled a cold, unblinking gaze at the room. “This *girl* is here because Seris herself has chosen me to share her message. I’m the emissary you’ve been waiting on.” I focused on the plum of a man I now knew was Highlord Sebastien Seabrook. “And Highlord, if this were some kind of trap, you lot would have already thoroughly incriminated yourselves with your startling absence of prudence.”

Next to me, Lord Exeter had gone pale as a ghost. He took a halting step back, bumped up against the table, sputtered something incoherent, then finally managed, “Wait, what?”

Maylis was grinning fiendishly. “What’s the matter, Zachian? You were so

eager to present yourself as a vacuous, self-indulgent blowhard only a moment ago."

This seemed to snap him out of his surprise. He straightened his jacket and turned his nose up. "Forgive me, Lady Denoir. I've disrupted the meeting. Please," he said, waving me into the room. He then shot a withering glare at Maylis before returning to his seat.

"Indeed, we seem to have gotten somewhat off from our purpose," Highlord Frost said into the silence that followed. "If you have truly come on behalf of Lady Seris, pray tell, what exactly does she hope to accomplish with this act of rebellion?"

This question, I knew, was intended more to usher us into a conversation than seek an actual answer. Each of these highbloods had received a number of missives already, which offered explanation for Seris's purpose. They knew what she was trying to do, but what they *really* wanted to gauge was if there would even be a chance that she could be successful. And, perhaps more importantly to them, what it would cost the highbloods to align with her against Agrona.

"Seat yourselves and I'll answer any sensible questions you might have," I said firmly. I kept my physical presence poised and confident but not rigid.

Normally, in a room with so many other highbloods, the practiced courtly demeanor my foster parents had drilled into me would have taken over, but I wasn't here to move through the typical machinations of noble politics. If they saw me as their lesser—or even their equal—then it would be all but impossible to accomplish my goal.

I was here as Seris's emissary, and she had high expectations.

Moving in a delicate dance of who would sit first and in which seats, the highbloods filled the long, stained table. There were eight people representing various highbloods that had shown cautious interest in Seris's message. I stayed on my feet with my hands clasped behind my back and let the faint impression of impatience bleed into my expression.

Lord Exeter was quick to take a seat halfway down the table. His gaze kept twitching toward Maylis, and although he presented himself as outwardly calm, I could sense his temper simmering below the surface. I hadn't heard of Highblood Exeter, but by the way he had sneered at Maylis about being a "new blood," I doubted he himself was newly raised up. More likely, his

was some middling blood from Sehz-Clar or Etril, raised up due to the amount of land they'd managed to acquire rather than strength in war or success as ascenders.

Highlord Frost took the seat at the head of the table opposite me. I'd met several of his blood at Central Academy, and the Frosts did occasional business with the Denoirs. I'd been quite impressed with his great-granddaughter, Enola, who had won her event at the Victoriad.

Highlord Seabrook, the puffy purple man with the wheezing voice, sat to Frost's left. He was staring at me and chewing on his cheek in a distracted sort of way.

To his left was the second son of Highblood Umburter, whose given name I couldn't recall. His brother, I knew, was off in Dicathen managing the blood's affairs. The fact that he was here instead of his father, Highlord Gracian Umburter, suggested that they were simply testing the waters. At least the Exeters had sent their heir.

Still, the Umburter boy was a step above the aging man next to him. Chamberlain to Matron Clarvelle, I thought his name was Geoffrey. The Clarvelle Highblood had been close to the Denoirs when I was a child, but some falling out between my adoptive mother and Matron Clarvelle resulted in the two bloods drifting apart. As chamberlain, Geoffrey was a trusted member of the household, but to send him to such a meeting as this was almost deliberately insulting.

We'd have to be careful with the Clarvelles.

On the other side of the table, Highlord Ector Ainsworth sat to Highlord Frost's right. In his sixties, Ector still had dark black hair, except for a slight lightening at his temples and down either side of his carefully groomed goatee. He had been quiet so far, both before the meeting and since my arrival, but his clever gray eyes seemed to be trying to look through me from across the room.

Beside him, a twitching, nervous-looking man was fiddling with the cuffs of his robes. He kept glancing at Highlord Frost like he was trying to catch his eye. His back had been to me as I watched from the hallway, but now I recognized the hawkish downturn of his nose and his unusual eyes: one was bright scarlet, the other a muddy brown.

"Lady Caera…" he said softly when he realized I was looking at him,

although his eyes focused on the table and not me.

“Lord Redwater,” I said in return, nodding politely.

Wolfrum of Highblood Redwater was a Vritra-blooded foster like me. His own adopted siblings—four brothers and a sister—had all perished tragically in the Relictombs. As his Vritra blood never manifested, the Redwaters were allowed to name him heir so the highblood—a very old blood that took its name from the river running not half a mile from the inn—would live on.

I’d met him, like Maylis, at the gatherings of young Vritra-blooded foster children I’d been forced to attend when I was young. I remembered him as an awkward antisocial boy who stood out among the self-important Vritra-bloods.

“Before we begin,” I said when I’d finished scanning the room, “there are two points I must make clear immediately. First, this is not a battle to replace one overlord with another. Seris does not seek to make herself High Sovereign over Alacrya, or even to rule at all.”

Highlord Seabrook made a show of rolling his eyes and looking across the table at Highlord Ainsworth with a foolish grin on his face.

Frost steepled his fingers and leaned toward me. “So her missives have explained. Thus far, she has painted herself as a…*freedom fighter*, leading this uprising for the good of the people of Alacrya.” Wolfrum chuckled awkwardly but went quiet after realizing he was the only one. “I would ask you to speak plainly, on your honor as a Denoir. What is Seris’s true purpose, and why now, in this moment of turmoil?”

“Does it have something to do with the sudden turnabout happening on the other continent?” Seabrook burst in. “I lost ten battlegroups in the city of…well…whatever it's called,” he finished lamely.

“The second point I am instructed to make clear,” I continued, ignoring their questions for the moment, “is that this is not a symbolic resistance. You ask why now, Highlord Frost? Because this is our last opportunity.” I put my hands on the table and met each of their eyes in turn. “The brewing war with the other asura clans will wipe out our world if we don’t prevent it.”

A chorus of voices broke out as Umburter, Seabrook, Exeter, and Frost all attempted to speak at once.

“—absurd—”

“—can’t be sure that—”

“—stop it even if—”

“—believe a word of that nonsense!”

My hand came down hard on the table. The resulting *crack* cut through the noise like spellfire, and the men settled down, although I drew hostile looks from Umburter and Seabrook.

“Apply the same lessons of etiquette you would enforce on your own blood,” I said coldly, my gaze sweeping over the highbloods. “Don’t interrupt me again.”

The room went still in tacit admission of their rudeness. I waited the length of three breaths, then continued. “There are few enough who can claim to know the mind of Agrona Vritra, but Seris is one of them. He will burn this world as fodder to return to the land of the asura, and all of us with it. The rest of the Scythes and Sovereigns are prepared to follow him even to that end, but Seris is not.”

“And—if you fine lords will excuse my speaking,” Chamberlain Geoffrey said in his deep voice, “what part does the disappearance of Sovereigns Orlaeth and Kiros Vritra play into this rebellion? One hears all kinds of strange rumors.” His sharp eyes narrowed as he watched me closely for a response. “I’ve even heard it suggested that Seris has somehow been assassinating them…with the help of the golden-eyed man from the Victoriad.”

I was ready for the question—and the mention of Grey. Tongues hadn’t yet stopped wagging about his appearance, seemingly from nowhere, at the Victoriad. There were also those who suspected he had something to do with the destruction here in Vechor, although official sources had claimed it to be a tragic accident with an artifact from the Relictombs.

“Sovereign Kiros is currently in chains beneath Taegrin Caelum,” I said pointedly, standing straight and crossing my arms under my chest. “As for Sovereign Orlaeth, well…” Here, Seris wasn’t quite ready to let the full truth out, fearing that, should word get back to Agrona, it would somehow help him disable her defenses. “Just know that he has been incapacitated, but not killed.”

The gathered highbloods stared around at each other, their expressions mostly falling within the spectrum of incredulity. Ainsworth shifted in his seat. Frost leaned back in his chair, causing it to creak. Umburter picked a sliver from the side of the table and frowned down at it, disgusted.

“What does Seris want with us?” Maylis asked. She was reclined back in the wooden tavern chair, one leg crossed over the other, her fingertips fiddling at the golden hilt of a dagger.

Seabrook barked out, “Soldiers, obviously,” before I could respond.

“No, she needs legitimacy,” Ainsworth said in answer, the first words he’d spoken since my arrival. “Support to establish that this is more than an upstart rebellion meant for a sudden and violent end.”

“But is it?” Wolfrum asked, looking to Frost for support.

The athletic older man nodded to Wolfrum. “Young Redwater asks a good question. While I am not so cowardly that I would refuse to say aloud that this continent has extensive problems, the reality is that we are ruled over by literal deities. We’ve all seen endless broadcasts of the wreckage the asuran attacks left in Dicathen. And the High Sovereign has many such Vritra at his command, each one capable of crushing entire armies. There is no standing up against that.”

Grabbing the nearest chair, I turned it around and sat down, my arms on the backrest. “I’m glad you’re aware the castles we all live in are made of sand.” This proclamation was met with another round of exchanged glances and murmuring. “Lovingly crafted and beautiful, perhaps, but standing only because a Sovereign hasn’t yet decided to knock it down. What good is your blood if, for even the most meager slight, an irritated, irrational god can wipe it away with one breath, then have forgotten you entirely by the next?”

Frost shifted in his seat. Maylis went still, her body carrying the tension of a coiled spring despite her relaxed posture. Umburter looked down at his hands, his face pale.

“And yet,” I said more softly, “the High Sovereign hasn’t smashed the shield around western Sehz-Clar or slaughtered Seris, and every day another city in Dicathen falls, taken back by the people of that continent. His control is already slipping.”

I focused on Seabrook, and the others did as well. The plum-faced man

raised his chins proudly.

“You asked about the golden-eyed man,” I said. “No, he hasn’t been sneaking around Alacrya slitting Sovereign throats. Because it is *he* who has been single-handedly retaking the continent of Dicathen, just as it was he who burned the military encampment to the north of Victorious.”

Exeter let out a low whistle. “So it’s true then? Ascender Grey is Dicathian?”

I nodded. “He arrived on our continent to master the Relictombs. And he has succeeded.”

Maylis let out a shocked scoff. “But what does that even mean, Caera? To *master* the Relictombs?”

“Simple.” My lips curved in a nonchalant smile. “To master the Relictombs means to master aether.”

This was one of the hardest parts. Seris wanted these people to see Grey as some kind of folk hero, more myth than man. Even given everything I’d seen him do, though, it was difficult for me to think of him that way.

“In all your ascents, have you ever met someone who can navigate anywhere they want in the Relictombs?” I asked, still focused on Maylis.

“That’s impossible,” she said immediately.

“Or, Highlord Frost, have you ever seen an ascender spontaneously receive a new rune without a bestowal?”

“No,” he said slowly, rolling the word around in his mouth as if considering its implications.

“I have,” I said simply, the statement devoid of gravitas. “Because I ascended alongside Grey through many zones and watched him do these things, and many more besides.”

Chamberlain Geoffrey’s gaze was very far away, but across the table from him, Wolfrum was staring intently at me. “Then what my friend in Taegrin Caelum told me…”

“You mean the Wraiths?” I asked, and all eyes turned to him. He shrank in on himself nervously. “Tell them what happened,” I prodded.

His gaze darted all over the table as he took in a deep breath, obviously steeling himself for whatever else he had to say. “He said, well there were rumors that…a battle group of *Wraiths*”—he whispered the word—“was destroyed on the other continent.”

“But the Wraiths are a fairy story, a—” Umburter started to say, but Wolfrum cut him off with a violent shake of his head.

“They’re not! The Redwaters, they”—he swallowed with some difficulty—“wanted me to be one, when my blood manifested. Only…”

Seabrook cleared his throat, somewhat nervously I thought. “Are you suggesting that this Ascender Grey killed them?”

“It’s true,” Ainsworth answered in Wolfrum’s stead. “I had men in that battle, one of them my own nephew. He described how the Scythes were crushing the enemy’s generals as terrible magic was unleashed in the distance, but then a golden-eyed man appeared and threw down a Vritra horn for all to see, and Scythes Melzri and Viessa retreated with a bow.”

“They *bowed* to the man?” Chamberlain Geoffrey burst out, scandalized.

Again, the table broke down into muttering and cross chatter, but this time I let the moment linger.

“You all saw for yourself what he did at the Victoriad,” I said when the noise had quieted down. “Alone, armies can’t fight asura. But with a man such as Grey leading them…”

I let the words linger. I expected someone to argue, claim a foreigner couldn’t possibly lead Alacryans, or that we’d just be replacing one authoritarian deity for another, but to my surprise, that wasn’t the response I got.

“Eight battle groups made it back to my blood before the long-range teleporters were deactivated,” Lord Exeter said, his low voice now soft. “They all shared the same story: this ascender Grey gave them a choice, multiple times, to come home rather than die.”

“Sounds like eight groups of cowards to me,” Seabrook huffed.

Exeter’s scowl was a violent, nearly physical thing.

“I’ve heard the same from several others,” Ainsworth pointed out, his focus also on Seabrook. “Apparently our enemy is more gentle with the

lives of our men than our own leaders are."

I stood suddenly, stepping around my chair and closer to Exeter, the fingertips of my right hand trailing along the table's edge. "Do you know what the asuran word for our kind is?"

No one answered.

"Lessers."

Frost watched me thoughtfully. To his side, Ainsworth investigated the scarred tabletop as if it were a battle map. Wolfrum's mismatched eyes followed me now, no longer bouncing around the other highlords. Seabrook was silent and brooding, Umburter unfocused, appearing lost, Exeter somewhere in between. Geoffrey was leaning forward on the table, tapping his lips with one finger as he contemplated everything that had been said. Maylis wore the stoic expression of one who had looked into the face of death often and fought for everything she'd ever had.

"To the Vritra, there is no difference between the most powerful highblood mage and the lowliest unblooded unadorned. To them, you are all *lesser*, and that is all any of us will ever be. And as lessers, our lives are only as valuable as what they can be traded for, sacrificed for. A commodity."

Umburter was nodding along now. Seabrook's cheeks had flushed red as wine.

"Seris is not content to let the *lessers* of this world be burned as fuel for a war of asuras. *I* am not content, *Grey* is not, and so together we will fight to ensure *you* are not so misused." Frost's hands clenched into fists. A silly drunken smirk stretched across Wolfrum's face. "Even if you will not," I finished somberly.

The words settled over the table like a heavy snowfall, blanketing everyone and dulling all other noise. Even the inn's barroom seemed to go quiet for just a moment.

And through the silence, I felt them. Several powerful mana signatures approaching from down the street.

No one else had sensed them, but Maylis must have caught the sudden tension in my stance, because she stood and rested a hand on her dagger. "What is it?"

“Mages—powerful ones.” I scanned the faces, all tensed like silk hoppers about to spring as they waited for me to give an order. I didn’t need them to give me any further indication of their support; that moment of servility from these otherwise decisive and commanding men revealed how the perception of power had shifted within the room.

“Go,” I said, and they all began to move.

Young Lord Umburter threw a cloak around his shoulders, and suddenly I found myself blinking rapidly, no longer able to focus on him. Although plain, the cloak was enchanted so that my attention would slide right off him.

The others all had similar magical accoutrements to keep them safe and unnoticed, but I didn’t wait to investigate each one.

Pulling the door open slowly, I peeked into the hall before leaving the room. There was no one to be seen, so I hurried toward the back door. Halfway there, an arm slid through mine. Surprised, I started to pull away, then belatedly realized it was Maylis.

Grinning, she grabbed a bottle of some deep red liquor from a shelf against the wall, pulled the cork with her teeth, and took a long quaff. When my further surprise showed on my face, she gave a throaty chuckle and said, “What? We’re just a couple of old friends meeting for a drink in these uncertain times. Come on.”

Then she was trying to pour the liquor into my mouth, laughing all the while.

After recovering from my near drowning, we went out the door, not quietly, but with Maylis kicking it open and cheering into the cool night. It still smelled of rain, although the storm had let up while I’d been in the inn.

Arm in arm, we left the alleyway and Maylis guided me to the right.

“You know, Caera, I’m pretty surprised your blood never manifested,” she said conversationally, her breath fogging slightly. “Of the Vritra-blooded kids I was paraded around in front of, you seemed the most focused.”

I felt a wriggle of guilt through my insides, but this was a truth Seris and I weren’t ready to tell anyone yet. “I’m certain my adoptive parents would agree with you. Although, surprised *and* disappointed would probably

describe their disposition more completely."

Behind us, I sensed the mana signatures stopping somewhere around the inn. My mana was still suppressed, and I could sense that Maylis had taken the same precaution.

Maylis chuckled and handed me the bottle. I took a sip, then asked, "How long ago did yours manifest? And I don't recall hearing of Highblood Tremblay before."

"Four years," she said, pulling me to the side so we didn't tromp through a large puddle. "And I'm not surprised. After I manifested, I spent some time—about three years and six months, to be exact—training in Taegrin Caelum. And being poked and prodded by about forty different researchers. Whatever they were looking for, though, I must not have had it. About six months ago, they sent me on my way with a new name and title—Matron Tremblay—and now I've got properties and estates and servants and…well, it's quite the change."

"But you still go on ascents," I stated, certain by her reaction earlier that she was no stranger to the Relictombs.

Her answering smirk was wry. "Much to everyone's chagrin, abso-fucking-lutely. I'm not just going to sit on my ass for the rest of my life." She suddenly peered at me, and one brow quirked up slightly. "So, this Grey guy. You two had a lot of alone time, huh?" Her eyebrows wiggled up and down, reminding me of Regis for some strange reason. "I only saw the broadcasts, but he seemed pretty hot…"

I felt myself go red in the face as I realized what she was insinuating. "Maylis! You really do have a lot to learn about being a highblood…"

But my embarrassment only made her laugh harder.

We continued on like this for a few blocks, then Maylis released me. "Whoever those mages were, they don't seem to be following us. Pity, I wouldn't have minded a fight." She grinned, shoving me playfully as I began to protest. "Anyway, I'm off in this direction. I *do* hope we see each other again soon, Caera. It seems like things are about to get *really* interesting here in Alacrya."

"I hope we can rely on Highblood Tremblay for support," I said formally, then, more conversationally, added, "because interesting isn't the word I'd choose for the times ahead, and I'd feel better facing them with you on our

side.”

She laughed, loud and carefree. “Always so focused, as I said. Farewell, Caera.” She spun away and began taking long, purposeful strides. “Oh, and of course, don’t die,” she shot over her shoulder before dipping into the shadows of an unlit street.

The mirth slipped away, her words conjuring a wary melancholy in its place. “I can only do my best,” I said to myself, then turned and hurried toward the back-alley tempus warp I would use to return to the eastern edge of Sehz-Clar, outside the asura-powered shields.

I became aware of the figure shadowing me almost instantly, though I couldn’t be certain if they’d been there before and I’d missed them or if they’d just appeared. I didn’t hurry my pace but kept up a steady march as my mind raced. Their mana signature wasn’t overwhelming, but it could be a stronger mage partially shielding their presence, or just a scout or spy sent to track me to my destination or keep other, stronger mages apprised of my location.

After a couple of minutes, I made a sharp turn away from my eventual destination, drawing my pursuer into a tightly packed residential area with limited line of sight.

After my third quick turn, I stopped and drew my blade. When the figure stepped around the corner, they found scarlet steel at their throat. I peered into the shadows under their hood, but it was too deep and dark, hiding their features.

“Don’t move,” I ordered. “State your name and purpose immediately.”

They were motionless, their hands out to their sides. From beneath the hood, a husky, raw voice said, “Can I move my lips, or—well, supposing I can’t, I guess it’d be too late for me anyway, but since you aren’t running me through, I guess I can.”

I felt my features pinch into a confused frown as the man rambled. “Who are you, and why are you following me?”

Slowly, hands raised up to the sides of the hood, pulling it down to reveal an older man, heavyset, with middle-length gray hair and an unkempt beard.

“Lady Caera,” the familiar figure stated, his eyes nearly crossing as he

tried to look at the point of my sword.

“Alaric,” I replied, plucking the name from the fog, only partially remembered. “To what pleasure do I owe such an unlooked-for visit from Grey’s counterfeit uncle this fine night?”

“I could hardly stand to see you playing patty cake with those prissy, overpruned nobles.” He chuckled, and his glassy eyes went dark. “It won’t be enough, lass. No, if you want to foment a rebellion, you need to look a lot lower.”

I withdrew my weapon but didn’t stow it. My mind whirled with questions, but I held back, still reserved. I didn’t know this man well and had only his tenuous connection to Grey for assurance.

“Continue.”

Alaric grinned, showing off yellowing teeth. “You need friends in low places, and nobody’s got more friends, and none lower, than me.” He hesitated, and there was a twinkle in his eye. “And my service will only cost you a bottle of mead for the walk.”

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A BLOODLESS EXCHANGE

ARTHUR LEYWIN

"You're doing the right thing," Jasmine said, her steady voice rising above the noise of the crowds milling around below.

Lines of disarmed Alacryan soldiers queued uncomfortably in front of the rows of teleportation gates being manned by loyal Dicathians. Jasmine and I had found a flat rooftop to watch Vanesy's soldiers work from above.

I let out a heavy breath. "I know."

The resistance against my plan had been stiffer here than in Blackbend. The hostility between the two sides hung in the air like a viscous mist. Many of the Alacryan soldiers didn't understand why their highblood leaders had given in so easily, and they were still eager for a fight. Their control here had been ironclad, and the people of the city had suffered with nowhere else to go.

The city felt like a powder keg, and sparks were flying in every direction.

Even as we watched, I saw a Dicathian augmenter shove an unarmed Alacryan hard in the back when the man didn't immediately move forward to close the gap in his queue. The man spun and pulled back his fist, which sprouted stone spikes, but the augmenter already had his sword in his hand, and the tip was pressed to the Alacryan's chest.

"Just say the word," Regis said as he lifted a leg off the edge of the roof. "I can piss down a stream of Destruction on them to set an example."

I felt the same urge to intervene as Regis. It wasn't in my nature to watch this strife and do nothing, especially since I could end it with a wave of a

hand.

“You relegated management of this city to Commander Glory and the Helsteas for a reason,” Jasmine voiced, her perceptive gaze catching the slight shift in my posture that gave away my thoughts. “To intervene now is to show that you don’t trust them.”

“That’s true,” I said, forcing myself to relax.

As if conjured into being by Jasmine’s words, Vanesy appeared through the crowd and forced the fighting men apart, shouting down her man while promising swift justice to any Alacryan who brandished weapon or spell against the Dicathians.

I stood up, letting Regis return to my body. “We should get moving.”

Together, Jasmine and I hopped off the roof and marched across the broad street that connected all the portal frames.

Most of the portals were busy, sending a nonstop stream of Alacryans beyond the Wall into a small town in the Beast Glades, which just happened to be the location of the only surviving teleportation gate on the other side of the mountains. But a single portal at the very end wasn’t currently being used, as I’d requested.

As we passed through, heads turned in our wake. Every human emotion was present, written on the faces and burning from the eyes of those gathered there, many mingled together into an incongruous alchemy of uncertain feelings.

I kept my focus forward, however, letting the fear, hatred, respect, and adoration of both Alacryans and Dicathians spill past me without absorbing it.

The teleportation gate hummed to life as the attendant calibrated it for Etistin City, and the world lurched around me when I stepped into the portal.

It was a significant journey from Xyrus to Etistin, crossing nearly the entire breadth of Sapin. As the blurred landscape flowed past, I felt myself settle, leaving the problems of Xyrus behind.

My vision lurched, and the inside of the stone structure housing the receiving teleportation gate came into focus. It was empty. No guards

manned the receiving gate or guarded the iron-banded doors that led to a broad plaza beyond. Through one of the open windows that circled the structure, I could see the palace in the distance, gleaming white in the bright sun.

Jasmine appeared behind me a moment later. Her daggers came out, but I gestured for calm.

Beyond the open doors, no less than fifty battle groups stood arrayed throughout the plaza. The soldiers, standing stiffly at attention, wore their gray and red uniforms, but they were not armed or armored.

As I crossed the tiled floor of the portal chamber, our footfalls were the only sound save for the distant crowing of some sea bird circling the bay.

Standing out in front of the gathered force was the retainer, Lyra Dreide, her fire-red hair blowing like a flag in the steady breeze coming off the sea. She stiffened at the sight of me.

“Welcome, Lance Arthur Leywin,” she said, her honey-sweet voice carrying easily throughout the silent plaza. “I am Lyra of Highblood Dreide, retainer of Central Dominion and regent of this continent on behalf of High Sovereign Agrona.”

Jasmine let out a sharp breath as she appeared beside me halfway through Lyra’s speech. Exchanging a quick glance, the two of us stepped out of the wide double doors and looked around.

A gap had been left between two lines of battle groups where thirty corpses had been neatly laid out on the cobbles. My first thought, felt with a flash of fury, was that it was yet another ploy from the Alacryans, and I was afraid of the faces I might see among the dead. Their garb, though, was Alacryan.

Behind the corpses were piles of weapons and armor.

Lyra Dreide followed the line of my gaze. “This is what happens to Alacryans who won’t follow orders.”

None of the remaining soldiers let their attention settle on the corpses. Those closest—the ones who would be able to hear the buzz of flies beginning to swarm the bodies—kept their eyes firmly forward.

Still, I remained wary of some trap, and so I activated Realmheart.

A ripple ran through the crowd like wind stirring the leaves of a great tree.

Realmheart lifted my wheat-blond hair from my head, and I could feel the warm glow from my back and beneath my eyes. The fear I instilled in them shone from their own eyes, reflected back at me in the shape of the violet Realmheart runes.

And I couldn't help but wonder, what did these men and women from that distant and alien continent see me as? Had I made myself a symbol for mercy, or could they only see me as an embodiment of death?

And, perhaps more importantly, regardless of which it was, would it be enough to overpower their fear of the asuras who controlled them?

"What is all this?" I asked, returning my attention to Lyra Dreide.

She raised a hand, and all of the soldiers present went down on one knee and bowed their heads. Slowly, she followed them, although she did not bow her head but rather kept up unflinching eye contact. "This," she said with a slow, exaggerated enunciation, "is my surrender."

A subtle movement to my left made me turn. Jasmine's fist was white knuckled around the hilt of one dagger, and she was chewing the inside of her lip. For most people, it would have been little more than a faint tick, but I could read her surprise, caution, and distrust clearly.

I took a step closer to the retainer and looked down into her quick, curious eyes. "What are the terms of this surrender?"

Her tongue darted across her lips as she considered how best to respond. After a long moment, she said, "I have not come to bargain or plead with you, Regent Leywin. There are no terms. Alacrya's forces in Dicathen surrender."

"Then what's keeping me from killing you now?" I asked. "Or these men?"

Lyra Dreide gave me a tight-lipped smile. "You offered men who were actively trying to kill you their lives, and yet you would slay those who now stand before you, unarmed and at your mercy?"

'I told you you were starting to be predictable,' Regis pointed out.

It isn't necessarily a bad thing, I argued.

Jasmine took a step closer to me. “Perhaps executing the retainer would make removing the soldiers simpler?”

Lyra cleared her throat. “Regent Leywin, I—”

“I’m not regent,” I interrupted, considering both Jasmine’s and Regis’s words. “Lance or general, maybe, but—”

“Excuse me, Regent Leywin, but I have ceded authority over this continent to you.” I glared at the woman as she interrupted me, but she didn’t back down. “Until such a time as you reestablish your own form of government, I believe that does, in fact, make *you* regent of Dicathen.”

“This is no place to have this conversation,” I said with a meaningful look at the crowd of enemy mages in their tidy rows. “Lyra of Highblood Dreide, you are, for the moment, my prisoner.” She bowed ever so slightly. “If I sense any treachery from you, you die.”

“Understood,” she said without missing a beat, a stark reminder that, in Alacrya, the price of failure at her position was always death.

“Is this all the soldiers in Etistin?” I asked as I turned toward the Royal Palace.

Jasmine and Lyra fell into step behind me.

“No, the greater bulk of our force here is still being escorted out of the city. Since Etistin has remained a hotbed of rebellious activity, there is a large force of troops here. Over sixteen thousand in the city alone, and nearly as many scattered throughout the surrounding countryside. The majority are currently being relocated into camps outside the city.”

“Don’t bother with camps,” I said over my shoulder.

A face peered down at us from the second-story window of a well-constructed estate: a girl, maybe seven years of age, her eyes wide as dinner plates and blue as the bay. I wanted to give her a smile, maybe even a wave, but I simply watched as she ran back out of sight.

“All Alacryans are being relocated beyond the Wall until this war is over,” I continued. Now that I was looking, I could see other signs of movement from the residents of Etistin. Lyra Dreide hadn’t told the people what was happening, I realized.

“Regent, perhaps I can—”

I stopped and turned, pinning her with a sober scowl. “Was there a part of ‘you are my prisoner’ that you failed to understand?”

She paused, waiting for me to finish speaking, then went on. “—offer you some insight into the situation in Etistin that might provide some options beyond just your current plan.”

Next to Lyra, Jasmine raised her eyebrows very slightly and slid a dagger partially out of its sheath. I gave her a subtle shake of my head.

I immediately found myself more curious than annoyed by the retainer’s daring. Groveling, begging, pleading…that was what I’d expected. Where did this boldness come from, I wondered.

When we reached the palace gates, armed Alacryan guards immediately laid down their weapons and marched away, following some predetermined orders. Several people curiously watched us approach from the palace entry but scattered to get out of our way, and no one engaged with us.

I’d been in the Royal Palace briefly before the Battle of the Bloodfrost, but not enough to know my way around. Jasmine and I allowed Lyra to lead us through the grand entry and into a series of solars and apartments until we reached a private study.

I looked around curiously.

The room was tidy but stuffed full of scrolls, maps, stacks of parchment, and books. Picking up a piece of heavy waxed parchment, I realized it was a detailed drawing of the palace itself. The piece below it in the pile was much the same, but from a different angle and with a cutaway revealing the palace interior.

I set the parchment down. Lyra and Jasmine were both watching me expectantly. “We need to fill the void left by your absence,” I said after a moment.

Lyra rested one hip against the side of the desk dominating the study and fiddled with the edge of a scroll. “Many of the previous Dicathian king and queen’s servants and courtiers still reside in the city. Some are imprisoned in the bowels of this palace, others have taken up new lives, new careers. I’m certain they will make themselves known when you publicly announce my surrender.”

What she said was true, but I knew I couldn't just pull some courtier out of prison and tell them they were in charge of Sapin's capital city. No, I needed people who knew the city well, who understood the politics and players, and who would immediately have public support.

"Wait here," I said, reaching for my extradimensional storage rune.

The heavy metallic tempus warp appeared in my hands, and I carefully set it down next to a crowded bookshelf. Warmth flooded my body as I activated Realmheart again, using aether to manipulate the mana required to calibrate the device for Vildorial.

After a moment, a portal shimmered into existence beside the tempus warp.

"Would you mind bringing the Glayders here for me?" I asked Jasmine.

She nodded before vanishing through the portal without hesitation.

Lyra pushed away from the desk and approached the tempus warp, kneeling down to examine it more closely. "Impressive. Only the High Sovereign himself is allowed to commission artifacts capable of such long-range teleportation."

I continued to peruse the stacks of parchment and scrolls. "The Wraiths I killed brought it with them," I said casually. "An emergency escape route in case things went poorly, I assume."

She scoffed, standing upright, her lavender eyes settling on me. "That certainly backfired on them, didn't it?"

I leaned against a shelf, arms crossed, and met her gaze. "You know a lot about what has been happening. On both continents, it seems."

"That is my job," she answered simply. "To know things. For example, perhaps it has occurred to you that the defense of Dicathen was rather ramshackle and ineffective? Well, it might interest you to know that Agrona's attention has been forced back home. Treachery at the highest ranks. Maybe even civil war."

Regis manifested from the deep shadows around me, his eyes wide with interest. "Ooh, do spill the tea."

Giving no other indication that she was surprised by Regis's appearance other than taking a step back from the shadowy wolf, the retainer plucked

a scroll from the desktop and tossed it to me with a forced smile. “Scythe Seris Vritra somehow defeated or otherwise removed one of the Sovereigns and claimed half of Sehz-Clar for herself.”

I unrolled the scroll. It was a missive detailing the events of the rebellion in Alacrya. *So Seris finally made her move*, I mused. “But even if she had the support of all Alacrya, she can’t win a civil war against the Vritra clan,” I said aloud.

“It does seem like an unnecessarily roundabout way of getting herself and all her followers killed,” Lyra answered. She shifted her weight and dug the toe of her boot into the polished wood of the floor. “Unless…”

I followed the thread the retainer had laid out for me. “Unless she isn’t trying to win. When exactly did this rebellion start?”

“Almost immediately after you destroyed a secret military facility in the dominion of Vechor,” she answered.

I frowned. It had been a week since the Wraiths ambushed me in Vildorial. More than enough time for Agrona to respond to their defeat. I’d made it more difficult for him to send additional soldiers to Dicathen, but not impossible. And even I couldn’t fight all his forces, especially if he sent more Wraiths or even Sovereigns.

A fact Seris would know well.

I recalled that first meeting, looking up—bloody, broken, manaless—from the bottom of a crater, Sylvie beside me, pinned to the ground by Uto’s blood iron spikes. Even then, before we had ever met, Seris had shielded me from Agrona’s servants.

Is that what she’s doing now? I wondered. There didn’t seem to be any other likely explanation.

“Do you mind my asking,” Lyra began, “what you will be doing next? With Vildorial, Blackbend, Xyrus, and Etistin under your control, it is only a matter of time until the rest of Dicathen falls back to you.”

“I’m expecting company after this,” I said vaguely, but at that moment, the opaque portal shivered, and a ripple passed over its colorless surface as Jasmine materialized.

Just behind her, Curtis and Kathyln Glayder came through.

I smiled to see the wonder on both their faces. Kathyln took a faltering step toward the desk, her hand reaching slowly out, fingers trailing across the smooth mahogany surface.

Curtis's focus was on me, a grin lighting up his square face, but then his head turned, and the grin collapsed into an outraged snarl. "What the hell is she doing here?"

Lyra, who had stepped back into the corner of the study, bowed to the Glayders. "Welcome, Lord and Lady Glayder. I understand this is—"

Suddenly Curtis was moving. Golden fire blazed from his fist up the length of his arm, which cocked back to deliver a mana-reinforced blow. But, quick as Curtis was, Kathyln was even quicker.

With a single step, she interposed herself between her brother and the retainer, her black hair flying behind her like a flag. Her hand came up and pressed against Curtis's chest, forcing him to stop.

"Kat, this is the woman who—"

"I know who she is, brother," Kathyln said, betraying no emotion.

Jasmine kept glancing in my direction, perhaps hoping for some guidance on whether or not to intervene, but I only watched. It would build resentment in the Glayders if I forced them to stand down or appeared to side with Lyra Dreide. They needed to work through this on their own. Besides, Lyra was a retainer. From what I'd heard, she'd put up a half-decent fight against Varay, Mica, and Aya all together. Even if the Glayders attacked her, I doubted they could kill her.

Kathyln turned around, leveling an icy stare at Lyra.

The retainer cleared her throat. "I understand your hatred of me, but know that I only ever did as I was commanded by Scythe Cadell or the High Sovereign himself. After all, each one of us is but a piece on the board, it is the Sovereigns who—"

Kathyln's hand crashed against Lyra's cheek with a sharp crack, snapping the retainer's head to the side. "Your excuses are feeble and pointless," she said, completely in control of herself. "Regardless of whether you butchered our parents for fun or only paraded their bodies around the countryside for fear of death at the hands of your own lord, you are a monster, and if it were up to me, you'd already be dead."

“Ooh,” Regis whispered before I shot a glare at him.

Curtis, arm still blazing, pointed a fiery finger at me. “Arthur, what’s the meaning of this? Why did you bring us here? Why isn’t this creature’s head on a spike already?”

I pushed away from the bookshelf and closed the distance to Curtis. Reaching out, I rested one hand on his upper arm—the arm that was burning. Golden flames danced between my fingers. He kept the conjured flames in place for a breath, two, then suddenly they vanished, leaving the room feeling much darker and less warm.

“Because, at least for the moment, we need her.” Curtis opened his mouth to argue, but I kept speaking. “This city is in shambles. I need a strong hand to help lift the people of Etistin back up, to provide leadership and security after the Alacryans are gone.”

“You want us to lead the city,” Kathyln said, one eye on me, the other on Lyra.

“You know the city, the people. Your name means something here, carries a natural authority.” I released Curtis’s arm. “There is a lot of rebuilding to be done. I trust you to do it.”

Curtis glowered around the study, his eyes focusing anywhere but me or Lyra Dreide. “What about the Alacryans? Rumor is you’re sending them all beyond the Wall.”

“Yes, I—”

Lyra Dreide cleared her throat again and gave me a smile simultaneously apologetic and yet very much not so. “As I tried to suggest before, I don’t believe sending so many Alacryan soldiers across the entire breadth of the continent to forage off your Beast Glades is the only—or the wisest—course of action, Regent.”

Curtis’s neck and cheeks flushed red. “Who said you could speak, demon?”

Such brazenness, I thought, almost amused. “What do you suggest then?”

Curtis’s teeth ground together as he glared at me, shocked.

Lyra hesitated a moment, apparently waiting to see if the Glayders were going to interrupt her, then said, “We have many ships in the bay. Allow

any Alacryan—or Dicathian—who wishes it to depart for Alacrya immediately. We have surrendered. It would be a sign of good faith, and a sound strategic decision as well, as the journey is a long one. Any soldiers who spend the next month at sea can't be used against you, but they are also safe from the High Sovereign's wrath as well."

"A sign of *good faith*?" Curtis sputtered, but Kathyln took his hand and squeezed it firmly, silencing him.

"And…" Lyra started but immediately paused.

"Go on."

"I would suggest that anyone who renounces their service to the High Sovereign be allowed to stay in Dicathen." She raised her chin as Curtis scoffed, her lavender eyes looking down her nose into the deep brown wells of his. "Many of these men and women have been here for over a year, Lord Glayder. They have homes, families—"

"Bullshit," Curtis snapped. "As if any Dicathian would willingly form a family with an Alacryan. What you mean is our people have been forced into slavery, sold off, their homes and lives stolen—"

"No," Lyra said firmly. "In fact, the High Sovereign forbids such things. Our culture values purity of blood, and the Sovereigns were firm in their insistence that there be no intermingling of Dicathian and Alacryan blood." She smiled, and there was a wicked sort of gleam in her eye. "But the Sovereigns are a long way away, and love is a strange and powerful thing."

"Love?" Curtis ground out. "As if the conquered can ever fall in *love* with the conqueror, except by force and fear."

"You may have lived the last year in a hole in the ground, Lord Glayder, but I have not," Lyra said sharply. "You will see for yourself soon enough."

"Perhaps," Kathyln said to Lyra, but she was looking at me. "I admit I'm uncomfortable with the retainer's suggestion. Ships full of soldiers could just as easily circle the continent and attack from another direction. Or bide their time off the coast until the next major attack, then we would be dealing with a conflict on multiple fronts. If more of those Wraiths were to come…"

She made a good point. I understood the intention of Lyra's plan, and it would be much easier to board the soldiers on boats than transport them all the way to the Wall, but that meant we were giving Agrona back several thousand warriors.

I glanced at Jasmine, who had been silent throughout the encounter. She only shrugged.

I found myself agreeing with Lyra's judgment, but I was still wary of simply making decrees and expecting everyone to jump in line and follow orders. "The three of you will be working together on this. Lyra has surrendered, but her suggestions aren't without value. However we proceed, everyone should be in agreement."

There was a tense pause. Curtis turned to Kathyln, who held my gaze.

"I believe we should do as the retainer has suggested," she said at length.

I expected Curtis to argue with her, but he seemed to be forcing himself to relax, releasing his balled fists and taking a deep breath. "If we're going to allow Alacryans to stay, we should at least imprison them for a while… thirty days, if not more."

Lyra frowned.

Kathyln's brows rose as she considered her brother. "That will allow the…*families* some separation, to ensure any such agreements are truly mutual, and protect both the people of Dicathen and the Alacryan soldiers. It's a good compromise."

A ripple of force disturbed the air in the study, casting a palpable veil over everything and causing us all to turn in the direction it had come from.

"What in the—" Curtis muttered, his hand on his sword.

"So much mana…" Lyra said, her eyes widening.

I quickly activated Realmheart, and a smile slowly bloomed on my face as I recognized the signature.

I started for the door with Regis close behind, then stopped suddenly and turned to face the Glayders. "This should go without saying, but Lyra Dreide is my prisoner. For the time being, she will stay here and help you with the arrangements. I expect her to remain unharmed." My focus shifted to the retainer. "When I return, I'll decide her fate. Depending, of

course, on how *helpful* she has been in that time."

Three sets of eyes blinked at me uncertainly, but I knew I couldn't spend more time lingering in Etistin. The next phase of the war was already beginning.

I pushed open the door and headed for the main gates, Jasmine a quiet shadow just behind me.

Once we were out of earshot of the study, I stopped.

"What's up?" Jasmine asked as I turned toward her.

I gave her an apologetic smile. "I'm sorry, I need to do this next part alone."

She shrugged. "I figured."

Then, thinking to Regis, I added, *I need you to stay here as well. To keep an eye on Lyra. Stay out of sight and watch her. My gut tells me we can trust her sense of self-preservation, but I won't risk the Glayders' lives on that alone.*

I felt Regis's disappointment and frustration bleeding through our link. *'I don't know about this, Art.'*

This is important, Regis. I don't know Lyra, but I know Kezess. I won't be in danger.

He sighed before turning to Jasmine. "I know this is weird, but do I have your consent to hide within the meat puppet you call a body?"

A shiver ran down her back as her red eyes widened with disbelief. "W-what…?"

I rolled my eyes and would have kicked Regis, except he'd already become incorporeal. "He's going to stay behind to keep everyone safe, but I want him out of sight. Lyra shouldn't know he's here."

Jasmine took a moment to compose herself, straightening her armor and smoothing the shocked expression from her features. "Whatever needs to be done."

Without a sound, Regis vanished into Jasmine. Her jaw tightened, and she clenched her teeth as the ball of aether that was Regis hovered around her

core.

“So weird,” she ground out.

‘Hey, it’s not much better for me, okay?’ Regis thought, but by her lack of reaction, I assumed Jasmine couldn’t hear him.

“Stay safe. I shouldn’t be gone long,” I said. *And you mind your manners,* I thought to Regis.

Then I was marching through the palace again, now alone.

Outside, I found a roughly oval disc of opaque energy hanging before us. Shouts rose up from the palace as the few people who had snuck out to see what was happening rushed away from the area.

A blinding white silhouette appeared, stepping through the portal.

The portal faded, revealing a man with platinum-blond hair in a dark military-style uniform, and his otherworldly eyes—each one like a window into a distant galaxy—settled on me.

“Arthur Leywin. It has been some time.”

“It’s about damn time,” I replied conversationally. “I wasn’t sure he would send you considering everything.”

Windsom’s expression remained placid. “I am Lord Indrath’s envoy to this world. And as such, I am here to fetch you.” Mana hardened into a shimmering set of stairs that led up to the portal. “Come, Arthur. Lord Indrath would speak with you.”

I gave a throaty chuckle. “Yeah, I’m sure he would.”

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A MATCH FOR MY TALENTS

NICO SEVER

Something heavy was grabbing me, pinning me down. And it was dark, all so dark. Wetness clung to me, slicking my bare skin, while something soft was pressing against me like the tongue of a giant creature, giving life and texture to the sickly-sweet onion smell sticking to everything.

I thrashed suddenly, certain that I was being devoured. A heavy blanket, which had been draped across my face, slid off the side of the bed and onto the floor.

I gasped, sucking in cold air that made me sputter and cough. Rolling onto my side, I meant to hang my head over the edge of the bed in case I got sick.

I wasn't alone.

Standing at the foot of the bed, now staring down at me with a look of disgust, was Agrona. Cecilia lingered next to him, her expression caught between nervousness, dismay, and embarrassment.

"I'll take my leave then," Agrona said, his ruby eyes turning on Cecilia. "No more delays, Cecil dear. You leave in the morning."

"Yes, High Sovereign," Cecilia said as she bowed deeply. "I'm ready."

My thoughts moved like molasses as I struggled to understand what the two were saying. A spark cut through the sluggishness, however, bringing me back to the last thing I remembered. "The regalia…" My tongue was thick and unwieldy, my mouth desert-dry. I moistened my lips and tried again. "What happened during the bestowal?"

Agrona gave me an unreadable look, then stepped closer and rested his hand on the top of my head. I felt a thrill at the contact, but bitterness immediately oozed up, a counterpoint to the initial emotional response. *Am I a hound that wags its tail at any sign of affection from its distant master?*

"As usual, Nico," Agrona said, his voice vibrating in my chest, "you have managed to fail in the most incredible fashion." He didn't sneer the words. They weren't filled with bitterness or insult. It was said simply, a statement of fact. "I had hoped perhaps your recent experiences would instill in you the sort of drive which you have always lacked. But alas, this new regalia is a perfect match for your talents."

His hand pulled away, and his brows rose a fraction of an inch in a silent question: *Do you have anything to say about that, idiot boy?* When I didn't reply, I seemed to confirm something Agrona had expected, because he nodded his head, then marched away, the ornaments in his horns jangling slightly.

When the door clicked shut, Cecilia hurried forward to the edge of my bed, sinking down to her knees and pushing sweat-damp hair from my eyes. "Oh, Nico. Are you okay? You've been unconscious for a whole day."

I rolled onto my back and focused on breathing so I didn't vomit in front of her. "Fine."

Her graceful fingers laced into mine, and she rested her head on the mattress and watched me silently.

"Agrona said you're leaving," I ventured after a couple minutes of silence. "Where is he sending you?"

She sat up, releasing my hand to brush a strand of gunmetal gray hair out of her face as she did so. "I'm to lead the assault on Sehz-Clar. Agrona wants me to put on a show of force to assure this rebellion doesn't spread."

I closed my eyes and bit back the bitter words that leapt to my tongue. It was the news I had been expecting, and yet I was still having trouble drawing breath. "You sound…pleased."

I heard Cecilia shuffle as she got to her feet, then the mattress shifted. I opened my eyes again to find her sitting next to me.

"Of course I'm pleased," she said, frowning. "I've been training for this

since I was brought to this world. It's finally a chance for me to prove to Agrona that I'm worth everything he's given me—us." She met my eyes and held them. "This is how we earn our lives back, Nico."

I swallowed hard. My tongue felt swollen, and I was suddenly afraid I might choke on it.

She leaned in closer, still staring deep into my eyes. "But I'm not going anywhere without you. So rest up, all right? I'll be back in the morning, and then, we're going to kill a traitor."

With a big smile gracing her gorgeous face, Cecilia ran her fingers through my hair, then jumped off my bed. She stopped to look back from the doorway. "Oh, I almost forgot."

From a pouch, she withdrew the slightly rough sphere of the dragon's mana core. "I don't think Agrona would have been very happy if he'd found this. You need to be more careful." Despite the admonishment, she smiled as she set the sphere next to me. Then, with a quick wave, she was gone.

I blew out a gusting, frustrated breath. "Shit."

A few hours…that was all the time I had to get ready. Cecilia was going to war. And I'd be right beside her, protecting her.

A dark laugh bubbled up unbidden from within me. "How exactly am I going to do that?"

I let my eyes drift shut again.

And then shot upright as if on a spring. "Idiot," I cursed myself, jumping out of bed.

Mana poured out of my weakened core, empowering the new regalia that rested across my spine just below my shoulder blades. I didn't know what to expect, which was an odd sensation in itself. Normally, the officiants would explain the runes, but from what little I could pull from my foggy memory, they hadn't known what my regalia was.

It was something new.

Something that matches my talents, I thought bitterly, the words sounding in Agrona's voice.

The light of my chambers shifted as the regalia activated. It was a subtle thing, hardly noticeable at first, like clouds slowly creeping in overhead while the lighting artifacts activated in the street.

I followed these new points of brightness as I scanned the room. The walls, floor, ceiling, furniture—everything mundane within the room—seemed dull and shadowy, while the lighting artifacts glowed more brightly. There was a subtle shine to the metal knob and lock of my door, but, curiously, no glow at all from the dragon core.

I picked the sphere up and rolled it around in my hand, inspecting it from multiple angles, but it was dim and dark. This seemed strange to me since something as small and inconsequential as the Imbued quill on my writing desk burned in my altered perception, as did the sending parchment I'd collected for ordering some of the materials for my new artifact.

As my mind touched upon the staff, I hurried to the door into my workspace and opened it. Inside, it was much the same, except there, all the items arrayed across my workbench glowed with various potency.

It was more than a visible sensation, though. I could *feel* them, almost as if they were connected to me—and to each other. Each magic item, and even those that were not yet magical but had the capacity for being Imbued, stood out to my senses.

Glowing most brightly of all in this altered form of perception was the charwood branch itself, inset with a single fitting. The silver metal of the fitting was dull against the bright black wood. On the table, set aside for further experimentation, was a collection of different fittings molded from a different alloy. These burned brightly.

Curious, I set down the core and picked up a fitting. Nothing changed. As I moved it closer to the twisted branch, however, both sources of this connection shifted, but the change was less a glow and more a vibration. There was something shared between them, an attunement…

And then, with a crashing, world-shifting realization, I knew what my regalia did, and a wide grin broke across my face. "Something that matches my talents indeed."

Grabbing the specialized carving tool in one hand and holding the staff's base firmly in the other, I set to work, knowing I had only a few hours to make myself ready.

The sun's light had only barely turned the horizon gray-blue behind the distant mountains when a knock came at my door. I ignored it at first, so engrossed in my work I had forgotten the reason for its urgency. The knock came again, louder and more insistent, and time and space coalesced inside my mind, bringing me back to reality.

"Come in," I shouted from the workbench, certain Cecilia had come to collect me for our mission to Sehz-Clar.

The door opened, then closed again, and I heard her soft footfalls cross to the inner door. "I'm sorry, Nico, I—where are your clothes? Have you rested at all?"

I looked down at myself.

When I'd woken after the bestowal, I had been stripped down to my briefs. Only now did I realize I had been so engrossed by my regalia and the artifact I was creating that I hadn't even dressed myself.

"Here, look at this," I told her, too excited to care about any of that.

Grabbing her hand, I pulled Cecilia to the workbench and grinned proudly down at my creation.

Where a twisting branch had lain before, now there was a smooth and polished staff of purest black. The head of the staff flared outward subtly, and where it widened, four gems had been inset into the charwood.

An emerald as green as a viper's eyes, a sapphire bluer than the deepest depths of the ocean, a topaz bright as a flash of lightning, and a ruby rich as crystalized blood.

The trueness of color was important, as was the purity of the gem, the cleanness of the cut, and the strength of my intention when each gem was set. *That* was what my regalia did. It connected my mind to the truth of the materials that I worked with. I could see, feel, even taste the way the different materials fit into the world.

But that was just the beginning, I was certain. The more advanced and powerful a rune was, the harder mastering it became, but the greater the results. With time, practice, and patience, I could only begin to conceive of

what would be possible with the regalia.

"…it do?"

"Sorry?" I asked, realizing that Cecilia had been speaking.

"It's beautiful! What does it do?" she repeated, eyeing me warily.

I lifted the staff, feeling the nearly imperceptible network of glyphs, runes, and connective elements that had been carefully scored into nearly every inch of the charwood surface. Taking it in both hands, I imbued mana directly into the staff. My mana was drawn across the surface via the circuitry of silver inlaid into the invisible grooves before being absorbed into a specially designed mana crystal hidden between the four visible gems.

Cecilia's eyes followed the trail of mana, and once again I was amazed by her enhanced senses. In part, the design of the staff was intended to shroud its abilities. After all, it would be a poor amplifier of my power if it also gave away exactly what I was doing. Despite this, however, Cecilia had no trouble following the mana through its journey.

Around the staff's head, the atmospheric mana began reacting to the mana imbuing the staff. I could sense it, but I knew she could *see* the individual particles being drawn into the respective gems.

"It's amazing…" she muttered, her fingertips stretching out toward the wood but not touching it.

"The purified mana within the internal crystal gives shape to the magic, which then draws from the stored atmospheric mana to materialize as an elemental effect, becoming a spell," I said, pride swelling within my chest. "It was the dragon core that gave me the idea for the structure, but I couldn't have reformed the mana crystal without the regalia. Here, let me show you."

Although the staff had been charged for less than a minute, it had enough mana for a simple spell. Through the connective circuitry, I could still feel and manipulate my stored mana. I shaped it into the spell I desired.

The gems flashed, and a whirling jet of hissing steam billowed from the staff, out my open window, and off into the distance.

"That was water, fire, and air mana," she noted with some curiosity.

“With this, I can hone my own spells the way they do in Dicathen,” I said, breathless with excitement and the flush of victory. “Shape them however I want without relying on only my runes. And”—my grin widened—“I can utilize all four standard elements.”

Perhaps it was my imagination, but something dark passed over Cecilia’s face for just an instant. Then she was grinning with me, her hands on mine around the staff. “This is really amazing, Nico. But…” She hesitated, and something squirming and hot wriggled around in my stomach. “Is now really the best time to be experimenting? We’re going to war. What if…” Her words trailed off, and she bit her lip.

“What?” I asked, ice now seeping out from the hot thing worming through my guts. *Can’t you see I did this for* you*?*

“Your core is still recovering,” she said finally. “I don’t want you to get hurt by pushing yourself too hard. What if the staff fails? What if it hurts you somehow or…or doesn’t work like you hope?”

“Don’t you have any faith in me?” I asked, my voice coming out thin and painfully whiny.

Her fingers closed hard around my hands. “Nico, now isn’t the time for this,” she said firmly. “You brought me here, now let me do my part so I can get us home. Okay?”

This is wrong, I wanted to say. *I was wrong…*

“Yeah, okay,” I said instead. “I’m ready to go.”

She looked me over for what felt like a very long time, then the shadow of a smile broke the tension. “You should probably put on some clothes first, though.”

After quickly dressing in dark battlerobes, I was whisked through Taegrin Caelum without truly registering where we were going. My excitement had melted into melancholy, and I found myself drifting within a dreary fog.

A portal was ready for us. Cecilia exchanged words with a handful of officials and high-ranking mages, but I didn’t take any of it in. Then they were activating the tempus warp, and we flitted across half the continent in an instant.

I blinked several times as we appeared under the bright early morning sun, which wasn't hidden by the mountains in Sehz-Clar. It took a moment for our surroundings to come into focus.

The receiving platform was at the heart of a sprawling garden. Large bushes, small trees, and dozens of types of flowers surrounded us. The air was heavy with sea salt. It made for a strange transition from the dark depths of Taegrin Caelum. I had expected a war camp, soldiers surging through the streets, destructive artifacts arrayed toward the massive shields conjured by Seris.

As my eyes adjusted, I saw the shields in the distance. "Wow. But how? How could she wrap an entire dominion—or even half of one—in such a thing?"

Cecilia stepped down from the raised platform we'd appeared on and started beelining for the garden's exit. Over her shoulder, she said, "Agrona only has theories at this point. I'm relying on you to discover the source of this power."

The melancholy I had felt only moments before faded as my mind set to work considering the implications of Seris's creation. But it just didn't make sense. Even with a mountain of mana crystals, it wasn't possible to store enough energy to maintain such a colossal conjuration. And even then, *charging* the crystals would require more mana than could possibly be maintained, no matter how many mages she had working in concert.

The gears continued to spin as Cecilia led us toward the shield.

As we approached, it became more clear that the barrier had split the city cleanly in two. Behind the transparent bubble of mana, steep cliffs rose several hundred feet into the air. Soldiers and mages were busy at work on that side, but the streets were strangely empty and quiet outside of the shields.

"Where are our soldiers?" I asked Cecilia.

She didn't look at me as she answered. "Forces are being gathered outside of Rosaere, and all civilians who live within a mile of the barrier have already been sent away."

"What are you looking for?"

Her turquoise eyes were jumping rapidly across the shield's surface like

someone speed-reading a scroll. “The seams stitching this spell together.”

As if from nowhere, a gust of wind grabbed me and lifted me off the ground. Cecilia flew ahead of me, following the curving arc of the barrier.

Those on the other side had taken notice. Indecipherable shouts rang out from a dozen different sources, and those closest to the shielding began falling back.

My stomach flipped, and I worried I might be sick again. Though I had been able to fly myself before Grey destroyed my core, it wasn’t the same as being carted around like an infant with someone else’s magic. But I kept silent and let Cecilia consider the barrier.

After a handful of minutes had passed in stationary silence, I felt a familiar mana signature approaching from the other side of the shield.

A lone figure flew down from the clifftops, moving fast. In a moment, she was before us, hovering just on the other side.

Seris.

“Ah. The Legacy. I was starting to wonder what was taking so long,” she said, her voice only slightly muffled by the mana between us.

“Is Sovereign Orlaeth still alive?” Cecilia asked back, her demeanor entirely calm.

I found myself staring at the fine elven features she inhabited and wondering where this poise came from. We were a very long way away from the training rooms of Taegrin Caelum, and she was largely untested. Facing Seris was unlike anything Cecilia had done in either of her brief lives.

So why wasn’t she afraid?

Seris flashed us a wry smirk as she said, “Actually, he is with us at this very moment. He is everywhere in fact, still guarding Sehz-Clar as he always has.”

“I’m not interested in your word games,” Cecilia said, and I sensed the mana all around us tremble. “Drop these shields. Order your men to stand down, and allow my forces entry. Come willingly before the High Sovereign to face judgment, and he promises a swift end. The longer you drag out this farce, the longer he will do so with your death.”

Agrona's words, I thought, sensing him behind each syllable. *His words from her mouth. I hate this.*

"Surely, there are a thousand other messengers Agrona could have sent to threaten me," Seris said dispassionately. "You aren't here just for this unpleasant conversation, are you? Because I've no interest in engaging in a battle of wits when my opponent arrives so poorly armed."

Mana surged, a tempest of crushing, rending force from the clear blue. Cecilia reached out and clawed downward, and the mana forming the shield shook like castle gates being struck by a battering ram.

"If you won't…bring it down…then I will," Cecilia ground out through clenched teeth.

We flew closer, and Cecilia pressed her hand against the barrier. The air thinned around us, and I struggled to draw breath. I felt helpless, not in control of my own body, and all I could do was watch.

I'd never sensed anything like this battle before.

The world itself seemed to flex as Cecilia pushed in on the shield. The bubble warped, bending inward toward Seris.

My attention caught on my ex-colleague.

She didn't move, didn't flinch away from Cecilia's assault. Her scarlet eyes tracked every movement, every fluctuation of mana, but it wasn't wariness or fear I saw in that gaze. Seris was studying Cecilia, taking in and cataloging her use of mana, her strength.

It was then I knew Cecilia wouldn't break the shield, not like this.

But she wasn't backing off. Pressure built and kept building around us as she pulled mana from everywhere except the shield. She couldn't control that mana, that much was clear, but I had no idea why.

"Cecilia," I called, then louder, "Cecil!"

But she couldn't, or wouldn't, hear me. I reached out, trying to grab her, but she was too far away, and I was trapped.

"Cecilia, stop!" I shouted again.

Suddenly I was falling as the magic holding me aloft was withdrawn. I

cursed as I hit the ground rolling. The butt of the staff, strapped to my back, cracked against my head.

Like the fool I was, I'd nearly forgotten it was there.

Ripping it free of its sling, I began channeling mana into it. There was no time to wait for a charge to build, so I immediately worked the mana into an air-attribute spell, copying what Cecilia had done to make me fly.

It *worked*. Soft cushions of air wrapped around my limbs and lifted me from the ground, and I shot back up to Cecilia's side.

Her assault was flagging. Sweat was raining down her face. The depression she'd made in the shield was healing, strengthening, pushing her back.

I grabbed her wrist with my free hand.

Her head whipped around, and she glowered at me like some feral monster, her teeth bared and her eyes blazing. I shrank back, and something inside her snapped. The storm of mana faded away just like that. Her expression crashed into dismay as she stared at me, one hand over her mouth.

"Nico, I…"

But I wasn't watching her. My attention was pulled to the knowing smile quivering on Seris's lips.

I flew close to Cecilia, muttering, "Not now," then interposed myself between her and Seris. "We didn't come here to hurl threats from the other side of this wall you've conjured," I said as firmly as I could manage. "Many, many Alacryans will lose their lives in a war between Sehz-Clar and the rest of Alacrya, Seris. Why? Why lead these people to their deaths in a war you can't hope to win."

"This isn't a war, little Nico, but a revolution," came her quick reply. "And Agrona knows well enough that it certainly isn't Sehz-Clar versus Alacrya, but the people against the Sovereigns."

"What people?" I shot back, gesturing to the empty city behind me. "What rebellion? This is the height of foolishness."

"You'd know all about that, wouldn't you?" she replied. "Your entire existence is formulated on the premise, founded on foolishness. You two

—reincarnates—have no understanding of what life is truly like in this world. To you, it's a playground, a game, a dream you'll wake up from one day." She wasn't smirking anymore. There was a hardness to her features that made the hairs on my arms stand on end. "I know what he's promised you, Nico. But I also know that he can't do it. He doesn't have that kind of power."

Her words went straight through me. I should have prepared myself, should have known better, but everything Cecilia and I were doing was so Agrona would send us back to Earth, an Earth where we had a chance for a life together—a real life, as ourselves, not as the forms we'd taken when reincarnating in this world.

But I'd always feared it might be a lie. Ever since Cecilia's reincarnation had been completed, a doubt had grown.

Agrona had barely been able to complete our reincarnations into this world. What had ever made me think he could so casually implant us back into another world?

Next to me, Cecilia's expression faltered, but only for an instant. "Liar," she said, breathless. "You'd say anything to save your pathetic skin. You don't know Agrona, not the way *I* do. He's more powerful than you can even imagine, and so am I." She was huffing now, and even I was taken aback by the viciousness with which she addressed Seris. "I promise you, *little* Scythe, I'll rip this barrier down one way or another, and then"—a cloud rolled in above us, casting its darkness over Cecilia—"I'll come for you."

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A BATTLE OF WORDS

ARTHUR LEYWIN

Windsom waited, his otherworldly eyes trained on me, his expression unreadable.

My head turned slightly so I could see the cavernous arched entry to the palace, where Jasmine's silhouette was just visible within the shadows. Inside the darkened outline of her form, Regis's violet glow was like a beacon.

I placed a foot on the bottommost of the ethereal stairs leading up to the portal Windsom had manifested. "Did you try to talk him out of it?" I asked, stopping.

Windsom frowned and ran his fingers through his hair. "I'm not sure what you mean."

"Elenoir," I said, turning back to him, staring into those galaxy-colored eyes. "As envoy to this world, did you try to talk Lord Indrath out of the attack on Elenoir?"

"No," Windsom said, relaxing. "I volunteered to go along and ensure General Aldir was able to complete the mission."

"I see," I said with a nod.

Unhurried, I climbed the rest of the stairs until I was standing just in front of the portal. Windsom's crimes would be punished eventually, I told myself. But at that moment, my mind was on much more important beings than him.

Drawing in a deep breath and mentally preparing myself for what was to come, I stepped through.

The palace, Etistin, all of Dicathen melted away into golden light.

Even before Epheotus resolved in my sight, I felt the distance yawning between Regis and me. The tether requiring physical proximity between us had been broken when I dragged Taci into the Relictombs, but there had been no time to consider the ramifications during that fight. At that moment after the battle, I had felt no change in whatever aetheric binding connected us. Now, in the instant where I was entirely within the golden beam of light, no longer in Dicathen but not yet in Epheotus, I felt my connection to him fade, leaving behind a biting kind of emptiness that would have felt like madness if I hadn't already understood its source.

Then the light faded, and I was welcomed by that familiar feeling of being in another world, just like the first time Windsom had brought me to Epheotus, and all thought of Regis was driven from my mind.

There were no twin mountain peaks, no shimmering bridge, no pink-petaled trees, no towering castle. Instead, I was standing on the carefully trimmed lawn of a simple cottage with a straw roof.

My heart skipped a beat.

Turning in a quick circle, I confirmed that the cottage was surrounded by towering trees with sprawling canopies of leaves that wove together, creating a small clearing where the familiar cottage stood out strangely.

Windsom appeared beside me, stepping through the golden light with his thin blond brows raised. He barely glanced at me before gesturing to the cottage door.

"Why are we here?" I asked, but he only repeated his gesture, more firmly this time.

I hadn't seen or spoken to Lady Myre, Kezess's wife, since I had trained here years ago. But I thought of her often, especially as my own understanding of aether increased and revealed the failure of the dragons' perspective.

I didn't allow my uncertainty to show in my movements or expression, however. When Windsom made it clear he wouldn't answer, I moved with outward poise to the door.

It opened with the lightest tug.

The bright, clean light of a magical lighting artifact spilled out.

The interior was exactly as I remembered it, nothing moved, nothing out of place. Well, almost nothing.

In the center of the room, lounging in a wicker chair, was Lord Kezess Indrath. He wore simple white robes that caught the light like liquid pearls, and jagged blood-red hoops through his ears.

I quickly scanned the rest of the visible cottage, but he appeared to be the only one present.

I stepped inside. The door closed behind me, seemingly of its own accord.

Kezess's eyes—lavender at first, but shifting to a darker, richer shade of purple as I entered—followed my every movement, their hardness and intensity at odds with his otherwise placid expression and body language. The smooth lines of his youthful face and relaxed angle of his thin limbs were likewise out of alignment with the air of unassailable power radiating from him. Not his intent—King's Force, Kordri had called it—because I still couldn't sense his mana or aura, but there was nonetheless a constant and inexorable force around him, like gravity or the heat of the sun.

Kezess shifted in his seat, and his midlength silver hair waved slightly. The silence between us lingered.

I understood the game well enough. No doubt Windsom would have stood at attention for hours waiting for Kezess to acknowledge him should the lord of the asuras deem it so. But I didn't accept him as my sovereign, and I hadn't accepted his invitation to simply stand in his presence.

"How long have you been following my progress?" I asked.

The corner of his lips twitched and his eyes darkened further. "Arthur Leywin. I should welcome you back to Epheotus. Now, as before, you are brought before me just as war stirs in your world."

"Stirs?" I asked, shifting my weight from one leg to the other. I was very aware of the physicality between us, with Kezess still sitting, almost motionless, and me standing before him. "You know all too well the state of the war between Dicathen and Alacrya."

"That conflict is no longer important," he said with the tone of one

discussing an expected change in the weather. “I told you before that I saw you as a necessary component in that conflict, but you failed to heed my advice, which led to your inevitable failure. Now it is time to determine if there is a place for you in the upcoming war between the Vritra clan and all of Epheotus.”

Something he said stuck out to me, and I couldn’t bring myself to move past it, despite other aspects of our conversation being more important. “Your advice I failed to heed…you’re talking about Tessia.”

His brows rose a fraction of an inch, and his eyes flashed magenta. “Through you and the other reincarnate, Nico, Agrona groomed the perfect vessel for the entity known as the Legacy. And through her, you have given him knowledge and power enough to be a threat to Epheotus, and in doing so all but assured the destruction of the world you’ve come to love and everyone in it. You think yourself wise because you have lived two short lives, and so you refuse to listen to well-meaning advice, forgetting that those giving it lived for centuries before King Grey was born and will live centuries after Arthur Leywin’s bones have turned to dust.”

I suppressed a scoff. “I don’t think you know half as much as you pretend to. If you’d understood any of this before Cecilia’s reincarnation, you would have had Windsom kill Tessia or Nico or even me.” I crossed my arms and took a step closer to him. “How has Agrona gotten so far ahead of you?”

Without the appearance of moving, Kezess was suddenly standing. His eyes were the color of angry violet lightning, but his expression remained placid except for the tightening of his jaw. “You aren’t making a good showing of yourself right now. Before, you had your bond with my granddaughter to shield you. As you have, in your many failures, allowed her to die in battle, you can no longer claim such protection. If you do not prove to me that you yet have a part to play in the war, I *will* destroy you.”

I’d been expecting this, both the threat and his mention of Sylvie. I couldn’t guess how much Kezess knew about what had happened to Sylvie, but there was a way to find out for certain. Empowering the spellform on my forearm, I reached for the iridescent stone egg I’d recovered from the Relictombs after waking.

The stone appeared in my hand, wreathed momentarily in aetheric particles. “Sylvie didn’t die.”

Kezess reached for the egg but stopped short, his outstretched fingers lingering just inches away. “So. It is true then.”

I waited, hoping Kezess might give something away. Asking any questions about the egg or what Sylvie had done would reveal my own points of ignorance, and I didn’t want to give the ancient dragon any more leverage over me.

But he was just as careful, and, after searching my eyes briefly, he let his hand fall and shifted back subtly. “I trust you will continue to work to revive her.” A statement, not a question.

“Of course. She is my bond.”

Aether reached out to grab hold of the egg and withdrew it into the extradimensional storage space.

Although Kezess hadn’t given much away, his response told me two very important pieces of information. First, he knew what was happening with Sylvie. I still didn’t understand how she had transformed into this egg or been transported into the Relictombs with me. Obviously Kezess knew what the egg-stone was.

Second, he couldn’t revive her himself. If he could, I felt certain he would have tried to take the egg from me. This most likely meant that only I could complete the process of imbuing the egg with aether.

Kezess turned and, unhurried, made his way across the cottage to where several herbs and plants were hanging from the wall, drying. “Lady Myre will be sad to have missed you,” he said conversationally, pinching something that smelled like mint between his fingers. “Although, I can’t help but wonder if her attachment to you was due more to the presence of our daughter’s will within your core than any innate characteristics of your own.”

He turned, and his eyes had softened to lavender again. “It was an impressive feat that you reached the third phase of connecting with Sylvia’s will. Too bad it killed you, or would have without Sylvie’s intervention. And yet, even though you lost her will, you have retained the ability to influence aether—even grown more proficient in it.” His eyes burrowed deep into mine, and the sensation of maggots crawling into my skull made my stomach turn. “You will tell me everything, Arthur.”

Aside from a minute twitch in my right eye, I kept my discomfort off my

face. “What are you going to do for me in return?”

The bright lights of the cottage dimmed as Kezess’s nostrils flared. “As I have already stated, you will be allowed to live if you convince me of your use.”

I chuckled. Without answering, I moved to a wooden rocking chair and took a seat, kicking one leg up to rest over the other. “You want to bargain for my knowledge. I understand. After all, you have sought this insight for centuries, even committed genocide only to fail to acquire what I learned in a year.”

His eyes narrowed. “If you know what happened to the djinn, then certainly you see that I won’t hesitate to sacrifice one lesser life for the greater good.”

I stared at the dragon, deadpan, rocking slightly back and forth in Myre’s chair. “Greed and greater good may share a few letters, but you’ll rarely find them sharing company.”

“Show me,” Kezess ordered, ignoring my jibe. “I can sense the aether around you, burning inside you, but I wish to see you use it. Prove to me this isn’t more than some parlor trick.”

I bit my tongue to keep from speaking more barbed words. I wasn’t afraid of Kezess, but I hadn’t come here just to provoke him, either. He had a purpose in summoning me, and I had a purpose in accepting.

I considered the runes at my disposal and what would cost me the least to reveal, but there was an obvious choice.

Sending aether into the godrune, I activated Realmheart. The heat of the magic brought a flush to my cheeks as it infused every cell of my body, and the air was filled with color, the godrune making visible the individual motes of mana that infused everything around us. Immediately visible as well were the borders between aether and mana, as the atmosphere here was rich with both. They seemed so obvious now that I had learned how to look properly.

I wondered if Kezess could see them.

Kezess made a short, sharp cutting motion with one hand, and aether flared outward from him, rippling through the atmosphere, causing the world itself to harden and go still. The mana particles drifting in the air were

motionless, and a string of herbs, which had been slowly rotating in the subtle air currents, froze. Then the ripple rolled over me, and I *felt* time stopping.

My mind flashed back to a time before the Relictombs, before my draconic form, before Sylvie's sacrifice.

I remembered sitting with Elder Rinia. I'd been suspicious about the nature of her powers, and so activated Static Void without warning. She'd used aether to counter me, freeing herself from the time-stop spell.

Reacting on pure instinct, I pushed against the ripple with a burst of my own aether. It clung to my skin like a thin film, repelling Kezess's spell.

His eyes went wide, showing real surprise and even, I thought, uncertainty for the first time.

Everything else in the cottage was frozen, motionless. But my chair kept rocking slightly, and I felt one brow quirk up as my lips curled into a wry, humorless smile. "I think you'll find my understanding of aether sufficiently worth your time."

Kezess glanced around, frowning slightly. He bent down to inspect something, and I realized there was some kind of spider clinging to the leg of Myre's table. Kezess pulled the spider from its perch, examining it closely. His fingers closed, and the spider's insides stained his fingertips. He tossed the tiny corpse to the floor, then returned his attention to me.

"You have come by this knowledge within the series of dungeons known as the Relictombs," Kezess said, an echoing dissonance resonant within his voice. "But Agrona has been sending mages into the djinn's final redoubt for many years." His eyes narrowed as he peered at me, time still stopped. "What made you different? How did you conquer where all others had failed?"

Experimentally, I pushed back against the time stop spell. The aether around me flexed, but I wasn't able to expand the barrier beyond myself and the chair on which I sat. "I'm willing to give you information. But only if we can come to some kind of agreement."

Kezess twisted his wrist, and the spell faded away.

I breathed easier, only then realizing what a drain it had been to hold off the aevum ability.

Before continuing, Kezess returned to his own simple wicker chair, lounging into it in a way that made it seem like a throne. He watched me for a while after that, considering. Then, slowly, as if tasting the words as he spoke them, he said, “The retaking of Dicathen has been a surprise, both for me and Agrona Vritra, but it can’t last.”

I nodded. “I’m aware that Agrona’s attention has been turned to his own lands. Once he’s resolved the rebellion there, his eye—and his forces—will return to Dicathen. He may not have a complete understanding of my capabilities, but he knows I took down a squad of his Wraiths. Next time, he’ll send a force he knows will win.”

“Indeed. Your time is running short.”

I dropped my relaxed posture, leaning forward and resting my elbows on my knees. “You want knowledge. Dicathen needs time. You spoke of a war between the asura, but I’ve always been told such a war would destroy my world.” I paused, letting my words hang in the air, then said, “I won’t let that happen, Kezess. That’s my price.”

Kezess was suddenly standing, again without my perceiving any physical movement. At the same time, the cottage melted away, dissolving like a cobweb caught in a rainstorm. The woodsy brown tones gave way to shades of gray, which materialized into the hard lines of stone and soft curves of clouds, and we were standing atop the Indrath clan’s castle in the very highest tower.

The clouds were thick, rising halfway up the castle to hide the mountain peaks and the many-colored bridge below. Eddies of white, gray, and gold clouds swirled in between the towers and around the statues and stonework. Pink petals occasionally appeared tumbling through the mist, plucked from the hidden trees below and carried high into the sky by the updraft.

But the part I found most amazing was that I had only sensed the barest application of aether from Kezess, and unlike his time-stop spell, I hadn’t been able to react or deflect the teleportation, if that’s even what had happened. My mind raced to consider the implications of this and where the power stemmed from. If the situation ever devolved into violence between us, I couldn’t allow him to simply shunt me around Epheotus at will.

Kezess placed his hands on the sill of an open window and stared out at his

domain. The room around us was plain and empty, but there was a circular groove worn in the purple-tinged gray tiles that made up the floor. *Like someone has paced endlessly around in a loop for hundreds of years.*

"You will explain the powers you have gained," Indrath said, still not looking at me. "And you will tell me in detail how you have managed this insight, and how you created a core that can directly manipulate aether. In exchange, I will guarantee that no conflict between asuras spills into Dicathen, and I will assist you in preventing Agrona from retaking the continent."

I swallowed my surprise. I hadn't expected him to make such a fair offer so quickly but was glad to avoid an extended back and forth, threatening and bargaining in turns. Still, I knew the lengths to which Kezess would go just to understand my power. "The people of Alacrya shouldn't be harmed either," I said firmly, adopting the mannerisms of a dictator making a proclamation, something I had done often enough as King Grey. "What happened in Elenoir can never happen again, on either continent."

Kezess finally turned to look at me, his gaze piercing me like a lance. "It is interesting that you mention Elenoir, because there is a second part to my offer, but we will get to that in due time. I won't use the World Eater technique in Alacrya, but preventing large-scale losses there will reduce my ability to assure safety for Dicathen."

"That's fine," I said, giving him a nonchalant shrug. "I won't trade millions of lives to protect thousands. Until Agrona is ready to move the war into Epheotus, he won't sacrifice his foothold in our world. So the onus is on you not to escalate the conflict."

Kezess nodded. "This is true. But can you deliver on my request?"

"We both know insight can't be directly transmitted from one person to another," I said, thinking about everything the djinn projections had told me. "I will explain my powers and how I received them, as well as my own process for gaining insight into the individual godrunes. What you do with the information is entirely up to you."

His eyes darkened as he considered. "You offer me mist and maybes but expect concrete results in return."

"You knew what you were asking me," I said, leaning back against the wall. "You tortured and exterminated an entire race chasing their insight,

but you didn't learn a damned thing, did you?"

"That is the second time you have mentioned this," he said, his voice taking on a low rumble as a storm cloud darkened his face. "Take care, Arthur, that you do not overstep. The events of that age are not a subject for polite company, and mention of that ancient and dead race is forbidden here."

I weighed my response, torn between pushing him further and letting it go. Indrath's atrocities against the djinn were unforgivable, but there was no point interrupting the current tenuous alliance we seemed to be forming over it. Not right now.

"You said there was a second part to this agreement," I said at length. "So let's hear it."

Indrath crossed the empty chamber to a different window. The view from the window shifted as he approached, one moment showing a distant mountain peak just barely piercing the clouds like an island in the sea, and the next endless rolling fields of tall grass in colors ranging from deep blue to turquoise. A narrow road ran winding through the grass. The ground was shattered and covered in blood and corpses.

"In addition to sheltering Dicathen—and Alacrya—from the coming war," Indrath said, his tone wary, the words drawn out tiredly in a way I hadn't heard from him before, "I offer you justice, if you will give me the same in exchange."

I don't think you would enjoy the kind of justice I'd offer you, I thought. Still, I was curious about what had happened and what he meant. "Go on."

"I ordered Aldir to use the World Eater technique. You and I both know he was a soldier doing his duty." Kezess turned to face me. His eyes shifted through several shades of purple, settling as a cool mauve. "But to the people of your world, it was *his* power that unleashed such devastation. Aldir is the wraith in the darkness they now fear. And so I offer you his life to placate the masses. Punish him for his crime and heal the wound the World Eater left in the hearts of your people."

For the first time since opening Myre's cottage door and finding Kezess waiting for me, I felt wrong-footed, entirely caught off guard by this unexpected proposition. "What justice do you want in return?" I asked slowly, buying myself a moment to think.

Kezess looked back at the blood-smeared grasslands. “Your justice is my justice. I asked too much of my soldier. The World Eater technique was not forbidden for its destructive capabilities, but because of the damage it did to the caster. It degrades the mind and corrupts the spirit of the pantheon who uses it.

“These red smears were once brave dragons, soldiers who fought beside Aldir, trained under him.” Kezess placed a hand on either side of the window, staring hard down at the alien landscape. “He abandoned his post, and when they reached out to him, sought to help him, he butchered them.”

I let out a barking laugh.

Kezess sobered immediately, the emotion he’d exhibited vanishing as his normally placid expression returned. “You walk a dangerous line, boy.”

“So your idea of giving us justice is to have us clean up the mess you yourself made?” I asked incredulously. “I know you don’t think much of us *lessers* but come on.”

Kezess eyed me for a long moment, then turned back to the window and waved away the view of the grasslands. The slowly rolling sea of clouds reappeared. “Then let this be a warning to you instead. Aldir has left Epheotus for Dicathen, and he is dangerous. If you give him shelter or attempt to ally with him, the rest of our bargain will be void.”

He’s serious, I realized. *Aldir must have really tweaked the old dragon’s tail to get him this mad.*

“Noted,” I said in answer. “And agreed. If you keep your war with the Vritra clan from escalating in our world, and you help me keep Agrona from overrunning Dicathen again, I’ll tell you everything I’ve discovered about aether.”

Kezess reached out a hand. I hesitated, knowing better than to trust him but unsure what kind of insult it would be to refuse. He waited.

After a moment, I took the offered hand. Tendrils of purple light appeared around our conjoined limbs, extending outward along our wrists and forearms. The aether gripped tightly, binding us together almost painfully.

“An agreement has been made, and you are bound to it,” Kezess said solemnly. “Break it, and this spell will devour your core.”

As he spoke, the coils of aether began worming their way into my flesh, digging through my muscles and into my nerves. It was painful, but not unbearably so. In seconds, the aether had reached my core, wrapping around it like chains, exerting a physical pressure on the organ.

“I didn’t agree to that—”

“We begin immediately,” Kezess said laconically, a sliver of a smile marring his otherwise expressionless mask. “You walk the Path of Insight.” My perspective of the room lurched, and I found myself standing on the worn stone path. “Walk, and activate your godrunes, as you called them.”

I stared at him, equal parts angry and uncertain. I hadn’t expected to begin immediately, and I chastised myself for being caught off guard by the binding. Of course he wouldn’t just trust me to tell him everything he knew. There had to be a safeguard.

Damn it, I thought, then immediately redirected my mental energy in a more positive direction.

“You’re wasting time,” Kezess said. “Walk and cast.”

I started moving, following the path of worn-down stone. Light immediately began to flicker and flash throughout the circle. I reached again for Realmheart. The circle burst to life with light and energy, forming a series of runes connected by dozens of bright lines. Mana particles of every color ran rich and eager around the circle, herded on by amethyst motes of aether. But I was only half looking at the sudden swell of mana moving through the runes.

Inside me, I could sense the foreign aether clinging tightly to my core. It reacted to my each and every thought, tightening if I even considered the possibility of lying or limiting what I showed Kezess. I knew if I hid anything, it would react violently and attempt to force my hand. And then kill me if I still refused.

It just wouldn’t do.

I wasn’t ready to reveal more about Realmheart than its presence. There was no reason for Kezess to know that I could move mana with aether. And so I let the godrune fade, then channeled aether instead into Aroa’s Requiem.

I felt Kezess's hungry gaze on me with every step, just as I felt the cord of aether constricting around my core. Violet particles danced along my fingertips with nowhere to go, but that didn't matter. The Path of Insight reacted, flickering and flaring, both mana and aether following my progress like one giant eyeball.

But inside my body, something else was happening. As I imbued the godrune, I also let aether leak from my core. But I kept it close, a halo of my own aether orbiting my core and Kezess's binding spell.

If I was going to make a deal with the lord of the dragons, it was going to be on my own terms, not his.

Carefully shaping my aether, I drew it close around the invasive chains, and my aether clung as tightly to Kezess's as it did to my own skin when I created a protective barrier. Then I pulled.

The spell resisted, the aether eager to hold its shape, to keep to its purpose.

I kept walking. A golden glow flickered across the room as the Aroa's Requiem godrune burned at my back, bright enough to show through my shirt. The Path shined just as brightly in response.

Like a bird dragging a worm from its hole, my aether pulled Kezess's slowly into my core.

This was the risky part. I'd never directly faced off against another aether-wielder before. But I'd also never encountered a source of aether I couldn't draw from.

Within my core, I felt the aether being purified, Kezess's influence overridden. Bit by bit, *his* aether became *mine*. Then, to help camouflage the change in case he could somehow sense it, I reformed the "chains" around my core with my own aether, no longer beholden to the shape of his spell.

With that complete, I felt confident enough to stop walking and step off the Path.

Kezess, who had been entranced by the Path of Insight itself, blinked back to awareness. "Why are you stopping? Surely that isn't everything you've discovered."

"It's not," I said with a light shake of my head. "You'll get more once I've

seen some progress on your end of the bargain.

“That’s not what I agreed to,” he said, an undercurrent of hostility barely detectable in his tone.

“It seems we both should have been more careful in our wording,” I replied. “I suspect you have enough to occupy your mind for a while already, anyway. And you still have your leash in place. Once I’m comfortable in the knowledge that Dicathen is safe without me, I’ll return to give you more.”

He looked at me. I looked back. He gave no outward physical sign of agitation, but I could still sense it rolling off him in waves. After a minute or more, he finally gave in. “Return to your world, but be waiting for my summons. We are not yet finished, you and I.”

“No,” I said with a smile. “No, we certainly aren’t.”

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TELL HIM

CAERA DENOIR

“Report,” Seris said, her tone commanding.

My mentor had been more serious and straightforward than usual since her brief conversation with Scythe Nico and his strange companion, the woman who wore the body of a Dicathian elf—the Legacy.

“The bombardment in Rosaere has started,” Cylrit answered with snappish military precision. “We estimate twenty thousand troops currently, although forces are still being rallied. The shield is holding.”

“And the Legacy?”

Cylrit’s handsome features darkened at the name. “She has so far seen fit to command from the rear.”

A frown, hardly perceptible, creased Seris’s brow. “Anything else?”

“A fleet of twenty steamships left Dzianis this morning, heading south,” Cylrit answered immediately, glancing out the open window toward the glittering ocean in the distance. “We expect them to make for the Vritra’s Maw and Aedelgard.”

Seris’s piercing gaze shifted to me. “Do we know if the Redwaters were able to complete the plan you suggested?”

I tapped one of the many two-way communication scrolls that littered the large table at the center of Seris’s war room. “Wolfrum sent word late last night that friendly sailors had been successfully relocated to Dzianis to help fill out the steam ship crews.”

“Good,” Seris said with a nod. “Have we received any additional confirmations?”

I glanced at Cylrit, who responded with a slight shake of his head. “No.”

“I see,” she said softly, clicking her nails together. Realizing it, she stopped and straightened. “Then I shall leave for Rosaere at once. Cylrit, you are to stay here and ensure the shield battery remains operational. Caera, relocate our strategic operations to the city of Sandaerene. You will be safer there.”

I bit my lip but didn’t speak the thoughts that came to my mind.

Seris’s brows rose a fraction of an inch.

“Forgive me,” I started, still grasping for the appropriate phrasing, “but I have no interest in remaining *safe*. I am not—”

“Expendable,” Seris said unexpectedly. My mouth snapped shut in surprise. “No one knows your strength better than I, Caera. But I *have* soldiers. What I lack is an abundance of Vritra-born highblood foster children with in-depth knowledge of both the intricacies of noble politics and the Relictombs.”

She paused, giving me an opportunity to speak, but I had no response. “This is not a contest of power and strategy between two sides, where strength of magic and arms will win the day. This is a revolution. This is about reshaping the world so that it works for the people who *live in it*, instead of the deities who simply use it. And even if it isn’t the role you would have chosen for yourself, your part in all this is to guide your peers toward understanding.”

My head fell, my unfocused gaze on the ground at Seris’s feet. She quickly closed the distance between us, her hand gently but firmly lifting my chin. As she had so many times before, she seemed to peel me apart with her eyes, laying bare my frustration and fear.

“Even I can’t foresee everything that will come to pass,” she said, more gently. “But I know for certain that any plans I make require you to succeed. Without good people to care for the world we seek to build, what would be the point?”

Her grip tightened on my chin, and she forced me to look her directly in the eye. “Now, you’ve wheedled enough compliments out of me for one

day, and you'll get no more. Make the arrangements with my contacts in Sandaerene. And reach out if you must, otherwise continue stirring the pot outside of Sehz-Clar."

She glanced at Cylrit, who gave her a shallow bow.

Then she was marching out of the room, off to lead the primary defense at Rosaere.

I glanced around the war room, where I had spent many, many hours since coming to Sehz-Clar. It was a sprawling, undecorated space on the west end of Seris's compound, dominated by a long oval table, with smaller desks pressed haphazardly to the walls around us. Open arches led out to a wide balcony that overlooked the western half of Aedelgard and gave a grand view of the Vritra's Maw Sea and the ocean beyond it.

"Lady Caera, please let me know if you need any assistance," Cylrit said with a bob of his horned head, then he started out of the room in Seris's wake.

Just before he passed under the arched opening deeper into the compound, I said, "Do you think she's all right?"

He stopped and turned to consider me. It took a moment for him to come to an answer. "She doesn't think about things like her own health and well-being. For her, it's all about the plan."

I couldn't help but smile at the chagrined reverence in his tone. "Is that why she has you, then? To think about her health and well-being?"

No flicker of emotion broke the stoic expression Cylrit always wore. "Perhaps." He started to turn away, then stopped. "We've set up several recording artifacts around Rosaere. If your mind won't settle, perhaps being able to see what is happening will ease your thoughts." Then, like Seris, he was gone.

I wondered how he stayed so calm and collected all the time. Despite looking relatively youthful, Cylrit had been Seris's retainer for many years. Together they had led Sehz-Clar's forces against the Vechorian invasion, back before I had even been born. Most of the time he seemed just as poised and confident as Seris. Sometimes when I struggled to see a positive outcome, it was Cylrit I attempted to emulate. As my mentor and a Scythe, Seris had always felt like something *other*, beyond reckoning. In contrast, Cylrit's story was very similar to my own, which somehow made

modeling myself after him feel more attainable.

But nothing at all will be accomplished by standing here thinking, I told myself. Straightening my stance and pulling my shoulders back, I began rifling through the many maps, missives, and communiqués, sorting them into hasty piles to be relocated.

I stopped suddenly, irritated with myself for forgetting that I had an entire staff of attendants to aid me with this sort of thing.

As if summoned by the thought, a young woman named Haella of Highblood Tremblay—a cousin of Maylis's—poked her head in the door. "Oh, forgive me Lady Caera, I saw Commander Seris and retainer Cylrit leaving and—"

"No need to apologize," I said with a wave of my hand. "Call everyone in, actually. We're relocating."

After a quick meeting with the rest of our small clerical entourage—all trustworthy individuals who agreed with our cause and had talents or runes that helped with the distribution of the many missives we sent out—I retired to my private quarters and began to collect my things.

I chafed at the idea of hiding in Sandaerene, a city near the center of the western half of Sehz-Clar, as far as possible from any potential fighting. But I knew Seris was correct in her assessment. And, while I would have liked to stay in Aedelgard and help watch over the shield battery array and the Sovereign at its heart, Cylrit was more capable than I.

To help still my mind and stop second-guessing my commander, I did as Cylrit suggested. Set into one wall of my sitting room was a projection crystal I often used to keep apprised of Agrona's messaging to the people of Alacrya. With a pulse of mana, I activated the crystal, then set about attuning it for the mana signature of our recording artifacts.

It didn't take me long to locate the artifacts Cylrit had mentioned.

The image showed the towering curve of the shield splitting the city of Rosaere in twain. The device seemed to be located around the city's central boulevard, facing outward.

The image it captured made my pulse quicken.

On the other side of the shield, several hundred battle groups were lined up and hurtling thousands of spells. Bolts and bullets of every element, green beams, black rays, and bright missiles crashed into the shield, many dozens per second.

The artifact wasn't portraying the sound of the battle, but I could imagine the cacophonous crashing of the spells, a noise to shake the bedrock foundations of the continent.

But so far as I could tell, the shield barrier was holding without strain.

I adjusted the attunement again and found myself looking at nearly the same image, but from farther and at a higher angle. This vantage point allowed me to see the depth of the enemies—I frowned, realizing I had taken to calling these Alacryan soldiers the enemy without even noticing—and the war camp in the distance, beyond the eastern borders of the city.

Changing the attunement for the second time revealed a sweeping, rushing image of the city from a bird's eye view, and my frown curved up into a smile. I found the simple birdlike automatons, one of which I knew was carrying this recording artifact, endlessly charming. They were a relatively new invention according to Seris, having been piloted in the war against Dicathen but never put into full-scale use due to the difficulty of crafting such things.

I watched for some time, forgetting what I was supposed to be doing. Seris had gathered just over five thousand soldiers in Rosaere as a failsafe should the shields be breached, and from the high, circling vantage I could see them in their defensive positions throughout the western half of the city.

I tried not to think about how much I would have preferred to be with them, closer to where the action was.

A noise like thunder reverberating inside a bell jar ripped through the air, so loud it shook the floor beneath me and made the projected image jump and blur.

I reached out and grabbed a nearby tabletop to steady myself. The noise came again, and the compound shook even harder. For a moment, I worried it might slide off the cliff and into the sea.

Screams came from a dozen different directions all throughout Seris's home.

My mind whirled, struggling to think through the reverberations left by the tremendous noise, then it was sounding again, sending a vibration through my teeth and eyes and into my brain, filling it with a dulling fog.

What in the abyss is—

It hit me all at once.

The shields.

The shields were under attack.

Moving at a dead sprint, I slammed through the door to my chambers and along the hall, hurtling up the stairs three at a time and then peeling through one of the upper dining chambers and out onto a balcony.

Beyond the shield, which came up from the base of the cliffs far below to curve gently overhead, two figures flew high above the tumultuous waters of the Vritra's Maw Sea.

The blood rushed from my face, and I had to clench my fists to keep my hands from shaking.

I knew these figures.

The pieces came together quickly. The Legacy must have ordered the bombardment of Rosaere to lure out Seris, then took a tempus warp northwest into Vechor before flying south over the sea. Whether she knew this compound was the source of all the energy currently powering the dominion-sized shield or was targeting this location only because it was Seris's home and base of operations, I couldn't guess.

I stood immobile as she reared back again, gathering a swelling force of mana to her, and hurled her hands outward. The thunder sounded yet again, a noise so great and terrible that it drove me to my knees with my hands clapped over my ears.

Through the railing of the balcony, I watched as jagged lines of white-hot light spread across the surface of the shield like cracks over thin ice.

Strong hands grabbed me beneath the arms and heaved me to my feet. Dazed, I struggle to focus on the face swimming just before me.

“Caera, listen carefully.” A familiar voice from that blurry face—Cylrit? “Evacuate as many as you can, then send word to Commander Seris. Go yourself if you can, but leave now—”

The thunder crashed again. I shook my head, blinking rapidly. Cylrit’s face finally came into focus, even more pale than usual. His jaw tightened and he flinched away from the noise, making me feel better—but also simultaneously worse. It was so much more frightening knowing that he was also afraid.

As the echoing vibrations receded, I risked a glance at the shield and was horrified to see how far the cracks had spread.

“Caera!” Cylrit said urgently, his hands gripping the sides of my neck with tender firmness. “I will stay and fight, but—”

“Cylrit…” His name was barely a whisper on my lips. He followed the direction of my wide-eyed gaze, and together we watched as the Legacy flew toward the shield.

Both her hands reached out and pushed *into* the cracks, taking hold and *pulling*.

Like glass shattering, except a thousand times more cutting, the shield began to give way.

Cylrit launched himself toward the breach with such force that the balcony cracked. I threw myself back into the compound just as the supporting timbers shattered, and the balcony separated from the building with a sound like breaking bones.

By the time I had my feet under me, Cylrit had reached the barrier, a pure black greatsword as long as he was tall clenched in his fists.

All I could do was watch as the Legacy’s fingers clawed through the transparent barrier, ripping a hole the size of an outstretched hand. The shield crackled with desperate energy around her fingertips, surging against her power and control as it attempted to reseal itself.

Silently, Cylrit thrust his void wind blade into the gap, aimed right at the Legacy’s core.

“Cecil!” Scythe Nico shouted in alarm, his voice barely audible over the pounding in my ears.

Suddenly Cylrit jerked violently, attempting to pull away from the breach. He was struggling, but from my vantage, all I could see was his cloaked back. Belatedly, I ripped my own blade free of its sheath, but any attack I made would do more damage to my ally than the Scythe and Legacy still on the opposite side of the shield.

The barrier bulged inward like a distorted bubble until Cylrit was outside of it. It was then I realized his hands were empty; his sword had vanished, and the Legacy was gripping him by the front of his armor. The cracked section of shield snapped back into place as she ripped him through it, then shattered with a prolonged crashing like trees being felled in a hurricane wind.

Despite Cylrit urging me to flee, I knew I couldn't. The shield had been breached. The hole wasn't large, perhaps eight feet tall and five wide, but it was more than enough for a person to come through, and I was the strongest warrior present aside from Cylrit himself. If I ran, many more might die.

As I stood, considering, Scythe Nico flew through the shield.

I cursed, and his gaze fell on me. Beyond him, the Legacy held Cylrit up with one hand. There was a surging conflict of invisible mana between the two. It was less a battle of spells than a contest of pure control over mana. Unfortunately, I'd seen enough at the Victoriad to understand who would win.

But there was no more time to watch. Scythe Nico was already moving toward me, flying on a shimmering cloud of air.

Leaping back, I slashed with my sword, sending a crescent of black flames clawing toward him, but he dipped below it, narrowly avoiding the soulfire.

I stumbled as I completed the arc of my cut. The floor had liquified beneath my feet, just for the blink of an eye, then turned solid again, and my feet were half stuck. In the moment it took me to wrench myself free of the stone, the Scythe had landed within the open arch in front of the shattered balcony.

A blood iron spike thrust up from the floor, just where my foot had been. I pirouetted away, bringing my blade up to deflect a second spike that thrust down from the ceiling. I was already breathing hard, too hard—*much* too

hard—when I realized each breath brought me only the barest lungful of oxygen.

When I spun around to put my blade between me and the Scythe, the emerald on the end of his staff was glowing with radiant light.

He's doing something to draw the air out of the room.

My blade burst to life with soulfire flames, and I thrust it into the ruined floor.

The stones shattered as the soulfire ate the floor out from under me, and I fell through to land atop a circular table. The legs snapped like kindling, and I leapt off its collapsing surface, twirling through the air to land on my feet several feet away. Gratefully, I sucked in a lungful of good air.

The room was dark, but I didn't have time to take stock of my surroundings.

The floor beneath me burst upward, a solid column of stone hurtling toward the ceiling above. At the same time, several jet-black metal spikes grew from the ceiling like so many stalactites.

Planting one foot on the edge of the column, I launched myself away, tucking into a roll and wreathing myself in a halo of soulfire as I went. Behind me, the column exploded, sending knives of solid stone pelting through the room, shredding everything inside.

The soulfire saved me, burning away all but one of the stone daggers, which slashed across my side, leaving behind a line of white-hot pain. As I rolled back to my feet, I quickly checked the wound; it was shallow, not dangerous.

Scythe Nico appeared above, floating down through the hole I'd carved in the floor. I brought my blade up, ready to defend against his next attack.

"Lady Caera of Highblood Denoir." His voice was as quiet and cold as a tomb. "I've enjoyed reading your many missives. Seris has really kept you busy, hasn't she?"

"If you've come to arrest me, I refuse," I shot back, more to buy myself time than anything else.

There was a closed door to my back and an open arch to my right. I needed to move, to keep him occupied and hope that some of the other servants or

guards managed to reach Seris. I had to be considerate about how and where I fought, though. The machines far beneath us were well protected by wards and thick walls of metal and stone, but a battle here would still be dangerous.

And that's not even taking into account the fact that I'm facing off with a Scythe, I thought.

Still, unlike the other Scythes, I could sense his mana signature and its potency. It was being distorted somehow—my eye was again drawn to the strange staff in his hand—but the signature was there, and it wasn't as strong as I might have suspected.

"You still aren't recovered from your battle against Grey, are you?" I prodded. Although I wasn't ready to place bets on whether or not I could defeat even a weakened Scythe, the fact that he had started talking worked in my favor. The longer I kept him occupied, the more of our people could escape the compound.

His pale skin flushed, and his dark eyes narrowed into a scowl. "If you take me to Orlaeth or the source of power for the shield around this dominion, Cecilia—the Legacy—has agreed to spare your life. Refuse or stall for time, and I will immediately send word to our soldiers in Cargidan to begin exterminating your blood."

As his face flushed, I felt the color drain from my own. I bore little love for my adopted blood, but that didn't mean I wanted them all butchered. "Why bargain from a place of strength? Obviously the Legacy expects your surprise incursion to be countered. Perhaps she is not as strong as—"

The staff whirled in Scythe Nico's hand, and the entire wall to my left was ripped free and came crashing inward. Channeling mana into one of my runes, I conjured a burst of wind that threw me sideways through the open archway to my right. The walls collided as I slid to a stop. The sound of collapsing stone and furniture swallowed everything else as the floor of the room I'd just escaped collapsed inward.

I found myself in a small chamber occupied by nothing but a few tiered benches and a beautiful harp that dominated the center of the room. Moving with a speed born of desperation and wind-attribute mana, I conjured a fistful of soulfire and blasted through the outer wall of the compound, then dove through the opening as the walls behind me began to unfold. Bullets of liquid fire hissed passed me as I arched out into the open

air.

All motion—the whole world—seemed to slow down as I fell.

I had rotated so that I could see where the hole in the barrier was. Beyond it, the Legacy was turning, her turquoise eyes snapping to the motion of my fall. Thirty or so feet below her, Cylrit was tumbling end over end, freefalling toward the rocky base of the cliffs.

I locked eyes with the Legacy.

The world lurched into motion again. I pulled in my body to turn in the air and grabbed a broken support from the balcony above, spun around it, and launched myself toward a lower balcony cut into the side of the rock.

I collided with something, an invisible wall keeping me from the balcony. At the speed I was moving, my legs crumpled, and I bounced off the surface before falling straight down. Stretching until my shoulder popped, my fingers just brushed the top of the balcony rail but skated off them. I scrambled to grab onto the bars, failed, but then caught the bottommost ledge of the balcony itself, jerking to a halt, my fingernails scoring lines into the wooden boards.

Heaving, I pulled myself up and over the railing in one smooth motion. Behind me, something blotted out the light. I spun around.

The Legacy had reached the hole in the shield. It had shrunk down to the size of a window, but she was gripping the sides and pushing outward, forcing it back open.

But a dark cloud was growing in front of her and the hole, billowing up from nowhere, condensing and dragging in the mana all around it. It seemed to leech the color from everything in sight, turning the whole world shades of gray.

Awed, I watched as the mist rushed out through the gash, boiling over the Legacy. She shot backward, abandoning the shield as she defended herself from the spell. With each wave of her hand, parts of the cloud were wiped away as if they were nothing more than soot smeared on the sky, but I could sense the raging mana pushing, ripping, and pulling from both directions.

Then Scythe Nico drifted down in front of me, interrupting my view of the battle.

“You’re good at running,” he said, feigning a casual air. But I could feel him flinch every time the mana burst behind him, and every muscle in his face was taut as a pulled bowstring. “But I was hoping—”

Suddenly he twisted around, and several blood iron spikes appeared, weaving together to form a shield. In the same heartbeat, a pure black jet of energy struck the shield, ringing like a giant gong. The blood iron burst apart, and the Scythe was sent tumbling down out of my sight with a yelp.

A figure, little more than a liquid pearl-and-black streak, flashed past my vision and through the shrinking hole.

On the other side, I realized the black mist was gone. The Legacy was flying fifty feet from the shield. She appeared unhurt. The pretty elven face she wore glowered, and a horrible aura shivered out from her that made the mana itself tremble.

Seris hovered before the closing rift in the shield, glimmering like a gemstone in her black scaled armor. Although I could hardly fathom it, she maintained her usual businesslike nonchalance as she said, “It’s rather rude to show up at my home unannounced and uninvited, Cecilia.”

“Nico?” the Legacy shouted, her gaze flicking past Seris to the compound. “Nico, are you all right?”

Remembering the Scythe, I glanced down from the balcony, but there was no sign of him.

When there was no response, the Legacy’s expression hardened, and she drifted toward Seris. “This is over, Scythe. *I* control mana. *All* of it. And I can pull down your barrier. Submit and take me to Orlaeth. Now.”

“You’re winded,” Seris said, and although I couldn’t see her face, I could tell she was smiling. “You don’t have the strength left to fight me. Leave. Go back to Agrona and tell him you failed, that everything he’s sacrificed to bring you here was for naught. Tell him I’ll be waiting right here if he wishes to speak to me.”

A ripple passed through the space between them, and Seris’s mouth snapped shut. Her body leaned into whatever the Legacy was doing. Dark lines of void wind banded around her, flexing outward against the invisible force assailing her.

Then, starting with Seris and rapidly expanding outward, a sphere of pure

inky black obscured them both.

A ragged gasp slipped uncontrolled from my lips.

“She can’t win,” a voice said from behind me.

I spun, bringing up my blade and wreathing it in soulfire, but Scythe Nico held up his hands placatingly.

“I’m not going to attack you again,” he said sincerely.

I waited, watching closely for any sign of aggression. His mana was still, his movements cautious and steady. There was a spark of curiosity in his eyes—or was that victory I sensed emanating from him like an aura?

A sudden jolt of panic surged through me, and I glanced at the shields. They were still operational. Surely he couldn’t have breached the complex below in such a short time, and even if he had, the shields would already be showing the effect.

“Maybe not, but what is to stop me from attacking you?” I asked to fill the silence, unsure what he could want from me or why his attitude had suddenly changed.

“This,” he said, drawing an item from an inside pocket of his battle robes.

It was a rough-surfaced sphere larger than his hand, transparent except for a light purple shading. I’d seen cores before and felt certain this was one, but it was larger than any mana core I’d ever seen. There was something almost magnetic about it, as if it were calling out to me, pulling me to it.

“I don’t care about this rebellion,” the Scythe continued, pulling the core slightly closer to him as my gaze clung to it. “I don’t give a shit about Orlaeth or any other Vritra.” He focused past me, into the black sphere. “If you’ll do something for me, I’ll leave. I’ll even buy you time.”

I hesitated, then dragged my attention from the core up to Scythe Nico’s face. Everything I'd ever heard about him framed him as some kind of monster. A cold-blooded killer, careless as a sharpened blade, eager to cut anyone who Agrona targeted. But now, looking at him, his black hair clinging to his forehead, his dark eyes simultaneously furious and pleading, I could see he was hardly more than a boy.

“What?” I finally said.

“Take this core.” He held it back out to me. “Give it to Arthur Leywin—Grey—on the other continent. Tell him…” He paused, and a pained look crossed his face. “Tell him he has to save her. He owes her a life.”

I frowned, uncertain. “I don’t understand.”

He took a quick step forward, heedless of the blade pointing at his throat, and pressed the core toward me. My sword nicked the side of his neck, drawing a thin line of blood on his sickly pale skin.

“Take it, and tell him.”

Slowly, I took one hand off the hilt of my sword and accepted the core. It was cool to the touch. “What does this have to do with Grey?” *Arthur Leywin.* “Who is ‘her’? The Legacy?”

Nico had taken a step back. His jaw tightened, and his voice was strained when he next spoke. “I’m trusting you with the most important thing in this entire world.”

Before I could press him further or think to refuse and hurl the core into his face, he had slipped the staff from his back and cast a spell to wrap himself in wind, then flashed out of the compound and toward the black sphere, vanishing into its impenetrable depths.

I clutched the core and stared into the abyssal dark. Not only could I see nothing, I couldn’t *sense* anything either. It was as if Seris—*or the Legacy*, I thought with a chill—had carved out a piece of the world and left behind only an empty patch of nothing.

Just when I wondered how long anyone could keep up such a spell, the sphere exploded.

Darkness swallowed all light, and for a heart-stopping moment—a breath that felt like eternity—I was utterly blind.

Just as quickly, the black melted back into light and color. I sagged against the wall and stared up to where Seris and the Legacy had been.

Inside the shield, Seris hung in the air, one arm holding the other limply against her side. Opposite her, well outside of the transparent barrier, Nico was supporting the Legacy, who leaned against him, her steel-gray hair hanging down across half her face. One mad turquoise eye glared out. Unlike Seris, though, the Legacy bore no signs of physical injury. Between

them, the asura-powered shield was once again complete and unblemished, no sign of the rift the Legacy had torn.

Nico turned the Legacy away, and she let him. At the last moment, he glanced away from her, just for a single instant, and our eyes connected. Then the two were hurtling away at speed.

Seris watched until they had vanished from sight to the east before finally drifting toward me. She looked tired, a bone-deep fatigue I couldn't have imagined seeing in her even at the very end of her power, and my heart skipped a beat.

"Go down and check on the battery array," she rasped. "And have the technicians create an opening near the base of the cliffs." She winced as she looked down toward the water. "I need to go find my retainer."

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INTERRUPTIONS

ARTHUR LEYWIN

Golden light again enveloped me, and for the first time since arriving in Epheotus, I felt the tension leave my body. Even though I was returning to a war, the threats I faced here were simple in comparison to the yawning abyss of negative possibilities Kezess presented.

The golden light faded from my eyes, revealing the inner courtyard and surrounding walls of the Royal Palace of Etistin, exactly where I had left. As the conjured stairs were no longer there, I immediately plummeted toward the ground, landing with enough force to crack the paving stones and kick up a cloud of dust.

Shouts rang out from several different sources, and the silhouettes of armed and armored soldiers encircled me. The sea breeze carried the cloud away, and I watched as the hard eyes of the royal guards widened with surprise before they quickly scrambled to stow their weapons.

“General Arthur!” an energetic female voice sounded, conjuring a chorus of chanting from the soldiers.

I focused on the speaker, a half-elven woman that regarded me with a warm smile. “I need to speak to the Glayders. Are they in the palace?”

She jogged forward, quickly breaking free of the surprise that made the rest of the soldiers hesitate, and pointed toward the palace doors with one heavy battle gauntlet. “I can take you to them, sir.”

I nodded and let her take the lead.

The halls of the Royal Palace were much busier than when I’d left Etistin.

Dozens of well-dressed people gathered, chatted, and marched about, all of them doing so with an air of importance. Their conversations stopped as we appeared, and wandering eyes began following me.

“The Glayders have been busy,” I mused, more to myself than my guide.

“It’s been a hectic few days, that’s for sure,” she said over her shoulder. “Who would have expected that so much could change so quickly?”

I stopped, and she turned around and gave me a quizzical look. “A few days?” I asked, surprised.

Her brows rose as she gave me an uncertain smile. “Well, yeah. It’s been a few days since the Alacryans retreated and the Glayders…” Her uncertain smile edged down into a frown. “Is everything okay, General?”

“Fine. Yes. It was just a lot less time for me.”

In fact, my quick trip to Epheotus had only felt like hours. *How long did I walk the Path of Insight?* I wondered.

The guard gave me a helpless shrug as if she didn’t have a clue what I was talking about, then continued leading me deeper into the palace. It was as I trailed behind her, idly watching her curly hair bounce up and down as I considered the next dozen steps I needed to take, that I realized who she reminded me of.

“My apologies if this is a strange question, but did you know a soldier named Cedry?” I asked.

The woman’s shoulders stiffened as she missed a step, and she seemed to recede into herself. Slowly, she glanced back over her shoulder. “Wh-what?”

Even as I said the name aloud, it felt so foreign, so long ago. I had only shared a brief conversation with the half-elf soldier, but perhaps it was because she fought with the same style of gauntlets as my father that I still remembered her name.

And of the many lives I had failed to save during the Battle of Slore soon after, her radiant gaze and playful smile stood out, and the way Jona’s voice had cracked as he told Astera and me that he’d intended to marry her…

“She, ah, was my sister,” the soldier said, her gaze falling. Then her face

pinched into a tentative frown. “Did you know her, General?”

“We met at Slore,” I said gently, watching as the soldier’s face hardened to keep the tears forming in her eyes from falling. “She was a fierce and brave warrior.”

“Oh,” she said softly.

We began walking again, more slowly. “What happened to her friend, Jona?”

She took a long moment to respond. “He died,” she said quietly. “Here, in Etistin, during the Battle of the Bloodfrost.”

I didn’t say anything. There was little to be said. But it served to reinforce my decision to work with Kezess. I would do everything in my power to keep their story from becoming everyone’s. Alacryan, Dicathian…no one deserved to die in the petty squabbling of the asura.

We exchanged no more words until Cedry’s sister bid me farewell outside a conference room. As she walked away, her head hanging, I realized I hadn’t even asked her name. Before I could do so, however, something shifted within the shadows of a nearby column and Jasmine stepped out into view.

Arms crossed, she leaned against the pillar and looked me up and down. “About time.”

‘Welcome back to the land of the lessers,’ Regis said with mock reverence. *‘I’d ask how tea with old Kezzy went, but I can already see it in your mind.’*

“No problems here?” I asked Jasmine, while at the same time thinking to Regis, *You can come out now.*

“A lot of side-eyeing and thinly veiled irritation but no violence,” Jasmine said with a casual shrug.

‘Oh, I’ll come out when the time is right,’ Regis said, veiling his thoughts.

Although unsure what antics my companion was getting up to now, I had more pressing matters to attend to. With Jasmine at my heel, I made my way into the conference chamber where I could already hear Curtis’s low baritone.

Inside, seated around one end of an ornate mahogany table, Curtis, Kathyln, and Lyra Dreide were deep in conversation with a half dozen well-dressed nobles.

Lyra saw me first and was quick to jump up from her seat and bow. All eyes went from her to me, and then everyone was standing.

“Arthur, you’ve returned,” Curtis said somewhat stiffly. “We were just discussing you, actually. Your sensational departure has continued to cause a stir over these last few days.”

One of the men present, whose shortness and roundness was only exaggerated by his proximity to the heroically proportioned Curtis Glayder, hurried around the table, his hand extended. “Lance Arthur Leywin! A pleasure, an honor, sir, truly.” Somewhat bemused, I grasped his hand and let him shake mine vigorously. “Otto Beynir, sir, at your service.”

“Beynir?” I repeated, certain I had heard the name before.

Curtis, who had walked up to join us, rested a hand on the man’s shoulder. “The esteemed House Beynir are old friends of my family. Otto here has been indispensable in putting the city back together.”

I looked more closely at the plump man. His brown hair circled up from his head in a color that didn’t quite match the darkness of his brows, and the skin of his face was rashy and pockmarked. His grass-green eyes were intense, and there was a sharpness—a cunningness—buried within them.

“And these others are?” I asked, pulling my hand away from Otto.

A quick round of introductions followed. There was another Glayder—a third cousin of Curtis and Kathyln—a big man from House Maxwell, an older woman of House Lambert, a paunchy middle-aged man from House Astor, and finally a nervous young woman named Dee Mountbatten.

A part of me questioned whether these nobles would be a good influence on the Glayder siblings. However, Curtis and Kathyln weren’t children anymore, and truth be told, I was tired and eager to return to Vildorial.

“How did the rest of the exchange go after I left?” I asked after nodding politely to the Mountbatten girl.

“As smooth as could be expected,” Curtis said, giving me a tight-lipped

smile. He glanced back at his sister and Lyra. “Let’s retire to a more comfortable space for long-winded explanations, and we’ll fill you in.”

My gaze lingered on Lyra, who was staring at me with an intensity bordering on violence. “No time for that. I’m headed straight back to Vildorial, I just wanted to collect the retainer and Miss Flamesworth.”

The barest hint of a frown disrupted Kathyln’s stoic expression. “Are you certain, Arthur? There are a number of decisions we’ve made that I feel you should be apprised of.”

Lyra Dreide had edged away from Kathyln and was slowly approaching in a roundabout way that kept several feet between her and anyone else. “I’m happy to fill him in.”

A scowl flickered across Curtis’s face, but he quickly forced a smile. Interestingly, Kathyln was focused on her brother instead of the retainer. The rest of the Glayders’ new council were watching the proceedings as if it were some kind of sporting event.

I looked from one face to the next. “I’m sorry, Kathyln. Could you put everything into a report and send it to me in Vildorial?”

“Of course,” she said quickly. “Let me take you to your teleportation artifact, at least.”

Curtis reached out and clapped my arm. “Don’t wait too long to return. The city is eager to hear how we plan to hold our continent now that we’ve taken it back.”

I reached up and took hold of his wrist, squeezing it firmly. “I have good news on that, but explanations will have to wait.”

Curtis laughed and took a step back. Emulating him, Otto Beynir did the same. The other nobles all joined in awkwardly.

“Until later then,” Curtis said. To his sister, he added, “I’ll be here with Beynir and the others when you’re finished, Kat.”

Turning on my heel, I led the strange procession of Lyra Dreide, Kathyln Glayder, and Jasmine Flamesworth out of the conference room and into one of the many grand hallways lined with paintings, statues, and other items collected by the Glayder royal family over generations.

“Your friend has hardly let me out of her sight,” Lyra mused, falling in

beside me. “She would even sit through these interminable meetings, I imagine, if Lord Glayder allowed it.” Lyra cocked her head slightly, side-eyeing me. “What did you expect the poor girl to do if I went mad and betrayed you? She appears to have some talent, but she lacks true power.”

Regis chose that moment to manifest from Jasmine’s shadow, rearing up fully formed and glowering next to Lyra. “Then your body would have been reduced to a fine ash.”

Lyra’s brows knitted together, and one side of her mouth quirked up into a wry half smile. “I see.”

Regis chuckled in my mind. *‘Worth the wait.’*

“We moved your teleportation artifact to a safer location,” Kathyln said, moving up to walk beside me and guide us through the palace.

Lyra gave a soft scoff. “She means they hid it from me so I couldn’t attempt to teleport away, forgetting that returning to my homeland is a death sentence.”

“Threat of death alone does not an ally make,” Kathyln replied calmly, her chin turned up and her eyes forward.

Kathyln led us through the palace in silence, down into the bowels of the undercroft to a guarded vault. We were allowed entry on Kathyln’s orders, and inside she took us to an individual room locked with a wardstone she was carrying. Within, resting on a metal table by itself, was the tempus warp.

As Kathyln stood aside to allow the four of us into the small room, I took in her stance, her expression, and where she was focusing her attention. “Thank you. I know this can’t have been easy, but Etistin—Dicathen—needed you.”

She rewarded my words with a small but warm smile. Then the smile faltered, and she looked away from me, her eyes losing focus. “I know you’ll be busy in the coming days and weeks, but Etistin still needs you as well. Please return when you can.”

“I will,” I promised, then turned my attention to the artifact.

Imbuing the Realmheart godrune with aether, I felt that heady rush of mana coming to life all around me. I quickly input our destination into the

device and then activated it by manipulating the mana with my aether. The portal opened flat against one wall. Aether reached out and tugged on the tempus warp, drawing it into my storage rune.

Jasmine nodded to Kathyln and went through.

“Thank you for your hospitality, Lady Glayder,” Lyra said, putting a hand on her chest and giving a shallow bow.

Kathyln said nothing as the retainer followed Jasmine through the portal. Regis went quickly after her.

The former princess of Sapin then gave me a nod before stepping back.

My gaze lingered on hers. “Are you sure everything is all right?”

“These are complicated times, Arthur,” she said in that cool, distant way she had. “Farewell.”

Just as she began to turn around, I reached out and took her hand. For a moment, the two of us stayed silent as I watched a flush of color spread in her cheeks. But her expression mirrored my own, an expression more complicated than just pain or sorrow, one forged throughout the time and tribulations we’d shared together.

Gently pulling her hand loose from mine, Kathyln wrapped her arms around me in a loose hug, her forehead resting on my chest. “Farewell, old friend,” she said again, more kindly.

She pulled away, and her fingers feathered through her hair where it had fallen over her shoulder.

“See you soon,” I assured her. With no more to say, I turned and stepped into the portal.

The scene shifted from the barren vault to the massive cavern of Vildorial. With the tempus warp, it was a smooth transition, nearly seamless, but the view itself was still dizzying.

Nearby, Lyra was looking out over the edge of the curving road with mixed emotions while Jasmine and Regis watched her carefully. A handful of dwarves in heavy plate armor were already moving in our direction from the gates of the Earthborn Institute, our destination. One dwarf put himself out front, and I recognized him immediately as Skarn Earthborn, Mica’s cousin.

“Lance Arthur,” he said, stopping several feet away. His contingent of guards halted just behind him. His gaze lingered on Lyra Dreide. “I’ve been on the lookout for you for the last few days. Do you mind if I ask… never mind, not my business.” He cleared his throat. “My uncle, Carnelian, needs to speak to you as soon as—”

I held up a hand, forestalling the rest of Skarn’s message. “I’ll make my rounds as soon as I’ve had a moment to check in on my family. Tell Carnelian that I’m back and will find him soon enough.”

Skarn’s always-pinched, vaguely hostile expression darkened, but he held back whatever argument he obviously wanted to make. “Aye, Lance. I’ll tell him.” To his guards, he said, “Back to your posts!”

He hurried away, his armor clanking furiously.

“Do you want me to hang around?” Jasmine asked, looking pointedly at Lyra.

“Go get some rest,” I answered, certain she hadn’t been sleeping much as she babysat the retainer in Etistin. “We’ll catch up later.”

Jasmine punched my arm. “I’ve had enough of politics. If you’re going to drag me along on any more adventures, it better be something exciting.”

Chuckling, I shooed her off.

She turned away, waving over her head without looking back.

“You are a strange leader,” Lyra said from just beside me. She, too, was watching Jasmine descend the winding road. “But then, perhaps only one who doesn’t wish for authority can wield it without corruption. Assuming, of course, that you really are this paragon of purity that you present to the world.”

I stared down at the retainer placidly. She stared back, matching my expression, almost as if issuing a challenge. But she said nothing else, only followed as I made a beeline for the open gates of the Earthborn Institute.

The guards let us pass without a word, and we delved into the stone halls cut into the side of the cavern. Instead of heading straight for my mother and Ellie’s rooms, I took Lyra well past the classrooms and living quarters. Although not a prison, the Earthborn Institute had a large number of secure vaults.

I found one that was easy enough to return to and currently appeared unoccupied. It had a barred front like a prison cell, and between each bar was a warding rune that would repel mana usage to some extent.

Reading my intention, Lyra scoffed. “Surely you don’t—”

I empowered God Step and grabbed her by the arm. Although the runes repelled mana, they did nothing to interrupt the aetheric pathways, and in a flash of amethyst lightning, we appeared within the vault.

Her words cut off in a surprised gasp.

Before she could react, I God Stepped back out of the vault. With lightning still cascading across my skin, I looked through the bars to meet her eyes. “We both know this vault probably can’t keep you, but I think we *also* both know it’s not in your best interest to break free.”

And just for safe measure, I want you to stay here and guard her.

‘How did I know that was coming,’ Regis groused. *‘When did I stop being your fierce asura-crafted weapon and become a full-time babysitter?’*

If you’re good at something, people will keep asking you to do it, I quipped.

“Is this really necessary, Regent?” Lyra asked with a sigh. “I’ve already __”

“Behave yourself, and maybe I’ll start to let out your leash,” I said over her, then turned and marched away.

Finally, after what for them would have been well over a week, I found myself back before the door to my family’s quarters.

The smell of something hearty, like a meaty soup or chili, was drifting from under the front door.

I knocked, softly at first, then slightly louder. Voices exchanged from within, muffled by the thick dwarven door, and a few seconds went by. The door’s latch lifted with a resonant *clunk*, and the door swung open.

My sister’s sandy-brown eyes flew wide as she saw me, and she jumped into my arms with a delighted screech. “Arthur!”

I pulled her into a tight embrace and spun her around, making her squawk

in surprise. When I finally set her down, she was red, and her mouth was somehow both smiling and pouting.

“I’m not a child anymore, you know,” she said, sticking her tongue out at me. “Where have you been, anyway?”

It was my mother who answered. She had stepped out of the kitchen and was leaning against the wall, wiping her hands on an apron. “Off saving the world, of course.”

I rolled my eyes as I crossed the room and gave my mother a hug as well. “It smells amazing in here.”

“She’s been practicing,” Ellie said, bouncing past us toward the kitchen. “I was pretty sure she was going to poison us all in the first week, but she’s gotten better.”

Mom reached out to swat Ellie as she went by, but my sister dodged out of the way and ducked through the kitchen arch. Mom hurried after her, saying, “Keep your sticky fingers out of that pie, young lady!” She threw me an exasperated look over her shoulder. “Come on, you can help finish up. Or at least pin your sister down and keep her from eating everything before it’s ready. I swear, I’ve never seen anyone who could put down so much food.”

“Ish ah mah trainung,” Ellie said around a mouthful of food.

I followed mom into the kitchen, where Ellie again dodged her while simultaneously snatching another roll from a heaped plate.

Mom threw her hands up and went back to chopping up a pile of vegetables that were going into a pot over the fire. “Somehow she’s wheedled the Lances into teaching her personally. By throwing *your* name around, I’m sure.”

Ellie swallowed hard, downing what looked like an entire roll at once. “Hey, after all the near deaths and running and hiding, being a Leywin *should* come with some perks…”

Her voice trailed off as mother froze, and my own face fell.

“Sorry,” Ellie said quickly, immediately recognizing the shift in mood. “I didn’t mean it like that.”

My mom stood stiffly for a moment, but when she turned around she was

smiling. “Don’t worry about it, dear. You’re right, we’ve been through a lot. I’m glad they’re teaching you, since your brother is too busy *saving the world*.”

They laughed together, albeit a little awkwardly, but that sound alone made all their teasing worth it.

“This again,” I shot back with mock offense. “You keep saying it like it’s a bad thing. I guess I could just let the world end. That way I wouldn’t have to worry about Ellie ever dating.”

Mom laughed even louder and a bit more genuinely this time around, as Ellie sputtered with outrage and chucked a roll across the kitchen at me. I snatched it out of the air and took a bite.

As I chewed, though, a force flared deep under the institute. I flinched at the mental impact of it, but Ellie and Mom showed no sign of noticing. Looking down at my feet, I stretched my senses.

A sudden, sharp wave of aether had burst like a geyser somewhere below, sending cascading flashes of mana ricocheting all throughout the institute. It was potent enough that certainly others should have sensed it…

“Arthur?” Mom said, noticing my faraway look. “Is something wrong?”

“I’m not sure,” I said, heading for the door. “Stay here, and”—I made eye contact with my sister—“summon Boo, just in case.”

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YET ANOTHER STEP

THE EARTHBORN INSTITUTE'S dim halls blurred past as I rushed downward, deeper into the labyrinthine mass of tunnels. No alarm had been sounded, and the few dwarves I passed appeared unaware of any strangeness, though my hurried descent drew nervous, questioning looks from most.

The aether had appeared in a rush, then dissipated almost immediately, from the direction of the laboratories. There were few enough people or artifacts who could cause such a phenomenon, and although she wasn't one of them, I was conscious of Lyra Dreide's presence in the institute.

Is our guest minding herself? I thought to Regis.

'She didn't have anything to do with that spike of aether if that's what you're asking. Want me to come with you to check it out?'

No, stay where you are for now.

'Yippee,' my companion groused, his boredom and irritation leaking through our mental connection.

As I moved off in nearly the opposite direction, my thoughts lingered on Kezess. He had promised assistance in defending Dicathen but hadn't been clear about the specifics of what that might entail. However, I didn't think that meant portaling in asura without informing me. I couldn't entirely trust his word anyway—that would have been the height of foolishness—and I knew it was within reason he might reverse course and take some hostile action instead.

Still, this didn't *feel* like Kezess. There was nothing to gain in either case, as far as I could see. No, the more likely scenario led me down familiar

tunnels, and when I saw two burly dwarven guards, each fully outfitted with shields, spears, and heavy plate armor, standing outside Gideon's lab, I felt certain my guess was correct.

The two shifted positions as they heard my approach, tensing, but then relaxing almost immediately. Simultaneously, they slammed the bases of their large shields against the ground. "Lance, sir!" they barked together. One went silent, and the other continued, almost apologetic. "Gideon has given strict orders that *no one* bother him—"

The doors shot open, and Emily's bespectacled face poked out, her eyes wide behind the lenses. She looked at the guards, opened her mouth to say something, spotted me, then seemed to change tack in the middle of her thought. "Arthur, you're a healer!"

She was breathing hard and slightly flushed around the cheeks. "I mean, I'm glad you're here." To the guard, she added, "Go get a healer."

The guard snapped a salute before jogging away, his heavy armor clanging with every footfall.

Emily pulled the door open, and I slipped through, then she let it swing shut behind me.

The lab, I was surprised to see, was empty. "Where is—"

"Come on, through here," she snapped, already rushing away.

I followed her through an arched door at the other end of the lab, then down a flight of stairs and into another hallway where there was a series of smaller chambers I hadn't visited before, each one blocked by a heavy stone door inscribed with runes. Emily stopped at the third door on the right, empowered it with mana, and pushed hard.

On the other side of the thick stone door was a wide, dimly lit chamber with a low ceiling. A single table had been dragged down here, but the main feature of the room was a protective circle in the center. A small shield generator was connected to several mana crystals, and when activated would create a very dense dome-shaped mana shield around the protection circle.

Sitting on the floor, his bare back against the curved wall, was Gideon. His gray hair was a mess, and there was a gaunt, pale look on his face, but when his eyes settled on me as I followed Emily into the chamber, they

were full of fire.

“I figured it out!” he croaked, heedless of Emily’s worry. “The bestowals, the artifacts, the spellforms, all of it.”

A manic grin spread across his face, and words began to spill from his mouth. “The hard part was the sequencing of the runes in the robe. I suggested before it was like a password, and your summons was right in that there is a trap woven in—if you channeled mana into the runes out of order, they will keep drawing on your mana until you either break the connection or run out, incapacitating or even killing the wearer, and before you say it, getting out would be no easy feat, as there are belts within the robes that are tricky to do and undo, and they have to be buckled correctly for all that mana to move properly.”

Gideon drew a deep breath, and I opened my mouth to ask him a question, but he immediately continued barreling onward. “In fact, the robes use the wearer as a kind of conduit for certain aspects of the manipulation, so just holding them on your lap or touching them with one hand doesn’t work, they *have* to be worn. It’s rather devious, honestly.”

Gideon shook his head, looking impressed. “But,” he continued, “I figured out the correct sequencing, naturally.” He gestured to Emily, and I realized with a sinking feeling in my stomach that she was wearing the ceremonial robes.

“*Gideon*,” Emily said urgently.

She had crossed the room and kneeled beside him while he was rambling, but only then did he seem to even notice her.

Still grinning, he said, “Oh, of course. Miss Watsken was quite the help, testing the artifacts individually to ensure that our hypotheses—”

“*Gideon*,” she said again, exasperated. “I sent for a healer. We should—”

“Bah!” Gideon burst out, struggling to push himself up the wall to stand. “Arthur, you’ve distracted me. I need to move on to the testing phase immediately.”

“Hold on,” I said, raising a hand to stop him. “We should really talk this through before we try the bestowal on a person. If something were to go wrong…”

I trailed off. Gideon's half-grown brows raised and furrowed simultaneously, his expression caught somewhere between confusion and disbelief. Behind him, Emily stared at the ground, rubbing her eyes with her hands.

My gaze tracked from Gideon's thin, soft bare form to the table where the staff and other artifacts rested.

Then Gideon burst out with a wild laugh and shook his head, his shoulders shaking with amusement. "What do you think is going to go wrong? I channel mana and my torso explodes?" He stopped, and a thoughtful look crossed his face for a moment. Turning to Emily, he asked, "Is that something we considered?"

"Wait," I said, feeling wrong-footed. Then, like a trapdoor opening in my mind, I connected the burst of aether I had felt with Gideon's words. I dragged a hand down my face with a sigh. "You already used it, didn't you?"

Gideon flipped a switch, channeled a burst of mana into the shield artifact, and took his place in the middle of the protection circle. "This spellform? No, of course, not, I'm—oh! You mean the bestowal artifacts. Well yes, of course, I couldn't sit around waiting for you forever, could I?"

I groaned. "Gideon, I say this with all due respect, but only an actual insane person would commit to a human trial of unknown and only partially understood magic *on himself*."

Gideon closed his eyes. "All magic is the constant act of self-experimentation. If I recall correctly, you once caused yourself a near-crippling number of microfractures throughout the bones of your legs by experimenting with a spell."

I ground my teeth, but I had to admit he was right. "Fine. But before you take this further, can I at least call in someone who understands the use of spellforms? Who can perhaps guide you on their use?"

Gideon opened one eye. "You just happen to have an Alacryan mage in your back pocket or something?"

"Not in my back pocket, no," I shot back. "Just…don't do anything else stupid until I get back."

"Sometimes I feel like you don't appreciate my genius."

There was a dull hammering from the door, and Emily jumped. “Oh, that’ll be the healer.”

I pulled the door open to reveal the guard and a heavyset dwarven woman whose scowl sent shivers up even my spine. She stomped into the chamber, glared around, and then settled her irritation firmly on Gideon.

I slipped out into the hall past the guard but could still hear the reverberation of her voice as she shouted, “This is the sixth time *this week*,” and then her words were lost.

Lyra Dreide’s vault-cell was not far, and I reached it quickly. Regis had sensed me coming, of course, and was standing in front of the bars with his flames waving fiercely.

“What’s going on?” Lyra asked as I appeared in front of her. “I sensed your beast’s agitation, but he’s even less communicative than you.”

Saying nothing, I God Stepped into the vault, took hold of her arm, and stepped back into the hall. “Stay close, and don’t try anything.”

The retainer let out a put-upon sigh. “Perhaps I was mistaken…”

For the second time, I made my way down into the lower halls where Gideon had his laboratory. The guards said nothing, but stepped well back from the door as I led Lyra and Regis into the lab, their hard eyes following the retainer closely.

Emily was quick to open the inner door when I knocked, and we all entered the chamber together. Lyra, who was looking around curiously at everything, immediately homed in on Gideon. “He has a rune.”

Gideon took in her dark eyes, her flame-red hair, her suppressed aura. His skin wrinkled as he frowned. “Isn’t that the regent?”

“Well spotted, both of you,” I said sarcastically. “She is my prisoner, and has forsaken service to the enemy and promised to make herself useful.” To her, I asked, “How could you tell?”

“There is a faint signature of the mana, brightest just after formation, though eventually hidden by the mage’s own mana signature.”

The sight of mana particles burned into my vision as I activated Realmheart. Sure enough, layered behind Gideon’s own mana signature, there was the more subtle glow of the spellform. It was then that I noticed

his core itself; it was still burning with mana, and within the mana currents was a thin trail of aether particles. As I watched, this swelling of mana began to fade, allowing me to see his core more clearly.

It was rapidly clarifying to a light yellow color.

“You have figured out how Agrona’s bestowment ritual works,” Lyra continued, her tone curious, musing. “A clever turnabout, but not without risk.”

“What risks?” Emily asked, keeping well back from the retainer and yet watching her with a kind of wary eagerness. “We assumed that, once a spellform was in place, it was only a matter of learning to control it.”

Lyra nodded along as Emily spoke, pursing her lips slightly. “Yes, practice and patience will allow a mage to master a new rune, but our entire culture is predicated on the training and knowledge to do so. Alacryan children prepare to wield runes even before their first bestowment, and still plenty of young mages have pushed too hard, too fast, and burned themselves to dust with a rune they didn’t fully understand and weren’t equipped to make use of.”

Gideon huffed, but Emily seemed shaken as the color drained from her cheeks.

“But the greater risk is in the bestowment itself,” the retainer continued. “Our people are adapted to the bestowals. You might even say we were bred for it. We are born with our cores, and twenty percent of our population develops magic. Your people lack asuran lineage, something even the lowliest of Alacryan unadorned can claim. Do not discount the danger just because this single Imbuer has survived unscathed. The process may very well kill some who attempt it.”

“Bah!” Gideon burst out, losing his patience. “It’s easy enough to see the divide between Alacrya’s development of the mechanism involved in this ritual and the original magics formulated by the ancient mages. If it worked for them a thousand years ago, and then for the Alacryans now, why wouldn’t it work for us too?”

He shifted his focus to me, scowling darkly. “Perhaps your prisoner is attempting to forestall our progress or sow doubt, eh?”

I considered his claim and the retainer simultaneously. Her placidity seemed a direct counter to his bubbling antagonism, but I didn’t sense any

misdirection or untruthfulness in her words. “What she has said lines up with my own experience in Alacrya,” I said after a moment. “We proceed cautiously, understanding the risks and mitigating them where we can.”

Gideon tossed his hands in the air in a mockingly jubilant prayer to the heavens. “Great. Can I light this thing up and see what happens now, or do any of you have any more dire warnings for me first?”

Regis’s lips pulled back from his teeth in a lupine grin. “Only that having one of these runes tends to coincide with being a homicidal maniac set on following a living deity into war with the kingdom of the gods,” he tossed out casually. “I don’t think that’s a side effect of a rune, really, but you never know.”

Gideon snorted in bewilderment, shook his head, and then closed his eyes. After a moment, he opened just one and looked at Lyra. “So I…uh…just push mana into it or…?”

Her lips formed a hard line as she nodded. “Feel for it. The rune itself is a part of you now, and you should sense it.”

Gideon closed his eye again, frowning deeply as he concentrated.

With Realmheart still active, I watched as mana flowed through him and into the rune. It lit up, and mana radiated out from it before rushing up his spine and into his brain.

Gideon gasped. His lips were moving, but no noise was coming out.

“What is it?” Emily asked, her fingers kneading white-knuckled into the front of the ceremonial robes. “Professor Gideon, are you okay?”

“Oh,” he said, almost a moan. “This is…”

The flow of mana cut off as he released his channeling. He was breathing hard, and his eyes were moving rapidly beneath his lids.

Lyra was smirking. “Don’t worry. There is a heady rush to a new rune, especially a crest or higher.”

Finally, Gideon’s eyes fluttered open. “I don’t entirely understand what just happened,” he admitted with a quiet reverie. “It was like the magical equivalent of drinking far too much coffee in far too short a time.”

“A mental rune then,” Lyra mused, moving slowly around the protective

shielding. “Probably either that of a Sentry or an Imbuer. A crest, certainly. Without the proper tomes…”

Emily held up the book containing a description of all the runes granted from this particular staff.

Humming to herself, Lyra took the book and flipped through it. “Here it is. Awakened Mind, the crest of an Imbuer. Not surprising, of course, although runes do not always align with previous life experience. It has only been granted twice that was recorded in this tome, but the notes indicate mastering it allowed both Imbuers to convert mana into a sort of mental energy, providing wakefulness and focus.”

She handed the book back to Emily, who took it with both hands like it was a child.

“Yes, that’s what I felt, but it was a chaotic energy,” Gideon said, gingerly pushing himself up to his feet and stumbling through the shield. He flicked the switch, and the transparent barrier dwindled and vanished. “It’ll get easier?”

“Oh yes,” Lyra confirmed. “And the effect will continue to grow in strength as you master the rune. When you’ve done that, attempt the bestowal again, and you may receive another more powerful rune. Often they are complimentary, although not always.”

Emily looked from Lyra to Gideon to me, a slowly dawning horror falling over her features. “So he’s going to be even *more* hyperactive?”

I chuckled appreciatively, but Gideon himself took no notice as he slipped a loose tunic over his bare torso and stretched, his back cracking like gravel crunching beneath a boot.

“Then we move on to the second experiment,” he said eagerly.

The chamber went quiet as we all looked at the old artificer in surprise.

“I know I said this is important,” I said, breaking the silence, “but you should rest, take time to make sure there are no side effects…”

Gideon wagged his finger in my face with almost comical violence. “You *did* say this was important! And I’ll be thrice damned if I’m going to waste our momentum. According to our previous conversation, just being around you enhances the rune received. I’ve tested myself to ensure that the

process won't kill either the officiant *or* the recipient of the spellform, but I'm a middling case. We've spent a bit of time together since your return, but not an abundance. Now we need to bestow someone who hasn't been around you at all."

I met Emily's eyes, but she only shrugged. She knew all too well how pigheaded her master was, and although she might not hesitate to voice her opinion, she wasn't about to help me try and talk him out of charging onward with this.

Lyra stepped closer to Gideon and said softly, "My own caution, then, would be against pushing your officiant too hard. Performing the bestowment ceremony is taxing on both mind and body. Agrona's officiants spend their entire lives training to handle the huge crowds that can show up to a bestowment, and often the load is shared between many people."

She hesitated, then added, "I would be willing to lend my services as an officiant if you teach me what you have—"

"No," I said flatly, crossing my arms. "We will consider who else to bring into this, but for the moment, Emily will be our officiant."

Lyra shrugged, smiling pleasantly. "Of course, Regent Leywin. I am only trying to help."

"Well, what are we waiting for?" Gideon asked, looking around at all of us. "Emily, go find me a dwarf. Arthur, you get the hell out of here so you don't contaminate my experiment."

"So, what next?" Regis asked from where he was curled up at my feet at the end of the hallway.

It had been some time since either of us had spoken, and I had to collect the wayward shreds of my attention before replying. "After this second test?"

"No, after all that. We've mostly taken back the continent, broken Kezess's limitation placed on the Lances, and now given spellforms to Dicathen to help even the odds in any future battles. But a couple of white

core mages and a few magical tattoos aren't going to defeat Agrona."

I leaned back against the wall and let the back of my head rest against the cool stone. "Strategic provisioning of the spellforms may not defeat Agrona, but it will allow us to rapidly provide power boosts where they are needed and add a lot of new tools to our repertoire, you know that." I thought for a few seconds. "Any one of the steps we take might be what allows for victory in the end, but I understand that you and I have other things to do. Seris is fighting a war for us in Alacrya, and there are two more ruins to hunt down."

I left unsaid the problem that loomed over everything else, the one I had done my best to keep to the back of my mind ever since Sylvie's sacrifice and my appearance in the Relictombs…because I still had no idea what I could do about Cecilia and Tessia.

Regis lapsed into silence, and together, we waited for Emily's return.

It took longer than Gideon would have liked to recruit a second test subject whom I'd had no interaction with. There was some worry that even incidental contact, such as my speaking to the guards out in the hallway, would sway the results, and most of the guards and soldiers in the Earthborn Institute had crossed my path at least once or twice.

But the real delay was that, when Skarn Earthborn discovered what Emily was asking about, he insisted on informing his uncle, Carnelian, about the tests so that the dwarven lord could voice his opinion. This inevitably became a struggle between the Earthborns and Silvershales to send forth a member of their house, but most had spent hours in close proximity to me during meetings with the Council of Lords.

But eventually, after what felt like many hours but was probably only one, Emily returned with a young dwarf lord called Daymor Silvershale, youngest son of Lord Daglun, Carnelian's chief rival. Daymor kept his pitch-black beard trimmed to only a few inches and his hair slightly shorter. He looked every bit the royal as he appeared in a regally tailored tunic and breeches, with rings on his fingers and a gold-hilted sword hanging at his hip.

I, of course, only watched from the end of the hallway with Regis at my side. Daymor met my eye before following Emily into the bestowal chamber, and his lips twitched beneath his beard. I thought he looked nervous, and he grew even more so when the two guards and attendant

who had trailed him down into these deep tunnels were made to wait outside in the corridor.

Although I could not watch the process, a fact I found somewhat disappointing, I listened to the muffled voices of Gideon, Emily, and Lyra explaining everything that was to happen. Still, I consoled myself with the fact that I had seen the bestowment ceremony before, in Maerin, and knew what was happening.

The ceremony itself took much less time than finding our test subject.

When the door opened again, the three dwarves were quick to hurry in. I followed behind, curious but hopeful. There had been no panicked shouts to indicate we had just killed off a member of the noble house of Silvershale, and indeed, when I peered through the door, I saw Daymor grinning as he rubbed at the bare flesh of his back.

He tried to turn around to look over his shoulder, as if he might be able to see his own spine, while Gideon shooed the other dwarves to the outer edges of the small room.

“Now, feel for the rune, and push your mana into it. It should feel natural, instinctual,” Lyra was saying.

Daymor turned his nose up at her and spit on the ground. “Like I said, I don’t take orders from Alacryan filth, and especially not the Bitch Queen of Etistin.”

“That’s enough, Daymor,” I said firmly. “What we are doing is important, and Lyra of Highblood Dreide is here at *my* order.”

The dwarf attempted to scowl at me, but his wide eyes and the twitching of a muscle beneath his beard gave away just how frightened he was. After a few seconds, he cleared his throat and said, “Aye, let’s get on with it then. This bloody thing itches like the dickens.”

Gideon sucked his teeth in irritation. “Fine, then perhaps you’ll listen to me. Stay within the circle and empower the spellform.”

Daymor followed Gideon’s instructions, settling himself in the center of the protection circle and taking a deep breath, making his broad chest swell.

Lyra had fallen back to stand beside me. “Thank you,” she said under her

breath. “For defending me.”

“I wasn’t,” I said, also keeping my voice low. “But it will grow awfully tedious if every conversation has to wait for a string of expletives to be thrown at you first.”

Lyra didn’t answer, and so I returned my focus to Daymor, quietly activating Realmheart so I could watch the flow of mana. Like with Gideon, it poured from Daymor’s core and down into his rune, but this time the resultant spell flowed down his legs and into the ground.

Thin fissures cracked the ground inside of the protection circle, and wispy flames erupted from them. I could see the fine line where the protection circle’s runes rebuffed the flow of the mana, preventing the spell from affecting anything outside it.

“Fire, my lord!” the attendant said, clearly shocked.

Daymor laughed, a booming noise like a cannon. “Ah, but it feels strange. Good, but strange!”

All in all, it was not an impressive spell, but I knew Daymor was a single-attribute earth mage. The mark had granted him the ability to cast a spell of a different type than his natural affinity; that alone was a great boon for a Dicathian mage. It was certainly something his father could crow about in the Council of Lords meetings for the foreseeable future, especially as Daymor’s mastery of the rune grew.

As Emily and Gideon began explaining to Daymor what was expected of him—daily training and monitoring, reports on how the spellform impacted his magic, and so forth—I let my thoughts drift to the next question. Gideon would want to do a third test, of course. This time with someone who I had spent a significant amount of time with…

Although the list was short, that did not make it easy. Who had I spent enough time with since returning to Dicathen?

The better question, I thought to myself, *is who among that short list am I willing to put at risk?*

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THE BEST CHOICE

ELEANOR LEYWIN

As I heard the dwarves' excited murmuring grow louder, I slipped deeper into the shadows of the room where I'd hidden. The guards farther down the hall hadn't moved from their positions in front of Gideon's laboratory, but they had cracked open the lab door to try and eavesdrop on the excitement below, which worked in my favor.

With my beast will active, I had been able to listen in as Daymor Silvershale received his bestowal. The increased sensitivity not only picked up sound from farther away but translated the subtle vibration of their movements and mana usage up through the stone into sensation as well.

Daymor and three other dwarves burst out into the hall a moment later, chattering like a bunch of teenage girls in the shopping district.

"Ah, I can't wait to see old man Earthborn's face when he gets a load of my new power," Daymor was saying. "And my older brothers' as well. How they've lorded their attendance of the council meetings over my head. Well, let's see who has something to crow about now!"

Another voice was quick to add, "A dual-elemental augmenter, the first in three generations of Silvershales. Your father will be ecstatic, sir."

Their conversation meant little to me, and so, despite the fact that I could have continued to listen to them for at least a couple of minutes, even as they moved farther and farther away, I instead tried to block out the noise and focus on my brother and those with him—Gideon, Emily Watsken, and a woman I thought must be the retainer he had captured, Lyra—who

were once again shut up in a chamber below me. I had to focus through two doors and ten feet of solid stone, but if I held my breath, I could just make out the weak vibrations of their conversation.

“How are you feeling?” my brother was asking Emily.

“Fine, just need a moment’s rest,” came her faint reply.

“Give her an hour or two, at least, before attempting the ritual again,” said the retainer.

Gideon’s reply was louder than the others. “But I need a third data point or what we’ve seen so far is worthless! Someone who Arthur has spent a lot of time around, the most time around, hours and hours. No middle ground or close enough, it needs to be—”

“Gideon, quit activating your spellform,” my brother said, his tone both exasperated and resigned.

The funny old artificer cleared his throat and mumbled something I didn’t catch, because at the same time, something heavy fell to the ground a few floors above, and a deep dwarven voice cursed.

I shifted position, keeping one eye on the open doorway into this room as I leaned closer to the ground, attempting to hear better.

“I need to think, and Emily needs to rest,” my brother said, speaking firmly.

“Fine, fine, but don’t take all day. Make your choice and bring them here this afternoon,” Gideon demanded.

They said their farewells, and I heard Regis’s claws scraping on stone as they began moving in my direction.

I cast a quick glance around the room where I was hidden, which was just down the hall from Gideon’s laboratory. It looked like a disused classroom of sorts, full of dwarf-sized desks, empty shelves, and a few soot-stained tables. Where the door used to be was now just an open frame. As near as I could tell, I was pretty close to being right over the chamber where Gideon had been running his experiments.

Arthur and his companion moved in silence, but I knew they could communicate without speaking. I wondered what they were talking about…or perhaps *who* they were talking about.

They needed someone my brother had spent a lot of time around—been close to—for the next stage of their experiment…

I immediately and *absolutely* wanted it to be me. Not because I wanted an Alacryan rune—or a spellform, as Gideon and Arthur referred to them as—although a sudden boost to my power and clarification of my core *did* sound good. But what I really wanted was to be involved, to be *helpful*. Between the long journey through the desert together, our training and meditation, meals and even sleeping in the same space, I couldn't think of anyone who would have spent more time with him, not even Mom.

But I also knew right away that he wouldn't want to put me at risk.

So, I just need to convince him I'm the only choice, I thought, steeling myself for the task.

I watched Arthur and the big shadow wolf pass by from where I was carefully hidden behind a larger table, but I didn't come out right away. Instead, I focused on their footsteps, waiting until they were far ahead to follow. The hall was clear except for the two guards, and if I stayed against the far wall, I could use the support columns that ribbed the otherwise smooth walls of the corridor to stay out of their line of sight, just like I had when I sneaked down here to begin with. The guards were focused on themselves anyway, chatting animatedly about Daymor Silvershale and what Gideon's experiments would mean for Vildorial.

With my beast will still active, I was sensitive to even the slightest noise, especially my own, which helped me to creep along in utter silence. I didn't think I'd get in trouble just for being down in these tunnels, but I didn't want Arthur to know I had been spying on him after he ran out in such a rush. He'd be upset with me and say that I constantly disregarded my own safety and took unnecessary risks, completely oblivious to how hypocritical he sounded giving lectures.

I forced myself to stop from going down this mental path. I needed to be thinking about how I was going to convince him to let me participate in Gideon's experiment.

Arthur had been moving slowly, no doubt deep in thought and in no rush, but I had to assume he was heading home. Taking a slightly longer route back, I moved quickly and quietly, using my heightened senses to avoid crossing paths with any of the guards, mages, or other residents who frequented these tunnels.

Instead of going inside, however, I leaned against the wall next to the door and waited. When, a couple minutes later, I heard the telltale scraping of claws, I released my beast will and carefully arranged my features into an innocent smile.

When Arthur stepped around the corner, I gave him a little wave and said, “Everything okay down there?”

Arthur stopped, his surprise reading clearly on his face. “Yeah, it wasn’t an emergency. What are you doing out here?”

“Waiting for you,” I said honestly, digging the toe of my turnshoe into the floor. “You were gone for a while.”

“Gideon,” he said by way of explanation, and I smiled.

Arthur leaned against the wall opposite me in the squat hallway and watched me silently. I felt guilt prickle into goosebumps on the backs of my arms as I thought about how best to convince him to choose me without giving away my spying expedition.

“What’s wrong?” he asked after a moment.

“What? Nothing,” I said in a rush, tucking a lock of hair behind my ear.

His eyes narrowed, and then his expression softened. “How much did you hear?”

I opened my mouth, and he cocked a brow. Instead of trying to lie, I let out a gusting breath. “How did you know?”

“Your guilt might as well be written across your forehead in ink,” he said, chuckling.

I groaned, pulling the hair I’d just fixed down in front of my face to hide my eyes. “Sorry, I just…”

He waved my apology away. “I get it. It’s okay.”

Despite his forgiveness, the silence that fell between us felt sour and awkward. “I want to help with the bestowment trial,” I forced out.

He nodded seriously. There was no surprised smirk or disbelieving laugh, which made me feel better. He really seemed to be considering it. Then he said, “I’ve already decided on Jasmine. She’s older and more battle-tested

and has spent nearly as much time with me as you have."

I had anticipated this answer, but I remained silent.

Regis, who had been pacing up and down the hall as we talked, stopped. "Plus, I lived in her core for a few days. That might make a difference, too."

"When I was in camp with all those Alacryans, some of them were really young," I pointed out, bringing up the counterargument I had prepared. "They get their first bestowals really early, right? I'm a lot younger than Jasmine, closer to the age a bestowment should happen."

"Point, Ellie," Regis said as his head turned from me to Arthur then back.

"It's not just about you being my sister," Arthur said, pushing away from the wall and taking a step closer. "The truth is you have a lot of variables Jasmine doesn't. You're a pure mana mage with no elemental affinity, you're a beast tamer, and you have djinn ancestry. Variables mean danger in this case, El."

"Still, I…" I trailed off, unsure how to respond. I didn't have an argument against the points he made, only felt sure that, despite the risks, I was the best choice.

"Why are you so insistent on this?" Arthur asked, inspecting me carefully with those bright gold eyes. "This isn't the only chance you'll get. Once the process has been tested thoroughly, you'll get your turn, I promise."

"You can't understand," I said in the direction of my feet. Tension crept into my shoulders and neck, and the instinct to bury what I was feeling made speaking difficult. "You don't have to cower with your mother every time retainers or Scythes come knocking, telling yourself you're protecting her when both of you know full well that you can't, that you're *useless* against that kind of enemy…" I turned away from Arthur, staring blindly down the empty corridor leading away from our rooms. "It's just…so frustrating, to feel so helpless…"

I rested my head against the wall and let out a long breath like a sigh. I could feel Arthur's gaze burning into the side of my face, but I didn't want to look at him, didn't want to see pity or disapproval or disappointment.

There was a groan of hinges, and my mother's voice said, "You should choose Ellie."

I whipped around to look at Mom, slack-jawed with surprise at her intervention. Even if I convinced Arthur, I had expected to have the fight all over again with her.

Arthur seemed just as caught off guard, and he rubbed the back of his neck awkwardly but didn't respond.

"You heard everything?" I asked her.

She gave me a wry smile. "You're not exactly being quiet out here."

She watched us for a moment, sad but determined, before continuing. "We are, all of us, in *constant* danger. Maybe taking risks is the only way forward. Maybe…we've been too cautious, too willing to let you protect us. But there is no way to know when one of our many enemies will appear and rain hellfire down on us. You might not be here when they do—if our enemy is wise, he'll make sure of it. But it seems like this might be a way to help us prepare, and if your sister is the best choice of test subject, then so be it." There was something haunted and forlorn in her eyes, a tired weariness that nearly broke my heart to see.

Biting my trembling bottom lip, I stared down at the ground, wordless.

"All I ever wanted—even before the war, before any of this started—was the power to protect you guys," Arthur said, his voice low and sad. I glanced up at him, but his face was hidden behind a curtain of wheat-blond hair. "I guess even now, after everything that has happened, I couldn't," he finished, his chin tilting up to reveal a pained smile.

Mom crossed the hallway, her hand feathering through Arthur's hair. "We are never promised another day," she said somberly. Then she half turned to look at me. "But we have today, and there is so much we can do with it."

Emily was waiting for us in Gideon's lab, a large room chock-full of tables, shelves, buzzing equipment, and stacks of notes, all warmed by a large firesalt furnace on one side. She gave me a quizzical look, which then moved to Arthur questioningly. He only nodded, so she shrugged, turned around, and led Arthur, Mom, and me through an arched opening across from us, down a flight of stairs, and to a specific door.

I glanced around the featureless hall, trying to map it out compared to the classroom above, curious about the strength of my beast-bonded senses.

The door opened to Emily's touch, and she led us into a plain, dimly lit chamber. A circle of runes had been carved into the floor and filled with silvery metal that glowed faintly, and some kind of artifact had been constructed just outside the circle. A single table was pushed against one wall, and a seemingly random assortment of items sat atop it.

The master artificer, Gideon, was fiddling with the equipment, while the retainer, Lyra Dreide, sat with her back against the curved walls and perused some kind of old tome.

"About time," Gideon mumbled, sparing me only a cursory glance. "The sister, huh? Well, I suppose there are worse people you could have been spending all your time with. She's not quite an ideal candidate though, is she? Dark orange core, a beast tamer—no idea how that interacts with the bestowment, if at all—and barely a child. A more mature test subject would be—"

"I'm a Leywin," I said firmly, cutting across his criticism. "My brother and I both had to mature fast." Of course, there was the small detail of Arthur already being well into adulthood, mentally, when he was born into our family, but I didn't know how many people were aware of that fact. "I'm ready for this."

"O-ho, are you?" Gideon asked, leaving off his work and leaning toward me. "Ready to have a potentially potent spell writ into your flesh by unknown and hostile magics, a spell that will certainly be unlike any magic your small mind has conceived of previously and could very well *kill* you if you don't do *exactly* as you are told?"

My lips parted to assure him that I was indeed ready for exactly that, but I choked on the words. It had all been well and good arguing for this from the safety of our rooms above, but now, down here in the dark, seeing Emily dressed in her strange ceremonial robes, her fingers unconsciously tracing the lines of a black staff, I was suddenly nervous.

"She is," Arthur said, stepping up beside me and resting a hand on my shoulder.

A swelling of warm pride eased my nerves and unwound the knot forming at the back of my throat.

Emily approached, giving me a comforting smile, and slipped her arm through mine. “You’ll be fine, I’m sure. Arthur has already told you what is going to happen?”

I nodded as she led me to the center of the circle of runes. She gestured to the ground, and so I sat, my legs crossed and arms resting on my knees, and looked up at her. She only smiled again before moving to the table, where she slid some kind of bracelet over her wrist, then picked up the staff.

“Mrs. Leywin, if you’ll stand back,” she asked respectfully. Mom seemed hesitant, and I felt certain she was starting to regret supporting this, but she did as Emily requested.

My brother, on the other hand, kneeled down beside me, just outside of the runes. His golden eyes met mine, and he winked. “Maximum aether exposure,” he explained quietly.

Gideon had pulled a notebook and pen from his robes and was writing furiously. The retainer was standing silently against the wall opposite my mother.

Emily’s shadow crossed over me as she moved around to stand behind my back. I could feel her looming, and my instinct to move or turn flared, causing goosebumps to roughen the skin of my arms and neck.

“Ellie, we expect this might be painful,” Emily said, her tone sour, like she didn’t like what she had to say. “A mark was received easily by a veteran mage, but even a crest struck Master Gideon like a blow, knocking the breath from him. If you receive a stronger spellform…”

“Then the effect on my body will be stronger as well,” I finished for her, staring down at the shimmering runes in front of me.

“Yes.” There was a pause, then, “Are you ready?”

I clenched my teeth together and forced myself to sit up straight. I wasn’t afraid of pain. “Yes.”

Behind me, I heard Emily begin to move, the fabric of the heavy robes scuffing against itself, the butt of the staff clicking against rock, a long exhale…

The light in the room changed. There was a subtle glow, probably from

crystal at the top of the staff.

Then every muscle in my body seized.

I jerked, my back locked into an uncomfortable arch, my mouth open, a moan halfway to my lips, my fingers clawing into my thighs, my eyes wide, so wide they burned and filled with tears.

It felt like a brand, like red-hot iron pressed against the base of my spine that set fire to every nerve in my whole body.

I snapped like an overpulled bowstring, the paralysis breaking, the moan turning into a weak scream as I crumpled to the cold floor, sucking in a feeble breath, fighting my own lungs, which refused to move air.

Mom said something, a panicky warbling that came in and out of focus, followed by Arthur's commanding baritone.

My lids dragged themselves shut, and in the dark, everything was worse. No, not worse, just *more*. I tried to open my eyes, but I couldn't. I wanted to ask for help, but my tongue wasn't following instructions. And the weight of the sensation grew, a building pressure centered on the small of my back.

A powerful hand had me by the shoulder, dragging me up into a sitting position, but I was only dimly aware of it, as if it was happening in the last remnants of a dream just as I woke.

Mana crashed over me, wave after wave, like nothing I'd ever felt before.

My eyes snapped open. Two golden orbs like little suns hovered just above me, moving rapidly in tiny bursts.

My core trembled, and I thought I might be sick.

Then it did something I have no words for, and I knew I was dying, because even when the asura's blade ran me through I had still felt like myself, still been present for the pain in my body, but now, with stunning suddenness, the pain was gone, and I felt nothing but its absence.

"She's going into shock," a lilting, honeyed voice said firmly, and the golden eyes vanished, replaced by flame-red tresses. "Eleanor, focus on my voice. Think and take the meaning of my words. Your core is being rapidly clarified, and your body is struggling to adjust. It will be over soon, but you must stay present. Your mind and your thoughts guide the process.

Stay here, with my voice."

I felt my face scrunching up in confusion as my brain struggled not with the meaning of the words, but to make sense of the strangeness of the situation: an Alacryan retainer, a woman responsible for the deaths of tens of thousands of Dicathians, was now sincerely guiding me through a process we had stolen from her people…

And I think it was exactly this that snapped me out of the cold spiral I had been following. My breath came easier and sensation returned. I became aware of the cold stone pressing against my legs and rear, and of the sweat clinging to my face, and the deep ache in my muscles due to the sudden clenching and releasing, and finally the hands holding either side of my face firmly, forcing me to look into the retainer's eyes.

A slight smile broke across her face, and she let me go. I leaned forward, pressing my hands to the ground and drawing in slow, steady breaths. A hand rubbed gently at my back, between my shoulder blades.

"Eleanor, we need to look," the retainer said. I could only nod in reply.

I felt the hem of my shirt being tugged up as Lyra shifted around me, then Mom was there, her hands resting on top of mine. Her eyes followed the retainer at first, but then snapped to my own. They were full of tears about to fall, but there was a quivering smile on her face.

"So, it is true," the retainer said quietly, her voice full of awe and reverence. "A regalia. It…should not be possible."

Sliding one hand free, I reached behind me and rubbed the skin of my lower back where the spellform still tingled.

"And look at that. It's pushed her clear to the light-yellow stage," Gideon said.

My heart thumped inside my chest, and I turned my attention inward. He was right!

Despite the aching and the fatigue, I knew what came next, and I couldn't wait to begin. "I…want to test it," I said around a dry lump in my throat.

"We can wait," Mom said, but Gideon was already moving.

He shooed everyone else back and activated the artifact. A transparent bubble of mana shimmered to life over the circle, cutting me off from the

others.

“Gideon,” my brother said with a note of warning, but Gideon ignored him as well.

Standing in front of me, just on the other side of the shield with a notebook in hand and eyes gleaming with curiosity, Gideon said, “Well, go on then!”

The retainer began to coach me through the process, explaining how to look for the rune, what it should feel like. Cautiously, I followed her instructions.

The rune bloomed into warmth and power as mana channeled into it from my core, and I waited for some revelation, some power to manifest itself.

And it wasn’t that *nothing* happened; there was a certain focusing in on the mana like I was more aware of everyone’s cores and the barrier of mana manifested into the shield, but that was it.

“Perhaps you aren’t able to channel enough mana to properly activate the regalia,” Lyra mused as I explained what I was feeling.

“Here, try this,” Gideon said as he disabled the dome-shaped shield and handed me a large mana crystal, then reactivated the shield again. “Draw on it.”

I glanced at Arthur, who was watching everything carefully, then at Mom, who had both hands over her mouth and practically vibrated with nervous energy.

Closing my eyes, I pulled on the mana trapped inside the crystal and directed it down into the spellform. The sensation of awareness returned, and it felt easier than I remembered to draw on the mana crystal, but no additional effects revealed themselves. I released my control over both crystal and rune with a sigh.

“What am I doing wrong—”

Emily, who had been leaning against the table while everything else was happening, gave a soft moan and collapsed. Arthur moved so quickly I barely saw it, catching her before her head could hit the hard stone and then laying her down gently.

My mother was there only a second later, both hands pressing against

Emily’s pale skin. Mom’s hands gave off a silver glow as she cast some healing spell, but it cut off quickly. She exchanged a look with Arthur as she explained, “She’s put herself into a state of backlash. I can’t heal her, but she should be all right, given time.”

Gideon shifted his weight from one foot to the other and bit his lip to stay quiet. Seemingly without thinking, he flipped the switch, turning off the shield that contained me within the runes.

I went to Emily’s side, kneeling next to my brother and taking her hand. Her eyes fluttered open, but she groaned in pain and closed them again.

There was something…uncomfortable about being near here. The enhanced awareness of mana I’d felt when activating the regalia remained, and the absence of mana in Emily’s core stood out as something wrong or unnatural, something that needed to be corrected—

Mana flowed out of me in white loops, glowing across my skin like an aura, and then maneuvered to Emily’s body, into and through her veins, all the way to her core.

Her ragged breathing softened, and her eyes fluttered open. “Oh!” she gasped, flustered. “G-good morning?”

The light of the mana exchange faded.

Gideon’s pen was scribbling furiously in his notebook, but everyone was quiet as they all turned to stare at me, wide-eyed.

What I had just done, it shouldn't be possible.

409

TASTE OF MAGIC

CECILIA

My insides seethed with nausea as the tempus warp returned us to Taegrin Caelum.

I had failed. Now, I somehow had to face Agrona and explain that failure. The *Legacy* had been defeated by a common Scythe.

Draneeve was waiting for us with a number of attendants. The crimson-haired, half-mad mage bowed deeply as I stepped down, arm in arm with Nico, off the reception platform. “Welcome home, Scythe Nico and Lady Cecilia. The High Sovereign is waiting for you.”

Despite the bone-deep exhaustion that had settled over me, requiring a full day of rest before I could even face the tempus warp, I knew there was no escaping this summons.

Nico knew as well. “Maybe he can help you understand what happened at Aedelgard?” he asked consolingly.

In my previous life, my handlers and the train of scientists and ki-optimization specialists they paraded through my life hadn’t understood what I was—not really. Even the name they gave me, “the Legacy,” seemed born from myth or legend, a term not of their own invention.

But Agrona, *he* understood me. He saw beyond the constraints of his own perception, and by doing so he gained knowledge that was inaccessible to others. But he shared little of what he saw, and he needed to work around my still-human mind, and so we progressed slowly and only when he decided I was ready for more.

“I am ready,” I said, more in answer to my own thoughts than Nico’s question.

Draneeve spun away, his unkempt crimson mop of hair splashing along in his wake. The other attendants—Imbuers, healers, Sentries, anyone who might have been needed on my return—fell into line behind us wordlessly like a flock of ducks mindlessly following their leader.

My eyes were blind to the passing halls of the fortress. Unconsciously, I stared at Draneeve’s crimson and black uniform, the sight of him tethering me like a leash so that my feet could follow where he led, but my thoughts were in Sehz-Clar, stuck there as if a part of me hadn’t really left. I wished to understand why the barrier resisted me. No other mana that I had encountered was outside of my control, not even the purified particles within the bodies of other living beings.

And yet, somehow, Seris had found some way to bind the mana so completely that it resisted even my influence. Not only that, but even an omnidirectional bombardment on multiple fronts from thousands of powerful mages hadn’t shaken anything loose, either. And then there was the Scythe herself…I had already known she was dangerous. All the other Scythes regarded her with a wary combination of respect and fear. Now, I understood why.

At my full strength, I knew that I could have overpowered the mana void technique she used. But I hadn’t been at my full power, and so had allowed her to overwhelm me and push me back.

At least I eliminated her retainer, I thought, but it was a small victory, and there was no pride or pleasure in it.

Draneeve stepped aside at the top of a stair that led down into the lower research levels. Nico was eyeing the stairs apprehensively, like a child afraid of the dark. I wanted to ask him what was wrong, but then glanced again at Draneeve and all the attendants. No, I could ask when we were alone. I didn’t want to draw attention to Nico’s discomfort, and remembering the mana core he had been hiding, I put two and two together.

“The High Sovereign will look for you where the phoenix roosts,” Draneeve said, his voice gravelly, his eyes darting and uncomfortable.

“What’s that supposed to mean?” I asked, confused by the unnecessary

dramatization.

“I know the way,” Nico replied quickly. “You are dismissed, Draneeve.”

Nico took my arm again and led me toward the stairs. I glanced over my shoulder one last time, frowning at Draneeve and the other attendants, but got no more answers from them.

“It was a message,” Nico said after a moment, his voice very low, almost a whisper. “Agrona knows I met her. He…might even know about the core I took.”

“Oh,” I said, then, “Met who?”

“One of his prisoners, an asuran woman. A phoenix. After I was…after you healed me.”

The stairs were cramped enough that it was uncomfortable to walk side by side, and so I slowed, falling into step behind Nico, looking down on him from above. The lower we went, the darker the stairs became, until the black stone steps were almost indistinguishable from the shadows. “Why would it matter that you’ve met this phoenix? Did something happen?” I said after a minute.

Nico’s steps stuttered, and he started to turn around to look up at me. Whatever he was thinking, though, he quickly smothered it and resumed the slow descent. “No.”

I let out a little laugh, but stopped when the darkness swallowed the sound. “I don’t see the problem, Nico.”

“Just…don’t say anything about the core? Even if he knows I took it, don’t admit you know?”

“But I could—”

He stopped his descent fully this time, and I nearly ran into the back of him. “Please?”

“All right,” I said, reaching out to lay a hand on the top of his head but stopping myself. Such little acts of intimacy still gave me horrible, wrenching nausea that I couldn’t escape. *Damned body*, I thought, suddenly angry. “But you shouldn’t fear him so much,” I snapped, venting that anger on the only target I had. “He isn’t a threat to you. Agrona is the key to our future.”

Nico's shoulders went stiff, and he curled in on himself ever so slightly, and I bit my tongue. Guilt and regret immediately overshadowed my anger. Seris's words had shaken him, I knew. I could tell the moment she uttered the foul lie—telling us that Agrona didn't have the power to send us back to our lives—that it had taken root in Nico's mind, and I had watched it grow in him as he watered it with his thoughts and attention.

But what I saw when he turned to glance at me was a smile, and in his eyes, I saw only his trust and love for me. Regardless of what trials we faced, at least I always knew that would be there.

We started moving again, continuing the slow climb down the winding stairs in silence.

It wasn't long before voices began drifting up to us from somewhere below. Nico stopped again, this time holding a hand up to warn me against making any noise. Two voices, those of the Scythes, Viessa and Melzri.

"…treating us like common rabble, it's absurd," Melzri was saying, her voice echoing slightly in the narrow stairwell, low and angry.

"We are lucky to be alive, sister," Viessa replied. The words seemed to creep along the black stone and tickle my ears like a haunting specter. "Take care with your words."

"Tch, what is Agrona doing, anyway?" Melzri hissed. "Sequestering himself away for days at a time, holding back the Wraiths—Vritra's horns, why not send the other basilisks to Sehz-Clar or Dicathen? His treaty with Epheotus is long since dust, along with the elven forests, and yet he has done nothing."

"The lives of asura are long," Viessa said, her tone lightly critical. "What to us may feel like ages, for the High Sovereign is a blink. Perhaps what looks like inaction is in truth only patience."

"Then our failure should hardly matter, should it?" Melzri shot back.

Viessa started to respond, but Nico chose that moment to step down loudly as he descended. Both Viessa and Melzri went dead silent, their footsteps faltering.

When Nico completed another slow revolution of the stairwell and caught sight of them, he stopped, feigning surprise. "What are you two doing down here?"

“None of your business, *little brother*,” Melzri snapped, glaring suspiciously up at us both. “I don’t have to ask why you’re crawling down these steps, of course.” Her eyes burrowed like maggots into mine. “Perhaps the Legacy’s failure will sap some of the sting from our own, or at least make us look better by comparison. I should thank you for that, Lady Cecilia.”

“Enough,” Nico said firmly, starting down the stairs again.

I didn’t have the energy to care about her childish sniping, and I followed Nico wordlessly, eager to get the inevitable confrontation with Agrona over with. Then we could figure out how to take down Seris’s barrier, together.

Viessa shrank against the inner wall to allow Nico to pass, but Melzri stood firmly in the center of the stairs.

“Agrona himself has asked for our presence,” Nico said stiffly. “Would you like to be the reason we are detained? It may not be a particularly dark black mark on your record, but with everything else that’s happened, perhaps it will be the board that broke the wogart’s back.”

Melzri sneered and stepped aside. “I guess I shouldn’t blame you for your urgency. Since Agrona was happy to leave you for dead after your pathetic display at the Victoriad, I’m sure you feel compelled to prove you’re not *entirely* worthless.”

My fists clenched, and a fury of mana sprang unbidden into action around us, slamming Melzri and Viessa against the curved inner wall of the stairwell.

Tendrils of black mana writhed around Viessa, grappling with my own power, trying to extricate her and force me away. I grabbed those tendrils—her power—and wrapped them around Melzri’s throat, squeezing.

“Stop this,” Viessa hissed, her wide eyes staring helplessly at her out-of-control spell.

Soulfire rippled and jumped across Melzri’s skin as she attempted to burn away my influence, but I suppressed her power, holding it down against her, no more dangerous to me than smoke on the wind.

“For far too long, you’ve treated him—a Scythe of Central Dominion!—like a dog you can kick to make yourself feel more powerful,” I said,

grinding the words out between clenched teeth. “Speak to me or Nico in this way again, and I will pull the core from your chest and drink its mana while the light fades from your eyes.”

I released my hold over the mana, and both their spells faded away. Melzri’s hand went to her throat where the void wind had choked her.

Not a single word was spoken as we moved down the stairs past them, and Nico was quiet until he must have been certain they were far above us.

“You shouldn’t have done that,” he said eventually, not stopping or turning to look at me.

“Why?” I asked incredulously, letting out a wry laugh. “The other Scythes become more irrelevant with each passing day. If anything, *you* should be *more* angry. Why aren’t you?”

Nico cleared his throat, then threw a dark scowl back up the stairwell behind us. “Like you said, they are becoming irrelevant. Why waste any feelings on them at all?”

After another minute or two, Nico led us through a door of black stone into a large, rectangular room with a high ceiling. A sudden and unwelcome series of memories flooded into my thoughts as the sight of the sterile space reminded me of the many similar rooms I had seen in my last life: places where I was cut open, drugged, and put through inhumane tests.

Vertigo made my knees tremble, and beyond the sickness of the sensation itself, there was also the deeper underlying shame I felt at being so weak. Only moments ago, I had felt so powerful putting the two Scythes in their place, and yet here I was, ready to curl into a ball and vomit at the sight of a few tables, tools, and bright lights.

“Cecil, are you—”

“Fine,” I muttered, blinking rapidly.

Nico must have understood, because he again put his arm through mine and quickly guided me across the room and into a long hallway. Cells lined both sides, but I had no mind for inspecting them, and Nico seemed to know where we were headed.

When that hallway ended, he led me left into a second, nearly identical series of cells, then stopped in front of the first to contain a living occupant

that I had noticed.

The woman on the other side of the cell's shielding barrier was truly beautiful—or must have been before her captivity. She looked young but felt very old, with tired eyes the color of fire and a smokey gray tint to her skin. It was the way her rich red hair clumped together in the shape of feathers that I found most interesting and beautiful, though.

Her power was suppressed, what little she still had shielded behind the barrier, but I could still sense her mana. It burned beneath the surface like hot coals under a blanket of ash.

"The reincarnate returns," she said, her voice a dim and dying rasp. Those glowing eyes settled on Nico, who shuffled uncomfortably. Then, slowly, as if dragged by force of will, they shifted to me. Several heavy heartbeats passed, then they widened in recognition. "Legacy…"

My lips parted, a question forming on my tongue, but Nico spoke first. "She's an asura, a phoenix. According to her, they have some understanding of rebirth and reincarnation." He seemed distinctly uncomfortable, his eyes never alighting on the asura for more than an instant before he looked away.

Her dry, cracked lips turned up at the corners. "The dragons have their aether arts, the pantheons the art of war. Titans will claim to understand life best of all asura, but they only understand creation, just as the basilisks know corruption and decay. *Life*, and all the many facets that make it up, is the domain of the phoenixes."

"You're being uncharitable, Lady Dawn," a deep voice boomed from just behind me, causing me to twirl around in surprise.

The sight of Agrona never failed to impress upon me a sense of awe. His lithe yet statuesque features maintained an evenness that settled my nerves, as the series of chains and jewels adorning his expansive antlerlike horns caught the light and held my attention.

Beside me, Nico shifted back, away from Agrona, and bowed, his gaze remaining on the floor except for a single glance thrown down the hallway, right of where we'd come from. I knew instinctively the cell must be in that direction, the one he'd taken the dragon's core from. He was wondering if Agrona had been down there, afraid he had been found out.

"High Sovereign Agrona Vritra," I said, not smiling as I used his full title,

something I rarely did. “I’ve come to report my failure to retake Sehz-Clar. The shield proved more robust than I anticipated, and in my weakened state, Seris’s void mana technique—”

He raised a hand, one finger extended, and I went silent immediately. His eyes, like two fathomless pools of rich red wine, drew me in. “It is my fault, Cecil dear, for not seeing the truth of things sooner.” Agrona ran his fingers through my hair, smiling fondly down at me. “I sensed Orlaeth’s signature in the barrier Seris has erected but assumed it was of his design. That may be the case still, but his presence within the magic is much more *literal*, I now realize.”

I reached for my understanding of this world’s technology, but it was still too limited, and I found only confusion.

Nico sucked in a startled breath. “You mean…but how could such a thing even be possible?”

Agrona grinned at Nico, but it wasn’t exactly a pleasant expression. “Orlaeth was a paranoid genius. No doubt he built the shield to protect himself from me, and Seris somehow baited him into a trap. The truth remains, Orlaeth is certainly the power source behind the shielding mechanism.”

I gasped, understanding coming at last. “Like she’s using him as a…a battery?”

“Exactly,” Nico said, one hand running down his face, his eyes losing focus as he looked at something only he could see. “So it wasn’t just about how much mana you could control or how fine your control is, but also the fact that this mana is being controlled by an *asura*.”

“Which has brought us here,” Agrona finished, taking me by the shoulders and turning me around to face the phoenix, Dawn. “If you wish to counter asuran mana arts, you must first taste asuran mana.”

The phoenix clenched her jaw, a muscle twitching in her cheek. Her glowing eyes bore into me like hot pokers. “Touch me, and I’ll burn through you from the inside out, Legacy or not.”

Agrona chuckled darkly. “Lady Dawn, you are hardly in a position to make threats. If you were as vicious or powerful as you wish Cecilia here to believe, perhaps you would not have spent these many years imprisoned under my fortress.”

The phoenix scowled at Agrona, her chest swelling as if she were about to scream, but all energy seemed to leave her at once, and she sagged against her bindings and released a defeated sigh. “Do what you will, then. Death would be better than rotting here any longer.”

“Glad we’re on the same page, so to speak,” Agrona said, releasing my shoulders and waving away the wall of mana that kept her imprisoned. “Be glad that you, in your death, will be more useful than you ever were in your long and wasted life.”

She turned her head away, no longer looking at us.

From the corner of my eye, I caught Nico shifting uncomfortably from one foot to the other, a guilty expression on his pained face. He seemed to realize it himself at the same time and forced his features into a passive blankness.

“W-what do you want me to do?” I asked, looking up at Agrona.

“Take her mana,” he said firmly. “All of it. Every last drop.”

I knew what he intended before I asked the question, and somehow the answer still managed to catch me off guard, sending a tremor down my spine and raising gooseflesh along my arms.

This was different from anything else I’d done. What was it I had thought while kneeling over Nico’s broken body after Grey pierced his core?

It is too cruel to take away magic once someone has felt the joy of it.

This wasn’t just taking a life, or even taking away the phoenix’s magic. I would be draining her life force—the mana that empowered her body and kept her alive—like an oversized leech…

I stared for a long time at the gaunt but beautiful lines of Dawn’s face, and wondered suddenly how old the asura was. She could have been thirty or three hundred or even three thousand years old for all I knew.

How much life could one live with so much time? And yet here she was, bound and powerless, her long life boiled down to this final moment of misery and hopelessness. It really was cruel, that she had to know it would be *her* power used against Agrona’s enemies. If his plan worked, of course.

I didn’t let these musings turn too far inward, however. Didn’t examine my own place in this cruelty. I was only doing what was required to reclaim my real life. One day, I would wake up on Earth, in my own body with Nico at my side, and my time in this world would seem like nothing more than a dream, just like Seris had said…

Agrona shifted, a subtle movement that loudly expressed his impatience, and I stepped toward the phoenix.

She did not meet my eye as I began.

Though her mana was suppressed, particles were still thick within her physical form. While a human’s body needed blood and oxygen, the asura’s also needed mana, and I could see it imbuing every part of her. The hardness of her bones, the strength of her muscles, the durability of her flesh, even the electrical impulses of her mind: it all required mana to operate properly.

Which meant there was still a rather significant amount of mana infusing her body.

I reached out to that mana, gingerly at first. This was no simple mana relocation spell like I’d used against Grey; I wasn’t just trying to evacuate all mana in an area, I was specifically trying to withdraw the mana inside her body and bring it into mine. I would need to purify the asuran mana inside my own core in order to adjust to it.

Her mana answered my call.

It was slow at first, just a trickle. I could sense how she held back, tried to keep the mana in despite outwardly giving up all hope. It was instinctual, I imagined, like pressing a hand to a bleeding wound after seeing the first sudden rush of crimson.

Perhaps, if she’d been in better condition, less weakened by her long imprisonment and mana suppression, I wouldn’t have been able to forcibly take the mana. Or maybe it just would have been more difficult. As it was, there was a moment of back and forth as my will struggled against hers, then her control cracked like the breaking of a dam, and the trickle became a flood.

The phoenix’s face fell, all fight gone out of her, and I thought she looked almost serene…

Something in the mana changed suddenly. Images began to play across my mind, thoughts or memories carried along with the mana, a vague impression of the phoenix's life that leaked into my mind from hers. I saw a flight of massive, winged creatures, huge dragonish bodies covered with ember-orange feathers, long graceful necks ending in fierce hooked beaks, bright orange eyes searching the horizon for their enemies, the dragons.

Then these phoenixes were in their human forms, but they were less of them. Disagreement had burst into shouts, threats, curses, and pleas, which all blended together in the memory. Some wished to stay and fight, others to flee and join the Vritra in the lessers' realm, more still to beg the Indrath clan for forgiveness…but when a man with unruly orange hair and bright yellow eyes raised his hand, the many voices went silent all at once.

Then there were fewer still, far fewer, and they were somewhere else entirely. The background coalesced as the memory focused on it: wild, untamed forests full of mana beasts. A hand on her shoulder, the handsome man with the yellow eyes, a sad smile on his face…

Images flashed past, moving more and more quickly, difficult to digest: dark tunnels and endless days of labor; strange-looking tattooed people intermingling among the asura; the slow growth of towering trees, their silver-gray bark shining like steel in the low light of a hidden underground cavern, their autumn-red and orange leaves fluttering like flames; a child, just a boy, running and laughing, his mismatched eyes—one burning orange, the other icy blue—full of joy and wonder.

A love that wasn't my own warmed my heart and made my own eyes swim with tears…

The backdrop changed again, and I was looking out from the phoenix's cage. The shift from warm to cold was so sudden, I worried I might shatter like glass. Agrona looked back malevolently, a cruel grin like a slash across his face. "Mordain was foolish to expect I'd let his messenger simply walk free after having seen so much of my land and stronghold. I've heard much about you, Lady Dawn of the Asclepius clan, and I find myself *very* much looking forward to testing the bounds of your rumored stoicism."

The phoenix moaned, and the memory wobbled in and out of focus as I experienced days, then months, then years of loneliness, boredom, pain, and regret all forced together into a handful of seconds…then it was over,

the memories were played out, and my mind settled into my own body again.

A warm flush was radiating out from my mana veins and core as the asura's mana filtered into me. The mana itself was pure, as much so as any mana I had ever experienced, but it felt like fire. I wondered idly, in an unoccupied space at the back of my brain, if this was some inborn attribute of the phoenix race, but the rest of my mind stayed focused on the task.

Sweat was building up on my brow, now, both from the warmth and the effort of controlling the mana. Even as it entered my core, it felt like something wild, an animal only half under control, like if I lost focus it would toss me from its back and run free. *Or like it will burn me up from the inside, a wildfire just barely contained. Like she said she would…*

The thought made me clamp down even harder. My teeth clenched until they began to ache, and my core quickly felt swollen and tender. I forgot all about the memories, the threat, banished everything but focusing on maintaining control. But, even as the flow of mana picked up speed, more and more remained inside of the phoenix's body, a massive reservoir that was difficult to wrap my mind around.

No. I had suffered worse than this before. Compared to the outbursts of ki that had wreaked havoc on my body, this was nothing.

"You are starting to feel it, aren't you?" she asked, her voice a breathy whisper barely audible over the pounding of my own pulse in my ears. "Your spirit may carry your potential from one life to the next, Legacy, but you are still wrapped within weak elven skin and bones." Her own skin had lightened into an ashy, sickly gray, and all the fire was gone from her eyes, but her colorless lips still managed to form a wry smirk. "Like the water hen that swallowed the wyvern's core, you'll…burn away…"

Nico was fidgeting stiffly, his hands clenching and unclenching, but Agrona was perfectly still and outwardly calm. If he harbored any concerns that this phoenix could be right, he didn't show it.

He would never let that happen, I told myself. And yet…the more of her mana I took in, the harder it was to contain it, and the more I ached. Pressure was rapidly building in every part of me so that I felt like an overfilled balloon about to burst…

A painful quake shook my core, and I let out an involuntary gasp of agony.

“Cecilia!” Nico said plaintively, reaching toward me.

Agrona’s hand grabbed Nico’s wrist. “Do not interfere.”

I closed my eyes, pushing away these distractions. Agrona said I needed to taste her mana, to absorb it *all*. There was more to it than just that, though, there had to be. Simply *taking* her mana wasn’t going to help me bypass the shield because…

My eyes snapped open.

I needed to *understand*.

Mana was all just mana, that much I knew. It took on the attributes of fire, water, earth, or air depending on the environmental stimulus, and could then be further molded into deviant attributes by an appropriately talented mage, but—aside from purity, something determined by the clarity of a mage’s core—the mana utilized by one mage was identical to any other. Likewise, the mana itself I was pulling from the phoenix should not be different, and yet…

The physically superior asuran body required mana to function, unlike a human body—*or elven*, I thought somewhat awkwardly—and that meant the core, veins, and channels were probably structured differently, too, if for no other reason than mana had to constantly, and automatically, be circulated, in the way my heart kept pumping blood without my needing to focus on flexing and unflexing the muscle.

Does that cycling of mana somehow make it stronger or more pure? I wondered, glad that my mind had a puzzle to work on, which took away from the strain on my body.

A thick stream of mana particles—mostly pure, though intermingled with some freshly absorbed atmospheric mana that kept its natural hue—was running out of the phoenix and being drawn into my mana veins, making us both glow with a bright orange-white light.

It could be both—but it could also be more attuned to the asura’s body… like blood types in a human!

I made this final connection with a sharp breath. “Phoenixes, basilisks, dragons…the form of their purified mana has changed over the ages, hasn’t it?”

I directed the question to the phoenix, then realized that she was too far gone to answer. Her skin, now more pale blue than gray, had tightened unnaturally over her frame, and beneath it the muscles had atrophied and shrunk. The orange had leached from her eyes, leaving them a dull cloudy color.

“It is that evolutionary change that has fueled the deviation in our mana arts,” Agrona said softly.

A sudden spike of pain from my core drew my back inward, and I realized I was at the end of my ability to continue drawing on the phoenix. I immediately lessened my grasp over what little mana remained to her, but a strong hand gripped my elbow painfully.

“No, you *must* take it all in,” Agrona said firmly.

I met his eye, tried to read whatever alien thoughts or emotions shined back at me and failed, then said, “I-I can’t, my core is—”

Then, I experienced a second moment of realization.

Dawn’s entire body had been full of mana, and an asura had to circulate mana at all times to support their body. I lacked the physical attributes that made this possible for them, but I had something else even better.

With a single thought, mana spilled out of my core. Instead of being released from my body or focused into a spell, I guided it through my mana channels, into every limb, every organ, focusing on strengthening my physical form. Instead of stopping there, as most Strikers would, I guided the mana to keep moving, cycling from one part of my body to the next, and eventually back into my core.

Soon, my entire body was infused with mana. This, in turn, eased the pressure on my core and allowed me to drag the last particles of mana from the phoenix’s cold lifeless husk.

I watched where the phoenix mana and my own intermingled, curling in and around each other like flames. Although her mana had been too warm and alien at first, I realized I had already acclimated to it, made it mine, and I knew with absolute certainty that, if faced with a phoenix, I would have no more trouble defending against their spells than I would any other mage.

This thought brought a frown to my face, and I looked at Agrona. Behind

him, Nico was watching me carefully, tense as a compressed spring.

Agrona was grinning, beaming down at me pridefully. “Well done, Cecil.”

“Will it be enough?” I asked, thinking about Seris and her damned shield. “I feel it, the phoenix-attribute mana. I’ve already taken it and made it my own. But the shield…will this insight be enough against basilisk mana?” A tentative thought was worming around in the back of my mind, but I was afraid to give voice to it.

Nico, apparently, had no such compulsions. “Is Sovereign Kiros still imprisoned? Cecilia could—”

“No,” Agrona said firmly, his grin cracking like thin ice. Then softer, letting a shadow of the smile return, he said, “No, that won’t be necessary. I may have other uses for Kiros. An understanding of asuran mana will be enough.”

Nico held my gaze from behind Agrona, making no other move than a slight flaring of his eyes. It was enough to communicate his thoughts.

“There is something else,” I said, flush with the power rolling through me like a firestorm. “I saw other asuras. In Dicathen—in the Beast Glades.”

Agrona’s brows rose as he considered the withered corpse of the phoenix. “Interesting. So, Lady Dawn, all these years protecting Mordain, and you give him up as life leaves you. Tragic.” To me, he said, “Perhaps, after you have eliminated the mild threat that Seris and her rebellion pose, you can sharpen your claws on a real enemy, Cecil dear.”

410

GOOD HUMOR

ARTHUR LEYWIN

“Where’s your pet Alacryan?” Gideon asked, staring around warily as if Lyra Dreide might jump out of the shadows from any direction. His face was soot-stained, and I couldn’t help but notice that his eyebrows were gone again, and part of his hair had been singed. “Not that I want her to see this, but where can you lock up a *retainer* and expect her to stay?”

Next to Gideon, Emily gave me a small wave. She was pale-faced and had dark bags under her eyes, but the fact that she was on her feet at all spoke to the return of her strength. It had only been a couple days since the bestowment test, and without Ellie’s regalia, I felt sure it would have taken Emily several more days to recover.

“I had one of the vaults in the Earthborn Institute fitted out to be a cell,” I said, coming to a stop before the two inventors. “Regis and Mica are watching over her while she coaches my sister on the regalia.”

Gideon huffed as he turned around and started to walk quickly away.

We were standing on the lowest floor of Vildorial, surrounded by freshly constructed stone dwellings, the destruction of the Scythes’ attack on the city already a distant memory—at least physically. I could still see the threat of attack in the furtive glances of the dwarves and elves that bustled about, in the way they avoided small talk and never moved their hands too far from their weapons.

It was with mixed feelings I saw some of that tension melt away whenever they saw me, my presence bolstering their courage.

“You should have all three Lances on her, at least,” Gideon continued after a moment as he led us into a narrow tunnel that I knew connected to some old mining shafts.

“The Lances are not mine to order around,” I pointed out conversationally. A small dwarven boy waved, a huge gap-toothed grin on his round face, and I raised a hand in return, then followed Gideon into the dark tunnel. “Bairon stays by Virion’s side at almost all times, and Virion has been busy tending to his flock. With Dicathen shifting back into our control, he’s been able to reach out to more of the elves scattered around the continent.”

“They’re trying to figure out how many are left…” Emily said softly, her voice hoarse with emotion.

The same despair that clung ragged to her words clawed at the back of my throat, and I had to cough to shake it loose. “Fighting broke out in Kalberk, and Varay went to assist. Apparently, some of the soldiers who fled from Blackbend made it to Kalberk and warned them what was happening. Instead of surrendering, the highbloods in charge of the city locked it down and dug in.”

“All the more reason to forge ahead with my other project,” Gideon insisted, moving quickly despite the dim lighting. “This war isn’t over yet.”

No, it isn’t, I thought, considering what would come next.

I had been trying to put myself in Agrona’s place, using everything I knew about him to gauge his next move. If Kezess fulfilled his end of our agreement, then it was my hope that we’d seen the last of any full-scale battle on Dicathian soil, and it was possible, if perhaps overly hopeful, that Agrona might simply write Dicathen off as more trouble that it was worth and turn his focus to Epheotus.

One particular element made that course unlikely, however: me.

I still didn’t understand how Agrona had come by his knowledge of reincarnation, or how he had been able to search across worlds to find the Legacy and the two anchor points he needed to fully manifest her potential in this world—me and Nico. But, regardless of how he had made these discoveries, their implementation hadn’t gone as he planned. I had been reincarnated on the wrong continent, in the wrong body, and he had been

forced to look outside his own domain for a vessel. Instead of being an anchor point entirely under his control, I became his enemy.

And through the actions of his own daughter, I was given the only power in this world potentially capable of standing up to both Agrona and Kezess.

I was under no illusion that either one of them would just let that go. Kezess was willing to exchange favors for knowledge in a tenuous alliance, but Agrona…

I knew the lord of the Vritra clan couldn't help but want what I had. The idea of striking a similar bargain with him—a trade of aetheric knowledge for his vow to leave Dicathen alone—had crossed my mind, but after much consideration, I also knew there was no vow he could make that I could rely on. And even if I decided to take such a risk, I couldn't consign the entire population of Alacrya to their fate just because Dicathen had been made safe.

Regardless of his intentions toward Dicathen, Agrona would come after me again eventually. I couldn't just sit around Vildorial waiting for that to happen.

These and many other thoughts occupied my mind as we delved into the old mining tunnels.

The tunnels grew hot and stuffy, the rock all around us radiating heat, and the air was thick with a sulfuric burning smell. We passed through several exhausted fire salt veins, the shafts abandoned for more fertile ground, until eventually our tunnel opened into a much larger cavern. Scaffolding had been constructed up the sheer walls and railings hung from the ceiling high above. Thin veins of fire salts were still visible in some places, but their low glow was overshadowed by a series of bright lighting artifacts that had been set up in a grid across the floor.

I was surprised to see six men and women—four dwarves, an elven man, and a human woman—already waiting for us. They had been sitting around a worn worktable and chatting idly but jumped to their feet as a group when they saw us approaching.

"Master Gideon, sir," one of the dwarves said. He had a frizzy mop of dark hair and a beard down to his waist.

"Crohlb, I assume you got the package down here without trouble?"

Gideon asked, moving directly to a stack of metal crates resting on the other side of the table.

"'Course," the dwarf said, grinning. "Glad to finally see these artifacts put to use."

Gideon grabbed the first crate, heaved, immediately failed to move it more than an inch or two, and then turned to two of the other dwarves. "You two, drag this over here and open it up for me."

I watched curiously as the two dwarves together lifted the top crate, moved it to a separate workbench, and then opened the lid. A shimmer of heat haze appeared momentarily above the open crate, accompanied by the same sort of dim orange glow that lit up the darker recesses of the cavern ceiling above.

Gideon pulled on a pair of heavy leather gloves like those used at a forge and then reached into the box. Metal scraped against metal, and Gideon lifted out one of his artifacts. It was a sword with a straight double-edged blade. Curling veins of dim orange swirled and spiraled through the dull gray steel. As I leaned in closer to get a better look, I could feel heat coming off the weapon. The crossguard was slightly too large, almost clunky, with a bastard-style hilt that could be wielded comfortably with one or two hands.

I activated Realmheart, and the cave shifted into a riot of color as the mana particles became visible. Fire-attribute particles clung to the blade, dancing up and down its length along the glowing orange lines. A strong source of mana radiated from the hilt as well.

Gideon held the sword out to me handle first. The dark leather was warm to the touch, but not hot. Gingerly, I ran a finger along the flat of the sword, but pulled back as the scorching heat of the fire salt-infused steel seared my flesh.

Gideon snorted. "I guess I'll have to add a warning label to the hilt that reads 'hey idiot, don't touch the glowing hot steel.'"

I chuckled as I took a step back and swung the blade experimentally. It wasn't the finest craftsmanship I'd ever felt, especially in the balance department, but as these were only Gideon's prototypes, I expected the designs to be refined as more weapons were crafted.

"Infusing the steel worked as we discussed?" I asked, spinning the blade

around and down in a cut that left a heat-haze arc in its wake.

Emily responded through a half-stifled yawn. “The crucible method was genius. Suffusing the fire salts into the melted iron allowed us to get the mineral itself hot enough to liquify, and increasing the carbon content of the steel by infusing it with high-carbon iron allowed the fire salts to bind to the steel, solving two problems at once.”

“Yes, yes, the wunderkind did it again,” Gideon grumbled, though I could tell he wasn’t actually unhappy.

At the center of the workbench rested a small shield generator like the one we’d used during the bestowment testing. Gideon activated it with a pulse of mana, then stepped back and looked at me expectantly. “Go on, touch the blade to the shielding. *Gently* though,” he added quickly. “We don’t need freakish Lance strength right now, I just want you to see.”

Rolling my eyes, I lowered the blade toward the small bubble shield. When the edge contacted the transparent barrier, it hissed and popped, sending off sparks. I raised the edge slightly, breaking the contact, and the noise subsided, though a thin trail of smoke rose from the sword.

Without waiting for further instructions, I pushed the blade down again, harder this time. Sword and shield surged against each other, the mana inherent to the blade’s structure clashing with the mana forming the shield. It lasted a second, two, then…

With a sputtering hum, the shield artifact lost power, and the shield itself popped.

“This is only a very low-power generator, but you see?” Gideon said, his eyes bright. “The fire salts, even in this form, continue to attract fire-attribute mana, creating a strong enough force to counter—and with enough strength, even break through—an opposing mage’s shields.”

I held the weapon up to examine it more closely. There was a sort of trigger embedded into the clunky crossguard. “What’s this do?”

Gideon grinned manically. “A weapon hot enough to sear flesh and capable of countering enemy shields without being imbued with mana was a good starting point, but a non-mage, even a talented warrior, would still be at a disadvantage against an augmenter. The mage can empower his body, strengthening his muscles and enhancing his speed and reaction times. This feature may not entirely counter such overt imbalances

between an augmenter and nonmagical soldier, but it definitely adds to the experience."

"I'm pretty sure Master Gideon just wanted to fit his original cannon idea into the weapon somehow," Emily said under her breath.

Gideon scowled and shooed Emily and the six non-mages back. "Go on, trigger it, but only for a moment. It has the strongest effect if done while swinging the weapon."

Moving back to put even more room between myself and the others, I took a couple more practice swings with the sword, getting used to its heft and balance. Then, as I made a sharp sideways cut from left to right, I pressed the stiff trigger.

Mana rushed from the grip into the blade, and the sword burst into flames. At the same time, it lurched forward as if propelled from behind. I absorbed the unexpected momentum by twirling the blade, releasing the trigger in the act, then bringing it back up in front of me so I could examine the effects.

The orange veins were glowing brightly, although the excess mana was being burnt through very quickly. Perhaps twenty percent of the mana stored in the handle had been expended in that single explosion.

"Eh?" Gideon said, practically vibrating as he shifted his weight from one foot to the other. "When triggered during a forceful movement, the sudden influx of mana into the fire salts causes a violent combustion effect, which can add to the speed and strength of a strike, as well as creating a fiery explosion."

"It's a little unwieldy at the moment," Emily added, "but with the right training, a non-mage soldier should be able to properly time and target pretty devastating strikes with it."

Her words drew my attention to the six non-mages watching quietly from a safe distance. I glanced around the shuttered mine. "What are we doing here?"

Gideon clapped his hands together. "I'm sick and tired of lab tests, that's what. It's time to see these babies in action." He waved toward the rest of the boxes while shouting at the non-mages. "All right, test dummies, grab your equipment and get ready." After a moment, he added, "And make sure to stretch! The last thing I need is my test scuttled because someone

pulled a muscle."

I was staring at Gideon, but he seemed to be purposefully ignoring me. Emily moved to my side, reaching for the sword with a gloved hand. "Sorry, he insisted. You don't have to, but you really are the best choice. If something goes wrong, you can just heal, after all…not that I expect any of these people to even land a hit on you." She smiled, half turned, then said, "Although, if you *let* them get a couple hits in, it would help with the testing."

"I think you need to spend some time away from Gideon, Em," I grumbled, cracking my neck and rolling my shoulders. "You're starting to sound just like him."

As it turned out, these six non-mages had already been training with the weapons, both to test them for Gideon and to prepare for a live combat exercise. Crohlb and the other dwarves had been involved first, but Gideon had gone out of his way to find both a human and elf volunteer with previous combat experience, to ensure the heat and force of the blade wouldn't be too much for someone with a slighter skeletal structure and less genetically tough skin.

It didn't take long for them to get ready, armored in heavy leathers designed to protect them from the heat of the weapons. There were two swords, each with a slightly different design, three battle axes, and one long glaive. As Gideon explained, they wanted to see how the fire salt-infused steel reacted when forged into different shapes, as well as vary the size of the mana-crystal rods that had been inset into the handle of each weapon.

Standing in the center of the large cave, surrounded by the leather-wrapped warriors, I brandished a plain metal rod pulled from some of the abandoned materials—a much safer weapon for the experiment than my conjured aetheric blade.

"Don't go easy on him, you lot. Remember, he's practically immortal, he can take it! Now, get to it!" Gideon's eyes gleamed hungrily from where he and Emily had barricaded themselves behind a much stronger shield generator. Next to him, Emily was hunkering silently over a notebook and quill, ready to take note of everything that happened.

I exchanged a respectful bow with my opponents, then settled back into a loose defensive posture.

The elven man moved first, his glaive slashing downward and exploding into flame the moment Gideon gave the command. But the force of the burst was too powerful for the lithe elf, especially since he couldn't strengthen his body with mana, and the glaive yanked to the side, slamming into the ground in front of Crohlb, who had jumped forward to slash with his ax at my legs. The dwarf tripped over the glaive's handle and went sprawling.

I spun away from the muddle, bringing my piece of iron up to deflect a swing from a sword-wielding dwarf. I made sure to control my movements, working to match the speed and strength of my opponents, otherwise I risked shattering bones or dislocating limbs with my blocks and counterstrikes.

The fire salt sword bit into the iron rod, then exploded in a combustion that singed my face. The sword surged downward, shearing my weapon into two pieces before glancing harmlessly off the aether cladding my skin.

With a short iron bar in each hand, I smacked the sword aside and stepped into a chopping ax, letting it rebound off my unarmored shoulder without trying to block it and instead throwing my forearm into the wielder's chest, not hard enough to injure, but more than enough to send him sprawling onto his back.

The human woman jumped over the fallen dwarf and brought her sword down with both hands toward me. I crossed the short bars over my head to catch the blade between them, but the woman triggered the fire salt burst, creating an explosion of fire and a burst of momentum that forced the searing-hot steel straight through the remainder of my iron rod.

Taking a short step back, I purposefully let the blade's glowing point claw across my front. To my surprise, it seared through the thin skin of aether that always clad my body and scored a line across the front of my shirt and into my flesh before slamming into the ground at my feet, driving into the solid rock.

The woman's eyes went wide, and she started to mumble out what I'm certain was meant to be an apology, but the words never manifested. Gripped tightly in both her hands, the trigger was still compressed, and mana built rapidly in the blade until it vibrated. Before I could warn her to release it, the sword exploded.

A storm of flames and steel shrapnel engulfed us.

Lunging forward, I wrapped my arms around the woman as she rocked back, lifting her off her feet and pulling her leather-covered body close against mine. The aether pathways revealed by God Step were humming to me before I even thought to look, and I stepped into them.

We appeared in a flash of purple lightning while the white-orange flames of the sword's explosion were still erupting behind us. Hot steel shards pinged into stone all over the chamber, so hot and fast they buried themselves into the hard stone walls, floor, and ceiling.

The others dove away from the blast, covering up as best they could, their heavy leather armor providing good protection against the heat but very little against razor-sharp shrapnel.

The woman's panicked panting as she struggled to rip off her protective helmet forced my attention back to her. She was clawing at the helmet with one hand while her other trembled violently in her lap. I helped to unbuckle the helmet, and she tossed it aside. Her face was red with exertion and the heat of her armor, but she began rapidly paling as she stared at me in horror.

Looking down, I realized my torso was peppered with small wounds. As I watched, the line she'd drawn down my chest with the tip of her blade and the many smaller punctures healed over, in some cases pushing out small fragments of the sword, which clinked on the ground at my feet.

"After *all* our *training*, ugh," Gideon grumbled, coming out from behind the shield. "Rule number two, don't hold down the trigger!"

"Is anyone hurt?" Emily asked weakly, staring at a crater in the stone where the woman's sword had been.

I glanced around the space, but it didn't seem as if anyone had been badly wounded. I appeared to have absorbed a significant amount of the shrapnel, so that even the human woman only had superficial cuts and scrapes from the shards themselves, although I could tell from the holes burned in her armor that there had been a few near misses as well.

It went wrong so fast, I thought sourly, listening to the other combatants calling out to one another to make sure everyone was okay. *If I'd have thought more quickly, I could have forced the mana to implode instead of explode, or even stabilized the sword itself to prevent the accident entirely.*

This was a problem I had been dimly aware of in the back of my mind but

was highlighted by this incident. As I gained more abilities such as Realmheart, it became more difficult to fully utilize each in combat. Although I could teleport instantly with the God Step godrune, my reaction times and even my perception were still limited by my own training and physical attributes.

A hiss of pain drew me back to the human woman, who was shaking as she tried to pull off her heavy gloves. Gently, I took hold of the fingers and eased the gloves off her. Underneath, her hand was already turning purple.

“Broken,” I said softly. “But not irreparably so. We have emitters in Vildorial who can heal this painlessly.”

“Emily!” Gideon shouted as he walked up. He chewed on his bottom lip as he stared down at the wound and waited as Emily hurried over, one hand holding her notebook and pen, the other adjusting her glasses as they bounced up and down. “Get Shandrae here to a healer, would you? I suppose I should’ve had an emitter on standby, just in case, but then, I didn’t expect one of you to *immediately* forget the rules and…” Gideon trailed off as Emily, Shandrae, and I all gave him meaningful looks. “Bah, give me that,” he said, plucking the notebook out of her grasp. “The rest of you, back to your places. We go again.”

Emily wrapped her arm around Shandrae and helped her up. The woman’s face had finally settled on green, and she couldn’t take her eyes off her shattered hand and wrist.

“And for the love of life itself, *don’t hold down the damned trigger*,” Gideon snapped, watching Emily and Shandrae stumble from the cavern.

The experimentation with the fire salt weapons lasted only an hour longer, during which time there were no more accidents. After wrapping up, providing my feedback to Gideon, and wishing the rest well, I hurried back into the city to check on my sister.

Leaving her with an enemy retainer, even on the other side of a mana-repressing cell door watched over by a Lance and my own companion, had been uncomfortable. When I returned, however, it was to the sound of Ellie howling with laughter, the noise of it carrying far down the halls of the Earthborn Institute.

When I rounded the corner that brought Lyra's cell into sight, I found Ellie sitting cross-legged on a mat in front of the cell, curled over in breathless glee, while Regis pranced around on his hind two legs, flailing as if he were in terrible pain. Mica was gasping for breath, one balled fist pounding on the wall and she, too, seemed entirely overtaken by hilarity.

"No, Regis, it's the only way," he was rumbling in a cartoonishly affected baritone. "I just *have* to boil myself in lava, I can't *possibly* do this without —" He caught sight of me and stopped suddenly, then slowly sank down on all fours. "Oh, hey there, boss…"

Ellie's eyes opened, and she pointed at me and laughed so hard that snot spurted from her nose. Mica gave a wild snort, and the two only laughed harder.

Once I was close enough to meet Lyra's eye through the bars, I gave her a serious frown. "Are you messing with their brains or something with your sound-attribute spells?"

Lyra, who was leaning against the inside wall with her arms crossed, shrugged. "No, your summons has proved ample distraction without me doing anything. I was happy exploring the depths of your sister's new regalia, but I won't pretend not to have enjoyed his stories about your time in the Relictombs. You really *have* seen and done some strange things, Regent Leywin."

Mica was struggling to stand up straight and suppress her fit of giggles. Her jaw was clenched tight, but both her lips and a muscle in her cheek were twitching constantly. She threw me a lazy salute and said, "Welcome back, General Masochist. The Alacryan has been surprisingly well-behaved."

"Thank you, Mica," I said with a bone-deep sigh. To Ellie, I asked, "Did you accomplish anything?"

Wiping tears from her eyes, she grinned up at me. "I'm figuring things out, I think. It's hard—not hard, weird. Like…relearning how to use magic from the beginning. But there is all this power there, ready to respond. Lyra thinks I'll need to grow into the regalia."

Lyra moved to the front of the cell, standing just inside the runed bars. "I'm not entirely certain regalia is even the correct term. This ability of yours to impact the bestowment, it is…" She trailed off with a shake of her

head, her lips curling up wryly. “The High Sovereign would pull off his own horns to be able to do what you can, I’m certain of it. The rune she received is powerful, beyond what I’ve seen received even by other retainers or the Scythes themselves. To be honest, it is too much for her.

“The purpose of mastering a lower rune before gaining a crest, emblem, or regalia is to build a mage’s strength and magical talent. Most mages never receive an emblem, much less a regalia. Your sister, well, I’m not sure she’ll ever be able to make use of this regalia properly. It will require a significant strengthening and clarification of her core to fully control.

“Beyond that, as I have attempted to make clear to her, it is also quite dangerous. If she pushes too hard, the rune could empty her core and leave her crippled.”

I didn’t respond immediately, instead taking the time to digest Lyra’s words as I looked down at my sister. Her ash-brown hair—the same color as our father’s—was slightly disheveled. As the retainer had talked, the mirthful expression had slowly slid off Ellie’s face, replaced by a small but determined frown, making her look more like our mother.

I couldn’t help but be of two minds, both about Ellie and the bestowals in general. Being able to instantly clarify a mage’s—potentially *any* mage’s—core while simultaneously granting them access to a powerful spell could change how Dicathen viewed magic. We could potentially churn out elite mages at a pace previously unheard of. But, to get the best results from this process, I needed to spend a significant amount of time with each mage.

And I’m only one person, I rationalized, knowing this drastically limited the tool’s overall usefulness, at least right now. Also, I’d spent enough time in Alacrya to see how the presence of these spellforms could completely overtake our magical culture. There were benefits, certainly, but the potential dangers were so varied and widespread that it was difficult to see the whole picture.

A deep-set guilt was also already seeping into me for allowing Ellie to get involved. I’d given her this power, knowing it *could* be dangerous, but having such clear confirmation that she could easily harm herself with the spellform reminded me that *I* was responsible for anything that might happen to her.

I looked deep into Ellie’s almond-shaped brown eyes. Beyond the slight

frown that turned down her lips, it was her *eyes* that revealed the depth of her maturity—a depth that felt too deep for her age.

I was aware that during my absence she had stepped up for our mother, for Dicathen, at a level I wish she hadn't had to. Yet, I still thought of her as a child. And because of that, I hadn't allowed myself to trust her, especially not with this newfound power. She was reckless and had proven herself irresponsible on more than one occasion, but she was also perceptive, courageous, and self-sacrificing.

She'd been through far too much to still be considered a child…but she was still much too young to carry the burden of being an adult. But I knew at that moment that I…*we* had no choice. She no longer saw herself as a child, and I needed to stop treating her like one.

Rather than constantly opposing her desires as I tried to force her into a role I was comfortable with, I needed to step back and allow her to grow in the direction she found most rewarding and comfortable.

She needed guidance instead of opposition.

I held back a sigh and forced a smile on my face, then reached out a hand to pull my sister to her feet. She took it, hopping up energetically.

"Come on, El. Walk with me for a bit."

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A FAMILY AFFAIR

OUR STEPS, both light, whispered off the carved stone of the tunnel walls. The low rumble of an earthen grinding was vibrating down through the Earthborn Institute from somewhere in the distance, and everything smelled of dust and stone and damp. I ran my fingers along the sandpaper texture of the stone as we walked, thinking.

"I kind of miss the open sky, don't you?" I asked Ellie.

"Do I ever," she replied wistfully. "It feels like I've completely lost track of time and normalcy while hidden underground. Still, it's better here than the sanctuary. At least we've got more than mushrooms and cave rats to eat."

I didn't apologize out loud—I'd already said those words to her and didn't want to cheapen them further—but I did in my heart. The guilt of knowing I could have returned sooner and didn't still lingered.

Boo was shuffling along in our wake, his thick fur occasionally scratching against the walls, and his claws scraping the floor, making a lot more noise than either Ellie or me. He huffed at the mention of cave rats, nudging Ellie from behind. She laughed, pulled what remained of a piece of salted meat from her bag, and tossed it over her shoulder to him. The bear snapped it out of the air in a single bite.

'Bring me back some snacks, too,' Regis thought to me, obviously keeping tabs on my thoughts despite the distance between us. Much to his annoyance, I had left him to maintain his vigil, standing guard over our retainer prisoner.

"How were things here while I was gone?"

Her narrow shoulders bobbed up and down. “Weird. Most people don’t know how to feel yet. Excited, hopeful, uncertain, terrified…they’re—I don’t know—tougher? Now, I mean. In the early days of the sanctuary, it was just fear. Everyone was waiting to die, every single day, y’know? And I see a lot more smiles, especially from Mom when you’re around. Although, for the elves, it’s worse. Their hope is…complicated.”

“It’s starting to sink in for them,” I said, mulling over her words. “That, even when Dicathen is retaken, they’ll never be able to go home again.”

“Yeah,” Ellie muttered, her eyes on the floor. “Especially the kids. My friend Camellia, it’s like she’s not even a kid at all. I don’t know if that makes sense.”

I stared at my little sister, not yet even sixteen, and completely oblivious to the irony of her statement. “You’re one to talk.”

“That’s different,” she said, blushing slightly. “Besides, the way you treat me, it sure makes me *feel* like I’m still a child…”

I wrapped an arm around her shoulder and pulled her against my side in a walking hug. “Isn’t that what overprotective big brothers are for?”

She huffed but didn’t pull away.

“I don’t know if I’ve said this, but it’s really kind of you to spend so much time helping the elves.”

She bit her lip, hesitant, then words spilled out of her in a rush. “But I’m not—not *really*. What good is that when I can’t *do* anything to make it better?”

I waited to reply as a pair of robed dwarves went by. “It may be *your* compassion that helps the few elves remaining stay hopeful enough to rebuild. You never know how even a small kindness will stick with a person, what it might mean to them. Besides,” I added as an afterthought, “you have your new regalia. Maybe it’ll let you help further when you’ve learned how to use it.”

“But how am I going to master it if you won’t even let me use it,” she pouted, sounding like the fifteen-year-old girl she was.

“I never said that—”

“What if I only do it under careful supervision?” she rushed on, speaking

over me. “Lyra promised to teach me as much as you’ll allow, and Emily and Gideon want to study me thoroughly, and I bet Mom would even watch over the sessions, and if she can heal me from an asuran spear, she can—”

“Ellie,” I said, trying to derail the out-of-control train of her thoughts. “Eleanor!”

She stuttered to a stop, looking slightly chagrined.

“I don’t want to keep you from using your regalia,” I said. The tunnel walls fell away as we exited the Earthborn Institute, coming out into the open courtyard. “But I think it’s best if you only use it when I’m there.”

She opened her mouth, rolled her tongue against her teeth, then took a deep breath. Finally, after she’d collected her thoughts, she said, “Don’t take this the wrong way, big brother, but you’re not exactly around a lot. How am I supposed to progress when you run off to save the world again?”

I slipped my arm off her shoulder and pulled her half into a headlock. “That’s why *you* are coming with me.”

Struggling, she slipped free of my grasp, mussing up her hair in the effort, and stared at me. “Don’t be mean, Arthur. You’re joking…right?”

I shook my head, but felt my smile slacken and grow somber. “When I was your age, I was training in Epheotus with literal deities. Even in my last life, I was training to be king by now. You’ve been given a tremendous power, but you’ll never be able to wield it properly if you don’t test yourself.”

Ellie frowned thoughtfully. "You’ve never talked about your past life before…”

I rubbed the back of my neck, smiling sheepishly. “I know you’re smart enough to have figured it out on your own, but…I should have. After what happened when Mom and Dad found out, I just never built up the courage, I guess.”

“It’s fine…but you owe me a story,” she said, her eyes gleaming. "I want to know more about your past life."

“There will be plenty of time,” I muttered as I turned to keep walking.

“After all, I can’t trust you enough to let you out of my sight.”

She bounced up beside me and punched me in the arm, then quickly slid her arm around mine and held on. “So, since we’re on the subject of how mature and ready I am for danger and stuff, don’t you also think I’m old enough to start dating?”

Stopping midstep, I raised a brow in suspicion. “Huh? Where is this coming from?”

“Just wondering,” she said with an innocent smile.

I peered down into her brown eyes as if I were considering her proposal. “Sure. But my rule hasn’t changed. You can start dating…when your date can beat me in a fight.”

Boo snorted and nodded his agreement, while Ellie pouted, leaning her head against my arm. “Not fair…”

Once we were outside of the Earthborn Institute gates, I stopped and looked around. Aether rushed to imbue the Realmheart godrune, and the world lit up with the visible manifestation of mana. As my body flushed with the warmth of that power, I focused on the sixth sense for mana the ability provided, searching throughout the massive cavern of Vildorial for a specific mana signature.

Two stood out amongst the entire population of the city. One was behind me, lingering somewhere in the Earthborn Institute, but the other was above, in the dwarven capital’s palace. Without explaining further, I led Ellie and Boo up the winding highway, letting Realmheart fade.

The palace guards bowed and opened the doors as I approached. Inside the entry hall, a few members of the dwarven lords’ houses lingered in conversation or leisure. They watched curiously, more than a few gazes focused on my sister as we passed through the massive hall, heading for one of the many passages that led deeper into Lodenhold.

Unlike a more terrestrial castle or fortress, such as the Royal Palace of Etistin, much of Lodenhold was buried within the cavern walls, with tunnels and hallways interconnecting hundreds of individual chambers designed for a wide array of purposes, some of which seemed very alien to me as a human.

Each set of kings and queens had expanded the palace even farther,

constantly seeking to outdo their predecessors with the splendor of their additions, leading to places like the meeting room for the Council of Lords, carved from the heart of an enormous geode. One of the older such additions had been constructed during a time of extraordinary closeness between the elves and dwarves, before the most recent war between Sapin and Elenoir, which saw Darv retreat back into its desert in order to avoid being pulled into the conflict.

The chamber in question was higher than most of the others, and so Ellie and I, with Boo trailing along behind, found ourselves climbing up a long switchback stair. By the time we reached the top Ellie was glistening with a thin sheen of perspiration, her breathing labored despite her efforts to hide it. Boo was grunting mutinously with each step.

“Have you been up here yet?” I asked with a smirk.

She shook her head, apparently having no breath for words.

The stairs opened into a sort of alcove, a small cave hidden behind a fold of rock. It wasn’t until we exited the cave and moved around the jutting stone that we could see the full chamber.

I had to shield my eyes against the bright light, a sharp change from the dimly lit stairs. Slowly, as my eyes adjusted, I was able to take it in properly.

Ellie and I stood at the edge of a large grotto, and for a moment it was easy to forget we were underground. The entire chamber was lit bright as day by floating lights, their radiance warm as the sun. On the ground, thick moss grew like grass, softening and hiding the stone, and a combination of moss and creeping vines turned the walls emerald as well. If you didn’t look right at them, it almost felt like you were surrounded by a dense forest.

About thirty feet up the walls, the green gave way to black, as the entire domed roof was carved of obsidian, which caught the light and reflected it in every direction, twinkling and shining like the night sky.

A single large tree dominated the center of the chamber. Its boughs spread out for dozens of feet in every direction, covered with broad, bright green leaves and little pink fruits. Supported within its massive boughs was a small structure, which looked as if it had grown into the tree itself, or perhaps out of it.

“The Elshire Grove,” I announced quietly.

Beside me, Ellie’s mouth fell open in wonder. “It’s beautiful…”

It was another voice that spoke next, coming from inside the structure. “A gift from the ancient elven king, Dallion Peacemaker.” Virion stepped out into the false sunlight and leaned on the rail of a balcony that ran around the outside of the dwelling, smiling down at us. “To the dwarven king, Olfred Ironhands, as a symbol of their friendship. The Council of Lords has been kind enough to gift it back to the elves for the duration of our stay here.”

Bairon came out behind Virion and leaned against the door jamb. “This tree very likely represents the last remnant of the Elshire Forest. It is only right that it belongs to the elves, and it should go with you when you eventually leave Vildorial.”

“Perhaps,” Virion said, with the air of someone avoiding a repeated argument. “While it may only take one acorn to plant a forest, Elenoir is a graveyard, and the soil there may never bear life again.” He pulled his attention back to me and Ellie. “It’s not large enough for all the elves to stay here, of course, but I have made sure to invite every elf in Vildorial here at least once, so they may experience this small memory of home. Anyway, we’ll come down to you. I’m sure you have something important to discuss, Arthur, if you went to all the trouble to come up here.”

As Virion and Bairon climbed down a steep series of steps that wound around the trunk of the tree, I led Ellie to a flat patch of moss next to a small brook bubbling away near the edge of the cavern. We each lounged back in the thick, soft moss, which released an earthy, slightly sweet smell as we disturbed it. Boo went to investigate the creek, no doubt hoping to catch a fish or two.

Virion and Bairon joined us only a moment later, the former sitting cross-legged next to us. Bairon stayed standing.

“Any word from Varay on the situation in Kalberk?” Bairon asked.

“Not yet, but if the Alacryans there are as dug in as our early reports suggested, it could take some time.”

“You could have gone yourself,” he suggested, his tone and intentions unclear. “It was good you didn’t,” he added after a moment, giving me a firm nod. “We’ve been underground for too long—literally, in my case—

and the Lances need to be seen, their presence felt."

Virion snorted with amusement, turning to look up Bairon. "An ironic sentiment, since I tried to send *you*, and you refused to go."

"I'm…needed here, at your side," Bairon replied hesitantly, looking down and away. "Varay is the better choice to revive the name of Lance in the hearts of the people."

I felt hope dwindle as I listened to the exchange, feeling I already knew the answer to the question I'd come here to ask, but I forged on. "Well, I'm glad to hear you say that, Virion, because it relates to why I'm here."

Virion returned his gaze to me, the wry smile smoothing out into an impassive curious expression, while behind him Bairon's features hardened.

"The continent is largely back in our hands," I started, considering my words carefully, "and I've extracted a vow from Kezess Indrath himself to help protect Dicathen from further reprisal from Agrona, who is busy minding his own continent, at the moment anyway. But that won't be enough, not in the long run. It's time I return to the task that kept me away for so long…"

Virion leaned forward, resting his chin in his hands. "Yes, I've been expecting this. I…am glad. If it means a chance to bring Tessia back…" Virion cleared his throat, then went quiet.

"If I'm able to gain insight into the aspect of Fate…well, I've already told you everything, but I have hope."

Virion smiled softly, highlighting the wrinkles etched deep into the skin of his face. "Hope is enough, for now. It has to be, because it is all we have." He refocused on me. "Is this a courtesy to inform me you're leaving, or was there something else?"

I sat up, mirroring Virion's cross-legged position. "I don't plan on returning to the Relictombs alone." I glanced meaningfully at Ellie, who had remained quiet throughout the conversation, then looked over Virion's shoulder at Bairon. "I'd like a Lance to come with me as well."

"Absolutely not," Bairon said instantly, his head shaking. "Sorry, Arthur, but Virion needs me here."

Virion patted the ground next to him without looking back at Bairon, who hesitated but eventually gave in and sank down into the soft moss with us.

Sitting stiffly and looking incredibly uncomfortable, he continued. “There are thousands of elven families to reach out to. We’ve started a census, with the goal to reunite as many families as possible. We still don’t even really know how many refugees were able to escape Elenoir after the Alacryan invasion.”

“A noble undertaking,” I acknowledged, “but hardly a job necessary for a Lance.”

Bairon breathed out hard, started to stand, glanced at Virion, and forced himself to be still. “I…wasn’t always kind to others before. You…” He paused, his eyes darting everywhere but me or Ellie. “You know what I was like. You were on the receiving end of it yourself more than once. And yet, after you vanished, when I thought I would never recover from the…from my wounds, Virion and his people cared for me in a way I don’t think anyone had before. They helped me rebuild my strength, and convinced me I had a purpose. *This* is my purpose, Arthur.”

Bairon’s jaw worked silently, and finally, his gaze met mine. “Don’t think I do not yearn to test myself. I can *feel* the potential within me, stretching out into the distance like an open road. The mana from that horn has brought me far, but there is so much more for me to learn and accomplish.” He set his hand on Virion’s forearm. *“After.”*

There was nothing I could say to counter Bairon’s argument. My original interpretation of the situation—that there was little need for a Lance to be involved in such a mundane procedure as a census—was shortsighted and even, perhaps, a little selfish. If Ellie was going to come with me, I needed assistance to make sure she was safe. But I couldn’t ask Bairon to leave behind this work, especially if it meant so much to him.

“I understand,” I said after taking a moment to process these thoughts. “And I appreciate what you’re doing. Elenoir was my home too, after all, even if only for a few years.”

Bairon’s brows rose at that, and he chuckled. “I’d nearly forgotten. It's difficult to think of you as a child.”

I rose to my feet, giving Virion and Bairon a tight smile. “To be fair, I never really was.”

We said our farewells, Ellie and I wished the pair luck, and we began the long descent back down the stairs, hurrying out of the dwarven palace before the Earthborns or Silvershales could try to drag me into some courtly drama, then made our slow way down the spiraling highway.

Ellie was the first to break the silence. “So, you’re really taking me to the place you talked about, the magical dungeon with a whole different world in each room?”

“That’s the one,” I answered.

“Wait, then why didn’t you ask Mica earlier, since she was right there?”

I grimaced and shot my sister a warning look. “Honestly, I thought Bairon would be the more…stable companion for this ascent. The Relictombs can be strange, as can Mica, and the two together…but I expect that to stay between us, got it?”

‘Ooh, I’m telling,’ Regis piped in from afar, his boredom palpable.

Ellie hid her smile behind her hand, stifling a laugh. “She is *really* eager to get out of the city, though. She mentioned it, like, twenty times while I was training with Lyra earlier.” The smile faded, and my sister sobered considerably. “I think the death of the other Lance—Aya?—hit her pretty hard…”

Flashing in and out of Realmheart again, I located Mica’s mana signature, still within the depths of the Earthborn Institute. “Let’s go see if she’ll join us then, shall we?”

“So…we’re just going to do this right here, in…” Lyra paused and looked around the small room with a single bed pressed against the wall. “Is this your bedroom?”

The space was relatively cramped with Lyra, Ellie, Mica, and me all standing awkwardly around the smooth, silver half-sphere of the portal-generating portion of the Compass, which was already projecting an opaque, oil-slick oval into the air above it. Boo had shoved his head and shoulders into the room, and my mother was craning her neck to watch from outside.

“The Compass needs to remain somewhere safe while we ascend through the Relictombs,” I answered. “Here, we’ll have an emitter close at hand if anyone gets injured and we need to return.”

“I won’t go anywhere,” Mom said gravely, standing on her tippy toes to better be seen. Worry lines wrinkled her face, and she pinned me with a sharp look that was both promise and threat: if anything happened to Ellie, there would be hell to pay, but she would be ready. Despite her obligatory parental apprehension, she had approved of the mission, acknowledging her role in arguing for Ellie to become our test subject for the spellforms.

Mica was bouncing excitedly on the balls of her feet. “Come on already, are we going to do this or what?”

Come out as soon as we’re on the other side, I thought to Regis. *I want you focused entirely on—*

‘Protecting little sis, yeah, I know. I’ve got this.’

I took a deep breath and met the other’s eyes in turn.

Mica had eschewed the Lances’ military uniform for a set of heavy dwarven-style armor. Each piece of blocky matte steel was engraved with runes, and there was a shimmer of visible mana projected just a fraction of an inch across her entire body. A circlet of smooth stone covered her forehead, extending down the bridge of her nose like a helm. Subtle runes were etched into the surface. Below it, her eyes, one bright and alive, one a dark gemstone, narrowed in determination.

Ellie stood beside her, a new bow in her left hand, the knuckles white around the grip. It was a simple, graceful recurve bow made from flat black metal, a dwarven design altered to mesh comfortably with Ellie’s pure-mana style of fighting. A gift from Emily to replace the bow she’d designed for Ellie so long ago.

She wore leather and chain to keep herself mobile while still offering some protection. Like Mica’s, her armor was heavily enchanted with protective runes, but I would be relying on Boo, Regis, and myself to keep her safe.

She steeled herself, giving me an almost imperceptible nod.

On Ellie’s other side, Lyra Dreide was draped in bright white armored battlerobes. She’d requested something other than the ash gray and crimson uniform of her previous station, and she looked somehow less

threatening in this new attire.

“Mica, you go first. Lyra will follow right behind you, then me. Ellie, you’re bringing up the rear with Boo.” When everyone had acknowledged their understanding, I focused on Mica. “Watch out for the geysers; the water is acidic and full of…well, you’ll see.”

Mica cracked her neck and conjured a huge earthen war hammer, then plunged into the portal. Lyra cocked an eyebrow at Mica’s back, but followed immediately after, no obvious weapon drawn.

Reaching out, I mimed a soft punch on Ellie’s bicep like she’d done to me earlier. “Deep breaths.” Before she could reply, I stepped into the oily surface of the portal.

And manifested at the edge of a slimy green pool, one of hundreds—perhaps thousands—that made up the floor of the zone. Ten feet to my right, a geyser was mid-explosion, sending acidic sludge spraying dozens of feet in every direction. But Mica and Lyra had already jumped into action, one conjuring a heavy shield of dirt and stone to catch the spray, the other hitting the jet of water with vibrations that interrupted the liquid’s momentum, causing most of the acid to splash harmlessly back into the pools it had originated from.

Regis materialized next to me just as Ellie stumbled from the ascension portal, and he interposed himself between her and a second geyser that burst behind us an instant later. Then Boo was there, pressed against her other side, his bulk barely fitting on the narrow shelf of solid land above the portal.

“We’ll need to move as a group, with one acting as pathfinder through the muck while at least two watch the pools,” Lyra commanded, her sharp eyes darting across the alien landscape. “Regent Leywin, is there any safe place within—”

“Oh, can it,” Mica snapped, already lowering her guard as she followed Lyra’s gaze around the zone, her lip curling up in disdain. “Even the bear outranks your prodigious station of *prisoner*.”

“Wow, it really stinks here,” Ellie muttered from between the living walls on either side of her. “It’s definitely not what I was expect—”

The pool right in front of us began to bubble, and a monstrous beast the size of a horse lunged into the air, the diffused light reflecting off its slimy

skin. A giant slug, blacker than tar and covered in dozens of toothy, snapping maws, arced into the air toward us.

While Mica was still adjusting her grip on the oversized hammer and Lyra's lips were forming a whispered curse, I stepped forward. An aether blade shimmered to life in my fist, moving in a smooth arc that bisected the beast, cleaving it in two and sending the disparate parts flying to either side of the others.

Mica's hammer fell on one writhing half, smashing it to a pulp, while a silent but visible vibration emanated from Lyra, distorting the air around the other half until it suddenly burst apart into green and black slime. Behind them, Ellie held an arrow against the string of her bow, her mouth open in surprise, eyes wide.

"Welcome to the Relictombs," I said somberly.

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THE LIE YOU BELIEVE

NICO SEVER

My fingers drummed across the surface of the charwood staff, the beat creating no discernible rhythm but acting as an outlet for the chaotic energy dancing nervously within me. Though I'd tried to embrace the cold, emotionless state again to help me progress without distraction in my work, the vision of Lady Dawn's shriveled and desiccated body still haunted me, appearing every time I closed my eyes.

It was also impossible to keep up any coherent train of thought with the constant wasp-hum droning of Draneeve in the background, and yet I couldn't bring myself to shut him up. There was something equally comforting about the noise that I had gotten used to over the years of his servitude.

"When I saw you, I think I about died right then and there, horrified into a heart attack," he said, chuckling. He was sitting cross-legged on the floor like a child, rolling a wooden ball around in circles, while I was standing at my workbench and staring down blankly at a collection of artifact parts. "I didn't know—never thought—'cause when I first went to Dicathen, you were safe in the dwarf-home, weren't you?"

He paused, taking a rattling breath, the noise of the rolling ball stopping for just a second, then going on again. "Well, that's what done me in, wasn't it? Bad luck, that was all. Cursed bad luck."

Without looking back at him, I said, "I think disobeying orders and nearly destroying Agrona's plans had something to do with it."

Draneeve let out a simpering noise that was part laugh, part the whine of a

kicked dog. “A cautionary tale, isn’t it? Maybe my ill luck will save some wee little mage a whole catastrophic heap of consequences one day.”

Hearing a strange note in his voice, I turned from my work to look at Draneeve. He had taken off his mask and set it aside. Beneath it, his features were unremarkable. When I’d first been brought home and returned to myself, I had found this lack of interesting scars or gruesome disfigurement both strange and a little disappointing. Even now, despite his constant talking and retelling of the same old stories, he’d never explained why he wore the mask. When asked, he would simply pretend as if he hadn’t heard and change the subject.

Now there was a faraway look in his eyes, and a lopsided grin on his unassuming face. “They’ll call it ‘The Dreary Ballad of Draneeve, the Would-Be Retainer.’ A fable about how ambition, when not tempered with patience and good sense, leads even the *greatest* of heroes to ruin!”

Feeling my brows rise, I licked my lips to speak, caught myself, and suppressed a sigh. Silently acknowledging that any interruption now would only prolong what was to come, I returned my attention to the unfinished artifacts on my workspace and tried to focus, letting Draneeve’s words roll past me like wind against the window panes.

“Our intrepid hero, Draneeve, sought to prove himself in the eyes of the High Sovereign, and so gleefully accepted the most dangerous of tasks. He took an unstable portal to a new and distant land full of strange magic and monsters, where he began the careful process of forging contacts and testing the locals, discovering who among them would be amenable to the High Sovereign’s will.”

Imbuing my regalia, I searched yet again through the now-glowing parts arrayed across my workbench, occasionally shifting them around to see how the different pieces attuned with one another. When I had the pieces I wanted, I moved them closer to an incomplete pair of cylindrical devices, each not much larger than a charcoal pencil. The result was unsatisfying, so I redistributed the individual parts and began again.

“The races of Dicathen were divided, and Draneeve found what he was looking for in the depths of the dwarven kingdom. The desert sands were fertile planting ground for promises of a better future, and Draneeve worked himself up from lords to the king and queen themselves until they agreed to support us.”

I stopped, distracted. This was when my earlier childhood memories were locked away and the persona of Elijah implanted into my mind. Thinking about it now with both sets of memories unlocked caused a dizzy rocking sensation to run up my legs and into my core. So much of the damage Agrona had done to my mind still lingered like scar tissue.

"Networks of spies were established, branching out from Darv and into Sapin, with Draneeve at their head, and a plan formed, a devious and ingenious plan. Draneeve saw an opportunity, weakness in the loose thread that wove the races and nations together, and an eagerness for hostility as they were pushed closer together."

"An old enemy, a spy like Draneeve, a traitor, pushed back at every opportunity, but Dicathen was struggling, and the task of holding it together was far more arduous than that of pulling it apart. But alas, our hero finds failure in success, because in his avarice of ambition, he went beyond the High Sovereign's design, and in doing so threatened a plan of which he knew not, risking the lives of both reincarnates and the vessel for a third yet to come…"

Draneeve trailed off with a long, long sigh.

Choosing a prototype part made with an alloy I'd invented myself, I slotted it into the artifact I'd been feverishly struggling to build. I'd worked without sleep since the moment I had the idea, in the aftermath of Cecilia's altercation with the phoenix, but every step had been a bitter and difficult process. Even as I examined it again under the effects of my regalia, I knew I wouldn't be certain until I actually used the artifacts. There were too many variables, too much that could go wrong…and yet, what other choice did I have?

I considered my other options, as I had been doing every hour for what felt like days, and cast them aside for the last time. No, I'd already made a decision. There was no point in hesitation now.

Turning around again, I looked at Draneeve. He was staring at the ball in his hands.

"And so Draneeve retreated home, removing me from where I was supposed to be and failing even to acquire the vessel," I said, continuing the story for him. "The High Sovereign was furious and nearly had Draneeve executed but felt that was too easy a punishment. And so you were demoted and assigned to be my attendant instead, after which I spent

years trying to make your life as miserable as possible."

Draneeve's eye twitched. "A sad end to our hero's tale—"

He snapped upright suddenly, leaping to his feet as he realized what he was saying, then falling into a deep bow, so low his crimson hair pooled on the floor. "Forgive me, Lord Nico, I did not mean to…to…"

"Agree with me?" I asked, amused despite myself. The moment I noticed my amusement, it soured, and bile rose up in the back of my throat. I felt the childish impulse to apologize but kept the words back. "Draneeve, would you like to be free of this life?"

His back unbent slowly, and when I could see his face again, his uncertainty was obvious. "As difficult as things can be, Lord Nico, I'm… not eager to die."

I blinked at him a few times, then realized the confusion. "Vritra's horns… no, I didn't mean I was going to *kill* you. I need something. I'm hesitant to confess this to anyone, even you, and would only be willing to do so if there is some way I can reciprocate this favor."

Draneeve's eyes slowly widened. "You mean…be released from your service?" He paced quickly left, realized there was no room to pace, and froze. "But the High Sovereign would never allow it. This is my punishment."

"Gee, thanks," I said, giving him a genuine smile. "What if I can release you, help you escape this life? No Agrona, no more punishment. If I could do that, would you help me with something very important?"

He hesitated, his eyes darting away, returning to mine, and then jumping off again several times. "I am already committed to doing as you wish…"

My smile turned slightly predatory. "And reporting everything back to the High Sovereign. But this is something that needs to stay a secret. If you can do that, I will help give you a new life."

The wooden ball clinked against the wall, having rolled slowly away when Draneeve stood, making him flinch.

"I'm sorry for how I've treated you," I said, recognizing the right time for those words. "The spymaster of Dicathen shouldn't flinch at every pin drop. That is, at least in part, my fault. And I'm sorry."

Finally, Draneeve's head bobbed in acknowledgment. "What do you need me to do?"

An hour later, with the finished artifacts stashed in my dimension ring, I hurried along the corridors until I reached the stairs back down to the cells where the phoenix had been imprisoned. The stairs were empty, as they usually were, but when I reached the door at the bottom, I found it sealed shut.

A crystalline panel was mounted to the black stone of the wall beside the door. It sensed certain mana signatures and only opened the door when it found one it recognized. Touching the tip of my staff to the panel, I began cycling different kinds of mana through it, in different strengths, to simulate a variety of mana signatures. It would have been easier if I'd known any of the researchers who worked down here, but still, such a lock wasn't designed to defend against a quadra-elemental mage, and after a couple of minutes, it hummed as the pulling force was deactivated, allowing the door to swing open.

"Scythe Nico?"

I froze halfway through the door. Inside, sitting around a table playing some mundane game, were four guards. Two more had been pacing the room, but their steps faltered at the sight of me. A half-dozen researchers and Imbuers were at work in the room, and they all went stiff and silent as the grave, likely remembering what had happened to the two who'd inspected me after my core was broken.

Straightening, I glowered around at the guards. "What are you doing down here? Lazing? Names, immediately. I'll have you reported to the master-of-arms and see you lashed for avoidance of duty. And you lot," I snapped, directing this at the researchers, "I need the level cleared immediately. Now go!"

The four seated guards leaped up, knocking their chairs about as they hurried to solute. "But S-Scythe, we were assigned here. A new duty shift," one of them said, stumbling over his own tongue in his haste.

Half the researchers had taken a few halting steps toward the door, but they stopped when the guard spoke.

“We’re not supposed to let anyone in who isn’t already assigned to this level,” an older guard said, less shaken than the others. I took him to be the ranking officer and faced him directly. “Even Scythes,” he added after a moment. “This order comes directly from the High Sovereign. Feel free to take it up with him if—”

I moved faster than he could respond. My core wasn’t what it had been, but I still far outstripped normal mages. Grabbing him by the neck of his armor, I lifted him up off the ground. “Then I would suggest you hurry to report my intrusion to the High Sovereign. If you don’t get out of my way, I’ll kill you all. Perhaps his annoyance—and your corresponding punishment—will be less than your lives if you simply choose to leave.”

Setting the man back on the ground, I shoved him toward the door. Not hard enough to send him sprawling, but with enough force that he stumbled several steps before catching himself. As he righted himself, all other eyes turned to him. He seemed to consider for a very long time, then said, “All right, men, out.” When they didn’t immediately respond, he shouted, “Now!”

Everyone lurched into a hurried retreat from the room, Imbuers leaving work half-finished, researchers abandoning their projects, the guards moving to usher them through the door.

As I watched the last few of them rush out, I considered the guards and what they meant. I had expected it to take twenty, maybe thirty minutes for word to spread from the laboratory workers to the point where Agrona would take notice, but the presence of guards could speed or slow that time, depending on how afraid of punishment they were. In the end, though, it changed nothing. If Agrona arrived too soon, all would be lost, but I wasn’t ready to abandon my plan.

Taking out a simple mana detection artifact, I affixed it to the inner edge of the door frame and activated it, then hurried along the corridors to the phoenix’s cell. Her remains had been left there, still strung up by her wrists. If I hadn’t watched Cecilia drain the mana from Lady Dawn, though, I wouldn’t have recognized the body, shriveled and decrepit as it now was.

I turned away. The phoenix wasn’t my reason for being here.

A few cells down, I found Kiros staring wearily out of his mana-shielded cell, as if he’d been waiting for me.

“I need information,” I said without preamble, watching the Sovereign closely.

How he reacted would tell me a lot about his state of mind, and if I had any hope of success, I needed to gauge him accurately.

Kiros loomed less large here, trapped and chained. Some of the bulk around his middle had shrunk, and his marble-gray flesh had gone sallow and murky. Absent all his ornamentation, he seemed much less imposing. But then, who could manage to look intimidating while manacled with their arms out and spikes shoved through their wrists.

Grey could. I ground my teeth as if I could crush the intrusive thought between them, and then took a step closer to Kiros, whose gaze had sharpened, but who hadn’t replied to my statement.

“What do you know about Agrona’s plans for the Legacy?” I asked, growling the question.

Kiros puffed himself up as best he could, lifting his chin and staring down his nose at me. “Scythe or not, how dare a lesser speak to me that way.”

I only stared, unblinking. After a moment, all the bluster oozed out of him, and he deflated.

“The Legacy is a being capable of ultimate control over mana. A weapon to use against the other asuras.” He tried to shrug, but it was a feeble movement chained up as he was. “Always sounded like a fairy story to me.”

“Can she do it?” I said quickly. “Can she destroy asuras, defeat Kezess Indrath and the dragons? Does she have that power?”

He grunted. “Not yet. But maybe someday. If she lives that long.”

“And when she’s completed his mission? What plans does he have, then?” I hadn’t meant to ask this question, but I was surprised by Kiros’s transparency, and my fear for Cecilia surged forward, drowning my other concerns.

Kiros spit phlegmy saliva against the inside of the shield. It sizzled and popped, boiling away in a moment. “The High Sovereign keeps his own council. If he has plans for an *after*, he has not seen fit to share them with the rest of the Vritra clan.” The sneer smoothed out into a cruel smirk. “If I

had to wager, though, I'd guess the same will happen to her as happens to most weapons after a war. They either get put on display or melted down and turned into something more useful, don't they?"

I forced down a half dozen other panicked questions. *This is not relevant, idiot,* I chastised myself.

"And if she wanted to prevent such an outcome? If the Legacy wanted to…preemptively strike back at Agrona himself…" Each word was voiced carefully, my enunciation painstaking and exact as I thought through each syllable. "Perhaps, if you were to be useful enough, there is a future for you outside of this cell."

Kiros was already shaking his head halfway through my speech, his horns scything through the air from side to side. "You're daft. All that muddling about the High Sovereign has done must have scrambled your brains, boy. But…" Kiros trailed off, growing thoughtful. "Perhaps, with me by her side, she *might* have a chance. Release me, and I'll help the girl take Agrona's head."

A mental *ping* of mana notified me that Cecilia had just left the stairwell, passing in front of the device I had planted at the entrance to this floor. There was no more time.

Activating my regalia, I followed the path of the mana, isolating the many individual parts that made the shield function. Within the wall, there were a series of housing units that translated power from mana crystals into the shield itself. Channeling my own mana through the regalia and into the shield, I forced it upstream until it ran back into those housings. The force immediately overloaded one, which caused a cascading failure of the others, and in a handful of seconds, the entire device gave a static crackle and the shield vanished. Kiros stared at me hungrily from within his now-open cell.

"Promise me," I said urgently. "That you'll help her. *Promise*."

"Sure, sure, I promise. On my honor as Sovereign," he said, lapsing into an amused smile. "Just hurry up and release me."

Working quickly, I forced open the manacles. Kiros squirmed as the spike inside his wrist shifted, and I shot him a warning look to be still. Slowly, I eased the rune-covered spike free of his wrist. As I did—interposing my body between Kiros and what I was doing—I very quickly but carefully

stabbed one of my newly created artifacts into the same wound before it could heal over.

“Damn, careful what you’re doing. That hurts,” Kiros moaned.

The artifact was slightly smaller in both length and thickness than the spike, and as soon as it had been inserted and the spike fully removed, the flesh of Kiros’s wrist began to knit back together.

With the second artifact hidden in the palm of my hand, I moved around him and repeated the process on the other side, then much more quickly released the manacles around his ankles.

After releasing the last of the chains, I stepped back.

Kiros groaned, stretching his back and rolling his shoulders. Then, with an almost lazy motion, he backhanded me across the chest, sending me hurtling down the hallway. I felt myself bounce off one of the other shielded cells, then crumpled into a heap on the floor. My vision went in and out for a moment, the hallway wobbling violently around Kiros’s muddled form as he stalked in my direction.

In the distance behind me, a silvery halo of blurry hair peered around the corner…

“Pathetic creatures,” Kiros mused under his breath as he stared down at me. “Why the High Sovereign has such a perverse interest in—”

Kiros spun around, facing Cecilia, who had lifted up off the floor and was flying toward us.

“Perhaps if I take Lord Indrath your heads, I’ll be allowed back into Epheotus!” Kiros shouted at her, his hands coming up as if to wrap around the handle of a weapon. Mana seethed and boiled around him, condensing into a shapeless mass in his fists, then bursting apart again, crashing like a tsunami through the hallway.

I groaned as the force slammed me down into the floor, and lights swam in front of my eyes.

Kiros snarled as even he was struck with enough force to be driven back into the wall by his own failed magic. He stared down at his hands in shock, but he had very little time to wonder what had just happened before Cecilia was on him. Even weakened by imprisonment and limited mana,

he was far superior to Cecilia physically, and his huge hands balled into fists as he crouched and prepared to meet her head on.

Every cell barrier in the hallway blinked out at once, and dozens of sets of chains struck at him, looking like nothing less than metal vipers snapping and lunging to wrap around his arms, legs, throat, and waist, wherever they could find purchase.

“No, release me, I command you!” he shouted, his voice cracking.

Cecilia landed before him, leaning slightly to the side to see around him to me. I only stared back from where I lay awkwardly splayed across the floor, giving no indication if I was alive or dead, although I felt certain she would sense my mana well enough to know I wasn’t fatally wounded. The angrier she was, however, the higher likelihood of success we had.

Mana surged around Kiros again, spilling out of him and choking the breath from me, but Cecilia was unphased. His control over mana was too imprecise with my artifacts implanted directly into his wrists. Every muscle of his towering form flexed against the chains, and a couple even broke with the sound of shearing metal, sending a spray of sharp steel pinging off the walls and ceiling, but for every one that shattered, two more snapped out to bind him.

“What were you thinking, Nico?” Cecilia snapped, again glancing past Kiros to me. I didn’t respond, and so her attention moved back to the struggling Vritra. “You shouldn’t have attacked him. I bore you no ill will, Sovereign Kiros, I was even sorry to see what Agrona was putting you through. So why?”

“A…mistake,” he choked out around the chains, which were imbued with so much mana that they were beginning to glow like metal left in a hot forge. “I can…see that…now. Release me, and I’ll…help you kill him.”

I held my breath. Everything hinged on this moment.

Cecilia’s expression crashed down into a confused scowl. “What?”

“Together…we can kill…Agrona…”

Teeth bared, Cecilia reared back and slashed with her hand. A scythe of cutting wind and white fire bit into the basilisk’s neck and chest, spinning his body half around. The wound had barely left a scratch.

Cecilia pulled the chains tight, but Kiros let out a low, dangerous laugh. Without attempting to channel mana again, he flexed against the chains, and another broke, then another.

"You may be strong enough to drain the life from the shriveled remains of a long-imprisoned phoenix, girl, but *I* am of the Vritra, a Sovereign of this land, this *world*. Your strength is as of yet nothing next to—"

Kiros cut off with a choked gasp. Mana was pouring from him, streaming free like water through a ruptured dam.

Cecilia was taking it.

I did everything I could not to let my smile show through.

Kiros tried to speak, but he couldn't. The chains around him grew continually tighter as his body diminished, shrinking in on itself, the mana that kept it strong and full of vitality no longer present.

Standing, I maneuvered carefully around the web of chains that bound him until I stood at Cecilia's side. Her entire body trembled, and a trickle of blood ran from the corner of her eye like a scarlet teardrop. Although I couldn't see mana particles like she could, I was very aware of the way her physical body seemed to strain against the ocean of basilisk mana. Her core had no room for it, and so it filled every muscle, bone, and organ. Mana was bleeding from her veins into the atmosphere, but even that she grabbed and pulled back. Then, with a gasp, she had finished.

I let out a breath I hadn't known I was holding. "Cecil, are you—"

Suddenly her body was limp and falling. I grabbed her in my arms and eased her to the ground, wiping the blood off her cheek. She was unconscious, but her breath continued steadily, even though her heart was pounding like she'd been running for days on end.

As I stared down at her, hoping this had been the right course of action, another ping warned me of someone else approaching just as I felt the sudden swell of his mana grasping like claws at the entire level.

Spinning, I conjured blood iron spikes from the chains, focusing my entire mind, all my will and mana, on the task. What remained of Kiros's body nearly exploded with them, dozens on dozens rending his withered flesh, pulling him apart into an unrecognizable, bloody mess. I felt a few of the spikes shearing into the fragile artifacts in his wrists, releasing a slow

trickle of Kiros's captured mana.

Just like the last vestiges of mana leaving a dead mage's body.

Then, with terrifying suddenness, I was immobile, entirely frozen, my mind and body no longer connected.

"What is the meaning of this!" Agrona snarled from behind me, his uncontained rage threatening to flay the skin from my bones.

My body spun around to face him, and his scarlet eyes burrowed into mine. I could feel the probing of his magic worming into my brain.

"What happened?" he asked, only slightly calmer.

I swallowed heavily as my facilities were partially returned to me. Not enough that I could move, but I was at least able to blink and speak. "I was talking to Kiros when Cecilia came to find me. She overheard him speaking of treason, and in her rage, she attacked him. His magic overwhelmed her, and she fell unconscious, but he was weak enough that I managed to destroy him before he could do any more harm."

The tendrils in my mind shifted about, poking and prodding each statement to verify its truth. I held that idea very carefully, confirming to myself that every word I'd just said was true.

"But what were you doing down here?" Agrona asked after a long pause, and the tendrils dug deeper. "Why did you threaten those assigned to this level?"

I was suddenly grateful that my body wasn't my own, as I felt the overwhelming urge to squirm with discomfort under Agrona's unblinking gaze. "I was afraid. I wanted to know…I had to ask, if she could really do it. Do the things you expect of her, defeat the other asura clans."

Agrona's thin brows rose in surprise. Then his gaze shifted to the ruined corpse behind me. "Well? Do you have your answer?"

I tried to nod but couldn't. "I—I do, High Sovereign."

I sagged in on myself, my body seeming simultaneously very light and very heavy, but it was mine again. I rubbed my chest where Kiros's backhand had caught me.

Agrona bent low and eased Cecilia's prone form from the floor, cradling

her like a child. As he turned his back on me, he asked, “Did she drink from Kiros’s mana, Nico?”

I stared through him, past him, into the distance, completely out of this world. I imagined I was looking into a new world, a different one. In that alternative version of this world, she hadn’t. I could see it. So clearly. I made myself believe what I was seeing with every fiber of my being. “No, High Sovereign.”

Agrona hummed softly as he carried Cecilia down the hall. Before turning the corner, he glanced behind him and past me to the corpse, where he no doubt saw the last bits of Kiros’s mana trailing off into nothing.

413

FALSE MEMORIES

CECILIA

My entire body quaked with convulsions that I couldn't suppress as the power within me clawed and hammered its way out. Beneath me, the small bed I'd finally come to accept as my own rattled against the floorboard, the wooden frame crackling like pine needles in a fire. My eyes wouldn't close, instead staring wide-eyed around the unadorned room, the line of their gaze determined more by wherever my head bucked and bounced than any intention of mine.

There was a furious punching sensation against the inside of my chest, and for a wild moment, I was certain the power was trying to rip its way out of me. Then I heard voices behind the heavy iron door of my room, and I realized the sensation was only my heartbeat as it gave a sickening lurch.

I wanted to shout out, tell them to go away, that there was no way they could approach. It was too much this time. I could *see* the ki in the air, cutting in every direction.

But the door was opening, and I could not push air through my constricted throat.

Framed within the opening, I could just make out Headmaster Wilbeck and a couple of others. Randall, the big man who helped clean up after all of us children, was leaning forward, one hand up to shield his eyes from the energy whipping around inside my room. He hesitated, and just before he forged forward, a much smaller figure darted into the room in front of him.

Nico, I thought, my heart seizing with equal parts fear and gratitude.

Nico dodged a blast of ki that hit Randall in the chest, lifting the big man up and throwing him back into the wall.

“You can’t!” I said, the words finally grinding out between my clenched teeth. “You’ll get h-hurt.”

But something was wrong. Whether caused by the storm of ki destroying the room or my own weakening sense of perception, Nico was beginning to blur—or rather, Nico stayed brightly, vibrantly clear, the clearest thing in the room, while a blurry halo surrounded him. I tried to focus, but staring at the halo made my head ache terribly.

Nico was crawling toward me, reaching out for me. I couldn’t look right at him, and so turned away, but I could still see him out of the corner of my eye. The crystal clear image of Nico and the fuzzy halo separated into two individual images.

One was Nico, clean and clear, his face set in a heroic grimace as he powered through the onslaught of ki my fit was unleashing.

The other, the blurry image, was a boy our age, sweat pouring down a face twisted in desperation as ki swelled within him.

The bed came apart, the feathers and fabric and chunks of wooden frame swirling up into the air and spiraling around me like they were trapped in a miniature tornado. I felt myself being lifted up. The two boys were as well, Nico pulled to one side, the blurry boy to the other. Every few seconds, they would overlap, becoming one figure, then burst apart again, tumbling end over end.

Then the room was coming apart, then the orphanage, as the storm of my ki grew and grew, peeling away layer after layer of the world and leaving it all bare.

Nico and the blurred boy suddenly split into dozens of copies of themselves, each slightly different, like light through a kaleidoscope. They began to fall like snowflakes, drifting down into as many overlapping scenes, pictures of my life—memories—each one played side by side, Nico—still crisp and visible—going through the same motions as the blur that moved like a shadow just behind him.

My eyes snapped open.

Leaning over, I released the pressure that had been building within me. An

attendant shoved a bucket under my face just in time to catch the contents of my stomach, and someone patted my hair and cooed soft comforting noises.

“Tell the High Sovereign she’s awake,” a disembodied voice said quietly from nearby.

Now that the dream was over, my waking mind could feel the gaps between the dual memories—places in my brain where Agrona had replaced my original memories with manufactured ones. But even acknowledging them was like sticking a finger into an open wound, triggering another wave of vomiting that made my mind go blank.

Grey, I realized, the context of the memories bleeding through the haze obscuring my mind’s eye. *So much Grey in my life…so many empty holes filled in or paved over with Nico…*

Feeling a surge of nauseous panic that triggered another wave of vomiting, I tried to search my memories for the parts much later in our relationship, times I’d never fully come to terms with when seen through this body, terrified of what I would find.

But…those were intact. That was real. Our *love* was real.

As the nausea eased from my tired aching body, I leaned back and closed my eyes, catching only a glimpse of the dark-haired attendant who reached out with a rag to clean my lips and chin.

“There now, love, you just relax,” she said with a hint of Vechorian lilt.

I had no sense of the passage of time and lost all coherence as my thoughts drifted through the inner landscape of my consciousness. I could feel the fault lines between real and manufactured memories in the same way one’s tongue feels the gap of a missing tooth. Without any direct guidance, my mind seemed to rush from memory to memory, exploring the inner depths of itself, mapping out and making sense of the shift in my awareness.

Whether a minute or an hour later, a stifling presence appeared at my side, pushing everything else away to make room for itself.

My eyes fluttered open. Agrona was at my bedside, gazing down at me with a slight frown that communicated both worry and concern.

“How do you feel?” he asked, his scarlet eyes locked onto mine. “My best

doctors and healers have been to see you, and they say that, physically, you are unharmed."

"I'm fine," I assured him, the words feeling scratching in my throat. When the horns spreading above his head tilted slightly, I said, "Honestly. He didn't hurt me."

Agrona, whose hands were clasped behind his back, was entirely motionless as he asked, "Cecilia, can you tell me what you were doing in that cell block?"

I furrowed my brows, putting on a frustrated frown, and looked at my feet. "Forgive me, Agrona. I know I shouldn't have been, but…" I trailed off as I felt the tendrils of Agrona's magic probe my mind. Like fingers kneading the soft tissue of my consciousness, they searched out my thoughts, hunting for both truth and untruth. But…

"Go on," he said, still motionless.

"Nico's attendant, Draneeve, came to me…said that Nico was acting strangely, that he was obsessed with the idea that Sovereign Kiros had information we needed, something he was afraid to ask you. Draneeve said that Nico had snuck down to interrogate the Sovereign, and so I followed."

As I spoke, I kept half my mind on the probing magic. It traced along the pathway of my thoughts and caressed the words as they formed in my head, even before they reached my tongue. I'd felt this same sensation a hundred times before, but something was different just then.

"I should have come to you and told you straight away," I admitted, letting my eyes drift shut. "Kiros tried to kill me."

Strong fingers gripped my chin and turned my head slightly. When I opened my eyes, I was staring up into Agrona's face. "Yes, you should have. Nico was foolish not to ask me his questions directly, and you were foolish for chasing him down to save him. That is a weakness, one easily exploited by those out to do you harm, even right here in Taegrin Caelum. If you truly wish to win me my war and return to your original lives, you need to keep him safe." Agrona's nose wrinkled slightly in distaste. "Especially from himself. Which may mean shortening his leash."

"Yeah, maybe," I said noncommittally.

I always found it difficult to discuss these kinds of things with Agrona. He

made it sound so simple, when in reality it was anything but. Nico was sensitive, self-conscious, and prone to heroics. I knew he felt increasingly sidelined by my increasing power, something he found very difficult to manage. Not because he wanted to be the strongest or most important, but because he wanted to keep me safe.

“Where is he?” I asked, suddenly realizing that Nico hadn’t been present when I’d woken up, and what that might mean. “Nico?”

Agrona gave me an understanding smile and reached out to brush his fingers over my hair. “He’s been temporarily confined until I could gain a more complete understanding of the events with Kiros. I will see that he is released to come see you immediately. Now that I know you are unharmed, though, I’ll leave you to rest.”

He started to turn away, paused, then glanced back at me. “Although, there is one other question I should ask you.” His tone was light, curious, almost nonchalant. “Did you absorb any of Kiros’s mana when he tried to kill you?”

The probing tendrils were still in my mind, but I finally realized what was different than before: he was being reserved, limiting his use of mana.

Is it kindness or something else? I wondered. He’d told me before how dangerous his kind of mental magic could be, if not wielded carefully and by one with appropriate control and insight.

If not for that realization, I don't think I would have had the courage to do what I did.

“No, Agrona. You had forbidden it. Even though it almost cost me my life, I didn’t take any mana from the Sovereign.”

The thin line that formed between his brows was the only outward sign of his feelings. He nodded, setting the ornaments in his horns jangling. I thought he intended to leave, but instead he turned back to me, patting my shin with one hand. “You should focus on processing the phoenix’s lingering mana in your body. Your core is nearing Integration, I can sense it.” He bared his teeth in a hungry smile. “You will be the first in many, many generations of lessers to do so.”

I was silent. The tendrils of magic in my brain had subsided, and I couldn’t read Agrona’s intentions.

“Integration is a strange quirk of your lesser biology,” he mused, looking past me and through the wall into some distant vision only he could see. “For an asura, such a thing is unimaginable. As we grow in strength, our cores grow too. The longer an asura lives, the more they grow. Not in size, but potency and strength. And yet, strangely enough, we are still constrained.”

“In what way?” I asked, hesitating. Agrona was not usually prone to simple conversation, and I felt certain there was some deeper purpose behind his words.

“Integration, I believe, is the key to unlocking a new level of magical understanding. I have pursued it among my followers for decade upon decade, but it has proven quite elusive. Your role as Legacy, however, has put you on the cusp in only a fraction of the time I’ve invested. It is quite remarkable. You ask why the asura are constrained, and I will tell you.” The pressure of his hand on my shin tightened. “We have power, but we do not *evolve*. You lessers, you replicate like insects, and each generation changes, molting the shell of their forebears and becoming something new. In change there is opportunity, and in opportunity *power*.”

“Like…insects?” I asked, almost amused by the unflattering comparison.

Agrona waved his hand dismissively. “Once you have reached the Integration stage, *then* you will be able to fully come into your power as the Legacy. Until then, do not let minor setbacks disrupt your progress. Yesterday’s defeat becomes the lesson that informs tomorrow's victory.”

He straightened and smoothed the rich purple fabric of his shirt. “Beings like the two of us cannot afford to let slip even the smallest of lessons, Cecil. You must absorb it all, internalize every lesson, and then weaponize what you’ve learned. Do you understand?”

I bit the side of my cheek, uncertain if I really did understand, but after a moment I nodded.

“Rest, then, and consider my words,” he said, and then strode away. Only then did I realize I was alone, and that all the attendants and healers had left me.

I sank back into the bed and stared at the nondescript ceiling of my bedroom, forcing each breath in and out, deep and consistent. Despite everything Agrona had said about absorbing and internalizing and

Integration, I found my thoughts drifting away from his unheeded advice and to Nico.

I had always known what Agrona was capable of. When he soothed my emotions or helped me bury *her* memories, I knew what we were doing. He'd even limited my access to my own previous life's memories with my knowledge, waiting until I was strong enough before revealing certain things to me.

But this had been for my own protection, and often at my insistence. Or so I'd thought. Why Nico and Agrona had felt it necessary to change some of these memories, inserting Nico in place of Grey…I couldn't wrap my head around. Much of my relationship with Nico—all the best parts, even—were real and *true*. But they had built him up, tried to make him more…heroic.

And they all but erased Grey from my life. Just to help me hate him?

That had been unnecessary. I hated him on Nico's behalf alone—except, as I examined the emotion building in my chest, I had to acknowledge that it wasn't hate I was feeling. I clamped firmly around the resolve I felt in killing him to free Nico of his rage. That, at least, was still true. I didn't need to hate him to destroy him.

As I considered this and a great many other things, my eyes grew increasingly heavy, and I drifted off to sleep.

It felt as if I'd only closed my eyes for an instant, however, when a small knock at the door woke me again.

"Cecilia?"

A sleepy smile spread over my face. "Come in."

The latch clicked, and Nico stepped into the room. He eased the door shut again behind him, then moved to the foot of the bed, looking at everything everywhere except me. He sat down stiffly, supporting himself on one arm but carefully not touching me. The silence between us built until it was awkward.

"Were they unkind to you?" I asked when I couldn't take it anymore. "If they were I'll—"

"No," he answered belatedly, his voice soft. "Do you…how are you

feeling?”

I watched the side of his face as he stared down at his lap. He was pale—well, more pale than usual—and he had a withdrawn expression. His fingers fidgeted nervously against the side of his leg. Despite the way his body seemed draped in on itself, it was also tense. Something was clearly wrong.

“I’m fine, honestly. Except, well…” I swallowed heavily. “I *lied* to him, Nico. You made me do that. You were letting him *out*, but I don’t understand why. Please, tell me why we did this.”

Nico glanced at me, but only for the barest instant. “I’m sorry, Cecilia.” He went quiet, and I could see him chewing on the inside of his cheek. The silence went on long enough that I didn’t think he was going to answer me, but then he started to speak again. “I’m really glad you’re okay. I didn’t think that—should have guessed Kiros would do something like that. I didn’t want you to get hurt, just thought, well, he could—I don’t even know, really—that if you…um…” He trailed off, cleared his throat, and then looked at me for real.

I sat up, pulled my legs under me so I was sitting cross-legged, and leaned toward him. “You’re lucky Draneeve saw fit to come tell me. If he hadn’t you—you’d be…” As I mentioned Draneeve, Nico’s fist balled up in the fabric of my blanket. “Don’t you go taking this out on him, Nico Sever. It’s because of Draneeve that you’re alive.”

“No, it’s because of you that I’m alive,” he ground out through clenched teeth. “Draneeve is a traitor. You have no idea what he’s done.”

“Is it any worse than what you’ve done? What *I’ve* done?” I asked waspishly, then immediately regretted allowing myself to become frustrated as Nico shrank in on himself. “Let’s just…not fight, okay? I’m sorry.”

He nodded quickly. “I know. Me too.” He searched my eyes for a long time before speaking again. “Are you sure you feel okay? Is anything…different? Y’know, with the basilisk mana,” he added quickly.

Aside from feeling myself unravel one memory at a time? I wanted to say, but I held back. I had no way of knowing how much Nico understood about what Agrona had done, the kinds of changes he had made, and I couldn’t bring myself to ask.

Then, with the uncomfortable recognition of my own stupidity, I suffered the chilling realization that Nico's mind may have been manipulated just like mine. Only, without any way to break through Agrona's magic, he would still be trapped in those false memories. My hesitance to speak about it suddenly seemed almost prescient, as drawing attention to the dual memories without first establishing some kind of framework might trigger any kind of reaction from Nico. He could fly into a rage, or rush straight to Agrona in some kind of preprogrammed response, or have a complete mental breakdown.

Did Agrona replace Grey in your mind too, to make you enemies? I wondered. *Or did he only take the hatred you already felt and fuel it, trimming out the good times and leaving only the bad?* Agrona was like a surgeon with a scalpel, careful in his nicking and cutting. But I had no doubt he could wield his power like an ax if it suited him.

"Cecilia?" Nico asked.

I blinked several times, realizing I had been drawn deep down into my own thoughts. "I was just…inspecting myself, I guess. But no…I don't sense any major changes within me. Perhaps it will make it easier to manipulate the shield around Sehz-Clar, though? I mean, certainly if the phoenix mana would have helped, then basilisk mana has to be even better, right?"

Several emotions seemed to flash across Nico's face at once before he reigned them in. "Yeah, of course. Silver linings, right?" He tried to smile, but it was weak and pained. "Why didn't you tell Agrona?" he asked suddenly, catching me off guard.

"I-I'm not sure…" I stammered, leaning back and letting my head rest against the wall.

Nico resituated himself, sitting more fully on the bed and facing me directly. "And you don't think he knew? He can sense lies…practically read minds, I think."

I shook my head, certain in my earlier observations. "He was holding back for some reason. I think he was afraid to hurt me."

Nico scoffed, but I quickly reached out and took hold of his wrist. "No, listen. I know you've suffered at his hands, Nico, and I'm so, so *sorry* for that. But he does care about us, and about this world, and his own world

beyond it. There is a passion and kindness and loneliness deeply rooted inside him that he keeps wrapped up, but I know it's there. Just like I know he can do what he says…give us a life together, a *real* life, in our own bodies, on our own world."

Despite everything, I knew this to be the truth. Agrona had an inhuman mind, and he did things others might consider immoral, but it wasn't fair to judge him on the morality of lesser beings. My mind was my own, unaltered by any foreign magic, with no outside influence insisting on my loyalty or care, and my feelings about Agrona and this world hadn't changed.

I wished Nico and Agrona hadn't thought it necessary to alter my memories, to hide those things from me, but nothing I saw in these false memories made any difference. My feelings for Grey, perhaps, were more complicated than I had realized; the ghost of his presence in my altered memories had been easier to deal with, simpler, and I could understand why that had been preferable for all of us, even me. But Grey wasn't my priority.

I opened my mouth to continue speaking but choked on the words. A new memory surfaced, but I struggled to make sense of it as two voices spoke out as one, two people playing through the same role, one clear and the other a faded halo, just like in my dream. It was the last memory that Agrona had unlocked for me, and as I relived it—now holding both the fake and real memory together, one laid over the other—my eyes grew slowly wider, my breath shallow and weak.

"Cecilia? Cecil! What's wrong?"

Hands on my shoulders, a gentle shake, warm breath on my face…

"N-nothing," I stammered, struggling to collect myself, unable to hold the present and both memories in my mind simultaneously. "Everything just… caught up with me all of a sudden I guess."

Nico jumped off the bed, running a hand through his black hair nervously. "Of course, I didn't mean to…I'll leave. You need your rest."

As I struggled to keep my eyes open and tear-free, I registered Nico searching my face one last time. Then, without even a farewell, he spun on his heel and bolted from the room.

I slumped over onto my side and curled up into a ball, squeezing my eyes

shut tight to block out the visual present, allowing the split-memory to continue playing behind my eyelids.

In it, underneath the false version crafted by Agrona, I listened to myself say all those bitter, vile things to Grey. I taunted and insulted him, toyed with him…all the things I'd thought he had done to *me*. Except, in the end, after his sword plunged through my body, there was more. Only the false memory snuffed out, allowing what was layered behind it to come into focus.

As his blade pierced through my chest, my blood ran down his hands and arms. My full weight pressed down on him, the hilt of his sword between us, and I wrapped my arms around him, almost like an embrace.

"I'm sorry, Grey. This… was the… only way," I said, blood bubbling in my lungs and staining my lips.

He released the sword, and my body sagged against him. "W-what—why?"

"As long as… I live… Nico will be… imprisoned—used against me."

He stumbled back, and I fell atop him, driving his blade even deeper into me. I let out a gasp of pain, but I barely felt it. Most of my body was already cold.

"No… no, this can't be…" Grey sputtered.

He held me in his arms, trembling until the memory faded to black.

414

SCHOOL IN SESSION

ELEANOR LEYWIN

"This would be much easier if we just *flew*," Mica said grumpily as she wiped a glob of blackish-greenish sludge from her face, all that remained of yet another beast that had attacked us.

"You can't simply bypass the rigors of the Relictombs," Lyra pointed out, sounding exactly like a school teacher. "The point is to *ascend* through them, defeating their challenges, not circumventing them. Otherwise, you gain nothing. Besides, flight is mana intensive, and you'll need to learn to conserve your strength."

"Oh, I'm sorry," Mica scoffed. "I didn't realize this was a day trip to kooky school."

Something flopped in the muck to our right, and my head twitched nervously in that direction. The light in the zone was diffused and hazy, making visibility weird. The green murk hid the distant walls and ceiling, giving the uncomfortably impression that the place just went on forever and ever. It also swallowed sound, making it difficult for me to tell whether it came from right beside us or halfway across the zone.

The smell was the worst, though. Like boiling rotten eggs layered over moldy manure and decomposing animals…

"This might be the first time I *don't* appreciate having your enhanced senses, big guy," I muttered, patting Boo on the back. He rumbled his agreement.

My bond with Boo made me the best scout and lookout, and so I was

sitting on top of him and watching for signs of geysers exploding or terror leeches—a name I'd invented myself—attacking from beneath the acidic pools, while also scanning the horizon for any sign of an exit.

"I wouldn't *need* to conserve mana if Arthur would just show us the way through this place," Mica went on, her knuckles creaking audibly around the haft of her hammer.

"Think of it as your first test," Arthur answered humorlessly.

Catching sight of a dim glimmer through the gloom, I pointed it out to the others. "I think that shiny thing over there might be a portal."

Mica floated up off the ground and squinted in that direction. "Mica doesn't—*I* don't see anything."

Regis chortled in amusement. "Then that means we made the right choice in making Eagle

Eyes here our scout."

"Oh, L-Lyra!" I burst out, catching sight of a crimson ball of slime oozing its way up the back of her boot.

Her head snapped around, and she quickly followed the line of my wide-eyed gaze to the blood slug. Her hand scythed down, and a blade of wind sliced the thing off her. With a sharp stomp, she crushed it. A circle of blood sprayed around her foot like a gory halo.

"You're all getting distracted," Arthur said, his arms crossed and one brow raised judgmentally. "Focus."

Lyra nodded deeply, almost like a shallow bow. "Of course, Regent Leywin. You are correct. During an ascent, one member of the team should always be given leadership authority, even among freshly forged groups. I would suggest—"

Mica scoffed for about the hundredth time and spun toward Lyra, but before she could speak, a massive tentacle snapped out of the pool of acid she was hovering above. I gasped and fumbled with my bow as the tentacle wrapped around her leg.

"Oh, rock and root, get off me!" she cursed, swinging her conjured hammer into the slimy appendage.

Instead of bursting, the tentacle seemed to stretch, absorbing the impact. As it stretched, it sort of melted, coming apart in sticky strands that very obviously defied the normal laws of nature, then solidified again in a loop *around* the hammer, trapping it while still holding Mica. Tendrils of smoke were rising from wherever the acidic tentacle touched her.

I drew the string of my bow and mana formed into a white beam of light nocked against the string. With the twang of release, the arrow drew a bright line through the murky air and struck the tentacle with a wet *thump*.

Mica pulled against the tentacle, attempting to fly upward and break its grip, but it somehow resisted even the strength of a Lance.

Stone spikes thrust up from under the surface of the water, each one pointing in a slightly different direction, many piercing the not-quite-real-looking tentacle, but still it held onto her.

The air began to vibrate. The noise this made was so low I doubted anyone but me could hear it. For a second, I wondered what kind of new monstrosity was attacking us, but then I sensed the mana pouring out of Lyra and into the tentacle. I held my breath for a second as I waited for something to happen, then the tentacle burst apart into a shower of inky, slithering snot blobs.

Boo lurched beneath me, dodging a splattering of the stuff.

“Gross,” Mica said, shaking like a wet dog as she brushed the hissing slime and bits of tentacle off her.

“See, Lance?” Lyra said with a poorly suppressed smirk. “It all comes down to knowledge and your ability to act on said knowledge without panicking. I was able to save you because—”

“I wasn’t panicking!” Mica practically shouted, followed quickly by, “And you didn’t *save* me—”

I jumped so hard I nearly fell off Boo’s back as a flash of violet light suddenly filled the zone, accompanied by a bonfire roar. I looked away, but not quickly enough, and suddenly found myself blinking rapidly as tears came to my stinging eyes. Boo grumbled, backpedaling away from the light and bumping into Regis, who had been walking just behind and beside us. The huge shadow wolf was knocked sideways, sliding down the edge of the raised lip of dirt we had been following until his paws hit the burning goop that filled the pool.

I turned back in time to see dozens of wriggling bits of exploded tentacle dissolving back into the acidic pool, blown away from Lyra by Arthur's aetheric blast.

"I'm sorry!" I said immediately, the words directed somewhere between the cursing Regis and glowering Arthur. "I should have seen that those bits were still moving and alive."

Regis was grumbling as he crawled back up the slope, his paws sizzling. "What a total cluster—"

Arthur shot a glare his way, and the shadow wolf's jaws snapped shut.

Boo gave a quiet grumble, and Regis shook his head in response. "I know, right?"

Mica had already landed back on the ground, and both her and Lyra were looking at Arthur sheepishly.

"For some reason, Ellie is the one apologizing even though she's actually doing the task she's been given," Arthur said pointedly. He ran his fingers through his hair and sighed. "Lyra, you've been in the Relictombs before, but never with me. And Mica, you're used to the Beast Glades, where there isn't much you can't handle. This place is different. The strength of the monsters grows with the people inside, and this whole place has adapted to my presence. You can't rely on just brute-forcing your way past every encounter. You have to be strategic, fight smart. The Relictombs is *designed* to test you…or kill you."

Mica lifted her chin and met my brother's eyes unflinchingly. "I'm not afraid of anything this place can throw at me."

Lyra scoffed but cut off at a warning look from my brother.

"But that's part of the problem. You have no idea what this place can do, and I need you to understand why you're even here. Ellie is travelling with me so she can practice her new ability, and Lyra needs to be kept close to me because I can't leave someone as powerful as her locked up anywhere __"

"Thanks for that vote of confidence," Lyra said under her breath.

"And so I need *you* to keep an eye on them both."

Mica's brows rose so high they vanished into her hairline, and her mouth hung open. It seemed like a rare thing for the dwarven Lance to lack any words, but I was too tense to see the humor in it at that moment.

As Arthur was speaking, I watched another blood slug start to crawl up the back of Mica's leg. "Um, Mica? You've got a…"

She grabbed the pulsating red lump in one hand, gritted her teeth, and squeezed. Crimson pulp oozed out between her fingers. "I understand," she said, tossing the mess into the closest pool of acid with a heavy splash.

"All right, let's get moving again then," Arthur said, gesturing for Mica and Lyra to take the lead.

Moving together, they started off in the direction I'd indicated. Arthur immediately lit up with a dim violet light, his blond hair floating up from his head. I watched him curiously. Even though I'd seen it several times now, it was still kind of eerie. Arthur already looked so different than from before he'd disappeared, and the strange runes only highlighted his alien nature. With Realmheart active, his head turned from side to side and up and down, scanning our surroundings.

As we passed the pool, I was distracted by something strange.

My arrow, the one I'd shot at the tentacle grabbing Mica, was floating on the surface of the acid. Boo, sensing my attention shifting, stopped and let out a grunt.

"What's up?" Regis asked, staring hard into the pool, perhaps expecting some other monstrous manifestation to jump out at us.

"Nothing, it's just…" Mentally, I reached for the arrow. I could feel it, sense the mana still compacted into that form. My regalia tingled, and I realized the arrow was still tethered to me by the spellform. I purposefully released that tether, and the arrow dissolved, the mana dispersing. "That's weird."

Boo whined, informing me that the others had moved on ahead. "Go on, catch up," I said, but my thoughts stayed with the arrow.

I'd always had a talent for forming my pure, elementless mana into shapes outside of my body. Although I didn't do it often, practicing making shapes with Arthur had really helped me to extend the range and power of my arrows. And Helen had taught me how to shoot a mana arrow that

formed into a protective shield around the target instead of harming them. But all the abilities I'd ever learned required me to focus and keep channeling mana, otherwise the effect ended.

Holding out my hand, I pictured a ball. As mana flowed from my core to my palm, the ball appeared, formed of glowing white mana. I tossed the ball aside, where it splashed into one of the pools. It bobbed up and down for a moment, then was batted aside as a tentacle slithered across the acid's surface.

"Don't disturb the pools," Arthur said over his shoulder, his voice vibrating with the energy channeled by Realmheart.

"Sorry," I said immediately, biting my lip.

In my hands, I conjured another ball, taking my focus away from the first, but I was careful not to actively *dismiss* the innate connection my regalia maintained with it. Even though my focus was on the ball in my hands, I could still sense the other one floating in the acid.

Somewhere up ahead, Lyra shouted out, and Mica struck down a terror leech with her huge hammer.

Dismissing the sphere in my hands, I twisted around on Boo to better see the other ball, which was now about fifty feet behind me. The draw on my mana was barely noticeable, but the form seemed unaffected by my lack of focus. Curious, I attempted to manipulate the physical structure of the sphere.

The mana imploded, causing a burst of energy that sent acid spraying up in the air like a miniature geyser.

I spun around, my gaze jumping guiltily to Arthur, but he dismissed the noise after a perfunctory glance, apparently mistaking it for one of the many natural geysers that were going off constantly.

"That was pretty cool," Regis said, plodding up to walk next to Boo as the path widened briefly. "You were using your spellform, right?"

"Oh, um, yeah," I said, feeling awkward. "I'm not really sure what it's doing though—or what I'm doing with it." The rotten-egg smell intensified, drawing my attention to small bubbles forming on the surface of the pool next to us. "On our left!"

An earthen wall sprouted from the ground, curving over us in a half arch, and I heard the spray of sludgy water on the other side. “Thanks,” Mica shot back over her shoulder.

“Try again,” Regis suggested after the noise had passed.

I thought about what I wanted to do for a moment, then began shaping the mana. When I was ready, I tossed it onto the path behind us, but maintained active focus on it, attempting to continue to manipulate the shape so that it moved with us.

A small blob with four stubs for legs trotted stiffly after Boo and Regis, glowing white in the dim light.

I turned around so I wasn’t looking at the conjured figure and scanned our surroundings. When I found what I was looking for, I drew my bow, conjured an arrow, and loosed. The white beam of mana thunked into a fat blood slug that was hunkered at the edge of the path, ready to latch onto the first thing to get close enough.

“Nice shot,” Lyra said, kicking the remains down the ledge.

Quickly looking behind me, I saw that the four-legged blob had stopped moving. It was still there, frozen with its stubby legs lifted as if it was in the middle of taking a step, but it was no longer following us. I tried to start it moving again, but like the sphere in the pool, it burst, creating a nova of mana that expanded outward for several feet before dissipating.

“The mana holds its shape after I stop focusing on it, but I don’t seem to be able to reconnect with it. When I try to change the shape again, it collapses,” I told Regis, glad to have someone to bounce my ideas off of.

“Collapses…or explodes,” Regis shot back, giving me a wolfish grin. “Maybe it’s just because I’m a walking, talking *weapon*, but I wonder… can you make something burst with more energy than that? Maybe if you compact a larger amount of mana into the shape? Or forge it with the intent that it, y’know, goes boom?”

I giggled at the excitement in his tone but went quiet when Arthur cocked his head, turning his ear back toward me.

Is right now really the best time to be playing around with your power? I asked myself with Arthur’s voice. *What if I draw in a bunch more of those monsters? Or something goes wrong, like Lyra said, and I go into*

backlash?

As I considered this, I noticed the golden glow emanating from Arthur's lower back glow brighter. "What's he doing?" I asked aloud, mostly to myself.

"Meditating," Regis answered. "He's been focused on Dicathen and hasn't made much effort to continue improving himself lately. This isn't just a chance for you and the insane dwarf to train. It's his, too."

I set my jaw. That made sense. And if even my invincible god-killing brother was doing what he could to train and become stronger, I had to too.

I didn't worry much about the physical form, just shaped the mana into a kind of very dense disc.

When I was satisfied, I tossed the disc behind us. It landed on the hard dirt with a quiet thud. Inside my head, I disengaged my focus from the mana but left the tether with my regalia intact.

This time I waited until we were almost a hundred feet away from it. There was a dull aching sensation coming from the spellform by then. I was nearing the outer range of the tether. *That's good to know*.

Instead of just trying to change the mana's shape, I specifically attempted to force the mana outward, imagining it as a violent explosion—

A huge *boom* shook the ground and tore the raised lip of solid ground apart, collapsing it into the acid pools on either side. Three geysers went off one after another, set off by the explosion, and several terror leeches and huge tentacles burst out of the acid to slither toward the wreckage.

"What was *that*?" Mica asked, flying back over us and hovering between me and the site of the explosion.

"S-sorry!" I squeaked, my heart fluttering in my chest. "I didn't think that it would be so…so…" Panicking, I pointed at Regis. "It was *his* idea!"

The shadow wolf barked out a gleeful manic laugh. "Hell yeah it was."

Arthur was beside me, one hand resting on Boo. He'd stopped channeling his godrunes, and the alien light that had infused him was gone. "You did that?" he asked, his piercing golden eyes tracking over the collapsed patch of trail. "How?"

A little haltingly, I explained what I had noticed about the arrow and the discoveries that had spiraled from that observation.

As I talked, Arthur activated Realmheart again. “Create something,” he suggested, watching me carefully.

I formed another ball but paused before I did anything with it. Tilting my head slightly to the side, I listened. “Does anyone else feel that?”

Suddenly the ground where my mana mine had gone off ripped apart, churning as if being swarmed by Darvish sand sharks. The handful of terror leeches still milling around the spot disappeared into the ground, where their bodies were pulverized by something I still couldn’t see.

Lyra hurried to Mica’s side between me and the cacophonous noise. Regis started forward with them, but he stopped, shot Arthur a questioning look, then shrugged his shoulders helplessly.

As the ground gave way, something started to surface from beneath it. A wormlike body rose up and up, rivers of muddy acid running down its shining crimson carapace. It was as tall as an Elshire tree before it stopped growing, and I had to wonder how much of it was still hidden beneath the ground. It didn’t have a head, only a huge hole for a mouth, filled with rows and rows of triangular teeth that rotated around within the chasm of its mouth like one of Master Gideon’s crazy inventions.

Even Mica didn’t have anything flippant to say as we all stared at the humongous monster.

The gaping maw bent toward us, unleashing a roar so loud I had to cover my ears with my hands. Three tentacles slithered out of the mouth, each one covered with dozens of smaller, tooth-filled sets of jaws, just like the terror leeches. The tentacles swayed back and forth, each one letting out a low, irritating hissing noise.

“Work together,” Arthur said. “Ellie, you stay back. Regis will be at your side.”

“Let’s get it done then,” Mica said. Cocking back her arm, she hurled her hammer with incredible speed. It hit one of the leech-tentacles and burst straight through, only to turn in the air and zoom back to her hand. “Huh, maybe this won’t be too hard after…all…”

As Mica’s words trailed off, the severed tentacle—*Is it a tongue? Or*

maybe a head?—began to grow back, its stump dividing into two at the base and forming twin leech-tentacle-head things.

“Oh, great,” Mica muttered.

As one, the four heads reared back and sprayed streams of swampy green acidic slime from all their mouths.

Jagged black lines scored the air with a noise like nails on glass, shielding us from the attack. Wherever the acid touched the black lines, it sizzled and seemed to be pulled apart into its base components, steam rising and clear water falling as the mana was destabilized.

But all the noise was drawing other things, too. More terror leeches and blood slugs were swimming through the pools of acid in our direction, coming from all sides.

With a battle cry, Mica threw herself into the air, moving like a ballista bolt. She spun midair, her hammer swelling with mana as she enhanced gravity’s pull on it until she collided with the two freshly grown leech heads.

They burst apart like sacks of half-melted butter, spraying acid in every direction—including all over Mica herself. She gasped in pain but didn’t slow down as she redirected her hammer, swinging at one of the two remaining heads. But it slithered away from the blow, which missed, while the other head snaked around behind her.

From the corner of my eye, I saw a black slash bisect the attacking head so that it peeled apart down the middle, flopping grotesquely. But I had my arrow trained on one of the terror leeches speeding toward us. Waiting for it to crest up out of the thick acid, I aimed for one of the many mouths and loosed. My aim was precise, and the arrow sank into the rubbery flesh and out of sight, but the leech kept coming.

“*Boom*,” Regis said, an unnerving gleam in his eyes.

Following his meaning, I focused on the tether of mana connecting me to the arrow and pushed outward on the mana.

Inside the terror leech, my arrow burst apart with a bass-heavy *whump*. The monster’s sides swelled with the force, then collapsed inward like a deflated waterskin, and it tumbled end over end for a couple of seconds before splashing to a stop, floating on the acid’s surface.

But all I felt was a growing dread as a dozen more followed behind it. “There are too many!”

To compound this, the giant hydra worm had gone from four heads to seven. Mica was flitting around between them, dodging spraying acid and snapping mouths, striking instead at the towering wormy body, but her blows hardly seemed to do any damage.

I released arrow after arrow, each one bursting within a terror leech body and stopping it in its tracks. On the other side of the path, Arthur had started unleashing aetheric blasts to fend off the swarm of monsters from that direction.

A scream drew my attention back to the hydra worm.

One of the heads had finally caught Mica, several mouths biting down on her legs and torso. When she drew her hammer back to strike at it, another coiled around the head of the hammer, holding it fast.

Lyra slashed her hand through the air, but yet another head moved to intercept the spell. The black slash sheared the tentaclelike head from the body, and two more grew in its place.

My heart was racing, and I could feel the panic start to cloud my mind. Drawing my bowstring, I conjured two arrows and used my index finger to part them slightly, giving them different angles. Focusing on maintaining both arrows separately, I took my shot.

The bright white beams flew just inside the two newly formed heads. One sank into a mouth on the trunk holding Mica, but the second missed its mark, impacting against the thick flesh of the second head, which had pinned her hammer.

Both arrows burst in a shockwave of mana.

The head biting Mica shivered and went limp, while the second was jarred forcefully enough that it released her weapon. Wasting no time, Mica shot straight up into the air, only to be followed by several arcing streams of acidic slime. Spinning, she hurled her hammer straight down. Even from a hundred feet away, I felt the swelling of its gravity, and watched as it flew faster and faster until it vanished into the writhing mass of tentaclelike heads.

The ground shook as the hammer impacted somewhere deep inside the

hydra worm's body. It squealed, the humming of its many heads taking on a sickening resonance as it was amplified several times over. My stomach churned, and I distantly felt my body wobble atop Boo's back.

With unfocused eyes, I watched as two more heads grew, splitting off the trunk of the limp head that I'd shot to free Mica. There were so many I could no longer count them…

Lyra spun, sending a vitriolic glare at Arthur. Her voice was barely audible over the continued screeching. "Lesson's will help none of us if we are all *dead*. This beast is matched to *your* strength, not ours!"

The ground shook again. The hydra worm was lunging upward toward Mica, growing taller and taller as its many heads strained after her. She flew straight up until her small form disappeared into the gloom and the fog. The beast on her heels was sixty feet tall, then eighty, then a hundred…

Arthur didn't respond, but something in his posture changed, then he was gone, vanished into a bolt of amethyst lightning.

Regis jumped into action at the same time, his jaws opening and purple fire rolling out over the oncoming horde of terror leeches. Whatever the fire touched vanished, not even ash remaining.

My brother had reappeared above the hydra worm, his distant body wrapped in coiling arcs of purple lightning, a beam of pure violet energy in his hand. Although I should have been helping Regis, I couldn't do anything but watch, all my focus on Arthur. His blade spun in an arc, severing several of the heads.

But the huge maw from which they all grew was still rising, and I could picture how those spinning rows of teeth were closing around Arthur.

At first I thought it was a trick of the light, but by squinting and focusing mana into my eyes, I realized the truth. Arthur's sword was growing, lengthening into a huge two-handed weapon that rivaled Mica's hammer in size. When he slashed again, several heads went tumbling away, including some of those just now regrowing.

Regis had spun to the other side and was unleashing another blast of purple fire that devoured any remaining terror leeches. Mica was out of sight, but Lyra, like me, was just staring up at the fight overhead.

As the heads formed and started to grow again, Arthur kicked off one of the trunks, hurling himself out of the way of the grinding mouth, then brought his huge blade over his head, swinging downward as he fell.

Where Mica's hammer had done little to the hydra worm's armored body, the aether blade cut effortlessly through the side of the gaping maw. As Arthur plummeted downward, he dragged the blade through the beast's body, opening it up like a fileted fish. The humming screech came again, but as more and more of the towering body gaped open above the falling point of light that was Arthur, the noise died into a grotesque gurgle.

Then, feet from the acid pool around the hydra worm's base, Arthur vanished in a violet flash, only to reappear back where he had been seconds earlier, wreathed in electricity.

Black blood and green acid rained down from the gaping insides of the hydra worm as it swayed back and forth, then it tipped toward us, the flaps of its opened body pushed out by the rush of wind. Lyra darted back past us, and Boo moaned as he turned around and trotted farther down the trail, putting more distance between us and where the body would fall.

Arthur and Regis didn't move.

Dirt and acid exploded outward as the corpse struck the ground, crushing the trail we'd been following, the longest of the heads falling just at Arthur's feet. Then I lost sight of everything as a wall of dust and yellow steam engulfed the zone with a noise like the world coming apart.

I closed my eyes against the stinging spray of acid and dust, feeling it prickling along my exposed skin wherever it touched me, despite the mana cladding my skin. Boo rumbled out a worried groan, and I patted his neck comfortingly.

A gust of wind kicked up and pushed the caustic mist away. Arthur and Regis were walking toward me, the fallen hydra worm behind them. Its stench was unimaginable.

I felt Mica approaching before I saw her. She drifted out of the cloud, flying wearily, her skin covered in blisters from all the acid she'd been splashed with. Parts of her armor were ripped open, and blood was oozing from several bite wounds.

Instead of landing on the ground, she settled onto Boo behind me, her back resting against mine so she was facing toward Arthur and Regis. "Mica

thinks this place kind of sucks," she said under her breath.

"You need to practice your mana rotation," Arthur said as he reached us. "You didn't use it at all that entire fight."

I felt Mica's head lean back onto my shoulder. "Yes, Professor Leywin," she mumbled tiredly.

"And you were all distracted by what was in front of you, so you ignored what you couldn't see. The mana fluctuations from the main part of the body—mostly still underground—that happened every time you cut off a head should have told you where to strike." His frustrated gaze focused on me. "Ellie, you should have been the first to notice this. Being on the backlines doesn't mean simply fighting from the back. You need to see the bigger picture and communicate with your allies."

I acutely felt the sting of his rebuke but could only respond with a firm nod, not trusting my voice to speak.

The truth was, in that moment, Arthur didn't even quite feel like my brother. Not here, in the Relictombs. The bond we had been reforming back in Vildorial had stayed there. Here, he was a cold and distant teacher, an emotionless protector…brotherly love was an obstacle, and so he was suppressing it.

I wasn't sure how that made me feel. *I don't think I could isolate my feelings like that. My emotions are a part of who I am. Who is he, really, when he's like this?*

"We should leave this zone quickly," Lyra said, just ahead of me. She was staring warily around at the surrounding pools. "We need rest, but this is no place to set up camp."

Arthur gestured for her to lead the way, and she did so, continuing in the direction where I'd originally seen the distant glimmer of light.

"I've never seen such a strong mana beast," I said into the following silence, trying to reduce the tension. "How did the ancient mages ever create such a thing? And *why*?"

"Alacrya's most talented minds have been trying to figure that out for hundreds of years," Lyra answered over her shoulder. "The ancient mages were a pacifist race, or so we believe. That they created things like this abomination…well, it seems contrary to our understanding of their

nature.”

I was silent for a while, not having expected an answer to my rhetorical question.

“You did well, Eleanor,” she continued. “With practice, you will be able to increase the range and number of conjured creations you can maintain. With enough willpower, you will be able to make more complex and powerful manifestations as well, I am sure.”

I felt Mica shift behind me. “I thought this spellform thing was for handing off mana or something?”

“Oh!” I felt a wave of embarrassment roll through me. Half turning, I set a hand on Mica’s shoulder and focused on my spellform, pushing mana into it. That mana rushed out of me, following the course of Mica’s mana veins into her core. “Sorry, I almost forgot!”

Mica took a deep breath, relaxing against me. “Thanks, kiddo. That’s… better.”

Lyra had turned around to watch us, and I caught her hiding a smile as she faced forward again. “Most runes have multiple levels or phases of activation, becoming more powerful as the bearer grows stronger and gains proficiency in the provided spells. Emblems and regalia often have potent innate effects as well, which do not require activation to provide their benefit.”

Mica shook her head. “Something I still don’t understand, I guess. Why aren’t all the Alacryan soldiers rocking a full-body ink suit of these regalia and stuff then? If one little tattoo can nearly put a teenage girl into the silver core stage, why don’t you guys have entire armies of white core mages? Or even beyond white core—Integration stage mages.”

“Most bestowals do not result in a rune,” Lyra explained. “And when a rune is granted, it generally matches the capabilities of the bearer. Simply performing the ritual more times doesn’t result in more runes. It is said that, in the early days of Alacrya, the Sovereigns attempted to do as you suggested, forcing their subjects to undergo years of forced bestowments, over and over again, even tattooing or burning the marks into their flesh in an attempt to recreate the ancient mages’ powers.

“But this is little different than if your Dicathian mages were to inject ink into your cores. The color of a mage's core is a byproduct of a myriad of

factors, such as lineage, talent, and insight, as is the reception of a spellform for an Alacryan mage.

“Which, of course, explains why these efforts were a dismal failure, and tens of thousands of people died. That, at least in part, led the High Sovereign to combine the bloodlines. The bestowment doesn’t work on asuras, but lesser physiology can be enhanced with asuran blood, creating a new race of beings capable of handling more and stronger runes.”

“That’s so creepy,” I muttered, a shiver running down my spine.

“An entire continent birthed as an experiment in crossbreeding,” Mica said, her tone suggesting she was thinking the same thing I was. “It’s no wonder you’re all absolutely psychotic.”

Lyra’s shoulders stiffened. “One must step beyond the swamp to understand its fetid nature. I promise my pride in being named retainer and regent was no less than yours when you were made a Lance, Mica Earthborn. But experiencing a life outside the iron grip of the Vritra clan, well…”

Her stride slowed, and she looked up into the gloom and mist above us. “At first, I thought it was you Dicathians who were mad. Your disorganized and ramshackle brand of magic, the way you bent the knee to lesser kings and queens like poor imitations of our Sovereigns…and all that *freedom*. How could anything ever get done when every man and woman was free to skitter across the surface of your continent like insects in the dark?

“But the longer I stayed in Dicathen, the clearer it became to me…which of us was mad.”

We walked in silence for a minute or more, growing close enough to the edge of the zone that everyone could see the curving stone wall and the gleaming arched portal that Arthur would use to take us on to the next one.

“How many Dicathians d’you think you’ve killed?” Mica asked suddenly. I could feel her body tense against my back.

“By my own hand?” Lyra asked without hesitation. “Hundreds, I imagine. On my command? Tens of thousands, at the very least.”

Already tired and on edge, my stomach soured at the thought of all that death. *So many people were killed in this war, and for what?*

I glanced over my shoulder at Arthur, expecting him to intervene, to stop Mica and Lyra from falling into another fit of bickering. He was looking away from us, his profile clear against the dim backdrop of the zone, and I realized he wasn't really listening to this conversation. I could see in the set of his shoulders, his stiff gait, the slight frown on his sharp features…

My brother was a million miles away. I wondered which of his many adventures was on his mind now. With the hydra worm's corpse still visible in the distance behind us, it seemed impossible that anyone could be thinking of anything but that fight, but it seemed to be consuming only me.

Arthur had been through so much, and although he'd told me plenty of stories, I knew there was more he was leaving out. Was this talk about the war and all the unnecessary deaths making him feel guilty? *It probably is,* I thought. *He blames himself for not being able to come back sooner. Not being strong enough.*

"And what about you, Lance?" Lyra asked. "How many Alacryans have you killed?"

"Not enough," Mica shot back, hostility oozing from those two simple words. Then, after a second's hesitation, she added, "Or far too many. I won't know, I suppose, until this is all done."

"We're here," I said as the zone wall rose up in front of us, the only breach in the dark stone a single carved arch. The portal inside the frame was softly luminescent, but wherever that portal led, I knew it wasn't where we were going.

Arthur seemed to come back to reality, marching ahead of us and drawing a metallic half-sphere from his dimension storage. "The path forward isn't completely clear," he said as he activated the device.

The opaque portal became translucent, like an open door, and several images melted in and out of focus in quick succession on the other side.

"I have a map in my head, but it's just pictures. The way to the next djinn ruin—the next keystone—is confused. It might take us a few tries."

"We're in this together," I said, immediately embarrassed by the childish optimism that came out in my voice.

Mica slid off Boo's back, her gaze moving from Lyra to me, then to

Arthur. “Hopefully the next zone or whatever smells better than this place, yeah?”

Lyra shook her head, her flame-red hair tumbling around her shoulders. “Rarely do the zones become more pleasant as you ascend farther.”

Mica rolled her eyes and threw up her hands. “So my hopes of us finding a resort complete with hot springs and honey wine are out the window?”

With a humorless smile, Arthur gestured to the portal. “Only one way to find out.”

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THROUGH SMOKE AND SPIRITS

ALARIC MAER

I reread Lady Caera of Highblood-bloody-Denoir's letter for the third time, unsure if it was the alcohol that made the words so insensible or if it was just what she was asking me to do. The bar below was quiet—a sign of the times—which actually made it harder to focus, if anything. I needed noise, movement, action—distraction. I missed the boy, although I would have never admitted it to anyone out loud. He was good for a distraction.

Heaving a great sigh that ended with a foul-tasting belch, I turned the parchment over and leaned back in the rickety wooden chair, glaring around the small room as if it had been insulting toward my mother.

I was back in Aramoor City in Etril, only having narrowly escaped from Itri in Truacia, where I'd been helping to organize the smuggling of weapons and artifacts along the coast and up the Redwater.

A task much more aligned to my skills and interests, I thought darkly, glancing at the back of Lady Denoir's parchment.

But our smuggling efforts had been successful enough to draw the attention of Bivran of the Dead Three, new retainer to the Dominion of Truacia, resulting in a sunk ship, dozens dead, and me running like my life depended on it.

"Just like the old days, huh?" a shadow said from my periphery.

I didn't look straight at her, so she moved around the edge of the room and leaned against the wall right in front of me. "You used to live for this kind of thing."

I scoffed, looking everywhere except at the vision of the woman, whose golden hair framed her sharp face and the hardened brown eyes that seemed to look into me.

Still, I saw as her lips turned up wryly. “You should acknowledge your commanding officer when she’s speaking to you, soldier.”

“Not my commander anymore,” I mumbled, closing my eyes and leaning forward to rest my head on the small desk. “I’m no soldier, and you’re dead.”

She laughed lightly. “All those years trying to get yourself killed in the Relictombs don’t change who you are, Al. You’re still an operator. That’s why you can’t stay out of the fight, no matter how hard you try. Sides may have shifted, but your purpose remains the same.”

I rocked my forehead back and forth, enjoying the feel of the cool wood on my hot skin. “You’re wrong. I *have* changed. I’m not the man I was when you knew me.”

She snorted. “And who could know you better than me? I’m in your head, Al. All that remorse and regret, that *hatred* and *rage* that burns like the core of Mount Nishan and makes you feel like if you don’t do *something* your bones might just vibrate to dust—I can feel all of it.”

I opened my eyes as I straightened up and glared at the vision. “You know what they did. You know *why* I walked away. I’d string Vritra guts from Onaeka to Rosaere if I could, but neither of us could ever be more than a part of their machine. Even as an ascender, it was all for their benefit at the end of the day. The murderous lizards even got you, didn’t they?”

She strode across the room, moving like a shadow, and put her hands on the desk, leaning down to pin me with her steely gaze. “I made my choices. What happened changed my life just as much as it did yours, and you know that. But…” She hesitated, then stood, turned around, and leaned against the edge of the desk, her back to me. “We both could have done better.”

Another figure appeared in the shadows at the corner of the room, beyond my old commander. No, not a single figure. The silhouette of a woman holding a child in her arms…

My hand trembled as I scrambled for a half-full bottle of amber spirits from one of the desk shelves. After clawing at the cork for a few seconds

with weak fingers, I gripped it in my teeth instead, pulling it out and spitting it onto the floor. My eyes closed as the cold glass touched my lips. “Get out of my head, ghosts,” I muttered into the open bottle, then tipped it back.

The satisfying burn of the alcohol trailed down my throat and into my belly, where it radiated out to warm the rest of my body.

I focused on that comforting feeling for a long moment, then half opened one eye, peeking out at the small room. The visions were gone.

“Must be getting old,” I mumbled, giving the bottle a shake. “Sobering up too quickly these days…” Tipping the bottle back again, I drained the remainder of its contents, then set it down heavily on the floor behind the desk.

But I barely had time to do more than sigh with relief before someone was knocking lightly on the door.

“Damn,” I grumbled, grabbing Caera’s letter and stuffing it into an inside pocket of my coat, carelessly crumpling it.

“Sir, your…guests have arrived,” a growling voice said from the other side of the door.

“Yeah, yeah, send them in,” I grumbled.

With a moan, I stood and stretched out my back, which ached from spending too much time in rickety old chairs like this one. I rubbed my hands vigorously over my face and through my beard, then placed them on the desktop, copying the vision’s pose from only a few moments earlier.

The door opened, and a handful of cloaked figures slipped in before closing it once again.

The first stepped forward and pulled back his hood immediately, revealing a carefully groomed noble with dark hair and a goatee. My brows rose of their own accord.

“Highlord Ainsworth. I hadn’t expected you to come personally—”

“What in the *abyss* is happening out there?” he snapped, puffing up like an angry bog hopper. “We’ve received nothing but assurances from Scythe Seris, who is still holed up behind her shield in the south, while the rest of Alacrya remains vulnerable to the High Sovereign’s reprisals. I have yet to

see any tangible benefit of the risks my highblood have undertaken."

Behind him, the other figures, four in all, also lowered their hoods. To Ector's right, a nervous looking Kellen of Highblood Umburter was making a show of examining his fingernails, while to the left, Sulla of Named Blood Drusus, head of the Ascenders Association in Cargidan and an old friend of mine, was looking on with a raised brow. Then there was a surprise, a girl with golden hair trimmed short, the brightness of it highlighting the dark freckles across her face: Lady Enola of Highblood Frost, unless I was very much mistaken.

The final member of this strange group was one of my people, who had shifted to the side slightly, putting room between her and the others.

"And now," Ector continued, his face growing slightly red, "Seris has asked us to directly expose ourselves in a way that will almost *certainly* destroy us. Does she even have a *plan*, or is it simply one desperate action after the next?"

I waited a moment, letting the highblood vent his frustration. Internally, I agreed with him. As eager as I was to strike at the Vritra in any way I could, it seemed to me that our efforts were far too small to do any lasting damage or pose a threat to the High Sovereign's absolute control over our continent.

Still, I had nothing to lose. But for men like Ector, this rebellion was a constant balancing act between fighting for a life without Vritra control and consigning his entire blood to a painful and long-lasting execution.

Not that I have any sympathy for these preening highbloods, I reminded myself.

"I've only just been informed of this new course of action myself," I admitted, unsure what this highblood expected *me* to do or say about it. "It's a risk, I'll admit, but not outside of your highblood abilities."

As Ector ground his teeth, my young spy, an unblooded mage named Sabria, cleared her throat. "Highlord Ainsworth, excuse me sir. Alaric, the two water-attribute emblem-bearers we hired were able to retrieve several of the crates lost from the last shipment from Itri, including the interference artifacts."

I slapped the desk and grinned at Ector. "See? That'll help. And so will these," I added, pulling a wad of fabric out of a basket behind the desk.

After catching it as I tossed it over to him, Ector let the fabric unroll, revealing a set of robes in the purple and black coloring of Stormcove Academy with their cloud and lightning emblem emblazoned across the chest. “What in Vritra’s name am I supposed to do with this?”

“Put it on,” I said, tossing a set to Kellen, Enola, and Sulla as well. “In about thirty minutes, a large group of Stormcove Academy supporters will be marching past this bar on their way to an exhibition tournament between Stormcove and Rivenlight Academies. A handful of our people will be in the crowd. You’ll leave with them, blending in until you can each safely make your way to a tempus warp.”

“Enough with both the complaints and the unnecessary espionage stuff,” Lady Frost said, stepping forward to be on a level with Ector, who she was almost as tall as.

Ector’s jaw clenched as he bit back whatever response had jumped to mind. Personally, between the two of them, I found Enola more intimidating, despite how young she was. And even though, as highlord, Ector outranked her, Highblood Frost was more powerful than Highblood Ainsworth.

“Promises were made. Half of the reason my blood agreed to join this insane venture is because I convinced them that Professor Grey—sorry, *Ascender* Grey was worth it. Lady Caera of the Denoir Highblood assured us he was involved in this, but we haven’t seen or heard from him since the Victoriad.”

“Well, there was that attack in Vechor,” Kellen said with an irritating shrug.

I eyed the girl curiously. Since saying goodbye and sending him through that Relictombs portal, I’d learned much about what Grey—*Arthur Leywin, Lance of the Tri-Union forces of Dicathen*, I reminded myself—had done at Central Academy and the Victoriad, as well as what he’d accomplished in the war before ending up on our shores. *Would she be as eager to follow his leadership if she knew who he really was?* I wondered.

But that wasn’t for me to decide. Scythe Seris Vritra would determine when the people got to know that little detail, or perhaps she would wait for Arthur himself to make it known.

Regardless, much of our support hinged on the high and named bloods’

interest in him.

“He’s the most wanted damned person in Alacrya, isn’t he? You’re not likely to find him strolling about in broad daylight where any old Scythe or Sovereign can catch sight of him,” I grumbled.

“But he *is* out there?” she asked, a note of desperation creeping into her otherwise steady timbre. “Rumors are beginning to spread. Rumors that he has been captured. Some people—even those who were there—insist that he never escaped the Victoriad at all.”

Kellen let out a little laugh. “Of course they’d say that. It’s rather difficult to maintain the illusion of absolute control if someone is actively evading said control, isn’t it?”

Enola turned to glare at him, wiping the smug smile off his face.

I rubbed the bridge of my nose between my callused fingers, already feeling the need for another drink. *Vritra help me that I got saddled with these highbloods*. “He’s out there.”

Sulla, in the dangerous position of being a named blood among highbloods, had carefully avoided interrupting the conversation so far, but he seemed to see his opportunity. “The Ascenders Association has been carefully maneuvering resources in preparation for a call to action. Grey is well-liked and respected among us, although, of course, bringing in new ascenders is still slow and dangerous work—the wrong word in the wrong ear could lead to the entire association being disbanded—but we have a sizable force prepared, along with a significant investment of resources—weapons, artifacts, and the like. All of whom have rallied to his banner.”

I couldn’t help but shake my head, curious what Arthur would think about becoming the rallying cry of this Alacryan rebellion against the Vritra.

Uncomfortable, I’d wager, I thought, amused. *But not as uncomfortable as I am.*

“Just like in Vechor, Grey will make his presence known when it suits him,” I said, fully aware that I was talking out my ass. “For now, we all take our marching orders from Scythe Seris Vritra. Highlord Ainsworth, I can’t speak to the purpose behind her request of your highblood, but I have been instructed to put my entire network of informants and operators at your service. Orchestrating the necessary acquisitions, manipulating the systems in place, and even absorbing the fallout, should there be any.”

Ector looked at me as if I'd just suggested I'd be his concubine for the evening. "While I'm sure your resources are sufficient for what they are, I don't see how *you* can assist *me*, given that this is *my* highblood's direct responsibility."

I shrugged off the insult. A thousand worries hung like knives over my head, and this highlord's respect—or lack thereof—hardly even rated.

Sabria, though, was having none of it. "Oh, I'm sorry Highlord Ainsworth, is there something about this whole rebelling-against-the-gods-themselves thing that isn't living up to your expectations? *What* exactly has your blood sacrificed to be here right now? Because I've lost *three fucking friends* this week alone to loyalist soldiers."

Ector looked disdainfully down his nose at the girl. "Perhaps you and your *friends* should be better at your jobs, then."

"How *dare* you—"

"Enough!" I snapped, staring Sabria down. "You forget yourself. This bickering serves no purpose except to waste time and reduce our readiness. If we're done seeing who can piss the farthest and least accurately, let's continue on with the true purpose of this meeting."

The others—three highblood nobles, a named blood ascender, and an unblooded orphan—went silent, and all attention turned to me. *Life is a bitterly unfunny joke*, I thought to myself. *One that drags on and on, so that by the end of it, you've forgotten where it started and what the punchline was supposed to be.* I took a drag from my hip flask, heedless of the looks this received, especially from the highbloods, and launched into the details of the instructions I had been given.

It took the better part of twenty minutes for Ector and me to get on the same page. Highblood Umburter's assistance wasn't strictly necessary but would make several aspects of the plan a hell of a lot easier. I wasn't entirely sure why Seris had invited the Frosts, except perhaps to keep Ainsworth in line, and maybe force Highlord Frost's hand. He'd been reluctant to take any real risk so far, but I would say putting his great-granddaughter—the shining star of his highblood—right in the thick of things showed he was ready to be involved.

That or he was a sadistically cold-hearted bastard.

As for Sulla, my network and the Ascenders Association tied Seris's whole operation together, and we nearly always had a higher-ranking official involved in these clandestine meetings. I suspected Sulla had come himself for the same reason Ector and young Lady Frost had: they were getting nervous.

"Better get those uniforms on," I said, nodding to the bundles of cloth each of them still held. "Only a few minutes now until the procession arrives, and then you'll need to be quick."

There was a moment of silence as they each pulled on their disguising robes.

"Alaric?" Sabria asked, cocking her head and looking askance at the door.

"Hm?"

"Does it seem quiet to you?"

I focused through the low-grade hum in my ears, listening for the normal clinking of glasses on the bar top or scraping of stools over the much-abused floorboards. But Sabria was right, the bar below was utterly silent.

"Shit, time to—"

The door ripped inward, exploding in a storm of shrapnel that dissipated against a shield rapidly conjured by Kellen.

The doorframe opened onto a pitch-black void.

Leaping over the desk, I shoved Highlord Ainsworth to the side and activated the second phase of my crest, Myopic Decay. Mana vibrated through the air in the room, targeting its inhabitants eyes and buzzing violently to disrupt the focus of their cornea, resulting in heavily blurred vision.

At the same time, I sent a pulse of mana into the floor, activating the mana-cutters I'd installed as a precaution the moment I got back to Aramoor.

But fast as I had moved, our enemy was faster.

An indistinct female form—as much smoke as flesh, except for the bright white of her short hair—drifted out of the void, seeming to float over the ground on a cloud of black mist. Tendrils of steel-hard shadow rose up

about her like dark flames, and as my power ignited the first of the mana-cutters, one of those tendrils thrust out like a spear, shattering Kellen's shield and shearing through his collarbone.

The floor ripped itself to shreds, sending us plummeting down into the barroom below. My desk—and all three bottles of booze hidden inside it—crashed straight through the shelves of liquor behind the dirty bar. I hit the bar itself and leaned forward to tuck into a roll, jarring my hip against the floor but ending up on my feet.

Enola landed on a stool, which shattered beneath her weight and downward force, but her mana flared, and she caught herself without a stumble. Ector was less lucky. Off balance from my shove, he landed hard, his head barely missing the bar as he crashed into the floor with enough force to break the planks. Sulla had vanished behind the bar, out of sight.

My focus caught on Kellen, dangling fifteen feet above us. Untethered from gravity, our attacker hadn't fallen with us. As I watched, the shadowy tendril split in two, one ripping up through Kellen's shoulder, the other cutting down and out his hip. The two halves of him spiraled off in opposite directions, painting the floor and walls crimson.

Then I noticed Sabria. The very edge of the floor above hadn't collapsed, and the foolish girl had put her back against the wall and was standing with just her heel on all that remained of the floor. The shadow woman—the retainer, Mawar, called "the Black Rose of Etril"—had her back to Sabria. The girl's only hope was to stay still and let the retainer come after me.

Sabria leapt up, put both her feet against the wall, and shoved outward, a curved blade appearing in her hand. Her body glowed with a dim orange radiance as she activated a fiery aura, and the blade sliced through the air toward the back of the retainer's neck.

With the nonchalance of one swatting away an insect, Mawar flicked out with her tendrils and caught Sabria in the side. The girl's momentum reversed, and she flew away from the retainer and through the wall with a sickening crash.

Then the woman's feline-yellow eyes settled on me, and I felt my insides shrivel up.

Don't piss yourself, I thought, clenching my nethers.

The Frost girl was already moving, darting toward the back door, away from me and Hector. I was still channeling mana into Myopic Decay, so to everyone but me, she would just be a hazy blur. Hopefully it was enough to keep the retainer from identifying the others. It wouldn't matter in the slightest, though, if they were all caught here.

With one hand, I grabbed the back of Ector's silky tunic and heaved him to his feet and toward the front door, forcing the retainer to split her attention.

More smokey tendrils curled up in front of the door, so I changed direction and headed for the closest window. "Shield yourself if you can," I grunted, pushing mana into my arms as I lifted Ector off his feet and hurled him toward the window.

I could already feel the retainer's mana shifting with her focus as she attempted to catch Ector in her shadowy clutches. A pulse of mana into one of my marks, Aural Disruption, sent out a shock of sound-attribute mana that disrupted channeled abilities by interrupting the casting mage's focus and drawing their attention to me. It wasn't nearly powerful enough to stun someone as strong as a retainer, but I felt a spark of satisfaction as the grasping tentacles writhed in place for the blink of an eye, just long enough for Ector to fly past them and smash through the window.

Behind me, Enola screamed.

Mawar's disconcerting gaze was still entirely focused on me as she drifted down from the room above, moving slowly on her black mist, but her tendrils had wrapped themselves around the Frost girl and had her pinned.

I ground my teeth. Of all of us, she was the *last* person I would want to be caught.

Sensing the attack, I lunged to my right as tendrils tried to snake around my legs and torso, feeling them brush against my back. I went into a roll and came up under one of the tables, lifting it and hurling it toward the retainer. With line of sight broken, I pushed more mana into the Myopic Decay, activating the third level of the crest.

The table shattered, and tendrils lashed at me like whips from every side. My body was a hazy blur now, one of several that surrounded me. I ducked a tendril, but most sliced through the false images. Breaking out into a sweat from the effort it took, I sent the blurry forms racing away in every direction while I beelined toward Enola.

The tendrils churned like thresher blades, sending splinters of wood flying like confetti through the air as the retainer ripped the bar apart.

A board broke beneath my feet, and I stumbled. She was on me instantly.

Only a second burst of my Aural Disruption rune saved me as I fell flat on my ass to avoid the grasping tendrils, which shivered and froze for that all-too-necessary instant. But they were everywhere, all around me. The retainer showed no signs of hurry as she drifted toward me, probably suspecting that I was penned in and couldn't run.

I could see her inhuman eyes squinting as she tried to peer through the blur of Myopic Decay. I didn't expect that it would take her too long to imbue enough mana into her eyes to overpower my spell, and if she did, both my identity and Enola's would be revealed.

The light had taken on an uneven, jumping quality, and I realized that coals had been knocked out of the fireplace, lighting little fires in a dozen places.

My hold on the crest weakened as I pushed all the mana I could spare into my emblem. The little fires explode outward into roaring blazes, engulfing the bar between one second and the next. The light these bonfires gave off, though, was a brilliant silver color, so bright it was impossible to look at, and suddenly the destroyed barroom was bright as the surface of the sun.

The retainer hissed and raised a hand to cover her face, as I'd hoped.

Darting between the squirming tendrils, I sprinted for all I was worth toward Enola. From the inside pocket of my jacket, I pulled another mana-cutter, fired a half-second burst of mana into it, and tossed it into the air toward the retainer. It went off with a subaudible *wump* that made my ears ring, sending out a pulse of destabilizing force that could break down walls, shatter floors, or, in a pinch, act as a kind of concussive weapon.

The retainer reeled back from the explosion, undamaged but knocked off kilter. She was already struggling to get her bearings in the blinding brightness and seemed to have lost track of me entirely.

As I struggled to come up with a plan to release Enola, a golden aura surrounded her, pushing away the retainer's hostile magic. *An emblem*, I realized, shocked that a mage so young could have such a strong rune.

The tendrils couldn't find purchase against the golden aura, and the

retainer must have sensed it, because the tendrils melted together into three spear-sharp shadow-tentacles. One crashed into Enola's shoulder, lifting her off her feet and driving her into a wall. A second stabbed toward her chest but skated off to punch through the drywall instead. The third cut like a sword across her throat, and the golden aura cracked and broke, and the girl collapsed to the floor.

For a moment, I feared the worst, but there was no blood. The spell from her emblem had absorbed most of the attack, but her movements were sluggish, and her eyes were unfocused. She was hurt, maybe concussed, or at least nearing backlash from trying to resist such powerful attacks.

Reaching out with my own emblem, I sent a shockwave of mana running through the flames devouring every surface around me, closing my eyes against the results. Even through my lids, I could see the flare as the silver flames grew bright enough to blind. But I didn't have the strength to hold both crest and emblem any longer, and so I let go of my focus on the Sun Flare spell.

The light immediately dimmed, but it didn't go out. The flames were in every board and beam, and I could already hear parts of the building coming down, although I couldn't see beyond my immediate vicinity.

Enola was stumbling to her feet, and only by the grace of good luck did the scything tendrils around her miss as they swung blindly.

Twisting to avoid one such slash, I grabbed the girl in both arms, wrapping her up and pulling her close without slowing down. I had only a bare instant to glance along the back of the bar for Sulla, afraid I'd see his burning body among the wreckage of the bar's stock of alcohol, but he wasn't there. I could only hope that, in all this madness, he had somehow escaped.

Leading with my back, I collided full force with the already weakened wall, bursting right through it and nearly tumbling over backward. This saved us both, as one of the tendrils thrust at us through the hole, but only scraped my arm instead of pinning Enola and me both through the chest.

With no time to nurse my wound or admire my continued good fortune, I sprinted down the short corridor with Enola in my arms. It ended in a window, but a pulse from Aural Disruption, this time formed into a condensed blast, caused the glass and most of the frame to burst apart, and I leapt through without slowing down.

Although I didn’t dare look back, I could hear the ceiling of the bar collapsing into the inferno that was the building.

There were people all over in the street, people dressed in purple uniform robes, half which were wearing masks. I’d had masks in the desk, too, but hadn’t had the chance to hand them over. *Oh well*, I thought wryly. *Hardly the worst of our problems now.*

The crowd, which must have stopped to watch the fire, was now whipping itself into a panic. Finally, I glanced back and realized why. The retainer had floated up out of the blaze, her impassive face now marred with an irritated scowl as she searched the street. It only took a moment for the onlookers to surge away, pushing and shoving and screaming.

Feral yellow eyes met mine, and I cursed.

The retainer's hand lifted, her fingers outstretched toward me like claws.

With Enola supported in one arm, I slipped a hand into my jacket and tossed several capsules up into the air, which shivered under the effects of Aural Disruption, ripping the casings apart and activating the contents.

Thick smoke began boiling out into the street, instantly swallowing most of the crowd.

And then I was running again, dragging the highblood girl along beside me, waiting for the ax to fall. Unfortunately, I knew the fear of collateral damage wasn’t going to stop Mawar from unleashing her worst, and I was all out of tricks.

My hand went automatically to the flare hanging off my belt, but I had already made up my mind not to use it. There was nothing my people could do against the retainer except get themselves killed.

Instead of the crashing sound of magic ripping the world apart, though, Sabria’s unexpected voice screamed out into the night, piercing the rising noise of the frenzied crowd. “Hey, is that really the best you’ve got, bitch?”

On the roof of the building next to the smoldering bar, barely visible through the smoke, Sabria stood with a curved blade in each hand. She was listing to the side slightly, and I suspected she was badly injured—probably several broken ribs, at least—but I couldn’t help but feel a flush of pride as I saw her stare the retainer down.

Then, with both blades facing down like two long fangs, she jumped off the roof, arcing through the air toward the retainer. I expected the tendrils of shadow to come to Mawar's defense, but the retainer brought her raised arm around and caught Sabria by the throat. The blades drove home but only glanced off the powerful layer of mana cladding the retainer's body.

With nothing but an irritated hiss, Mawar squeezed, ripping out Sabria's throat. With a casual flick, she tossed the body down into the fire.

A bolt of fire shot from a nearby window, striking the retainer in the chest. Then a spear of ice launched up from the crowd. Spells flew from other buildings as well, from a half dozen different directions.

I felt something inside me go numb. "I didn't send up the signal, you idiots."

None of the spells managed more than a scratch, but it was all I needed. Giving everything I had left to the Myopic Decay crest, I surged into the third phase again, extending the effect to Enola. I needed to find one of my people, someone disguised in the crowd who could help her disappear. Even through the smoke, it didn't take long; they were already looking for me too.

A man with long blond hair and angry dark eyes came up beside me, looking dour. "Sir, we got Highlord Ainsworth and Ascender Drusus out already, but—"

I shoved the semiconscious girl into his arms. They both had the purple uniforms and could blend in with the escaping crowd. "Get her the hells out of here, now!"

"Sir, what about you—"

"Go!"

He didn't waste any more time but scooped her up and fell in with the rest of those escaping. An ill-timed breeze was kicking up eddies in the smoke, pushing it away from the ruined bar and down the street after them.

I came to a slow stop, and the pain of the last couple minutes caught up with me. My skin, I realized, was blackened and blistered all over and was weeping blood in places where it had burst open from the heat. My joints felt like the flames were in them, too, and every muscle was complaining with fatigue.

A dull ache was working its way into my skull. Unsheathing my flask, I turned around and looked up at the retainer again. She sent a missile of dark energy through the window of a nearby building, and the entire upper floor detonated. The explosion sent shrapnel raining down into the street, falling like deadly hail among the stampeding bystanders.

I tipped back the flask, draining it to the last, and then threw it on the ground.

“Enough!” I shouted. If I brought her attention back to me, the loyal, foolish mages who had been stupid enough to fire on her might get away. “I’m right here, you scarecrow. I’m the one you want!”

Her head slowly turned around as she searched the street for me. The crowd had moved past me, and only those moving slowly due to injury or dragging along the injured were still nearby. Whirls of smoke blew here and there, obscuring parts of the street, but not me.

Heavy, clanging footsteps moving in time suddenly became audible over the rest of the noise, and I turned. Through the gloom and the smoke, a force of loyalist soldiers was approaching. Quickly, I searched their number for any prisoners. They had a few, mostly people in purple uniforms, a couple of whom were indeed members of my network, but Ector and Enola were not among them. I let out a deep sigh and raised my hands.

“That one is for the High Sovereign,” Mawar said, her voice like ice water down my spine. “Bind him with mana suppression cuffs and hang him somewhere uncomfortable. I’m not done here.” Then, like I didn’t matter in the slightest, she turned away and drifted toward another building where spells had been fired from earlier.

A strong hand grabbed my shoulder as an armored boot took my feet out from under me. I went down hard on the cobblestones. My arms were yanked behind my back, and cold steel bit down around my wrists. I realized just how close to empty my core was when I couldn’t even feel the effects of the mana suppression.

“I’ve got this pile of wogart dung,” a woman said. Someone, I assumed the same woman, jerked me painfully up by the cuffs. “Keep looking for the others, the ones he was meeting with. They couldn’t have gone far.”

The other soldiers moved aside as she marched me through them. From the

shadowed doorway of a nearby shop, the vision of my prior commander was shaking her head, her disappointment quite clear despite the dark, the smoke, and the distance.

“Not sure what you think you’ll get out of me,” I mumbled as we moved out in the open, away from the rest. My heavy eyelids kept trying to drag themselves shut, and I wished very much to polish off a bottle of something hard and bitter before crashing into a deep, drunken unconsciousness. “I’m just an old, washed-up ascender.”

The back of a steel gauntlet caught me hard across the ear, making the world tilt on its side. “Shut up.”

The pain of the strike was little more than a tickle considering the chorus of agonies currently screaming for attention across my body, but the sound of the woman’s voice piqued my interest. It was vaguely familiar, but I couldn’t place it, and that rarely happened to me.

Turning slightly, I caught her rather striking profile. Horns grew out from her forehead to sweep back over her blue-black hair, which was pulled into a tight, all-business sort of ponytail. Her burgundy eye turned toward me, and she bared her teeth. “Need another one?”

“Lady Maylis of Highblood Tremblay. What brings a lovely young woman like you to a dive like this?”

She leaned in, almost close enough I could feel her lips moving against my ear. “If you want either one of us to get out of this alive, I really need you to *shut up*.”

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THE THIRD RUIN

ARTHUR LEYWIN

The zone trembled as its behemoth protector collapsed, its chest pierced with translucent mana arrows and stone shards, its final piteous roar choked with black blood.

Mica, sweating and caked with dirt, nudged the behemoth with a toe, making the massive fur-covered corpse rock slightly. Its tiny black eyes were staring sightlessly past me from above the piggish snout and tusks.

"And…another one…bites the dust," Mica said, flopping down on one huge forearm like it was a shaggy couch.

A shiver ran through the aether in the zone, and I scanned our surroundings.

We stood atop a column of dry, crumbling rock. We'd had to cross from column to column, fighting various monsters of increasing size and power, to reach this final battle. The ground was an indistinct sandstone wasteland a mile below, so far that the columns blurred together before reaching the bottom. The zone seemed to go on forever in all directions, with the columns slowly fading out into a heat haze where they met the soft blue of the sky on the horizon.

Boo moaned, and I glanced in his direction. Ellie was standing beside him, giving him comforting pats.

Regis chuckled. "Who would have guessed that an asura-bred guardian beast could have a fear of heights?"

The shiver happened again.

Ellie had started to give Regis a dirty look but stopped when she saw my face. “Brother, what’s wrong?”

“I’m not—”

The stone at my feet cracked. All eyes turned to the crack, only a few feet long at first, but even as we watched, it began racing across the rough surface of the column’s flat top. Boo and Ellie jumped to one side as the crack split the column’s face nearly in two. Then, with a guttural grinding that vibrated in my bones, a dozen other fractures split off the central crack, and the stone beneath our feet began to shift.

All around us, the zone exploded with the avalanche cacophony of shattering stone, and a thick cloud of dust choked the air.

The exit portal, which was inset into the floor and had been guarded over by the behemoth, flared to life, offering us passage to the next zone.

Lyra sprinted for it, her feet hardly touching the crumbling surface as she ran.

“Don’t go through!” I shouted, and she slid to a halt just beyond the square frame. “Stabilize the platform if you can!”

As Mica and Lyra hurried to follow my order, I scooped Ellie up and leapt half the width of the column’s top to land by the portal, the Compass already in hand.

Setting Ellie down, I channeled aether into the Compass and focused on the portal. If my mental map from Sylvia was correct, the third djinn ruin was just on the other side, but since we didn’t have simulets, the others might not end up there unless I stabilized the portal first.

Mica jumped to the center point of the crack and slammed her hammer down into it. Instead of sending the column bursting apart, magic raced from the hammer along the spreading cracks, pulling stone back against stone. Lyra sprinted around the outside of the column, a gust of magical wind flowing out from behind her and down around the edge of the lip to stabilize it by buttressing the structure with a supportive band of hardened air.

“It’s like something else is controlling the mana!” Mica shouted, an edge of panic in her voice.

“The landscapes of the Relictombs are immutable,” Lyra huffed as she ran. “They built this place using aether, and their creation resists tampering by even the most powerful mages…”

With the sliver of my attention I’d given to everything except the Compass and portal, I realized I had never considered this fact before. I’d lost my mana core before entering the Relictombs, and so had always relied on aether to survive here. While it made sense that the djinn’s intention would preclude allowing those testing within to simply remake the zones with mana, it also suggested that, with the proper utilization of aether, the fabric of the Relictombs itself could be rewritten.

There was no time for such considerations right now, though. From my periphery, I saw as Mica began to tremble, her biceps bulging as she held onto her hammer with all her strength. The stone beneath Lyra’s feet collapsed, and she vanished into the hole. From somewhere below, I felt the mile-high column shift and twist, the noise of it lost in the cacophonous tumbling of rocks from every direction.

The column shattered.

Lyra and I were standing on the edge of the portal frame, which didn’t move. Ellie was standing right beside me, but one foot had been off the frame. When the surface crumbled, her eyes went wide, and her hand reached for me as she was pulled backward by gravity.

Behind her, Boo, Regis, and Mica plunged down with the broken rubble, the guardian bear giving out a despairing roar as its claws scrambled for purchase against stone no longer capable of supporting it.

I nearly lost hold of the Compass as my hand snatched out for Ellie. My fingers brushed hers, but I had been focused on stabilizing the portal…

Her hair flew up past her face, whipping in the wind like a flag, her hands clawing at the air as if she could take hold of it somehow or catch herself on nothing. Belatedly, a scream pierced the air, pleading and helpless.

Cursing, I leapt off the side after her and activated God Step.

The paths flashed past at a speed that was difficult to process, especially with my heart in my throat. With my eyes on Ellie, I let the rest of my senses focus on the paths.

Aiming my body toward her and making myself as aerodynamic as

possible, I sped after her. It felt like it took a very long time. Her body was twisting around in freefall, and when I caught up and wrapped my arms around her, it was with enough force to knock the air from her lungs. She scrambled to take hold of me however she could, pulling my hair and jamming her thumb into my eye. We both began tumbling end over end, locked together by her grasping fingers and my arm around her waist.

"El…Ellie! You have to"—my fingers finally closed on her wrist, and I dragged her around to face me—"calm down!"

She pulled closer and wrapped me in a tight hug, screaming, "Boo!"

About twenty feet to our right, the guardian bear's huge bulk was rotating end over end. A long, low, mindless growl was issuing from him, and he was trembling wildly.

Regis was closer, nearly straight ahead. He did a kind of twirl and spun to look at me, his tongue lolling from the side of his mouth. *'I always thought I'd like skydiving,'* he thought. *'And dodging several million tons of killer rockfall definitely adds to the experience.'* His shadow wolf form melted away, leaving behind only a small wisp, which began drifting back up toward the portal frame.

"We need to save Boo!" Ellie screamed in my ear.

"You'll have to summon him from the top," I hollered back over the wind.

Ellie's brows furrowed in determination as she nodded despite the wind-whipped tears streaking across her cheeks.

My focus turned to the aetheric paths, searching for one that would return us to the portal frame now high above, but then Ellie's grip tightened on me again. Noticing her horrified gaze, I followed it.

Mica was nearly a hundred feet above us, the aetheric paths shifting and fading as her relative position to us kept changing. I cursed, struggling to calculate how I could get to her and then the portal frame in time.

"Brother, hold me still!"

Ellie raised a glowing white hand as she clutched tightly to my robe, stabilizing herself as she took aim at the Lance. A misty white bolt shot out, barely grazing past a falling rock before finding its target.

With a sudden infusion of mana, Mica stopped falling. She hesitated,

looking down at us, but I shook my head. She nodded and flew straight back up into the air.

I spared a second to watch the ground growing rapidly closer, then tried to bring all my focus to the aetheric pathways. When they didn't immediately coalesce in my mind, I closed my eyes, feeling them the way Three Steps had taught me.

There.

With Ellie firmly in my arms, I stepped into the aether. We appeared atop the thin edge of stone surrounding the glowing portal.

"Boo!" Ellie screamed, her voice shrill.

With a faint *pop*, a shadow appeared overhead, and the enormous guardian bear crashed down on top of me.

From under a fringe of fur, I saw Mica's boots land next to us.

"Boo!" Ellie exclaimed, her sobs muffled as she must have shoved her face into her bond's side.

Careful not to send the mana beast tumbling off the edge again, I extricated myself from his bulk and brushed myself off. Regis drifted into me, humming a tune, heedless of the fact that everyone had nearly just died.

The rest of us all shared a look, but no one had any words.

Once again, I pulled out the Compass and set to work stabilizing the portal so that it wouldn't send the others off on their own. I nodded when it was ready, and Lyra stepped in, looking like she was sinking into a pool of quicksilver. Mica reached up to rest her hand lightly on Ellie's shoulder. The two shared a look and a pale smile, then Mica hopped in after Lyra.

Ellie hesitated. "I'm sorry," she said after a moment. "I should have—"

I held up a hand to forestall her continued apology. "Stop feeling like you need to apologize for everything."

Glancing over the edge, a shiver ran through her, and she nodded. Boo needed no encouragement to wade into the portal, and Ellie followed with a look of grim determination.

I looked around the zone one last time, taking in the destruction with a sigh, and then stepped into the portal.

On the other side, we found ourselves in a familiar corridor, brightly lit by panels of light running along the top of the walls. Mica, Lyra, Ellie, and Boo were staring around. Feeling a sense of déjà vu, I turned to watch the portal we'd entered through vanish.

"Well, this is eerie," Regis said as he stepped from my shadow. I shook my head, realizing that he'd said exactly the same thing when we found the first ruin.

Before, the sterile environment had put me on edge, but now I knew what to expect. Sure enough, runes lit up along the walls a moment later, and the lights faded to a low violet color.

Once again, an irresistible force took hold of me—of us all—and suddenly our group was skidding across the tiled floor, bringing us to a massive black crystal gate.

Cursing, Lyra spun around, but the white hallway was gone. "What's happening?"

"It's all right," I assured her. "On the other side of that gate we'll find what we're looking for. I'll face some kind of test or challenge. You won't be able to help me, so you should have the chance to rest there."

"Who needs…rest…" Mica asked, leaning against Boo's side to hold herself upright.

'Welcome, descendant. Please enter.'

"What was that?" Ellie asked.

"Did you hear the words?" I asked as the runes on the gate pulsed brightly.

"Not words, just…something. Like a whisper beyond the edge of my hearing."

I frowned, considering. It would have made sense if Ellie could hear the message too, since she was also a descendant of the djinn, but she didn't have any insight into aether, so maybe the Relictombs saw her differently.

Better get inside me, just in case, I suggested to Regis. *I don't want you trapped on the wrong side of the door.*

He became incorporeal and drifted into my body, his wisp form settling near my core. *'Wake me up when something interesting happens.'*

"This next part can be a bit trippy," I said, reaching out and brushing my fingers across the smooth surface of the gate.

My fingers went through, the crystal clinking lightly as it folded away from my hand, making room for my passage. Taking a deep breath, I stepped into the solid surface, my skin tingling from the strange warm caress of the black crystal flowing around my skin.

Everything went dark for a moment, and it felt like I was walking along the bottom of a warm ocean, then the crystal veil parted again. This time, when I saw the geometric patterns, I recognized them as being similar to those I'd seen in the keystone when I learned Aroa's Requiem. Something about that magic and this was the same, although it was still beyond me to comprehend exactly what.

I wasn't expecting danger, but I still quickly scanned the space on the other side of the crystal door.

It was brightly lit by a large number of lighting artifacts giving off a sunshinelike glow. The room was lined with glass display shelves, and the middle of the room contained over a dozen low glass-encased tables.

Stepping up to the closest display, I searched for a plaque or card that might explain what I was seeing, but there was no label on the contents. Inside the glass, resting on a purple velvet cushion, was a featureless cube.

The air changed behind me, and the shifting black crystals folded into existence just long enough for Lyra Dreide to step through into the room, then the apparition melted away again.

Wide-eyed, she stared around, her mouth hanging open. "Is this…some kind of museum?"

I walked slowly down the aisle between two rows of display tables, examining the artifacts. "Something like that, yeah. This is different from what I've seen before. And I don't recognize any of these artifacts."

The tinkling whisper of the crystal door came again, and this time Ellie stepped through, followed immediately by Boo. "Whoa, this is so cool," she muttered, bouncing on the balls of her feet in excitement.

Boo's bulk was so great that he couldn't move without bumping into something, but the displays seemed fixed in place, not moving even when the guardian bear rubbed up against them.

Mica arrived only a few seconds later. After looking around for a moment, she shrugged. "So this big test thing is happening in a dusty old museum? Isn't that kind of weird? I think it's weird."

I didn't respond, finally seeing something that I recognized. On the opposite wall from where I'd first appeared, one of the shelves held three identical spheres. *More Compasses*, I noted, tracing my fingers along the edge of the glass front. Carefully, I attempted to shift the glass or otherwise open it, but it didn't respond to subtle force.

"I don't see any way to open them either," Lyra commented as she ran a hand along the bottom edge of a table. "We could smash them open. The contents of this museum—"

Balling my fist, I struck the front of the glass hard enough to rip through steel. The case neither resisted the force nor shattered under it. Instead, my fist passed through it, the image wobbling incoherently until I pulled my hand back. Once the case stopped wobbling, I pressed my forefinger against it. It felt solid.

When Caera and I had reached the second djinn ruin, the place had been collapsing. The entrance hall and the library on the other side had been merged into one another. They weren't quite real. This museum was probably the same, a visual representation of a place that didn't exist.

"It's more like…" I trailed off, trying to think of an appropriate metaphor.

"Like a picture made real," Ellie said, gazing curiously at an engraved rod made of dull metal, about a foot and a half long.

"Yeah, something like that. Even the Relictombs zones we've cleared reset after we leave. They're meant to be manipulated, though, to test us. This room is nothing, really. Just a distraction."

"It's certainly working," Lyra said, her voice full of awe as she nearly pressed her face up against one of the displays.

I craned around to see what she was looking at and felt a sudden jolt of recognition at the handful of many-faceted crystals resting on the velvet cushion. Images—djinn faces—were projected across each facet with

steadfast but forlorn expressions. Imbuing aether into my extradimensional storage rune, I called forth a matching crystal, which I had taken from the second ruin and then forgotten about.

When the crystal appeared in my hand, Lyra immediately reached out for it, then caught herself and slowly lowered her hand. Her eyes darted back to the collection of djinn crystals protected underneath the glass display, her confusion clear.

“These are sort of like books. Or journals,” I said in answer to her unasked question. “Or at least, that’s the impression I got before. I’ve been carrying this one around for a while.”

“What does it say?” she asked, almost reverent.

“I’m…not sure,” I admitted. “I’ve never listened to the creator’s message.”

Ellie came close, leaning into me for a better look. “So you could have been walking around with the secret to ancient magic in your pocket and not even known it?” Her brows rose, and she shook her head at me.

“I very much doubt that,” I said, but Ellie’s words made me uneasy.

I’d taken the crystal from the collapsing library, which had overlapped the second ruin, more or less on a whim, and had felt guilty about it at the time. My focus afterward, though, had been entirely on the keystone, and I’d never given the crystal another thought.

“Can you activate it so we all can experience it?” Lyra asked. “I have never heard of such a repository of ancient mage knowledge, and I would be incredibly interested to hear what this man had to say.” She pointed to the face speaking silently across the various facets.

I turned the crystal over in my hand, considering it, then sent it back into my dimension rune. Lyra looked put out as she gazed at my empty hand, but I ignored her. Something was wrong. Before, even in the collapsing library of the second ruin, I’d only had to activate aether to access the ruins hidden below the surface. But I’d just used aether to access my dimension storage twice.

Mica said something, maybe asked a question, but I didn’t register any of her words. Holding up my hand, I channeled aether, releasing a harmless burst of formless energy that manifested as glowing purple light.

Again, nothing happened.

In order to be more intentional, I reached down and put my hand against the floor, then pushed outward with aether. Nothing changed.

I tapped my fingers on the floor, and Lyra's words atop the crumbling column came back to me. "I wonder…"

I imbued the Realmheart godrune.

It was strange. Mana was there, but normally the presence of mana particles aligned with the physical attributes of the space in question. One would expect to see a high concentration of earth-attribute mana clinging to the floor and walls, air-attribute mana floating in the atmosphere, and in a place like this, only lingering traces of water- and fire-attribute mana.

But the mana particles didn't line up with the space we were seeing at all.

It was like I was looking at a second image superimposed beneath the picture my eyes were showing me, a collection of dots loosely outlining the features of another space.

Because the mana is aligned with the realities of the chamber. The ruins, the pedestal, the ring, like in the other two ruins.

Again, I considered Lyra's words. A mana-wielding mage may struggle to alter the physical characteristics of the Relictombs, but there had to be a way for me to pierce the veil of separation between the museum and the ruin just behind it.

Aether began to radiate out from me, filling the chamber with violet light. Mentally, I reached for the invisible seams, the places where the illusion contained itself in opposition to the real. It was like feeling for the gap around a hidden door—a place where the two separate pieces didn't perfectly align.

The grasping fingers of my probing aether touched on a jagged edge, and the entire room wobbled in and out of focus.

Mica groaned, her eyes trying to follow along. "Reminds me of when I tried to beat Olfred in a drinking contest, ugh. Are you *trying* to make us all sick?"

I had to trace back over where I'd been twice before I found the edge again. As soon as I touched it, a static blur vibrated through the chamber,

making my eyes go crossed. Boo grunted in agitation, and Ellie made soft cooing noises to calm him.

Closing my eyes to let my other senses do the work, I held on to that edge with aether. I pictured it like a piece of parchment laid over our senses, and so did the most appropriate thing I could think of. I tore it in two.

My companions burst out with dismayed moans, and it sounded as if Mica was very nearly sick as she retched. Someone fell to their hands and knees. Lyra cursed under her breath—or offered a prayer to the Vritra, it was difficult to tell which.

When I opened my eyes again, we were surrounded by light gray stone.

The third ruin, I thought, still wary.

Unlike the last two, however, this place wasn't a ruin at all. The stone walls and floor looked as if they'd just been quarried and shaped yesterday. There was no overgrowth, no broken walls or crumbling ceiling. It was all in perfect condition.

Even the structure in the center of the room was undamaged, but the four rings that should have been orbiting the pedestal lay dormant, and the crystal itself was dark.

"That was bloody horrible," Mica complained.

Ellie was kneeling on the ground beside me, Boo moaning and nudging at her. I rested a hand on her hair, and she looked up at me. Sweat was pouring down her face. "Seconded," she said weakly.

"It was like…having my eyes pulled out of their sockets, then thrown into the air while still connected to me," Lyra breathed, leaning back against the unblemished stone wall.

Regis manifested next to me, his flames casting a jumping purple light over the stonework. "You Vritra sure have a way with words." To me, he said, "What now, boss? This place seems dead as barbequed roadkill."

I set the palm of my hand against the crystal. It was cold, and there was no reaction to my touch.

Keeping part of my focus on Realmheart, I channeled additional aether into Aroa's Requiem. Bright motes of restorative energy flowed down my arm and hand and onto the crystal. I pushed more and more motes into the

large object, watching as they swarmed across the surface, congregating in every crevice as they searched for anything to fix.

Some was absorbed into it, melting right through the crystal's surface. I kept in my mind my understanding of the artifact, its purpose and what was likely stored within, giving the godrune a pattern on which to build if it found anything broken.

But, after a full five minutes, nothing had changed.

I released the godrune, and the motes slowly faded away. "I don't think it's broken."

"Maybe it's more like…out of power?" Ellie asked tentatively. She had gotten to her feet and was slowly walking around the circular rings.

Frowning, I gathered aether into my hand and imbued it into the projection crystal. The crystal absorbed the aether, but it did not come to life.

Like she was moving in a trance, Ellie slowly reached out for the crystal as well. Her fingertips just brushed its surface, and a spark of mana rushed out of her core, through her veins, and into the crystal.

It flickered with dim, cloudy light from deep within.

"That appears to have done something," Lyra said, twirling a strand of fire-red hair around her fingers. "Eleanor, can you give it more mana?"

"I think so," Ellie whispered as she pressed both hands firmly against it. Her small frame flared with white light as pure mana poured into the device.

The crystal emitted a soft glow and an audible hum. The rings shifted, jolting slightly, but they did not rise from the ground or begin to orbit the pedestal like I'd seen in the first ruin.

My sense of foreboding grew. I could only hope the captured remnants of whatever djinn mind haunting this place still remained.

The runes covering the pedestal and dormant rings flashed, and a voice emanated from the crystal, sharp and ancient and wary. "Life—into my old bones—but…" The voice trailed off for a moment, and the runes dimmed, only to flash again as it said, "Is my mission not…complete? Tests given, keystone rewarded…I've slept for such a very long time. For what purpose am I now roused?"

I glanced down at Regis, sharing the bad feeling that was emanating to me from our connection. “Djinn, are you saying that the keystone in your care was already given to someone else?”

The light within the runes shifted, almost like it was focusing on me. “A worthy descendant presented themselves…a very, very long time ago. They passed my tests and claimed the knowledge I guarded, and so the structure housing my mind and memories went to sleep, the energy sustaining me utilized elsewhere.”

My heart gave a painful thump, and it suddenly felt strenuous to draw breath. Clenching my fists, I forcefully steadied my breathing. “Can you tell me who this descendant was? Or what knowledge was contained within the keystone?”

“That information is not stored within this remnant.”

I was acutely aware of my companions’ eyes all lingering on me, but I didn’t meet any of their gazes in return. “What about your test? The previous manifestations or guardians or whatever you call yourselves tested me, and through those tests I was able to gain insight. Even without the keystone—”

“This housing lacks the energy to commit to another test. Whatever arts you’ve used to wake me are sufficient only for the most surface-level application of my stored consciousness, and already I can feel it running out. My purpose is fulfilled. I can see the anguish in your mind, but I can offer you no balm for your pain. I…am…s-sorry…”

The voice lost integrity, gaining a tinny quality like it was echoing out of a can, then faded away entirely. The last of the light left both runes and crystal.

“Well, shit,” Regis said succinctly, sitting back on his haunches.

“Agrona must have it,” I said immediately, turning to look at Lyra for confirmation.

She shrugged helplessly. “It is possible. This keystone may be what allowed him to form our nation to begin with or to survive the assassination attempts sent by the other asura or even unlocked the knowledge of the reincarnates and the Legacy. Or all of it. But I’m afraid I don’t know for certain.”

Mica flew up off the ground, suddenly in Lyra's face. She pushed her hammer against the retainer's shoulder, shoving her back into the wall. "Aren't you one of his generals or whatever? How could you not know? Don't lie to us!"

Lyra lifted her chin and glared at Mica. "The High Sovereign is quite effective at compartmentalizing his forces. No one except Agrona himself sees the entire picture. The Scythes and retainers are political figures, both carrot and stick for the civilians. The deeper workings of his empire are largely left to the Vritra clan themselves, those who still remain after fleeing from Epheotus beside him so long ago. His army of Wraiths do nothing but train and prepare, a secret even from most of his own continent."

"A likely story," Mica shot back, pushing harder with her hammer.

"But Agrona couldn't have gotten in here himself, right?" Regis asked, careless of the tension between the two powerful women. "Who could have gotten in here besides you?"

I shook my head, unsure. Crossing the room, I took hold of Mica's hammer and gently pulled it away from Lyra. "We don't have time to fight against each other."

Grumbling, she lowered her weapon. Lyra and Mica glowered at each other.

Ellie was watching them nervously as she played with the hem of her shirt. "So, what do we do?"

"There is still one more ruin out there," I said firmly. "We need to find it. Now."

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ONE OF MINE

CAERA DENOIR

Our base of operations in Sandaerene lacked all the charm and beauty of Seris's villa in Aedelgard. Seris had commandeered one of the Sovereign's research facilities for us to use as a command center, and there was something about the sterile building that left me feeling chilled all the time. Nothing but cold metal and even colder white light everywhere one looked.

The grated floor rang with a somber, impersonal tone as I marched down the hall toward the central meeting chamber where we held our daily conferences. The door—cold metal like almost everything else—sensed my mana signature as I approached and slid open with a dull grinding noise.

The inside of the meeting room was no better. The central table looked more like a laboratory counter than anything else, and the chairs surrounding it were purposefully uncomfortable. Crystal viewing panels lined one wall. The primary broadcast from Central Dominion played in the middle screen, while smaller displays to the left and right showed a number of locations. I recognized the battery chamber and Sovereign Orlaeth's holding cell on one screen, and a moving panoramic of the city of Rosaere on another.

"You're early."

"You're out of bed," I answered, turning to find Cylrit sitting on a bench against the wall to my left, his head resting back against the wall. "You shouldn't be."

He rubbed one hand down the side of his pale gray cheek, scratching at the stubble growing there. “If I lie in bed any longer, I may actually die.”

I rolled my eyes. “All men truly are babies, aren’t they? Even retainers.”

His brows rose very slightly. “Oh, I don’t know about that. I think I’ve recovered fairly well considering my core was nearly shattered by the Legacy.”

Cylrit and I both turned toward a door on the opposite wall of the room, sensing a powerful mana signature approaching. The door slid aside with the same quiet grating noise, and Seris stepped into the room. Cylrit eased up from his bench to bow, and I followed suit.

Seris waved our greeting away. “Cylrit. I have no use for a retainer who can’t follow orders. You are to remain at rest until our healers are satisfied that your core has suffered no lasting damage.”

I looked very closely at the Scythe, trying to read her expression, tone, and body language. Our conflict with the High Sovereign and his forces had not been going as well as we might have hoped, and I felt certain the stress of our recent losses must have weighed on Seris, but she gave no outward sign at all.

“Forgive my impudence, Scythe Seris,” Cylrit said, sinking back down on the bench, “but Doctor Xanys *did* release me, not thirty minutes ago.”

Seris walked around the table to stand in front of the screens, staying just outside the range of the telepathic field. The broadcast was showing a long line of men and women being paraded past the recording artifact in chains and with metal gags clamped around their mouths. “Named Blood Akula of Truacia.”

The Akula blood had been part of the smuggling operation out of Truacia, moving both silver from their mines and armaments brought up from Vechor.

“No one from their blood was assigned to the shipment we lost,” Cylrit said, watching the screen with a sour expression. “It’s possible they slipped up, but it’s equally possible someone gave them up.”

I remained quiet, acknowledging the guilt I felt without wallowing in it.

I’d been the one who brought the Akula blood into this. In a way, I was

responsible for what was happening to them now. But I couldn't shoulder that blame personally; this was a war. There would be suffering and loss on both sides. Still, when the youngest member of the Akula blood, a girl no older than eleven, was marched past the recording artifact with tears streaming down her bright red cheeks, I had to look away.

But Seris watched, holding a silent vigil for them all, knowing they would be executed. Even when the others started to arrive in twos and threes, then larger groups, until the room was full to bursting with analysts, operators, Imbuers, and commanders, she kept her eyes on the broadcast. The chatter that would pick up with each new arrival, as people acknowledged each other with quick greetings, died quickly.

Only when everyone had arrived did Seris turn her back on the broadcast. Behind her, the rest of us watched as carts carrying the prisoners rolled away from the recording artifact.

"Reports?"

In the instant of hesitation that followed, I stepped in. "Maylis—Matron Tremblay—has reached out and confirmed that our high-value assets in Aramoor have been successfully relocated." All eyes turned to me, some wary, others hopeful. "It was very close, and we lost multiple mages in the conflict with retainer Mawar, but so far it appears the identities of those present have not been compromised."

"The High Sovereign's forces are getting more aggressive," one of our field commanders said. "And not just against us. They're using violence against the people to turn public opinion against our efforts."

"We believe they're tracking interdominion travel, at least among highbloods," an engineer from Highblood Redwater put in.

"How?" asked someone else—I didn't catch who in the packed conference room.

"Not sure yet," the engineer admitted. "But we've seen enough reactive movement to high-value assets maneuvering that we're confident they are."

There was some mumbling at this proclamation, but it died out after only a few seconds.

"Are our plans for the next assault on the shield in place?" Seris asked,

scanning the room for the several people involved in that project.

An Imbuer from Highblood Ainsworth cleared her throat. “Despite this recent setback, our highblood will do its part. I received a message from the highlord just this morning confirming our commitment to your…plan.”

The Imbuer’s halting cadence suggested she wasn’t exactly thrilled about what Seris had asked them to do, but then, I was rather surprised they’d agreed to go forward with it at all, especially after Hector nearly lost his life to Mawar. He was a prideful man, however, and such close calls tended to either break a person’s will or buttress it. Clearly, he was one of the latter.

“The necessary alterations to the estate have been made,” another engineer added. “Testing the wider connectivity is…difficult, of course, but if Highblood Ainsworth follows through, we’re confident in our work.”

The Imbuer lifted her chin and looked down her nose at the engineer. “We’ll do our part. Even if it leads us to the same fate as the Akula blood, apparently.”

Despite the growing tension, the conversation changed course, focusing on a number of technical details that were outside of the scope of my role, and though I did my best to stay invested, many of the finer points escaped me.

One of the doors slid open. Many sets of eyes turned to the late arrival, but the flow of conversation didn’t stop. Wolfrum of Highblood Redwater froze under so many gazes, looking like a startled rocavid as he searched the room. When he saw me, some of the tension left him, and he followed the wall to where I was standing.

We exchanged silent nods, then both turned our attention back to the conversation, which was finally shifting away from the previous topic.

“There have been five recorded descensions within the shield over the last week,” the head of the Ascenders Association in Aedelgard said. Anvald of Named Blood Torpor was a bald man with broad shoulders and a severe look. “Sixteen ascenders in total. All were interviewed, logged, and released beyond the shield in Rosaere. None were operating with the express purpose of reaching Sehz-Clar.”

The few descension portals in the western half of Sehz-Clar were kept under heavy guard. Seris had been monitoring traffic out of them since even before the shield went up, and we continued to do so now to make

sure Agrona wasn't actively trying to get agents into the dominion. It was possible to destroy the portals, of course, but Seris said that until they had proof that Agrona could weaponize them against us, she wasn't willing to break anything she couldn't rebuild.

After everything I had seen while adventuring with Grey, I felt confident a handful of descension portals weren't going to matter to the Relictombs' future, but I hadn't argued the point. It was nearly impossible to target a specific descension portal outside of the second level anyway.

A few follow-up questions were asked about the ascenders, and then the meeting moved on.

"We need to reconsider our supply lines from eastern Sehz-Clar and Etril," one of the analysts said before launching into a report on the amount of food our territory was consuming versus the amount produced and smuggled in. It was a concerning problem. "At this rate, the larger cities will be rationing the sale of food to civilians in three weeks. The smaller towns may not feel the hit for another six weeks, but within two months, you'll have people starving in the streets."

"There are too many eyes on the coast," one of Seris's strategic advisors said. "The last four ships that have tried to come down the coast—from Vechor or Etril—have been caught and sunk. We tried expanding some of the research tunnels under Rosaere, but the mana usage required drew attention, and we had to collapse everything we'd done and then some to prevent it being used to circumvent the shields."

"Central Dominion isn't being watched so closely," I said aloud, having a thought. The entire room turned as one to focus on me. "We could route supplies to our allies there under the pretense of highbloods stocking up on provisions, hedging against potential economic collapse due to the ongoing rebellion. There is a river that springs up near the border between Central Dominion and Sehz-Clar, primarily used for shipping goods from Sehz-Clar up to Cargidan for distribution through the rest of the dominion. But it is also a common destination for recreation among the highbloods."

"It'll be just as thoroughly watched as the coast, surely?" the analyst countered. "Moving resources into Central Dominion would be easy enough but getting them down here has the same problems."

Seris was thoughtful for several seconds as she considered our arguments. "The network of tunnels and underground labs around Sandaerene is

extensive. Begin opening a supply line straight through to the base of the cliffs around the Vritra's Maw. Hire unadorned laborers for the last ten miles or so. That will limit outside detection of the digging. The tunnel system should come out just across the sea from the river Lady Caera mentioned."

Several people hurried to take note of this command.

"Meanwhile, arrange for distribution of incoming food throughout our highblood allies in Central Dominion, Vechor, and Etril. Devise several routes for supply lines. Make it appear as if the goods are being shifted from one highblood to the next. We'll need several unaffiliated highbloods involved as well. Make sure it isn't only our allies who are suddenly stockpiling provisions." Seris's mouth twitched in a barely visible smile. "Make it clear that people are beginning to question Agrona's ability to end this rebellion."

Once again, the conversation broke down into a discussion of specifics, with representatives of each group asking questions and others offering suggestions to solve new problems. This went on for nearly half an hour before Seris dismissed everyone. People began to filter out quickly, many of them rushing off to immediately start work on the details discussed.

I started toward the door as well, but Seris caught my eye, communicating clearly that *we*, at least, were not yet done. Settling in beside Cylrit, I waited for the rest to leave. The only other person not queuing up to get out of one of the doors was Wolfrum, a fact I was curious about but expected to learn the reason for momentarily.

Once the last person had left and the doors had closed behind them, Seris relaxed ever so slightly. She eyed Cylrit for a moment, considering the retainer before focusing on me and Wolfrum. "Things are coming to a head," she said, leaning one hip against the table and crossing her arms over her stomach. "Word from within Taegrin Caelum is that Agrona has taken steps to prepare the Legacy to attack our shield again."

Cylrit stood slowly. "We'll be ready if she breaches it."

Seris raised an eyebrow a fraction of an inch. "Of course we will. But there must be a counter strike as well. It is time to change the narrative."

We all waited as she let tension build. Wolfrum bit his lip as his fingers twitched nervously, but Cylrit was still as a statue.

“We’ve given Grey time to put his house in order,” she said, meeting my eye. “Now, we need him. A decisive victory, in plain sight where Agrona can’t sweep it under the rug. And I’m sending you to retrieve him.”

“To—” I cut myself off, looking pointedly at Wolfrum.

Seris nodded. “It’s all right, Caera. Wolfrum can be trusted. He’s one of mine.”

I experienced a moment of confusion, then felt my brows shoot up. “Another Vritra-born protégé?”

He smiled awkwardly. “Lady Seris helped me when everyone else gave up on me. When my V-Vritra blood didn’t manifest…well, I owe her a lot.”

“Why didn’t you tell me?” I asked my mentor, unsure how I felt about this revelation.

“It was essential that my connection with the Redwater blood be kept entirely secret,” she said, no hint of apology or even acknowledgement in her tone. “Only Cylrit was aware. I hope you’ll need no further assurances?”

I straightened, suddenly conscious of how I was still looking at Wolfrum. It was difficult to imagine the painfully antisocial boy I’d known, who had turned into the jittery man before me, being mentored by Seris. If he had gone through the same sort of training and preparation I had, however, then there had to be a lot more to him than I’d ever suspected. At the very least, he possessed a hidden strength that I appreciated.

“Good,” Seris said after a moment. “Because he’s coming with you to Dicathen.”

Wolfrum paled. “To the other continent?”

“I’ve sent a team ahead to ready my personal long-range tempus warp. Grey—Arthur—is based out of the underground city of Vildorial. The dwarves were heavily divided by the war in Dicathen, and tension will still likely be high there. Do not expect a warm welcome. If Arthur isn’t there, you may also speak to Virion Eralith, the Lances Bairon Wykes, Varay Aurae, or Mica Earthborn, or whichever dwarven clan is in charge of the city itself.”

Wolfrum’s wide eyes turned to me, his mouth open slightly. It seemed

Seris's alternate protégé was feeling somewhat overwhelmed.

"I need Arthur—Grey—to return to Alacrya soon," Seris continued. "He is…singularly focused on the protection of his family, and I worry that now that he has finally returned home, he may not be eager to leave it again. Convince him."

I set my jaw. "Of course, Scythe Seris. I trust him…" I couldn't help but ask myself if that was true, causing me to trail off. Immediately, I added, "I trust that he'll do what is right."

Seris pushed away from the table and headed for the same door she had entered through. "Come on, then. You'll take a tempus warp to the oceanside, where a member of the forward party will meet you." She hesitated, then added, "For what it's worth, Caera, I trust him too."

Wolfrum and I followed on Seris's heels, leaving the silent and brooding Cylrit behind. The research center's primary tempus warp chamber was tucked away between several offices and protected by a guard station. At a word from Seris, the operator programmed the device and stepped back.

"Remember what we've put the Dicathians through when you arrive in Vildorial," Seris said as we stepped up in front of the matte metal of the tempus warp. "Be patient with their hostility. You will find, given a chance, that they aren't the barbaric failed continent Agrona has painted them as. And I believe it is important that they learn to see Alacrya not as their aggressor, but as an equal victim to the asuras' plotting."

"I understand," I answered, and Wolfrum repeated it.

"Then go."

The operator activated the tempus warp, and I felt the magic grab hold of me, pulling me through space. In only seconds, we were deposited in a small bunker. A young woman in olive leather armor jumped up off the stool she'd been lounging on and snapped a salute. Her gaze flicked to Wolfrum before settling back on me.

"Lady Caera, ma'am. The long-range warp is set up just on the other side of the shield. Follow me, please." And then she was moving.

Wolfrum and I followed her out of the steel door and down a steep rocky path that led toward the coast, perhaps half a mile away and a couple hundred feet below. The base of the shield was just visible where it curved

down out of the sky to sink into the sand and stone of a rocky beach. I recognized it as the northwestern coastline of Sehz-Clar.

“So, you’ve been quite central to Seris’s operation here, haven’t you?”

When I looked at Wolfrum, he responded with a stiff smile, and I realized he was trying to make small talk. Aside from the short meeting with Highlord Frost and the others, I hadn’t seen Wolfrum in a few years, not since my adopted mother and father stopped forcing me to go to parties with the other Vritra-blooded fosters. As children, our relationship had been amiable, but I had never formed close bonds with any of the other Vritra-bloods.

“I agree with what she’s doing,” I answered after a moment.

“Yes but…she trusts you, clearly. You seem to be involved in all her decision-making.”

I laughed despite myself, but there was no humor in it. “Not all, apparently.”

“You’re…angry.”

I bit my tongue, immediately feeling guilty. I knew all too well how difficult Wolfrum’s life had been and how he had been treated by the others like us. “I apologize. I’m not, really. Just…your relationship with Seris…took me by surprise, is all.”

His brows pinched together in a serious expression. “She is good at compartmentalizing. It’s interesting, you know.”

“What’s that?” I asked, hopping down a steep step as I carefully followed after the soldier.

“The way she thinks, plans, and executes…lessons taken directly from the High Sovereign. But she is using his own tools against him. It’s…almost poetic.”

I stopped and looked over my shoulder at Wolfrum, who had fallen behind me as the trail down the steep slope narrowed. There was a strange, almost wistful look on his face.

“Come on, it’s a bit of a hike still, and our window through the shield is scheduled for…” Our guide shaded her eyes with her hand and looked toward the sun. “Shit, only about seven or eight minutes. It only lasts thirty

seconds, so we need to hoof it.”

She began hurrying down the slope, occasionally sliding on loose stones or leaping over the edge of several-foot drops. I hurried after her, listening to Wolfrum’s steps behind me to make sure he was keeping up. He’d never been very graceful.

The rocky hill plummeted straight down into a cliff before joining the beach, and our guide led us into a series of steep stone steps cut into the cliffside.

“So, what should I expect on meeting this Ascender Grey…or Lance Arthur Leywin of Dicathen. It sounds like you know him well.”

As I took a sharp switchback, I glanced up at Wolfrum again. He was staring down at me, and there was an intensity in his mismatched eyes that didn’t match his tone.

“He’s difficult to describe,” I said, growing uncomfortable. “You’ll understand once you’ve met him.”

I realized that this discomfort had been building in me as we’d descended the hillside, but not understanding what I was feeling, I had pushed it to the back of my mind. I considered everything, as I’d been trained to do, moving backward from this last question up the hill, searching for subconscious details that had triggered my unease.

My heel turned on a loose stone, and I slid down two steps. I planted my hand to catch myself at the same time Wolfrum’s fist closed around my arm to stabilize me. Something silver tumbled out of my sleeve, bounced off the hard stone, and went spiraling down the cliffside, vanishing in the rugged bushes that lined the beach's edge at the bottom.

I cursed.

“That looked valuable,” Wolfrum noted, helping me back to my feet.

“It was,” I muttered unhappily.

“No time to search for it,” the soldier said from below, shaking her head. “Unless you want to explain to Scythe Seris Vritra why we missed our window.”

I only shook my head, and we went on in silence for a minute or so. “I was thinking, you’ve been training to fight with Seris, right?” I asked, breaking

the silence as I realized what had been bothering me. “Your footing is much more stable than I remember. Those dances we were all forced to attend…” I met his eye over my shoulder, forcing a clumsy, half-suppressed smile to my lips. “You’ve changed. The nervous act…it’s just that, isn’t it? A masquerade?”

He shrugged as he straightened his shoulders, but he didn’t miss a step. “It’s not so different from your role with the Denoirs, is it? People expect you to be something, and Seris has taught you to show them what they want to see. If anyone ever thinks of me at all, they remember the clumsy, terrified young Vritra-blooded boy who managed to embarrass himself at every turn. They expect me to be just that, so convincing them I am has been all too easy. Seris taught me that there is power in underestimation.”

I let out a breath, relaxing as I reminded myself that we had both undergone the same training from a Scythe. I was suddenly glad that Seris had sent Wolfrum along, and curious about what he was capable of. When I opened my mouth to ask about his training, though, I was cut off by another curse from our guide.

The soldier jumped off the last set of steps, plummeting fifteen feet down to the sand below, where she landed with a grunt. Then she was up and moving, jogging across the beach and waving us after her. “See those striations? It’s time. We’re already late!”

There were lines like stretch marks running vertically down the shield. Outside of it, on an outcropping of rock that broke the otherwise smooth stretch of sand and water, several people were waiting for us. Our guide was kicking up sprays of wet sand as she ran across the beach toward the spot where the lines converged on the ground.

Empowering my legs with mana, I leapt off the cliffside, clearing twenty feet of air before landing softly, my boots sinking into the sand. Wolfrum landed beside me a moment later, and we both hurried to follow the soldier.

The shield split apart with a low electrical hum, creating an opening ten feet wide and fifteen feet high.

There was a flash of green light.

A bolt of mana lifted our guide up off her feet and flung her back at me. Reacting on pure instinct, I caught her, but in the second it took me to do

so, several more spells were fired off. Half of the group waiting beyond the shield collapsed as bullets of fire and raining acid took them unaware. It was over before it even began.

The young soldier was squirming in my arms, trying to twist around enough to look over her shoulder at me. Her eyes were wide, her breath coming in shallow gasps.

The attackers were already hurrying to the gap in the shield.

Wolfrum was standing at my side, almost touching me. But he wasn't watching the mages, who had stopped at the gap and started throwing down what looked like components of an artifact of some kind. He was watching me.

"It'd be better if you don't fight back. We'd prefer to bring you in unharmed," he said, his voice completely changing as the intensity in his eyes turned into a dark confidence.

"I know you're calculating your odds of victory right now, but…" Wolfrum expanded outward, growing taller and more muscled. Onyx horns sprouted from his head, short and sharp. "Let me assure you, a battle can only result in your injury or death."

I stepped away from him, still cradling the soldier in my arms. A red stain was growing over her left side.

His Vritra blood manifested, but he's been hiding it. Like me.

Underneath the shield opening, the mages, each of whom wore an emblem symbolizing a winding red river, had set up an arch of black metal rods. High above them, the streaks in the shield were wiped away as the thirty-second timeframe passed. When the streaks were gone, the shield flexed around the artifact. The two forces conflicted, issuing a ringing buzz, but the gap didn't close.

I needed time to think. There was no way for me to know how strong Wolfrum was, and I was outnumbered seven to one, so I couldn't be sure of the results of a fight. I needed to understand more about what they were trying to accomplish. "How long have you been a traitor?"

Wolfrum was stalking toward me slowly, but he paused to consider the question. "I was never Seris's, regardless of what she says. Besides, if you betray a rebellion, doesn't that make you *loyal*?"

One of the Redwater soldiers ran up with a pair of manacles clanking in his hands. Wolfrum took them by the chain, holding them up for me to see. Mana-suppression cuffs.

“It’s ironic, of course, that Seris gave me all the tools I needed to spy on her,” he went on, jangling the manacles. “Everyone thinks she’s the clever one, but even she never suspected that my blood manifested.”

“Ship coming round the bend!” one of the Redwater mages shouted. He was standing atop the rocky outcrop with a spyglass pressed against his eye. “Five minutes!”

Wolfrum took a step toward me. “Here, let’s get these on you. I’d hate for you to be tempted to do something stupid when Scythe Dragoth gets here.”

Silently apologizing to the soldier in my arms, I dropped her.

Wolfrum lunged at me, reaching for my wrist, but I threw myself into a backward roll, drawing my blade from my dimension ring as I came back to my feet. But Wolfrum was fast, and he was still right on top of me. His fist drove down like a club, wrapped in sable flames to smash my blade out of the way. I pivoted around the blow, absorbing the shift in momentum from his strike to bring my sword around in a wide arc toward the back of his legs.

He launched himself into the air, his large frame rotating in a graceful backflip as he landed a few feet away.

I felt the mages at my back beginning to conjure their spells.

“As much as fighting back is not the right call, Caera, I’m curious to see what you’re capable of,” Wolfrum said with an air of confident curiosity. “Seris has so much faith in you.”

Spinning the manacles over his head, he hurled them at me. They flew like a bola, whirling around and around.

I set my feet as best I could in the sand, ready to dodge or deflect the wild throw.

The air around me hardened, congealing into an obfuscating snarl of jet-black wind that blinded and restrained me. *Void wind*, I thought feebly as the manacles, guided by his magic, snapped closed around my wrists before pulling my hands together in front of me.

The queasy sensation of my mana being snuffed out filled every cell of my body as the cuffs locked it inside me.

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SHACKLES

THE OPPRESSIVE GUSTS of void wind pressed in on me from every direction, blinding and deafening me. I could sense nothing but the rapid-fire beating of my heart and the cold metal pressing against my wrists. Even the omnipresent hush of the ocean lapping against the shore was obscured.

“You two, get the tempus warp packed up for travel.” Muffled by the spell, Wolfrum’s voice was distant, only barely audible. “The rest of you, over here. I’ll lower the spell. Disarm her and move her outside of the shield. Scythe Dragoth Vritra will be here soon.”

The darkness changed, swirling as if it were being moved by the wind. I felt its hold on me lessen and smoothed out my expression, unwilling to give Wolfrum the satisfaction of seeing me struggle.

Just as the void wind spell faded, strong hands took me by the arms, and something sharp dug into my back.

“How anticlimactic,” Wolfrum mused, studying me. “I’ll admit, I did sort of idolize you when we were younger. Now, I have no idea why.”

I lifted my chin, not flinching away from his unnerving gaze or his words.

“Still, you’re quite the prize for Dragoth. With a little…incentive, I imagine there is a whole lot you can tell us about Seris’s operation, hm?”

I didn’t fight back against the mages holding me, letting my arms sag in their grip. “Nothing that will save any of you,” I said, keeping the quaver out of my voice.

Something small and bright caught the sun above and behind Wolfrum,

and I tensed.

Mana surged, and a ray of black light shot from it. Wolfrum, sensing the mana, grimaced in surprise as he spun, attempting to conjure a shield of soulfire at the last second. The soulfire passed just above his shield, striking him at the base of one horn.

With a resounding crack, the horn shattered, spinning off into the sand. Wolfrum howled in pain as his eyes went wide with rage.

“Reinforcements!” one of the mages shouted, letting go of my arm as they conjured a spell.

The sharp object at my back pulled away, leaving only one mage still holding on to me. I drove an elbow up into his nose, snapping his head back, then wrenched forward out of his control.

My blade was on the ground at my feet, knocked from my grasp by the manacles. Catching the blade with a toe, I kicked it upright so that the handle stuck in the sand with the scarlet blade pointing straight up.

There was a second burst of mana, but the lance of soulfire flew a few feet to Wolfrum’s left. It bypassed his shield and struck my blade. The scarlet steel burst into black soulfire.

With all my manaless strength, I drove the chains down on the point of the burning blade, and several things happened all at once.

The four mages were shouting all around me, caught between searching our surroundings for their attackers and stopping me from escaping. Wolfrum had both hands raised, one emanating the fiery shield, the other —pointed at me—swirling with void wind.

Utilizing the limited pool of mana I had already charged into it, two additional silver shards released from my bracer and rushed into orbit around me, firing off lances of black fire. Wolfrum reacted with lightning swiftness, reshaping his spells and combining them into a vortex of ashen wind and fire, absorbing the barrage of attacks.

The point of my sword lodged up through one link in the manacle chains. My pulse spiked as the sword’s handle sank deeper into the sand, deadening the force of my downward strike. Then it caught, buttressed by something hard deeper down.

The flames clawed through the Imbued steel, and the chains shattered with a bright spark.

Something cold and sharp slashed across my hip, and I dodged forward, pulling the scarlet sword from the sand and slashing behind me as I moved.

A steel-hafted spear blocked my rushed strike.

Finally, I got a good look at the four Redwater mages surrounding me: a Shield, two Casters, and a Striker.

Both Casters were holding fire in their hands. The Striker was already spinning his spear around to go on the offensive. Sand formed into metal discs and floated up to defend them as the Shield retreated to a safe distance. They were potent mages, and as my sense for mana returned, I got a feel for their power. Their mana signatures suggested emblems, but Seris had encouraged our forces to cover their runes, so I couldn't be sure.

The vortex shield around Wolfrum exploded outward.

Conjuring soulfire along my blade, I stabbed into the ground. A shield of fire sprang up around me.

The third orbital shard—the one I had "lost" while descending the cliffside—flitted past Wolfrum to join the other two, and they shifted into position just outside of the shield, their mana resonating with each other. I gritted my teeth as I struggled to maintain focus on both the soulfire and the artifact.

When the shockwave hit, the orbitals sent out a pulse of mana to counter it. They held for a full second before being knocked out of position and sent tumbling away behind me. I braced for impact as the soulfire shield emanating out from my sword quivered, cracked, and then flared out. But the remaining strength of Wolfrum's spell was only enough to set my hair waving in the resulting light breeze.

The mages were huddled behind several metal discs, and their Shield was sweating profusely. Wolfrum had apparently been willing to destroy his own men without a second's thought.

"I doubt you'll be welcome at any more Vritra-blooded parties looking like that," I said, standing and lifting my sword to point at his shattered horn. The bracer drew on my mana, and the three orbitals flitted back into

place, hovering around me defensively.

Wolfrum snarled as he fingered the broken stub. “So, I’m not the only one hiding their real power. I should have guessed. Are you hiding your horns as well? Is it that bracer there on your arm or”—he focused on my pendant, which had slipped out of my shirt in the fighting—“that little bauble around your neck? An illusion? That would be Seris’s way. Go on, I want to see who I’m really fighting. Show me, for old time’s sake.”

“It’s almost a shame you decided to be a Vritra lap dog.” I conjured soulfire along the scarlet blade again, causing it to writhe with black flames. The other mages were holding back, waiting on Wolfrum’s command. I could now see the boat in the distance, being rowed swiftly along the shore. “If you’d ever actually listened to what Seris was trying to teach you, you could have been so much more.”

Wolfrum conjured black fire in each of his hands as he adjusted his stance. “I think you’ll find I learned much more than you.” To his soldiers, he barked, “Bring her down. Kill her if you have to.”

The spear-wielding Striker lunged forward. Twin bolts of fire followed, tracing a smooth arc through the air as they passed him on either side. In the distance, a large transparent panel of mana shimmered into existence over the hole being held in Seris’s shield, cast by one of the two men who had been in charge of the tempus warp. The other, a Caster, conjured a cloud of caustic green haze to stain the air and make the path to them impassable.

Two lines of soulfire met the flame bolts, launched from the orbitals. The soulfire burned the spells to nothing. A third ray targeted the Striker. When one of the metal discs lurched into position to defend him, the soulfire scorched right through it, but the Striker was fast, and he’d already dodged. Still, the flames scoured the ground at the Casters’ feet, making them jump back and interrupting their next spells.

Behind me, Wolfrum thrust both hands forward, unleashing a torrent of soulfire pushed on a gust of void wind.

I lunged to meet the Striker. His spear licked out twice, three times, four, with the quickness of a lightning bolt. I parried each strike without breaking my stride, the soulfire wreathing my weapon burning through the spear so that when he thrust for the fifth time, only the short end of the ruined steel remained. He realized his defenselessness too late, and the

edge of my blade effortlessly parted his armored uniform, mana, flesh, and bone.

In the wake of my blade, a crescent of black fire rolled toward the two Casters. Bullets of bright yellow flame shot back, flying all around me, a few scorching my flesh. All the metal discs shifted into position to block the soulfire, but it wasn't strong enough. Not nearly. The black fire devoured the shields, then the Casters behind them, and the barrage of bullets ceased.

The Shield turned to run. As I focused on his back, I pulled on the three orbitals, like squeezing the trigger of a crossbow, and three rays of black flame lanced through him. His body tumbled into pieces.

Channeling mana into one of my runes, I conjured wind to push at my heels, speeding my flight as Wolfrum's soulfire licked at my back.

I had no choice but to rush straight into the acidic cloud of water-attribute mana. It hissed and popped against the mana cladding my body. On the other side of the shield, standing atop the outcropping of rock in front of the tempus warp, the Caster waved his hands and the cloud condensed into viscous drops of rain, which immediately began burning through my protection.

Releasing the soulfire wreathing my blade so I could focus on both the wind-attribute spell and the orbitals, I aimed at the two mages beyond the shield. Twin lances of fire ripped through the barrier cast by their Shield, burning a large hole in each mage's chest. The final orbital fired backward blindly as I hoped to disrupt Wolfrum's concentration.

I felt his soulfire clash against mine as the inferno surged. Risking a glance behind me, I saw the full effect of his spell for the first time.

A huge smokey skull, its mouth wide and eyes empty as death, trailing a twenty-foot tail of pure soulfire, was closing in on me. The orbital's attacks were vanishing into the skull's open mouth, never reaching Wolfrum.

I aimed for the tempus warp. With the way clear, there was no reason to stand and fight. Not when a Scythe was closing in on me.

A bead of dark mana condensed in the air above the opening. Wild lines of void wind began reeling out of it, spiraling downward until they touched the ground to form a cyclone that blocked the way.

I sprinted straight at it while recalling the orbitals, wind-attribute mana pushing me forward faster with every stride. They snapped into place in the bracer, and I released the mana and concentration powering it just as my blade flared with soulfire once again.

Slashing at the air with my sword, I felt a thrill of success as soulfire carved through the artifact they'd installed to hold Seris's barrier open. The metal melted away as if it were wogart butter, and the arch collapsed. The shield around it flexed, pushing inward.

In my periphery, I could see the darkness of the encroaching spell starting to surround me.

Wrapping myself with wind, I leapt, making myself as narrow and aerodynamic as possible, shooting forward like an arrow.

The shield closed around me.

I was immediately picked up by the void wind cyclone, which cut through my own wind mana effortlessly. My senses reeled for a moment as I was spun end over end, then the cyclone released me.

Catching my balance, I rotated my body to land crouched on both feet, one hand pressing into the sand for stability.

Fifty feet out in the ocean, the tempus warp splashed down into the water. It had been lifted by the cyclone, then tossed away as the wind's momentum vanished. My stomach plunged with it.

"If it makes you feel any better, we didn't program the tempus warp anyway, Lady Caera," Wolfrum said from the other side of the shield. "You were never going to leave here."

I spared him no words. He was no longer a threat to me. The approaching ship, however…

The boat was close enough now that I could sense the monstrous mana signature emanating from it. Even as I watched, a silhouette, somehow still looming large even from such a distance, floated up from the deck and hurtled toward me, onyx horns gleaming.

Focusing on the ripples still rolling away from where the tempus warp had sunk under the water, I sprinted out along the rocks toward it, stowing my blade as I ran. There was a surge of mana, and the rocks under my feet

heaved, rolling away from me like the deck of a ship. I would have plunged face first into the jagged stone if not for the wind-attribute mana already imbued around my feet.

Pushing off against the air itself, I leapt out over the open water, pulling my body into a streamlined diving position. When I hit the water, I shot deep down below the constantly rolling waves. The frigid cold bit at my skin, and the drag of the water pulled at my hair and clothes, threatening to tow me away.

I scoured the seafloor for the tempus warp, but it sloped steeply away from the beach, growing darker and darker as it went deeper.

Strengthening my vision with mana, I peered through the gloom, searching for the roughly anvil-shaped artifact. A cloud of silt obscured the ground, but there was a subtle emanation of mana within the cloud. Focusing on it, I pushed harder, swimming as fast as I could, all too aware of the Scythe's mana signature growing closer by the second.

Using wind-attribute mana to cause a current, I pushed away the floating silt. The tempus warp was sticking up from the soft soil, half sunk into the ground. Dozens of scratches had been scored into the surface from the void wind, matching the dozens of raised welts all over my body.

Please work, I thought, the Scythe's shadow moving across the top of the water in my peripheral vision.

I was certain Wolfrum had been lying about not activating the tempus warp. If he hadn't, he wouldn't have kept talking. He was trying to engage with me and keep me there. They couldn't spring their trap until Wolfrum arrived and the shield opened, and it would have raised suspicion to prevent the other mages from preparing the artifact.

Or so I hoped.

The ground around the tempus warp moved suddenly. Mana swelled through the soil, and a giant hand made of black iron formed with the artifact in its palm. A second hand punched up beneath me, slamming into me and sending me spinning off through the dark water. Bubbles burst from my lips as I gasped, every bone in my body aching from the force of the blow. As I reeled, the hand grabbed me, squeezing, and more bubbles rushed from my mouth as it crushed the air from my lungs.

Both hands began moving up toward the surface, but I could hardly see

them through the stars sparkling behind my eyes.

Gathering the last of my strength, I pressed my own hands against the blood iron restraining me. My eyes drifted closed. I searched for the inborn confidence that always assured me I could do anything I attempted. Desperation kept it at bay. So I reached for my rage instead.

My mind went blank. Except for the mana—the soulfire that burned in my blood and my heart and my core. That, I embraced. I took hold of it with my entire being, gathered every ounce of my power, and pushed.

Black flames flooded out of my hands. The water began to boil wildly as it was destroyed. Soulfire ate into blood iron. The hand quaked beneath me. Metal began to dissolve. The grip lessened.

A funnel of wind whipped the ocean water into a frenzy, ripping me free of the giant hand's clutches and shooting me straight at the other hand and the tempus warp held in its palm. I slammed against it, scrambling to reach the tempus warp pinned under thick metal fingers.

Spikes erupted from the surface of the hand. I felt the pain, saw the red trails in the water, but had no time to check the nature of my wounds. My fumbling fingers found the controls.

I felt, rather than heard, the splash from above. Drawn as if by gravity, my head turned so I could see above me.

The muscular form of Scythe Dragoth Vritra drove down through the water like a bullet. His eyes gleamed like rubies, and there was a white crest trailing from his horns due to his speed. One of his hands was curled into a tight fist, and the other pulled back as if to swat a fly. The crushing press of his aura was enough to make my heart stop, but it was the unfiltered rage in his expression that drained all the warmth from me.

The blood iron fist next to me clenched harder. Metal shrieked against metal as the surface of the tempus warp began to cave in.

Trembling, I activated the artifact.

The world was ripped away from me, or I from it. There was no air in my lungs. My entire body erupted in pain. I thought the process must have failed. It was taking far too long. Everything was dark.

My body splashed, wet and heavy, against stone, but I had no wind left to

be knocked from me. Gasping, struggling and failing to bring in air, I dragged my eyes open, uncertain when I had closed them. I didn't understand what I was seeing. My hands clutched my chest, my body desperate for oxygen. Finally, a breath came.

Dimly, I became aware of something hard and sharp pressed against my cheek. A spear. Without moving, my gaze followed the line of the spear's long haft to the man holding it. I registered blond hair and green eyes, dark in the low light.

"Move, Vritra, and I'll pin you to the floor," he said, his voice carrying an edge of thunder.

The sound of his voice, the sight of him and his surroundings, melted together with pain and fatigue into a muddle. I blinked several times, my focus moving inward. Each breath came with a deep ache that suggested broken ribs, and I had been pierced by blood iron spikes in both legs, my side, and the inside of my left arm. But all these wounds were superficial and would heal with time.

I wouldn't die.

Assuming, of course, this Dicathian didn't follow through on his threat.

"I'm not your enemy," I said, keeping my voice slow and steady as I met the man's eye. Others had approached as well. Dwarves, by their stockiness, I guessed. Hopefully that meant I was in the right place. "My name is Caera of Highblood Denoir. I've come looking for—"

"You're a Vritra," the man snapped. "I can guess well enough why you're here." He frowned, focusing on my wounds. "Though you don't look to be in any shape to attack us."

I took a steadying breath, unable to keep the grimace off my face at the resulting pain in my chest and ribs. "*Please*. Bring the Lance, Arthur Leywin. He knows me. I assure you that—"

"Arthur isn't here," the blond man said. To my relief, however, he withdrew the spear, keeping it pointed at my core, but at least it was no longer digging into my skin. "Which would be a convenient time for a spy to attempt to slip into Vildorial, especially one who presented themselves as too weak and injured to be a threat to us." He sneered. "Perhaps it would have been a wiser plan to send someone without demonic horns sprouting from their skull."

Momentarily confused, I reached for the pendant that normally hung around my neck.

It was gone.

I started to sit up, but the spear pressed against the side of my neck. I held out both hands. “I really don’t intend you or anyone else here harm. Arthur is my *friend*. I—” I bit off my words. I’d nearly stated that I worked with Scythe Seris, but I couldn’t be sure how such information would be taken. “He spent time in Alacrya, you must know this. We met, traveled together. If you’ll—”

“As I said,” the man interrupted yet again, “Arthur isn’t here. Perhaps you are some friend of his. Perhaps you’re a lying demon. Until we know for certain, you’ll wait in the dungeon.” He stepped back and gestured with the spear.

Slowly, I stood up. A dozen sources of pain bloomed hot and bright across my body, and I sucked in a sharp breath between gritted teeth.

“Mana-suppression shackles!” the man ordered.

When a heavily armored dwarf clanked up with a pair, I nearly laughed at the irony. I held out my wrists, which were already bound with the broken manacles from Alacrya.

The dwarf eyed them curiously. “She’s…already wearing a pair, General Bairon. Not of Dicathian make, by the looks of it.”

The tip of the spear clanged against the broken cuffs as the blond man inspected them. *General Bairon…*

“You’re Lance Bairon Wykes,” I said as he indicated that the dwarf should shackle me anyway. As he slapped the cold metal around my wrists, I added, “Like I said, I’m a friend of Arthur’s.”

“As am I,” he replied, only redirecting the point of his spear when the dwarf nodded to confirm my shackles were firmly in place. “But I am also a protector of Dicathen, while you share the look of our enemies. In the event your words are proven true, I’ll offer you my apologies. Until then, you are a prisoner.”

Lance Bairon took hold of the shackles and inspected my wounds for a moment. “Send for an emitter. She looks likely to bleed out if we leave her

manaless in a cell."

One of the dwarves saluted, then hurried off. We went in the other direction, with the Lance leading me by the chains. A sea of dwarves parted to allow us through, some falling in line behind us, others watching as he led me up a curving road that ran around the edge of a truly enormous cavern.

"Can you send him a message?" I asked after a moment, trying to stay calm. "My reason for being here is an urgent one, and…" I trailed off as Lance Bairon stopped and turned to look down at me.

"Tell me why you're in Dicathen."

I hesitated, and his nostrils flared.

"I thought so. If you'll only speak to Arthur, then I'm afraid you're going to have to wait. I can't send him a message."

"But why?" The moment the words left my mouth, I knew why. "He's in the Relictombs."

This caused the Lance's brows to rise. "I won't be confirming any details. Know, however, that you haven't found this city undefended. At this moment, you are only alive due to my goodwill. Attempt any sort of treachery, and that goodwill ends."

I blinked. There was something about the straightforward bombast of the Dicathian mage that felt…refreshing. "Noted."

I followed Lance Bairon up the long road, taking in the sights and people of Vildorial as I went. Among the dwarves I saw a smattering of humans and even a few people I thought must be elves. Despite being underground, there was nothing cramped or claustrophobic about the city. In fact, I was quite taken aback by its beauty. The way the buildings and homes were carved into the side of the cavern, how the rays of light, generated by large crystals affixed to stone pillars or hanging from long chains, reflected off the cavern walls to glint like stars in the night sky, even the rugged, fearless way the people of the city—most not even mages—looked at me, their gazes inevitably drawn to my horns…it was all so charming, while still being undeniably solid and strong.

I thought we were making for a sort of stone fortress that filled the highest level of the cavern, but before we reached its gates, he took me instead

through a plain, if heavy, iron door inset into the wall, and suddenly the place lost its charm.

The hall beyond was narrow and cramped. It led through a guard post, where several dwarves snapped to attention as we passed, into a series of unadorned corridors. Cells lined both sides.

Lance Bairon led me through the prison to what seemed to be the deepest cell farthest from the entrance, opened the door, and waved me in. I went without complaint. It wasn't ideal, but this would be exactly the wrong time to create hostility between us. With time, even if Arthur didn't return immediately, I was certain I could convince this Lance, or perhaps the lords of the elves or dwarves, that I meant them no harm.

The door, which was heavy oak banded with iron, closed with a dull *thunk*. Although I couldn't sense it due to the mana-suppression shackles, I was certain the cell was magically warded and locked.

The cell itself was plain. A straw-stuffed mattress on the floor with a single woolen blanket folded atop it. I grimaced at the bucket resting in the opposite corner.

"I understand these accommodations may not meet the standards of a *highblood*," Lance Bairon said through the barred window inset in the door, "but I'm afraid the more comfortable cells normally reserved for nobles in the palace are occupied by families made homeless by the Vritra clan's invasion."

I clenched my jaw, working it back and forth in frustration. Before I turned around to face him, though, I smoothed out my features, presenting a stoic front. "It was exactly that: the Vritra clan's invasion. My people have suffered under their rule for hundreds of years, yours for barely a single year. They are just as much my enemy as yours, I promise you that."

The Lance's brows wrinkled in a thoughtful frown. "We'll see."

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BLACK DOORS

ARTHUR LEYWIN

As I watched the others vanish one by one through another portal—the fourth now since leaving the third djinn ruin—I considered the mental map left for me by Sylvia. Despite my confidence in isolating the proper zone, it was still strange. Unlike all the other pictures in my mind, which included a sense of what to expect in the zone, this one was empty, nothing but an intangible blank slate.

I cast a glance back at the zone we'd just cleared: a suffocatingly cramped castle full of traps and monsters. It had been dangerous but straightforward. The unknown beyond this next portal unsettled me.

It was the gentle swirling of the portal's internal light that dragged me back into the moment. Whatever else might wait on the other side of the portal, my sister was already there without me. With this in mind, I stepped in after her.

I appeared surrounded by…nothing. Absolutely nothing. Void emptiness in every direction. And I was alone. When I tried to call out for my sister, no sound came. I tried to look down, but there was no down or up or *me*.

It felt like when I'd first appeared in the Relictombs. I didn't relish the sensation.

'At least you've still got me,' Regis's voice sounded in my head. *'Wherever I am. Can I still be inside you if neither of us exist?"*

Then, like a scene fading in at the beginning of an old Earth movie, the zone materialized in front of me.

I was looking across glassy black ground at Mica, Boo, and Ellie. Except something was wrong with them. They were flat, like reflections of themselves on dark glass, and their movements were stiff and unnatural.

“El,” I said, my voice sounding muffled and incomplete.

Her mouth moved in response, and I read my name on her lips, but I couldn’t hear her.

I need to get out of here, I thought. I felt myself drifting forward, and then my feet touched down on solid ground.

Turning around—I had a body again, I realized—I examined where I’d come from. Behind me, a smooth rectangle of mana about seven feet tall and three feet wide hovered just beyond the edge of the ground I now stood on. An identical shape stood a few feet to its left. Lyra was peering curiously out from its surface.

I heard my name spoken by Ellie’s voice like a pleading whisper coming from a great distance.

Turning away from Lyra, I crossed to the other panels—*doors,* I decided mentally, although in truth they resembled a physical door only in their outline. “It’s okay,” I assured my sister, reaching up and pressing my hand against the surface of the door. She raised hers as well, placing it where mine was. “Just think about leaving, and you will.”

She nodded, her features hardening, the panic easing away. When nothing happened, her brows furrowed in concentration, but she was still inside the door.

Regis manifested next to me, shaking his burning mane. “Something seems off.” He sniffed at the door, his breath fogging the smooth surface. “Maybe there’s some trick to all this.”

“Aether,” I said, realizing Regis was right. The doors were wreathed in aetheric particles. With my hand still pressed against the door, I sent aether out through my fingertips.

Ellie immediately appeared at my side, sagging in relief. “Ugh. That was really uncomfortable.”

The doors reminded me of the mirror zone. Remembering what happened to the Granbehls, I hurried to release Boo, Mica, and finally Lyra in the

same fashion.

I watched each of them for a moment, but there didn't seem to be any aftereffects or strangeness in their behavior as there had been with Ada when she was possessed. And when they stepped out of their respective doors, no reflection or image was left behind.

Once they were all free—and I was convinced they were themselves—I turned my attention back to our surroundings.

We were standing on smooth black ground, almost indistinguishable from the darkness beyond. Boo kept his side pressed against Ellie protectively, his small eyes staring out into the nothing.

Mica rolled her shoulders and cracked her neck, an uneasy frown creasing her features. "I feel…weird. Not sure how to describe it."

"Yes, there is a strange sensation in the atmosphere here, like gravity or the air is wrong…or like *we* are wrong," Lyra said as she bent down to run her fingers across the smooth ground. "This is mana. Pure, focused mana. No physical landscape at all." Her eyes traced a line into the distance. "It's a platform. See there, a subtle shift in the blackness?"

I moved to where she had indicated. She was right. We were standing on a floating platform in the void, a twenty-foot square. "There could be others that we can't see," I proposed, squinting and pushing aether into my eyes, searching for any sign of more platforms. "Maybe we have to navigate blind. I should be able to…"

I activated God Step, but nothing happened. No aetheric paths lit up in my vision or called out their presence to me, and I didn't experience the expanded innate sixth sense of my physical surroundings, either. The godrune didn't even glow. It was like it was dormant, unreachable. I couldn't feel it at all.

Regis clicked his tongue in frustration. "It's the same with Destruction. It's there, but…not."

With no clue what that might mean, I sent aether into Realmheart. The godrune lit up, the mana particles forming the ground glowing like multicolored fireflies. Aside from the mana of our platform and some lingering atmospheric mana drifting in the void, Realmheart showed me nothing.

But at least it worked.

Turning my attention back to the doors, I ran my hand along the closest one, from which I'd released Lyra. It felt smooth and silky like polished obsidian, but there was a static tingle to its surface. "If aether pulled you all out of these things…"

I sent a small amount of aether into the door.

With a sickening lurch, my perspective shifted. Suddenly I was looking back at my companions and their surprised expressions.

"It's okay," I said, my voice again sounding strange, as if I were underwater. I was certain that these doors had something to do with clearing the zone, but their purpose wasn't immediately obvious. "I just need a minute to think."

My perspective was fixed, so I couldn't look to the side or up and down. I couldn't move at all. Like when I'd first appeared in the zone, it was as if my body didn't even exist. From this door, I could see nothing but my companions, the platform, and the other doors.

The thought of other doors gave me pause. *What if they really* are *doors?* I wondered. I had stepped out of a door by thinking about it. Perhaps…

I focused on the door Ellie had appeared within and thought, *I want to go through that door*.

Like before, I began drifting forward. For an instant, I thought I would appear standing in front of Lyra's door, as I had my own, but instead I kept floating, picking up speed slightly as I moved in the direction of my thoughts.

A couple of seconds later, I stepped back out onto the platform, but it was through Ellie's door, and I was now standing behind my companions.

Boo groaned in surprise, stomping back and forth as Ellie gasped out, "Arthur!" She took a couple halting steps before Boo moved to intervene, pushing her back with his broad head. She twisted around, searching frantically; her eyes skated right past me, stopped, then jumped back. She pressed a hand over her heart and her expression softened. "You scared the crap out of me," she complained, causing the others to turn around as well. A low, nervous whine from Boo served to add emphasis to her distress.

“How did you do that?” Lyra asked, her lips pursed as she considered the black rectangles lined up along the platform’s edge.

I quickly explained what I’d done, and my theory.

“So you think these—doors?—can move us around the zone?” Mica asked. Brows raised, she turned to her left and right, gesturing at the vast emptiness. “And go where?”

“There must be other platforms and doors out there,” Lyra insisted, moving to the edge of our platform and staring into nothing. “It’s the only thing that makes sense.”

“If this is one of the djinn’s puzzles,” I said, thoughtful, “then there is always an intended solution.”

With my hand against the cold surface of the door, I released another pulse of aether and felt myself drawn into it.

This time, instead of letting myself be distracted by what was right in front of me, I focused on the emptiness around our platform. And as I stared out unblinking into space, something caught my eye. Far off to my right and a few dozen feet below us, there was a second platform with two doors visible from my angle.

“I found it,” I said, carefully stopping myself from thinking about going through that distant door. It felt reckless to go and leave the others, especially if they couldn’t navigate the doors on their own. “Regis, you can sense the direction in my thoughts. Can you see the platform?”

Regis loped to the edge, staring out in the direction I indicated. “There’s nothing out there.”

“Maybe you can only see it from inside the door?” Ellie asked, tapping a finger on her lips thoughtfully.

“Only one way to find out, Regent Leywin,” Lyra said, turning away from me to watch in the distance, following Regis’s line of focus.

I hesitated, but only for a moment. While I didn’t like leaving the others behind, this seemed like the clear way forward. With a thought, I was drifting through the empty space toward the leftmost of the two doors I could see. Like before, I slowly picked up speed as I moved, but it wasn’t fast. A strange foreboding built within me as I grew closer and closer to

the second platform, but I was unsure if it was some trick of the Relictombs or my intuition trying to warn me about some unseen danger.

Twenty seconds or more passed before I stepped out onto solid ground again. The diffused, sourceless light of the zone lit up this much smaller platform, and I couldn't help but wonder why I hadn't seen it immediately.

'Oh, hey, we see you,' Regis thought. *'The platform just kind of appeared a second before you did.'*

Looking back, I could just make out the others—Boo by far the most obvious—standing along the edge of their platform perhaps three hundred feet away.

Between me and my companions, the void oozed like shadows moving within shadows.

I thought I was imagining it until a four-fingered clawed hand reached out from the void and grabbed the platform, digging into the flat panel of mana. A second claw followed, and, very slowly, spindly arms formed, dragging a horribly skinny creature out of the black background and into reality right in front of me.

Its bones protruded in sharp ridges against shiny black skin that blended into the darkness behind it. The flat face had no mouth or nose but four out-of-place eyes. As it uncoiled from its crouched position, I found myself looking up at it; the creature was at least seven feet tall.

It blinked, each eye closing and opening slightly out of time with the others. Then it lunged forward, clawing at my stomach.

I stepped into the blow, conjuring an aether blade in my left hand. The monster's claws dug into my side beneath my ribs, slicing right through the aetheric barrier that clad my skin.

My sword punched into its bony chest, then ripped up and out the side of the neck. Its eyes rolled in four different directions as it toppled over, and when it struck the ground, it dissolved into the platform under my feet.

Pressing a hand to my side, I checked the wound; it was healing rapidly, as expected. *At least* that *power is working*.

'You know, we've seen a lot of shit in here, but that thing was nightmare inducing,' Regis said via our telepathic link.

“This is going to be a problem,” I said to myself, considering the obstacles this zone presented. *Is everything still clear over there?*

‘Yeah,’ he confirmed, absent his normal flippant attitude.

Returning to the others worked the same way: the jarring feeling of floating disembodied through space, the shadows rippling as if the void itself was alive, before I finally stepped out of Ellie’s door on the starting platform. I searched for the distant platform, but it was gone.

“This is going to take some trial and error,” I said, explaining what I’d learned to the others.

Mica jumped forward, looking up at me with grim determination. “I’ll go first.”

I had released her from the doorway by imbuing it with aether, and I attempted to put her back into it the same way. With Mica’s hand pressed against the same door I’d used, I sent a small pulse of aether into the surface.

Sure enough, Mica vanished from the platform, reappearing inside of the door like a moving portrait of herself.

“Now, can you see the other platform? Think about leaving through one of those doors,” I instructed.

She nodded, but nothing happened. Considering what we already knew, I assumed that aether was the problem. She couldn’t move in the same way she couldn’t release herself. But I thought I already knew the solution to that.

I confirmed that she was focused on the distant door, then imbued aether into the doorway again.

Mica appeared right in front of me. Her face rose, then fell again as she realized where she was. “It didn’t work.”

“Perhaps you were not focused enough,” Lyra said, crossing her arms.

“Or maybe the portal is racist against dwarves,” Regis muttered, getting a sputtering laugh out of my sister.

Mica’s eye narrowed, but I stepped in between them. I had no patience for an argument.

She focused on me instead, clearing her throat. “I was one hundred percent focused. It has to be something else. Although, if Professor Relictombs Know-It-All wants to try, be my guest.”

“It’s worth being exhaustive,” I said, waving Lyra forward.

She passed into the door easily, but when I imbued it the second time, she too stepped back out onto our platform. The only silver lining was that no more monsters showed up to attack us while we were on the starting platform. However, we were getting no closer to progressing through the zone.

“Now that we know there are other platforms out there, why don’t we just fly through?” Mica asked, stepping up to the edge of our platform. “I can’t see it anymore, but you were just over there somewhere.”

Not waiting for a reply, she lifted off the ground and flew out into the void. The moment she crossed over the outer edge of our platform, a spindly, black-clawed arm congealed from nothing and wrapped around her throat. A second raked down her face, shearing through her protective mana with ease, while two more grasped at her ankles.

I grabbed the back of her armor and yanked her onto the platform.

Three of the creatures came with her.

Imbuing my hand with aether, I struck the one choking her in the side of the head. Unlike the other, this one had no eyes, only an open mouth full of serrated, gnashing teeth. The skull collapsed, splattering dark ichor over Mica and me both.

Mica kicked down hard, shattering the collarbone of another. Twin arrows sprouted from the third, one in the throat and one in its single off-center eye.

Ripping herself free of my grasp, Mica conjured her hammer and started swinging.

I took a step back. The overlarge hammer made short work of the monsters’ remains, crushing them into a heap of soggy black bone. As soon as she stepped away, breathing hard, the three corpses dissolved.

She brushed her hair from her face as she turned around. “Perhaps flying is…not a great idea.”

“It does seem that the djinn intended a certain path be followed to navigate the zone,” Lyra commented, raising her brows and looking at me. “*Your* path. Which I must say, for the rest of us, is rather unfortunate.”

“There has to be a way through,” I said, stepping up to one of the doors and staring at it. “We just have to find it.”

An hour and several experiments later and we still hadn’t moved beyond the first platform. But we had learned a few things about the zone.

I couldn’t travel beyond the second platform. I could see a third but couldn’t move to it. It felt like strong hands were holding me back, and my working theory was that the zone would only allow me to move one platform beyond my companions. Although I had hoped to go to the end and see if activating the exit portal would free the others from the purgatory of the first platform, this wasn’t an option.

Any attempt to cross through the void resulted in an immediate attack. The longer Lyra or Mica stayed out there, the farther they tried to push, the more creatures clung to them, rending and mauling with claws capable of ripping through mana and aether alike.

I had even attempted to send a bolt of aether from one platform to another, but the aether fizzled away before reaching its target, absorbed back into the zone.

And as long as anyone was standing on the second platform, the horrifying monsters kept appearing, slithering free of the void one after another.

“It’s quite strange,” Lyra mused, pacing back and forth across the platform as we rehashed our ideas for the third time. “*I* feel strange. Has anyone else noticed?”

“Yeah,” Mica answered, drumming her fingers against the platform as she leaned back on her elbows. “I can’t put my finger on it exactly, but all this”—she gestured to her torso—“isn’t the way it should be. It reminds me of how I felt the first morning I woke up without my eye.”

Lyra nodded. “Exactly.”

Ellie pulled her knees to her chest and hugged them, looking nervous. “Do

people ever get…stuck in the Relictombs?”

Boo rumbled, nudging her shoulder with his nose to comfort her.

“We’re not stuck,” I said firmly. “We just haven’t made the right connection yet. I’ve been in several zones where the solution wasn’t immediately obvious—”

“Arthur!” Ellie said, bolting to her feet. “A connection!”

I stared at her for a moment, unsure what she meant.

“My spellform—the tether!” When I still didn’t understand, she spun in a circle and tugged on her hair in exasperation as she reached for whatever words she was looking for. “My arrows, maybe we can make a *connection* somehow, y’know, between doors…”

My brows furrowed into an uncertain frown, and she trailed off, losing her confidence.

“The doors require aether, El,” I said, thinking out loud, “and the void would probably break down your arrows before they could reach another platform.” She looked down at her feet, but I was starting to see through her words to the intention behind them, and I kept brainstorming. “But your spellform might be enough to keep the mana’s shape intact and within your control as it passes through the void…”

Mica sat up and crossed her legs, resting her elbows on her knees and leaning forward. “But how does that help us?”

“It doesn’t, unless I can imbue aether into Ellie’s arrow.”

“But…the platform isn’t there,” Lyra pointed out.

Cursing, I realized she was right. I would have to go first, opening the doorway so to speak.

“But you have to be here to send everyone through,” Regis said, stepping up to the door. “It’ll have to be me. I’ll go ahead to activate the next portal.”

“You’ll be attacked the entire time,” I pointed out.

He puffed up his chest, and his flaming mane flared brightly. “Maybe you’ve forgotten because you’ve been looking upon my beautiful face for

so long, but I'm a god-weapon, remember?"

I eyed him for a long moment, then nodded. "If this works, Mica will be right behind you as backup. Assuming you're up to test this?" I asked, meeting her eye.

She floated up to her feet with a shrug. "Better than sitting on my thumb any longer, isn't it?"

"Adios, muchachos," Regis said before pressing his nose to the door and vanishing within it. I felt my connection to him vanish and knew he was within the network of doors, drifting toward the next platform.

We waited a few seconds before Mica pressed her hand against the door. I imbued it with aether, but nothing happened. She wasn't pulled in.

"Perhaps because it is already in use?" Lyra asked.

"That's going to slow things down," Mica said, watching the dark patch of nothing in the distance where Regis would soon appear.

"Be ready. We need to move fast."

Several very long seconds later, the platform lit up as Regis appeared in front of one of the doors. Mica was still touching the doorway, so I wasted no time in sending her through.

Ellie conjured an arrow. "Now what?"

Activating Realmheart, I wrapped my hand around the arrow and sent out a small amount of aether, the aether and mana shifting slightly to mingle together. I looked at the arrow and felt a frown creeping onto my face.

"It's just going to bleed out. It needs to be…"

The mana particles moved, leaving a sort of reservoir in the arrow's head that would be completely surrounded by Ellie's mana.

"Like that," I said, moving the aether. I focused on pushing it through the outer layer of mana until it was fully shielded within.

She took her time setting up the shot. It was a long way to the door she was aiming at.

From this distance, I wasn't able to see the monster forming to attack Regis, but it was obvious when it did. Regis, glinting like a purple jewel,

leapt on a shadowy silhouette and tore it to pieces.

Ellie's arrow trailed through the dark like a shooting star, striking the distant door with a quiet but satisfying *thwack*. She turned to me and grinned.

"Now, the other one," I said, and we repeated the process, Ellie's second aether-infused arrow sticking into the bottom corner of Mica's door.

"Don't overdo it," I cautioned.

Ellie waved me away, closing her eyes. "I won't."

Her eyes moved back and forth beneath the lids for a few seconds, then with a soft burst of mana, both arrows detonated simultaneously.

I held my breath.

Mica vanished from the door. When she didn't immediately appear in front of us, I hurried to the edge, peering into the darkness. Regis had a second monster by one arm, shaking it violently. His pain radiated through our link as its other claw tore at the flesh of his back, but so did his intensity. He ripped the arm off and spit it on the ground, then pounced, slamming the skeletal horror in the chest with both paws and driving it to the ground. Finally, his jaws closed around its throat, and it dissolved beneath him.

When Mica stepped out of the door a few seconds later, her hammer already in hand, she jumped into action, fighting side by side with Regis as another monster climbed out of the void.

"Woohoo!" Ellie exclaimed, jumping up and raising a hand to Boo, who gently met it with his paw in a sort of high-five.

I let out a relieved breath, but with the mystery of how to move my companions across the zone solved, I felt anxious to get through it as quickly as possible. "Let's send Boo next, just to make sure it'll work for him too."

Ellie sobered slightly as she exchanged a look with the guardian bear. But when Boo pressed a paw to the door, I was able to send him in, and Ellie's trick with the aether-infused arrow worked just as we expected. With Regis, Mica, and Boo on the distant platform, the continually manifesting horrors were taken down one by one.

Lyra went next. It wasn't until only Ellie and I remained that we realized

the flaw in our technique.

“So…how do you think *I* get over there?”

“Shoot your arrows, but don’t make them explode. Then I’ll send you into the door,” I suggested.

Shrugging, Ellie worked with me to infuse two arrows, shooting one into the door on our platform and the other into the distant platform where the others were fighting for their lives. With that done, she pressed a hand against the dark rectangle of mana, which I imbued with aether.

She vanished. And the instant she did, her connection with the arrows was severed, causing them to shatter with a slight pop.

My sister’s image vanished from the doorway in front of me. It was with a growing sense of unease that I waited for her to appear on the other side, watching as the others took down two more of the horrors. It wasn’t until she finally stepped out of the far door that I was able to relax and follow her through.

By the time I stepped out of the portal, my companions had formed a protective ring around Ellie. Her bow was drawn, a glowing arrow of mana against the string, and when a skeletal monster dragged itself free of the darkness, she let the arrow fly. There was a dry crack, and the monster’s head snapped back as the arrow pierced its skull. Slowly, it tumbled back into the void, vanishing.

“All right, Regis, head for the next platform,” I ordered, moving to Ellie’s side.

Regis wasted no time with banter, vanishing first into a door on the opposite side of the platform, then from the door as well.

A long chitinous tail with a bulbous stinger at the end stabbed down from the void as another monster appeared. Lyra deflected the attack with a burst of wind, and Ellie sent an arrow into its chest. It fell on all fours, scrambling like an insect. Mica brought her hammer down at its head, but it jerked away erratically, and her hammer rang against the floor.

The tail swung wildly, whipping around like an untethered electrical wire. I pulled Ellie down with one hand as I conjured a blade in the other, slashing across the shiny black skin in the same motion, slicing the deadly appendage off. Boo pounced on the monster, crushing it lifeless.

In the distance, I saw the next platform appear, followed a second later by Regis.

“Mica, go,” I ordered, rushing to the door. She met me there, and I sent her in with a pulse of aether. “Ellie!”

As Boo and Lyra worked to corner a new horror—this one with four clawing arms and two mouths where its eyes should have been, each filled with needlelike teeth—Ellie disengaged, conjuring an arrow with a reservoir for my aether in its head. The next monster to appear crawled out of the void right beside us as I sent my aether into the arrow, and its claws sank into my shoulder.

Vibrations rippled visibly in the air, so strong I felt my skin tingle, and the monster crumpled, letting out a horrible squeal. I stomped down hard, and the noise ceased.

Ellie shot the arrow first at the far platform. When it hit its mark, we repeated the process with Mica’s door. Ellie wasted no time in bursting the arrows and releasing the contained aether. With the connection formed, Mica vanished.

“This is going to get difficult,” I said into the momentary quiet between attacks.

Boo was ready the moment Mica passed through the other doorway, and I sent him in. This time, I worked with Ellie with one hand as I held my blade in the other. With only Lyra on the platform with us, defending Ellie became my entire priority.

But we were getting faster. Only one monster appeared, and was subsequently cut down, before Boo was on his way.

“We can do this,” Lyra said firmly, standing by the doorway, some dark spell crackling on her fingertips as we waited. When the next horror oozed out of the darkness, her spell crashed into it, sending it flying off the platform and out of sight.

Then it was her turn. She watched us nervously from within as Ellie hurried to form her arrows, and I filled them with aether. When a two-headed horror dragged itself onto the platform, I reabsorbed the blade, focusing it into a single point in my hand before releasing it as an aetheric blast.

The two-headed horror dodged to the side and launched itself at Ellie.

With an aether-infused arrow already on her string, she adjusted her aim and released. Instead of arcing toward the next platform, the arrow struck the monstrosity in the stomach. Then, it exploded.

The monster was ripped apart from the inside, showering our platform with black gore, which rained down around us with a heavy, wet splattering.

Without missing a beat, Ellie conjured another arrow and held it out to me. Beside us, a chunk of oozing black mush ran down Lyra's two-dimensional face.

Once Lyra was gone and Ellie was inside the door, I felt better. I'd entirely forgotten to track the other group's progress on the third platform, but Regis's thoughts were filled with the glow of battle and success. I dispatched two more monsters before I could make the jump myself.

"Shit," Regis said a minute later, stepping back out of a door on the third platform, which was large with several doors lining each edge. He had just tried multiple doors looking for the way forward. "There are three platforms." Sidestepping a claw, Regis dragged down an attacking monster with its arms and head in the wrong positions on its torso. When it was finished, he asked, "Do I just pick one or what?"

"Yes, just go," I said, shielding Ellie from the swiping claws of another creature. "But make note of your choice. If this place turns into a maze…" I left the rest of my meaning unsaid, certain we all understood the danger of getting lost or having to backtrack while under constant attack.

In the twenty seconds it took Regis to reach the next platform, we dispatched three more monsters, which were appearing much more quickly than on the second platform. Already, Mica had a deep wound in her side, and Boo was bleeding from a dozen cuts all over his massive body.

"Their damned claws go right through mana and steel," Mica said with a grimace as she took another shallow cut across her forearm. "They may break like shale, but with so many of them…"

'It's a dead end,' Regis thought back to me. *'The doors only face back.'*

Come back and try another, I thought, suppressing my frustration.

All we could do while waiting for Regis to return was keep fighting. One particularly horrible manifestation with a vertical mouth down the middle of its face and three eyes on each side, lunged at me. I brought the aether blade up, severing its outstretched arm, pivoted to the side, then carved through its torso as it flew past.

Boo reared up in front of Ellie, bringing both huge paws down on the shoulders of another creature, which collapsed under the guardian bear's weight. Mica was doing her best to conserve her mana by launching stone blades out of her hammer from a distance. Lyra had pinned two of the creatures beneath a wave of sonic vibration that was pulling them apart.

As my target fell, I scanned the platform for any more.

Ellie was braced behind Boo, firing off arrow after arrow. My attention caught on her face, which was a mask of determination. No fear, no hesitation. Pride warmed me.

Lyra and Mica had gravitated to opposing corners of the platforms, fighting separately. Most of the creatures were focused on them. Even as I watched, a clawed hand crept over the edge of the platform and slashed at the back of Mica's leg. She went down to one knee with a suppressed cry of pain, holding off another horror with her hammer.

I cleared the platform in an instant, slashing twice through the three-armed monster on the platform and allowing her to spin around and slam her weapon into the other one's face, sending it tumbling off the edge.

"Thanks," she muttered, pressing a hand over the fresh cuts.

"A-Arthur?" The sound of Ellie's voice drew my gaze back across the platform.

Staring with wide, wet eyes, Ellie was pressing both hands against her sternum. Blood was gushing freely between her fingers and running down her front.

Her stomach was a red ruin, and I could see clear through her to the emptiness beyond.

Boo roared, his claws rending and tearing through the monster that had appeared behind Ellie while I was helping Mica, ripping it to tattered pieces.

With a sick lurch, time slowed, and the distance between me and Ellie seemed to grow wider and wider.

Ellie's knees buckled and she started to fall. Moving in a daze, I swept her up in my arms, gently easing her to the ground, my hands flailing against hers as I futilely attempted to help.

"I d-didn't think…" Ellie said, struggling to speak as her body and voice both shook uncontrollably. "I'm s-so sorry."

"No no no." Desperate, I empowered Aroa's Requiem, remembering my visions in the keystone. I only need better insight, maybe I could…but no, there was nothing. Like God Step, it was dormant, a useless mark on my skin. I pushed aether into the wound, urging it to do *something*, to heal her the way it could heal me.

My vision was growing blurry. The bloodstained hands at the ends of my arms didn't even feel like mine. They were trembling so hard flecks of blood were splashing off them. I didn't know what to do.

'Arthur, what's wrong?' Regis thought from the next platform, but my mind was buzzing with static, and I barely comprehended his words.

Boo was trying to get to Ellie, his roar blending into the hurricane rush of blood pounding in my head. When I pushed him back, his claws slashed across my shoulder in fury, but I barely noticed.

Because even as I watched, Ellie's tear-filled eyes lost their spark and rolled back, her body going stiff as a final labored breath came out of her lungs, and then she sagged in my arms.

All life was gone from her.

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BLACK DOORS II

A CHOKED sob lodged in my throat as I stared down at Ellie. My mind was blank. I grasped for sense, but the image of her ripped open and crimson with her own blood seemed so impossible, so unbelievable, that all reality shivered to a halt. The only thing to penetrate my brain aside from the horrible sight was the mournful roaring and tramping of Boo behind me, which felt like a manifestation of the emotions I couldn't shake loose myself.

"…thur!"

A hand was on my shoulder, squeezing and shaking. A heavy wave of aether rolled outward from my body in response, and the hand pulled away. Distantly, I was aware of Mica and Lyra struggling against the monsters.

A shadow crossed over Ellie, and I looked up into Regis's bright eyes, now full of our shared despair. He phased into incorporeality, then took on the shape of a wisp as he sank down into Ellie's body.

My spark of hope was doused before it even fully manifested. *'She's… gone,'* Regis thought, drifting around her core. *'Wait. There's something wrong—'*

The weight of Ellie's body vanished from my arms as she became transparent. For a moment I could see plainly how the dark wisp of Regis settled into her outline, then they both vanished, dissolving like the monster that had killed her.

I opened my mouth to yell or curse, but only a wheezing breath came out.

“W-what happened?” Mica asked, batting aside a grinning skeletal beast, but not before it took a chunk out of her side.

“Regent…Leywin, you must…release your—”

Rage flared within me, and I spun on Lyra. The Alacryan retainer shrank back and fell to her knees, succumbing to the force of my intent. Aether formed into a sword in my hand without my conscious manipulation. There was fear in her eyes, radiating as bright and clear as the reflection of my weapon.

Grimacing, I swung the blade.

It carved through flesh and bone. A brief shriek of pain, then silence.

The monster that had manifested behind Lyra collapsed into two pieces, then melted away.

Closing my eyes, I forcefully retook control of my aura. When I opened them again, Lyra was watching me warily. She swallowed heavily, then eased back to her feet, as if she was afraid that any sudden movement might set me off again. In the next instant, her entire body flinched at a roar from Boo. The bear launched itself at another attacker, ripping into it mercilessly.

What am I going to do now?

‘You have to go on without us,’ a somber voice answered in my mind.

I froze. *Regis?*

‘Don’t worry about us. We’re in heaven now. It’s beautiful. Nothing but busty demon babes as far as the eye can see, you know? Just like I always wanted.’

An eerie tremor ran up my spine. Before I could reply, a light bloomed in the distance, arcing across the empty black background like a flare.

One of Ellie’s arrows.

It *had* to be. Boo looked up from his kill, the light reflecting in his small black eyes, then he vanished with a slight *pop*.

Regis, you son of a bitch, explain or—

‘Don’t speak ill of the dead, princess,’ Regis shot back.

I rushed to the door that would lead me backward, but hesitated, turning to look at Mica and Lyra. Another horror had manifested, but Lyra and Mica were already unleashing their spells.

“Go, we’ll be fine,” Mica said, spinning to slam her hammer into the jaw of a faceless monstrosity.

Wasting no more time, I went through the door. It seemed painfully, impossibly slow moving, dragging me through empty space with deliberate malaise. When I finally reached the second platform, I fired an aetheric blast from my palm, ripping apart two of the monsters, then hurried back into the door.

My heart stopped.

Standing on the edge of the starting platform, staring out into the zone, was Ellie, her bow in hand. Boo stood next to her, nuzzling her and moaning deep in his chest. Ellie, who was pale and shaking, had one hand entwined through his fur, holding on as if afraid she was about to fall.

“Ellie,” I gasped as I stepped out of the door.

Twisting around, her face wrinkled up as sobs overtook her, and she threw herself into my arms, heaving breathlessly. I could do nothing but hold on to her, too shocked to even feel joy that she was alive.

Eventually she pulled away from me to wipe her face on her sleeve. Her eyes were red and swollen, and there was a sense of horror in them that kept her from looking at me straight on.

I stroked her hair and made gentle cooing noises to try and comfort her. “What happened?”

“*What* happened is easy,” Regis said, sitting back on his haunches. “Like our furry compatriot here, we poofed across the zone. Ellie reappeared in her door, and I came out of yours. *How* and *why* it happened…” He trailed off with a shrug.

I pulled Ellie to me, lifted her up off the ground, and pressed my lips to the top of her head. “I’m so sorry, El. I never should’ve…I—” I felt her small hands press against me, and I eased up, allowing her to pull back.

“It wasn’t your fault, Arthur,” she said, wiping her puffy tear-reddened eyes. “It happened so fast. It felt…it was so real.”

I went quiet, unable to think past one all-encompassing fact.

I had *failed*. My sister had died in my arms. Whatever was happening in this zone that brought her back didn't change that.

Reaching into the extradimensional storage rune, I withdrew the Compass.

"What are you doing?" Ellie asked, taking a step back, a slight flush coming to her ghostly pale cheeks.

"I'm going to take you back."

"No, I don't—"

"This isn't a debate," I said firmly, not looking at her. I didn't want to see the expression of hurt I knew was on her face. "I know exactly what you've just been through, because I went through it myself a hundred times in Epheotus. But now, unlike there, we don't know if you'll come back again, or how many times. We don't have any idea what's happening here. The platforms are only going to get harder, and if I couldn't protect you in the earlier ones…"

Ellie grabbed my arm and pulled at me, reminding me suddenly of the way she'd used to drag my mother around the shopping district. Bile rose up in my throat as I imagined telling Mom that Ellie had died…

Warm tears slid down my face. "I can't lose you too, El."

"You won't—Boo, help me!" she sputtered.

The guardian bear sat down and huffed, turning his face away from Ellie. Her grip loosened and slid off my arm. "Boo…"

She approached her bond slowly, but he kept turning, putting his back to her. She sighed and leaned in against him, pressing her face into his fur.

I gritted my teeth and resisted the urge to crush the metal half-sphere in my trembling fingers.

I needed an existing portal frame to use the Compass on, but we had appeared through the black doors. Out of desperation, I activated the relic and focused on the closest door. Nothing happened, of course. There was no shortcut out.

We were trapped.

One of the doors glinted with internal light, and Mica appeared within it. Her breathing was labored, and I almost thought I could hear the rapid hammering of her heart. I released her almost instantly. She solidified in front of her door, her hands patting up and down her body frantically as she confirmed it was really there.

“It’s okay, you’re—”

“I died…” She blinked several times in a fashion that would have been almost comical if not for the horror of our situation. “But…I’m not dead.”

“You’re very much alive,” I said, squeezing her shoulder. “We’re not sure what’s—”

“Oh,” Mica said, the exhalation part gasp, part moan.

I turned to follow the line of her gaze. Lyra had appeared in her doorway, looking slightly green.

I hurried over and, with a spark of aether, drew her out. Her eyes drifted closed, and she took a deep breath, then wrapped her arms around herself.

“I can still feel it, the claws and teeth inside me, ripping and tearing at the meat,” she said in a breathy whisper. “I’ve been subjected to many tortures in my life, but that was by far the worst…”

After taking a few minutes to calm down, we were all sitting in a circle around a small bottled flame that Mica had brought. It took some prodding, but I had convinced Ellie, Mica, and Lyra to eat, and they were chewing mindlessly on some of their rations. Ellie was leaning back against Boo’s side, her focus somewhere deep in the void darkness. Lyra and Mica both watched the flames curl and snap with matching haunted expressions. Regis was standing several feet away from everyone else, his back to the fire.

“When we first arrived here, you two mentioned feeling strange in your own skin,” I said, breaking the long-held silence. “And some of my godrunes are dormant and unusable.”

Mica only grunted in response.

Lyra leaned toward the fire, moving her index finger in and out of one lashing tongue of flame. “You think…what, exactly? That we’re…” She waved her hand in shallow circles, trailing off as she searched for the

words.

“I doubt even the Relictombs can resurrect the dead,” I said, steepling my fingers in front of my lips. “This zone is different. I don’t think it’s real. Not in a physical sense, anyway.”

“What does that even mean?” Mica asked gloomily. She punched the ground beside her. “That feels pretty real to me.”

I shook my head. “I know, but hear me out. When I trained in Epheotus, I spent a lot of time—years, actually—inside a relic called the aether orb. It’s complicated, but it basically manifested my mind and spirit inside another realm, where I could train and fight—and die—indefinitely.”

Lyra hissed. “Vritra’s teeth, that’s cruel even by Alacryan standards. So what we just went through…”

I gave her a tight-lipped smile. “I’ve done hundreds, if not thousands, of times. You…” I looked at Ellie and hesitated. “Experiencing death over and over is something you can never get used to. It messes with your mind and warps your sense of what’s real. I didn’t bring you here to experience that.” *After all, what was the point of going through such trials myself, if not to keep those I loved from experiencing the same?*

“You think this is…like that?” Ellie asked, plucking absently at Boo’s fur.

“I know the djinn have similar magic. In the first two ruins I discovered, I fought the djinn manifestations inside of my mind. It felt real, but it was separate from physical reality. This zone could be too.”

The silence crept back in as everyone considered this theory. After a couple of minutes, Lyra said, “Perhaps this is the universe punishing us, forcing us to feel the deaths of all those we’ve killed…”

“Don’t lump me in with you,” Mica snapped, jumping to her feet and leveling a glare at Lyra. “I’ve always had reasons to kill someone. *Right* reasons.”

Barely audible, Lyra whispered, “From where I stood at the time, so did I.”

Mica scoffed but sat back down, glaring into the small flame. “We need some kind of plan of attack here.”

“Agreed. Even if we cannot die here, I have no desire to experience that again.” A shiver ran through Lyra as she finished speaking.

We discussed it for a while. Although no revelation was made about how we could progress deeper into the zone, it provided an opportunity for the others to rest and rebuild their confidence.

But one aspect of our progress in particular continued to vex me. I didn't voice my concern out loud, but those last moments where it was just me and Ellie on the platform were the most difficult and dangerous.

How can I protect Ellie from the increasing number of monsters while we both have to concentrate on creating the connection between doorways?

My aetheric powers had given me the strength to reclaim a lifetime of training and power in a matter of months, but I was well aware that there were limitations to what I could accomplish with such limited flexibility.

'The problem with a sword is that it's only as useful as the swordsman's ability to wield it,' Regis said, watching me from across the fire. *'Which, of course, is why I am the superior weapon.'*

When I was a quadra-elemental mage, I had a dozen spells at my disposal that would have been more effective. I need to be able to defend myself without one hand tied behind my back, so to speak.

'You're thinking about the second djinn projection,' Regis noted, frowning.

I should have pushed myself harder to learn her techniques.

'Isn't the point of all this insight business that you have to discover these things for yourself?' Regis pointed out.

It's not enough. If I can—

I cut myself off, acknowledging the spiraling pattern of my thoughts. It was a deep, twisting road down the path of self-doubt and regret. And another part of me knew that I had learned what I could, or what I had to in order to progress. Now, though, was one of those times. Without increasing my skills, there was no way to get my companions through this zone.

"Don't think talking's going to get us any further," Mica said unexpectedly. When she turned to face me, her huge hammer coalesced in her hands. She let the hammer's head fall heavily to the floor, and I felt the weight of it tremble through the mana. "I don't care if I die a thousand

times, I'll be damned if I'm going to let this place get the better of me."

Beside her, Ellie gave me a grim-faced nod.

Lyra unfolded from her sitting position, rolling her shoulders as she stood. "Indeed. Though, I would prefer to avoid feeling the grasping claws of death again…"

I studied my companions for a moment. Although I could sense the scars of their experience hidden just beneath the surface, outwardly they projected strength and defiance. With aether, I plucked at the force that was always tethered to me. Black scales inlaid with gold feathered into existence over my body as the relic armor enveloped me.

Mica cracked her neck and gave me a vicious grin. "I'm ready. Let's do this."

"I wasn't ready for that," Mica gasped, wiping vomit off her mouth.

She was on her hands and knees, a pool of sick splattered across the ground beneath her, but I understood the reaction. Watching as a headless horror pulled her intestines out through a gaping hole in her stomach wasn't like the quick deaths I had experienced at Kordri's hands so many times.

Taking her under the arm, I helped lift her to her feet, then wiped a streak of bile off her cheek with my sleeve.

As we had moved to the fourth platform, the horde of grotesque monsters had overwhelmed Mica before Lyra could even arrive. Regis had fought them off, killing enough to make way for Lyra, and the rest of us tried to push on. Unfortunately, it had taken Regis three attempts to find the fifth platform, and in that time Boo fell under a wave of attackers.

Deciding there was no point in moving forward, we headed backward, but that proved just as difficult, and Lyra perished on the way, dragged off the platform by rending claws. But at least my sister hadn't died again.

Once Mica was steady on her feet, I went about releasing the others from their doorways. Boo seemed unphased by his repeated deaths. Lyra was quiet, and the others seemed to take their cue from her.

I wasn't sure how much of this they could take.

"We need to move faster," Mica said after the post-death fog had cleared. "Sometimes there are multiple doors facing the next platform, right? We should send two through at once."

"But that removes two people from the battlefield," I countered.

"True, but it would speed up getting two of us to the next platform, which is when things are the most dangerous for us," Lyra pushed back. "You are always the last to leave one platform for the next, and you are the strongest. It is as the rest of us move to a new platform that we are going to struggle, especially the first person there."

Regis hummed deep in his chest, almost more of a growl. "Even if Ellie and Arthur can keep up with sending two more or less at once, there have only been a couple of platforms where that's even an option. Really, whoever is following me needs to get there and turtle up until help arrives."

"Then send me first this time," Lyra said, not quite able to hide the quaver of fear in her voice. Mica scowled, looking as if she wanted to argue, but Lyra forged on. "My defensive spells are more potent. If we can't be sent at the same time, then I go first. You've"—her tone softened somewhat—"had it worse than I have. It is my turn to take that risk."

Mica's anger morphed into uncertainty, then begrudging acceptance. "Yeah, all right. Whatever."

"Third time's a charm," Regis muttered, then vanished through a door.

As Ellie finished firing the connecting arrows between two doors, Boo's image vanished from the door in front of us. I was keeping tabs on the battle at the next platform through my link with Regis. So far so good.

Ellie transitioned from preparation to combat with growing ease. Arrows of white light and pure mana leapt rapidly from the string of her bow, hitting target after target. We were on the sixth platform, and the monsters were surging constantly from the void, manifesting two or three at a time.

I counted in my head as I cut them down, moving constantly so as to try

and protect her from every direction. Her arrows picked off some just as they formed, but any who closed in on us, she left to me.

My blade carved through a slashing arm, severing it at the elbow, then reversed direction and bit deep into the monster's boney hip. With my free hand, I pulled Ellie away from the scything claws of a four-armed horror that was skittering up from behind. With a forward kick, I sent it flying off into the void, where it vanished, reabsorbed by the darkness that birthed it.

Vaulting over Ellie, I came down blade first, bisecting a headless creature from shoulder to hip. Two closed in on me at once, one lunging at my legs while the other leapt into the air, pushing off a skeletal, whiplike tail. Focusing aether into my fist, I sidestepped the low attack as I caught the flying creature on the tip of the aether blade. Its body slid onto the blade effortlessly, and gnashing jaws closed around my throat as claws raked across the black scales of my armor.

A surge of aether from my core answered, reinforcing the armor. At the same time, I yanked my blade sideways, tearing a line through one monster's chest as I released the aetheric blast. The second attacker vanished in a violet cone.

Twenty.

"Ellie, door!" I shouted.

She conjured her arrows, which I struggled to imbue with aether as I simultaneously fought off our attackers. Without her arrows picking them off as they formed, it grew even more difficult.

Her first arrow sank into the corner of the door in front of us. Her second went flying off into the void, aimed at the next platform.

I was surrounded by the grisly creatures, my focus split between getting her into the door and defending her.

The distant arrow sank into the void, falling just short of the door she'd been aiming for. In the quarter second the sight of the plummeting arrow distracted me, one of the creatures darted beneath my swinging blade. It's three clawed limbs wrapped around Ellie, the force of the impact jerking her off her feet and carrying her out over the void.

I jumped into the air, reaching for her.

Her hand closed around mine, but a dozen spindly arms had already grabbed her and were dragging her down. Three more of the horrible things slammed into me from behind, and I was half pushed, half dragged over the edge with her. In an instant, we were both pulled into the darkness, and then everything went cold and blank.

I stepped out of the door onto the starting platform the moment I manifested. Across from me, Ellie was staring out from her door with a defeated expression.

'Well, shit,' Regis thought, sensing my frustration and angst. *'What do we do?'*

Can you hold out long enough for us to get back? I sent, moving to Ellie's door and releasing her. The instant I did, Boo popped out of nowhere, nudging between Ellie and me and growling sternly.

'Not now,' Regis thought. *'Lyra's already wounded, and we're completely surrounded.'*

Only a few seconds passed before Lyra once again appeared in her door. Wearily, I released her. She sank to the ground and leaned her back against it, her eyes closed.

Mica returned less than a minute later. "What happened?" she asked as she manifested. "I felt like we were getting the hang of things."

"I missed my shot," Ellie answered, her voice sinking. She rubbed her hands down her face, then turned away, groaning and mussing her hair. "And then one of those *things* got me and dragged me off the platform."

Mica kicked the ground with the armored toe of her boot. "I really hate this place."

"What now?" Lyra asked, not bothering to open her eyes. "We made it farther, but…"

"But I'm too slow," Ellie said matter-of-factly. "And Arthur has to split his attention."

"Take some time to rest," I suggested. "Prepare yourselves mentally. That's the important part."

"What are you going to do, then?" Mica asked, raising a brow.

“What I do best,” I said with a humorless smile. “Train.”

With a mental command to Regis, I headed for Ellie’s door, taking it to the second platform. As I drifted through empty space, surrounded by the perception of shadows moving within the darkness, I forced my mind clear of all my worries and fears, all considerations beyond this very instant and what I planned to do with it.

When I arrived at the second platform, I moved to the center. With my eyes closed, I pictured the second djinn projection, the woman who had guarded over the keystone containing knowledge of Realmheart. I copied the stance she had used during our battle. The aether, responding to my intentions, flowed into the shape of a blade in my right hand. A moment later, a second blade consolidated in my left.

It wasn’t strenuous to hold them both, but this kind of two-weapon fighting had never been my focus. Acknowledging this fact helped me see part of the problem: I’d learned to fight with a single blade, been taught that my weapon was an extension of my arm.

One of the monsters congealed out of the void, crawling onto the platform and snarling with a mouth that took up most of its face. Yellow eyes stared at me from its shoulders, and a long, segmented tail snapped back and forth.

I waited. When it lunged, I took a step back, letting its claws pass right in front of me. My swords swept across its neck, closing like shears, cleanly removing the grotesque head. The monster dissolved, and I returned to my starting position.

Even now, the way I held a sword, the way I fought, was based on the principles I had learned as King Grey. Kordri’s influence was there, too, in my footwork and timing, in mastery over the micromovements of my blade and body in concert. But really, I was still very much the same swordsman I had been in my previous life.

Except I couldn’t be. It was a limiter, locking my perspective into a single way of doing things. What was it the djinn had said?

“It is not power you lack. It is perspective. Constraining yourself to a system that already exists around you only holds you back.”

I was unknowingly locked into an out-of-date methodology, and this was preventing me from utilizing my own abilities fully. My abilities as a

swordsman made me strong—or so I'd thought, but now I recognized the need to evolve past what I already knew.

"You are trying to win, but you should be trying to learn."

Recalling how a third sword had appeared over her shoulder, then a fourth by her hip, I imagined similar blades hovering around me. Aether flowed from my core. From my peripheral vision, I watched the purple light flicker like sunbeams through stained glass. Sensing my own distraction, I closed my eyes, entirely focused on the mental image.

The aether was there, but I couldn't shape it. Thinking perhaps it was a matter of dividing my attention, I released the blades in my hands.

Another of the things came for me. I listened as its taloned feet scratched against the smooth mana-forged surface. Although I could feel the aether infusing its body, I focused instead on the sound of air rushing over the surface of its dark flesh when it attacked. Eyes still closed, I caught one arm, then the other. A third scraped across the scales of my armor. With a swift turn, I lifted its emaciated body and tossed it, sensing as its physical form was reabsorbed by the void.

Minutes past in this state of flux. I defended myself when necessary, otherwise focused entirely on the aether. I treated it like meditation, letting myself stop worrying about whether it worked as I embraced the effort itself.

I kept track of the time by counting the monsters I slew as they crawled out one by one to attack. Five became ten, became twenty, and then forty. When I eventually lost count, I acknowledged the need for a break and took the doorway back to the others.

Mica and Lyra, who had been watching me for the last thirty minutes or so, avoided my eyes, and I realized I was scowling, my frustration bleeding through my attempts to limit my expectations and stay calm. I wiped the dour expression off my face. "I'm getting closer," I assured them, although I wasn't entirely sure that was true.

The twang of a bowstring drew my attention to Ellie, who was standing on the opposing edge of the platform and summoning arrow after arrow. Some she sent off into the void, directionless, while others she let dissipate. Boo watched her attentively, occasionally making deep grunting and humming noises.

She must have felt me looking at her; she glanced in my direction, but immediately refocused on her training. “I need to get faster,” she said simply.

As I watched another glowing arrow streak through the darkness, I had an epiphany.

“El,” I said, excitement practically vibrating out of me.

She stopped middraw, her lips pursing into a pouty frown. “Huh?”

“I need you to train me!” Moving to stand in front of her, I rested my hands on her shoulders, turning her body to face me directly. “The tether you use to maintain a spell's shape. That’s what I’m missing.”

Her brows furrowed, and she looked at me with obvious confusion. “I can’t teach you that, though. The spellform just kind of…does it. I don’t know—”

“But you do,” I insisted, a smile widening across my face. “The spellform may help you shape the mana, but it’s still your mana. The way it feels, the shape it takes, *that’s* what I need to understand.

Ellie looked to the others for support. “But I—”

Lyra cut in, saying, “It is true that the runes provide the shape of the spell, but it is the mage’s knowledge and understanding that allows them to master it. Although you are just beginning, you still *know* about this spell. Whether you can provide enough context into your understanding for Regent Leywin to share your insight, I can’t say.”

“I mean, of course I’ll try,” she said after a moment, smiling weakly and hanging her bow over her shoulder. “So, um, where do we start?”

Ellie sat in the center of the platform, her eyes closed. Several spheres of mana gently orbited her, each glowing with soft white light.

I was pacing slowly around her in the opposite direction of the sphere's orbit. Realmheart was active, conjuring the glowing purple runes under my eyes and across my skin and revealing the mana particles. There was a constant flow of mana from Ellie’s core into her spellform, which then

sent a thread of mana out to each of the spheres: the tether that Ellie had felt.

She wasn't manipulating the atmospheric mana, which was how a conjurer would do something similar, but utilizing her own purified mana in a method consistent with being an augmenter. But I still didn't understand what the spellform was doing. The effect of sustaining her spell without her conscious input—or even understanding—was closer to how an artifact might work than an actively cast spell.

The important part for me, however, was whether or not I could simulate this ability to do something similar with aether.

One of the threads shone brighter suddenly. "What did you just do?" I asked, homing in on the phenomena.

"It's sort of like…flexing a muscle," she said slowly, thinking about each word. "Like when you are trying to relax before meditation, and you tighten and release each individual muscle. Some of them are hard because you don't use them very often. I've been stretching, trying to touch the tether itself, and I think I just did."

"I saw it," I said, mulling over her explanation.

As I paced, I formed a sphere of aether, the amethyst light of which stained Ellie's mana pink. At a thought, the sphere lifted out of my grasp, hovering just a few inches above my palms.

Thinking of Ellie's description, I began to flex and release the various parts of my focus. Similar to how I'd found the gaps around the edge of the illusion in the third ruin, I needed to bring any unconscious aspects of my aether usage into my conscious mind.

It was difficult. As Grey, I'd learned the internal manipulation of ki, and become exceedingly efficient at it. Then, as a quadra-elemental mage, I'd been an augmenter, shaping mana inside myself before sending it outward as a spell. This had carried over into my aetheric abilities as well, with all my powers either being initiated within my body or channeled through a godrune.

But Ellie was an augmenter as well. She may have had the benefit of a spellform to shape the mana for her, but that didn't change the fact that her technique was still possible.

I returned my attention to her, the spellform, and the tether of mana particles that flowed between Ellie and the orbiting sphere. The key was there. I just needed to find it.

Mica's image in the doorway vanished as Ellie completed the connection utilizing her aether-imbued mana arrows. With one hand, I unleashed an aetheric burst that destroyed three creeping monsters. With the other, I caught a barbed tail that had lashed out at Ellie. Before the monster could react, I activated Burst Step, having already pushed aether into my muscles, joints, and tendons.

The single near-instant step took me across the platform, where my armored elbow impacted against a two-faced horror's skull, crushing it. I still had the other monster by the tail, and its momentum carried it into two more only partially on the platform. All three went flying away into the void in a tangle of shattered limbs.

Arrows zipped past me constantly, leaving bright afterimages in the dark before impacting target after target.

Boo was back-to-back with Ellie with three of the misshapen horrors pinned beneath him. A violet blade of aether spun around the pair, chopping and hacking at anything that came too close.

By studying Ellie's tethering ability, I had been able to visualize something similar, like an invisible third arm attached to the weapon and holding it aloft, freeing my hands and giving me a wider range of motion. It was imperfect. It took very nearly all my focus, and I had to be aware of where it was in relation to my allies at all times; my control over it was clumsy at best.

Still, after several hours of practice, I had learned how to wield the sword from up to twenty feet, which proved especially useful when I was focused on imbuing aether into Ellie's arrows. This had allowed us to progress to the twelfth platform, where Regis, Mica, and Lyra were defending themselves against a horde of attackers.

Boo roared out a warning as a jagged, spiderish manifestation dropped from above, too many arms and legs splayed out as it plummeted toward Ellie.

Aether concentrated in my fist, quickly building up enough pressure to make the small bones ache.

Mentally reaffirming my grip on the aetheric sword, I lifted it above Ellie and slashed with all the grace of a butcher's cleaver.

Ellie dodged away from the falling monster, but two more were clamoring onto the platform less than five feet from where she ended up.

The aether blade sheared off several limbs with the first strike then split the monster in two with the second, raining down thick black ichor. At the same time, I released the aetheric blast that had built up in my hand, obliterating the two other grasping horrors before their claws could reach her.

Lunging across the platform away from the striking tail of another, I headed for the doorway to the next platform. Ellie raced to meet me there, sending arrows back past me. I heard the mana sink into my pursuer's flesh, and its body clatter to the floor.

Ellie conjured two arrows, and I hurried to imbue them both with aether while simultaneously swinging the hovering blade, hacking apart any enemies that got close enough. Boo rushed around the edge of the platform, his massive paws delivering crushing blows to monster after monster.

The first arrow sank into the portal right next to us. Barely an instant later, the second was arcing through the void, aimed at a door almost five hundred feet away.

I knew from the relief on Ellie's tense face that the arrow had hit its mark, and I took Ellie by the arm with one hand as the other pressed against the door. When I channeled aether, she vanished off the platform and her image appeared in the glossy black panel.

Instantly, both arrows detonated as her connection to the mana was severed, releasing my aether into the tether her arrows created, and she vanished again.

Boo howled in pain as a headless abomination with deformed limbs covered in spurs landed on his back and tore at his tough hide, but there were three more between us.

Dismissing the tethered sword, I reconjured it into my hand, set my feet,

and Burst Stepped toward the guardian bear. At the end of the step, I released my weapon. It spun away in a blur, passing through Boo's attacker before dissolving in the void. Behind me, three corpses sloughed to the ground in pieces.

I knew when Ellie had reached the next platform because Boo vanished with a *pop*, and I wasted no time in entering the door myself. Within it, I could more clearly see the next platform and the series of doors surrounding it. Picking one of the three that faced back in this direction, I thought about moving to it.

I drifted forward out of the door and into open space. It was a familiar sensation by now. Little by little, I picked up speed as the void seethed with oozing shadows around me.

During the slow passage of time between the two platforms, I watched my companions battle the now constant surge of skeletally thin humanoid monsters that poured out of the inky black space between platforms.

Regis blazed with violently purple aetheric flames, which he unleashed from his mouth to engulf several monsters at a time. He never stopped moving, throwing himself between our companions and their attackers, absorbing as much punishment as possible.

Mica and Lyra fought back-to-back with Ellie in between them. Walls of jagged black void wind sprang up wherever a monster appeared, keeping the tide at bay as Mica's hammer unleashed cannonball-sized lumps of stone and Ellie fired arrow after arrow. Whenever a creature was able to approach, the oversized hammer crushed it into the ground or a burst of void wind vibrated it apart.

The second I arrived on the platform, Regis vanished into the doorway, and I took up his role as defender. While the conjured horror's claws weren't slowed by the aetheric barrier any more than the mana protecting my companions, the relic armor deflected all but the most direct blows. In concert with my ability to heal rapidly, I shrugged off a number of strikes that would have killed any of the others.

Regis reappeared on the platform a moment later, and my stomach sank, fearing another dead end.

'The exit portal is on the next platform,' Regis thought, excitement bubbling under the surface of his thoughts.

“Hold the line!” I shouted, spinning around slashing claws before driving a blade into the attacker’s chest. “This is it, we’re almost out of here.”

Mica let out a victorious battle cry and slammed her hammer into the ground. Stone spikes stabbed up through half a dozen monsters, then burst apart, sending sharp shards of rock into as many more.

In response, Ellie gathered a silvery orb of mana and sent it into Mica, replenishing her mana levels even as she began to unleash bigger and more devastating spells.

‘Hey,’ Regis thought when he arrived on the distant platform a minute later. *‘It’s safe here. No more H. R. Giger-fever-dream-looking monstrosities.’*

I refused to allow myself to relax with the end so close. A misstep now would be catastrophic. “Mica, you’re up!”

A gravity well formed to one side of the platform, dragging several monsters off it and clearing Mica’s way to the portal. She wasted no time in closing the distance, and I instantly sent her into the door. Ellie and I hurried to imbue the arrows as Lyra and Boo defended us. I supported them with the hovering blade, hacking and chopping at the endless horde.

It took almost a full minute for Mica to appear on the far platform, after which Lyra went next. To better defend ourselves now that we were down to three, Ellie, Boo, and I moved to the center of the fifty-foot-wide platform. Boo guarded Ellie from one side while I guarded the other. We became a maelstrom of aetheric blasts, mana arrows, and razor-sharp claws, keeping back the tide until I counted to sixty in my head.

“Time,” I announced, grabbing my sister and Burst Stepping to the door. We imbued the arrows in an instant, and then I sent her through.

Alone on the platform with Boo, I fell into a rhythm, moving with deadly efficiency as I carved through attacker after attacker. When the minute was up and Boo teleported away, though, I was glad to step through the door and begin my last short voyage through this zone. A smothering mental fatigue was hovering just outside my thoughts, but I could feel it pushing in like the leading edge of a storm.

“So, that’s what it looks like when you go all out…” Ellie said as I stepped out of the door a minute later. Her shoulders were sagging, and there were dark bags under her eyes like she hadn’t slept in days.

Wrapping my arm around her shoulders, I dragged her along with me to the exit portal. She was tired enough not to protest.

I wasn't entirely sure what waited on the other side. According to my mental map, this was the last zone before reaching the final ruin, but I hadn't interacted with any other zone that took me out of my own body. Perhaps we would just wake up, refreshed and ready to go on to the next zone. Perhaps not…

Feeling certain that I wouldn't need the Compass, since we weren't actually traveling anywhere, I reached for the portal.

"Wait," Ellie said, pulling away from me. She hesitated as everyone looked in her direction.

"What is it?" I asked, searching her eyes.

"I know the ruin is important, and obviously reaching it is our goal, but…" She swallowed and took a moment to find the words. "I don't think we'll ever get another opportunity like this." She gestured behind her into the void. "I came here to learn about my powers, to train and get stronger. I think we all did. It's like you said, about the aether orb thing…that's how you trained. Well, isn't this a chance for us to do the same?" She looked at Mica and Lyra. "You both have gotten better already, and I definitely have." Her eyes drifted back to me. "Even you've been able to progress here. You learned that flying sword thing so fast."

She took a steadying breath, then continued. "I don't know what's going to happen between Dicathen and Alacrya—and even Epheotus—but I know I need to get a lot stronger if I want to be able to protect myself and…Mom. I—"

"El," I said softly, reaching out to her.

She batted my hand away and forced herself to stand up straight. "I know what you're going to say, that you'll always be there to protect us, but we both know you can't be. You don't know where you'll be dragged off to next. But my point, anyway, is that we have this place where we can fight and train and even if dying here sucks, we just wake back up. We should take advantage of it."

She took a deep, steadying breath and looked defiantly into my eyes. "We should do it again."

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ONE LAST RUIN

THE NOISE and turmoil of combat filled my senses as I watched each of my companions carefully. Whining squeals of pain erupted from the horde of scurrying monsters, while Boo voiced his battle fury in a roar that shook the mana that made up this platform. Mica and Lyra shouted at each other in turn as they worked side by side to hold off the surge.

Although Ellie herself was quiet, she made the most noise of all.

Three explosions rocked the small platform as Ellie jumped backward, away from the scything claws of a three-armed monster. Her attacker, along with three more of the grotesque manifestations that had only been halfway on the platform, vanished in a flash of white light. When the light faded, Boo was standing between her and the source of the blast.

It had happened so fast I had to replay it in my mind, slower and more deliberate. As she dodged inward, away from the edge, she had dropped three globes of softly glowing mana. Tucking into a roll, she then immediately sent a pulse of mana through the tether connecting her to the spheres, causing them to erupt one after the other. The contained power was enough that she cleared that corner of the platform of enemies.

In almost the same breath, she sent a ripple of mana through the air to Boo. I recognized this as a command trigger for him to teleport. As Mica had rightly pointed out, relying on emotional outbursts to trigger the guardian bear's teleportation wasn't an effective battle strategy, so Ellie had been practicing its control over the last few runs. At the command, Boo had disappeared from behind her and reappeared in front of her, shielding her from some of the force.

This had happened in less than a second. But Ellie didn't pause to catch her breath, because each monster we killed was instantly replaced by another in an endless cycle of conjuration and destruction.

Mica's huge hammer spun around with the grace of a baton twirler, crashing through whole groups of enemies at a time. I could feel the gravitational force of the hammer even from across the platform as it pulled monsters into its path only to pulverize them an instant later. With Realmheart active, I could both see and feel the careful balancing act of mana usage, with Mica actively engaging in mana rotation while simultaneously ensuring the efficiency of each spell she cast.

Although mana rotation had been instrumental in breaking the binding on her core, it was difficult for her to practice or utilize. All this fighting, though, had proven the perfect training ground. In just the short time we'd been training in this zone, her ability to conserve mana had increased severalfold.

Void wind shields appeared and disappeared in flashes like black lightning, warding off any creeping horror that got close to the others long enough for a stone spike, mana arrow, or hammer blow to fell it. As a retainer, Lyra hadn't been trained in one specific role like a normal soldier, but she was a natural Shield. Her abilities took time to come out, but I saw them more clearly as her teamwork with the others improved. But she didn't constrain herself to just defensive spells: scythes of cutting air-attribute mana and bursts of sonic force flew out from her in such quick succession that she hardly seemed to aim at all, and yet every strike found its mark.

Regis darted back and forth across the platform, driving like a wedge through any knot of monsters that lasted more than a couple of seconds, but like me, he held back his full power. He acted as a failsafe, preventing the others from getting overwhelmed while I studied their progress.

As I watched the shadowy wolf prowl outside the arc of Mica's hammer, he suddenly spun, lashing his tail like a whip. The flames of his mane raced along his spine to the tail, flaring like a torch, and a lash of aetheric fire cut across two monsters that had jumped on Boo, sending them sprawling. Boo, in turn, pounced, ripping them limb from limb.

'And they say you can't teach an old dog new tricks,' he thought to me, sensing my interest. *'It's got a ways to go before it's as good as*

transforming into a winged, Destruction-breathing wolf-dragon, but it's useful.'

"We must be doing something right," Mica grunted as she unleashed a spray of stone shards from her hammer, slicing through several monsters before Lyra finished them with a subaudible sonic blast, momentarily clearing the platform of enemies. "The general is *smiling*."

I shook my head, realizing it was true. "Just pay attention—"

As I spoke, an abomination with skeletal wings instead of arms manifested above us, diving toward me like an overgrown bat.

I waited until it was nearly on me, then my fist blurred, and the monster's chest burst apart, leaving a gaping hole all the way through it. The long, shriveled limbs cracked like dry sticks as it tumbled across the platform before finally dissolving into nothing.

I winced, shaking out my arm, which ached painfully from my knuckles to my shoulder.

Noticing that the platform had gone silent, I looked up to see my companions regarding me with confusion and shock.

"Were you able to catch what happened?" Lyra asked Mica.

"No, and I didn't even blink," Mica scoffed, her eyes tracking from my hand up to my face. "What in the molten-rock hell was that?"

"Something I've been working on. Just an idea," I answered, but by then a new wave of aberrant horrors were surging onto the platform.

Ellie, whose eagle eyes had been focused on the void instead of me, raced past, planting a series of disc-shaped mana objects as she ducked between the claws of newly forming monsters. When one fell toward her from above, Boo teleported beside her, knocking her out of the way as he caught the thing out of the air. His jaws closed over its eyeless face, and it dissolved into nothing. An instant later, Boo teleported again, shifting position only a few feet, and all the mana discs Ellie had laid down exploded one after the other. Pieces of several monsters flew in every direction before melting away.

I inspected their performance for a few more minutes, but it was becoming increasingly clear that they were a match for this zone. We had reached the

end of what it could provide. “I think that’s enough,” I said aloud. “It’s time to move on.”

Sweat dripped from Ellie’s nose as she nodded in agreement.

We wasted no time shifting into our well-practiced procedure of moving from one platform to the next. It took a few minutes, but the tension had eased from the process. Ellie and I worked together fluidly, having honed the process to a rapid-fire exchange. Learning to wield the tethered blade felt like trying to teach myself to write calligraphy with my off hand, and I wasn’t sure how viable it would be outside of this place, but the skill had proven essential for clearing the zone.

I stayed on the platform after Ellie and Boo went through the door, focused on nothing but me and the endless stream of enemies. Their claws raked against the relic armor, teeth gnashing and the occasional barbed tail stabbing like a spear, but they couldn’t touch me as I moved fluidly between their attacks, lashing out with fist, foot, and blade, always in the eye of the storm of monsters.

It was like a kind of meditation, almost peaceful after everything that had happened to us here.

I practiced my new technique a couple more times, but each strike left my limbs momentarily stunned and opened me up to attacks from other monsters. Still, it was a foundation.

The flow of attackers never ended, but after a minute or two, I was satisfied. Activating Burst Step, I crossed to the door and pulled myself into it with aether, focused on the very last platform, and began to cross.

My eyelids felt like lead as they struggled open. I couldn’t immediately make out my surroundings; my vision was sleep stained and blurry. I blinked several times to try and clear it. A moan came from somewhere nearby, and I shifted to one side.

The tip of my nose touched something soft, and my sight, which had just started to come into focus, went blurry again. Warm breath blew across my face, and I pulled back slightly, still trying to get a feeling for my body.

Mica was lying next to me, so close that our noses had touched when I turned. There was a poorly suppressed smirk on her face, and she raised one brow. “I always knew you’d try something like this one day.”

Feeling myself flush, I tried to sit up, but the sudden motion made my head spin, and I had to close my eyes again. “What’s wrong with my body…”

“Uh, I’m *starving*…” Ellie said from right next to me. “How long were we in there? I feel like my stomach has half eaten me.”

Boo answered with a low, despondent rumble, communicating clearly that he felt the same way.

The rush of vertigo passed, and I was able to open my eyes again and stand. Mica had pushed herself up onto her elbows and was looking around. Lyra was curled in a ball on Mica’s other side, cradling her head, her face hidden behind a curtain of flame-red hair. Ellie had crawled from my side to Boo, shoving her face into his thick fur.

We were in a short low-ceilinged hallway. It was plain white and unadorned, except for a series of flat black rectangles along the walls, identical to the doorways we had used to navigate the previous zone. Our bodies had been left to lie on the stone floor while our minds were trapped.

“Is everyone all right? Any other side effects?” *Of dying over and over again?* I asked, purposefully not speaking the last words out loud.

“My head feels as though it might crack in two like an egg and give birth to something horrible,” Lyra mumbled from within the cocoon of her hair and arms.

“Maybe she’s been infested,” Mica said, wrinkling her nose at the Alacryan. “One of those ugly things is going to crawl out of her brain. We should put her down now before—”

Lyra unfolded and jolted up into a sitting position, glowering at Mica. “That won’t be necessary, thank you. I believe I am just dehydrated.”

Standing, I approached one of the doors. It was smooth and reflective enough that I could just see my mirrored image on the surface, but I sensed no aether or, via Realmheart, mana within it. When I pressed a hand to the door, it was smooth and cool, but it didn’t react. I could only shrug and turn away, looking instead for the zone’s exit portal.

At the far end of the hallway, a jet-black arch contrasted against the bare white stone. No portal was visible inside of the arch at first, but when I took a few steps toward it, the air distorted, and an opaque, oily portal shimmered into existence.

"Wake your bodies up. Eat, drink," I suggested, glancing over my shoulder at the others. "After that last ruin, I no longer feel confident about what we'll find in this one."

My companions didn't need to hear this twice, as they were all famished and parched. There was some chatter as they dragged out their rations, but only the sound of ravenous chewing—and the occasional creak of a stiff joint—as they devoured several days' worth of traveling food in one sitting.

Meanwhile, I let the wheels of my mind turn, considering what might await us in the fourth djinn ruin. This, though, was more frustrating than helpful, as I could only hope that the last keystone was still in place, and its djinn guardian active.

'What insight do you think the fourth keystone will contain?' Regis mused, drifting around my core. *'Let's see…Aroa's Requiem is aevum, right? The ability to turn back the ravages of time on an object. And Realmheart lets you see mana particles, which helps build an understanding of how mana—and aether, actually—works. So what's the connection?'*

I shrugged, then stretched my neck from side to side in response to the stiffness in my muscles. *Honestly, I don't see how the two fit together, or how either ability leads to an understanding of Fate. We've spent so much time in the Relictombs following Sylvia's message, but we're no closer to understanding why.*

When my companions had finished gorging, they joined me one by one in front of the portal.

Lyra was the first, and when I looked at her inquisitively, she raised her hands defensively. "Fine, I'm fine. I suppose I am adapted to a certain kind of lifestyle, even at war, but my brain is not infested with monsters." She tossed a chagrined look at Mica, who was stowing her remaining food back in her dimension ring.

"Not that you know of," Mica said with a vexing smile, humming under her breath.

Withdrawing the Compass, I used it to fix the destination of the portal, ensuring none of my companions would be sent off into the Relictombs at random. Then, with a deep breath, I stepped through.

Expecting to step from one white hallway to the next as I entered the exterior portion of the fourth ruin, I found myself disoriented, standing amidst piles of collapsed and scorched wreckage. I hardly had time to take it in before Lyra appeared next to me, and then Ellie just behind her. In a moment, we were all occupying a relatively small clear space at the end of a blank hallway. In front of us, a pile of fallen stone blocked the way forward.

"This doesn't look like the last one," Ellie said under her breath.

'Are those…claw marks?' Regis thought, drawing my attention to one large piece of rubble.

I ran my fingers along three lines scored deep into the stone, wiping away a smudge of ash to reveal the white underneath. Looking up, I saw the familiar sterile lighting artifacts. "We're in the right place, but it looks like it's been…attacked."

Mica waved one hand in a slashing motion, and the obstructing rubble collapsed into sand, which quickly ran through cracks in the shattered floor. Collapsed sections of the walls and ceiling revealed a strange sight beyond: solid bedrock, which was marked by fire and claws.

Stepping carefully, I told the others about my experience in the second ruin, which had been failing when Caera, Regis, and I reached it. Whatever had happened here seemed quite different.

"Do you think the dragons attacked?" Ellie asked, digging the toe of her boot into a deep slash in the floor.

"Can't have, as far as I understand," I answered, explaining that asuras couldn't enter the Relictombs.

A moment later, we were grasped by the hall's magic and dragged forward. The collapsed hallway vanished, and instead we were standing in a blank space before the crystal door.

It was in ruins.

Black crystal shards were scattered around the space, crunching beneath

our feet. What remained of the door itself was an uneven, jagged mess, with clusters of crystals stabbing out of the smooth black surface. Every few seconds they would pulse, sending a little ripple through all the individual shards like a heartbeat.

'That can't be good.'

Approaching, I pressed my hand into the portal. Before, the crystals had always shifted to allow me passage. Now, however, they felt rigid and immoveable. Sharp. *Dangerous*.

The godrune for Aroa's Requiem burned gold as I imbued it with aether, and motes of aevum flowed over my skin to spill across the malformed crystal structure. More and more poured into it, filling every nook, then flowing away from the door to touch every individual crystal that had been ripped free of the portal.

As if time were reversing, the loose shards jumped up from the floor and flew back to the portal. The craggy, mutilated ridges smoothed. Fluid movement returned to the edifice, and my hand pushed into it. As the previous portals had done, the crystals rolled smoothly away to make room for my passage.

I looked over my shoulder. The others were watching me with a kind of uncertain awe. "Follow right after. Don't linger." Then I plunged into the portal.

Though I feared the magic itself may have been broken by whatever destroyed the outer chamber, my passage was unaffected. Moments later, I found myself once again surprised by my surroundings.

Ethereal walls, floor, and ceiling drew a loose representation of a room around me in misty white lines. Underlying this immaterial space was the expected structure: the central pedestal, its aetheric crystal floating above it, surrounded by orbiting rings that hummed with intense magic. I tracked the motion, releasing a breath I didn't realize I was holding.

"It's working," I said to myself, relief washing away the tension in my shoulders and behind my eyes.

One by one the others appeared. The instant the portal faded away after depositing Mica, who brought up the rear, I channeled aether into my fist.

The immaterial shell of the blank room faded away like tattered clouds on

a strong wind, leaving us standing on solid stone bricks. Lyra clicked her tongue in disappointment, and I heard Ellie's bow creak as she put tension on the string.

Mica approached the whirling rings, holding up a hand and closing her eyes. A curious, playful smile lit up her face. "It's…singing."

But my focus was elsewhere.

A strong aetheric presence was moving cautiously through the chamber, circling around us. It avoided coming too close, and when one of my companions would move, it would alter its course to keep its distance. I tracked it from the corner of my eye, ready to conjure a weapon if its behavior changed.

"So…what now?" Ellie asked, running her fingers across the crumbling stonework of one wall as she moved around the room's outer edge.

"We wait," I answered distractedly.

Mica and Lyra exchanged a glance, both tensing. A moment later, they jumped as the hidden figure coalesced.

"Don't worry," I said quickly, holding up a hand to stop them from attacking. I knew they couldn't harm the projection but worried they might do something to interrupt the trial.

The djinn's projection gave us an amused smile. His skin was a dull lavender color, and like the others I'd seen, he was covered in spellforms everywhere except his face. The crown of his head was bald, with a curtain of white hair hanging to his shoulders below it. Even his bare scalp was marked with spellforms.

"I applaud your restraint," he said after a moment. "Interesting, that you can sense me but your companions cannot. Then, you have the mark of the djinn upon you already. I am not the first remnant you have interfaced with."

"No," I said, offering him a respectful bow. "I have learned from three other remnants already, although one of those no longer had a keystone to offer me. I'm hoping you do."

The djinn's violet eyes flashed with some internal light, and it seemed to shrink. "I see. Your journey so far has been strange and…unfortunate. Let

us not tarry, then, but proceed with your trial."

The ruins dissolved into a blank white canvas, and my companions vanished. Even Regis, who had been safely hidden within my core, was gone.

The djinn moved to stand in front of me, his hands clasped behind his back, his stance wide. "You have been tested on your senses, reactions, awareness. Through circumstances I do not understand, you were even trained in *combat* by a rebel djinn's bitter essence. Then, due to what can only be seen as a failure of the Relictombs' design, an opportunity to further test yourself was taken from you. Most unfortunate."

The djinn went quiet for some time, but his eerie stare never left my eyes. "The Relictombs, it seems, has failed."

I started to protest, but hesitated, really taking in the djinn's words. "You mean more than the loss of a single keystone, don't you? But how has it failed? What was the purpose of all this?" I asked, gesturing at the blank background.

Expecting to hear the same refrain of "That information is not contained within this remnant," I was surprised when the djinn answered. "The creation you call the Relictombs is nothing less than our civilization's combined knowledge in both mana and aether. It is a living library, a multidimensional encyclopedia containing all our insight. Everything we'd come to understand is contained within, and each chapter is intended to—"

"Chapter?" I asked despite myself, not intending to interrupt.

"What you call zones," he said. "Each one is not a test as you see them, but rather designed to provide insight into some aspect of aether. One only has to move through the chapters to gain insight into the tools we used to write them. Even then, it was an imperfect solution, but such is the only way we could teach these skills to future generations."

"For a nation of pacifists, the djinn have protected their creation pretty violently," I pointed out, the memory of my companions' repeated deaths still very fresh in my mind. "If this place is supposed to be a library, why all the awful monsters?"

The djinn looked down and away, a cascade of different emotions passing over his soft features. "Much of the Relictombs was built as our civilization crumbled. There is a certain…darkness that crept from the

subconscious of our people as they sought to protect this, our greatest and last work. We djinn could move through it safely, and we knew that whoever eventually claimed our knowledge would discover how to as well, or would be strong enough to bypass these protections."

"But your people…" I trailed off, unsure how broad the programmed memory's knowledge really was.

"Are gone, I know," he said. His jaw clenched, and he turned away for a moment. When he met my eye again, though, there was a deep sadness there, not rage. "The dragons couldn't—wouldn't—understand. And so they burned our civilization, attempted to scour us from the world. But a powerful descendant of the djinn stands before me, so they have not succeeded."

Since this remnant seemed much more amenable to answering questions than the others, I pushed further. "I've seen the power of Kezess Indrath firsthand. But with everything your people accomplished"—I again indicated the blank slate surrounding us—"I still don't really understand how you were wiped out. If your knowledge was so important that you enshrined it in this…place, then why not fight to keep it alive in you?"

"The answer is not simple or satisfying," the djinn said, sighing wearily. "Perhaps, though, this trial will help you understand. Or perhaps it won't. You should know more than you do, have much greater insight. The fact that you have progressed so far while understanding so little speaks well of you, Arthur Leywin, but poorly of our design."

Unsure how to respond, I stayed quiet.

The djinn smiled more warmly. "But do not despair. You are something we could not have foreseen. It is enough to give an old djinn hope. But I will not hold you back from your purpose any longer. Steel yourself. This trial will be unlike any you have faced in the Relictombs thus far. Let us begin."

422

THROUGH THE DJINN'S EYES

LIGHT AND COLOR bled across the blank white canvas in greens, blues, and purples. My surroundings ran like watercolors, coalescing into a stained-glass diorama before finally realizing recognizable shapes. I found myself sitting on a soft cushion made of a deep navy material. In front of me was a small wooden desk, expertly crafted to highlight the whirling grain of whatever alien tree it was crafted from.

A couple dozen similar seats and desks were arranged in tidy rows under an open-air pagoda carved of soft white stone and tiled with an iridescent cyan material I didn't recognize. A clear stream ran through a shallow trough in the middle of the floor, separating the seating area into two halves.

At the edge of the pagoda, the stream joined a larger body of water as it tumbled off a cliff's edge. Standing, I moved to the edge to look down. The spray from the waterfall lightly obscured a sprawling city spreading out from the base of the cliffs. When I tried to focus on the city, though, the mist seemed to shift and swirl, preventing me from focusing on it.

"An illusion," I whispered. The voice that came out wasn't my own.

Looking down, I realized the skin of my arms was a light pink. Spellforms covered much of my exposed skin. But more than that, I was small—a child, perhaps the equivalent of eight or nine years old in a human context.

"Very good," someone said from behind me.

Spinning, I realized it was only the djinn remnant. His hair was a couple inches shorter, and he'd lost less of it, but he was otherwise the same. He was standing on a dais raised four inches or so above the floor, from under

which the stream was bubbling.

“Please, sit.” He gestured to the cushion I’d occupied when the trial started. Wordlessly, I did as he requested. Something shifted in his posture and expression, but it was difficult to read. “You are here today to test your aptitude and knowledge, pupil, so we may best judge the future of your individual learning. First, explain what you know of the relationship between mana and aether, if you would.”

I glanced around, uncertain, before focusing on the djinn. “Really? This is the trial?”

The shadow of a frown crossed his face, but it passed in an instant, and he gave me a reassuring smile. “It may seem elementary, but it is my Lifework to gain a full understanding of my pupils’ knowledge and talents so that they may fulfill their potential in their own Lifework.”

“I preferred the fighting trials,” I mumbled under my breath. Louder, I said, “Mana and aether are simultaneously opposing and collaborative forces. Although they have unique defining properties, they constantly press against one another, shaping each other. The metaphor I was taught used water and a cup. In reality, if mana is like water, then aether would be a waterskin, because they are both changeable with the appropriate force exerted by the opposite, but I don’t think that metaphor holds up either.”

I paused, thinking. “No, a more appropriate comparison would describe aether as an arrow and mana as the wind.”

“Your understanding is rudimentary. Blunt,” the djinn replied immediately, but there was no disapproval in his flat tone. “You view aether as both a tool and material—a thing to be wielded and utilized. Your thoughts are muddied by the violence of your past experiences. This mechanical explanation of how the twin forces of mana and aether interact is accurate at a surface level, but you do not understand what *separates* them.”

My fingers drummed across the surface of my desk as I attempted to suppress a twinge of irritation. “Can you correct my mistakes, then?”

The djinn’s head turned very slightly to the side. “But you haven’t made any mistakes.”

My knee began bouncing of its own accord. “But you just said—”

“I have voiced observations. Truths, not judgments,” the djinn said with an air of scholarly diplomacy. “My purpose is to help you direct your efforts in the future. Your path is fluid, not deterministic. Next question: given only the strength and magic currently at your disposal, how can you participate in the progress of our nation?”

I stared at the djinn. “Your nation? But…”

Something clicked into place. The shift in his demeanor, the absence of current context in his questions and responses…this conversation was taking place as if I really were a djinn child living before the genocide of his people. He wasn’t addressing me as Arthur Leywin, but replaying what must have been an oft-repeated exchange with real children from a very long time ago. Whatever else this test was, it was also a look directly into the heart of the djinn people before their extermination.

I decided to be forthright. “Instead of building an encyclopedia, I’d build walls. Based on what I’ve seen in the Relictombs, I don’t understand why you didn’t transplant your entire cities into the aetheric realm. You could have protected yourselves.”

The djinn nodded. “Violence, again. You—” The djinn faltered, stumbling a step. One hand pressed to the side of his head as he eased himself down onto the dais.

I started to stand but froze. Was this a part of the trial? Or had I broken some parameter or disrupted the remnant’s thoughts by not playing along? “Are you all right?” I asked after a moment, easing back into my seat.

The beautiful clifftop scene melted away, the colors running and darkening like wax. I had to close my eyes against the vertigo of the sudden shift. When I opened them again a few seconds later, I was still seated, but everything else had changed.

Rows of dark wooden benches faced a raised podium, behind which sat three hooded djinn. The building’s interior was brightly lit by high arched windows lining the walls to my left and right. Through them, I could see the cliffs in the distance, and at the top of a thin waterfall, the cyan-roofed pagoda.

Birdlike creatures flitted among the rafters high above, chittering happily, but the light and cheer of the surroundings did not extend to the many djinn present.

I blinked several times as I tried to look at the djinn crowd, but beyond a vague impression of unease, or perhaps disappointment, I couldn't focus on their features. Except for the three behind the podium, only the djinn remnant, who was standing at the back of the room, was clear.

One of the presiding djinn cleared their throat, and a spellform began to glow on their neck. When they spoke, their voice was magically amplified, filling the room without volume like they were standing right next to me. "It is a rare and sad occasion when there is need to convene this council, the Legal Body of Faircity Zhoroa. Today, we address the crimes of the defendant: abandonment of his Lifework and the corruption of aether to devise implements of hostility. As is tradition, first, we will allow the defendant to explain his actions."

Judges, I realized, recalling my experience in the High Hall. *This is a courtroom.*

All eyes turned toward me. Thrown off by the sudden transition into this new scene, I struggled to form a response.

An indigo-robed djinn standing next to me rested his hand on my shoulder and gave me an encouraging smile. "Just speak the truth. Remember, everyone here is eager to understand."

"But maybe I don't," I said slowly, trying to wrap my head around the judge's accusations of crimes I hadn't even existed to commit. This trial-within-a-trial was clearly purposeful, however, and my response was not only expected, but would be gauged by some metric I wasn't aware of. "Are these accusations even crimes? What keeps me chained to the same job…Lifework…forever? Can't I change my mind?"

The three judges nodded under their hoods, and then the central figure spoke again. "Is this the defendant's only response?"

"A life's work can't be abandoned, only change its course," I said, getting my footing as I tried to fathom the trial's purpose. "And as for my use of aether as an 'implement of hostility,' I make no defense or apologies. The aether itself is eager enough to adopt a destructive form. Why would there be something like an edict of Destruction if aether wasn't intended to be used as such?"

The central judge leaned forward, deepening the shadows under their cowl. "Is it not the role of civilization to use those natural elements at our

disposal to suppress their destructiveness as well as our own? Fire may burn, and water drown, as is their nature, and yet we call it wrong to harness them for this express purpose, do we not?"

"Maybe not if the person you are burning is an enemy intent on doing the same to you," I answered, immediately regretting my flippantness. I didn't want to risk somehow failing the trial. "What I mean to say is, surely there is some allowance for defending myself." I struck on an idea and decided to run with it. "After all, I've seen some horrible and violent aetheric creations guarding the Relictombs. Grotesque monsters, deadly traps, terrible implements of war. And all created to safeguard the djinn's knowledge. Why is it acceptable to guard knowledge but not lives?"

"You answer questions with questions, and in doing so ask that we provide your defense for you," the judge said. "So be it. We will deliberate."

Suddenly, the courtroom spun. The dizzying sensation lasted only a fraction of a second, and when it stopped, my perspective had changed.

I found myself sitting behind the podium, facing the other two judges. "And you?" one asked, as if we'd just been having a conversation. "What is your judgment of this case?"

Needing a moment to think, I made a point of looking over the podium at the defendant. The indigo-robed djinn was still there, but a stranger with purple skin and a body covered in jagged spellforms sat beside him staring up at us, the flame of defiance burning within his eyes. The illusion was so real that it was difficult to remember that this wasn't actually happening. This man's life didn't hinge on what I was about to say because he'd been dead for a very long time, if he'd ever lived at all.

"Law isn't always justice," I answered. "It seems like this djinn has only done what he thought was right. And someday, your descendants may look back on this moment and agree with him."

"For five thousand years, the djinn have constructed a nation built on the peaceful acquisition of knowledge," the central judge explained. "Disease, hunger, violence—these are all symptoms of an ailing civilization. It is not our advancement in mana or aether arts that is our greatest accomplishment, it is our civility. Should we allow outside forces to take that away from us? If we lower ourselves to the station of our enemies, then we have already lost. This is why our law is written as it is, and as today's presiding judges over the Legal Body, we are responsible both for

upholding the law and the good of both our great city and the wider union. What then, is your judgment?”

I couldn’t help but shake my head. “I judge his actions justified.”

The other two judges nodded, then the light vanished as deep shadows enveloped the courthouse. Everyone turned toward the windows, craning their necks to see. Everyone except the djinn remnant guiding my trial, who was staring at his feet. Then the scene melted away again, the shadows deepening until I couldn’t see anything at all.

When the light returned, my surroundings had changed yet again.

I was in a spherical chamber, surrounded by djinn. A domed stained-glass roof let in the sunlight from above in a thousand shades of purple and blue. Flowering vines grew up the walls, and little streams trickled along the edge of the stairs that broke up concentric rows of amphitheater-style seating. Every seat, it seemed, was filled.

Next to me, the djinn remnant had a faraway, unfocused look in his eye as he stared down at two people seated opposite each other from across a round table. Something was carved into the table, but I couldn’t make out the details. And I didn’t have the attention to spare on wondering what it was, because the mere sight of the man sitting on the far side of that table was like a lightning bolt of shock through my nervous system.

Kezess Indrath.

There was no way to know how long ago this vision had happened in the real world, but he appeared no different than he had when I’d just met with him in Epheotus. Everything was identical, from the style of his cream-colored hair to the cool, distant quality of his hue-changing gaze, which was aimed like a weapon at the djinn opposite him. Despite his relaxed posture, though, he possessed some intangible quality that made him feel like a fox in a chicken coop.

The djinn, a woman with blue-tinted skin and hair so fine it seemed to drift around her scalp, appeared to have just finished speaking.

“My position hasn’t changed, Lady Sae-Areum,” Kezess said, oozing ostentation. “Your knowledge of the magic arts called aether are a danger to your civilization—this entire world—and must be folded into the dragons’ understanding of it, no matter the effort or cost. There is simply no alternative but for your people to teach mine.”

The audience was entirely silent. The remnant next to me shifted in his seat, though, revealing the tension gripping his body like an electrical current.

"You seem to think that you only need to visualize that the world operates in a manner of your choosing to make it so," Sae-Areum replied, a bone-deep sadness in every word. "But it is exactly this inflexibility that has stopped you from gaining further insight into aether arts. We *can not* teach you, not in the way you wish to be taught."

The slight wrinkle of Kezess's nose communicated more than the most hostile of sneers. "We know what you're working on. Honestly, I approve. Our world of Epheotus is something similar: a piece of this world drawn into another dimension, planted there and grown by my ancestors' ancestors. So the question is, if you are so convinced the asura can't learn djinn arts, why are you trying so hard to keep them from us."

A piece of this world drawn into another dimension…

Kezess's words lodged in my brain like a broken bone in a wolf's throat. Although I knew Epheotus was a realm of its own, not a physical place on this world, I was shocked to realize that the asura had created it themselves, and immediately spiraled into wondering how such a thing was even possible, or where exactly it was. Were there more dimensions, places separate from the physical space where this world and, presumably, my old home of Earth resided?

The aether realm, I thought immediately. *It must be something like that, perhaps even the same place.* Before I could think further on it, though, my attention was forced back to the moment.

"We are not," Sae-Areum said placidly. "But your warning of what awaits any civilization that becomes too magically powerful encouraged us to look beyond the bounds of our own world and the narrow scope of our own timeline, and in doing so we realized the true importance of ensuring our knowledge is written down in a way that will never fade. It is no easy thing to pass on insight, Lord Indrath, even to the receptive."

A tinkling, dangerous laugh escaped Kezess. "But we dragons aren't… receptive, is that what you're saying?"

"I have explained our position, and you yours." Sae-Areum's gaze swept the quiet audience. "Does any djinn here wish to make their heart known?"

The audience was silent. I couldn't even tell if the djinn remnant next to me was breathing, he was so still.

Did no one answer her? Did no one argue, or plead…or get angry?

I stood, and a tremor ran through the room. "You can't give the dragons what they want. Not only because they still would have wiped you out, even if you'd done so. No, the real reason is that their understanding of aether is, at its core, flawed. They lack the ability to gain further insight because they won't reconsider the foundations of their knowledge."

I paused, thinking about what I wanted to say. This was a test, after all. I needed to express myself clearly, because I thought I was starting to see the purpose of all this.

"Their sense of superiority and infallibility prevents their civilization from advancing," I continued, my baritone resounding through the chamber. "The dragons—all the asura—are entirely beholden to Kezess's strict worldview. Chained to it. Regardless of the strength of their physiques or power of their magic, they do not *grow*. Not anymore."

Kezess's eyes darkened to a thunderous violet as he stared right through me. "The djinn custom of letting all voices be heard, even in a matter of state such as this, is a tiresome one, Lady Sae-Areum. If you are not wise enough to treat with me individually, perhaps I am speaking to the wrong djinn."

"And yet, isn't that the descendant's point?" Sae-Areum asked, but the words sounded like a whisper in my ear, like they were meant only for me.

"But the truth is," I continued, stepping down onto the bench in front of me and passing right through two djinn, "this decision is already made. You don't want my input, because I can't change what already happened. I doubt even Fate can rewrite the past like that, can it? But you're judging my intentions, my ethics, and my understanding of your people. And, in a strange way, I think you're trying to confirm whether you did the right thing or not."

I stepped from bench to bench until I reached the floor, not twenty feet from where Sae-Areum and Kezess sat. "So have my answer. You did the only thing you could do—what *you* thought was right."

Sae-Areum didn't look at me, but she smiled and absently traced her finger

along the grooves carved into the round table. Kezess stood, giving me a piercing look. I expected him to have some rebuke, but instead the scene dissolved, turning to ash and blowing away.

I thought perhaps it was over when everything became white, but, like when I was first drawn into the trial, light and color bled across the blank white canvas. This time, though, it was soot-gray and bright orange and ruddy crimson. My surroundings ran not like watercolors but like the flickering of a flame.

The same pagoda from before took shape. The cyan roof was blackened and half collapsed. The stream was gone, drained away through the floor where a crack the width of my fist had opened up in the stone slab.

A distant roar trembled in the air, followed by the forge-fire rush of flame and wind, drawing my attention to the city. Zhoroa, they had called it. Clouds of smoke billowed up from flames a hundred feet tall, thick enough that they blocked out the sun and darkened the sky for miles around. And the dragons were still attacking, breathing fire so hot the stones glowed orange and ran like blown glass.

I wasn't alone. A woman was sitting at the pagoda's edge, her feet where the stream once joined the narrow river before it plunged down the cliffs. Even the river was gone.

"Lady Sae-Areum…" I said, reaching out a hand before realizing it was my own hand, not that of a djinn.

She turned to look at me, and I realized I was wrong. She had the same blue tone in her skin, but her hair was darker and thicker, flowing like water instead of floating on the air.

"What should we do?" she asked, the despair so thick and sharp in her words that they clawed at my heart. "Tell us what to do…"

I started to reach for her to make some futile comforting gesture, then remembered where I was and let my hand fall. This scene was different than the others, somehow. After the meeting with Kezess, the trial seemed to be over. I'd realized its purpose and answered as best I could.

So why, then, is it continuing? I wondered. Out loud, I said, "Your choice is already made."

She swallowed heavily and wiped away her tears. "And was it the right

thing to do? If it happened all over again, would you follow our path, descendant?"

I watched the wheeling dragons breathe death on the city for a long time, half expecting the trial to end and return me to the ruin, but it kept going. It expected something else from me, clearly.

I've spent the entirety of both my lives struggling to become more powerful, I thought, sure the djinn mind that was conjuring all this could read my thoughts as plainly as if I'd spoken them. *If Kezess led his dragons to burn Dicathen tomorrow, I would fight them no matter how hopeless the battle.*

Did that mean it had been wrong for the djinn to refuse to fight, though? *If their final days had been spent at war, perhaps the Relictombs would never have been completed. And then all their knowledge, the memory of their entire civilization, truly would be gone.*

"You thought it was. But no, your way isn't mine," I said at length, in answer to the sobbing girl's questions. "Perhaps, in the eyes of this trial, that makes me unworthy, but I hope you can see I only want to do what *I* think is right, too. If no one fights back, our world will be crushed between the Indrath and Vritra clans. Then, what good will guarded knowledge be?"

The flames died down, and the ash-filled smoke smothered the landscape. When it cleared, I was standing in the crumbling ruins once again. Ellie, Boo, Lyra, and Mica were all leaning against the wall or sprawled on the floor.

Some small movement must have given away the fact that I was back with them, because Ellie yelped and jumped to her feet. "Arthur! Are you…in there?"

I nodded and cleared my throat. "How long was it this time?"

Mica pushed away from the wall and crossed her arms, looking sour. "Almost an hour. A little warning would have been nice."

'Back from total brain death, huh? And here I thought I was going to inherit all your vast wealth if you didn't come back,' Regis thought, chuckling in my mind.

You couldn't see any of that? I asked.

‘Nope, quiet as a grave in here the whole time.’

Disconcerted, I turned to the crystal hovering over the central pedestal. “I don’t understand what the purpose of this all was. Why show me these things?”

The crystal pulsed, and the djinn’s voice echoed out of it. “It was a test.”

“Did I pass?”

The extradimensional storage spellform grew warm on my arm as the crystal spoke. “It is not my place to judge. You must decide for yourself. I’m only a memory, after all.”

Activating the rune, I drew out the nondescript cube cut from dark stone that had just appeared in my dimension rune. “Can you tell me anything about what this keystone contains?”

A barely audible static hum vibrated from the crystal, and then it said, “No. But that does not mean I can’t help you. The process of your mind, the weave of your thoughts, is very different from the djinn. This could be fatal to your understanding, or it may allow you to become something beyond what we ever imagined. Either way, know that the path forward will be difficult.

“But I feel compelled to say that I, at least, believe you will accomplish what you’ve set out to do. The four spellforms locked within these keystones are themselves a map toward a deeper insight. Our greatest minds theorized that if one could understand these four edicts of aether, then perhaps they could also gain insight into Fate itself. It was a distant, desperate hope, but now that I have met you, Arthur Leywin, I believe it may actually happen.

“I…feel a sense of loss.” The crystal gave a melancholy hum. “It has been a very long time that this piece of my consciousness has watched over this keystone. Now, I am the last, and soon I will be gone.”

“Can you tell me anything about what happened to the third keystone? The missing one? If I can verify that Agrona somehow recovered it—”

“That information isn’t stored within this remnant.”

Knowing instinctively that time was running short, I voiced another thought that had lingered in the back of my mind since speaking to Kezess.

“During that conference with Lord Indrath, he claimed that Epheotus was taken out of this world and housed somewhere else, and that the djinn were creating something similar. What is the place where the Relictombs are contained?”

“You should understand better than I, as you bear a godrune that connects you to the inner fabric of the universe,” the crystal said, almost sounding amused.

“God Step,” I said softly to myself.

Several layers of understanding settled into place, completing a picture that I hadn’t even realized wasn’t complete.

“The godrune doesn’t reveal hidden pathways,” I continued, feeling my expression slacken, “I’ve been using the connective tissue of this word, the in-between place where Epheotus and the Relictombs are, to move.”

The godrune burned against my back, casting a dim golden light through the room.

‘It changed,’ Regis noted, drifting down through my body to inspect it. *‘The design is more complicated.’*

My understanding had changed too, but before I could activate the godrune, the crystal spoke again. “The damage to the external edifice has been very draining for me to maintain. You have already seen how I was forced to withdraw the energy from the secondary illusion that should have impeded progress to this room. I will need to manifest a portal for you to leave through, but it will drain what energy I have left. Apologies, Arthur Leywin, but you must leave now.”

“That doesn’t sound great,” Mica said. “We should probably listen to the talking-crystal-gyroscope-thing, right?”

“Yeah,” I said distractedly. Then I looked at Ellie, and the bottom dropped out of my stomach as I remembered every single time she’d died in front of me in the last zone. “We’re ready. And…thank you.”

The crystal hummed again, much louder this time, and we all floated upward through the immaterial, transparent floor of the nonexistent room above. Through the crystal’s power, the floor hardened, allowing us to stand on it, and then a rectangular portal swirled into existence, inset in one wall.

As this happened, the rest of the room began to collapse, the aether maintaining its shape being shifted to the portal.

Withdrawing the Compass, I hurried to connect the stuttering portal with its other half, and a distorted image of the small bedroom came into view. “Go!”

Mica jumped through before the word was even out of my mouth. Lyra urged Ellie through, followed by a nervously mewling Boo, and then went through herself without so much as a backward glance.

But my attention was stuck on the slowly dissolving space around the portal. Beyond it, the twilight purple sea of the aetheric void. I took a step away from the portal and touched the rune marking my forearm. The horror of the last zone, the djinn’s test and everything I’d learned, even the new insight I’d gained into the God Step godrune, it all went out of my mind in a moment.

Because there was one thing more important than all of that.

When I’d been in the aetheric realm fighting Taci, I’d realized that with the limitless ocean of aether, I finally had enough power to complete Sylvie’s egg. But it had remained out of my reach ever since.

Until now.

Less and less of the room remained by the moment as the djinn remnant spent its power to maintain the portal.

‘It doesn’t look like we have time, chief,’ Regis said.

Time…

Holding out my hand, I imbued Aroa’s Requiem. Bright aetheric motes flowed out of me, racing along the edges of the collapsing room.

But nothing happened. “Please, can you hold it a while longer? I just need __”

“I apologize,” the crystal voice said, echoing from all around me. “If you do not leave now, you will be trapped.”

I closed my eyes and sighed, letting Aroa’s Requiem go dim.

With a heavy heart, I turned away from the image of the endless aetheric

void and stepped into the portal.

423

UNEXPECTED VISITOR

By the time I stepped out of the descension portal into my family's room in Vildorial, the others had already spread out. Boo was in the kitchen slurping up something out of a cast iron pot, and Ellie was wrapped in our mother's embrace. Mica had thrown herself down on the couch, heedless of how filthy and bloodstained she was. Lyra was standing near the small fireplace on the far side of the sitting room, her arms crossed and a faraway look in her eye.

Mom pulled back from Ellie just enough to take my sister's face in her hands, inspecting her closely. "You're back in one piece…"

"*Mom*, you're embarrassing me in front of a retainer and a *Lance*," Ellie complained, trying in vain to wriggle free of our mother's grasp. "I'm *fine*, I promise. I mean, okay, I did die like ten times, but—"

"What?" Mom exclaimed, looking incredulously from Ellie to me and back again.

"She's clearly in one piece like I promised," I said, giving my sister a warning look. When this didn't immediately quell Mom's furious worrying, I gave her a smile and pulled her into a hug. "How long were we gone, anyway? It always feels much longer in the Relictombs."

"A few days," Mom answered, giving Ellie a side-eye that suggested she wasn't done with the whole died-ten-times conversation. "It's been busy here though. Lord Bairon has been here multiple times looking to see if you'd returned yet. Apparently some very important visitor is waiting for you at the palace. And Gideon has been driving me a little crazy, if I'm being honest. He's absolutely desperate to study any advances Ellie has

made.”

My sister collapsed into Mom’s favorite chair and started to kick her boots up on the footrest, but she froze when Mom’s brows shot up. With a chagrined smile, she eased the dirty boots off her feet and set them aside carefully, then leaned back and put her feet up. “He’s going to *flip out* when he sees everything I can do. I bet he’ll be so surprised his eyebrows will fall out again.”

I shook my head at my sister’s antics but was still focused on what Mom had said before that. “Who is this important visitor? Do you know anything?”

Mom sighed and shrugged her shoulders. “No, the general didn’t tell me much, just insisted that you be sent to the palace *immediately* upon your return.” Her mouth pressed into a thin line, revealing her irritation. “I told him I may be your mother, but I wasn’t going to order you about. I also reminded him that you’d likely be tired and in need of a good home-cooked meal after traipsing around for who knows how long in the—”

“Mom,” I said, laughing lightly. “It’s all right. Thank you. I’ll go see him immediately.” I turned to my companions. “Mica, you’re free to do as you wish. Ellie, you should clean yourself up and get some rest. Don’t let Gideon pressure you, but track him and Emily down when you’re ready to debrief them on the ascent.”

“Aye, aye, Captain,” she said sarcastically, saluting me with two fingers at her temple.

“General,” Mica muttered sleepily.

“And me, Regent Leywin?” Lyra asked, letting her arms fall and standing straighter, an edge of defiance in her posture. “Will you be escorting me back to a prison cell?”

Tension hung in the air like an electric charge. It would have been the safe thing to do, of course. Disabling her core and putting her on trial for her crimes would have been completely justified. She would always be remembered as the Alacryan who paraded the corpses of Dicathen’s king and queens from city to city while praising the Vritra clan for their kindness and goodwill.

“So you can rest? No, I’m not letting you off that easily,” I stated. “I’m sending you beyond the Wall to check on your people, see what they need.

Consider it both punishment and recompense for your crimes against this continent." To Mica, I said, "Arrange transport back and forth. Lyra of Highblood Dreide is free to move between the Elenoir Wastes and Vildorial." My gaze went back to Lyra. "Just there, understand? This isn't freedom."

Lyra lifted her chin as she regarded me. "I understand, Regent. I acknowledge this punishment and accept an opportunity to aid both your people and mine."

"I want you to represent your people on this continent," I said, softening somewhat. "Those soldiers in the Wastes should know they haven't been forgotten. But all isn't forgiven, either."

Mica had sat up to watch this conversation play out with a growing frown.

"Problem?" I asked, addressing my fellow Lance.

"No, just thinking. Things might have been a little boring if we'd actually killed this skinny Alacryan back when we had her chained up in the Beast Glades."

Lyra snorted and rolled her eyes. "This continent has many positives, but as torturers and jailors, you are woefully lacking." She pursed her lips thoughtfully. "I suppose this is not a *bad* thing, though."

The two devolved into familiar bickering as they headed for the front door of my mother's rooms. Just before it closed behind them again, Lyra met my eye. She gave a small bow, then let the door close.

Ellie smirked. "The great Lance Godspell showing his soft underside to the enemy, who'd have guessed."

"It's a punishment," I said, glowering at my sister.

Mom rested her head on my shoulder. "With all your many responsibilities, you may have an image to uphold to the public, but it's just us here. No need to put up a façade in front of your family."

Ellie broke into a fit of giggling, but I ignored her as Mom pulled away from me and headed through the kitchen arch. She had to shimmy around Boo, who took up nearly the entire room.

"Do you want anything to eat? Or will you be rushing off right away?"

I considered ignoring Bairon's request for at least an hour or two so I could spend some time with her, but the fact that he had come here, to our home, multiple times in my absence made me uncomfortable.

"I should go," I said. "Hopefully I'll be back shortly. I wouldn't mind something hot to eat, if you can reclaim your kitchen."

"If there's any food left in it when I do, you mean," she said, standing on her tiptoes to see over Boo's back. "Go on, then. The world might fall apart if it goes without you for an hour, but your family will hold itself together."

Waving, I headed toward the door. On the way, I carefully kicked the footrest out from under my sister's feet, making her sink half out of the chair.

"Hey!" she grumbled, flicking a spark of mana at me that sizzled away against the aether clad around my skin.

I laughed and opened the door.

"Art?"

I looked back. Ellie wore a serious expression despite the slight flush to her face.

"Thank you, y'know, for…letting me come with you, and protecting me and stuff. I—it was really…cool."

"Love you too, El," I answered with a knowing wink, then left.

The hike through the Earthborn Institute was uneventful. *You've been quiet,* I noted of Regis as I walked. Normally he liked to get out of me as soon as he could, but he had remained in wisp form near my core since before the last ruin.

'I was just thinking,' he sent back, his tone more serious than usual. *'This world is fucked up.'*

I scoffed. "It really is, isn't it." Memories of the djinn trial played behind my eyes, lingering on the city in flames.

'Just makes moments like this, with your family, with Caera back in Alacrya… all of it a bit better.'

All I could do was agree, and we continued in silence.

At the Earthborn institute gates, I looked up and down the highway at the crowds of people. My passage always drew attention, but at the moment I had no desire to be the object of their stares. Instead, I channeled aether into God Step.

A web of interconnecting violet lines appeared, overlaying the city before me, each line connecting two points to create a network that seemed to connect every point to every other.

There had been a subtle shift in my perspective, more an awareness of potential than any visible change in the aether paths themselves. When I had learned to stop just seeing the paths and to hear and sense them under Three Steps' tutelage, it had felt like a significant paradigm shift in my insight. Now, I felt compelled to do more than simply see and hear them. I wanted to grasp them.

The aetheric pathways weren't just doors, tools to be used for simple navigation.

I raised my hand, pulled to these streams of amethyst light that represented another dimension. My fingers twitched as they approached the paths, and I felt a draw from the godrune as it reacted to my intentions.

External to the aetheric pathways, a descending pressure sent an icy shiver down my back.

My arm whipped toward the oncoming source of energy, aether coiling around my fingers and palm as I released God Step.

The aether wound around my hand faded as I saw the vaguely familiar sight of olive-green feathers.

As the shadows receded from the flying figure, I was able to make out its avian body and the single horn sprouting from the owl's head.

Avier, I remembered.

This owl had been the bond of Cynthia Goodsky, director of Xyrus Academy. But he'd vanished after her imprisonment and eventual death.

"I've been waiting for your return," the owl said, bobbing its horned head as it landed on a post.

“So you can speak,” I said. Most bonded animals could communicate with their tamer, but very few could speak to anyone else. “You’re the one who’s been waiting for me?”

“You’re confused,” Avier said. “I understand my appearance hasn’t been expected, and you might be hesitant.”

I raised a brow. “Hesitant, suspicious, either works.”

Avier’s head tilted as he regarded me with wide, intelligent eyes. “To get straight to the point, Aldir has sent me.”

I sobered instantly, but the mention of Aldir’s name only raised more questions. “You were Cynthia’s bond. Why are you working with Aldir?” I asked, voicing the most immediate one.

The owl ruffled its green feathers. “I am not. But I have been waiting too long already, Arthur. I need you to come with me. We can discuss more on the journey.”

Motion drew my eye to the highway, where two dwarves followed by a cadre of guards were rushing toward us. Looking more closely, I recognized Lords Daglun Silvershale and Carnelian Earthborn. I could only watch, mystified, as Carnelian waved off their guards. The two dwarven lords slowed to a quick walk for the last fifty feet. Both were breathing heavily when they arrived, bowing first to me and then to the owl.

Daglun cleared his throat. “Ah, Lord Avier, you left so quickly we didn’t finish our conversation. Before you leave, I would like to extend the respect of this great city, and welcome you back into it any time you wish.”

Not to be outdone, Carnelian added, “Indeed, the Earthborn Institute”—he waved a callused hand to the gates behind us—“would be most interested in hosting you for a longer stay next time. There is much we could learn from one another, I believe.”

Avier’s bushy brows rose as his head turned halfway around to face them. “I’m afraid I do not see that happening, but I thank you both for your hospitality. Farewell.”

The two dwarven lords could only stare, astonished, as the owl hopped into the air and fluttered to my shoulder. “Leave through the third eastern

gate. I believe that will take us most quickly to the surface."

Considering, I realized I really had no choice. If there was a chance to meet with Aldir, I had to take it. Addressing the dwarven lords, I said, "Please inform Virion, the other Lances, and Alice Leywin that I'll be leaving the city for…" I trailed off, raising my brows questioningly to the owl on my shoulder.

"A few days, at least," it answered.

"Of course, Lance," Carnelian said quickly.

"And what of the Alacryan, General?" Daglun asked, stepping forward to be a few inches closer to us than Carnelian was.

"General Mica has heard my instructions and can take responsibility for the prisoner until I return," I said, uncertain why Daglun had thought to ask.

The two dwarven lords exchanged a confused look, but I was already moving past them toward the highway. Skarn Earthborn, Mica's cousin, was among the dwarven guards, and we exchanged a terse nod.

Curiosity bubbled from my companion. *'I wonder where Aldir's been all this time. He's not exactly inconspicuous, is he? But Windsom pretended to be a shopkeeper, so maybe Aldir is, like, tending a bar somewhere.'*

Avier guided me up the highway and out one of the many side tunnels. From there, he flew ahead of me, leading me toward the nearest passage up to the surface. We reached the barren desert at dusk, just as the sun was setting behind the dunes.

"How are we traveling?" I asked as Avier wheeled around above me.

"I will carry you on my back, if you'll allow it," the owl said, stopping to hover in front of me. "That will be the fastest way."

I looked the olive-green owl over carefully. It was slightly larger than a normal owl, but still small enough to comfortably ride on my shoulder. "And how's that going to work exactly?"

'Uncomfortably. By balancing on your tippy-toes.' Regis chortled at his own joke.

The owl made a sound that was more reptilian than avian, then began to

grow.

Its wings expanded outward at a rapid pace, the olive-green feathers morphing into scales of the same hue. As the short neck lengthened, frill-like spikes grew along the spine. The thick, scaleless flesh of his wings and frills was a dim golden color. His beak elongated and widened, becoming a reptilian face with a gaping mouth full of dangerous-looking fangs, and two long horns swept back from the rear of his skull. The powerful legs ended in curved talons like scythe blades, and a heavy tail dangled just over the sandstone.

"You're a wyvern…" I said, recalling what I'd heard about them. They were exceedingly rare, supposed descendants of the dragons that hardly ever interacted with humans, elves, or dwarves. And yet this one had been bonded with a human woman, and an Alacryan at that. "I never knew."

"Cynthia kept my true form a secret at my request," Avier said, his voice deeper and richer than in his owl form. The beating of his wings kicked up sand all around us, but he landed a moment later, the clawed protrusions on his wings curling inward so he could walk on them like front legs. "Now, we have a long journey ahead of us."

"Where are we going?" I asked, not moving to climb onto his back.

He huffed, and the force of his breath blew my hair back. "If you do not trust me, you shouldn't have come this far. But I will tell you. Aldir is in the Beast Glades. I can answer any more questions you may have on the way, but there are things you should learn in the proper time, and from the proper source."

I don't see how we can refuse, I thought, probing Regis for his perspective.

'If it's a trap, sending a strange mana beast you haven't seen since you were, like, fourteen is a weird way to set it,' he pointed out. *'At worst, I'm sure you can turn the experience of being eaten by a thirty-foot-long flying lizard into some kind of training.'*

I suppressed the urge to roll my eyes, aware that Avier's fiery golden gaze was leveled intently on me. After another second, I gave in and jumped up onto the wyvern's back, settling in between two separate ridges.

Avier wasted no time, pouncing straight up into the air then snapping out his wings to catch the hot desert breeze. Wheeling, he turned away from the setting sun and shot like an arrow westward.

Despite saying he would answer my questions, we spoke very little as we flew. He moved with a speed that rivaled even Sylvie's, and the wind cutting past his spine fringes howled against my ears, drowning out all but my own thoughts. I felt myself drawn into a melancholic reverie, the flight on wyvernback drawing my recent failure to bring Sylvie back to the forefront of my mind.

I started paying more attention when we flew over the mountains into the Beast Glades. As the rocky slopes gave way to dense forests, I activated Realmheart, watchful of anything powerful enough to be a threat. The longer we flew, the more the landscape changed; we passed over barren lifeless wastes, putrid swamps, and glass-smooth lakes. We were headed into the heart of the Beast Glades, where S-class beasts that had scared even Olfred Warender resided.

Nothing bothered us, though, a fact I attributed to Avier himself. Cynthia's former bond surprised me once more, making me question how powerful he might actually be when he began putting off a tremendous warding aura, warning away any predatory mana beasts that got too close.

"What have you been doing out here since Cynthia's death?" I yelled over the wind, finally voicing a question I'd wanted to ask since Avier revealed his true form in Darv.

"While imprisoned, she released me from my bond," he answered, his voice carrying easily on the wind. "She didn't want me to risk myself attacking the castle to free her. I think she had an inkling of her fate and didn't want me bound to her when it happened. At her request, I retreated into the Beast Glades."

"I'm sorry," I said, quiet enough that I didn't expect him to hear me. "She deserved better than what happened."

Avier let out a sharp cry that seemed to cut through the air like a blade. Once it died away, he said, "She was very fond of you."

I waited, but the wyvern said no more, and so I lapsed back into thoughtful silence.

Not long after, he began descending toward the forest below. Trees a hundred feet tall with canopies just as wide and trunks thick as watchtowers rose up to meet us. Burning orange leaves swayed in a constant breeze, making the canopy look like a bed of smoldering coals.

When we dipped below the boughs, though, the shadows were as deep as an overcast night, and my vision was nearly overwhelmed by the abundance of mana particles. The leaves, the trees, the ground itself, every aspect of natural growth was alive with mana. And lurking in the distance, each one bearing a forceful mana signature, were mana beasts of impressive size and strength.

Yet even these S-class mana beasts were kept at bay by Avier's warding aura.

Suddenly we dipped down again, and I thought we were going to crash straight into the ground. A deep black shadow within the dim light under the canopy became clear only in the moment before we entered it, and Avier threw out his wings, catching a gentle updraft and hovering. Slowly, we descended down a natural crack wide enough for two wyverns to fly side by side.

Strangely, I could sense no mana from within the crevice, but there was an uncomfortable pressure against my eardrums that made me wary.

As we neared the bottom, flames flared to life in sconces set around the crevice, lighting up the floor beneath us, presumably so Avier didn't accidentally crash into the floor.

Chalky white shapes covered the floor, and when Avier touched down, his talons crunched in the detritus. The bones of hundreds of mana beasts carpeted the floor.

Avier paid this no mind, however, walking carelessly over the boneyard and into a cave that opened off the ravine. The cave seemed dim and empty except for a few more scattered bones, until more sconces lit on the opposite side, revealing a large set of doors carved from matte black wood.

"A dungeon," I said, sliding off Avier's back and approaching the door. Barely visible in the dim light, a scene of some sort had been etched into the wood, but it was too dark, and the engravings too faded, to make sense of. I looked back into Avier's gold eyes, which glowed subtly in the dark. "Aldir is here?"

"Yes," Avier confirmed. "Though we may have to fight our way to him." Reaching out one wing, he sent a complicated series of mana pulses into the wood: a code or combination of some kind.

The doors swung open silently, and the dungeon's fetid breath spilled over us, heavy with death and rot. Regis manifested next to me, the flames of his mane stiff like a wolf with its hackles raised.

Side by side, Regis and I stepped into the dungeon. Avier, his wings folded in on themselves as he walked on the knuckled joint, followed. As the doors closed behind us, more torches lit up by magic, revealing a wide chamber carved out of the dark bedrock. Bones, and even some more recent corpses, lined the walls. The floor was caked with dark stains that crackled under our feet. The instant the torches lit, a shadow flitted down a tall, broad tunnel that opened ahead of us.

"What is this place?"

"No adventurers have reached this dungeon to name it. We call it Hollow's Edge," Avier answered. "Its inhabitants are referred to as ebon scourges. I expected to be back before the dungeon reset, but you were too long in returning."

There was an edge of wariness in Avier's voice that made the hairs on the back of my neck stand on end.

Something moved in the dark tunnel ahead of us.

Stone crunched, and a jet-black mana beast the size of a bear charged out of the darkness. It ran on four muscular limbs like a gorilla, much faster than its size suggested. Its body was glossy black like obsidian, with a shovel-shaped eyeless head that jutted out in front of it like a weapon. Three curving horns extended forward, two from the sides of the flat head and one from the bottom, where a chin or lower jaw would normally have been. In between the three horns, a gaping mouth full of yellow teeth the size of daggers gleamed like a grim grin.

Avier lunged past me, gliding on extended wings. One talon slammed down on the ebon scourge's neck, which was protected by bony protrusions that extended back from the top of its skull half the length of its body. The mana beast, despite its size, was crushed to the ground under Avier's weight, but his talons only scraped across the rock-hard exterior of the skull.

Wings still extended for balance, Avier used his free talon to rip at the scourge's side and belly as it struggled against him, twisting enough to get one huge three-clawed hand around Avier's ankle. Each claw was four

inches wide and twice that in length, and, after a moment of struggle between the scourge's strength and Avier's mana, the scourge pierced Avier's scales, while Avier's talons struggled to wound the scourge.

Aether took form in the shape of a sword, and I dug my heel into the floor. The world blurred as Burst Step propelled me to the mana beast, the translucent blade piercing a hole in its thick skull with a crunch.

Even with a hole in its skull, the mana beast refused to relent, lashing an arm as thick as my torso like a battering ram.

I drove my elbow down to block its attack, but the force of the impact threw me off guard.

Regis was on top of it in an instant. With one of the horns locked between his jaws, he twisted its head around. The ebon scourge roared in defiance and rage, and Avier's neck snapped downward like a striking cobra. His jaws opened, and a stream of emerald flames poured into the scourge's open mouth.

The mana best trembled, its flesh cracking and fissuring in several places, allowing tongues of green flame to reach out.

Avier's fire continued for several seconds before he relented. The smoking remains no longer moved, and both Avier and Regis stepped back.

I brushed myself off and got closer to look at the corpse.

The hardened flesh was formed of dense rock, more like an exoskeleton than hide.

Avier's long, thin tongue snaked out and licked the bloody wound in his leg. Flames curled up from the spot, and the scales healed. "Let us continue."

In the next section of the dungeon, we found a chamber that split off in three different directions. Ebon scourge corpses were scattered across the floor and piled against the walls. Some were split in half, the stone shells of others scored with deep claw marks. One had a scourge horn stabbed through its throat and into its skull, where it must have destroyed the beast's core.

"Do these mana beasts often battle among themselves?" I asked Avier, but his head was on a swivel, and he did not immediately respond.

A hollow roar tore through the dungeon from the tunnel to our left, and we maneuvered into a defensive position, Regis right beside me, his flames rearing, while Avier circled around to the other side, acrid smoke rising from his jaws.

Conjuring a new sword and fixing my footing, I waited as heavy, thumping footsteps resounded down the corridor.

Except it wasn't the squat bestial silhouette of an ebon scourge that appeared.

It was a hulking statue of a man that stepped into the low light, flanked by a bearlike mana beast easily twice Boo's size with rich mahogany-colored fur and black markings like scars down its face.

Avier relaxed. "Evascir. It is good to see you."

The statuesque figure, I realized, was actually wrapped in a layer of stone, like a pilotable golem. As I recognized this, the stonework manifestation crumbled away, and a muscular man stepped out. His head was bald, his skin the color of gray limestone. Inside his earthen armor, he had towered to ten feet tall, but even without it he was still over seven. The weight of his aura would have been enough to crush most people to the floor.

This man was an asura.

"Good timing, Avier," the man said, his gaze landing on the wyvern's injury. "Since you weren't back yet, I decided to clear the dungeon. Guess I missed one."

"Regardless, you have saved us much needed time," Avier answered. "Thank you for coming."

The asura gave the wyvern a nod before eyeing me speculatively. "This is the one you were sent to fetch? Hopefully he is as powerful as he is pretty."

"There's a reason I call him princess," Regis chimed in with a lupine grin.

"Is your initial judgment a formal test or an ignorant observation?" I asked, matching his unblinking gaze.

The asura—a titan, I thought—let out a booming laugh, pure and joyful. "No, not a test, and perhaps a bit biased rather than ignorant, lesser." He gestured to his oversized bear companion, and it moved aside, making way

for Avier, Regis, and me to pass. “Come. Let us leave the stinking wretchedness of these dungeons and return home.”

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CHANGING THE NARRATIVE

CECILIA

"And here we are, once again," I said, glancing to my left.

Nico was flying next to me as we hovered just outside the protective barrier surrounding the western half of Sehz-Clar. Behind us, twenty thousand loyal Alacryan soldiers filled the streets of Rosaere, the city spanning the two distinct halves of the dominion. The translucent shield neatly bisected it.

It was nearly dawn. A cool breeze blew in from the Vritra's Maw Sea, tugging at the steel-gray hair I'd never gotten around to dyeing.

The shield itself seemed different to my eyes now. Whereas before it was an inexplicable monolith, now I could see it clearly. The signs of basilisk mana were obvious as a blood stain, and its underlying structure was easily observed.

On the other side of the shield, I could sense only a meager resistance. Pockets of traitorous rebels were dug into defensible positions throughout the city, but we outnumbered them five to one.

"Seris knew I was coming," I told Nico. "She's pulled her forces back."

Nico was quiet. We'd barely spoken since he ran out of my bedroom after our conversation. I purposefully avoided thinking about the lie we now shared, and the truth that I was keeping from him. But I wasn't ready to take the risk of divulging what I'd learned. Not yet…

Turning suddenly, I flew up higher so all my forces would be able to see me. When I spoke, my voice came from everywhere at once, each

molecule of atmospheric mana my bullhorn. “Warriors! Today, you fight for the spirit of your continent. This isn’t a war, but a reclamation. These traitors have attempted to fracture Alacrya itself by sowing lies and discord. But look!”

I waved at the opposing half of the city. Mana flared as it peeled away from the giant shield and drifted toward the pockets of resistance, making those few thousand men and women glow and highlighting the small size of the force. “Even they know the fight is already lost; the bulk of their warriors have already fled!”

A distant but thunderous roar came back to me, twenty thousand voices raised in a deafening battle cry.

With a flourish, I twirled and pressed one hand against the barrier.

The power of a Sovereign was laced through hundreds of miles of protective energy, pushing out against the rest of the world. My consciousness traced the lines of it, all the way back to Aedelgard, down the network of mana-conductive material to the heart of Seris’s machine, to Orlaeth Vritra himself. I could sense him—the battery on which all this operated—but that was all; I had no sense of what they had done to him.

This time, when I turned my senses toward the mana, it reacted. Like leaves growing toward the sunlight, the individual mana particles that made up the barrier drew toward me, and the entire structure shivered.

Curling my fingers, I gouged them into the shield. When I withdrew my hand, a fistful of immaterial energy came away with it, sparkling like fireflies in the predawn gloom. I opened my hand and let the mana pour through my fingers, where it dissolved into its base form.

The hole in the shield expanded, the edges flaring with flickering white light. The light crawled over the lustrous surface, and the hole expanded, picking up speed with each passing second.

Even though my soldiers couldn’t see my face, I arranged my features into an expression of calm determination. I was a leader at the head of an army, not a child like Seris thought. Wherever she was hiding, I hoped she could see this. What she had labored for years to create, I had just unmade in an instant.

The gap in the shield grew until it was a few hundred feet wide, opening the way for my soldiers, but I didn’t immediately call for the charge. My

gaze followed the receding edge until, with a suddenness that surprised even me, the shield burst like a bubble. One moment it was there, and the next…

“The High Sovereign has proclaimed that any mage, unadorned, or slave who has turned their back on this continent is unfit to live on it. Give no quarter.” I took a deep breath. “Attack!”

The spring-snap noise of catapults firing followed my order like an exclamation as Imbued ammunition arced through the air, past where the shield had been, and crashed among the buildings in the western half of the city. Condensed stones burst apart, sending out deadly shrapnel for dozens of feet. Barrels of flammable liquid shattered and sprayed their surroundings, which ignited instantly, setting the city on fire. Clusters of mana crystals spread out in wide arcs, exploding from the force of their landing and collapsing entire structures.

A shockwave of noise and mana rippled past me.

Enemy shields sprang up all over, and there was a flurry of return fire and counterspells. A blue bolt of lightning shot up from the ground, aimed at me. When I reached out to the mana, it froze, a jagged, dancing line of electricity hanging in the air. A wave ran along the length of the lightning bolt, starting at the end hovering fifty feet below me and racing down toward the ground.

Dozens of smaller bolts exploded outward from the point of impact, and I sensed several mana signatures go dark.

Something squirmed uncomfortably in my guts. *Better a quick death in battle than weeks of torture and starvation in the depths of Taegrin Caelum*, I thought.

“There’s no reason for us to linger here,” Nico said, drawing me back into the battle. “Our side will have this cleaned up quick enough without our assistance.”

Melzri was leading a force from the west to capture Seris’s base of operations in Sandaerene while Dragoth and the soldiers from Vechor patrolled the Vritra’s Maw to prevent a mass retreat.

Looking down toward the center of my soldiers’ formation on the ground, I said, “Echeron, you’re in command. You have your orders.”

My voice traveled on the wind directly to Dragoth's retainer's ears.

"Yes, Legacy," sounded his response, wispy and distant.

I looked at Nico and nodded. "Let's not waste any more time then."

Flying higher up, we sped northward. As we crested the cliffs above Rosaere, several dozen spells—bolts and jets of green, blue, red, and black magic—flew from a series of covered bunkers.

Grunting in annoyance, I grasped the threads of each spell and pulled, dragging the spells off course and forcing them to cluster in the air in front of us.

Nico's staff flashed with red light, and he slashed it through the air in front of him. Retina-searing balls of blue fire bombarded the bunkers, shattering their shields and collapsing the reinforced structures on the mages within.

Condensing all the gathered spells into a storm of multi-elemental bullets, I sent them hurling back down at the smoldering remains of the bunkers, snuffing out the few remaining mana signatures I could detect.

Nico held his position for a moment, watching for any more activity, but I could tell the substructure beneath was clear. "Come on. These soldiers are unimportant. Our real target is waiting for us in Aedelgard, unless she's already fled."

"This is a token defense," Nico said thoughtfully, as if he hadn't heard what I'd said. "Even discounting the presence of any Scythes or retainers—or you—such a meager fortification wouldn't have held for even a day against our superior numbers. So where are her armies?"

"We'll find out soon enough, I imagine," I answered, speeding forward. I sensed him follow, the wind spell he used to replicate flight pushing him along in my wake.

The countryside north of Rosaere was dotted with small settlements and private estates, but no additional fortified locations. We flew at top speed, north and west, and as we approached Sandaerene, I felt the battle long before I could see it. Nico and I kept slightly east of the city, not intending to involve ourselves in the battle; Melzri and Mawar would have things tidily in hand.

Although Nico and I could have breached the shield near Aedelgard as I

had before, avoiding the hundreds of miles flight, the bulk of our army had to attack over ground from Rosaere, and I had wanted them to see me break the shield. In addition, it had been an opportunity to sweep the length of the dominion, making my presence known to the people there, citizenry and rebel mages alike.

Still, I was anxious to put an end to things by the time we reached Aedelgard, where Seris's compound and the shield's source of energy were.

Seris was wily, a survivor, and I doubted I would find her standing on the balcony of her estate waiting for me. After all, she had managed to outwit and capture a Sovereign.

When the city came into sight, I was surprised to see smoke and fire rising from several different locations throughout. A potent mana signature radiated from the city's eastern edge.

"Dragoth already moved in," Nico noted sourly, glancing at me.

I kept my expression impassive. "Unimportant, as long as he hasn't let Seris slip away by disregarding his duties."

All the Scythes—except Nico, of course—were bitter and frustrated with my position. They scrambled for whatever small acclaim they could find, each of them hoping to replace Cadell as Agrona's right hand and prove themselves worthy of their station. It was no surprise that Dragoth had taken this opportunity to win a victory for himself. But it hardly mattered. Given the scale of the coming war, the Scythes were no longer relevant in my eyes.

As we approached Seris's estate looking over the Vritra's Maw Sea, I finally caught sight of Dragoth. He was flying over the estate, his arms crossed, watching us approach. With his sprawling horns and incredible bulk, he looked like a side of beef hanging on the rack.

"You're out of position, Dragoth," Nico snapped once we were close enough to speak.

Dragoth floated up a foot or so in order to look down his nose at Nico. "I had a resource in the city before the shields fell who informed me of a rush of activity. Since your tour of the dominion delayed you, I thought it best to lock the city down." He gave me a sneering nod. "To prepare for your arrival of course, Legacy. Vechor's ships and soldiers are still patrolling

the sea, but if the rats are fleeing their sinking vessel, we haven't seen them."

Perhaps that's because you can't see beyond the confines of your own ass, I thought.

Out loud, I asked, "Has there been any sign of Seris?"

Dragoth shook his head. "The lower depths of the estate are shielded, however. She may be hiding down there. If I know her, she'll have some trick up her sleeve."

"I don't care what she tries," I said, not trying to hide my irritation with the Vechorian Scythe. "This is over."

"Indeed. The fact that I was able to turn one of her own suggests she's lost her touch." Dragoth chuckled. "Made weak-kneed by some unblooded nobody from the other continent…it's no wonder she's fallen so far."

Tipping toward the ground, I flew to one of the open balconies of the estate. Dragoth's soldiers were ransacking the place, dragging out anything of value and tossing it into piles. One particular mage caught my eye; he was standing at attention as if waiting for our arrival.

His appearance was generally unremarkable, but there was a strange duality to him. On one side, he had a red eye and a short horn that stuck up from his black hair, but on the other side, his eye was brown and the horn had been shattered, leaving only a jagged stump half hidden. Still, he didn't flinch back at our approach like most of the soldiers. Instead, he fell into step beside and just behind Dragoth like he belonged there. Several mages broke away from whatever else they'd been doing and took up formation around the two.

"What have you discovered here, Wolfrum?" Dragoth asked.

"We've followed most of the mana cabling down several levels but haven't managed to bypass the door at the bottom. We presume it leads into whatever is—was—powering the shield," the Vritra-born man said in a confident, slightly nasally voice.

"Take us to the door," Dragoth said, then amended, "If that is what the Legacy wishes."

I stopped, having walked through a large solar and into a connecting

corridor covered in fanciful paintings. Instead of replying, I only waved a hand. The young man, Wolfrum of Highblood Redwater, I now realized, hung his head and hurried past me, not meeting my eye. He led us through several more rooms until we reached a steeply descending staircase. By the length of time we followed the cramped stairwell down, I knew we must be deep into the cliffside under Seris's home.

The door in question was a thick iron square inset into the wall. The only sign of how to open it was a dim mana crystal affixed to the wall nearby.

"Whatever magic is Imbued into this door, we haven't been able to crack it," Wolfrum said. "I've sent for multiple Imbuers to help us gauge—"

I could sense the mana inhabiting the crystal, as well as the stored mana in a device above the door that would drag it up into the wall, and a series of clamps that held it firm on the bottom, preventing it from being forced. The door itself was heavily warded against magical force, but the attached mechanisms were reliant on the mana input system and so more easily manipulated. By me, at least.

Disbursing the mana forcing the clamps shut, I activated the chain mechanism. The door shifted slightly, making the floor vibrate, then lifted into the recess above it with a gentle hum.

The space beyond, a laboratory of some kind, was lit with cool blue light from huge glass cylinders full of a glowing liquid. Incredible amounts of mana were suspended within the liquid, and it quivered at my presence.

"Wait out here," Nico ordered the soldiers before stepping warily through the door.

Dragoth snorted. "Don't presume to give my soldiers orders, where I—"

He caught my scowl, and I saw recognition dawn slowly on the Scythe's broad face. "Stay here, men," he said, leaving unspoken the part Nico and I had already figured out: whatever state Sovereign Orlaeth was in, we wanted as few people to see him as necessary.

Glass tubes connected many of these cylinders to each other and a variety of devices and artifacts attached to the walls, none of which made any sense to me. Blank projection crystals dotted the walls like sightless eyes among the other equipment. I glanced at Nico; his eyes were rapidly tracking across the lab, and his mouth hung open slightly. I wished, for a second, that I could have given him more time to enjoy that moment, but

there was something much more pressing to take care of.

Beyond the first rows of cylinders, the center of the lab was isolated by a dome-shaped shield. There was a smokey tinge to its coloration, and it was incredibly dense, but I recognized the source of the mana.

Walking forward, I moved between the bright blue, silently bubbling cylinders, and a larger tank came into view, right at the center of the shielded area.

Orlaeth Vritra was floating within it. The Sovereign had a wasted look to him, and his face was vapid and empty of thought or expression. At least, he did on one of his heads. The other was missing entirely, nothing remaining but the bare stump of a neck that had healed over in a gory scar.

Standing next to the tank, her pearl hair standing out against her black scaled battlerobes, was my prey.

“I promised that I would come for you, Seris. And here I am.”

The Scythe gave me the same frustrating, unflappable smile that I’d seen too many times before.

“Hey,” Dragoth said with a nod to Seris, crossing his arms and leaning carelessly against one of the tanks.

Seris spared Dragoth only a passing glance before focusing on the young Vritra-blooded mage. “All this time, Wolf? Did I really teach you so little?”

He raised his chin, glaring fiercely at the Scythe. “You taught me everything I needed to beat you, my *mentor*. That was all I ever needed from you.”

Dragoth boomed with laughter. “Big dumb Dragoth outplays the dangerous intellect of Seris. Who’d have thunk it, huh?”

Seris picked at her fingernails absently as she regarded the pair from behind her shield. “Hardly. I admit that my feelings are hurt, but it’s better to have trusted and lost than to never have had that potential at all. Besides, I believe that Caera was successful in her escape, was she not?”

“Enough,” I snapped, stepping toward the shield, further irritated that Seris had ignored me in favor of exchanging pointless jabs with an angry little boy. “I thought you were smart, Seris. But you’ve backed yourself into a

corner and are now relying on an old trick that I've already bested. I'm actually kind of disappointed considering the fearful reverence all the other Scythes seem to hold you in."

Before she could respond, I pushed my hand into the shield and ripped it apart.

Or rather, I tried to, but it resisted me.

"Orlaeth still actively controls this mana," Seris said, stepping closer to her side of the shield just across from me. "With it spread so thin and processed through relay after relay to reach the far corners of Sehz-Clar, his control over it was weakened. But here, so close"—she gestured at the comatose basilisk floating behind her—"I think you'll find it *much* more difficult to wrest control away from him."

I lashed out with my mind and mana, bringing to bear the full might of my power. Mana crashed against mana, and the shield trembled. It did not, however, break. "Bring it down," I ordered, focusing all my power into lashing out again.

Nico sent multi-elemental bullets and blood iron spikes into the shield on one side while Dragoth conjured a jagged black war hammer wreathed in void wind and smashed it again and again into the barrier.

Seris only gave us a solemn, demeaning smile for our efforts.

"For far too long, Alacrya has served as the playground of mad gods," Seris said, loud enough to be heard over the concussive blast of so many spells, but not speaking to any one of us in particular. "They breed people like beasts, assign us purpose at birth based only on purity of blood, and cast off any who do not meet their needs. But the truth of our daily lives is so much worse than anyone knows."

Beside me, Nico faltered as he looked around the room in confusion.

"Because all of this—our entire existence back to our bloods' earliest known ancestors—was only to create a people strong enough that Agrona could step upon our backs as he reached toward his ultimate goal," Seris continued, turning to her left, no longer even looking at us.

"Enough!" I barked again. "Back away," I ordered Nico, Dragoth, and the one-horned boy.

Thrusting both hands forward, I pressed against the shield again. The laboratory went quiet except for the incessant droning of the equipment.

Instead of pushing outward toward the mana in an attempt to control it, I drew it into me.

A victorious grin spread across my face as the surface of the smoke-tinged shield swirled. Seris was right, I couldn't break Orlaeth's ironclad hold over his mana, the Sovereign was far too powerful, but I could absorb it as I had done with the phoenix and Sovereign Kiros.

Seris had paused to watch me begin, and sadness overtook her features as she realized in truth that she'd lost. "Agrona has started a war with Epheotus, the land of the gods. He doesn't expect you to win the fight with him, nor his Vritra-bloods, his Scythes, or even his Wraiths. He will burn us all for fuel in the furnace of his ambition, because he doesn't want to be Lord of the Lessers; he intends to be King of the Asuras."

Mana poured into me. I opened myself to it entirely, absorbing until I swelled to bursting. Ghostly flames wreathed me, flickering from my skin as I burned the mana I couldn't contain. "You're wrong," I growled through clenched teeth. "I *will* win his war for him, and then I'll return home."

"Cecilia…" Nico said, sounding uncomfortable as he took a step back from me.

Seris turned her head in my direction, brows raised slightly. "Oh, Lady Cecilia, Legacy born of another world. Forgive me, did you think I was speaking to you?" Her eyes widened slightly, then she resumed facing away from me.

At the same time, several projection crystals lit up around the laboratory.

I faltered as I saw the image reflected in several screens: Seris, seen through a dim gray haze, looking solemnly into the recording artifact, while beside her I sweated under an aura of colorless flames, struggling against her shield like a baby trying to take its first step. Then the picture changed, showing the stairway outside the lab, focusing on the discomforted expressions of my soldiers as they exchanged glances or backed away. Then again, this time on Sovereign Orlaeth's mindless slack-jawed face.

"What is this?" I asked, feeling my face redden as I realized that Seris had

sprung some kind of trap after all, but not yet understanding what it was.

“She’s projecting this,” Nico said, looking from panel to panel. “But to… oh, oh no.”

“Hear me, Alacrya,” Seris continued, projecting her voice as if giving a speech. “Do not believe the lies you’ve been told. Any time an Alacryan dares to voice opposition to this cruel regime, the narrative is always the same. But I do not fight to seize power or to increase the standing of Sehz-Clar, or even because I believe I alone can defeat Agrona. I fight to show *you* that it is possible. Our civilization may have been grown in the Vritra’s fetid soil, pruned by their lack of empathy and humanity, and watered in our own blood, but it is *our* civilization, not the asuras’. It is time to cast down our Sovereigns. You and only you can claim sovereignty over yourselves.”

Orlaeth began to squirm inside his tank, and I sensed a weakening of the shield. I redoubled my efforts, and the flames around me grew.

“Cecil, we should…”

The blood pounding in my ears drowned out whatever else Nico had to say, but I was almost there. In a moment, the shield would fall, and when it did, I would use Orlaeth’s captured mana to pull Seris apart cell by cell.

She must have sensed this as well, because she suddenly strode toward the tank in the center. A bolt of black energy shot from her hand, shattering the glass. Thick bluish liquid poured out, spilling across the floor and filling the laboratory with a preservative stench.

Orlaeth’s body ripped free from the cables stabbed into his flesh, flopping onto the floor like a corpse.

“For those of you who do not believe me,” Seris continued. A blade of dark mana manifested in her hand. “We can change the narrative of our lives. We can make the Sovereigns bleed!”

The sword flashed, and Orlaeth’s remaining head tumbled across the floor, coming to rest face up in the slime, sightless eyes staring at me.

The shield vanished.

The ghost-fire rushed to my hands, and I met Seris’s eye. She was resigned, but still she gathered her mana.

I thrust out with all that power, exalting in it.

Seris's mana flared. And then, she was gone.

"No!" I screamed, feeling like time had wrenched to a sudden halt as I felt the tempus warp on which she'd been standing pull her away.

The flames flared out. Something broke inside of me.

"What?" Dragoth roared, lunging forward to where the tempus warp, embedded in the floor, was now exposed. He said something else, but his words were lost beneath the ringing in my ears.

Gravity seemed to be changing, listing slowly sideways like a leaking ship about to sink. Mana was flowing toward me, smothering me, and I felt like I was sinking below waves that grasped me and tried to pull me under.

But my core was worse. So much worse.

I was on the ground, although I didn't remember falling. Hands were grabbing at me, gripping my face, forcing my head to turn, but the sharp, panicked features staring back at me didn't line up properly. It *should* be Nico, I knew distantly in the back of my mind, but it wasn't *my* Nico…

A spike of pain pulled my senses away from his pale, sweating face to my core again. It was throbbing, aching…cracking.

The core—*my* core—was covered in a spiderweb of microscopic fissures, but even that was wrong because, instead of the mana inside the core pushing outward, all this mana—from the slime covering the floor, the huge lightning-blue cylinders, the equipment—was seeping *into* my core, and the pressure was building and building and building and…

My core imploded.

In an instant that felt like a lifetime, the hard white shell of the magical organ dissolved as it was pulled inward, into the inferno of mana that now raged in my sternum.

I gasped, breathless, tears rushing down my cheeks. Something was happening outside of me, but I had only the vague sensation of movement, shouting, a bust of magic, then I was drawn inward again.

My core was gone.

And all that mana came rushing out in a white explosion. For a moment, I was floating at the center of a blank white universe, as if the blast had wiped the slate clean, leaving behind nothing but me.

Then the darkness rushed in, and everything went black.

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AMENDS

ARTHUR LEYWIN

The dungeon grew darker and more labyrinthine as we continued. Mana beast corpses littered the halls, the detritus of their broken bodies evidence of the titan's incredible strength. The corpses grew larger as we went deeper into the tunnels, and the dungeon became little more than broken walls full of their raw, dug-in nests.

As Avier led the way, I attempted to strike up a conversation with Evascir, but he only suggested I save my questions for one better equipped to answer them.

Our path took us through a second level of the dungeon. We passed through a chamber at least a hundred feet wide and half as high with dozens of dens clawed into the walls. A towering pile of mana beast corpses filled the center of the chamber, including one several times the size of the others. It was similar in shape, but with strange protruding ridges under its belly—some of which were broken off—and a smoldering heat trapped in its three horns, which glowed like coals.

"The emperor scourge," Avier said, noting the direction of my gaze. "A mana beast worthy of hunting, even for an asura."

Evascir grunted, but sounded pleased with himself when he said, "I've slain the emperor of this dungeon more times than I care to consider, but it is always a battle worth recounting."

From this chamber, it was only a short way to our apparent destination: a second set of large doors, the black wood engraved with the image of a huge bird, its wings spread wide. The engraving was inset with some kind

of metal that caught any small amount of light and flickered with a dim orange sheen. Vines crawled down from a crack in the ceiling to frame the door with orange leaves the color of autumn flame.

Evascir went ahead. A tall, reddish stone staff grew in his fist, which he knocked against the ground. The doors swung open, revealing a twenty-foot square chamber and another set of closed doors. His bestial companion took up position in an alcove at one side of the chamber while Evascir pushed open the inner doors.

“They will be waiting in the hall,” he said to Avier, who nodded appreciatively and went through.

I did the same, curious who “they” were and where this place was but withholding my questions. Evascir didn’t watch us walk away, but closed the door behind us and returned to whatever his duty was.

“Is this some kind of…asuran stronghold?” I asked quietly.

Avier’s tail swished in agitation. He paused, turning around to look at me. “Those doors have not been opened to a human, elf, or dwarf since they were carved from the first of the charwood to mature in the Beast Glades. Though you have been invited, it remains to be seen if your presence is welcomed. A king’s grace will suit you far better here than a dragon’s physique.”

Without waiting for a reply, he continued down the hallway.

Instead of the dark, rough stone of the dungeon, this interior passage was warm gray marble studded with silver sconces from which burned little orange flames. More vines grew along the walls and across the curved ceiling, adding a bucolic airiness and sweet autumn scent that made it easy to forget that we were far underground.

The short hallway opened onto a balcony that jutted out from the wall of an enormous room. I gaped down at a garden larger than that of any royal palace, a wild riot of color complete with soaring silver-barked trees covered in bright orange leaves. Several globes floated near the roof of the gardens, giving off a pleasant light that felt like mild summer sun on my skin.

“I thought the dwarves did a good job making their caves homey, but this…” Regis let out a muffled whistle. “It looks more like Epheotus than Dicathen.”

Avier's head bobbed at the end of his long, reptilian neck. "Indeed. In some ways it is. The charwood trees, the plants, these people you see here, they are all remnants of Epheotus."

A few people lounged or walked around the gardens, chatting or just sitting with their faces turned toward the lighting artifacts. Their matching shades of true-flame red or smoky black and gray hair and their vibrant orange eyes marked them as members of the phoenix race.

Those eyes began turning upward toward us as more and more of the phoenixes noticed our presence. Some only watched curiously, but others abandoned their leisure and quickly exited the garden.

'Didn't think I'd see birds less friendly than our tour guide owl here,' Regis communicated mentally.

I cracked a smile.

"Retake your seat on my back," Avier grunted, as if hearing my companion's thoughts. "We will fly from here."

My brows rose at the idea of flying through an underground dungeon, but I did as he suggested after Regis was tucked safely back within me.

Avier stepped lightly off the edge of the balcony, and we drifted out over the garden. The asuras still remaining there watched us go with an air of apprehensive curiosity.

We flew between two of the trees, then down into a yawning tunnel entrance. This tunnel was much more plain than what I'd seen previously, just bare marble that was covered in ashy black streaks like scorch marks. The tunnel split, and Avier banked right, then drifted back to the left, where our tunnel joined with another.

The passage ended abruptly, opening high up into another exceedingly large chamber. My first impression was of a theater with several levels of balconies looking down on a central platform.

Like the other chambers I'd seen, the stonework was predominantly gray marble, but columns of black wood held up the balconies, around which grew more of the vines fringed with colorful fall leaves.

A large circular table currently rested on the central platform, around which sat four people, two of whom I knew well and one I could already

guess at, but the fourth was both a stranger and somewhat out of place.

Avier circled the space once, then landed gently. When I slid to the ground, he transformed back into an owl and fluttered up to a nearby balcony, perching on the railing and watching us with his overlarge eyes.

The four figures had stood up from their seats around the table, watching our approach. Aldir was closest to me. He'd abandoned his severe, military-style uniform for a relaxed tunic and light training pants, and his long white hair draped over one shoulder, but he otherwise seemed unchanged. The vivid purple eye in his forehead watched me emotionlessly, while his two regular eyes remained closed.

Wren Kain stood to his left, draped in a soot-stained white cloak and appearing distinctly out of place in the grand hall. Like Aldir, he looked the same as when I'd trained with him in Epheotus: dirty, tired, and almost purposefully unkempt. The only thing that stood out was a single bright-orange feather in his hair and the way his observant gaze seemed to burrow into my chest to my core.

But it was neither Aldir nor Wren who spoke first.

A tall man with an athletically graceful physique stepped past Aldir. He was dressed in a golden robe embroidered with stylized feathers and flames over a cream-colored silk tunic and dark pants. His hands were tucked into the robes, held together at the waistline by a dark belt. Markings like feather stems glowed like coals down the sides of his face, which had the same air of eternal youth as Kezess's, but where Lord Indrath could only appear dispassionate and smug, this man's sharp-lined face conveyed an undeniable sense of wisdom and curiosity.

He was smiling, but there was something complicated about the simple expression. Perhaps it was the way his eyes blazed like two captured suns.

"Arthur Leywin, son of Alice and Reynolds Leywin, bond of Sylvie Indrath, reincarnated soul of the Earth King, Grey." The man dislodged one hand from his belt and ran his fingers through his untamed mane of orange hair. "I am Mordain, phoenix of the Asclepius clan. Welcome to the Hearth."

I rolled my tongue against my teeth, considering my words. "Thank you for the kind welcome. I realize that allowing me to come here must have been a carefully weighed decision, but I have to ask…am I here at Aldir's

request or yours?”

“Admittedly, it took some convincing on Aldir and Wren’s part for me to invite you here,” Mordain answered without hesitation. “The truth is my eyes have been turned away from your world for a very long time. Except…” He paused, and some emotion I couldn’t identify passed over his features but receded just as quickly. “I found myself quite surprised, then, when they turned my head and showed me you. But I wasn’t immediately convinced that meeting with you face to face was worth the risk.”

Although the courtly thing to do would have been to exchange several rounds of probing pleasantries to inch closer to the conversation's true purpose, I didn’t think Mordain or I had the patience for or interest in such games. “Do you plan on helping us against the Vritra clan? Or even Epheotus, if it comes to that?”

“Straight to the point, and a valid question.” Mordain took a step back, gesturing to the table. “Please, join us. There is much to discuss.”

As Mordain returned to his seat, I met Aldir’s eye. He looked away as he eased into his own chair.

Moving around him, I took the seat next to Wren, who bit his lip as he eyed me speculatively, cast a sidelong glance at Mordain, then leaned toward me in barely concealed anticipation. “So? Where’s the weapon? I can sense the acclorite’s energy within you, but—”

Giving Regis a nudge, I forced him out of my body. Purple fire wreathed the edges of my shadow as Regis manifested, his jaw momentarily slack with surprise.

“A conscious manifestation…” Wren mumbled, leaning forward to get a better look. “And such a unique form. I’ll need to be told everything, of course, about your state of being when the weapon manifested, and inputs prior to manifestation. Personality traits are of primary interest when evaluating a conscious weapon, but acquired powers are essential too, of course…”

Wren trailed off, his eyes darting rapidly, and I could just imagine him mentally cataloging all these thoughts.

“Say hello to your creator, Regis,” I said, suppressing a chuckle.

Regis blinked, inspecting Wren. The flames of his mane were still. “Daddy?”

Wren’s brows wrinkled up, and he frowned at me. “Did this weapon just…?”

“So, you’re the guy who made me, huh? We really need to have a talk,” Regis continued, his tone changing. “I’d like to file a complaint. Being alive is great, and I don’t mind even being a weapon—I am a really *badass* one—but did I really have to come in a box with Lava-Burn Barbie? Do you have *any* idea what this guy has put me through?”

Wren seemed completely flummoxed as he looked blankly between Regis and me.

Mordain cleared his throat. “It seems the two of you have much to discuss. With Arthur’s permission, perhaps you could continue this conversation somewhere else, at least for the moment?”

‘You know how much I love these politically fraught, socially awkward little business meetings, but I’m willing to sacrifice attending if you’d prefer I go chat with this old loon?’

Go, but keep your eyes open, I sent back. *I want to know anything you can discover about this place.*

Wren’s chair floated away from the table, and I realized he was sitting on a stone conjuration. Already talking animatedly, he drifted toward one of the few lower entrances to the chamber, Regis loping along beside him.

After watching them leave, I returned my attention to Mordain, but it was the table between us that caught my eye. Its surface had been carved in exquisite detail, bringing to life a beautiful cityscape. It was a city I recognized.

“Zhoroa,” I said, tracing a finger along the roofline of a building that could have been the courtroom I’d seen in the last djinn trial.

Mordain let out a sharp breath, and his burning gaze swept to the fourth person at the table, who had still not been introduced. The man was broad-shouldered and barrel-chested, wider in stature than Aldir and much bulkier than Mordain, but less tall. His face was broad, with soft but handsome features, and he shared the orange hair that marked most of the other phoenixes, except slightly darker, and with a smokey tinge that

shone purple when he moved and the light caught it.

His eyes, though, stood out the most; one was bright orange, like looking into the caldera of an active volcano, while the other was glacial blue, so light and clear it was almost white.

“That city—and its name with it—has been gone for a very long time,” Mordain said, drawing my attention back to him. “This table is indeed a relic from when that city still stood.”

I pictured Lady Sae-Areum, the djinn woman who sat across a table—this table, I was certain—from Kezess in my visions, and wondered what the connection was between that scene and this place.

But I had to put my curiosity aside, because I hadn’t come to learn about Mordain, or even the djinn.

“This is all interesting, but I feel compelled to address the reason I came here at all,” I said, focusing on Aldir. “I know what I’ve seen with my own eyes, and I know what Kezess has told me—and offered me. I’d like to hear you answer for your crimes.”

Mordain raised a hand, no doubt preparing to interject some complaint, but Aldir stopped him with a small shake of his head. “It is only fair. Arthur was there, after all, when I used the World Eater technique…” My eyes widened slightly. “I felt your presence, though I didn’t realize it was you at the time.”

I swallowed past a lump in my throat as I remembered that moment, my vision flying from Alacrya to Elenoir, where I watched as Windsom battled Nico and Tessia—already turned into Cecilia’s vessel, even though I didn’t know it—and Aldir destroyed the country I’d called home for half of my youth, nearly murdering my sister in the process.

Aldir continued to speak, but I didn’t interrupt as he explained what happened afterward, how he began to doubt his purpose and Kezess’s leadership, was banished from the Thyestes clan at his own request, and fought against soldiers he himself had trained.

He retrieved a small box from a hidden dimension artifact and set it on the table in front of me. “I had at first thought to come to you immediately and offer to assist in retaking Dicathen, but I was uncertain you would accept, and understood all too well how your people would look at me—like a monster. Wren agreed, and so we bided our time, taking up temporary

residence in the flying castle over the Beast Glades, since Dicathen's forces haven't attempted to take it back yet."

"I became aware of them almost immediately," Mordain interjected. "Our security is very reliant on knowing when other asura are around. But it helped that my sources in Epheotus had already informed me of the situation with Aldir, so I was on the lookout."

"Mordain welcomed us into the world he has created for his people, and so I've waited for an appropriate time to meet with you," Aldir finished.

Throughout his explanation, he spoke with the cold efficiency of a soldier delivering an important missive. Clerical and absent of any emotion.

"Are you not sorry?" I asked, the words raw in my throat.

Aldir only nudged the box slightly closer to me. "I've brought you this small token."

I nearly struck the box off the table to shatter on the floor, but I restrained myself. Instead, I deliberately lifted the lid on the box. It was full of dark, fragrant earth.

"Soil from the slopes of Mount Geolus," Aldir said stiffly. "I hope that, perhaps, it may help make amends by undoing some small part of the destruction I've caused."

Slowly, I closed the lid. "Can I regrow the lives you took there, Aldir?"

Aldir did not turn away from me. His two normal, very human eyes opened and met mine.

"Trees aren't a culture or a civilization. A forest won't bring back the elves from the edge of extinction." My voice grew sharp as I spoke, my jaw tightening in anger. "Kezess wants me to kill you, you know. Said it would bring justice to both our people. Even if I choose not to, he's forbidden me from allying with you. In exchange for sharing my knowledge of aether, he's going to help us protect Dicathen from Agrona, a deal which your continued existence puts in jeopardy."

A meaty fist pounded on the table, making the box of soil jump. We all turned to face the young asura with orange and blue eyes.

"You'd come *here* and make threats?" he growled in a deep, bassy voice that vibrated in my chest. "General Aldir has—"

“Peace, Chul,” Mordain said, lowering his hand slowly in a gesture of calm. “Arthur has the right to speak his mind, and we will listen. Although I must admit, I am troubled at the idea of Lord Indrath sending dragons to Dicathen. Even if he upholds his end of your bargain, which he just might if the payoff really is aetheric knowledge, that means that he already has loyal soldiers in position to strike when you are no longer of use to him.”

I kept my hard stare on Chul for a moment longer, then addressed Mordain. “You mean, the presence of Indrath forces will put the Hearth at risk of being discovered.”

“It would, should it come to that,” Mordain agreed amicably, “but things are advancing that are outside of your ken. With the Legacy.” I focused on him, goosebumps rising all over my body at the mention of the Legacy. “Agrona has long held one of my people prisoner. I’ve been able to sense some of what she’s been through, and very recently she was…executed.” His eyes flicked to Chul, almost too fast to see. “The Legacy absorbed all her mana, killing her.”

Chul stood suddenly, sending his chair crashing backward. “And *still* you refuse to move against Agrona!” he shouted, his voice booming like a cannon.

“We mourned the loss of your mother a very long time ago,” Mordain said, his voice soft and full of controlled despair.

“What of you, stranger?” Chul demanded, putting both hands on the table and leaning over it toward me. “Are you afraid to fight back against the Vritra? Will you hide your nation beneath the wings of dragons and stick your head in the sand?”

“Forgive him,” Mordain said, giving the young asura a stern look. “Lady Dawn was imprisoned when Chul was only a boy. He would see us fly to battle, raining fire down on Taegrin Caelum in retribution.”

“Are there others like you,” I asked Chul, “who are eager to leave your hiding place and take the fight to Agrona?”

He crossed his muscular arms and turned his head to the side, looking away. “No. You’ll find that those here prefer to live out their lives strolling in gardens and forgetting they were once the mightiest hunters in Epheotus.”

Mordain stood. I thought perhaps he was going to reprimand Chul, but

instead he gave me a bright smile. “And so an opportunity presents itself. Arthur, you haven’t asked for it yet, but you want my aid in this battle. Chul, you wish to leave and bring your fight to the Vritra clan.”

I saw immediately where he was going with this. “It’s almost amazing, the way you asura can twist things around to try and make what’s good for you sound like the best thing for everyone else, too. It sort of seems like you’re just setting me up to babysit an asura who is straining your patience.”

Chul’s mismatched eyes bulged, and he pointed a thick finger toward Mordain. “You know that’s not what I meant! I want *us* to—besides, what chance does this lesser have against the Vritra, it’d be a waste to—he probably can’t even fight!”

I raised a brow, regarding him passively. “How many battles have you won, asura?”

“Perhaps a spar then,” Mordain suggested, slipping his hands into his belt. “An opportunity to test each other's strength and worthiness.”

Chul scoffed.

“Fine by me,” I answered, eager to release some pent-up frustration.

Mordain gestured for us to stand away. With a wave of his hand, the table was drawn down into the stone like it was sinking in quicksand. Braziers burst alight with bright orange flames, and a translucent shield hummed to life, separating the center of the room from the balconies.

Mordain and Aldir flew to the lowest, most central balcony. “You are trying to make allies of each other. Fight accordingly,” Mordain said. Next to him, Aldir wore a thoughtful frown.

Chul cracked his neck and raised his fists, each one the size of my head. “Ready, human?”

I rolled my shoulders and reinforced the aether cladding my body, but I didn’t conjure my weapon or armor. Instead of speaking, I lunged off my back foot, sprinting forward. Despite his size, Chul was fast. His stance shifted between one step and the next, and his fist burst into flames as it shot toward my face.

Falling to my knees, I slid beneath the punch, hooked his arm with mine,

and let myself be pulled back up by the force, driving my knee into his ribs. Fire-attribute mana exploded out from him in a nova, pushing me backward while I was still in the air, and he pounced after me, his fists clenched together and held over his head like a hammer.

Still in the air, I rolled my body to catch the blow on one forearm.

His strength was like nothing I'd ever felt before.

The power of the two-handed strike slammed me into the floor with enough force that the flames trembled in the braziers. He didn't press his attack, however, but backed off and allowed me time to get to my feet.

"I'm almost impressed," he said, grinning fiercely. "I half expected all your bones to shatter."

"And I expected you to hit harder." I didn't mention the fact that several of my ribs were quickly settling back into place after being fractured by his strike.

Chul laughed, and I recognized that a change had come over him. He was comfortable in battle, much more so than at a meeting table. *Or trying to make a life for himself here in this calm, detached place*.

This time, he moved first. In a flame-wreathed blur, he charged straight at me, lashing out with burning punches and kicks that blistered my skin even through the aether. I struck back, but it was like punching a granite wall. With each strike, the burning energy around him built until he was the center of a raging inferno, so hot even countering his attacks left me with burns.

He wasn't holding back, I was glad to see.

I wouldn't either.

Aether infused my body, heightening my speed and the strength of my muscles, bones, and tendons. Using the technique I had started to learn in the Relictombs, I took a short step and drove my fist forward in a straight jab.

My knuckles connected solidly with his sternum. With a grunt, Chul slid backward several feet, the shockwave of the impact blowing out his burning aura.

He sucked in a pained breath, one hand pressed against his sternum as he

stared at me, uncomprehending.

I heard Aldir hum and spared him a glance. He was holding onto the balcony railing tightly as he leaned forward, engrossed in every movement.

The move was a modification, or expansion, of the same technique Burst Step was built on. By carefully engaging a series of microbursts of aether, I could not only move near instantly, but also strike. It was a technique that would have broken my body as a human, and even now I felt the strain of using it just once, but this simple spar had shown me it could wound even an asura.

After several seconds, the grin returned to Chul's broad face. "Now, maybe this will be some fun after all." With a cacophonous battle cry, he threw himself at me again.

We exchanged blow after blow, our fight growing continually faster as we both sought to push the other to their limits. After a few minutes, I noticed other people starting to slink into the room, watching us at first curiously, then with growing amazement.

It wasn't long before Chul was sweating profusely, his chest heaving with each breath, but his grin remained firmly in place, no matter how hard we fought.

After catching me with a spinning kick that I had expected to be a feint, he stepped back, letting me pick myself up yet again. I could tell from the way he held himself that his energy was flagging.

Suddenly his hand thrust out, palm open, and a roaring fire boiled outward. I Burst Stepped straight through the flames, expecting to catch him off guard, but as I took that near-instant step, Chul was engulfed in a flash of golden light, and I passed straight through where he had been. The brightness overwhelmed me, and I stumbled as I came to a stop. Two huge arms wrapped around me, pinning my own arms to my sides and lifting me up. Chul and I were both wreathed in phoenix fire.

"Yield!" he roared as my aetheric barrier struggled to ward me from the roiling heat.

My bones complained loudly, threatening to shatter under his asuran strength, and my skin began to blister and blacken.

A grin as big and wild as Chul's split my face.

Sensing for the aetheric paths, I moved into them, leaving Chul behind as I appeared on the other side of our combat floor. But I didn't give him time to recover.

I Burst Stepped once more, aether coursing through my body in short, controlled spurts. It felt like I was being stretched in eight different directions, but I gritted through the pain as I focused every fraction of a second on properly maintaining control.

Chul bent sideways as he was lifted off the floor, unable to even comprehend what hit him before a blurring hook snapped his jaw in the opposite direction, followed by a straight jab that sent him barreling toward the shields like a missile.

Thin wisps of violet-tinted smoke rose from my mending arms as the young phoenix crashed heavily against the protective barrier surrounding us and fell to the ground. The shields fell away, and Mordain was at his side in an instant. More casually, Aldir drifted down from the balcony toward me, inspecting me seriously.

I allowed a moment for my wounds to heal as aether seeped from my core into my broken bones and burned flesh.

"I see your physique is no longer a barrier to utilizing Mirage Walk, or at least your version of the technique," Aldir said, brushing out a flame still lingering on my clothes. "A very illuminating battle."

Meanwhile, Chul was struggling to his feet despite Mordain trying to keep him prone while inspecting his wounds. The big phoenix bullied his way past and marched up to me, fists clenched and huffing like a startled moon ox.

"A good fight," I said, holding out my hand.

He looked at the extended appendage, batted it aside, then wrapped me in a crushing bear hug. "A good fight!" he bellowed, making my ears ring. He suddenly released me and took a step back, his fists on his hips. "A good fight, he says," he repeated, grinning brightly. "A damned good one, I'd say."

Not letting his enthusiasm obscure the reason for our spar, I held his gaze until the grin started to fade. "I noted toward the end you seemed to be

running out of energy, though."

He sobered quickly, looking at the ground for several seconds before answering. "I'm only half phoenix. My mana tends to…burn up fast, if I get carried away." He lifted his chin. "But I'm as strong as any asura my age, I can promise you that."

"I believe it," I said. "And I accept. If you want to come with me, I'll gladly take you."

Chul let out an eager *whoop* and thrust his fist into the air.

Mordain ran a hand through his hair, ruffling it. "I know that for you, Arthur, this will just be going home, so to speak, but for the Asclepius clan, and all the other asura who have joined us here, this will be a momentous occasion. If you don't mind, I'd like to arrange a celebration to mark Chul's leaving."

My mood immediately soured as I considered everything that needed my attention back in Vildorial and beyond. "I'm sorry, Mordain. Time may stand still here, but it is rushing by out there, and I don't know when Agrona will strike again."

Mordain's eyes seemed to age rapidly as I looked on, but when I blinked, he was the same as he had been. "Of course. Chul, go prepare to depart."

Chul's face slackened, and I could see the reality of his situation falling on him. "Of course," he said, seeming slightly out of sorts, then hurried off, flying up to one of the many tunnels exiting the theater.

"He has the fiery temper of his mother," Mordain said, watching him depart, "but her strength as well. You'll find no fiercer ally in your battle against the Vritra."

I felt myself frown, catching something that had gone unsaid in Mordain's words. "And what about his father? He's a half-phoenix, he said? Who…" My mind jumped to the table now hidden beneath the stone. "He's half djinn."

Mordain nodded, his gaze moving to the floor as if he'd read my mind. "Some came with us when we found this place. Far too few…we could have saved more, but they would not leave their Lifework, as they called it. Too set on finishing their aetheric vaults, where they claimed all their vast knowledge would be stored. The Relictombs."

I stared at Mordain, his mention of the Relictombs giving me an idea.

The floor rippled, and the djinn table floated up through it, coming to rest once the stone surface had hardened again. Mordain moved to take a seat, leaning on his elbow. “There were very few such pairings, and of the handful of offspring that occurred, most carried as much djinn blood as phoenix. Their lives were…limited in length. At least relative to asuran longevity.”

Regis chose that moment to reappear, walking just ahead of Wren Kain. “What’d I miss?” he asked, in good cheer.

“Good timing. I hope you got what you needed. We’re headed back to Vildorial as soon as Chul is ready.”

‘We’re bringing that meathead with us? We’re going to need a bigger wyvern.’

Maybe not.

“Lord Mordain, you mentioned the Relictombs,” I began, knowing it was too much to hope that they would be able to fulfill the request I was about to make. “I discovered a deactivated portal into the Relictombs underneath an ancient djinn village in Darv. You’ve been in the Beast Glades for centuries…have you found any other old portals in that time?”

His brows wrinkled in a frown, making him look significantly older. “The Hearth, as many of the dungeons that dot the landscape of the Beast Glades, was created by the djinn. There is an old portal here. It was operable for a short while after we took this place as our home, but the djinn who lived here eventually deactivated it.”

My face lit up. “Can you show me?”

After sending word to Chul, Mordain led me and the others along a series of tunnels and past many other curious phoenixes, moving in a general downward direction. Eventually we came to a small cave. Green and gold moss grew in a thick carpet across the floor, and luminescent crystals sprouted from the ceiling, casting a pale blue light on a carved stone rectangle in the center. It was ancient and crumbling, the runes in the stone no longer readable.

Avier glided through the cave and landed on top of the frame. “If you were hoping to use this to transport yourself back to Darv, I don’t think it’s

going to be of use.”

“I haven’t been down here in many years. It’s like stepping into a living memory,” Mordain said with a sigh.

Walking up beside the phoenix, I gently touched the stone arch before turning around to face Aldir.

I held out my hand, revealing Sylvie’s stone resting in my palm. “You said you wanted to make amends, right? This is how you can start.”

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HOPING

ALDIR LOOKED UNCERTAINLY at the iridescent stone in my palm while Mordain sucked in a shocked breath. Avier shuffled across the top of the portal frame and leaned down to peer curiously. Regis's attention homed in on the asuras, sensing that there was some understanding about the egg that we lacked.

Behind the others, Wren Kain whispered something under his breath. He was lounging back in his floating rock throne, absently making several stone spheres orbit above his curled hand.

"This is *old* magic," Mordain said, unable to take his eyes off the stone. "Do you have any idea what it is that you carry?"

"I know Sylvie is inside this stone, and I've been slowly bypassing a series of…locks, I suppose. My hope is that, when I've finished, she'll come back to me…"

Mordain reached gingerly toward Sylvie's egg. When my fingers instinctively curled around it, he blinked as if waking from a dream and let his hand fall. "There is a legend—a myth really—told as a bedtime story to our children that describes a phenomenon like this. True self-sacrifice being rewarded for the brave and genuine. That, though the body may perish, our mind and soul will mold themselves into a physical form and be reborn."

Wren Kain scoffed as he floated closer on his moving throne to better see the egg. "How is it that beings with world-altering abilities still manage to fall victim to fables of impossible magic? It's mind-boggling that you would think it's appropriate to bring up a bedtime story in this situation.

He's asking for help, not to be tucked in to sleep."

"Bedtime story or not, Sylvie is inside," I stated, looking between the two ancient asura. "Regis can inhabit the egg, and I can *feel* that it's her. And it just…appeared, after she…" I trailed off, not wanting to relive the moment of her sacrifice. "Somehow I was transported from Dicathen into the Relictombs, and that egg came with me."

The stone spheres Wren had been controlling fell still as the asuran artificer's face wrinkled in thought.

Mordain took a shaky breath. "Some members of the phoenix race have learned to control their own rebirth, guiding the soul into a new form, but these old tales describe this as something else. A recreation of body, mind, and spirit, just as it was before…" Mordain's gaze traced from the egg in my palm up my arm to my torso. "The draconic aspects of your body…she destroyed herself giving them to you, didn't she?"

I could only nod, unable to speak past a sudden lump in my throat.

"And does Lord Indrath know of this?" Mordain asked innocently enough, but there was an intensity in his burning eyes that suggested some deeper context to his question.

"He does," I admitted, "but he wouldn't give me any further details. I… was hesitant to give away my own ignorance by asking too many questions."

Mordain gave me a wry smile. "Kezess was likely doing the same. Still, if he knows his granddaughter will be reborn…" He trailed off with a shake of his head. "I will have to think on this. But do not let the musings of an old man hold you back from your purpose. You want Aldir's help with something? What, exactly?"

Instead of answering immediately, I stepped up beside him and activated Aroa's Requiem.

Bright motes of aether danced down my arm before jumping eagerly to the portal frame, causing Avier to leap off and fly to Mordain's shoulder. Mordain took a step back, watching with wary interest as the motes flowed into all the cracks and crevices. The portal frame rapidly began to repair, as if time was being turned back before our eyes. In moments, the last cracks had sealed and the final loose pieces of stone were drawn into place.

A dim purple portal hummed to life within the frame.

Aldir's single amethyst eye lingered on the egg as if he could burrow down into its core and see the asuran spirit resting there. "I will do what is needed."

As concisely as I was able, I explained the portal and the Relictomb's relationship to the aether realm in which it existed. Sparing them the details of our fight, I told them how I'd drawn Taci through into that place, accidentally discovering it. I was careful not to give them the impression they could use this technique to breach the Relictombs itself, however, whether it could be done or not. The djinn had chosen to keep even their phoenix allies out of the Relictombs for a reason. I wouldn't be the one to kick the door in for them.

"Sounds utterly stupid and dangerous to me," Wren Kain said, catching me off guard. "You did what you had to last time, but you nearly couldn't escape."

"That was because I was fighting an asura hell-bent on keeping me from escaping."

"Even still." His baggy-eyed gaze turned to Mordain. "In all the years you sheltered djinn, no one ever told you about this?"

Mordain stepped up to the portal and reached out to it. It responded by projecting a repulsive force like a magnet pushing back against another of the same polarity. "No, the phenomenon Arthur has described was never explained or, to my knowledge, used by the djinn who came to live in the Hearth."

Avier hopped up onto the top of the portal arch. "Perhaps they didn't tell anyone because it could be dangerous. For the travelers, the Relictombs, even this world."

"Thank you! Finally, someone speaking sense," Wren said with a scoff. "It sounds like *breaking* something. And while I may not be a mighty dragon or member of the Indrath clan, I can tell you that, when it comes to either mana or aether, *breaking things* is generally pretty bad."

"It is equally as likely that they knew it was too important to keep this knowledge from Lord Indrath to trust even us with it," Mordain countered thoughtfully. "Asuran lives are very long, and the last surviving djinn had

every reason to expect the worst of the future."

"You're all assuming they even knew about the realm," Regis said from where he was lying in the moss. "No matter how smart these guys were, the djinn were idealists to the point of silliness. They definitely didn't understand everything that they created. We've seen that with our own eyes."

I recalled what the last djinn remnant had said. "They were fracturing at the end, too, I think. The Relictombs is…a dark place. Out of character with the way the djinn attempted to live—and the way they chose to die. I think they definitely had a pretty grim outlook on the future of our world, based on what I've seen. Enough to poison their trust even in their only allies."

"Perhaps it is for the best that we'll never see their creation," Mordain said, stepping away from the portal. His face fell for a moment, but quickly brightened again. "I know you are eager to proceed, so I won't press you any further, except to ask how long we should expect you and Aldir to be gone?"

Regis joined me in front of the portal before stepping into me and sheltering near my core. We hadn't discussed if he should come or not, but it felt right having him with me.

Aldir immediately followed, standing just beside me. He was expressionless, neither tense nor placid. Despite my earlier anger with him, I couldn't help but appreciate his fearlessness in this situation.

"Honestly, I don't know," I answered.

With an understanding nod, Mordain rested a hand on Aldir's shoulder. They exchanged no words and yet still communicated something very clearly between them, even if it was unreadable to the rest of us. When this moment passed, Mordain moved around us to the exit of the small cave, and Avier again flew to his shoulder. Together, they watched in silence.

Wren Kain suddenly drifted forward. "Listen, there is no reason to rush this without a better understanding. That stone or embryo you're carrying isn't going to expire. Lady Sylvie isn't going anywhere. You're being stupid."

My brows rose, but Aldir clapped Wren Kain on the arm. "Urgency is a matter of perspective, isn't it? Why forgo doing now what we may lack

time for in the future?”

Wren Kain shrank further into his floating throne. “Well, if you rip a hole in the fabric of the universe and wipe out this continent, I guess that’s on you two.” He focused on Aldir. “Whatever. Just get this done and get back here, all right? If Indrath is sending dragons to Dicathen, we need to prepare.”

“You know I didn’t bring you here to fight a war, old friend.”

Wren Kain blinked and a somber smirk tugged at the edge of his lips. “Yeah…but I was kind of hoping you had.”

Aldir returned the sober smile, then turned to face me.

Each gripping the other’s forearm, we stepped closer to the portal and immediately felt the repulsive pressure meant to prevent an asura from crossing through the portal’s boundary. Aldir’s vicelike grip clenched down hard enough to hurt, and we both leaned into the portal.

It wavered, bending away from us. We leaned farther, then took another shuffling half step.

The stone of the arch shook, and the purple energy of the portal’s surface flexed farther, trembling.

As before, I could feel the opposing forces within the portal attempting to draw me in while rejecting Aldir, but I kept his arm clamped in mine as we took another small step.

My stomach lurched as I sensed the portal reaching its breaking point, like I had stepped on a rotting board in a bridge.

The portal imploded.

A raging aetheric wind dragged the two of us inward, and the world dissolved into fractals of interdimensional connective tissue. For just the barest instant, I recognized the network of aetheric pathways that I saw when activating God Step, then everything went dark.

I was anticipating the mental backlash this time and managed to retain my senses and intention as the aetheric void coalesced around us. Purple-tinged space stretched away in every direction, broken only by the last of the portal energy that was being absorbed into the aetheric soup and an unknown Relictombs zone floating off-kilter below us.

‘Whoa,’ Regis thought, a mental shiver running through his incorporeal form. He flitted out of me but didn’t take the form of a wolf. Little eddies of aetheric current swirled around the dark wisp as he began to absorb the boundless aether. *‘We’ve come a long way since the days of sucking up millipede poop crystals, haven’t we?’*

He was right, but my mind stayed on the task at hand. Regardless of what the aetheric void could do for *me*, I needed it for something much more important first.

Drawing out the stone, I clenched it in my fist. Sensing my thoughts, Regis broke off of his gorging and merged into it.

‘Nothing has changed in here,’ his thoughts came floating back to me a moment later. *‘Her mind is here, still sleeping.’*

I want you to stay in there and monitor everything that happens, I thought, starting to grow nervous without knowing why.

An upside-down Aldir drifted in slow circles nearby, his amethyst eye wide and staring.

I opened my mouth to interrupt his reverie but reminded myself how I had felt the first time I’d been drawn into this place with Taci. The urgency to get here and to begin imbuing the egg cooled. Suddenly, I was…afraid.

“I saw something in a djinn memory…” I said softly. “In it, Kezess claimed that Epheotus was built somewhere like this. A different dimension.”

Aldir hummed in thought. “According to asuran legend, some of our earliest ancestors removed and expanded a piece of your world, creating Epheotus within it. Some believe that the asuras only discovered the path between these two dimensions. But yes, Epheotus is shielded within its own realm, connected to, but not a part of, your world.”

We floated in silence for several seconds as Aldir gazed into the distance, obviously deep in thought. Then his visage sobered, and his attention went to the stone in my hand.

“Do not hesitate on my account,” he said, drawing his legs up toward his body so it looked like he was sitting cross-legged in the air. “Please, do what you set out to do.”

Taking a deep breath, I cupped the iridescent stone between both hands. Simultaneously pushing and pulling, I began imbuing aether into the stone while drawing it from the rich atmosphere. *Aether rotation, based on mana rotation, the very art taught to me by Silvia, now the lesson I'll use to save her daughter*. This and many other thoughts flitted through my mind, but I kept my focus on the flow of aether now filling in the complex geometric designs inherent to the stone's inner structure.

Several minutes passed as I balanced on the precipice of this exchange, absorbing and imbuing. It became clear that, despite the depths of my aetheric reservoir, I wouldn't have been able to complete the layer outside of this realm with its endless supply of aether. My mind wandered, trying to piece together the wider puzzle that the egg presented.

If Sylvie's egg was a naturally manifested phenomenon, how could it have such a complex structure? The comparison to the godrunes I received was immediately obvious, and just as equally a mystery. Sophisticated magical constructs didn't appear by coincidence, an accident of a universe always in motion. Unless…

I considered the aether itself. Particles of magical force capable of divining intent and responding accordingly. The dragons believed that aether had its own designs and purpose, and even the djinn's teachings suggested it was conscious. Was it somehow the source of both the egg and the godrunes?

With no answers, only questions, I forced my mind quiet and let myself be absorbed into the rhythm of the process.

'Something's happening,' Regis said after several more minutes.

I focused on the stone; it was nearly full and starting to throb in my hands. The pulses came faster and faster, like a quickening heartbeat, and then something cracked.

Outwardly, there was no change, but I had been expecting this and immediately pushed more aether into the structure.

It didn't take it.

Regis, what can you sense?

'Her mind stirred when that layer broke, but now…I'm not sure. I think there's another layer, but I can't feel it the same way.'

Neither can I…

I felt sick. I was missing something, clearly *had* missed something, but what?

If only Kezess or Mordain had known more, maybe—

A pair of strong hands wrapped around my own. Aldir was floating right in front of me, all his eyes open, giving me an understanding smile. “Aether isn’t enough,” he said simply, and then I understood.

Unfolding my hands, I let Aldir press his own on top of the egg. Instinctively, I activated Realmheart to watch the process. Aldir’s mana—bright, strong, and pure—was flowing rapidly into the stone. A minute passed, then two, then five…

Nerves began to eat at me. I knew the pantheon general was powerful, but here, in this place with no mana, would he be able to sate the starved egg?

The aura around Aldir began to dim as more and more of his total mana reserve was given over to the egg. After ten minutes, I was about to demand he stop when the internal structure of the stone suddenly shifted again with an inaudible crack. Sweating and sagging under the weight of his own body, Aldir pulled back.

For the first time since I had known him, the third eye gleaming in his forehead was closed.

‘It worked, another layer opened up. I can’t be sure but…I think this may be the final lock.’

I firmly resisted the impulse to look into the egg, focusing instead on Aldir. The act of giving up his mana had left him diminished. “This isn’t why I asked you to come here.”

“But it is why I came,” he said weakly, forcing his two normal eyes open and regarding me with weary sincerity. “I knew before we entered the portal that I would not be returning.”

“What do you mean?”

“As punishment for my act of war against Dicathen and my treason against Lord Indrath, you will imprison me in this place,” he said, his voice unwavering. “It is a fitting punishment, and will be a victory you can take to both your people and to Kezess.” A silver rapier shimmered into

existence in his hand. He held it out to me. “My sword, Silverlight. Proof of my death.”

I stared at the blade but did not take it. My jaw worked as I gritted my teeth, considering my response carefully, then finally saying, “Keep it. Use it to fight beside me, against Agrona and Kezess both.”

Aldir smiled sadly and gave a small shake of his head. “I believe that my days of fighting are done. I won’t kill more of my own kind, even to get to Kezess. Both your world and mine deserve more than endless war. I hope you find a way to end the threat posed by the Indrath and Vritra clans without mass casualties.”

“Quitting is a luxury people like us don’t have,” I pushed back. “We don’t always get to live life as we’d choose, Aldir, especially when it is over. We both have a responsibility to that world…”

I took in his expression, the way he held his body—like an old man struggling to stay upright—and the flagging focus of his mana, and my words died on my lips. I could only stare at him, my churning thoughts suddenly still. His mind was made up, and any argument I could make seemed futile. Unable to meet his eye, my gaze slid away from him, settling on the distant Relictombs zone without truly seeing it.

“Don’t look like that on my account,” Aldir said, straightening to his full height. “I have lived a very long, very violent life, and for the first time, I am truly tired, Arthur. This place…it offers me a quiet, peaceful end. Perhaps more than I deserve.”

Carefully, slowly, I took the sword. “So be it then.”

Aldir’s third eye slowly opened. He gave me a respectful nod, then turned and began to drift away. I could only watch as he grew smaller and smaller against the endless purple sky. Eventually, I blinked, and when I opened my eyes again, I couldn’t find him at all.

Between Regis and me, there was only silence. We shared the same sense of loss for words, not yet able to comprehend the repercussions of this decision.

I took a deep breath and looked sadly down at the stone in one hand and the sword in the other. “Silverlight,” I whispered into the void, gripping its hilt in a white-knuckled fist. It vanished into the dimension rune, and all that remained was Sylvie’s egg.

Aether rushed down my arm, and I resumed the act of simultaneously imbuing and absorbing.

This layer appeared as a series of complex runes, like spellforms or godrunes. I couldn't read them, but their meaning was plain. They described the shape of a person. Of Sylvie…

Unlike the last layer, which had taken ages and unquantifiable amounts of aether, this layer filled up rapidly. I was finished almost before I realized it.

I held my breath and felt as if my heart would stop.

The color drained from the stone as it began to glow with pristine golden light. Then, little by little, particles broke away from the stone, condensing and taking shape in front of me…

In that timeless, motionless place, it seemed as if all the universe had come to a stop except for the unraveling embryo.

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A DREAM YET TO HAPPEN

SYLVIE INDRATH

“Arthur, you’re not going to make it.”

My voice sounded distant to my own ears as I reached into Arthur’s thoughts. He tried to push me out, tried to keep me from the worst of it, but he was too weak.

I didn’t shy away from the desperation and despair I found there. I wanted to, but I couldn’t, because *he* couldn’t. He thought he knew how this had to end, believed with his entire silly, brave heart there was only one way forward.

“The portal isn’t—it isn’t going to stay stable for much longer, Sylv. P-please, I can’t have you die too.” Instead of continuing to shield his feelings, Arthur suddenly reversed course, flooding me with his desperation, sadness, and despair. And hope. So much like my bond, to give me hope, even when he held none for himself.

The pocket dimension Arthur had conjured shivered and twisted, but I held back, not allowing myself to be moved through it as Arthur tried to force me into the same portal Tessia and the others had gone through.

Don’t worry, papa. I’ll always take care of you. Reaching for my true draconic form, I embraced it, simultaneously unleashing and containing myself. My thin human frame radiated violet light as I expanded outward, fair skin becoming dark scales until I was towering over my bond.

“Sylv? What are you—”

“Try to keep yourself alive while I’m gone, okay?” I said, giving him a

wide grin to try and ease his hurt. *Why did I phrase it like that?* I wondered, distant and disconnected, in the back of my mind. There was no coming back from this. Still, though, it felt…right. Better than goodbye. Suddenly I felt stronger, more decisive. *No, this isn't goodbye. Just…see you later.*

I hope.

"Sylv, no! Don't do this!" Arthur reached out, pressed his hands into me, shoving, but the process had already begun. His hands passed straight through me.

This…wasn't magic I'd been taught. As if anyone in Epheotus would care enough about a lesser to do what I was about to do. No, this was something inherent in our bond. It unlocked within me the moment I understood that Arthur was about to die, like that knowledge had been the turning of a key.

Everything that made *me* was intrinsically, inseparably linked to *him*. We were one and the same. My body, my magic, my vivum arts…they could save him, but only if I gave it up for myself.

I didn't receive this insight in a flash like thunder from the mountaintops or the quaking foundations of my beliefs. No, it was just there, as if it always had been. He was my bond, and I could always help him, even now.

Even now.

My physical body had become ethereal as I gave up my dominion over it. Gold and lavender motes of pure lifeforce floated away from me to stick to Arthur, until his whole being was glowing inside and out.

I could still sense his pain. His body had been shattered by overuse of my mother's will, and now it was being reforged, and every mote of me felt like hot coals and hammer blows to him. *I'm sorry, Arthur. If I could take away the pain too, I would.*

As he sagged, I scooped him up and pushed him toward the portal he'd created.

"Until we meet again…" I said, my voice distorted and somehow incorporeal, and I could only hope he heard me.

The portal drew him in, then began to collapse, taking the pocket dimension with it. I knew that when it was gone, I would be too, and the last of my essence would be picked up by the warm wind blowing through the ruined city to be carried off and spread throughout Dicathen. Knowing I would be in the grass, trees, leaves, and water of Arthur's home made me feel at peace, and I let go of the last vestige of resistance that was keeping me together.

Only…I was caught.

The collapsing portal was pulling itself apart, and my claw, which I'd used to push Arthur through the portal, was being reeled in. I lacked the strength to resist or the awareness to understand what might happen next. I could only give in.

Irresistible force pulled at my essence, dragging me in two different directions…

Everything became stardust and the ever-expanding universe. Suns caught fire, stuttered, then blazed. Constellations formed, faltered, and then fell from the sky. Everywhere I looked, people flickered in and out too fast for me to see. And all the while, I was being drawn through it, plunging like a shooting star in the night sky, insensate with wonder, too awestruck and alienated from my own perspective to even be confused.

The expanding universe became nothing but a tunnel of light, every color of it felt so bright it burned my spirit. I felt myself simultaneously racing—pulled inexorably toward some distant source of gravity—while also going quiet and calm, like I was sleeping.

The light faded.

I was in a small sterile-white room. There were people there. A woman in a white uniform with a white mask over her face was standing over the room's single bed, staring at a clipboard. A pale woman with mousy brown hair was lying in the bed, breathing heavily as she stared up at the woman in white. Tears were streaming down her face. An overweight man with sad, tired eyes sat on a stool on the opposite side of the bed.

The door behind me opened, and a masked man in a light blue paper gown strode in. I stepped back to avoid him, but he was moving too quickly, and he bumped into me.

Or rather, he passed right through me as he marched to the bedside. He

said something, then began checking strange artifacts, but I was staring down at my own hands.

They were small and pale like I remembered them. I ran them over my face, hair, and horns, but nothing seemed different. Except…

Reaching out, I touched a tray that was sitting on a small rolling table. My hands passed through it.

What am I?

Suddenly the woman burst out with a piteous, raw growl, and the man—a doctor, I realized—hurried to the foot of the bed. I only then became aware of a soft gold and lavender light radiating from the woman's belly, which was swollen.

The doctor started giving orders. The overweight man clumsily reached for the woman's hand. The nurse seemed to be doing five things at once, but it was all so confusing…

And then, almost before I fully comprehended what I was witnessing, it was over.

The nurse held out the baby boy, swaddled and cleaned and crying, to the woman, who took him carefully and nestled him into her arm. He was glowing, radiating that same gold and lavender light.

I stepped closer, leaned down to him, and took his tiny little hand in my incorporeal fingers, shaking even as I smiled.

The woman stared at him for a long time, as did I. Then, like tearing her gaze away from him was also ripping something inside her soul, she looked at the man. "A-are you sure? We could—"

He shook his head, and she made a sound like a knife had just been shoved between her ribs. He looked down and away, clearly unable to bear it, and a single tear flowed down the crease between his nose and cheek. "You know I wish we could, but we're already struggling as it is. Without a parental grant…what kind of life could we give a child. He'll be cared for. Trained even, to fight for our country. And then, maybe…" He swallowed hard. "Maybe in a few years we can try again?"

I saw the light leave the woman's eyes as something broke inside of her and knew beyond all shadow of a doubt that they wouldn't, but they didn't

hold my interest. They weren't my reason for being here…*he* was.

My gaze drifted down to his round, red face, and I didn't take it away again. Not as the baby was taken from the parents he would never know, or as he slept and was fed in a bright room with a dozen others, and certainly not when he dragged himself along the hospital floor for the first time—though no one else was watching except for the other infants—or when he took his first, shambling steps.

I followed him when he was relocated from the hospital to a small orphanage, watched him watch the world as he grew and learned.

Years passed, and I watched him. Incorporeal, sleepless, empty of all desire except to keep my vigil, I experienced the young boy's life with him, step by step. I was by his side as he made and lost his friends, as he trained and was guided toward becoming king, as he was manipulated into striking down his best friend, as he waged war for the de facto mother figure he lost.

I did not look away. Even as he diminished, losing the spark that had driven him to become king, floundering in a world that was ill-suited to him and didn't deserve who he would become, I knew it was a necessary travail. Without these experiences, both success and failures, this sad king would never become my bond. The detachment and weakening link to humanity he felt now would define his worldview in the next life as he set himself in opposition to it.

But he didn't have to suffer long, because even from the moment of his birth, the long arm of fate had been extending toward him. And I was there for that, too, the end of his journey as King Grey.

I stood beside him, my incorporeal fingers feathered through his hair—not yet the auburn he would inherit from Alice Leywin—as I sensed doom approaching.

The rapid passage of time—meaningless to one who does not sleep, eat, dream, or even live—came to a sudden and thundering halt, and I felt the presence as my own pulse in my throat. Like the black claw of death itself, my father's magic manifested, clutching at the sleeping king.

I found myself helpless. I was present in awareness only, lacking both substance and power, and could do nothing more than clutch at the spirit being drawn from his body by the looming, dark claw of forced

reincarnation. But…I knew, even if I'd been given the ability to do so, I wouldn't have stopped what was happening. Because this moment was bringing Arthur a step closer to me, even as I was already walking beside him.

Agrona's methods were cruel and awful, and yet he brought me Arthur. Or…was bringing me Arthur? After so long on Earth, drifting along in Grey's wake like a haunting ghost, it was difficult to keep sense of time. My life felt like a dream yet to happen, my death like the beginning after the end…

Clinging to the sundered spirit, I was dragged upward, away from the body left behind, the palace it rested at the heart of, the country of which it had been king, and the world that had forged the spirit I wouldn't let go.

Time and space opened before us, a reversal of the force that drew me to my bond's first birth. The universe itself seemed to unfold like curtains of stars being pulled to the side, revealing the stage behind: our world, simple and sleepy and quiet after the noise of Grey's Earth.

Still firmly in the claw's grasp, we were pulled toward that world, toward the skull-shaped continent of Alacrya and a waiting infant, naked and crying on a rune-carved dragon's skull.

But that was wrong.

Arthur wasn't—couldn't—be born in Alacrya.

Panic slashed through my incorporeal essence. I pulled at the spirit, trying to hold it back from its course as my weakened mind struggled to understand. But the force of Agrona's dark claw was inexorable. I might as well have tried to stop the sun from setting.

But I would. For him, I will stop the world from spinning if I have to.

Wrapping myself around the spirit, I focused away from the dark aspect of Alacrya toward distant Dicathen. Whatever strength my current form maintained, I exhausted it all. Suddenly I was no longer the ghost of the small horned girl. Wide, transparent wings spread and caught the cosmic wind. Powerful talons closed around the spirit. My long tail whipped the air in time to the beat of my wings.

"You'll never have him," I said, voiceless and eternal. "His fate is outside of your dominion."

Our course shifted an inch. My spectral wings beat. Miles slipped away beneath us. My long neck strained. Dicathen came closer still.

The black claw trembled. The shape of Agrona's spell hadn't accounted for resistance. It struggled to retain course, but the farther away I dragged it, the more its strength flagged.

Dicathen clarified beneath us. Sapin flew past. Ashber rushed toward us.

A woman came into view, auburn-haired and pale. Young, strong, and swelling with the silver light of an emitter's magic. That felt right. I wasn't sure why, but it felt *right*. And beside her, a wide grin plastered across his handsome square-jawed face, was the man whose pride would build up my bond's life, and whose death would very nearly tear it back down again. But that hadn't happened yet, wouldn't happen for a long time.

Except it already happened. Didn't it?

It was growing more and more difficult to focus. There was a song like a sweet scent in the air, calling to me.

In my moment of distraction and weakness, suddenly I was slipping backward, being pulled *away* from the family that my Arthur had to have. Waiting within that auburn-haired woman's belly was Arthur's vessel. No other would do.

My wings beat again, and I matched my diminishing strength against the will of my father.

My father, I thought bitterly. *But not my papa…*

Pulling so hard I worried my incorporeal essence would come apart, I dragged the black claw back toward the house and the baby. A silent roar tore out of me and rippled through the fabric of reality. Space again unfolded between me and my destination: the baby being born beneath me. The doctor had already gone to work, giving quiet, firm instructions…

The spirit in my talons touched the nimbus of white light infusing the baby.

Agrona's dark claw melted away, the black mist of his lingering magic dispersed by the wind of my beating wings.

With mingled glee and sadness, I watched as Grey's strong, mature spirit took over and absorbed the infant spirit within the unborn child. "I'm

sorry," I said, my own soul suddenly heavy with the weight of what I'd had to do. "This was the only way."

I wanted to stay, to watch as Arthur grew and learned, to witness him form his core, to experience this part of his life that I had missed, but…

The sweet siren song was calling to me, and I found that I couldn't ignore it. Uncertain when it had happened, I had eschewed both my draconic aspect and the girlish form I had lingered in so long on Earth, existing now only as my essence.

It was with a deep ache that I was pulled away from that baby, that family, that home. My spirit drifted eastward toward the mountains. As I crossed them, though, I was halted by the strangest of sights.

A caravan of familiar faces making their way up the mountain paths. Alice, Reynolds, the Twin Horns, young Arthur…

But how? I wondered. It had only been moments, and yet years had passed…

I could only watch helplessly as they were attacked. I knew what happened next, but to see it unfold in front of me was different. Darker. So much worse.

If my heart had been beating, it would have come to a stop as Arthur, only four years old, plummeted off the cliff's edge to save his mother.

Plunging after him, my shapeless spirit dragged at his, as I'd done before, trying to hold him up, to arrest his fall. But my power was spent. A feeble scream shivered through space and time as I fell with him, infusing him with what little of me there was left, so that at least he was not alone.

And then, I felt her. So clearly here, so strangely the opposite of my father in every conceivable way.

My mother.

Her power wrapped around Arthur's small body, cushioning him, bringing him slowly to the ground, and I suddenly remembered him recounting to me that was what had happened. For an instant I had forgotten, lost myself in the desperation and fear. There was so little of my essence left…

I wanted to stay with Arthur, be with him when he woke, but the song's source was so close now and too strong. It filled all my senses, emptied me

of all other thoughts as it subsumed them so that only the song remained. And so I followed, unable to do anything else.

Its indefinable notes were issuing from a cave hidden on the border of the Elshire Forest and the Beast Glades. I knew that place, and when I saw it, I understood the source of the siren's song…

The trail of summoning notes led me down into the cave.

Mother…

Despite seeing her, being aware of her presence, it was difficult to focus on my mother. Her gigantic, demonic form radiated a strong Vritra aura, but that wasn't what forced my attention away. No, it was the song still. For, resting in her huge hand, was an egg. *My* egg. Even in the dim light, it gleamed with a rainbow-infused hue.

The song was coming from the egg. Drawing my spirit into it.

Correcting the paradox of my multiple existences, I thought sleepily. The next moment, I could not recall having the thought at all, or any other desire beyond wanted to be inside that egg, all curled up, safe, waiting for my bond to bring me back into the world.

And so flowed into it. There, I rested.

Until…

I woke suddenly, confused by my surroundings, uncertain what had been real and what had only been a dream.

The shell of the egg holding me transmitted sensation like a second skin, and I was aware of it cracking and opening up. Light spilled into the tranquil darkness of the egg's interior. I blinked rapidly as a blurry face appeared above me as more of the shell broke away.

Slowly, the face came into focus.

A young boy with auburn hair and wide, hopeful azure eyes, was staring down at me. Arthur. *My* Arthur. Except…

I blinked again. I'd been wrong. Arthur was older, not the boy who first hatched me, but the general and Lance who rode on my back into war, strong and severe, but also kind and protective.

His face was still fuzzy, though, and I blinked. Arthur was still there, but his face was even older. Sharper, leaner. His azure eyes had turned to liquid gold, and his hair…it was the same color as mine.

“Kyu…?”

A wry, trembling smile curved one corner of his lips.

“Welcome back, Sylv.”

AFTERWORD

Hello! TurtleMe here, author of this little novel that you've just finished reading. I hope you've enjoyed the story and you're looking forward to the next installment of Arthur's journey! While waiting, please consider taking the time to leave an honest review of this novel. **Ratings and reviews are tremendously important** and since this is what I live off of, I would greatly appreciate your thoughts on this book so others can make sure that this is the book they want to read! Whether you loved it or hated it, I hope you can spare the time to write your two cents.

Kindest regards, TurtleMe

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